Chapter 301

Chapter 301 Bomb and Wine

The day after the witches from Sleeping Island moved into their new home, Roland called City Hall Premier Minister Barov to his office.

“I want you to issue another recruitment notice,” Roland said, while he pushed the first draft of details in front of Barov, “A week long temporary job for about ten people, preferably women.”

Barov picked up the paper, read it again before asking. “Your Highness, excuse me… what is starch?”

“Do you know about wheat flour?”

The Premier minister hesitated, “Are you referring to coarse powder or fine powder? Wheat grains, after grinding, can be baked into bread or wheat cake. And if instead of using it you go a step further and filter out the bran, you get a fine powder. The output of the latter is only 6 / 10 of the former, and bread baked with it is softer, but its price is also very high, so only powerful aristocratic families are able to afford it.”

The thing Roland liked the most about Barov, was that he had a comprehensive understanding concerning goods from all categories. Food shortage as a result of the lagging agriculture could mean something completely different depending on the consumer’s social class. For example, with the frequently seen wheat, civilians would often put the wheat grains directly into their pot and cook congee, this way making the most out of their limited food. However, sometimes wheat shells and sand would also land in the boiling pot which results in crackling sounds and cause tooth pains whenever they ate.

Small aristocrats paid particular attention to this and would order people to sieve the sand and stones out of the wheat grain. Then they would grind it into a coarse powder, and bake it into bread or pancake before eating.

And at the top of the hierarchy, the wealthy families and powerful aristocrats, who didn't look at food as a mere way to fill their stomachs, but rather, as something to be enjoyed. The wheat would be further sieved in the kitchen, removing the bran, to get fine white powder. The resulting baked bread was of yellowish cream color and when eaten not only tasted exquisite but also had a much sweeter flavor.

"The basis of starch is a fine powder which then goes through another purifying process," Roland explained. "After you hire the people, I'll send someone who will instruct them on what exactly we need them to do."

"Then, continue to process?" Barov couldn't stop himself shouting out loud in shock, "How much wheat will they be needing for this?"

"I do not need too much, only three or four hundred kilograms …" Roland paused, before opening his mouth again, "Fill up a basket that is about the size of my table."

Barov nodded and asked further, "Why do they need to be woman?"

"Because they will do things more carefully. Moreover, I want to see more woman following the path of a worker, instead of being idle at home," Roland, suddenly had an idea, so he asked, "At present, it seems that the education of Border Town's women's classes are progressing more quickly, right?

"Although the head of the Ministry of Education is Lady Scroll, the situation is indeed like this. They can't do much more than taking care of the children and do housework, so they spend most of their time increasing their reading and writing skills."

"That being the case, I request that after the next round of examination, you will take the lead for the City Hall and recruit a batch of female apprentice, in that way gradually expanding the proportion of women posts," Roland commanded.

"Your Highness, this… there is no precedent for it," Barov complained. "If they only have to be careful, my apprentice aren't worse than any woman."

“If there is no precedent we have to create one,” Roland bluntly said. “This is also the easiest and quickest way to increase the labor force without expanding the total population. If all woman can take on a small task in building Border Town, my available staff will double. The only thing I’m asking you to do is to lead people to change their view. As long as the pay is attractive, I think they should come over on their own one by one.”

After Barov retired, Roland heard Nightingale’s laughter next to his ear, followed by her asking a question, “What kind of delicious thing are you planning to make this time?”

“Starch? It’s not something you can eat,” Roland said, after taking a mouthful of tea, “Even though you can indeed get some pretty good food from the leftover materials after processing.”

First soak fine wheat flour in water, then rub and scrub it until the water had entirely blanched, then move on to another water basin and continue. In the end, it will become a sticky mass known as gluten. The gluten can be used for deep-fry or stir-fry and has a texture which is both pliable and tough. When smeared with honey or sprinkled with flavoring after leaving the pot, all in all, it made for a very delicious meal.

But Roland’s focus was not on food.

By sifting and afterward letting the milky white water stand still, it would form a precipitation which was precisely the starch he was looking for, and was also a main ingredient used in manufacturing explosives.

Since the experiments with nitroglycerin hadn’t started yet, there was no possibility that he would have access to TNT, so nitrostarch was his most immediate opportunity for making powerful explosives, it also shared the same manufacturing process as nitrocellulose. The finished product had a low sensitivity, and couldn’t be ignited by an open fire, instead, one needed to use a fuse for it to detonate. Furthermore, it was more powerful than TNT and had thus been widely used as a substitute for it during the two world wars.

With highly pure starch, the alchemic apprentices who already knew the manufacturing process for nitrocellulose by heart should also be able to quickly prepare a batch of nitrostarch.

After lunch, just as Roland was planning to go back to his room to take a nap, he suddenly heard someone knocking on his door.

Nine out of ten times it was Anna who would come to find him at this hour. So when he heard the knocking sound, his heartbeat immediately began to dance. Can it be, after falling asleep last time because of her exhausted, she decided to come over at noon?

"Come in."

However, the door creaked as it was pushed open, and Roland started when he saw Evelyn standing outside.

This… now, isn't what I've been expecting at all. He coughed twice, then showed a reassuring smile as he asked, "What's the matter?"

Hearing his question, Evelyn entered the room, and walked over to the edge of the table and bowed down in salute, all in all she seemed a bit nervous, "Your Highness, I would like to ask you a question."

Don't tell me it is going to be the same question again, 'Why are you so kind to us witches'? However, in accordance with treating them like comrades, it was important to be as warm as the spring wind, so he smiled and said, "What question do you want to ask?"

"You… why did you want me to come to Border Town?"

For a moment Roland was slightly surprised, can it be that she doesn't like the taste of the wine?

"My kind of ability isn't only inferior to Sylvie's; it is practically at the same level as Lotus and Honey's," she whispered. "It's just wine tasting. However, a monthly salary of one gold royals is already enough for you to hire a specialized Wine Brewer from King's City."

“What are your thoughts about those… wines?”

“At first I thought they burned too much, only by slowly drinking them was I able to accept them. As for those three wines mixed with ice cubes, fruit juice, and syrup, their taste is richer. But that is merely my personal opinion,” Evelyn replied cautiously. “My family’s pub only sold cheaply-priced wines and diluted ales, the aristocracy’s tendencies …I do not know anything about that.”

As it turns out she isn’t questioning the wine, the Prince breathed out in relief. He got up and opened the bookcase, then took out a jar of ale from the top and put it in front of Evelyn with the question, “Can you turn this jar of ale into the wine I brewed?”

“I think… that shouldn’t be a problem.” She stretched out her hand, and held it above the jar, a moment later the yellow ale began to change. In the wake of the rising bubbles, the ale became more and more clear, until it finally turned as crystal clear as plain boiled water; yet Roland could already smell its strong alcoholic fragrance. Unable to stop himself, he dipped his finger in a little, then put it into his mouth. It tasted bitter and burning at the same time, this was the taste of highly purified alcohol.

Roland couldn’t help but begin to laugh, while saying, “That’s the reason I picked you.”

Looking at the puzzled Evelyn, he patted her hand and explained, “I’m going to set up an alcohol factory… No, a brewery. Would you like to be the chief winemaker?”

Chapter 302

Chapter 302 The Bugle Horn of the Decisive Battle

At the palace in the Kingdom of Eternal Winter, flames were raging within the fireplace.

Compared to Graycastle with its four seasons, here the summers were especially short, and the autumn was only like an advance notice for the impending arrival of a severe winter. There wasn't even enough time to change into shorter garments before the cold wind came back once again.

Garcia Wimbledon, sat on the throne with a fox fur coat draped over her shoulders, listening to the complaints and demands of the nobility.

She didn't like the palace. The pillars, walls, and floors were all built out of snow white stones, each piece polished until it was smooth and shining, just like ice in general. Despite the fact that she already had two additional layers of cushion on her seat, she could still feel the bitter chill of the cold iron chair.

This damned castle is like an iceberg, absolutely frustrating! I'll wait for the situation to stabilize, and the first thing I'm going to do after that is to smash all of the walls and floors to bits then re-lay it with dark brown granite slabs afterward.

"Your Majesty, I hope you can bring justice for me," a noble said, looking at her with a scowling expression.

Prior to this, he had used a lot of words, where in fact, a few would have been sufficient. At the time when the Church was occupying the Kingdom of Endless Winter, some nobles who had done many evils deeds had been put on a public trial which had been presided over by Archbishop Heather. Most of the nobles had been sent to the gallows. However, this guy was among the lucky ones and had only been punished with the confiscation of his assets, which had then been equally divided among the victims.

“I can understand your request; private property shouldn’t be plundered,” Garcia pondered for a moment and then slowly said, “But the specific amount is hard to define. Well, if you can provide me with the testaments of the last five years of financial income and expenditure, I can evaluate an average value and give you a part of the of the seizures as compensation.”

“But the mob has looted my house, and I’m afraid the records are…”

“Then I can only follow the published announcement and compensate you according to your title.” Garcia interrupted, “Take a look around you, they are all nobles who have suffered from looting, if I give you more, some of them would end up getting less.”

“That’s right! Only God would know if the number you reported is the truth or not!”

“Why are you so troublesome, Knight Halon, these gold royals aren’t yours.”

“You have it already quite good, just take a look at your associates, they can only go to heaven and find God to demand compensation.”

Seeing all of the surrounding nobles glare at him, he was forced to shrink back, bow deep in salute and say, “In that case, please compensate me according to the standard. Thank you for your kindness, Your Majesty.”

“Excellent,” Garcia smiled and then ordered, “Next.”

“My regards to you, Your Majesty,” a white-haired old man stepped out of the crowd and caressed the glittering silver heron family emblem on his chest reverently.

“Marquis Bodø, I remember that the Church’s thugs didn’t attack your territory.”

“Yes, that’s right,” he nodded, “Not that they didn’t want to, rather that they couldn’t… the Inundated Snow Ridge is difficult to attack. So, my Knights were able to block all of the invading bandits. However, my child wasn’t as fortunate. On the day of the riots, he was on duty within the imperial palace,

and for the purpose of protecting the Queen, not only was he killed by the believers, but his body was also hung above the city gate. It was not until you arrived in the Kingdom of Eternal Winter, that he could be freed from his humiliation."

"That's truly a tragic story," Garcia assumed a grieving expression and sighed, before asking, "So, what is your request?"

"The name of the man who killed him is 'The Butcher', nowadays he is the leader of the remaining rebels. That group of people are hiding within the Impassable Mountain Range north of us. I want revenge for my child." The Marquis calmly declared.

"From the beginning, I didn't have that many troops under my control. The are already keeping the peace during the day, patrol, guard the city wall as well as the granary; it would be quite difficult to split my men and dispatch the troop to the barren mountains and wild hills just to go find a group of one hundred exiled thugs." She shook her head and said in regret, "Furthermore, when the winter comes, the heavy snowfall will also close off the mountains, thus, making it impossible for them to get any supplies. So, they will freeze to death sooner or later; there is no need for you to be so impatient."

"Your Majesty, I'll only be able to find peace if it's me wielding the sword that kills my child's murderer. I also don't need you to send any warriors to search for the thugs. There are many natural caves at the foot of the mountain; they surely will be hidden within one of them. But most of the cave's entrances are very narrow, and if they used stones to block the entrance, it would even be difficult for the Knights to attack them. I hope you can provide me with the alchemical creation that had been able to blow up the city gates; I'll do the rest by myself."

Does he want to get his hands on the snow powder? Garcia frowned, that stuff has a large power, and its strong enough to be the trump card in a hopeless war and alter the outcome, it absolutely cannot be allowed to spread out.

At the time, she was about to declare her refusal, the other opened his mouth again, "If you grant me this request, I am willing to return to court and serve

you. The silver heron family will fully support your ruling over the Kingdom of Eternal Winter."

This sentence then made Garcia swallow her words. At the time, the Church executed the Queen; they also killed some chief ministers. Here, the Marquis of Bodø has a lot of prestige, if he were to serve as my Prime Minister, all the remaining nobles would follow along. To some degree, it can also make up for the deficient administration and also turn around this awkward situation.

"This request is not too much," she thought for a while, then after finally coming to a decision she said, "But I cannot put the alchemy powder directly into your hands. When you require it, I will send a special alchemist who will provide you with assistance to blow open the hole."

…

After the end of the court session, Garcia returned to the back room, where Ryan was already waiting for her with a cup of warmed fruit wine, "Thanks for your trouble, Your Majesty. As expected, those nobles were all taken over by you. In this way, even if we don't depend on the Wolf King, you can still swallow the entire Kingdom of Eternal Winter slowly."

"As long as there is no Church," the Queen said as she shrugged.

The Church, in their act of striping the nobles of their rightful inheritance, had pushed them to her side. Now, with the support of those very people, coupled with the crippling of the Church's former base of power, it had been very easy for her to gain a foothold in the capital. But if she wanted to control the Kingdom of Eternal Winter, she still had a long way left to go – it was here where the people were influenced by the Church the most. When she'd dispatched her Black Sail Fleet to wipe out the Church's bases in other major cities, they had continually suffered under the attack of the believers. Therefore, it was crucial to form a coalition with the Wolfsheart Kingdom. Not only so that they could resist the Church together, but also to weaken the influence the Church held over the population by accepting people from Wolfsheart Kingdom.

As for those stubborn civilians, it will be alright if they are just cleanly killed off.

“Oh, by the way, a messenger from the Wolfsheart Kingdom has arrived with a letter for you,” Ryan informed her, as he took an envelope from his pocket, “Because you were dealing with government affairs, I didn’t dare to bother you.”

Garcia opened the envelope, took out the letter, and began to read the letter carefully.

“Is it bad news?”

“The Church has sent out troops once again,” she said in a low voice, “They’ve taken the land route and are heading straight for Wolfsheart City. They’ve already broken through several of the recently set up defensive lines.”

“What?” Ryan started with big eyes at her in disbelieve, then he said, “The Months of Demons will be coming soon, don’t tell me they’ve set out while completely disregarding the New Holy City?”

Showing a frowning expression, Garcia sat back in her desk.

She knew that the Church would never let them go, but she hadn’t expected that the other side would move so fast. If they had just waited with the war until spring next year, her preparation would have been complete. However, the enemy apparently didn’t want to give them any space to breathe – if she just sat idly while the Wolfsheart Kingdom asked for help, and the kingdom got destroyed as a result, it wouldn’t be long before it would be her turn to disappear.

But this also contained an opportunity.

If she could make the Church waste its forces on the city walls of the Wolfsheart City, they would be facing a great disaster when the demonic beasts invaded Hermes at a large scale.

They might have sent out the God's Punishment Amy, but by now, she also had formidable weapons like the snow powder, the hard to extinguish black river water, the demonic fire powder, as well as Wolfsheart City's towering city walls. With all this, she would surely be able to consume a large number of their vital forces.

Thinking until here, Garcia commanded, "Pass along my orders, the Black Sail Fleet is to get ready for battle! This year, we will be spending the winter within Wolfsheart City."

Chapter 303

Chapter 303 Preparation for the Air Raid

After going through a week of assembling and testing, Roland and Anna together completed the development of an impact detonator.

Compared to the fuse of the artillery shells, it does not need to withstand high temperature and pressure, and there was also no high-G overload when it left the chamber, so the structure was very simple. However, due to the necessary precise constitution of the firing pin and the spring, the two had to test many variations before they finally succeeded.

The main problem was that no one knew how much elasticity the spring needed, to make sure that it wouldn't go off it it accidental fell. While they also needed to guarantee that it would always trigger when it was launched normally.

He and Anna only changed the thickness and hardness of the spring a little before testing it once again.

Fortunately, Anna and Lucia had done a lot of the required work in advance. As a result, Roland had more and more high-quality materials available at hand. Ultimately, after a lot of testing they'd chosen to use steel alloy No. 1365, which had a relatively high hardness, but a toughness that was on the lower side. Even if the bomb fell from one meter, it wouldn't be compressed to the end.

After the selection of an appropriate spring, the rest was easy. Just like the saying: where water flows, a canal would form. Even though Roland had never seen the look of a real detonator before, he could still rely on his work's experience to come up with a design by himself.

Compared to modern ones it was certainly lacking, but for the current crude big black bombs, this would be enough.

The finished version of the impact detonator was in the form of a cylinder, twelve centimeters long, about five centimeters in diameter, with a spiral pattern on the underside which could be screwed into the opening at the top of the bomb.

The interior looked like a downwards convex groove, while the firing pin shared a similar appearance, so that it could also fit into the groove. In its normal state, the spring would lock the upper part within the indentation, while the striker would land right inside the indentation, only one finger apart from the primer. For the purpose of taking precautions, Roland had also made a hole in the head of the firing pin, so that a bolt could be fixed on top of the ammunition case. Thus, before the bombing, they first had to pull out the bolt, only then could the strike move up and down.

The simulation test was held on a sunny afternoon.

Because this bomb which filled with a padding of gravels instead of black gunpowder, had already reached five times Nightingales weight, Roland decided not to board the hot air balloon, and instead watched the process with an observation mirror from three hundred meters away from the impact location.

Apart from himself, there was also the Commander of the Fist Army Iron Axe and the Chief Knight Carter Lannis, who were here to watch this first test.

“Are you planning to use a hot air balloon to throw the giant explosive packages into the heart of the imperial palace?” After listening to Roland’s battle plan, Carter struggled to believe his ears. To attack from an altitude of two kilometers above the ground while simultaneously completely disregarding the city walls and the forces of the garrison, ultimately overturned his former concept of what defined combat – and of course, living in Border Town during this last year, his view had already gone through changes many times before.

“As long as the controlling system is fully functioning it really isn’t impossible to achieve,” Roland nodded. “Right now, Timothy is pressing people into service once more, to build up his new militia force. If we cannot stop him, the Western Territory will inevitably suffer another attack from his

drugged forces. And even if we force him back again, it won't give us even one bit of benefit."

The secret letter that Theo had sent had indicated that Timothy was currently still using the same old routine of trying to consume his strength. However, Roland didn't know if the team dispatched by Barov could overtake their counterparts and rope in the people and make them come to Border Town.

"Supposing that you can really release heaven's fury thunder above Timothy's head, he absolutely will be frightened, not knowing what to do!" Iron Axe said excitedly, "This is absolutely a heaven's punishment which no one can resist!"

"That's what I'm hoping for," Roland said with a smile.

Although Theo had mentioned in the letter that Timothy had most likely figured out the method for making black gunpowder and opened a workshop in the inner city to try and mass produce the dangerous product, after thinking it over repeatedly, Roland still decided that the roof of the imperial palace should be the target of the bombing.

The reason was simple, the palace was the only place which was eye-catching enough.

When looking from a height of two thousand meters, even the most magnificent city of Graycastle was only the size of half a palm. Therefore, they also had to find a good target point to throw off the bomb in advance. And the palace was located at the midpoint of the inner-city district, and was surrounded by a red tile wall. Furthermore, pure white stones covered the roof of the palace, would be particularly eye-catching while they were aiming, which meant it would almost be impossible for them to miss their target.

But the workshop was different.

Roland didn't possess a layout plan of King's City, and the ground was also unmanned, and if he only relied on spoken words it would be quite difficult to describe the position of the selected target. Plus, the workshop's area

wasn't large. If the bomb were to fall on top of a civilian's house, the gains of their plan wouldn't make up for the losses they would face.

Suddenly, a white shadow fell straight to the ground, causing a smoke pillar to rise from the test field, followed by the muffling sound of something smashing into the ground a moment later.

"It seems as if the bomb has hit the ground," Roland put away the mirror, "Let's go and take a look at the result."

After a week of training, Lightning had significantly improved her bombing technique. This time, the bomb had hit the ground five meters away from the center of the target. It had drilled its whole body into the earth and the outer shell had been substantially deformed due to the force of the impact.

After Cloud Gazer had landed, Anna used her black flame to cut open the bomb, so that everyone could see that the soil near the detonator has been charred black – this proved that the primer's temperature was high enough to ignite the gas sprinkled on top of the gravel, which was what they had used in place of black gunpowder, and this showed that the detonator itself was working fine. If they instead filled the interior of the bomb with nitrated starch, it could easily create a four to six meters deep hole, and kill all of the people who hadn't taken shelter that were within the vicinity of 50 meters.

Now, after having fully trained the air drop, the next step was to organize their combat plan.

Roland let his gaze wander over everyone surrounding him, then opened his mouth and slowly said, "We will execute the surprise raid on King's City next Monday. First, Iron Axe will lead a group of fifty firearms and escort the witches to the outskirts of Silver City. There is a mountain ridge in the area which can shelter you from detection, and it should be perfect if you want to set up camp or send off a balloon."

"I hear and obey, Your Majesty!" Iron Axe agreed.

"Why can't we just fly directly from Border Town?" Wendy asked.

“No, that would be too far,” Roland shook his head, from the Western Territory to King’s City it took at least a week. When traveling with Cloud Gazer or flying directly there, it would still take them around three days, together with the return trip it would be six days. Furthermore, after the installing the dropping mechanism, the basket would only have enough space to carry two people, which meant that Nightingale would be unable to follow them. With the exception of Anna, none of the other witches had any fighting ability, so making them spend six nights in the wild it would be much too high a risk, which was something that would be impossible for him to feel at ease about. “By starting from Silver City, you will be able to complete the bombing in just one day and return even before the sun goes down.”

“Secondly, the witches assigned to the mission are Anna, Wendy, Lightning, Maggie, Nightingale and Sylvie. The latter two are responsible for monitoring the surroundings of the camp, while the attack will be carried out by the first four people according to the training method, especially Lightning,” he looked towards the little girl, “Whether we succeed or not all depends on you.”

“You can leave it to me.” The latter patted her chest.

“In that case, the last thing I wanted to mention was that you should all pay attention to your safety,” Roland said while stressing each word, “I will be waiting for your return here in Border Town.”

Four days later, the first bomb ’Easterly Wind No.1’ was loaded on top of a cart, and under the escort of the First Army, it boarded a cargo ship to Silver City.

Chapter 304

Chapter 304 An unexpected but pleasant surprise

May would never have thought that by the time she was about to set foot on the road back to Border Town, her heart would once again be filled with so much expectation.

The woods along the Redwater River had already begun to turn yellow, and the breeze blowing directly in one's face brought along a trace of chill. The waves of the shimmering river were rolling under her feet, and from time to time she was able to see the fallen tree leaves floating past the side of the ship.

Now, without all of the anxiety and restlessness she had felt on her last trip, the exuberant surrounding autumn landscape seemed like it was something which came out of a poem or painting.

"Miss May," a voice, full of respect, came from behind. "Your play of the 'Witch Diary', is it true that His Highness wrote the play for you personally?"

When May turned around, she saw that a group of actresses had gathered behind her, the person standing in front looked at her with a tense expression. She recalled that this one's name was 'Swallow'.

"Aha, sorry," Irene waved at her, then bowed and said with an apologizing smile. "I wasn't able to answer this question. So without any better option I had to let them come and ask you."

This fool… May thought and gave her a supercilious look. If it had been her from the past, she would have only dumped them with a sneer. But now, after having spent so much time together with Irene her patience had unexpectedly grown stronger day by day, and thus she dared to answer, "No, His Highness didn't write it for me. Rather it was the City Hall's Minister of Education, Lady Scroll who had written the Witch Diary."

“Uh, is that so?” Swallow blinked in wonder, “At the time you argued with Bella, we all thought it was the truth.”

“His Highness wrote it personally” and, “His Highness wrote it personally for me”, the meaning of those two wordings were poles apart, how could these people grasp the first half of the sentence, but totally dismiss the second half? Thinking of this, she then said to them, “But His Highness endorsed both the script writing and the theatrical performance. Therefore, when Bella ridiculed the script it was indeed equivalent to mocking His Highness. Regarding that point, I haven’t fooled her.”

“Have you ever seen His Royal Highness?”

“I heard that he has the royal family’s mark of long gray hairs and looks extraordinary handsome, is that right?”

“I also heard that he was born with the natural disposition of a romantic and has many lovers!”

“Eh, was it really like that?”

“…” Looking at this group of lively little girls, May couldn’t help but knit her brows. Curse it! I should never have responded to their curiosity.

“Alright, that’s enough, don’t you girls bother Miss May,” Rosia said and began shooing the group of females away while showing an apologizing expression towards May.

“No, harm” she shrugged and then continued to enjoy the scenery along the coastal area. “After all, I was the one who sought out trouble.”

“I… do not understand,” Rosia scratched her head, “Why did you want to take them along when we left? Of the thirty-five people, only two people have stood on stage before, while twenty-six of them have not yet completed any of the courses for their drama classes. According to what you’d previously said, they cannot even be considered as baby chicks. They are still inside their eggshell, yet to hatch… Even if the Lord’s requirements for the play are not so demanding, I’m afraid that even His Highness would find

it difficult to accept them. In case you want to retaliate against Bella, you should have tried to court some more experienced supporting actors."

"I didn't intend to let all of them perform."

"Ah?" The other side froze in place for a moment.

"They can read the scripts for a play, isn't that right?" May asked laughingly, "Although they still have a long way to go until they can enter the stage, all of them can at least read and write. Don't tell me you haven't discovered it yet? His Royal Highness is currently exactly in need of that exact skill." She paused for a moment, "Do you truly think that His Royal Highness Roland Wimbledon loves drama so much, that he recruited us for a play?"

"This…"

"In case it was Lord Petrov, then the answer would be yes. Before he had taken over Longsong Stronghold, he had the habit of going to the theater once a week. However His Highness Roland, apart from viewing the first play of a new theatrical work, he didn't appear in the town's square for the rest of the time – so he never promoted the drama for his own enjoyment. Instead, he intends to spread his views to the masses through the drama." May paused, before going on to say, "Compared to the first shows, which emphasized resisting oppression and the message that witches aren't evil, the new play, 'The Dawn of a New Era' and 'New City' have moved towards recruiting people, and 'one becoming rich though one's own efforts' as the message. I'm merely following along with his idea and using the small amount of power I currently have."

"So, it was originally like this. I never thought about that…" Rosia seemed to be speechless.

"To polish and refine the script for a play, in addition to putting yourself into the character you are playing, it is also important to try and understand the overall story as much as possible if you want to express its true meaning. This is also a quality that a good actor needs to possess."

"Yes, thank you for your guidance!" She bowed.

“Be at ease,” May said as she showed her a reassuring smile, “Even in the case that you don’t want to perform any longer, you should still be able to find a pretty good job inside Border Town. Maybe you can enter the City Hall and become an administrative officer. After all, His Highness does not require you to have any sort of status, and he also doesn’t look at your family background. This road would be much easier than going on stage.”

…

When the vessel arrived at the town, May saw Ferlin Eltek waiting to greet them at the pier.

Naturally, he was here to see Irene.

When she saw the girl dash forward and happily throw herself in his arms, she could only gently sigh.

“Isn’t that man Morning Light?”

“He hadn’t been exiled by His Royal Highness …”

“The first knight of the Western Territory is magnificent” Swallow said, “I thought he and the theater star would be -“

“Who’s talking such nonsense,” May’s cold voice made everyone suddenly close their mouths. “Hurry up with your luggage and disembark. Ghent and Rosia will take you to the City Hall so that you can register your identity. Everything else will be arranged by them.”

“Yes,” came everyone’s respectful reply.

Walking down the pier, Ferlin, with his arm around his wife, came over to greet her, and spoke to her, “Miss May, Irene just told me about the clash in the theater. Thank you for the kindness you showed her.”

“There is no need for you to thank me,” May couldn’t accept it, “Even though it looked like the other party was looking for trouble with her, but in fact, their target was me.”

“Even so, I still want to thank you.” The Knight laughed brightly and continued to say, “If it weren’t for you stepping forward, she would have cried right on the spot.”

After the two had left, May curled her lips and alone she began carrying her luggage toward the residential district.

Although she had already let go of her feelings, but seeing such a scene still had her feeling some regret. Furthermore, that familiar figure also did not appear, which was contrary to the vow in his letter that he would be waiting for her with a pleasant surprise.

Well, the other side, after all, is an important man to His Highness. Unlike Morning Light who can walk around as he wishes, right?

Back home, May put away her luggage and was hit by a sense of relaxation that she hadn’t felt for quite a long time. She took a long breath, took out the white wine from the cupboard and was about to pour herself a drink when a knocking sound came from the door.

When she opened the door, Carter Lannis’ awe-inspiring figure appeared before her.

“I did not expect you to be half an hour early,” he wiped the sweat from his forehead. “The moment I heard that the boat from Longsong Stronghold has arrived, I immediately rushed over from the barracks.”

I don’t know why, I definitely didn’t catch sight of him at the pier, and he obviously didn’t go to receive me, but the moment I see him, my mood immediately lifts up, “Do you want to drink a cup?”

“No, I still have to work this afternoon,” Carter waved his hand.

“Well,” she nodded, “The matters of His Highness are more important.”

“I came because I want to give you a present,” The Chief Knight took a white wooden box from his pocket and handed it to her.

“Is this the latest product of the convenience market?” May asked full of curiosity as she took the wooden box. When she opened the lid, she saw a yellow-orange ring quietly stand at the bottom of the box. Its top was inlaid with a bright and transparent stone, it reflected the autumn sunlight falling through the window with a colorful light.

There is no doubt that this ring is worth a lot of money, which makes it unlikely for it to be a selling item for the convenience market. And when nobles give a ring, it means… she couldn’t help but cover her mouth.

“Miss May, are you willing to marry me?” Carter asked her earnestly.

Chapter 305

Chapter 305 Chemical Breakthrough

Four days had already passed since the witches, and the First Army had set off, according to the plan, they should arrive at the outskirts of Silver City by tomorrow afternoon.

Equipped with Honey's flying messengers, Roland received letters sent by the team every day; the letters were from Iron Axe, Anna, and Nightingale. Even though they weren't as fast as mobile phones, it was basically the same as a wireless telegraphing. In case there were several winged messengers on the same road, and if there existed birds who would always go to and from the same two places, it might have the same effect as text messaging.

In the absence of Nightingale, the Chief Knight took over the responsibility of defending the castle. However, Roland couldn't understand why Carter always wore a happy expression these days; it seems like he's encountered something especially pleasing these past few days. Could it be, that returning to his former task and acting as my personal guard is something that's worth being so happy about?

He shook his head and focused his attention back on the report from his Minister of Construction, Karl van Bate.

With the help of the witches from Sleeping Island, Border Town's construction projects were progressing at an amazingly rapid pace these past few months.

First, there was the steel bridge across the Redwater River which had been successfully completed – compared to the traditional stone bridges and wooden bridges, the structure of the steel bridge had been made in advance, only afterwards had it been hoisted into place. The two floating islands Lotus had raised within the river course had further simplified the former difficult

task and also shortened the time needed to construct the main bridge to an amazing one month's time.

Although, when one looked at it with eyes of a person in the future, the bridge did indeed seem short and narrow, and the architecture simple and crude, the theoretical capacity very low, turning it into a project which was purely a waste of material, but within this era it could be regarded as a magnificent super bridge. Its total length carrying on for more than 100 meters, the bridge's surface was smooth and offered enough space for two carriages to move side by side. Furthermore, even its lowest part still met the requirements to let an up-river sailboat pass through, something which a cumbersome stone bridge could never accomplish.

Secondly, Lotus had also completed the construction of the new city wall. Those walls, made purely out of earth, had increased the town's area by more than two times. If they'd been placed in a modern area, the original town would be considered the veritable "inner city"; Roland however, was more inclined towards the two-ring system. Perhaps someday in the future this place could expand into a giant city which even had seven rings, and could then be formally crowned as the imperial capital.

Lastly, regarding the construction of the Kingdom Avenue, Lotus had already leveled out some of the Impassable Mountain Range's extensions, so now the road could go straight through instead of going around which had thus significantly reduced the overall length of the journey.

"Your Highness, what do you want Lotus to construct next?" Karl asked after he reported on the progress.

Roland was able to tell that he was brimming with admiration for her ability to transform the terrain, because, not only had he proposed that she be integrated into the Ministry of Construction, he'd even put forth a request to appoint her as the vice minister.

"Well…" Roland was also already thinking about this question. There were three major construction projects he wanted to implement next.

The first was the sea port project: Looking for small openings in the southern mountain ridge before caving in a path to the beach was a task he would have to rely on Lotus to achieve. Once they completed the transformation, the Western Territory would gain access to a seaward harbor.

The second project was the residential expansion: Although City Hall had invested a lot of the workforce and financial resources to step up the construction of residential quarters, with winter soon to approach, by now there were nearly three thousand people who would be unable to live in a warm brick house. Nowadays, erecting wooden sheds and simple shelters simply couldn't meet the requirements to resist the cold, so they needed a group of cave rooms with thick walls and kangs if they wanted to solve this problem.

The third point was to set up a dock: If he wanted to produce shallow water gunboats, he first had to arrange for a large dock, which at the same time would also affect the passage of the Redwater River. Roland intended to reduce the height of the riverbank on the western side of Border Town, to form a dry dock and install a lift gate at the side of the Redwater River so that they can control the water intake and runoff. The scale of the necessary earthwork was immense, and he would also have to rely on Lotus' ability to complete it.

After considering for a moment, he finally decided to place the residential expansion as the first priority. Since they had invited the refugees from the Eastern Region to Border Town, they were going to have to take responsibility and provide them with the basic necessities of life. If they were to freeze or starved to death, then, not only would it be a loss for the Western Territory, but it would also reduce the people's attachment toward this place.

"So where is the place we should build the temporary residences?" Karl asked.

"The best place would be at the place of the current serf shantytown," Roland glanced at the map, "That place is far from the defense line of the city wall, they can also use the cover there to protect themselves from the wind coming from the Impassable Mountains."

After the Minister of Construction left the room, Roland had just planned to take a short nap in his chair when Kyle Sichi arrived at the door.

“Your Highness, the large-scale acid production method you have requested, has been successfully developed.”

Hearing this sentence dispelled Roland’s weariness immediately. He showed a smiling expression on receiving such a pleasant surprise, Roland stood up and said: “Really? Take me to see it.”

When their group came to the laboratory at the Redwater River, he saw a few gray jars and a kiln set up beside laboratory No. five. Each jar was the height of two people and had a pipeline connected to the top, which had a smooth shape; which had clearly been cut out by Anna.

“I pay my respect to you, Your Highness,” a very young looking man said toward Roland and bowed.

“I presume you’re Chavez?” Although he had already learned about the several alchemist apprentices and outstanding alchemist that Kyle had brought from Redwater City, today was still the first time that he saw the other’s appearance.

“You even remember my name,” Chavez said astonished.

“Mr. Sichi has mentioned you plenty of times before,” Roland explained and patted his shoulder in encouragement, “Keep up the good work.” Then, looking over to the Chief Alchemist he asked, “How will this thing produce acid?”

Kyle stroked his beard and said with a smile, “The successful manufacture is entirely according to a derivation of an equation of the ‘Elementary Chemistry’. You see those kilns, the purified sulfur will burn in the kiln, and through further heating the gas produced will pass through the pipes and into a lead jar.”

“Are all those devices made of lead?”

“That’s right; only lead can resist acid’s corrosion.” Kyle nodded. “The nitro-sulpheric acid will unceasingly sprinkle down from the lead pipe at the top of the jar, and, together with the hot sulfur dioxide below, the heated nitric acid will decompose into nitrogen oxide. Finally, the water and sulfur dioxide together will generate a sulfuric acid solution. This solution will flow out of a hole at the bottom – the smart thing about this reaction is that nitrogen oxide only acts as oxygen carriers, but by itself it can’t be consumed. Therefore, the amount of nitric acids used is small, and once the reaction has started up, it can carry on working continuously!”

“How is the output?” Roland asked while agitatedly patting against a lead jar. Functioning large-scale acid production was the premise needed for mass production of smokeless gunpowder. As long as he could solve this problem, there was hope for the rise of a new generation of weapons and ammunition.

“This is the fourth device I’ve tested, the daily output may be as much as the weight of using the laboratory’s dry distillation method for an entire week.” the Chief Alchemist proudly said, “Because it is a testing device, the volume isn’t large. However, the capacity could be further improved, if you could build lead jars with a larger capacity.

“That’s good news,” Roland said laughingly, “Wait until Miss Anna comes back, and you can set up a larger acid plant right away. If the lead isn’t enough, you can use iron instead, Miss Soraya’s coating can make it resistant against the corrosion of the acid.

Kyle nodded in agreement, but his next sentence made the bright smile on the Prince’s face turn stiff.

“Now, that I accomplished the large-scale acid production and all the five laboratories are also filled with apprentices, Your Highness, can you reward me with the ‘Intermediate Chemistry’ like you’ve promised?”

TN: Once again, Kang

Chapter 306

Chapter 306 Inside the garden

Scroll stood behind His Highness Roland, attentively watching as he wrote out the manuscript. Autumn sunshine was falling in through the window onto her back, which made it feel like her whole body was being bathed in warmth.

“Ah, in addition to electronic gains and losses, what further content ah… online class, very urgent.” From time to time the Prince would write something onto the paper and then began to lean his forehead on his hands while he pondered and said some difficult to understand nonsense. At first, Scroll was a little worried about the Prince’s health, but later on she discovered, that this was His Highness’ normal state when he was trying to recall his ‘knowledge’.

Merely that today’s symptoms seemed to be much more severe than ever before.

Unfortunately, I cannot help him… Scroll lightly sighed, if there was a witch who could help him in this regard, I am afraid there is only one, Anna. She had already noted down all the content of the previous books His Highness had written in her brain – but it was merely noted down, nothing more. The past knowledge about those math and natural principles was something much deeper, just reading it is already enough to make people’s head turn muddle-headed, no wonder His Royal Highness feels so embarrassed.

“How about, ending it here for today?” Scroll couldn’t stand it any longer and so she opened her mouth.

Roland decided to give up and put down his pen, leaning his back against the chair then said, “I really envy you for your highly retentive memory. If I could be like you, why would I ever need to worry about exams? I would have been admitted to a famous school and walked to the pinnacle of life.”

She automatically ignored the other's later half of words as nonsense, "Your Royal Highness did they also demand you take those exams at the palace?"

"Yes ah, or how to separate which prince is more outstanding than the others," he mumbled to himself.

"In fact, sometimes it is not good to remember everything," Scroll said with a smile. "For example, bad experiences, or the times when you felt deeply hurt or sad, or when you are unable to forget when your life was still happy."

At the time when she lived in the Seawind Region, due to her identity of being poor, she had to suffer bullying and beatings countless times already. Until today, she could clearly remember the location of every hit, the faces of the perpetrators twisted in anger, and the pain of each kick. Only after finding shelter by the old captain with the broken leg did her life become slightly better. In fact, living in slums like places, with each of them pillaging, fighting, and killing each other, was not much different from freezing or starving to death.

For a long time, she had hated herself very much, why were all her suffering still vivid in her mind. Because the memory of those scenes was still so clear, the nightmares she suffered during the nights, were repetitions of her unbearable past. Later on, during her day of adulthood, when she awakened her branch ability "Magic Book", she finally understood that her extraordinary memory was actually something that came along with her identity as a witch.

Probably Roland could guess what she wanted to say, so he revealed an apologizing smile and said, "You might be right."

Scroll suddenly felt warmth flowing through her heart.

There were only very few people who cared about a witch's thoughts, not to mention, this person was even an illustrious member of the royal family.

"It doesn't matter, those times have already passed, Your Highness."

Roland Wimbledon, compared with other nobles she had seen… no, he was very different compared to all of the people she had met. He possessed a lot of learned knowledge, but all day long he only thought about how he could teach it to other people; his identity was that of a noble, however he didn't reject people that were below his rank; he enjoyed the praise of the crowd, he could act recklessly, but this was not everything to him, instead, he also took care of other people's feelings.

A desolate and impoverished town had undergone earth-shaking changes within one year. The freedom and peace that witches had longed for, was actually granted to them by His Highness Roland. If she hadn't personally experienced it, she would never have believed that there could exist such a ruler in the world.

Nowadays, Scroll had discovered that her own way of thinking had undergone some changes. Before this she hadn't approved of His Highness wanting to take a witch as his wife at all, but now she felt that regardless of who His Royal Highness married, he would take over the throne of Graycastle. He wasn't like the others who kept with the routine of favoring those power-hungry and corrupt nobles, rather, he preferred to make a better life for his people.

She faintly felt that this surge of strength seemed to be stronger than any previous force..

"Ah, let it be," all of a sudden Roland said while rubbing his head, "This is the last page."

"Will you continue to record tomorrow?"

"No, just give it to him like this. Together with the physics teaching material, it should be enough for him to study for a while." His Royal Highness took a new paper and quickly wrote down a few characters on it before he continued, "After all, it is a copy of a book from 'ancient times', so it should be normal to be missing most of it, right?"

Scroll took the paper and saw the name of the book – "Intermediate Chemistry (Remnant)".

…

After finishing her memorizing task, Scroll left the office and was preparing to go back to the City Hall when the magnificent scenery of the back garden attracted her attention.

After the completion of the castle wall expansion, the castle's backyard had almost reached the size of the town square. And now, less than a week after, it was already covered by all kinds of plants. There was no doubt that this must be a masterpiece of Leaves.

Scroll followed the pass formed by two rows of olive trees, step by step going towards the depths of the garden. After passing by a row of dense sugar cane, she saw Leaves sitting on the shore of a pond.

The other side hadn't bound her hair into the braided pigtails she usually wore during the daytime, instead, today she had draped her head full of green long hair over one shoulder. Her spotless white feet were lightly splashing around within the water, she was holding some wheat grains in her hands, and from time to time she would throw them towards the fishes swimming around her feet. Unable to stop herself from chuckling out loud, whenever one of those fishes approached her and gently brushed against her toes.

"Are your feet completely healed?" Scroll asked as she sat next to her.

"Oh, it's you Teacher Scroll," she blinked for a moment in confusion, then nodded happily and said. "Yes, Miss Nana has restored them to their original form. Like this, I finally don't need to endure the pain in my toes during winter."

"Are all these plants you planted in the garden your improved versions?"

"Well," Leaves said as she began to point happily towards each of them, "Over there is the vine shed, here are the fruit trees, and there are the crops. I also asked His Royal Highness to bring me a batch of compost, just so that I could test the absorption quality of the new crops. In addition, there are dozens of bird's nest in the fruit trees, and the messengers Honey raised are all sleeping on top of the trees."

Scroll lovingly stroke her hair and said, “I thought you would be the first witch of the Witch Alliance to evolve. After all, when we were within the Impassable Mountain Range, the ability you displayed wasn’t below that of Cara.”

“His Royal Highness said that the possibility to evolve one’s ability comes along with the understanding of our ability. Plant cells do indeed make people feel they are unfathomable is what I’ve thought long ago, but now I think that at the root of it they are all the same. You see, a bundle of tiny grass when fused together can change into flexible vines, but if they were different, how could something like that ever be possible?”

Scroll opened her mouth, but she didn’t know whether she should comfort her or agree with her, so finally, she said: “Your ability, even without evolving, can already do so much for His Highness.”

“I feel that it is not far away from me,” Leaves said, shaking her head, while her eyes were filled with bright light, “Animals are living, plants are living, and even several parts of them together are living as well… Birds need trees to build a nest, while their droppings once again bring nourishment to the trees. A forest can provide a living being with everything its needs while at the same time the forest extends due to the provided moisture of all living things.” She paused, “Look at this garden. I think I already found a way to move forward.”

TN: We are still searching for people who want to help with the Release That Witch Wiki

Chapter 307

Chapter 307 Death from the sky

The hot air balloon was flying two thousand meters above ground, which was something Lightning had measured by flying vertically up towards the sky.

When she raised her head, it seemed as if the clouds she could see were almost within reach, looking like a loose cotton. However, if she really wanted to touch them, she would still have to fly a few hundred meters or so further up.

The whole hot air balloon was painted with blue and white patches, which from a distance, gave it the exactly same appearance as the sky. Furthermore, they themselves had also put on camouflage clothing, the same was even true for “Easterly Wind 1”. According to His Highness’ requirements, it was important that this surprise attack was sudden and came from under cover. Therefore, the First Army had even gotten off the boat before they reached Silver City’s pier and walked to the back of the nearby mountain.

Under Sylvie’s surveillance, the team was able to avoid all eyes, not drawing anybody’s attention from beginning to end. After they finished setting up camp, Cloud Gazer slowly took off, they would carry out the bombing mission on the next day.

After spending one week on the street, today was the beginning of the first month of autumn.

Due to the insufficient possibilities to observe from inside the basket, Maggie flew out in front of the balloon like a white shadow, taking over the responsibilities for directing and investigating their route. Even from such a high altitude, after changing into a white-tailed eagle, she was quickly able to identify the roads connecting the towns and the carriages that was traveling

on them – at this point, the eagle's eyes were much better than an observation mirror.

Fortunately, the other side cannot change the place at which the bomb will drop, Lightning thought, otherwise I really wouldn't have anything to do.

"Are you tired?" Anna asked, leaning over the side of the basket, "Come in and take a rest, we won't come across any Devil here anyway."

The little girl shook her head, "At this speed, I can fly the whole day long."

"Aren't you a little nervous?" Wendy asked, as she came and leaned over the side.

"I'm not," she said, curling her lips, "I have practiced the course of event many times, and the palace is so big, it'll be impossible for me to miss."

"Is that so?" Wendy smiled. "Anyway, do not try to be brave, His Highness said that the most important thing is our safety. Also…. the incident at the Devil's Town during the investigation mission wasn't your fault."

"What, I…"

Wendy interrupted her in a gentle tone, "Anyone could see that you've been frustrated these last few days, but you weren't too cowardly to fight, rather, you just haven't gained enough battle experience yet. If it had been me in your place, I definitely couldn't have done any better."

"Indeed, Nightingale possess reflexes and skills which most of us witches don't have," Anna added in comfort. "You might as well come in and have a rest, the amount of magic you will need to adjust the impact point of the bomb won't be a small amount."

Hearing the comforting words coming from the two, Lightning sniffed gently, then bowed her head as she entered the basket. Even before she had landed, Wendy had already wrapped her into her bosom, "No one blames you, so you should also not blame yourself, understand?"

"Ok…"

…

After flying for an entire morning, Maggie flapped her wings and returned to Cloud Gazer to report to the other three, “The King’s City of Graycastle is in front of us, we are almost there, goo.”

Lightning immediately flew out of the basket and lifted the lookout mirror – only to see that it was exactly as His Highness had said, King’s City’s city wall was such a grand sight, that it was still clearly visible even from so high up in the sky. It arose from the earth, just like a blue-green colored crooked string as it described the scope of the city. Furthermore, the fingernail-sized white spots in the middle of the gray block seemed especially eye-catching.

According to the first plan, they would first drop leaflets all over King’s City before releasing Easterly Wind No.1. But after going through several test runs, they finally had to accept that there was not any possible way for them to control the direction the papers would fall when releasing it from a height of two thousand meters, even if they were to add some extra weight it still wouldn’t work. Trying to reduce their altitude however meant they would then easily be discovered, after all, Cloud Gazer’s size was just too big. If that was coupled with the stream leaflets dropping from the sky attracting the eyes of the crowd below, it would become very difficult for them to hide.

Therefore, His Royal Highness had decided to cancel the leaflet part in the end. Instead, he had shifted the task to Theo so as to inform the public of the news, that they were the ones who had thrown a bomb at the palace.

Wendy manipulated the airflow so that the basket came to a halt above King’s City.

“Everyone ready?”

“Pull up the valve,” Lighting said while nodding.

Then, she could only hear a loud humming sound as the heavy bomb started moving away from the basket, falling straight down to the ground. As the weight suddenly reduced, the hot air balloon began to fly upwards.

Regarding the following step, she had already knew them by heart for a long time.

Under the airflow caused from it dropping down, the parachute at the end of Easterly Wind No. 1 opened, and so Lightning could easily catch up with the bomb, she then began correcting its trajectory a little at a time.

The witches of the Witch Union weren't unfamiliar with King's City at all. When they'd moved westwards on their journey to the Holy Mountain, they had hidden themselves within the city's slums for several months. One of the reasons for this was to gather food and another was to attract new blood, during which time Soraya and Echo had come to join the Witch Cooperation Association. Although Lightning hadn't experienced it herself, but she had often listened to them speaking about this. Compared to other cities, King's City was very strict in implementing witch hunts, on top of the flight of steps at the outer city's public square, witches would be executed almost every month. As a result, they had stayed there for the shortest amount time, because with every day that passed, they would have to suffer the pain of seeing another sister pass away.

Therefore, Lightning had no favorable impression of this bustling capital city. If she could end the rule of the person responsible for it by dropping a bomb on top of their head, she would be glad to do so. If Roland was the one ruling the Kingdom of Graycastle, all those tragedies would never have happened, isn't that right?

She now had the chance to correct this error.

Under the whistling sound of the wind, the scene below continued to expand, and soon, the details of the palace at the middle of the inner city started becoming clear to Lightning's eyes.

Compared to the size of the living places of the commoners, the palace was many times larger – its main buildings were made up of a dome, a banquet hall, and a tall castle tower. The rest were auxiliary buildings such as stables, barracks, warehouses and so on. Taking into account the steep walls of the castle, the roof's structure was very complex, and not very usable for

the impact detonator, thus His Highness had decided that the imperial palace's hall would be the target of the attack.

As the height dropped sharply, the parachute quickly reached the point of detachment. Lightning pulled the release mechanism, and let the parachute separate from the bomb, then picked it up and quickly began rising towards the sky.

Before their departure, Prince Roland had repeatedly told her that she had to rise high enough and reach a safe position before the bomb hit. By no means should she ever turn around or go and take a look at the explosion, but the young girl was still tempted by her curiosity, and was unable to restrain the impulse to lower her head.

Only to see a dazzling flash of light rise from the top of the hall and rapidly expand in all direction.

The incandescent light quickly turned into a bright orange-red, only to be followed by a rolling cloud of smoke and dust which slowly faded out. This process lasted only one instant before suddenly an ear-splitting sound of an explosion bombarded her ears, almost making her lose her balance.

Lighting really wasn't inexperienced with the booming sound of artillery barrage on a battlefield, but compared to those terrible weapons which could shoot iron balls, the sound of Easterly Wind No.1's explosion would be ten times louder!

Smoke spurt out of the windows and between the pillars of the palace hall, engulfing the surrounding garden and gallery. Soon, several cracks appeared on the round dome which had been at the center of the impact.

Lightning couldn't help but stop and hold her breath as she took in the last moments of the hall.

Those countless black cracks wantonly flowed in all direction like ink, and instantly covered the entire roof. Then, as the roof was no longer able to support itself, it came crashing down, and raised an even stronger cloud of smoke.

Under Easterly Wind No.1’s amazing might, the palace hall finally collapsed.

Chapter 308

Chapter 308 Fear

In recent days, Theo had kept in daily contact with Prince Roland.

In spite of the many incredible things he had seen during the last year he had worked for His Royal Highness, this new order felt a bit inconceivable and had also left him feeling… puzzled.

Announce the attack on the imperial palace as Roland Wimbledon's punishment on Timothy Wimbledon?

At the time the militia which had attacked the Western Territory returned to King's City, he had naturally also heard of the "warning" that they had brought along with them. However, Theo had merely thought that it was His Highness' bluff, or perhaps a plan to threaten the east and strike the west – getting Timothy to increase the defenses while he sent out troops to attack other cities. Just like Garcia had done, going out to loot one of the enemy's cities before the approaching winter.

But the following orders sent from Border Town gave him the impression that he'd been mistaken. In fact, it seemed that His Highness really did intend to attack King's City, and had thus asked him to be ready to spread some propaganda. This latest command had made it clear that the attack would be launched on the first day of autumn, at exactly the same time as announced in the "warning" message.

Taking a look at this sentence, "The attack on the imperial palace could be considered as punishment", in other words, His Highness would forcefully enter the King's City inner city – but how could that be possible? King's City possessed Graycastle's mightiest city walls, with a thickness that could accommodate two houses set side by side, which even for His Highness's artillery would be difficult to destroy. Furthermore, with the kingdom's best Knights, personal guards, as well as the enlisted militia as defenders, it

would be hard to set even one step into the city without already having an army that was more than ten thousand people strong.

Even using witches to initiate surprise attacks would have a similar outcome. Within the imperial palace there were as many God's Stone of Retaliation as there were hairs on an ox. In addition, in the palace's grand hall and in the other parts of the palace all had giant God's Stones of Retaliation installed in them. So as soon as a witch set even one foot inside the room, she would immediately be stripped of all her powers. This was also the reason why Timothy could hunt and kill witches wantonly while being fearless of any retaliation – wishing to ever assassinate a member of the royal family was simply an unattainable dream.

Furthermore, even if there was a method, it still held some hidden dangers to it. If Timothy Wimbledon really was to die under a witch's hand, most likely the Church would be the party to receive the greatest benefit… With only a little bit of guidance, they could start to claim that the 4th Prince, a pawn of the Devil's minions would sit on the throne, which would result in all of the other nobles unifying against him. But Theo believed that a person like His Royal Highness already possessed enough intelligence to see hidden dangers such as that.

So, in the end, how will His Highness get into and attack the inner city?

"Sir, what kind of instruction do you have for me to come over?" Opening the half-closed door, Hill Fawkes walked into the living room.

"We are waiting for a new order," Theo said and spread out his hands, "So go and take a seat first."

"…Yes."

Theo could only smile helplessly when he saw the flabbergasted expression on the former member of the acrobatic group. Usually he would only inform these people when he had received precise orders; but this time, it would be inconvenient for him to inform them of His Highness' mission ahead of time – in case they were unable to launch the attack on the imperial palace, this

seemingly absurd instruction could easily reduce the other party's level of trust.

But on the contrary, if His Royal Highness was able to be true to his claim it would become an unprecedented shock to them, which could also greatly enhance the confidence of these people – especially if they could see with their own eyes that His Highness was able to shake Timothy's throne even from a thousand miles away, and thus cause a real threat to the throne. Compared to spreading propaganda from mouth to mouth, this kind of action would be several times more effective.

So, Theo chose to go with a compromise and called Hill over to the house in the inner city before waiting for His Highness to fulfill his warning. If they were successful, it would naturally be to everyone's delight, but if they failed, he just had to lie and say that the messenger had been delayed during the journey.

"Have some tea," Theo offered laughingly, "Don't always show your doubt all over your face, as an intelligence officer the most important thing is –"

"To mask yourself, Sir." He took the cup in response, "Oh, by the way. Recently there have been much more patrols visible on the streets, even the guards defending the city wall have been doubled. Don't tell me… do these maneuvers have something to do with His Highness' order?"

"Indeed, Timothy –"

Just half of Theo's words had left his mouth, as a sudden clap of thunder from above rolled over the mansion. A sound that was so loud and clear that the glass in the windows began to tremble. At the same time, the ground also began to faintly shake with distinct tremors for a short duration. As he was caught off guard, Hill's hands began to shake, the teacup fell to the ground, breaking into several pieces.

"I'm sorry, Sir… But," Hill stuttered stupefied, "This is… what just happened?"

"Come with me," Theo ordered, wearing an earnest expression.

The moment they ran out of the residence and entered the garden, their gazes was immediately attracted to a pillar of black smoke that was rising from the palace. Apparently, that was where the thunder had come from. Theo had experienced when cannons and firearms released their might, he naturally knew that only the alchemist's fine powder could give rise to this sound of heaven's anger. What's more, such a violent tremor was unlike anything that an artillery bombardment could have caused. Instead, it was more like those explosive packages they had originally used to deal with the heavy armored demonic beasts.

Hill stood beside him, his mouth opened wide and unable to believe what his eyes were telling him. "Could it be that His Highness' declared warning was real?"

"That's right," Theo was finally able to control his racing heart, he turned, pretending to be profound as he stated, "This is the new order His Highness wants me to give you."

*

Timothy could only look on with an ashen face as the chandelier fell in front of his eyes, and was struck speechless for a long time.

"Your Majesty, keke… Are you alright, Sire?" The Imperial Prime Minister said coughingly from somewhere from within the dust that had flew up and was filling the whole sky. "What the hell just happen outside?"

Timothy didn't answer, he merely felt a terrible pain in his throat. The chandelier just now had fallen on top of a silver armored knight. At that time, the man had still been in the process of giving a report of the refugees that were enlisting, yet his neck had been broken by the chandelier. If I had gone one step further, I am afraid I would…

Thinking until here, all the hair on his back stood up straight.

"Is this an earthquake?" The Finance Minister said, still locked in a panicked state, "We have to get out of the castle and reach an open place."

“That’s right Your Majesty, it isn’t safe here!”

“Everyone shut up!” Timothy shouted. The moment he opened his mouth however, he discovered that his voice had turned hoarse, becoming difficult to understand, as if he was speaking while pinching his own throat, “Sir Weimar, take me to the basement immediately!”

“Yes, Your Majesty.” Although he looked a bit nervous but compared to the performance of several other ministers, he could still be regarded as very calm. He immediately walked over and helped Timothy up, then they walked together the stairs leading further down.

Along the way, the new king saw that the aisle was covered with pieces of shattered glass and also that the blue dome of heaven behind the damaged windows had ceased to exist. In the midst of the still soaring smoke and dust, only a few pillars from this former magnificent building could still be seen. This wasn’t caused by an earthquake, but by an explosion caused by a large amount of snow powder!

If I leave the castle now I would undoubtedly step on my own path of doom. Only god knows where Roland has buried snow powder. I’m only safe behind the thick walls of the basement.

Damn it, Timothy thought hateful, how on earth can my brother be in possession of such an alchemic weapon? Could it be, before her departure of Clear Water, Garcia had given him the formula, so that he could use the snow powder to make both sides suffer?

But even then, how was he able to bring the snow powder inside of the palace? Even with the ability of an extraordinary witch it still wouldn’t have been possible!

“Take some knights along with you and thoroughly search the whole palace. Especially the sewers, gardens, and warehouses; anywhere that it would be easy to hide snow powder!” Timothy immediately ordered toward Knight Steel Heart after reaching the basement. “If you find any suspicious character, noble or commoner, immediately arrest them. All attendants and servants

who enter or leave the palace should be thoroughly searched, none of them can be spared!”

“As you bid, Your Majesty.”

After Sir Weimar had left, the new king discovered that his back was now covered in cold sweat.

Roland has actually done it!

Regardless of how he had done it. Since he could hide the snow powder inside the palace this time, does that mean that he can reach the castle as easily as turning his hand the next time he comes?

“Your position is not as safe as you think, everyone will see that your throne is already crumbling.”

Recalling the words of the warning, Timothy could not help but shudder.

As his anger gradually subsided, he felt fear come rising from the soles of his feet, bit by bit it was taking hold of his heart.

Chapter 309

Chapter 309 The Exploration of Knowledge

On the second day of autumn Roland finally received a letter from King's City.

Since the letter sent came via a flying messenger, it was most likely written by his personal guard Theo.

Freeing the paper from the bird's claw, Roland stepped over to the window, using the radiant and enchanting sunshine to carefully read through it.

"Because the palace was quickly blocked and no one was allowed to enter or leave, I wasn't able to scout out the damage caused by the explosion. But within the evening almost all of King's City's inhabitants knew of the attack on the palace, whether it be in the pub, the inn or the city squares, wherever people gathered there was only one topic of discussion. Even the death of the former King hadn't caused such a sensational impact. In addition, since you've given a warning beforehand, there are now many people who believe that Timothy has already died from this attack and they believe you will soon start ruling over King's City from there becoming the new king of the Kingdom of Graycastle."

This paragraph allowed Roland to feel thoroughly relieved – there could be no better news for him than to hear that the bombing mission had been successfully carried out, and that the witches would be safely returning soon.

He made himself a cup of tea before returning to the side of the mahogany table and continuing to read the letter.

"However, according to the collected information, at present, there isn't any sign of activity from the several big nobles outside King's City. Furthermore, the royal palace has also responded very quickly, so I speculate that Timothy Wimbledon is still likely to be alive.

“In addition, there are some people who swear that this attack had come from the sky. In the end, there seems to be some residents who’ve witnessed an unremarkable colored object drop from the sky, falling with utmost speed unto the imperial palace. Therefore, I have already come up with an initial plan regarding the task you’ve handed me – if I could actually embellish this matter into heaven’s punishment against the fake King, I think that many of the people will believe it to be the truth.

“Regarding this, the hands under my control are full of enthusiasm. During daytime, they’ve collected information concerning all of Timothy’s tyrannical practices. If this was to be mixed in with the story, it would surely become even more effective. I believe that it won’t even be a month before the street rats spread this news to the ears of all of the citizens.

“In addition, I will continue to closely monitor the movements of the Eastern Barracks. But looking at the current situation, Timothy still doesn’t seem to have come up with any countermeasures to resist the attack, so it seems that he doesn’t have any time to care about anyone else.”

The letter was again not signed at the end. After reaching its end, Roland folded the letter and put it into the drawer before releasing a deep and long breath.

In case Easterly Wind No.1 really has stopped Timothy from dispatching troops, the result would already be very good.

After all, the large number of drugged people consumed during a fight was indeed too wasteful. The later the other side launched its battle of attrition, the more opportunities Roland could get to win over the population.

Roland raised the cup and drank a mouthful of fragrant black tea. For now, the next thing he needed to do was to rest and wait for the witches to return.

It was already several days since he had last seen Anna, and there was also nobody who stole any of the dried fish out of the drawer, all in all, this made him feel a bit uncomfortable.

At this moment, Carter opened the door to the office.

“Your Royal Highness, two fleets have arrived at the pier.”

“Has Margaret’s Chamber of commerce finally arrived? Taking into account the time she had spent on the road, she must have missed a good show… hold on,” Roland stopped for a moment, feeling slightly surprised, “You said there were two fleets?”

“Yes,” Carter said laughingly, “You remember the messenger group you had sent to the Southern Territory to recruit staff? A batch of troops has already come back. The number of refugees that they brought along with them is already enough to crowd the pier to its bursting point. Currently, the City Hall is carrying out your plan and Miss Lily is executing the…”

“Quarantine operation.”

“Ah right, you’re talking about the program to eliminate the existence of plagues or similar threats…” The Chief Knight coughed twice, “This group of people number about four or five hundred people in size.”

“Do they?” Roland couldn’t prevent the corner of his mouth from rising. It seems as if it was just moments ago when we spoke about the possibility of this matter, but now it’s already started to show results. It seems as if the number of temporary houses Lotus needs to prepare has increased yet again, “Let’s go and take a look.”

*

Kyle Sichi put down the extremely thin remaining section of the “Intermediate Chemistry” while repeatedly muttering, “So that is what it is.”

“Mentor?” Chavez asked anxiously.

Since the time he had received the “Intermediate Chemistry”, Kyle had been unable to find any sleep within the last two days, almost reading through the whole ancient book overnight. Chavez himself had also taken a few glances at it, but the book’s content was too abstruse and much too difficult to understand.

“I’m fine,” the Chief Alchemist’s voice didn’t contain any trace of weariness, instead it appeared as if his spirit was trembling with excitement. Even though the corner of his eyes may have contained some dirt, his two eyes were still bright and full of fire, and looked nothing like a person who had just gone through a sleepless night.

The times when the mentor delved into alchemy they mustn’t be easily disturbed, this was a rule which each disciple need to abide by. So, having waited until now, Chavez finally dared to open his mouth and speak, “This book… this disciple doesn’t understand what is an atom, and what is an electron?”

“You are already a qualified alchemist, so you mustn’t call yourself a disciple. According to His Highness, we are colleagues now.” Kyle paused, “As for your question, I do not know how to answer it… In fact, when His Royal Highness Roland gave me the “Intermediate Chemistry”, this book was also attached to it.

Chavez looked at another book on the table, on the cover was written: “Theoretical Foundations of Natural Science”.

“Sichi… Mentor” he wasn’t accustomed to using such a familiar form of address yet, “It looks as if it closely follows alchemy… No, it completely lacks any relation with chemistry.”

“I also thought the same,” Kyle said while stroking his beard. He sighed then continued to speak, “However, after reading through a few pages, I discovered that I have actually been totally ignorant of this world.”

“What?” Chaves was stunned. Alchemy is the study of the composition of substance, the essence of elements. If they could be considered as knowing nothing about it, then what difference was there between other people and monkeys?

“I mean the concept behind it,” the Chief Alchemist’s voice was full of excitement… and also satisfaction, “We think that alchemy is just alchemy; that it is the research of scholarly knowledge. We say to ourselves that the

sun rising and falling, and the flowers blooming and fading are things which have no relation to us."

"Isn't that right?… Those who are good at observing the sun and the stars become astrologers, as for the plants," Chavez was slightly disgusted, "Only farmers and herbalist would study them."

"That's why we know nothing at all," Kyle shook his head, "From the beginning, this book tried to connect everything together, whether they it be stones, flowers, thunder, or fire, all are made up of the same thing, all follow the same set of rules. Not only does chemistry react according to these rules, even the sun rises and falls and the flowers bloom and fade according to it. This rule is so precise, that as long as the conditions are the same, the result will also always be exactly the same. Chemistry is only a small part of this."

"……How can this be?"

"I also find it hard to imagine," he unfolded the periodic table of elements. "In Intermediate Chemistry, it describes the form of these elements – one big ball surrounded by numerous smaller balls. The big ball decides which kind of element it is, and the number of balls in the outer ring determines the characteristics of the element, and this very list, is arranged according to this law. They're as neatly lined up as a parade of soldiers. Now, I also fully understand the meaning of His Highness: Why we can, without ever having seen or come into contact with this element, are still able to deduce its properties and reactions. Because even the smallest reaction, like the loss or addition of those small balls, won't involve any changes to the big ball at all. This is also the reason why elements don't disappear during a reaction, they will only ever transform."

For a moment Chavez pondered about what he had heard and then asked, "Do you … believe it?"

These theories are too misty, and they cannot be verified by the eye, so how are the people who wrote the book able to know of it?

"I do not know, so I cannot answer your previous question," Kyle said while showing a smile, "But it doesn't matter whether you believe it or not. The

key is that it provides a perspective I have never imagined before… In the end, it allows me to look at it through another door and behind that door, there isn't only just chemistry." Speaking until here, his voice came to a stop, "Unfortunately, His Royal Highness wasn't able to record everything. Perhaps he was unable to understand it himself, so who knows what he might have missed."

Chavez wasn't able to comprehend everything he had heard, just like when he had become an apprentice. When he'd first heard the terms used by alchemists' it had been like hearing people speak in another language, and now, he once again had this feeling.

But he wasn't worried, as long as he followed his mentor, he would be able to learn this so-called theory of "all living things are interconnected." Compared to the Chief Alchemist, the thing he lacked the most now, was time.

After a moment of silence, Chavez asked, "But, why did His Highness use different colors for the names of the books?"

Showing an expression of surprise the Chief Alchemist let out a cry, "Ah." Then he said, "This… is something I'd actually ignored. Could it be that he'd casually used them?" But he quickly shook his head, "No, if they were colored black and red it could be the case. But these types of colors are especially difficult to make, it is unlikely to be unintentional. In other words, His Highness deliberately used them?"

"Elementary Chemistry" was blue, "Theoretical Foundations of Natural Science" was also blue, "Elementary Mathematics" was green, and "Intermediated Chemistry (Remnants)" was written with purple paint. It didn't stand out when you looked at each of them alone, but if placed together, it was particularly eye-catching.

"Probably for appearance sake?" Chavez guessed.

Chapter 310

Chapter 310 The Purified

Mayne stood on top of an arched hillside, overlooking the city ahead of him from a distance.

Last time, Wolfsheart city's walls had looked far different from what it looked like now – the walls were built with stones from the Kingdom of Eternal Winter appearing clean and white, just like the teeth of a newborn wolf. However, within just three months' time, its appearance had been completely changed. Breakages had been filled with the local black boulders and the gaps which they couldn't mend in time had been blocked with wooden palisades, the blood-soaked stone had lost its pure white color, and turned into a reddish brown instead.

Looking from the distance, the current walls looked rough and seemed to be covered with dirt, like wolf teeth that had experienced years of wind and frost. Compared with its prior appearance, they now looked more like the teeth of a ravening predator – like the time when they were tearing their prey apart, which was the most fearsome sight to humans.

The Church's army had set up their camp about 2,5 miles outside of Wolfsheart City. In order to prevent the former Queen of Clear Water from raiding the Old Holy City, they hadn't brought along the same size as last time. The Army of Judges and the baggage teams were both around five thousand people, while the God's Punishment Army had a total of nearly eight hundred or so. However, with their secret siege weapon and the purified, Mayne had full confidence that they would be able to clear out this nest of wolves.

"Your Excellency, the Siege Beast is in place and ready to attack." A priest came to the top of the hill to report to him.

"What's the status of the Purified who are controlling it?"

“They are also prepared to launch.”

Mayen lifted the observation mirror and looked toward the direction of the ‘Siege Beast’ – only to see two fearsome steel beasts lying within the farmland two miles away from the city walls, both sides were surrounded with obstruction boards and had a grass covered roof over them. If you didn’t take a careful look, it would be difficult to detect this ferocious weapon with its uncanny shape.

Moving his line of sight forward, he saw a lineup of the God’s Punishment Army. These were the transformed soldiers of the Church’s most devoted believers, standing straight in the autumn wind, all of them motionless. Only when the enemy fought against them would they really be able to understand just how terrifyingly powerful these extraordinary warriors were. Unfortunately, they couldn’t act autonomously and would only act according to the orders issued by the commander during battle. However, the commander has never appeared publicly in the Church, and during battle would fight from within the ranks, disguised as a member of the God’s Punishment Army. So, except for the three Archbishops and the Pope, there was no one who knew his true identity.

“Very good,” Mayne said as he nodded in satisfaction. “Return to your position and wait for the attack horn to sound.”

“Yes, Your Excellency.”

His next task was to meet with the Purifieds that the Pope had sent.

When he thought of those two witches, he could not help but frown, they were as different as black and white compared to the other witches of the Church, even during the march to fight they were still carrying on with their own things. If they were one of his own Purifieds, they would already have been punished with a flogging, but the position of these two and Archbishop Mayne were on equal footing, so he wasn’t allowed to direct them. His Holiness had only sent these two Purifieds to ‘provide assistance’ during the battle, not to ‘obey’ his orders.

But he also knew, if he wanted to completely eradicate all of the hidden dangers he was going to have to depend on their powers.

The Archbishop went down the hill and stopped in front of a tent outside the camp. But when he opened the curtain, the bedstraws were unsurprisingly empty.

“Zero and Isabella?” He asked the judge standing at the entrance.

“The two Ladies are currently interrogating the captives, they should be at the east side of the camp now,” the judge said. “There is a flat open space there, you can see it immediately when you get there. Or do you want me to go and call them back?”

If it would be enough to send you to call them, I wouldn’t have needed to come here to begin with. But they are playing with the captives again… aren’t they tired of playing? “No, it’s alright, I will look for them myself.”

…

He soon found the place the guard had told him of.

Only to see two women stand in the center of a level ground. One of them was leaning forward, her head next to the ears of three prisoners whose hands were tied together, and whispering something to them. The expression on her face was gentle but focused, her white long hair and her robe was dancing in the wind, just like a flawless spirit. The other woman possessed an impressive figure and had a head full of golden curly hair, and from time to time she would release a sweet-sounding and clear laugh.

“Have the surrounding Judges immediately vacate the area.” Mayne instructed his personal guard to send instruction to the Presiding Judge, “The same is true for the people responsible for looking after the captives, tell them that there is no more need for them to look after them.”

“As you bid.”

At this moment, the blond witch also noted their arrival, she informed her partner and quickly walked over.

“Your Excellency,” the blond witch said while giving a slight bow, “Why did you drive the audience away? The trial was just about to begin.”

“Ms. Isabella,” he nodded back, “The all-out attack on Wolfsheart City is about to begin, so interrogating the prisoners has become meaningless now. Furthermore, these people can’t tell us more than the other spies we’ve caught along the way, and that was only a pathetic amount of news. If possible, I hope you and Zero can immediately rush over to the front line.”

“Don’t worry, since we are already here, we couldn’t let such an important enemy just walk away,” Isabella said while spreading out her hands. “As for the trial… there is nothing I can do to stop her. How about, you can just act as the audience, it won’t take them that long anyway.”

“The same as before?”

“Well, the rules will be basically the same,” she laughed, “Zero really likes this kind of game.”

“If it’s like that then quickly get started.” Damn it! Even though Mayne’s face became expressionless, inwardly he was burning with anger. Speaking of this judgement game, it would be more appropriate to look at it as a cat playing with a mouse. The captives had to escape a predefined range or defeat the witch, only by doing this could they obtain a slim chance of survival – and this chance to live was extremely slim, but the bait was still good enough to lure out the mouse. It already seemed difficult to achieve, but in fact, it was something they would never be able to reach.

The reason for scattering the Judges who were responsible for safeguarding and monitoring the Purifieds was that the upcoming process couldn’t be considered as entirely fair or just. The other’s action wasn’t in accordance with the behavior of Purified, so seeing this, he was afraid that it might waver their faith in the Church.

Just wait until I take over the position of the Pope, at that time I will have to teach them the importance of obediently following orders.

At this moment, Zero had already freed the prisoners from the ropes and spread out her hands to show that she wasn't wearing any weapon on her body. While in front of the prisoners there laid a sword, a machete, and a light crossbow.

"Come on, fight or run, just follow your hearts," Zero said with a gentle tone. "Only God can issue a ruling."

One of them clenched his teeth then suddenly picked up the crossbow from the ground and directly shot an arrow at the Purified. Not even looking whether he had hit, his other hand had already taken hold of the sword as he tried to seize the opportunity to rush forward and chop out horizontally. This whole set of actions were executed in one smooth movement, clearly a skill that was impossible for militia.

However, the captive cut through nothing but empty air. The Purified had simply taken two steps back and easily avoided the surprise attack. When the captive came to a stop and raised his head, he couldn't suppress a short flicker of surprise when he saw that the other was holding the arrow with her teeth, as if she was chewing on a harmless branch.

Zero spit out the arrow, waved at the captive, and with a smile, she said, "Please, carry on."

The captive stared blankly at her, his hands trembling slightly. Mayne could see that all the courage he'd gathered with such difficulty had already left him again, even if the fight were to continue, it would only for last for one more exchange.

Sure enough, after hesitating for a moment, the captive raised his head and roared like a wild boar. Then raised his sword and darted toward the unarmed woman.

But this attempt was too stiff, even with closed eyes, Mayne could guess at the result – just within his half a lunar cycle long contact with Zero, Mayne

had already become aware that her powers were almost limitless. Even though she wasn't an extraordinary, she still possessed innate battle skills not inferior to them. These skills weren't in her supernatural strength or resistance, but rather in her extremely skillful technique.

Even if she couldn't use any magic, she was still a dreadful enough soldier.

The witch moved her body slightly to the side, easily avoiding the opponent's hack. Then her pair of seemingly fragile hands clamped the prisoner's head, and using his forward momentum, she softly moved it. This slight flick only released a light cracking sound, but as if the other side had suddenly lost all the bones in his body, he immediately became limp and fell to the ground.

She turned her head and looked to the two remaining captives then said, "Now, it's your turn."

Chapter 311

Chapter 311 War of Mortals (Part 1)

Seeing this scene, one of the other prisoners turned and ran away which caused Zero to look somewhat disappointed.

She turned into a ray of light and entered the fleeing captive's body, who immediately stopped his steps. The captive's eyes turned white, and his body began to undergo strange changes – this wasn't Mayne's first time seeing such a scene, but no matter how often he saw it, he couldn't prevent a chill from arising within his heart.

A dim ray of light burst out from within the captive's body and his body began to twist and deform until finally changed into the very appearance of the Purified who had entered him.

He knew that this wasn't a simple act of replacing and slaughtering, but what exactly happened during this transformation process, Mayne was afraid that only the Pope or the people involved could fully understand.

Zero took a deep breath and went back to the last prisoner.

He was the youngest of three captured spies, probably only fourteen to fifteen years old. His young and inexperienced eyes were filled with shock and fear, unable to accept what had happened just now.

"Now, you're the only one left," she whispered, "Eyre."

Hearing these words, the trembling boy who had originally wanted to pick up the machete froze in shock and started to stammer, "H-how…"

"God told me everything. Actually, you were merely a farmer's child living in the outskirts, but because of the Wolf King's order, you and the other village people were forced to move into the city, and became responsible for repairing the city walls, creating the military supplies, transporting the

army's provision and so on. In other words, forced labor. Instead of letting you go because of your young age, they rather decided to recruit you into the investigation troops. In reality they've planned for you to emerge and perish on your own," she reached out and touched his cheeks, "The best evidence for this is that at the time you sent back the intelligence about the large military operation of the Church, the captain of the guards didn't even let you enter the camp. Instead, after listening to your report he immediately sent you back to us, right?"

"I…" Eyre opened his mouth, but couldn't find any words.

"Of course, they couldn't let you enter, because your family had already ceased to exist. Your parents were accepted, while your brother was the same as you, merely consumables for the Wolf King. So, if you were allowed to return, wouldn't it make all the other scouts know about it?" Zero said, "Your father fell to his death while trying to fill a gap in the wall. Your mother, trying to find the workplace overseer had to suffer punishment with a whip and is now on the verge of death. In a world where God doesn't examine everything, evil always wantonly flows around like sewage. Are you sure you really want to fight for such a ruler?"

The young boy stared with wide eyes at her, unable to mask his sorrow, "This… is impossible, you're lying to me!"

"God never lies," the Purified shook her head. "And in the bottom of your heart, you know that I'm telling the truth. The root of all this evil is the nobility. They never regarded you as one of their own kind, they merely see you as livestock. What the Church is trying to do is to put an end to all this evil and injustice, they want to build a new world under the care and watchful eyes of God."

With a plopping sound, Eyre sank to his knees, lowered his head and began to cry bitterly, "What should I do?"

"Follow your heart, only God can issue the ruling."

He choked with sobs and said, "I was wrong. I am willing to tell you everything I know, I will do anything I can to save my mother."

“Such a clever child,” Zero patted his head then took out a plant with slender leaves from her pocket and held it in front of him, “Eat this, and you will have a good sleep. It will also help you stabilize your mood.” She tore off half a leaf, put it into her mouth, and began to chew, before saying, “Just like me. Wait until tomorrow, after breaking through the walls of Wolfsheart City you might be able to see your mother again.”

Mayne puckered his brows, the Peacefully Sleeping Bracken was something used in the making of Dream Water. It didn’t show any effect on witches, but when taken by ordinary people it was a very severe poison, which required that they intake the Winterflower to neutralize its toxicity. Sure enough, after eating it, it didn’t take long until the prisoner’s face turned ashen. He forcefully gripped his throat, and looked with an expression of absolute disbelief at the smiling Purified, only able to release some incomprehensible ‘och och’ sounds. His own fingernails quickly tore open his skin and blood vessels before the blood that came splashing out dyed his neck bright red. His painful struggle continued for half an hour until his body gradually turned limp and he finally stopped breathing.

“It’s such a pity that God didn’t forgive your sins,” Zero said while smiling. Then she walked over toward the Archbishop and bowed in greeting, “Your Excellency, how do you feel about the trial? Did it have the same elegant manner of Excellency Heather?”

“Why must you deceive him into eating the Peacefully Sleeping Bracken?” Mayen asked with a heavy tone, “If it had been Heather, we could have added one devote believer to our ranks. Rather than making him kill himself while thinking he is moving back on the right path.”

“If the situation of the captive’s loved ones were like I had said, I would naturally have recruited him as a believer, but unfortunately I do not know what really happened to his parents. Those words of mine were nothing more than me talking nonsense.” She said in a carefree voice while shrugging, “The moment he discovers that my words were all lies, he would obviously turn against the Church. Believe me, I serve the Church wholeheartedly.”

If you served the Church wholeheartedly, you would have properly waited for my orders in the tent, Mayne thought while impatiently turning his head

and stating, “The attack will begin soon. You must immediately prepare yourself and move according to the plan, the Wolf King and the Queen of Clear Water —”

“—Must die, Your Excellency,” the Purified said, “If it was me alone, I might not have been able to do it. But since even Isabella has come with me, they absolutely won’t be able to run away.”

*

“Woo-woo-”

The bugle horn’s trumpet, which was the signal to attack, rolled across the horizon. Under the pressuring dark clouds and in the middle of the rustling autumn wind, it raised the curtain to the second act of the siege against Wolfsheart City.

One mile away, the frame of the ‘Siege Beast’ that launched the spears gave out rays of magical light. The moment the light was as bright as the sun, the iron spear suddenly burst straight toward the walls. Flying as though it had been thrown by a giant’s hand, it reached a speed that made it difficult to sight, and a moment later was followed by an earsplitting roar.

After crossing such a long distance the spear had hardly lost any of its might. The moment it hit the wall, it crushed the stone into powder. Even the house-sized boulders were easily pulverized and the soldiers standing behind the wall were coincidentally also shot dead. After merely three rounds of fire, the city gate was completely smashed, and the surrounding walls utterly broken.

Even though the firing rate of the Devil’s siege weapon was equivalent to an ordinary catapult, its range was several times further. Against this kind of offensive, it was absolutely impossible for the garrison force to try and strike back. Unable to see the trajectory of the launch, they weren’t even able to determine where the next attack would be hitting, The Church’s army hadn’t moved, yet the defensive line was already in imminent danger.

Just then, a world-shaking loud boom suddenly sounded behind the wall!

Seeing a massive fireball soar into the sky, the people on the battlefield all felt the earth starting to shake beneath their feet. Then, accompanied by black smoke and fire, the wall collapsed with a loud rumble. Finally creating an opening in this mottled wolf's tooth.

The sharp horn sounded again, the mixed forces composed of the Army of Judges and God's Punishment Army initiated their charge against the city wall. Looking at it from afar, they looked like a flowing reddish-gold ocean, mercilessly swallowing everyone who even dared to stand against it.

Now Wolfsheart's defenders would have to rely on their own flesh and blood in order to withstand these soldiers who stood apart from the mortal world.

Chapter 312

Chapter 312 War of Mortals (Part 2)

Mortals cannot defeat the Devils, Isabella thought to herself, therefore the Church created the God's Punishment Army.

They possess considerable strength, feel no pain, and know no fear, making them the best weapon against the Devils. Although they don't possess the ability to act on their own, that isn't necessarily a disadvantage in battles between armies.

Against such a powerful force, a garrison of mortals naturally would never be able to resist.

Especially after losing the backing of their city wall, seeking to beat the Church's elite force in a melee fight is nothing less than a wishful dream.

Like a powerful golden current, the Army of Judges dashed through the main gate of Wolfsheart City's wall, entering hand to hand combat against all of the assembled defenders. The red colored God's Punishment Army looked as if they were walking on level ground as they climbed over the collapsed city wall and started to massacre those who attempted to stop the flood of enemies.

"Do you want to go and help them?" Isabella asked after turning towards Zero.

The latter yawned and then said uninterested, "No, my magic is limited, so I have to save it for the important targets."

"You could just use the sword, hammer, or crossbow to fight ah," Isabella said, feeling displeased, "No matter what they wouldn't be able to beat you."

Zero shook her head, "If I go, they will easily win. If I don't go, they will still easily win. There is no point in doing it, so I don't want to."

“Alright,” she changed the subject. “Why did you do that before?”

“Why?”

“While you were playing with the prisoners, the Bishop’s face was stiff for the whole time,” said Isabella. “It seems that he doesn’t appreciate your kind of trial, and also he is the most likely candidate to be the next Pope, when that time comes you might suffer a lot.”

“The reason why Excellency Mayne becomes angry is only because he hasn’t become the Pope yet,” Zero said carelessly. “When he goes into the library at the top of the Pivotal Secret Temple, he will come to understand that my way of handling things is exactly the way in which to please God.”

“What… way of handling?”

“Playing with, ah,” the Purified ran her hands through her hair to tidy the mess created by the wind. “God has never descended on the world, he also doesn’t protect his people. Only by having a single illusory objective can we guarantee to take over when someone else fails to reach it, in hopes of receiving his favor. Doesn’t this concept resemble the trial I just held? I at least provided him with a real objective, something that God never will. It isn’t even guaranteed that his objective is realistic or whether everything is our own crazy raving. Yet even with so much uncertainty, we still dash onward with no thought to our personal safety… Tsktsk, it is truly the most thorough play.”

What’s this woman talking about? Why can’t I understand one word? Isabella knitted her brows and asked confused, “Have you ever been to the library?”

“No,” She shrugged her shoulders, “These were words His Holiness O’Brian had said to me. He isn’t a witch, and his lifespan is already approaching its end. I heard that when mortals reach their end, they will start to reminisce on their life and will always hope to find someone to talk to about it. He even wants to let me swallow him before his death.”

“You can’t –”

“Of course I mustn’t, that would make Excellency Mayne furious,” Zero interrupted, “Rest assured, I know what I’m allowed to do and what not.” A mysterious smile played around her lips, “There is another possibility. What will happen if I lose? Can’t I then offer up my body as a present to him?”

“I don’t think so. If you lose, chances are that nothing is going to happen.” Isabella sighed, this woman is a strange one, probably because of her ability – after swallowing so many people, it’s very hard for her to find something she hadn’t experienced yet. Which leads to her seldom being interested in anything and instead is simply doing everything for the sake of pleasure, furthermore, only an unusual pleasure will suffice.

Isabella moved her line of sight back to the battlefield. A group of desperados suddenly appeared from the gaps in the city wall and started charging into the ranks of the God’s Punishment Army. Most of them came to a screaming end at the end of a spear, but there were still a few who managed to slip through the net. The sound of explosions began to rise, followed by smoke rising to cover all of the gaps within the wall.

This should be the new alchemy weapon which started to appear during the last siege, she thought. It seems quite powerful; thus it would be a good choice to use it against the demonic beasts. But using it in an attempt to deal with the God’s Punishment Army is just a quick way to commit suicide. If it weren’t for those pills, they would never even have dared to approach the soldiers of the God’s Punishment Army.

On the other side, the mighty current of the golden ocean slowed as raging flames suddenly emerged on the path through the city gate, isolating the soldiers who had already entered the city from the Judges still standing in front. Some people who were caught by the flames desperately started to roll over the ground to try and extinguish the flames, but it was to no avail.

“Hmm… the amount of the God’s Stone of Retaliation has increased exponentially behind the gates. There are even two high-quality stones present. It seems as if someone important has come.” Isabella opened her mouth.

“That being the case, let’s go and end it,” Zero said, and leisurely stretched her waist.

“But those two are neither the Wolf King nor the Queen of Clear Water,” Isabella informed while glancing at the city, “The most intense reaction is still inside the castle. Are you sure you want to go?”

“Isn’t the army in trouble? Winning easily and winning miserably isn’t the same. I still have to help His Holiness O’Brian reduce the losses,” Zero tilted her head and continued in an earnest tone, “Just like I said before, I serve the Church wholeheartedly.”

…

It was already afternoon when Wolfsheart City’s defensive line finally broke under the siege warfare. After the soldier of the God’s Punishment Army got control over the city gate, the Army of Judges began to chase the enemy’s soldiers through the streets to clear up all the resistance.

“The targets have started to move,” Isabella said after looking toward the direction of the castle, “It seems they intend to go to the river dock.”

Those two people who had come to organize the resistance at the wall and city gates were the Wolf King’s sons. And now, through the information she gathered after swallowing both of them, Zero further confirmed that the two moving God’s Stones of Retaliation with the highest reaction were indeed the primary targets of this mission.

In addition, they had also taken care of a fallen witch who looked and dressed as if she was of a different tribe. After the death of the witch, the militia forces who dared to go against the God’s Punishment Army suddenly reduced by a lot.

“They probably want to leave by ship,” Zero said with a blooming smile. “Let’s go and complete the mission given to us by His Holiness.”

The action of the other side made it clear that they were very cautious. On their way toward the docks they changed routes several times and when they

finally arrived at the pier they didn't board one of those huge ships with black sails, but instead chose the small sloop of a merchant.

But no matter how hard they tried to cover their whereabouts, in front of the constantly monitoring Isabella their movements were immediately exposed.

The moment the Wolf King and the Queen of Clear Water boarded the deck of the ship, two people came over from the other side of the pier. There were twenty additional soldiers on top of the ship, most of them were personal guards. When they saw the two appear, they immediately knew that something was amiss without even needing to think about it. Thus everyone drew their weapon and jumped off the vessel, throwing themselves straight at the Purifieds.

It was once more time for Zero to display her superior fighting skills. She was empty handed as she seized the sword of a personal guard and drew everyone in to start fighting against her. With every sword stroke she made an enemy collapse, her footsteps lithe and quick, with only a few people able to anticipate her next move. Whether it was a poke, strike, chop, or block, Zero always used the appropriate amount of strength and the trickiest angle to strike, and soon, more than a dozen personal guards were lying on the ground, everyone having been killed by one sword.

The Wolf King pulled out the sword at his waist, ready to throw himself into a desperate fight.

"Isabella!" Zero cried.

"I know," the latter immediately launched her ability – forming a circle of light that was only visible to the magic eye. Within Isabella's field of vision, the lightless domains formed by the God's Stone of Retaliation appeared, each of them was trembling at a different frequency, like ripples on the surface of water. She controlled her field until it trembled at the same frequency, then connected it with the domain of the God's Stone of Retaliation. Both sides of ripples immediately canceled each other out, leading to the domain becoming level and smooth.

At that moment, Zero immediately turned into a beam of light, and drilled herself into the Wolf King's body.

The Wolf King began to twist before changing into the form of the Purified, after seeing this the Queen of Clear Water revealed an incredulous look, "How can this be possible? Why are you able to use your power around the God's Stones of Retaliation?"

"Because the God's Stones of Retaliation isn't what you believe…" Isabella said while still smoothing out the ripples of her opponent's domain, "But there isn't really a reason for you to know this, because… your end has come."

The moment her voice had fallen, Zero threw herself directly at Garcia.

Chapter 313

Chapter 313 The Battle of the Soul

She hadn't felt such a warm sunshine in a long time.

Garcia stood in the garden and took in a deep breath, inhaling the smell of rosemary coming along the breeze.

This was no longer the Kingdom of Eternal Winter; besides the forever frozen soil and the non-aromatic Winterflower, that country in the extreme north really had nothing to offer. Within that castle's backyard, lumps of meat and pig guts would always be hung out to dry in the open air, making it impossible to get rid of the awful smell. This place was also not the Port of Clear Water, with its familiar taste of salt and its moist air, where if she closed her eyes, she could hear waves breaking over the beach.

This is the palace of Graycastle, she thought.

But… its appearance was somewhat different from what she remembered.

Garcia sat down at the central flowered pond, gently caressing the slightly rough rocks – back in her childhood, while playing hide-and-seek, she had fallen to the ground and fiercely hit her head against the stones on the side of the flower pond. Since then her father had ordered for all the stones to be broken into small pebbles. As a result, it was then impossible to hurt oneself when stumbling, but it had also become impossible to hide oneself behind them.

At that time, she remembered, that besides herself, Gerald and Timothy had also been present. Seeing their younger sister fall down both of them had become very frightened. To coax her to stop her sobbing, one by one they'd made themselves fall and deliberately knocked their head against the stones at the side of the pond. Of course, afterward, they were ruthlessly beaten up by their father.

It was a period in her life that Garcia thought she would never recall again. It was like a secret hidden beneath a tree, deeply buried in the earth. But now that she's returned to this familiar place, she discovered that the scenery hasn't faded in the slightest. After digging it out of the earth, it still appeared just as vivid and lifelike as in the past.

It seemed as if everything has returned back to the time in her childhood.

"As it turns out, this is your world," an unknown voice sounded from behind her, "As a resting place, it's a pretty good choice."

Garcia turned around, and saw a woman dressed in white coming from the direction of the flowered pond. She had a pair of light red eyes and long, snow white hair, her facial features were so delicate that they seemed to have been carved, and her voice was ethereal and melodious, all in all she was like a god who had fallen into the mortal world.

The face of the Queen of Clear Water completely darkened as she stated, "You are the Church's witch."

"My name is Zero, the word 'witch' doesn't suit me," she laughed. "I'm called a 'Purified'. My blood, and that of those fallen, is entirely different."

"A Purified? That's just the term the Church uses for the toys they've raised," Garcia said coldly, "What kind of trick is this scenery? Does your ability allows you to create illusions?" She suddenly picked up a stone and squeezed it in her hand. "It's just an illusion! None of this will fool me!"

The Queen's cry traveled far, but the scenery remained entirely unaffected. When she opened her hand, she saw that the stone in her hand wasn't crushed, instead, her skin was cut by its hard edges and corners. The pain bursting from the wound seemed clear and real.

"It appears that you aren't completely unaware of witch abilities. That makes things much easier," Zero grasped the hem of her skirt and gave a slight bow, "Welcome to the World of Consciousness, I call this place the Battlefield of Souls. It is here where we will carry out our fight. The winner gets everything, the loser loses all… Just as God proclaims in the Holy Book."

Souls… battlefield.

Garcia stared blankly, trying to digest what she had just heard when she suddenly felt a sharp pain coming from her lung. She didn't know from where the pike had come, but somehow Zero had had directly thrust it into her chest. Her breathing immediately turned heavy, when she tried to open her mouth and shout, not even the smallest of sounds came out. Meanwhile, Zero turned the pike around and fiercely pulled it back, blood came spraying out of the wound, soon covering half of her body. Garcia sank to her knees, trembling as she tried to cover her wounds, but due to the enormous blood loss, her consciousness had already began to blur.

The next moment she found herself standing at her former place in perfect condition. The shadows standing a few meters away from her, as she had never left her place to begin with.

What happened? Garcia opened her mouth wide, taking in a deep breath, an illusion? Her hands were still fiercely pressing against her chest, and she could still feel an aching pain at the place the wound from a moment ago had been. Lowering her head, she saw a large spray of blood scattered around her feet.

"This is the basic rule. One's consciousness isn't immortal," Zero explained, spreading out her hands, "The pain of every death will feel real to you. It will slowly consume your mental and physical strength, and when this sense exceeds your limits it will be time for your eternal rest.

"Every time you die, your body will return to its original state. An average person can withstand at most three to four times, of course, I have also seen a lot of determined individuals who managed to go through seven, eight, or even more deaths," She explained gently. "Although I am looking forward to your performance, I can also understand if you give up. After all, the feeling of continuous death is an unbearable suffering. At this point, choosing to escape isn't a cowardly behavior, especially when the outcome has already been decided."

Finished speaking with the dropped pike in her hand and a great sword on her back she leaped forward and tried splitting Garcia apart.

The latter stared with wide open eyes, she is wearing a white gown, there is no way for her to hide such a huge weapon. All these weapons are… coming out of thin air? Suddenly the other's words reappeared in her mind –

"This is your world…"

"I call it the Battlefield of Souls."

"One's consciousness isn't immortal… everything is real to you."

The great sword chopped down, but instead of cutting the former Queen of Clear Water in two, it slammed against a huge iron shield. Confronted with the huge unexpected rebound, Zero lost her grip on the sword as it flew into the air, at the same time her body was also forced a few steps back. Garcia, because of the great strength she'd used to deflect the heavy blow, fell to the ground.

"The end is already destined?" She ground her teeth and sneered, "Previously you said this is 'my world', didn't you?" The moment the words fell, she popped up, and a crossbow suddenly appeared in her hand immediately releasing the arrow at Zero. Simultaneously a crucifix raised up behind her and firmly trapped her body.

In a flash the crossbow arrow drilled into the abdomen of the Purified, immediately causing a suffering expression to appear on her face. After gasping twice, Zero opened her mouth, "Th-that surprised me… cough cough, as an ordinary person… just accepting this is already very hard, n-not to mention using your own consciousness to retaliate. You just proved… why the Queen of Clear Water is able to cause Mayne so many headaches."

"Thank you very much for your praise," Garcia said while picking up the spear that had fallen on the ground. "If it weren't for you talking too much I would never have been able to comprehend the wonders of the World of Consciousness so quickly. Now, should I put some more holes in you?"

Zero laughed challengingly, "For now, I'll let you do as you like."

…

When Garcia stabbed her for the tenth time, the Purified finally died – she had deliberately avoided piercing any of the fatal points, slowly moving from the hands and feet toward the abdomen. At first the Purified had cried out miserably, but later on her voice had gradually started to break.

Next, that animal should be restored to her original state, right? However, this is the palace of Graycastle, it's my home ground. Since it is possible to change the environment and objects at will, I cannot lose.

Sure enough, the body of the Purified flashed in a white light. In the blink of an eye, all of her wounds had disappeared, and Zero once again opened her light red eyes.

Garcia lifted the pike, readying to send her to her death once again, but suddenly everything changed – the hands bound to the crucifix easily broke the rope, kicked against the pike, then instantly appeared at Garcia's side and delivered a strike with her raised hand. Before Garcia could respond, she had already lost sense of her body.

With a loud bang the headless body collapsed, yet the other's hands were still empty.

How can this be?

After her restoration, the Queen of Clear Water clutched her neck and took two steps back and felt somewhat uncertain… Just now, did she use her empty hands to cut off my neck? Seeing the broken hemp rope and the blood on her hands, it became apparent that the previous scene hadn't been an illusion.

"If you couldn't understand the nature of the World of Consciousness, how could I get a real fight?" Zero smiled and said, "You seem very puzzled about how I got my hands out of the thick rope, isn't that right? In fact, this isn't so difficult to understand, 'The winner gets everything, the loser loses all'… Among those people whom I've swallowed, there is a class of witches who are unusually powerful. Their might is boundless, their body is nimble, and they don't need to fear the effect of the God's Stone of Retaliation. You might

not know of them, but the Church has a particular term for them – Extraordinary.

She opened her hands, “It is impossible to beat me by only using common methods. If you want to survive, you will have to double your effort… Now, it’s my turn.”

TN: Many thanks to Zackarotto for creating the full list of characters.

Chapter 314

Chapter 314 Annihilation

It was Garcia's first-time experiencing the horror of an extraordinary.

The weapon in her hand was obviously only an ordinary one-handed sword, but the burst of pressure from her every move seemed to absorb parts of her soul. Each blow that came raining down on her shield was as heavy as a strike from a two-handed sword. Two or three blows later, Garcia could no longer even lift her arm and was hit on her chin by an upwards moving strike.

After her restoration, the Queen of Clear Water thoroughly abandoned defense, and before she could second guess herself, a ballista had already appeared in front of her body. She pulled the trigger, it wasn't an iron spear that she released, but several jars of black water. Reacting instinctively, Zero cut the jars apart, only to get showered in the black water. When the pieces of fire crystal hidden inside the jars came in contact with the air, they quickly began burning, and turned the whole area into a pillar of fire.

However, it was still not guaranteed that this would work. After all, Zero could still use her speed which far surpassed everything an ordinary person could ever achieve to move around the flower pond while the ballista couldn't even turn around. Thus, Garcia had no other alternative than to rely on raising the stone walls embedded with spears to restrict the Purified's movement. In addition, she turned the flower pots surrounding the pond into explosives by filling them with snow powder, and hid several pits into the ground, setting up a formation of deathly traps.

After killing the other side several times like this, Garcia discovered that her breathing gradually became heavy, beads of sweat started running down her forehead and waves of dizziness started to attack her mind, leaving her almost unable to keep standing upright.

“Well done,” the once again reborn Purified said, she wasn’t taking advantage of Garcia’s weakened state and was instead clapping her hands. “That you are able to do all this far surpasses my expectations. However, there is something I forgot to tell you. Even though you can use your consciousness to change the environment and venue in this world, it will consume a much larger amount of energy than creating completely new things… the amount is even similar to one’s restoration. You should already be feeling the weakness and exhaustion taking over your body, maybe after your next death, you will already fall into an eternal sleep.”

“Ah, that’s still better than getting one’s neck cut off,” Garcia panted heavily, “But you seem to forget the screams you made when being burned by the evil fire. I do not think you’ll be able to hold on any longer than me.”

“…” After a moment of silence, Zero said, “Ever since I’ve become a Purified, the Church has given me a lot of support to improve my abilities. From increasing my knowledge to teaching me fighting skill, to feeding me with Judges to improve my ability. Those Judges, even knowing that they would be sacrificing themselves, were still glad to enter the Battlefield of Souls. Here, in the World of Conscious, they honed my skills in life and death struggles, reassuring me that they accept their death before transmitting all of their insight and experiences to me.

Garcia did not interrupt her words. Even if the other was stalling for time, she also needed a break.

“I have swallowed up an extraordinary, and her strength was impressive – I nearly lost a Battle of Souls. But in the end, I relied on the Devil’s weapons to prevail over her and then got everything from her. Due to the different characteristics of magic, I can’t actually turn into an extraordinary or use the abilities of the witches I swallow. However, here in the World of Consciousness, these differences don’t matter to me. In the last two hundred years, I can’t even remember the number of people I have swallowed, but there have only ever been a few individuals who could threaten me. All their pain, happiness, sadness, and delights they’ve had in their life, became part of my own personal experience…” She paused, “Including their death.”

“What exactly do you want to tell me?” Garcia cautiously asked.

“The difference between you and me,” replied Zero calmly. “The assimilation of so many souls has made my will matchless. In case you want to know the number of death I can survive, I think I can bear at least hundreds of death by now.”

“In that case, I will have to help you to verify it.” She scoffed. But inwardly her heart sunk… When looking at her demeanor, it doesn’t seem that she is merely bluffing. From the time at the pier, where she cleanly and easily killed all their personal guards, it could be seen that this Purified possessed fighting skills that went beyond her age. If that’s the case, I need to use even more powerful weapons… quickly, what can I think of that can easily kill even an experienced super witch?

“The Battle of Souls isn’t a contest to decide who has the greater imagination,” Zero said, as if she already seen through her, “You cannot make yourself impervious to sword and spear without foundation, nor can you summon the weapons which destroyed heaven and earth from the legends of ancient times… Things you cannot understand you also cannot create, what we have seen and understood is the key to success.”

“Then I’ll just cover the whole garden with strong snow powder, even you will be unable to avoid it,” Garcia declared coldly, “Even if I die, at least I will drag you down with me!”

“Even if killing me doesn’t have the least bit of importance?” The Purified looked at her with eyes full of pity. “In that case, let me show you the real power of the Church.”

Suddenly a red light appeared behind Zero and condensed into a ferocious looking war chariot. Its shape had such extreme dimensions that it immediately crashed against the walls of the garden. To Garcia, the two sharp metal spears at the top of its head looked like the report given by one of the Wolf King’s personal guards – a kind of never before seen ballista which was attacking the walls. Both its range or power are at unprecedented levels. Don’t tell me that this monster in front of me, is what the guard has been speaking about.

Then she heard a loud hum.

The thick and solid spear directly broke through the layer upon layers of barriers Garcia had set up, not even bothering to spend any power to tear her in half as she was immediately sent flying backward. As she flew she could see her own organs and blood being left behind.

In unbroken succession, the war chariot continued to shoot those spears, thus soon after being restored, she again suffered the same death. She didn't even have enough time to create the snow powder and take the enemy down with her. Under the constant pain, her consciousness gradually became blurred, the earth began to shake, cracks appeared in the sky, lightning flashed, thunder rumbled, and the garden burst into a blazing fire.

"A strong will can only delay defeat, it cannot change the outcome. Close your eyes now," Zero said, "You've held it for long enough, rest in peace."

The moment her voice fell, the whole world broke apart.

…

"Is it over?" Isabella curled her lips, "Shouldn't it be done in an instant? You've already changed back into your original appearance, but for quite a while now you haven't said a word… I thought you really failed this time."

"I found some fascinating things in her memory," Zero opened her eyes, "This way of thinking… makes me sigh."

"Oh? There are still things which can make you sigh?" Isabella said carelessly, "That kind of strange alchemy powder should be something you have found out, right?"

"Well, the alchemist called it strong snow powder and the composition is quite simple. All the needed components are the most common things in the workshop."

"If it's like that then let us go back to the Holy City to report, we have already fulfilled all the orders given by His Holiness O'Brien," she spat out. "This battle will continue for at least three to four days, but now without a

leader or witch to guide them, those remnants won't count as a threat to the God's Punishment Army."

"Let's go," Zero nodded.

"Hold on…" Isabella shouted for her to stop.

"What happened?"

Was it an illusion? Obviously, there's no change in her appearance from before. But why do I feel that the look from her light red eyes has become somewhat different? Isabella carefully studied her counterpart but then shook her head, "No… it's nothing."

I guess I'm just overthinking things.

Chapter 315

Chapter 315 Celebration Feast

A grand celebration banquet was being held in the main hall of Border Town's castle.

In addition to the witches, the high-ranking staff in City Hall and the First Army all fully attended this feast. There were the nobles Barov Mons and Carter Lannis, and also Iron Axe and Kyle Sichi who were from a civilian background. Especially for the latter, Roland had to spend a lot of effort to persuade him to come out of the laboratory and attend this according to him "meaningless" banquet.

To include his subjects in this joyful event, besides giving a public speech he'd also ordered the kitchen staff to bake a large amount of white bread by using the leftover refined starch from manufacturing explosives, and distribute the bread to all of the town's people. As long as they were in possession of an identification card, they could get a limited amount of delicious food at the City Hall. Even while the First Army was on their way home, most of the town's inhabitants had already learned of their victory in battle.

Of course, they may not necessarily understand the purpose and significance of the expedition, but as long as there was free bread it counted as a day of celebrate for them.

This was also Roland's first time imitating those "lofty" banquets hosted in King's City.

There was no barbecue and no large pieces of stewed meat, all the food was cut into small pieces and splendidly arranged on spotlessly white plates. At the edge of the table stood several basins that contained all kinds of seasonings, so that they could flavor their food according to their own taste, similar to the buffets of later generations.

“Welcome back,” Roland said, carrying two glasses of wine to Anna, “The journey must have been hard for you.”

“You already said that at the pier,” Anna took one glass, “And my answer is still the same, ‘it wasn’t hard’.”

When their glasses faintly touched each other, her eyes were filled with a sweet smile. Seeing this, Roland had to struggle to resist the impulse to embrace her on the spot. Instead, he went on and exchanged a celebration cup with the other witches.

“What about me?” Lightning shouted.

“You’ll also get your share,” Roland said, calling over a waiter from whom he then took a glass of cider for her, “Work hard.”

“I demand to drink white!” The little girl looked at him with big eyes.

“Uh huh…” After thinking about it, Roland finally decided to fulfill her wish. After all, this kid’s curiosity had always been quite high, so if he refused her all the time, maybe she would learn from Nightingale and sneak into the kitchen, but she’d be stealing wine instead, “Alright, but only one drink.”

“Yeah!”

When Roland handed her a weak white wine mixed with ice and grape juice, she suddenly approached and gave him a kiss on his cheek.

“Keke… Is this the custom from the Fjords?”

“Sure,” Lightning nodded seriously, “That’s what my father told me!”

Because it wasn’t the first time they saw it, the other witches of the Witch Alliance didn’t feel that it was too strange. However, Sylvie’s eyes became round from shock before throwing an accusatory glance at Roland, and saw he was moving along while wearing an awkward expression – does there really exist such a custom of kissing the head when celebrating heroic deed in the Fjords?

Then it was time to exchange a toast with the ministers.

When it came to the chief alchemist's turn, the man leaned over and whispered, "Your Highness, since you gave me the 'Intermediate Chemistry' I have already read it twice, but, there are still a lot of things that I can't understand.

"If you are talking about that sub-atomic constitution of matter, that part involves a lot of physical knowledge, so you have to read another book to understand it." Roland pointed out, "So, I suggest that you first read the 'Elementary Physics' before going through the remnants of the Intermediate Chemistry again. This way, many of your doubts should be answered."

"That's what I was going to do, but…" he hesitated for a moment before continuing, "Your Royal Highness, why are the colors used on the cover of each ancient book different? Does it have any special meaning to it?"

"That is…" Roland pondered for a moment, "The color represents the requirements and time needed to comprehend it."

"It was like this?" Kyle mused, "From green to purple. So, it seems that the deeper the color, the more profound is the knowledge recorded within. In that way, 'Advanced Chemistry' must surely be black?"

"No, it is orange."

"Ah," Kyle got startled, "Why?"

Roland smiled, "Who knows?"

…

Halfway through the banquet, Roland stepped out of the hall and went to the castle terrace. Standing in the gently blowing evening breeze, he couldn't help but feel a slight chill. Half of autumn has already passed he realized, so in other words, it wouldn't be long before the lengthy winter would cover the whole Western Territory with snow and bring about the Months of Demons.

But the situation during this year and the previous year had become as different as black and white. The trade with Margaret's Chamber of Commerce had brought in a lot of floating amount of money, and in exchange for food and materials many of these gold royals were paid to the people in the form of a salary. According to statistics from the convenience market, the recent sales of products has shown a lot of growth, from which some of the goods would significantly improve the people's quality of life. Sales for products such as steak and eggs was growing especially quickly.

There was no doubt that this was a sign of the gradual improvement in the living standards for the people. In particular, the indigenous population had all received new free housing, while their salary, compared to before, had also increased a lot. Nowadays, they had even started to buy food which they usually could only enjoy during festivals. The newly introduced population was still at the stage where they were busy saving money in order to purchase a house, but when they manage to settle down the market was bound to usher for a new peak in sales.

What exactly do people need? Sometimes, eating and drinking one's fill was already enough to be grateful to their Lord and follow him until their death.

During this era, most civilians were easy to please.

"Your Highness, beware of catching a cold," Nightingale said, and appeared behind him with a thin coat in hand. She threw the cloth to Roland, took out a piece of dried fish from a bag and came to stand beside him, "What's going on here?"

"Nothing," Roland said, showing her a smile while he put on the coat, "I just suddenly had the urge to see my territory."

"It seems the town is still very busy," Nightingale said and pointed to the still brightly lit town square, "It's already night time and there are still so many people who haven't gone home."

"That's because today was the first time they were showing the new drama, 'Dawn'," Roland explained happily, "Furthermore, it was also the first show after the troupe's several months of departure from Border Town. So, the

villagers have probably been full of anticipation to see Miss May and Misses Irene again."

But that being said, Miss May would soon become Lady May Lannis. He actually had never expected that his own Chief Knight would act so decisively to hold the hands of the Star of the West. When the other side had informed him with a sincere face about his intention, he was first stupefied for a while before he was finally to respond. The wedding of the Chief Knight needed the approval of his Lord, but Roland naturally had no objection to this kind of happy event. In the end, the wedding for the two was scheduled for after the end of the Months of Demons, more precisely, for the day when Border Town officially became a city.

"It was a dead place when I first snuck into this town," Nightingale exclaimed, "But now, even while standing in the castle, it seems I still feel the joyful atmosphere surrounding us."

"Life will improve, day by day," Roland looked up, looking at the cloudless night sky as he took in a deep breath. There were still many things left to be done such as expanding the scope of education, setting up a public health care, increasing the amount of cultural constructions, encouraging birth rate and so forth. All these things would transform the Western Territory into a stable force and lay out the foundation for the unification of Greycastle.

Nightingale tilted her head and looked at him with keen eyes as she asked, "So what about us?"

"Of course, the same is also true for you," Roland said as he patted her head, "I promise."

Chapter 316

Chapter 316 Re-exploration of the Stone Tower

When Lightning saw His Highness leave she pulled Maggie to the corner of the hall.

“Goo?”

Maggie’s hair was almost hanging to the floor, giving her the appearance of a floating ghost whenever she moved. Pushing aside the white hair covering her cheeks, Maggie’s high puffed up cheeks and the half swallowed crisp pork chop dangling in her small mouth became visible.

“I found a fascinating place,” Lightning whispered. “It’s hidden inside the Concealing Forest, I intend to go and explore it tomorrow. Would you like to come with me on an adventure?”

“Guru,” Maggie swallowed the food in her mouth and nodded again and again, “I want, I want. What should we prepare?”

“To go on an adventure, you need three items… Wrong, three of the most commonly used things,” Lighting discovered that from time to time she has started to use His Highness’ strange vocabulary. “You need a flint, dry food, and a dagger. The place isn’t far from here. So it will be fine if you just take along enough food for a day. Don’t fill your whole pocket with it like you did last time.”

“Okay goo,” Maggie patted her chest, ready to leave, but Lightning stopped her once again.

“Remember, that this adventure is our secret. Don’t tell anyone else about it,” the little girl said, “We’ll start early tomorrow morning.”

Looking at Maggie’s back, who couldn’t wait to get back to the table full of food, she curled her lips and began to think about their plan for tomorrow.

Despite the success of the bombing mission and meeting His Highness' expectation, she found that her flying has become much less flexible than before, as if something was holding her back. Whenever Lightning raised her speed, she would always have the feeling that a Devil was chasing her.

This obstruction was brought by fear, she realized. Furthermore, the source of her fear was the exploration of the Stone Tower, when she saw the horrible figure in the basement doorway, she had lost her cool and calm. At that time, her only thought had been to flee from that place as quickly as she could. Ever since then she had started to question her identity as an explorer.

"Fear is not terrible, terrible is the unknown. If you want to overcome it, you must approach it first."

Within her heart, Lightning silently repeated her father's teaching again and again. Tomorrow she might encounter real danger, but an explorer should not be afraid of risk, nor should they shrink back. If she couldn't get over it, she was scared that she would never be able to fly freely again.

This was also the reason why Lightning decided to keep the adventure hidden from His Royal Highness and act without authorization. According to His Royal Highness' plan, the exploration of the Stone Tower was scheduled for after the Months of Demons and would be a cooperation between the First Army and the witches. However, she was worried that by that time, even if they visited the Stone Tower once again, it would be hard for her to see it as somehow fulfilling the idea of "conquering the fear" – only daring to approach the danger zone by relying on the strength of everyone, just couldn't be called an adventure.

Afterward, His Highness may scold her, even going so far as confiscating her ice cream, and her sisters from the Witch Alliance would surely also be worried, but she was still determined to go through with it.

As the daughter of the Fjord's greatest explorer Thunder, Lightning just couldn't accept her cowardly self.

But it didn't mean that her decision was a reckless act. Compared with her unprepared attempt a few months ago, she now had a revolver -a gift from

His Highness-, possessed a greater understanding of the Devils, and lastly, she was being accompanied by Maggie.

Especially the last point… If they really did encounter a group of Devils in the Stone Tower and even if Maggie couldn't change into her demonic beast's appearance to drive them away, they would at least still be able to flee on their own.

An explorer doesn't need a brigade of troops to increase their courage, she thought, but they can still have a few trusted teammates.

After dinner, Lightning gathered some pieces of honeyed meat and put it into a cloth bag, she then added torches, weapons, and water bags.

The successful completion of the bombing mission gave her some confidence, together with His Highness's encouragement and her slightly cheeky reputation let her feel doubly courageous. And just like the blacksmith's saying went, 'it's best to strike while the iron is hot', tomorrow would be the best time for them to depart.

At first light, Lightning flew to the top of the castle, where Maggie was already sitting on the wall and waiting for her.

"Let me check your package."

"I got everything you told me, goo," she changed back to her original form, opened her backpack and held it in front so that the little girl could confirm its content. This time she had reduced the amount of food to half, but at least had also added a dagger and a flint.

"Alright, this can be counted as qualified… let's set off," Lightning said rising into the air, flying together with the pigeon toward the Concealing Forest.

…

In her mind, Lightning had already repeated the journey many times, reaching a point where she could find her way there even with her eyes closed. The

weather was a bit overcast today, but it was still much better than the dark clouds that had been there last time. As the color of earth slowly fell away behind them, the closer they came to the Stone Tower, the greater became Lightning's nervousness.

"Did you say you found an interesting place last night, was it a new eagle nest?" Maggie asked after a while.

"No, it's much more interesting than that," Lightning shook her head. "The target we want to explore is an ancient relict, a stone tower that has been left behind for more than four hundred years. Since the basement hasn't collapsed yet, we might be able to find some ancient books if we are lucky."

"Ancient books?" Maggie shook her wings, "That doesn't sound as if it's more exciting than digging for eagle eggs, goo."

"An eagle nest has at most two to three eggs, something which you finish up in a flash," the little girl said. "But, if you actually can find such a book and bring it back to His Royal Highness, he will surely reward you with a basket full of eggs. Whether you cook or steam them, you'll be able to eat three eggs every day for a long time to come."

"Really?" Maggie was full of spirit immediately, "Then let's hurry up and look for ancient books! Googoo!"

Around noon, the two successfully arrived at their destination.

The remaining half of the stone tower was still hidden within the woods covered in moss and vines. Everything around them looked the same as a few months ago, it didn't seem as if anything had changed. Yet, Lightning still lowered her height and flew a few rounds around the tower to confirm their safety before landing gently.

"Have we arrived, goo?" the pigeon shouted from above her head.

"Hush–" Lightning signaled her to be silent, within the silence of the forest their voices seem particularly noisy, "Speak softly. There could be Devils nearby."

“The Devil?” Maggie’s tail immediately erected.

“You wait for me at the top,” Lightning said with a lowered voice, pointing to the upper part of the broken tower. “I will go and take a look at the situation first.”

When she walked over the gradually withered grass, she could hear a slight rustling sound coming from her foot. Reaching the entrance of the tower, she saw that it hadn’t been covered by plants and that the small cluster of vines cut off by her dagger last time was still there. Holding her breath, she moved forward along the former road and entered the tower. Taking one step after another, she slowly neared the center of the tower with its passage to the basement. At the time she saw the stair leading into the darkness in front of her, she even heard her heart loudly pounding.

Fear comes from the unknown, to overcome the fear, you have to approach the unknown… the little girl constantly encouraged herself, then lit a torch and climbed the stairs leading down.

Reaching the corner of the channel, she quietly shot out a probing glance, only fragments were left from the collapsed wooden door. The basement entrance also wasn’t blocked by the Devil, the only thing left behind at the door was a thick darkness, like an open mouth waiting to swallow the people who enter.

At this moment, she suddenly heard traces of a voice floating over from the darkness, only faintly discernible but still feeling very familiar –

Immediately all of her hairs were fully erected, her body was grasped by shivers and the almost uncontrollable urge to turn around and flee came up once again! She grit her teeth and struggled to suppress the boiling fear at the bottom of her heart. Then, covering her mouth, she bent an ear and listened attentively one more time.

This time the call was much clearer, the tone exactly the same as last time.

“Help me…”

Chapter 317

Chapter 317 “Ice Coffin”

Lightning felt goosebumps roll over her body.

She suddenly remembered all the stories that were spread among explorers – Demons crawling from the abyss, the vengeful ghosts still bearing a grudge at the end of their life, or the wandering undead. These were the nightmares of every explorer, even if they were already dead they were still able to take someone’s life. They were exceptionally good at using illusions and deception, so could it be that one of these monsters were hidden within this ruin?

Although Thunder had said that these stories were just some nonsense made up by third-rate explorers, but at this moment she still felt shaken to her core. Otherwise, who would ever be able to keep shouting under the Devil’s siege, even holding the same tone and interval after several months have passed?

She was now facing a dilemma – if they were indeed one of these evil things from folklore, they would have killed all Devils, but then it would become difficult for her to escape after having trespassed into their domain. But if the other party was still able to hold on until now, shouldn’t those Devils still be inside then, what should we do?

After hesitating for a moment, in the end, she decided to fly back to Maggie to discuss the next step with her.

After hearing a short narration about the current situation, Maggie raised her head and said, “We could extinguish the torch and stealthily find our way in goo, this way those Devils won’t be able to see us.”

“Uh, but then we won’t be able to see them either.”

“I can turn into an owl,” said the pigeon rubbing her face, “The dark of night isn’t a big problem for me, goo.”

Lightning's eyes lit up, "That's a good idea, but… those legendary evil creatures, they live in the dark all their lives. Doesn't that mean they might have a way to find their prey? Otherwise, they should have died from starvation long ago, right?

"Didn't you say that they were all made up stories meant to frighten people?"

"It wasn't me who said that, it was my father." The little girl corrected.

"That's all the same. Anyway, living in Greycastle I have never heard of those undead monsters, if they were indeed so horrible, they shouldn't only remain in a little place like the Fjords, right?" Rays of light suddenly broke out of Maggie, and the pigeon suddenly began to swell, turning into a gray-brown owl, her eyes full of eagerness, "I thought you would be interested in these legends."

That's right, if I want to qualify as an explorer, I should never let go of an opportunity to verify a legend. Not to mention that I still have to defeat my heart demons, if I flee now, I will waste all of my previous efforts. After hesitating for a moment, Lightning decided to go along with Maggie's suggestion.

But wait… the reason why I want to explore the ruins at all cost is so that I can overcome my fear, but why is Maggie so interested in exploring them? Could it be…

"It can't be that you're so impatient because of the basket of eggs, right?"

Hearing the question, the owl blinked her two big eyes before turning her head away.

…

Once again standing in front of the entrance to the basement, Lightning took a deep breath, tightly gripped her revolver as she silently entered into the deep darkness.

She felt much calmer compared to before, that was probably because Maggie was squatting on her shoulder.

The ground under her feet felt very wet, even so far that they could encounter some puddle of water from time to time. This area was the terrain's lowest point, thus the rain falling over the tower would slowly come to gather here. Although the basement was equipped with a drainage system in general, after facing wind and rain for hundreds of years, these hidden ditches were most probably already clogged up since an earlier time.

Maggie patted her head with her wings, signaling that there were stairs leading downward in front of them.

Lightning slowed her pace, and carefully, little by little she searched her way to the edge of the stairwell. Then, after having cautiously gone all the way down the stair and turned a corner, she suddenly saw a light appear ahead of them.

A soft yellow light coming from the end of the stairs penetrating all the way through the dark, which, when falling onto the ground, would be reflected in shaking waves.

She carefully studied this for a moment only to discover that the slight shaking on the surface was actually a piece of sewage. By looking at the lower half of the door which was buried in the water, it could be seen that the water level in the basement was about knee deep.

She slowly walked to the point between the staircase and the water, lifted both her feet from the ground, then slowly floated over to the door and throwing a probing glance to the inside.

And saw that the area behind the door was spacious and empty – the stone tower's basement was unbelievable huge, offering far more space than the area it had covered on the ground. She couldn't detect any burning torch which created the yellow light. Instead it seemed that the light came directly from the stones that were embedded in the walls. It roughly outlined the contours of the basement, while at the same time allowing Lightning to see everything within the room.

A stone platform was erected in the middle of the chamber with several figures standing on top of it. According to their burly size and the carapace on their back, it seemed that they were all Devils. Luckily, the enemy hadn't yet noticed any movement coming from the door, Instead each of them were holding a spear in one hand and a large shield in the other, surrounding a blue stone erected on top of the platform.

At this moment, the cry for help was becoming clearer and clearer, as if someone was shouting directly into her ear.

"Save me, save me…"

Lightning had to swallow. What should I do next?

"We…"

"Go and save her, goo," Maggie whispered into her ear.

"Eh?" The little girl got startled," But there are several Devils… We cannot win against them!" She felt her hand that was firmly gripping the revolver begin to sweat, "It wouldn't be a problem if it was Sister Nightingale instead of me, but I alone… cannot do it."

"Are they the demons you spoke off?" Maggie inquired, "It seems as if they are already dead, goo."

"What? Dead?"

The moment her voice fell Maggie had already thrown herself into the air flying toward the stage, giving Lightning quite the scare, stunning for a moment. Otherwise, she would never have forgotten to pull her friend back. But when she finally came back to her senses Maggie had already thrown herself against one of those Devils. With no other option left, Lightning clenched her teeth and raised her gun; trying to remember all the important points that Nightingale had taught her.

But what she then saw, was completely unlike what she had expected, when the owl pecked a Devil twice, it crumbled down, just like a piece of broken

stones after experiencing countless years of wind and frost, turning into a pile of floating ashes.

What's going on? Lightning stepped beside Maggie and looked at the other three Devils in amazement.

Looking at them under the weak yellow light, she discovered that their bodies were covered with tiny cracks, and that spiders had spun nets between their legs, looking through their hideous helmets, she could see that their eyes and skin had turned pale, showing no traces of vitality. It was like this, she thought, within the dark light, an owl's eyes are indeed several times better than mine, which allowed Maggie to be able to speak so confidently.

But before she could relax, Lightning's gaze was already completely attracted by something else.

On the high platform surrounded by the Devils stood a huge cube. What had looked like a stone column from a distance actually turned out to be transparent crystal when seen from up close. Wrapped within the crystal cube was a woman who wore a gorgeous robe, her eyes were closed, her hands stretched open, and her hair spread out behind her as if it was still fluttering in the wind.

"Is she a witch, goo?" Maggie asked as she flew to the top of the crystal then fiercely pecked against the surface. However, this time it didn't crumble into countless pieces, but instead sent out a sharp and clear hitting sound, "Very hard, goo!"

"I do not know," Lightning murmured as she laid her hand against the crystal. A cold chill penetrated her skin – the crystal's surface was covered with thick dust, which made it obvious that the woman had been in this "sarcophagus" for a very long time. Yet her expression was still so lifelike, her eyebrows were raised into a frown, looking a bit confused, but even more than that, they also seemed a bit anxious and worried.

"Save me…"

The sound could be heard once again, it was coming from behind the crystal.

Chapter 318

Chapter 318 Unknown

Roland scratched over the surface with the brush, writing a long paragraph on paper.

Before he came to this world, he had only drawn mechanical blueprints using the computer. At that time he had already thought that there would only be small chances where he would ever need to write characters using a pen, never did he expect to have to use this kind of ancient form of recording ever again.

Two papers filled with text laid next to his hand, containing the next plans for what he wanted to implement.

One plan was the large-scale production of sulfuric acid and the new equipment that was needed, made by the hands of Anna and Soraya. Instead of using lead for the reaction vessel, they would use the more robust and reliable iron together with an anti-corrosion coating. Furthermore, the vessels would be made three times larger than the previous trial version's.

Considering that at the present stage there was fundamentally no way to collect or purify the produced industrial waste gas (mainly used from combustion of sulfur and leakage of nitrogen oxides), Roland decided to place it at the southern end of the industrial park – far enough away from the residential area and the Redwater River. Furthermore, he planned to use stones so as to better isolate the building and also erect a chimney to raise the altitude at which the emissions would be released.

Increasing the output of sulfuric acid was of great help to enlarge the scale of concentrated nitric acid, so putting this equipment into production would be the most important task at present. The content of the document were instructions to Kyle Sichi to select a group of disciples who will be specializing in the production of sulfuric acid. In addition, Barov also

needed to recruit some reliable local residents who could work as auxiliary handyman, raising the number of staff required for the chemical plant to around 100 people.

The second document was the formation of a public health care system.

To be honest, Roland wasn't familiar with this subject. Talking about it, he didn't even understand a single thing about modern medicine. However, this didn't prevent him from using his common sense to develop a plan which meets all of their current needs.

First of all, the biggest task of this department would be to give publicity to modern scientific discoveries. Things such as boiling the water before drinking it, the fact that meat has to be fully cooked before eating, the cause of illnesses and how they manage to spread, the difference between parasites and microbes, and so forth… Thanks to his growing prestige it wouldn't be difficult for him to get people to do what he wants, but if he wanted them to understand why they should do something, he would need someone to do the publication and education for him. It would be useless if they only spoke once about these things. Instead, it had to be repeated seven or eight times, maybe even dozens of times, like those slogans that were hanging at the edge of the field. If they continually spoke about it, their view would always become accepted in the end.

The second part was encouraging the birthrate – since the City Hall only had a limited number of staff, Roland did not want to set up a separate family planning department. Thus he temporarily also placed this under the public health care's responsibility. The population was always the most scarce resource in this era, and the best way to confront this was by leading people to give birth to more lives. Nana's ability completely erased the risk of giving birth and many of the other thorny problems. And with her help, the post-natal survival rate would almost be around one hundred percent. In order to avoid the abandonment of baby girls, as well as restricting any changes of something like that happening in future, Roland developed a full subsidy and punishment policy. For example, the subsidy for baby girls was slightly higher than for baby boys, subsidies would be given in installments, and the abandonment of babies would be punished with fines or imprisonment, and so on.

The last point was the regulation of payment. Except for fertility treatment, the hospital would charge a fee in accordance with the amount of magic that Nana needed to use. This way it would reduce the little girl's burden as well as lay the foundation for the future hospital system. Roland had also already found the first person he wanted in charge of this department, Viscount Tigu Pine, Nana's father.

The third document, was currently in the state of being written, and was the most complex and far-reaching plan – it was the plan to establish Border Town as a city.

It was related to the problems created by the expansion of Border Town and the later merger with Longsong Stronghold. When that time came about, there would definitely be a demand for new laws concerning the governance of these two places, and both the judicial system and the public security system would have to be implemented. However, if he wanted to make these points watertight, merely relying on his own knowledge wouldn't be enough, thus Roland intended to draft a list first, and later discuss all the details with City Hall Premier Minister Barov.

After finishing the introductory part, Roland felt some pain in his wrist from all the writing so he went to the window to take a break.

Today's weather was very gloomy, and from morning to afternoon he had yet to see the sun. The sky was consistently being covered with dark clouds, and gave the impression that torrential rains would soon be coming. The chilly autumn wind swept over the castle backyard and Roland heard the olive leaves rustling.

At this moment, a black spot appeared on the horizon, flying in the direction of the castle.

"It's Lightning," Nightingale's voice came from behind him.

"She probably went to the Concealing Forest to pick some mushrooms again," Roland said with a smile. Usually, when they weren't on investigation duty, the goal of Lightning and Maggie's practice was left up to themselves. Therefore, it was entirely reasonable for them to not come back

to the castle to eat lunch. According to the two, they would often be somewhere in the woods looking for some eggs and honeycombs, or catching some strange animals to barbecue and eat. It was likely that all explorers would ultimately transform into Bear Grylls.

Although the bird kissing mushrooms mainly grew on trees, he could not help but always think of the story called: 'The mushroom plucking girl'.

"Your Highness, your… smile is a little strange."

"Keke, I had to think of a little short story, do you want to hear it?"

"Ok?"

Roland cleared his throat, "Once upon a time, there was a little girl, she liked to gather mushrooms… Wait." The shadow was slowly growing, but contrary to what they expected it didn't fly over the castle, but instead lowered her altitude and went straight to the window of their office. Feeling shocked, Roland opened the window only seconds before Lightning directly flew into the room without stopping.

"Y-Your Highness!" Hardly had she landed when she already started to shout in excitement, "I found a witch!"

"A witch?" Roland asked full of curiously, "Where?"

"In the Stone Tower hidden within the Concealing Forest," Lightning pointed to Maggie, who flew into the office just at that moment, "She can testify!"

"Googoo!" Maggie agreed.

"Stone Tower?" He frowned, "Carefully tell me what happened, from the beginning to the end."

After listening to Lightning's narration, Roland could not help but suck in a mouth of cold lump. This fellow is too bold, actually only taking a pigeon along she dares to explore a ruin which contained Devils. But what's even more frightening, is that there is still a witch sealed inside these ruins. Of

course, there is also the possibility that she could be an ordinary person sealed away by a witch… In any case, this is incredible news.

“What was the cry of help?”

“It is coming from this thing. I found it on a table behind her,” Lightning pulled a palm-sized square box from her pocket, at first glance it looked just like a small make-up mirror. However, when she opened the lid, Roland saw a red gem embedded inside of it, and when Lightning pulled a trigger next to it, the anxious sounding voice of a female suddenly appeared in everyone’s ears.

“Save me…”

Hearing the voice, Roland’s body began to shudder, the sound seemed to flicker, sometimes appearing near sometimes coming from far off. It was indeed somewhat horrifying, if he imagined himself hearing this distressed voice after entering a dark underground chamber, he would certainly turn around and flee without any hesitation.

“The gem contains magic,” Nightingale appeared behind them and said in astonishment, “Within it, I can see a weak magic whirlpool, just like inside a witch’s body.”

Well, it seems to be a magic machine which continuously repeats previously spoken words. With this, the probability that the other person is a witch has increased. “Did you find any other stones inside the basement of the Stone Tower?”

“I didn’t take a closer look, also, many parts of the room were flooded,” Lightning shook her head. “At that time, I only thought about coming back and telling you about this news as soon as possible.”

“Never do something like this again, especially if you want to go to a dangerous place, you should first ask for permission,” Roland patted her head, then looked over at Nightingale, “Call Iron Axe and all of the members of the Witch Alliance over to the office. The exploration of the relics will be scheduled earlier than planned.”

Chapter 319

Chapter 319 Autumn Snow

After the others arrived, Roland informed them about Lightning's discoveries from beginning to end. "A transparent crystal coffin in the basement of an ancient ruin, without any sign of corrosion even though the environment is damp and moist, a magic stone which regularly released a call for help, and Devils broke into countless pieces upon contact… What do you all think about this?"

"You mean she could be a witch?" Anna pondered, "If she is still alive, we can probably learn more about what happened four hundred years ago."

"It is also possible that she isn't a witch, or even from that era," Scroll said after a moment of hesitation, "Furthermore…"

"Furthermore, she might not necessarily be on our side," Leaves added.

This sentence left Roland slightly shocked. Indeed, if these remains had been left by the Church, it is more than likely that the other side could be a member of the Church. Also, according to Lightning's description, she was wearing a gorgeous gown, which could mean that she was a high-ranking member. In the case that she was an ordinary person everything would be alright, but if she really is a witch, then dealing with her would be quite tricky.

Looking at the fights Ashes and Nightingale had been in, it could be seen that it was impossible to predict the kind of attack a witch could perform beforehand. Furthermore, there was no clear dividing line to rank witches by strength. The extraordinaries might be unable to contend against witches with unique abilities even when they were wearing the God's Stone of Retaliation, and if combat witches were surprise attacked by support witches the situation would be equally worrying.

No one can guarantee that her ability won't pose a threat to the Witch Alliance if she held any malicious intent towards us… unless, we wake her

within the influence of a God's Stone of Relation.

"You're all crazy, how can you even think that she won't be on our side?" Lily, grasping her forehead, could no longer sit still and decided to interrupt, "She should be from more than four hundred years ago, how could she still be alive today? It goes without saying that witches all die young, even if they possess the strong body of an extraordinary witch, they might never exceed a hundred years of age. All of you are thinking too much. Most likely it's just like I said, the moment we free her, the person inside will be just like the Devils and turn into dust."

"The reason why most witches die young is because of the so-called Demonic bite," Roland corrected, "A witch's physical fitness is generally much greater than the average person. Thus their actual lifespan should also be longer."

"The average person's lifespan is forty to fifty years, ah," Lily grunted, "Do you think everyone can live as long as a turtle can?"

The reason why the average lifespan is merely forty to fifty years is because of an inadequate food supply and the low level of medical care; as long as the standard of daily living is increased, it should quickly increase by another twenty years. However, what she said is by no means utterly unjustified, Roland conceded, even if I add those twenty years, there still remains a gap to reach four hundred years… Even if we were turtles, I'm afraid we could never live for that long.

"But she is still alive, really," Lightning cried aloud, "If you could've seen her, you'd immediately understand why I say so. Compared with the dead Devils she looks entirely different, her skin is smooth, and her lips are full of color. Tell them Maggie!"

"Goo! What Lightning said is true!"

"Alright, don't fight," Wendy stood up and interrupted. "No matter if she is still alive or already dead, it's worth a try."

"Are you sure?" Scroll asked unsure while knitting her brows.

“If she really is one of those Church’s witches, as long as we hang a God’s Stone of Relation around her before she wakes up it should be all right. Moreover, we also have Anna and Nightingale, so I believe she won’t be able to cause much of a problem.” Wendy calmly said. “The key point is, it is possible that she might know about the incident that occurred more than four hundred years ago. The possibility that she can bring light into the darkness is worth the risk of rescuing her.”

Indeed, gathering more information about the Devils is very critical for the survival of Border Town. Moreover, any news the Church desired to hide so much will surely be extremely unfavorable for them. Thus, if we can take hold of this knowledge ahead of time, there’s a chance that it might help us take the initiative in the future battle.

Soon after, Anna and Nightingale also agreed to Wendy’s view, so even though she still thought that it was wrong, Scroll no longer opposed them and the Witch Alliance came to a consensus.

“The First Army?” Roland looked toward Iron Axe.

“At most, you can send up to fifty people,” the latter started to talk, “Your Highness, you already sent out several squads to assist City Hall to recruit refugees from the other regions, by now there are only around 500 left in Border Town. Even though Timothy has encountered Heaven’s wrath, there’s still a chance he might become desperate and launch a large-scale assault on the Western Territory. Thus, the First Army needs to have enough soldiers to guard against a possible attack from King’s City.”

“I understand,” Roland said while nodding. A size of fifty people is a little small, if they happen to have to face a long-range attack from the Devils who can throw their spears from out of view, the damage caused could be quite serious. If I want to make up for this, in addition to Lightning’s and Maggie’s air surveillance, Sylvie’s magic eye ability will also be essential. The ideal force to send out would be a ground force, supported by a team of witches stationed in a hot-air balloon. The witches will be responsible for observation and close combat battles, while the First Army will use their flintlocks to suppress the enemy over a long distance.

But then, the witches from Sleeping Island will also learn about the existence of the Deep Sleeper in the ruin. Roland thought through all the possibilities again and again, but in the end, he still decided to bring Sylvie along. After all, during this rescue mission, their safety would still be the most important consideration.

Just when he planned to arrange the rescue plan, Mystery Moon exhaled loudly before exclaiming, “Heavens… What is happening?”

Hearing her cry, everyone followed her gaze and looked out of the window, only to freeze up immediately.

Roland not daring to believe what he saw opened the window, then was finally forced to accept what he saw, beyond any of their expectations white flakes had begun to fall from the gloomy sky. They were hiding the sky and covering the earth, but completely lacked any sound. He stretched his hand out, catching a handful of white drops, which made an ice-cold sensation spread through his palm.

It’s snow.

This is not normal… According to his knowledge, it would only snow in the Western Territory during winter, but now, it wasn’t winter yet!

“It is normal for it to snows during the last month of autumn?: He looked at Iron Axe, but the latter wore a serious expression and said, “I have been in Border Town for seven or eight years, and until now I have never experienced something like this.”

Once the snow began to descend from the heaven, it meant that the Months of Demons had arrived, and the sun would be buried behind a wall of clouds until its next brilliant bloom. During this time, the entire Western Territory would face the threat of demonic beasts. Not to mention the First Army, even when using a hot air balloon, the witches would still be in danger – at this time, the Concealing Forest was full of savage demonic beasts. So leaving the protection of the wall was an incredibly risky matter.

For now, he was forced to call a stop to the rescue mission and wait for the sky to clear up.

At the bottom of his heart, he felt that the early snow was likely an accident and would soon end. After all, the temperature was still at the average level of autumn and it also hadn't dropped by much.

However, three days later, the town was wrapped in silver, the distant mountains and woods were covered by a layer of white gauze. A beautiful scenery like this was definitely a rare view in his past, but Roland wasn't in the mood to appreciate the landscape.

Although the snowfall had weakened a lot, there were still some snowflakes falling from the sky. The First Army had also entered a state of full alertness, and has established regular patrols along the new wall. Furthermore, they had also erected a temporary camp at the foot of the new city wall, so that the soldiers would be able to quickly enter into battle. The temperature had changed almost overnight, forcing Roland to change his clothes from his unlined garment to a knitted cotton coat.

On the fourth day, hearing the news from the front made Roland's heart drop.

The western city wall had suffered an attack from demonic beasts.

The Months of Demons had arrived more than one month ahead of time.

Chapter 320

Chapter 320 “Sleeping Spell”

Fjords, Sleeping Island.

“I never expected that the first guest of the ‘Sleeping Spell’ would actually be you,” Tilly smiled and said as she handed over a cup of boiling hot fish soup, “It was only due to your help that we could explore the Shadow Islands.”

“You are too polite,” Thunder answered as he received the fish soup, “Regarding the Mysterious Sea, even if I don’t receive any more commissions from you I would still like to go there a few more times for myself. To be honest, without your witches’ support, exploring the sea east of the Shadow Island would definitely be very dangerous for an explorer.” He sipped his fish soup, then let out a sigh, “Ah… it’s boiled black-tailed fish soup, it’s really delicious.”

In the Fjords, black tea and barley wine from black tea were considered to be unpopular, she was used to the custom of eating a bowl of ice cold frozen fish during midsummer, while here they drank a bowl of boiling hot fish soup when it got cold. They used a different method to cook the fish so the taste was not at all the same, this was something Tilly had gradually come to understand after arriving at Sleeping Island.

“Therefore, you were impatient to come and visit the Sleeping Spell?”

“The right thing to say would be that I can’t wait to go on the next expedition,” Thunder straightforwardly stated. “The scene I saw last time when I looked through the observation mirror left me stunned – what is there on the land and for what reason is there a stone gate embedded inside that overhanging cliff? I wish I could fly there and go take a look.”

“Is that it…” Tilly also poured a cup of fish soup for herself, “You should already be aware that I’m planning to personally go to Border Town. One

reason is to personally speak with the feudal lord and Witch Alliance, another reason is so that I can increase my knowledge by experiencing the Months of Demons in Border Town. You… don't you want to come with us and take a look?"

For a moment Thunder was silent, but then he said with a broad grin, "Not yet. She should be having quite a good time over there. The way it is right now is also good… After all, the thing with exploring is, an accident can always happen one day. I already lost her mother, I really don't want to also lose her. When that time comes, I ask you…"

"I will," Tilly nodded, "After all, she is also one of our members." Speaking until here she stopped and showed him a smile before continuing, "But business is business. Even though you have helped us a lot, you still have to take the costs to employ our witches on the table."

"Of course, business is business, that is the way of the Fjords." Thunder drained his bowl of fish soup before he laughingly agreed.

…

"So, who did he hire?" As she saw that Thunder had left the palace, Ashes entered the hall from outside, sitting cross-legged before Tilly.

"'Magic Servant' Molly, 'The Door of Random' Orbit, and 'Puppet' Remote Shadow." Tilly spread out the contract, "In the end, the fee was set at four thousand and eight hundred gold royals. The payback is very generous, right? "

"Four thousand…" Ashes' eyes became big, "Where did he get all the money from?"

"Don't forget, Thunder is the most famous explorer in the Fjords," the 5th Princes said laughingly, "No matter if it is the discovery of new routes or finding treasures when exploring new areas, all of it can bring in plenty of money. It was only because of this that he was repeatedly able to recruit such a large group of experienced sailors who would be willing to follow him to explore those mysterious and dangerous zones. But, with witches, he can

greatly reduce the risk, and ever since ancient times it has always been thought as a good bargain when one can offset risk with money."

"However, is that really okay?" Ashes asked unsure, "The establishment of a bounty guild will indeed bring a lot of wealth for Sleeping Island, but, at the same time, the abilities of us witches will be exposed; if this ever spread to the Church's ears… "

"Sleeping Spell" was a new guild that Tilly had formed. From it, explorers could hire suitable witches to help them complete their expeditions. Of course, in addition to the main project, they would also provide many convenient services, such as repairing damaged items, producing exquisite works of art, quickly constructing houses, providing insecticide for growing flowers and so on – as long as the witches don't use their ability to do anything evil, 'Sleeping Spell' will come to be accepted."

Of course, all this was only possible under the premise they announced their abilities publicly.

Tilly took Ashes' hand, "Didn't I already tell you? I do not care about those gold royals, but I hope that through the bounty guild more people will learn about Sleeping Island, and thus reach out to us to make a deal. Thunder has a saying I agree with, 'Fear comes from the unknown', the same is true for the witches. The fear of the people of the Fjords and the Four Kingdoms is nothing more than the slander of the Church and the result of their own ignorance.

"I can't force them to take the initiative to come in contact with us and try to understand us witches. Therefore, we can only step forward and actively go and promote ourselves. Telling them again and again that we witches aren't the Devil's messengers and that our abilities aren't strange and unpredictable – that they awaken from ordinary people, and that our essence is still that of a human being. 'Whenever there is a complete understanding of each other, there will no longer be anything left to fear'." She paused for a moment, then continued, "As for the Church, they have never cared what we are capable of. They simply send out their Army of Judges to capture us, they even occasionally send out the God's Punishment Army. Furthermore, regardless

of our abilities, in front of the God's Stones of Retaliation, they are all the same."

"I hope you are right," Ashes whispered, "I only know how to fight and kill, but regarding this matter I'm unable to help you."

"You have already helped me a lot," Tilly said showing her a reassuring smile. "If we want to further develop Sleeping Island, the most important thing for us will be to associate the Fjord's inhabitants with us witches from the island. The creation of mutual understanding will be a slow process, and I'm only doing all this in order to shorten the process as much as will be possible. In addition, the bounty guild can also play a special role in achieving our goal," she stuck out her tongue and revealed a sly smile before saying, "That's to find new uses for the seemingly useless abilities, so that support witches will no longer be discriminated against or think of their abilities as useless."

Hearing her reasoning Ashes began to laugh, "There are always so many reasons for your actions, whenever you reveal so many layers one after another it makes it hard for other people not to come to accept them."

"That's because I'm always saying the correct thing," Tilly said before changing the topic. "Maggie has not returned to Sleeping Island yet, could something have happened?"

"Perhaps something has delayed her travel," Ashes pondered about her next words, "Or…"

"What?"

"She might no longer want to come back," Ashes said, while shrugging, "Compared to the Fjords, the living condition in Border Town is much better. In the past, I already told you not to send witches there. What will we do if Honey or Lotus also don't want to come back?"

"Then we should head over there at once," Tilly said.

“Oh, well, I will immediately get ready… what?” For a moment Ashes froze before she recovered enough to ask, “W-We are going to travel to them?”

The 5th Princess curled her lips, “Didn’t we reach an agreement that we will help them resist the demonic beasts, and, while doing this, we can also conventionally pick up the other witches. If we don’t have Lotus, the people coming with the Crescent Moon Bay immigration next year won’t have any houses to live in.”

“But right now, there is still one month left to the beginning of the winter, do we really have to go so soon?”

“We will have to spend a lot of time on the road. And if Border Town happens to encounter any trouble along the way we might have to help the witches as soon as possible, and…” She winked at Ashes, “I also want to go see what kind of person my disgusting older brother has turned into.”

Chapter 321

Chapter 321 The Law of Border Town

Early in the morning, the cold woke Roland up. He climbed out from under his cold blanket, put on his wool coat, then immersed his feet into the warm water bucket.

This was one of the corrupting privileges which he could only enjoy as a Prince – every morning, a maid would put out a basin of hot water beside his bed, as well as a clean towel and a cup of warm milk which would warm up his body almost instantly.

Of course, compared to the powerful nobles who had other methods to constantly keep their beds warm, he felt that this was good enough. The former 4th Prince had always attempted to invite Tyre over with exactly that thought in mind, but unfortunately, he wasn't able to enjoy it before his death. However, the new Roland didn't enjoy this practice, so when the position become vacant he had filled it with an elderly but experienced maid instead. In fact, this choice proved to be the right one. Since nowadays there were so many witches staying inside the castle, but she still managed to keep the inside and outside of the castle in good order.

The fire in the fireplace had gone out long before, leaving only white flying ashes behind. Through the cracks in the open window, the cold wind blew into the room, it was so bone-chillingly cold that it was hard to believe that it was still autumn. Roland dried his feet, then washed the rest of his body with another tub of hot water before going over to the window and closing the small gap he had opened through the night.

Even though open fireplaces were very common in this era, he was still worried about the issue of carbon monoxide poisoning and thus he always left a small gap open before he went to bed. This way, with the fire burning the temperature could be kept all the way through the first half of the night,

but, after the fire went out there was no difference between the temperature inside and outside when morning came.

I have to come up with an idea to solve this problem, Roland thought, or I won't be able to sleep in the future.

After eating breakfast, Roland took Nightingale, his Chief Knight, and his personal guards on a routine inspection of the city walls.

The vast expanse of grass between the new city wall and the old city has become a vast expanse of white. As they walked over all the thick snow the soles of their shoes made crunching noises.

Lifting his head, he saw a pale gray sky and falling snowflakes that occasionally came floating into the gap between his coat and his neck, bringing with it traces of coldness. He knew that it was very likely that this kind of weather would continue until spring next year… or it might even be longer.

"How is the situation at the defense line?"

"It's much better than the last time," Carter Lannis said, looking relaxed, "Most soldiers of the First Army have already gathered experience on the battlefield. Furthermore, now that we have these revolving rifles, ten guards are already enough to protect about one hundred meters of the city wall, and suppress all the demonic beasts that appear at the feet of the wall. In addition, compared to the old stone wall, the new wall is about half a meter higher, which is a height that is very difficult for a wolf to reach. Due to this, the defense has turned into mere shooting practice for the soldiers. As long as no mixed species appear these monsters won't ever be able to step one foot past the defense line."

"It seems everything is well."

As Roland boarded the wall, all the soldiers he came across gave him a salute, standing straight with their head held high and their chest out. Just by looking at their spirits, it was already clear that the soldiers had completely changed from the time they spent as part of the militia. At that time, although

they stood side by side on the wall, seemingly uniformly stabbing with their pike, it was in truth nothing more than a conditioned reflex formed after repeated training. The expression in their eyes was war numb, their movements were all stiff, and when someone took a closer look they would immediately see that most of them were trembling slightly.

But the soldier's eyes at this moment were brimming with self-confidence. After going through the ceremony, they immediately turned around and continued to monitor the battlefield.

Walking along the city wall toward the Concealing Forest, the area became much livelier.

The temporary shelters for the serfs and refugees was arranged within this area. When Roland looked down from the top of the wall, it seems as if many slopes were arranged in lines parallel to the wall, looking like upward and downwards moving waves. Each of those slopes offered a place for ten rooms, with an inner structure that was identical to that of a cave. The thick walls were able to maintain the indoor temperature, while the kang heated the room and a linen cover at the entry kept the cold out.

The whole area was divided into two blocks, the one close to the wall was called the West Side and was used to shelter the refugees; while the East Side set further away from the wall has been assigned to the serfs.

Every day the City Hall would send out people to distribute food and charcoal, while the refugees had to take over the task of delivering for the soldiers of the First Army who were protecting the walls. As for the serfs, most of them had all the wheat they needed. With the exception of some people who went out to look for a job to earn some extra money, the others all rarely left their warm houses.

At this moment, suddenly a fierce argument broke out at the junction between the East and West side. When Roland became aware of it he went over and saw a group of people standing in the middle of the road that passed through the residential area that were bust arguing out loud. One of them wore a blue and white uniform and seemed to be a clerk who worked in City Hall. It didn't take long for the verbal quarrel to escalate into a fight, both sides

began to push each other and strike one another, turning the whole scene into a mess.

“Your Highness,” Carter asked.

“Let’s go take a look,” Roland agreed.

When they reached the place where the disruption was happening the chief knight took the lead and went straight into the fighting crowd, immediately knocking down two or three of the trouble makers. And as Roland’s personal guards, having already drawn their swords shouted out for everyone to stop, the scene soon fell back under control.

Discovering that the newly arrived people were actually the Lord’s men, the two quarreling sides fell immediately on their knees just like breaking waves.

“What is your name?” Roland frowned as he asked the clerk who had two punch marks on his face, “What’s going on here? Who attacked you first?”

“Your Highness, my name is Khoya Harvie,” he cried and hid his face with his hands. “It was that damned refugee who hit me first, it’s the man dressed in brown linen! I was still busy distributing food when he rushed up to me like a dog who’d gone mad.”

Hearing Khoya’s words and after being pointed out, the man wearing refugee clothes turned and said, “Your Highness, things didn’t happen as he described it. These people and the serfs conspired to blackmail us. Every time they distribute porridge they collect money, but, at the time you took us in you clearly told us that it would be free!”

Hearing him speak left Roland slightly surprised. All of the refugees who had come from the east coast had been combed through by the City Hall; they’d already sorted out all of the craftsmen, people with special abilities, or those who were literate. Those were moved to the inner circle, so the remaining people here should supposedly be ordinary civilians. But judging by his tone of voice and his choice of words it didn’t resemble a civilian at all.

In contrast, it was the man from the city hall who had used words like ‘damned dog’ and other insults, which left a really disappointing appearance. Since he had a well-known family name… in all likelihood, he was one of Duke Ryan’s former people.

“I have said that before you are officially incorporated into Border Town the porridge and shelter will all be free of charge,” Roland repeated once again in front of the refugees. “Today, those words are still valid!”

“His Highness is merciful!”

“Long live the Lord!”

“Thank you, Your Highness!”

The refugees began to shout while kowtowing.

But at the same time, Khoya Harvie’s face turned livid.

“However, fights within the inner territory resulting in injuries are a violation of the law. In particular, attacking a member of the City Hall,” Roland said, then ordered his personal guards, “Take all the refugees and serfs who started the fight and bring them to the castle, I will personally try this fight.”

He paused, and then looked at Khoya with interest, “I would also like to ask you about this matter of charging for the porridge.”

…

Chapter 322

Chapter 322 Western Territory Security Bureau

Returning to the castle hall, Roland went to sit in the Lord's seat that was overlooking the subjects gathered within the hall beneath him.

In his memory, the only time the 4th Prince has ever used his right to exercise a trial was the first time he had come to Border Town. Later, after his fallout with the nobles and his dissatisfaction with his current lifestyle in general, he had thrown everything into the hands of Barov, never asking him anything about it.

Seeing that everyone was present, Roland called for the trial to begin.

At first, he let all sides state their case, then he asked them questions of his own – with Nightingale there secretly assisting him it wasn't necessary for him to determine who was deliberately lying and who spoke insincerely, nor did he need to have the meticulous mind of a grim reaper, concluding who was responsible became effortless and simple.

Soon the whole truth of the story was revealed.

At heart, Khoya Harvie was unwilling to accept that he was deprived of his identity as a knight, at the same time he had also grown tired of the tedious writing work at the City Hall, which resulted into a stomach full of resentment against the refugees. He made use of the opportunity presented by the distribution of the wheat porridge to purposely charge the refugees a fee and instigate dispute between both sides. He deliberately told them that it was because the serfs didn't turn over all their grain that the wheat stock wasn't enough and for that reason they could not give out porridge free of charge.

In fact, what made Roland the most aggravated was that Khoya was only able to charge them for several days because he had been wearing the eye-catching uniform of the City Hall and that the refugees had been worried

about the possibility of retaliation from officials that they kept silent. Until today, when a refugee named Vader had stepped out in protest against his behavior, and from this commotion everything had then been exposed.

When Roland finally understood the whole situation he felt relieved.

An organization on the rise should be brimming with vitality, full of youthful energy. Later on, when the situation was more stable, corruption and rigidity would be inevitable, but that should only be something that happens after the unification with Longsong Stronghold. If those problems were to appear in the beginning, then the organization would be doomed to never go very far.

However, it now appeared that Khoya had acted on his own and that none of the other officials of the City Hall had been related to this matter. Furthermore, it was only a matter limited to extorting money, and not the thing he had feared the most, which was serfs selling and reselling grain in private.

Of course, to some extents, Roland was also the one responsible that the situation had develop to this. Due to City Hall originally being so desperately short of manpower, Roland had placed the surrendered Knights under Barov after only giving them a warning about the circumstances and no further screening or training. The result showed that not everyone had been able to accept the job without complaint or bare the great mental pain of dropping in rank from a knight to a civilian.

Roland called Barov to his side and asked him in a low voice: “What would other Lords do in this case?”

“Your Highness, there are two possibilities,” the latter respectfully replied, “If the offender is a nobleman, after paying a few gold royals the situation would be turned over and they could be let go without any further punishment. While the punishment for a civilian attacking a noble can be big or small, from cutting off one hand to flogging.”

“But Khoya is no nobleman,” the Prince responded, “I have deprived him of his title.”

“Yes, that’s true, Your Highness. In this way, the disposition will be based entirely on the mood of the Lord.”

“There are no fixed numbers?”

Barov shook his head.

Hearing this Roland began to frown, that it is entirely dependant on the mood of the Lord means that in the eyes of the nobility it doesn’t matter how civilians are treated, they do not consider them as “people” at all.

“In addition to cutting off hands, breaking feet, whipping and pulling fingernails are there any common punishments? For example, imprisonment?”

“Imprisonment?” Barov asked startled, “You mean to simply lock them away? What kind of punishment would that be? A prison is only a temporary place for holding the sinner, sooner or later they will be brought to trial and their case will be closed. During their imprisonment, you have to feed them the whole time, I’m afraid that it would be a reward for some people.”

Well, it seems that the general term of imprisonment used in later generation won’t be very useful here. After thinking about it for a moment, Roland decided to follow the rules of the castle. He stood up, and let his gaze wander over the people gathered beneath him, “I’m ready to give my verdict now.”

“Khoya Harvie, because of dereliction of duty, extortion of refugees, you are abolished of your position within City Hall, sentenced to work in the mine for ten years, and to be fined with three times the amount you have stolen.

“Vader, as the first to attack a City Hall officer you will be sentenced to ten lashes with the whip.

“All the other refugees and serfs involved in the fighting are fined two silver royals or five lashes with a whip.

“The distribution of the wheat porridge will continue to be free of charge, all previous extorted money will be refunded.” He looked to the Prime Minister

of the City Hall, “You will carry out the above ruling and also announce the result to the people in the temporary residential area.”

“As you command, Your Royal Highness,” Barov said.

Back to the office, Roland leaned against the back of the chair and stretched, he then felt a pair of hands resting on his shoulders and gently massaged them.

Closing his eyes Roland enjoyed a moment of leisure.

This matter had made Roland realize that with the increasing number of people in the city, the authority of the City Hall had also expanded rapidly and that they might already have to face the problem of internal regulation by now.

He did not want to set up an institution similar to the prosecutor’s office, but he was also unwilling to set up an independent public security bureau of later generations. Not only would the former need a larger number of literacy personnel, they were also prone to attack each other, interfere in the commission of the policies, the appointing and expelling systems of government, and hinder the implementation of new policies. While the latter weakened the Lord’s authority in disguise. It would still be better if he kept those powers, such as the formulation and interpretation of the law and holding a trial, in his own hands.

What he needed was a simple yet effective System which didn’t require many people to play the role of a supervising organization.

Roland took hold of one of the hands placed on his shoulders.

Feeling her hand being grasped, Nightingale stepped out of the fog and sat on the edge of the table while holding the Prince’s hand, she then crooked her head and asked: “What’s up?“

Her slender legs dangled from the table, swaying in the air, forming a perfect curve with her high tube moccasins and her close-fitting pants.

Roland coughed twice, “I intend to set up a new department which will supervise the City Hall, as well as arrest other people who attempt to harm the Western Territory or destabilize the community. This department only needs to report to me and will be completely independent of the City Hall or the First Army.” Emphasizing every word Roland went on, “I will name it the “Western Territory Security Bureau” and I want the first supervisor to be you.”

“Me?” Nightingale blinked confusedly.

“That’s right, only you can easily distinguish the truth of the spoken words. Furthermore, any cheats or tricks will be meaningless in front of you, “Roland nodded. “How is it? If you wish, I can provide you with my own afternoon tea’s ice cream during winter, and also…”

Nightingale gently pinched his hand, “It’s unnecessary to say that, I promise I will comply – anything, as long as it is something you want me to do.”

“…” Roland suddenly felt a bit embarrassed.

She laughed, but didn’t let the silence continue for too long and instead said, “But what should I do?”

“Well, the supervising part will be very simple,” the Prince got his emotion back under his control, “I will set up an accusation box at the entrance to the castle area, thus you only have to check the contents of the reporting letters inside.”

If he wanted to solve the problem in the least costly way, it would be to use the masses to supervise, as well as make the City Hall supervise itself. Just like last year when they had caught the spies during the Months of Demons.

For future generations, this method wouldn’t be easy enough to use. No matter if it was the reported target or the reporter themselves, it would need a lot of effort to verify. Simultaneously, there could also be cases of false reports, mistaken reports about correct situations, and not to mention deliberate framing. But in front of Nightingale’s ability these shortcomings wouldn’t be a problem. Verifying the information would be very easy for her,

she merely had to question the accuser in person – truthful reports would be rewarded while false accusations and false reports would be punished. Centering the implementation around these two points, the system was bound to be extremely efficient.

“As for maintaining the stability of the Western Territory, and eliminating threats and hidden dangers, it will be more resemblant of a national intelligence system. However, for this, I will slowly extend your hands until your eyes are spread over the whole of the Western Territory.”

Chapter 323

Chapter 323 Ministry of Public Security

Roland already had a rough plan of the future public security system for his territory.

At present, the town had a population of about twenty thousand. Besides the local indigenous people, there were also people who had immigrated from Longsong Stronghold as well as the refugees who have escaped from the Eastern Region. By the time the messengers sent by Barov came back, they might already have brought people from the Northern or Southern Region of the kingdom and as a result would further complicate the cultures that the population consists of. With all the different morals, conflicts like what had happened today would only become more and more common.

He would therefore need to establish a public security system to separate the First Army's task of patrolling from internal and external violence. He had already thought of this issue before but had not thought of anything definite because of how few staff he had. However, now that he had the First Army to fight against the demonic beasts and the population was growing very rapidly, the time to implement his plan had come.

By formulating and interpreting the laws himself and holding trials of major crimes, he would be the first and also the final instance; the public security would capture criminals according to the law while also settling civil disputes. The Security Bureau would be responsible for maintaining the purity of the system and to effectively prevent the corruption of the systems, they would also use public security personnel to carry out the corruption cleaning operations and in that way save on human resources. This was the outline for Roland's security system.

The ideal situation would be if he could first try to run the security system in Border Town, and by the time he had established Border Town as a city next year he would expand the system to the whole of the Western Territory.

By then, no matter if it was an autonomous Lord's territory or not, they would all have to implement the same set of laws and accept the rule of a unified department. Only he alone would be able to stand above the law.

As the mightiest noble of the Western Territory, Roland knew that it was unrealistic to say that everyone was equal before the law, nor could he abolish the aristocracy. But at least he could make sure that the traditional system of feudal fiefdom does not exist within his city anymore. If they wanted to get the protection of the Western Territory, they would have to hand over their power of self-governance.

As for the head of the Ministry of Public Security, Roland already had the right person in mind for that.

Someone filled with a strong sense of justice while also not being pedantic, Carter Lannis would be a fitting choice.

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When Vader stumbled back to his temporary residence, old man Kukasim came out to welcome him.

"You… never mind."

"It's tolerable," Vader grumbled, "His Highness only sentenced me with a punishment of ten whips."

"Let me take a look," Kukasim eagerly stepped forward.

"Go back to the house," Vader said as he walked into the house where the warmth inside immediately dispelled the chill within his body. As the door closed, it appeared as if the inside and outside were two completely different worlds. Compared to the wooden sheds from before which would let through wind and rain, this somewhat low and narrow mud house gave people a sense of comfort.

That's right, the locals seem to call this house 'cave dwelling'.

The old man let him lie on the kang, and when he tore off the clothes at Vander's back he couldn't help but suck in a mouth of cold air.

"Your back is covered with blood, I'll go get some ash to cover it."

"Wait, there is no need. It's only dried blood left from from after the torture, the blood has already stopped flowing long ago." He had to repeatedly pause as he spoke, "Sir Knight has said that it would be best to keep it open like this and to wait for two or three days by which time the wound will have already healed."

"Two or three days?" Kukasim shook his head in fear, "No, son, by then you may have already fallen into a high fever and your back will swell up into a ball. Even if you might have a strong body, you will still need at least a week to recover. You of all people should be aware of what happens when a disease flares up."

"You may not believe it," he licked his dried lips. "But I don't feel much pain from the wounds on my back. On the contrary, I feel a cool and itchy feeling, which is a sign that its healing. After they finished the whipping they splashed a bucket of water on my back… "

"Saltwater?" The old man frowned.

"At the beginning, I had the same thought, but the scorch I expected did not come," Vader laughed twice, "The Knight executing the penalty said that this can eliminate all disease-causing microorganism. If I want to let my wounds heal quickly, I shouldn't do anything superfluous with it, and allow it to dry."

"What are those disease causing micro… organism?"

"Microorganism," he curled his lips, "Who knows what they are, most probably something related to those witches."

The old man lowered his head, then after a long time he opened his mouth again: "You shouldn't have stepped forward because of me, if it is only words it's still bearable… "

“If we were to keep on enduring it, we would have to suffer under an even more severe treatment. I know that kind of person, they have the morality and appearance similar to many of the nobles living in King’s City,” Vader spat. “I’ve heard that in this area the snow will last for several months, but the money we have won’t last until then.” He paused, “and… I also deliberately picked that time to hit him.”

“Caused, deliberately?” Kukasim asked disbelievingly.

“Yes. After all, the Prince will always appear on the west side of the city wall at this time of the day. Since he had promised to give us free food, he must hate this kind of behavior which is damaging his reputation. Thus, this was also the most effective way. If we had merely caused a simple fight, it wouldn’t be certain that it would ever reach His Highness’ ear. After all, Kohya Harvie might have received instructions from others. So if any of the City Hall officers wanted to suppress news about this, it would become meaningless regardless of what we said.”

“But he could also have been instructed by His Highness…”

“The possibility that this was the case was very low. If His Royal Highness wanted to save his money, then the three meals he promised would be reduced to two meals. Furthermore, I have inquired about him in advance and no matter whether it is the local residents or those serfs, all of them praise His Highness’ kindness and wisdom.” Vader said, smiling proudly. “You see, I wasn’t gambling or anything like that, right?”

“Originally… so that’s how it is,” the old man sighed in relief, “It seems you really have considered everything already.”

But there was also a part I hadn’t guessed, Vader thought, that was the penalty.

Working for ten years as a patrol officer in Valencia, he had a profound understanding of the ugliness hidden beneath the city’s glamorous appearance. There were more than a dozen of nobles who have used their power to blackmail, even among the ranks of the patrols. Therefore, there wasn’t much need for him to want to punish these nobles.

His Royal Highness's reaction had been basically the same as what he had expected, it was only that the amount of punishment was beyond his expectation.

In this kind of circumstances, the Lords who mind their reputation would have ruled the suppressor as the innocent party, but he instead had punished everyone. It seemed that His Highness cared more about the system than of his reputation.

For a Lord, accustomed to doing as he pleased to care so much for his subjects, this was something that was rarely seen.

"What are you going to do next?" The old man asked after a moment of silence.

"Just like Sir Knight had said, rest for two days, then continue as before, and help those guys carrying those strange weapons by delivering groceries."

"You could have lived a decent life together with the craftsmen in the inner city."

"But it would be impossible for you to get in, Kukasim. So, stop talking about this," Vader said, shaking his head. "I refuse to leave you behind."

This old man was neither his family nor his elder. Half a year ago, the other had still been a prisoner kept in prison. Everyone knew that the old man had been pushed forward by the black street rats to act as a scapegoat, but this matter appeared too often that the patrol had become too lazy to take notice of it anymore. Later, when a group of pirates looted Valencia, Vader had believed that he would die within the turmoil, but in that critical juncture, the old man hidden within the prison had covered him with his stinking bed sheets which in the end allowed him to luckily escape.

Vader did not expect that he would be saved by one of those prisoners he was normally so unwilling to look at. But at that moment he had finally come to understand that there was essential no difference between how they acted and the disgusting nobility.

The other two people in the room were both aware of Kukasim's identity, but since he was looking after him they didn't dare to touch him. However, in case he left, they would certainly try and make trouble for the old man.

"Don't worry, everything will be fine." Vader patted his counterpart's shoulders.

Two days later, he heard the news from the inner city that His Highness was recruiting for the positions in public security.

Chapter 324

Chapter 324 Signs of the sea

“Hey, girls, do any of you want a bowl of fish soup?” Captain Jack asked after stretching his head into the cabin, as smoke curled up from the pipe he held in the corner of his mouth, “A lucky fellow caught a large tailless trout just a moment ago.”

“Thank you,” Tilly Wimbledon nodded. “We’ll come over right away.”

“Is it fish soup again?” Ashes said regretfully after the Captain left, “Where in the world is such tasteless fish soup even remotely tasty?”

“You can ask for a little salt if you want to add it to the soup,” Breeze laughingly said. “Pepper would also be alright, but that’s more expensive. I’m afraid Mr. Jack won’t want to give it to you.”

“Don’t put anything into the soup. Boiled soup keeps its original flavor, while also keeping the quality of the food itself,” Andrea said, gracefully sorting her long light golden hair, “Lady Tilly, I would presume we were supposed to go to the captain’s room.”

“As long as it is something warm we should go over right away,” Shavi, who had the shortest stature of all of them, muttered, “My toes are stiff.”

Following along the stairs the group entered the captain’s cabin in the Charming Beauty. One Eye Jack stood near the porthole, looking at the white track of the rolling waves spreading out behind the ship.

“This damn weather, how can it suddenly become so cold?” He asked, puffing out a cloud of white smoke, “Oh You Three Gods, it’s supposed to currently be mid-autumn, ah~.”

“Maybe the gods just fell asleep?” Ashes said and shrugged.

“Pei Pei, you can’t say words like that when you are in the middle of the sea ,” Captain Jack grinned, “The Emperor of the Sea is always keeping his eyes on us,” he said and put his hands on his stomach before making a praising gesture, “Let it be for now, we shouldn’t think too much of it. Let’s first fill our bellies with warm fish soup.”

In order to fully enjoy the warm food in the captain’s room, he did not hesitate to open a big hole in the floor, put a brazier frame in the middle, and fill the space that was left with sand. In this way he could keep the heat isolated and avoid igniting the whole ship.

A large pot of soup was bubbling above the brazier, making a rumbling sound and filling the room with an overflowing fragrance.

The six people took their shoes off and sat in a circle around the brazier. They buried their feet in the warm sand, completely surrounding their ice-cold toes with the hot gravel and enjoying the warmth from the burning charcoal.

Tilly received the fish soup that the captain had offered her and gently blew on the piping hot soup to cool it. Compared to the milky white surface of boiled black tail fish soup, this bowl of soup was a deep yellow with oil bubbles floating on its surface, giving it a crystal sheen when reflecting the light.

When she occasionally saw some green and white specks within the soup, she knew that the captain had taken some goods from his own reserves. After all, due to frequently sailing for several months on end, it resulted in that the crew could hardly ever eat fresh vegetables and fruits. Thus, these soft green onions were obviously some vegetables which he had deliberately preserved within iced saltpeter. The fragrance of the green onions neutralized the fish’s own fishy smell, and harmoniously mixed in with the ginger and ale, making it taste all the more rich and delicious.

When the soup became cold enough that she wouldn’t burn her tongue, Tilly drank a small sip, before pausing and gently blowing again. She could clearly feel every small mouthful of it, after drinking the soup a warm current

flowed along her throat and into her stomach, where it rested, releasing a nice and warm feeling.

The chilliness soon faded, almost as if her body was experiencing a slight fever.

“Try and add some pepper,” Jack said, pointing at the seasoning jar standing next to the brazier, “In addition to enhancing its taste even more, it will also especially expel the cold. It’s even more effective than wine.”

“Although tasting its original flavor is the true meaning of eating food, but I must say, the added ingredients are perfect, bringing out the flavor to perfection,” Andrea praised.

“Won’t you drink something?” Tilly asked while looking at Ashes.

The latter waved her hand, “I would better let it be, I’m really unable to stomach the fishy taste.”

At first, Tilly was also unable to accept the habit of the people of the Fjords who loved eating fish for every meal. They ate it in all kinds of variations, roasted, boiled, and not to forget deep fried. Furthermore, there was also something similar to frozen fish, fish sauce, caviar and other strange preparations… However, after she had forced herself to eat it several times during formal banquets, she’d discovered that its taste was quite good and that once she became familiar with the taste of the sea it could instead further serve as a contrast for the food’s tastiness. Like those sun dried fish, roasted cuttlefish and even the fried fish with its pungent smell, was something she could by now enjoy eating.

“Our High and Mighty Miss Ashes’ appetite has already been corrupted by Border Town’s barbarous cooking,” Andrea said, “It is a pity that the taste of spices and fine salt not only made her lose her ability to identify what’s delicious. It now seems that not even any of her courage is left.”

“What did you say?” Ashes glared at Andrea.

“Why, isn’t it like this?” Andrea issued a series of laughs, “Just a little fishy smell is enough to make you flinch. Willful like a little girl, how do you expect us to believe that you will bravely step forward when Tilly needs it?”

“So it was actually like that… it seems you want to provoke me to play with you,” Ashes voice suddenly became gentle, “Give up, Border Town has a terrible weapon. Far more powerful than your arrows. Even then, I was still able to win the duel. So, if you would like to take over the post of Tilly’s personal guard from me, you will still need to practice for a few more years…” She paused, “I misspoke, you would have to practice your whole lifetime.”

“You –!”

The corner of Ashes’ mouth rose as she said, “Besides, the fine food that His Highness Roland invented was not only the layering of spices and salt, only when you try it will you be able to understand. Remember, don’t let your drool drip on your clothes, Lady Tilly cannot afford to lose face.”

“Nonsense, it will be you!”

Tilly could not help but smile. These two witches were Sleeping Islands most powerful combat witches. They would often fight against each other to determine who would be number one, Tilly knew however, no matter if it was Ashes or Andrea, they were also her best subordinates. During the time of danger, they wouldn’t hesitate to fight side by side, both working together to build the impregnable walls surrounding Sleeping Island.

The two’s quarreling lived up the atmosphere in the room, and as she saw the scene, Tilly couldn’t help but think of the five witches she had sent to Border Town. Are they doing well in my brother’s place?

At this moment, the Charming Beauty suddenly began to shake violently.

“Be careful!” Ashes shouted as she grasped the 5th Princess. The iron cooking pot on top of the brazier turned over and the soup that poured out put out the charcoal fire. The brazier standing on the wok was overturned to the

ground, the soup poured out the charcoal fire, while the fish meat ended up on the ground.

A sharp whistle came from outside.

“Enemy attack!

A sailor rushed into the captain’s room and shouted, “Captain sir, Sea Ghosts are coming! More than one!”

Sea Ghost… isn’t that another name for demonic beasts Tilly got shocked, how can they even come to this place?

As the group ran out of the cabin, they could see more than a dozen fish monster with crabs legs entering the deck, and some that were still climbing up the two sides of the Charming Beauty. With their six legs they moved fast and nimble like cockroaches, wielding a humanoid arm on both sides of their head; their humanoid arms had an amazing strength, which could easily break a seaman’s neck.

“Since you are unwilling to accept my challenge, we will have to compete,” Andrea shouted as she snapped her fingers. Her fingers began emitting a golden light which turned into a bow firmly held in her hand, “The one who kills the most monster is the strongest.”

“No matter,” Ashes countered as she pulled her strange sword from her back, “I’m on.”

Chapter 325

Chapter 325 Arrow of Light

Tilly poured her magic into the flying magic stone then jumped into the air, from where she could overlook the entire deck.

The crew of the Charming Beauty was mostly formed out of experienced sailors, so after the initial panic subsided one after another they picked up their weapons and grouped together to fight against the demonic beasts to gradually guide them to the aft of the ship. It was obvious that it would be impossible for them to defeat such a large number of enemies with their strength alone, so their only hope lay in the witches that were together with them on board.

When Ashes joined the battle the situation quickly changed.

She was like a gust of wind, causing all the monsters to cry and scream as she passed. Any demonic beasts daring to face her sword met with a clean cut; leaving with severed limbs scattered all across the deck.

Unwilling to fall behind, Andrea released one arrow after another. Her magic longbow allowed her to use any object at hand as an arrow and release it with an alarming power and accuracy. So she rarely prepared a conventional feather arrow, but rather a bag of glass beads. The glass beads were solid enough that it could cross a distance of twenty paces and penetrate the demonic beast's head, turning the brain into a mass of paste, only allowing them to weakly twitch before turning limp, without even managing to release a single miserable cry.

Breeze and Shavi pushed their way back and forth over the deck and rescued the injured sailors. Under the protection of an invisible barrier, the demonic beasts weren't even able to come close to them.

Even on seeing the demonic beasts quickly being beheaded, and their number rapidly beginning to dwindle, Tilly still did not dare to relax.

These fish-shaped monsters were clearly not enough to cause the violent shaking that the Charming Beauty had felt at the beginning. Instead, it was as if there was a huge monster hitting the bottom of the ship from below. Without the protection from Molly's servant, the force would have been strong enough to turn the ship into a piles of broken wood floating in the sea if it managed to hit the ship a few more time. At that time, the witches would just barely be able to protect themselves while probably only a few seamen would be able to escape ending up in a fish belly.

Just like she had expected, the moment Ashes' sword had cut down the last demonic beast, a gigantic shadow, which was much too large to be a fish, appeared in the water in front of the ship's hull. It quickly approached them and once again bumped into the Charming Beauty.

"Be careful!" She shouted.

Her voice had hardly fallen when the shadow once again passed beneath the bottom of the ship, causing the sailboat to start violently shaking. Two masts began to issue a series of cracking sounds, as if they would come crashing down at any moment. Fortunately, the shadow didn't attempt another attack, and instead quickly disappeared into the depths from where it could attack the Charming Beauty with its back, shaping its knife and fork for a satisfying meal.

After dropping down back on the deck, Tilly quickly summarized the situation.

"We must force it out of the sea, otherwise sooner or later this damn monster will manage to sink the ship." Ashes declared with a frown.

"I'll try it," Shavi said. "Since it's coming from beneath when it hits the bottom of the ship, as long as it gets in close enough, I could use my barrier to stop it."

"Oh Emperor of the Sea above," Old Jack cried out as he wiped the sweat from his forehead, "If it's really as huge as Lady Tilly said, I'm afraid that ordinary attacks would be unlikely to work against it. So how would you kill it, even if you are able to force it out of the sea-"

“Just let me do it,” Andrea combed her loose hair back behind her ears as she showed them a confident smile. “There is no enemy able to resist my full power within a distance of ten steps.”

It wasn’t long before the shadow appeared again, but this time it had changed direction and was coming at them from the stern of the Charming Beauty.

Monitoring the situation from high up in the air, Tilly immediately called out a warning. When Shavi heard her she quickly ran into position and jumped off the ship. Previously she had firmly tied a hemp rope around her waist, while the other end was in Ashes’ hand, who could use it to control Shavi’s falling height.

As the shadow approached, Shavi quickly opened her barrier, splitting the dusky sea water, as if it was separated by something invisible.

As the monster rushed into the barrier, its huge bulk stopped and Shavi let out a pressured groan, her hands were hanging down beside her body, as if she was using an enormous amount of strength. Looking down, the shadow beneath her feet was rapidly expanding, and the water was rising violently.

“Quickly pull her up!” Tilly shouted as she rushed downwards.

Using all her power, Ashes single-handed pulled on her end of the rope. The moment Shavi fell on the deck, a huge sea monster came roaring out of the water, causing waves which made the Charming Beauty sway heavily. The monster looked like a mixture between a shark and an octopus, with a triangular head which was covered with several tentacles, all of which shot straight toward the deck.

Even without hearing its cry it became clear that the unfathomable impact has made it incomparably angry, as it let its adult thigh sized tentacles rain down onto the ship, trying to break everything apart, but even from the beginning up until the end it had no way to penetrate Shavi’s defense.

“Andrea!” Ashes bent down, entwined her fingers and formed a step with her hands.

“Coming,” the latter set a foot onto Ashes’ palms and shouted, “Give me everything you’ve got!”

Thrown by extraordinary power into the air, Andrea turned into an arc and within the blink of an eye, she had already appeared above the monster’s head.

She summoned her magical longbow, pulling the string to its fullest, unexpectedly there were flashes of light breaking out between the bow and its string. Rather than flashes of light, it seemed as if the sun had actually come out from behind the clouds, reflecting across the sea’s surface in a golden luster.

“Go!”

The light flashed, and with an ear-piercing cry an arrow, made purely out of magic, it drilled right into the monster body like a strike of thunder. The monster’s gray-brown skin suddenly swelled, and golden cracks appeared all over its body, before finally, with a loud explosion, it shattered.

The huge explosion created ripples across the surface of the sea. Its blood, which was as black as ink, dyed the sea a pitch-black, while viscera came falling from the sky like rain. The previously attacking tentacles all curled up and sunk back into the sea together with pieces of the monster’s blown up head.

Andrea crashed into the sea.

“Ah… Help, help I can’t swim! Guru, who… who’s going to pull me out?!”

Ashes glanced toward the seemingly tired Shiva before she helplessly sighed. “She is indeed only a handsome fool,” she said then unhooked the sword on her back and jumped into the sea to swim to Andrea’s side.

As the threat of a sunken ship was lifted, Tilly finally felt some relief. At least she no longer had to worry how they were going to travel on their own to Border Town.

But just at that moment, she suddenly felt something cold on her nose, raising her head, she could not help but freeze on the spot.

She could see snowflakes falling from the gray sky, flying around like white fairies, filling her entire field of view.

“This… is snow?” Tilly asked in disbelief as she looked at the melted water on top of her hand, “Graycastle has snow during autumn?”

“Well, it’s like I said. The further West we go, the colder it becomes,” One Eyed Jack said as he pulled out his pipe, “It seems you are really returning toward an abyss of suffering.”

Tilly was unable to answer, only showing a dignified look. Breeze had originally come from the Kingdom of Dawn, which had a favorable climate throughout the year, while Jack was born within the Fjords, where even during the strongest winter it was difficult for them to see heavy snowfall. But for Graycastle’s Western Region, snow had a special meaning.

Her court tutor had once said, that once the snow began to fall it wouldn’t stop for a long time. Just like the Devil’s fanfare it symbolized the beginning of the Months of Demons and would only settle after the Months of Demon had come to its end.

Although the beginning of the Months of Demons isn’t at a fixed date, generally it won’t start before the beginning of winter, can it be that Border Town is already under the attack of demonic beasts? Moreover, those Sea Ghost would usually only appear East of the Burning Fire Island, but right now there are even traces of them at the most southern corner of the Vortex Sea. I wonder if those merchant ships sailing between the Fjords and the Four Kingdoms are also under attack from these monsters.

Tilly was starting to feel more and more worried.

Navigating through the whirling snow for two more days, they finally saw the hazy coastline on top of the horizon.

Chapter 326

Chapter 326 Contact

“Is this the place where you landed last time?” Tilly asked, looking at the tall rocky cliff standing in front of them.

From the moment they had first seen the coastline, the Charming Beauty had followed it all the way westwards, until Ashes finally shouted for them to stop when they’ve reached the known beach.

“Yeah, take a look at them,” Ashes said as she pointed at the top of a cliff.

Tilly followed the direction of Ashes’ finger with her gaze and saw an orange flag on both sides of the peak flapping in the wind.

“Although it was a sandy beach when came here last, those two flags prove that we haven’t taken the wrong road.”

“I also had the same impression,” Old Jack said, the pipe as always still in his mouth, “But the last time they came, it was with a huge balloon which they had used to carry all the woman over the mountain. So, how are you planning to get over that?”

“Huge balloon?” Tilly asked curiously.

“That’s right, it can fly when it is filled with hot air,” Ashes nodded in confirmation, “It is said that it’s one of His Highness’ inventions. The principle behind it is to use the power from hot air to carry the balloon and the people inside up into the sky.”

The 5th Princess looked somewhat worried as she stated, “The court mentors have never taught us anything like that.” She then spat out a mouthful of white air before continuing, “No matter, I will see him soon, and when I do I will naturally come to know the truth. Let’s go ashore.”

“Are you sure you don’t want to wait aboard until he comes to pick you up?” The captain asked, clearing his pipe from ashes, “How are you planning to cross the cliff?”

“Shiva will handle it,” Tilly said smilingly.

Since it was a naturally formed coastline and no one really knew the depth of the seabed, the Charming Beauty couldn’t approach the shore. So the only way to send the people towards the sandbar was by using the landing boat.

When the group of witches stepped onto the thick snow, Tilly turned toward One Eyed Jack and said, “Mr. Captain, please wait here for three or four more days, Lotus and the others will also need your help returning to Sleeping Island.”

“Of course,” the captain agreed immediately, “Without you witches on board, I wouldn’t dare to sail back, ah. Who knows whether those Sea Ghosts will attack again on our way back home.”

When everything was said, Tilly went to the edge of the cliff and used the flying magic stone with her ability to head straight to the top of the hilltop. Looking around, the terrain behind the mountain was much higher than the beach, it was almost at the same level as the hilltop. In other words, they would only have to go up and there would be no need for them to go down again to land. The height of the cliff was about fifty paces, and the magic consumption of the barrier would be increased when used against objects, but such a distance should still be no problem for Shiva. Having slowly come to land beside the four woman Tilly said, “Shiva, I will have to trouble you with those three.”

“Yes, Lady Tilly,” the latter said, showing a big smile while patting her chest. Then she summoned her invisible barrier. By now all of them were fully recovered after having rested for two days since last deflecting all the violent attacks from the sea monster. Waiting until all the people had stepped on top of her transparent barrier, she guided her magic, so that the barrier slowly rose up and soon they were above the hilltop.

Then, with Ashes' guidance the group spent half a day until finally arriving at Border Town.

The first thing that caught Tilly's eyes was a steel bridge with its unique shape. It spun across a wide river with only two bridge piers at the bottom to act as support. Its iron beams neatly arranged, without any unnecessary beam or additional decoration or patterns. The snow laying on top of the deck was in stark contrast to the exposed parts of the black bridge, giving it an initial impression of an air of grandeur.

"This bridge… is really huge," Breeze sighed, "In the end, how many iron ingots did they need in order to create a bridge like this?"

"It's just a waste of materials. The traffic problem could have easily been solved with a pontoon bridge. What's the point of building a bridge so high?" Ashes said, making it clear that she thought differently, "Border Town lays at the end of the route of merchant fleets, so which ship would want to travel to a river's origin to do business?"

"That's the opinion of people who only have a superficial knowledge and experience," Andrea said while elegantly shaking her index finger. "Even though I'm not a citizen of Graycastle, I can still see that the forest at the western side possesses a considerable value for reclamation. Even though there is no town there right now, that doesn't mean that there won't be one in the future. If you want to continue to expand your territory, it is a good choice to expand into an uninhabited area. At that time the pontoon bridge would only become a hindrance for the trading route, Lady Tilly's brother can be considered as someone thinking more long-term than you are."

Ashes raised her eyebrows, "Previously you called him a vulgar nobleman who loved barbaric cooking, but now you've already changed how you address him to Lady Tilly's brother?"

"The two words 'vulgar nobleman' were added by you," the blond witch stated as she flung her hair away in a disdainful gesture, "In addition, thinking long-term and barbaric cooking doesn't conflict, you shouldn't try to stirring up enmity in front of Lady Tilly."

Tilly, however, didn't care about this already common conflict between the two, her gaze instead was directed to the other side of the river.

There she had noticed an incredible phenomenon.

At this time the snow was still falling from the sky, the temperature no different than during the winter, so it was reasonable to say that it was a time the town's people should be hiding in their own homes, either around the fire, or rolled up beneath the quilt. Even in King's City, she had only ever seen a few people who had intensified their physical strength so as to elapse the bitter cold. If they wanted to keep their body warm, they would have to eat more than usual, not to mention the risk of catching a cold whenever they stepped out of the door. Therefore, apart from gathering the necessary food and drink, the overwhelming majority of civilians would always avoid any sort of action in the winter.

However, on the town's riverside there were people constantly coming and going, some pushing carts, some carrying big bags on their back, all walking hurriedly as if they were working. Yet, Tilly could not see a whip holding overseer anywhere among them, that was to say, these people were completely voluntary at their work.

How can this be?

After crossing the iron bridge, they were immediately stopped by two guards armed with peculiar spears, the guards were wearing uniform clothes and looked full of energy. Their demeanor completely different from the common patrols in the big cities. "Stop, why have you come from the South?" One of them looked at them for a moment before asking, "Wait, are you… witches?"

This question left Tilly slightly stumped for words. Even though she was already aware that witches were living openly within the town, when personally hearing ordinary people asking such a question in such a calm manner, it still set off a bursts through her heart. "Yes, we are witches."

"It seems you want to join the Witch Alliance," the guard assumed laughingly. "Please wait here. I'll report to the higher-ups immediately."

“Wait? No, this is –”

“That’s right. Then we will stay here and wait.” Tilly stretched out her hand to interrupt Ashes, “Furthermore, can you tell me what those people there are busy with?”

“Oh them, they are repairing the dock. Due to the abrupt snow, there were a lot of things which have gotten messed up, but in the end I really don’t know much about what is going on over there.”

When the guard stepped back to his post, Ashes asked puzzled, “Why didn’t you inform him about your identity?”

“Aren’t you curious? Aren’t you wondering how he would receive a witch from another city?” Tilly told her with a wink.

It didn’t take long until a tall woman dressed completely in white to come over. She had long blonde hair and her looks were impeccable. Even without having seen her magic, Tilly could feel a piercing vigor coming from her body, just like a sharp unsheathed blade.

There was no doubt, that the woman in front of them was a combat witch, and a very powerful one at that.

“I really thought that you were new witches who want to join the Witch Alliance. Haven’t you already gone back to Sleeping Island?” She first said as she looked at Ashes, before sweeping her gaze over the rest of the crowd. When her eyes finally fell on Tilly she showed an expression of surprise for a moment before the sharp feeling suddenly disappeared, to be replaced by water-like warmth.

“Hello, my name Nightingale,” she nodded in greeting. “I presume, you must be Tilly Wimbledon, His Highness Roland’s younger sister.”

Chapter 327

Chapter 327 The reason

“Lady Tilly!”

Guided by Nightingale to the lord’s castle, the 5th princess never expected that the first person to greet her would be Sylvie. She ran over cheerfully, skipping the salute and instead bent over to give her a hug, “How come you’re here, it’s still autumn.”

“It’s no different from winter now,” Tilly laughed, “Where are the others?”

“Lotus is currently building houses for the refugees, Evelyn and Candle are still in the industrial area, and Honey is in the back-garden busy training messengers.” Sylvie counted on her fingers, “His Highness has already sent people to go inform them.”

“Don’t worry, I think you’ll be able to see them soon.” A familiar, yet strange voice came from behind Sylvie.

Tilly raised her head and saw a gray-haired man with a big smile on his face, his appearance was not much different from her memories, his smile and his demeanor however were completely unlike in the past.

“Welcome to Border Town, my dear sister.”

…

Tilly’s thoughts were in turmoil, there were too many suspicions she wanted to blurt out, but she kept a straight face as she followed Roland Wimbledon into a room that looked like a study.

“Please sit,” the other side said as he poured a glass of warm black tea and placed it in front of her. “A whole year has gone by since the last time we’ve seen each other. I know you’ve had a lot of things you want to talk to me

about, it's the same with me… but there's no need to hurry." He looked at the falling snow outside the window and continued to say, "The winter is still very long."

She grabbed the cup, and wordlessly sat down by the mahogany table, quietly sizing up the fourth prince.

Even with only the opening remarks Tilly felt that it wasn't something she could ever imagine her timid and cowardly brother to say. He had always appeared strong on the outside but was actually weak on the inside. He was always looking for the fastest way of escape, never wanting to face an issue directly. The Roland Wimbledon before her was completely different. He was trying to take the initiative of the conversation, and despite his soft and gentle tone, he completely showed the demeanor of a person fully comfortable in his place as a leader.

"Nightingale," Roland tilted his head.

"But Your Highness…" the guiding witch's voice came from somewhere within the room.

"It doesn't matter, she is my little sister."

"Very well," Nightingale was silent for a moment, then her body appeared, before she unhappily left the room.

"Now the only people here is you and me," he laughed a little as he returned to the table.

Tilly was silent for a while, "In the end, who… are you really?"

She thought that the other party would hesitate or pretend to be mysterious, never would she expect that he would answer her so quickly, "I am your older brother, Roland Wimbledon, Graycastle's 4th Prince." Then he laughed, "I know I changed a lot, but I'm willing to explain it to you slowly."

Tilly suddenly remembered what he had written in the latter. 'As for what let me make this decision, and what made me no longer indifferent to this as I

was in the past, these small trifling things can be slowly discussed at a later opportunity.' It probably had been this sentence that prompted her to decide to come to this remote town.

She couldn't help but open her mouth, "I'd be happy to hear what you have to say."

The whole story wasn't complicated, but was very exciting. After Roland told her of his experiences after being given Border Town, Tilly discovered that her cup had long since been emptied. She let out a long breath, then reviewed his story once again. Simply put, a witch named Anna moved Roland, and through the saved witch, he became aware of the evil acts of the Church and the sinister lies they told the people. Then, with Garcia's assassination attempt it brought him to realize the dark side of the royal power, even when he hid in the corner of the kingdom he still would not be able to evade their viciousness, so finally he decided to change it all.

Even though this sounded somewhat dramatic, but with some difficulty, it could count as an acceptable explanation. However, there still remained the question about the strange knowledge, whether it's the steam engine or the guns, it's impossible that it came from a moment's perception and awareness.

"So, you are saying, that the ultimate cause of all this is the memories which suddenly appeared in your head?" Tilly asked.

"Indeed," Roland said honestly, "I know this is hard to believe, but it's a fact… After I luckily evaded 3rd sister's assassination attempt, that was when I woke up from the coma and came to realized these things. If we say that meeting Anna was the impetus, then the content of the memories was the driving force behind my wish to change the status quo."

Was it a witch? Tilly thought, the possibility of either replacement or control are both slim, Sylvie has already confirmed that the Witch Alliance's abilities weren't unknown, every day they would undergo a special practice, none of them have powers relating to those two areas, not even remotely.

The only possibility left was possession, she didn't eliminate the possibility that they had this kind of ability, which allowed them through invade and

occupy the body and obtain the other person's thoughts. But this speculation is equally uncertain, no matter how father thought about Roland, he is undoubtedly one of Graycastle's princes. Therefore, always wearing a God's Stone of Retaliation was normal for him, and there were always knights and personal guards around to protect him, which made it impossible for a witch who has no hiding ability to get close to him.

But, even with such a witch, how can she possibly know so many things that are out of the ordinary? When she was a child, Tilly besides liking to rummage through the Palace Library, she also received teaching from several white-haired, erudite and multi-talented court mentors, but even they had never talked about using the power of steam and snow powder to replace animal power and swords.

So it seemed that his quirky knowledge had something to do with his bizarre encounters.

"How will you prove that you are indeed Roland Wimbledon and not just the part which appeared with those extra memories?"

Tilly knew that this question was quite rude, if he were to act like the former 4th Prince she knew, he would undoubtedly have exploded into a rage by now, flipped over the table and stamped out of the room.

"Because I still remember the matters which happened on the court," the other party's tone remained calm. "I think it is a person's unique memory that distinguishes the essence of a person. If a well-known witch was to become exactly the same as you, with only her memories not the same, she would still essentially be another person. Even though I have a lot of strange memories, I do not remember where these came from. However, your weeping expression as you left me when I threw you onto the broken glass is still vividly embedded in my memory, so there is the proof." He paused, "Of course… I haven't had the time to apologize to you, but I still hope that it will not be too late."

Tilly fell silent, the Roland before her eyes wore a clean attire and an expression of sincerity. As if to tell her that it was needless to doubt since it was all true. Obviously, no matter from where she looked at him, the new

him was much better than the dandy Prince from before, but there were some doubts remaining within her heart.

“Truly… hard to believe.”

“That’s normal,” Roland said as if he had seen through her thoughts. “There are a lot of things which are unthinkable before you personally experience them. For me, I would never have expected my younger sister would have awaken as a witch, even concealing it from all the people within the palace. However… As I’ve said at the beginning, this winter is still very long, we will have a lot of time to slowly come to understand each other.”

It’s probably the best solution, at the moment, Tilly nodded, “Then for the next few months… I’m sorry to be troubling you.”

“Let me handle it, you’ll love it here.”

Chapter 328

Chapter 328 Formal talk

After Tilly had left his office, Roland finally breathed out in relieve.

Obviously, when in front of a smart person, having to hold serious conversation while also talking complete nonsense created a lot of pressure. Especially, if you want to maintain a sincere and genuine expression. Fortunately, Nightingale's report allowed him to take a breather – Roland took the fact that the witches from Sleeping Island have all returned to the castle as an opportunity to end the conversation.

"How come you don't have any special feelings when facing your younger sister who's become a witch?" Nightingale said as she turned around to sit on the table, occupying a high ground to overlook the prince.

He rolled his eyes and ill-humoredly said, "Can't feeling strong pressure also be regarded as a special feeling?"

"I thought it was a touching reunion," Nightingale said, curling her lips.

"Previously I didn't have a good relationship with her," Roland sighed. "During the time we lived in the palace, I used to bully her. Later when we grew up we both became estranged from one another, so it was an unexpected pleasure for her to come here."

"Oh?" Nightingale said meaningfully, "It is unlike you to confront an unfamiliar witch alone, as I see it you are quite trusting of her."

That's because I didn't want you to see me lying, Roland decided it would be better not to answer, instead he refilled his cup and leaned back in his chair slowly sipping a mouthful.

"In short… you will come to understand it later."

Nightingale reached out, touching his lips, “You will tell me everything, won’t you?”

“…Yes.”

“I’ll take that as a promise then,” she laughed and disappeared.

Roland leaned back against his chair, recalling his whole conversation with Tilly, searching for any possible flaw – he had given her the “most appropriate” explanation that he could think of. Many years of work experience had told him, the more exaggerated a lie, the lower the possibility that it would survive speculation. Therefore, deliberately hiding one’s clumsiness during childhood to save face, accidentally finding ancient books, or meeting a hermit who taught him were the kinds of lies that would be easily exposed as long as the other side kept on asking. Furthermore, in addition to being his sister, the other side was also from a witch organization, thus every lie exposed before we form a stable relationship could bring on a heavy blow to our mutual trust.

So he chose to tell the truth about the parts that could be uncovered and explained the additional from a sudden appearance of new memories – even though it sounded incredible, but in contrast to an even more incredible thought of crossing overit at least did not have too many negative consequences and also couldn’t be claimed to be false. If the latter event was to take place, it wouldn’t be certain whether or not she could come to accept a complete stranger from another world.

As long as he insisted on his identity as Graycastle’s 4th Prince there would be no way to deny it. Furthermore, Roland believed that all she had wanted was to hear an explanation personally from his mouth. Within his heart, he knew, that a good leader shouldn’t entangle themselves with the past, instead the most important thing would be to move towards the future. The winter would allow him to show her the vast prospects that the Western Region held so as to ensure their cooperation, only then would this be seen as a successful first meeting. As for the relationship between her and him, there would be a lot of time to repair it in the future.

That evening, they hold a grand banquet in the castle hall.

Not to mention the commonly seen pepper steak, fried egg, and white bread there were also all kinds of liquor on display, sweet smelling fried bird kiss mushrooms, steamed dumplings as well as ice cream. With the desire to bring the taste of the dishes to a new level, he simultaneous introduced the concept of fancily arranged sampler platter. Placing small pieces from the main dishes on top of a big china plate and sprinkle it with soy paste, creating an excellent visual effect that entices everyone who sees it to reach out for it.

Crisscrossing their wine cups under the sparkling candle light, the dinner finally ended with a warm and lively atmosphere.

That was when the more formal talk started.

Within the living room in front of a burning fireplace, Roland and the members of the Witch Alliance sat in a long row of seats, while Tilly and the other witches of Sleeping Island sat in the opposite row. Maggie however, because of her sensitive role, had simply turned into her pigeon form and squat down on the chandelier above their heads.

Tilly took the lead and started the discussion: “I, in addition to wanting to help Border Town resist the invasion of demonic beasts, also intend to send back the first batch of five witches.” She summarized Sleeping Island’s current situation, “Next spring, Silver Moon Bay are going to send us a group of ordinary immigrants to the island, so we will have to rely on Lotus and Honey to prepare extra food and housing for them in advance.”

Roland got a headache, if he wanted to resist the invasion of the demonic beasts the First Army would be enough. With the exception of nimble and extremely fast types of mixed species, there was hardly any situation which demanded that they send out witches.

But in the construction area, the role of the witch was irreplaceable. At the moment, the path through the mountains toward the new sea hasn’t yet been opened, the dock was only halfway constructed and he would still like to build additional cave dwellings for the newest batch of immigrants. Thus, he decided to ask, “Can you delay their journey for half a month?”

“I wish I could agree, but circumstances have changed,” Tilly reluctantly shook her head, “We have already met with Sea Ghosts in the southern part of the Vortex Sea, which are fish type demonic beast. I suspect that this has to do with the advanced beginning of the Months of Demons. According to legends, the longer the Months of Demons is, the more aggressive and fearsome the demonic beasts will be. Therefore, they will have to travel as soon as possible, if we want to guarantee a relatively safe trip.

“They are not fit to fight.”

“I know, that’s also the reason why Breeze will escort the ship – her ability is very effective against mentally inferior enemies, we also don’t intend to return in the same way we came. Instead, we’ll be sailing northward along the coastline until we can reach Port of Clear Water. From there we will take the usual trade route to Sleeping Island. According to recently arrived messenger birds, there haven’t been any demonic beasts detected on the routes between the Fjords and the Four Kingdoms.

Roland still had to make at least one final effort, “Uh … So, besides Lotus and Honey, would it be possible for the other three to stay? Currently, they are only halfway through their Primary Education, so leaving now would be the equivalent to them giving up halfway…”

“Puff Haha,” Tilly couldn’t suppress her laughter, “It seems you are quite interested in them.”

“…” he did not know how to respond to this statement.

“I would like to know how you are planning to use Candle’s and Evelyn’s ability?”

“Curing metal parts and brewing, the former can greatly improve the efficiency of mechanical operation, the latter well…” Roland slightly paused, “Wine is a very good thing, there are many other uses to it besides drinking.”

“Well, on Sleeping Island they’ve always been worried that there wouldn’t be an actual use for their ability, furthermore, they were also often…” Tilly

didn’t elaborate further, but Roland could already speculate that she was actually talking about discrimination. The same experience Mystery Moon had to face during her time with the Witch Cooperation Association. “I am very happy to hear that you want them so urgently to stay. Sure enough, every witch has their own unique and unmatched role, and it doesn’t make the least sense that their ability would be meaningless.” She looked at Evelyn and the others and asked, “What do you think?”

“I want to follow you, Lady Tilly,” Sylvie stated.

I…” Candle touched her head, “Am willing to go anywhere.”

“Lady Tilly, if you need me, I will go back to Sleeping Island,” Evelyn fell silent for a moment before she continued to say, “Otherwise, I would like to stay in Border Town. I… there are still so many things that I hope to learn from Teacher Scroll.”

“Don’t be so nervous, I’m not forcing you to choose if you want to stay or go – it isn’t a two choice question,” Tilly smiled and shook her head. “I just want to know what you think about living in Border Town. You can return to Sleeping Island at any time. The same is true for Lotus and Honey, it is unlikely that they will leave forever. I even hope to invite the witches from Border Town to come to Sleeping Island. We hope that through our efforts, whether it be the North or the South, in the future all witches should be free to live where they want. Don’t you think so too, Elder Brother?”

Roland was slightly shocked, this was the first time he had heard her addressing him like this. Even within the memories of the 4th Prince, it was also more than a decade ago. He smiled and nodded, “There will definitely be a day like this.”

Chapter 329

Chapter 329 Clarion

After coming to an agreement, Roland cleared his throat and continued in a serious tone, “Next there is some news regarding the Devils and the ruins.”

He informed Tilly about Border Town’s recent discoveries within the Concealing Forest and behind the snow-capped mountain, “I’d intended to send witches and soldiers of the First Army to bring the trapped person back to Border Town, but the heavy snow arriving more than a month ahead of time has messed up my plan.”

“That the Devil’s legendary army was in such close proximity, and that there are still some people left within the ruins from more than four hundred years ago…” Tilly became dumbstruck in amazement, “I’m slowly starting to believe what you’ve told me…”

Anna looked at Roland and he coughed twice, “According to the scene we observed and the reaction shown, it seems that the Devils must have been behind the snow-capped mountain for many years already. I suspect that they are limited to the area covered by the red fog, and thus unable to continue their expansion toward the Four Kingdoms. So, for now I don’t think that they will be a threat to Border Town. Within the next two years, I will set up a coastal warning point to monitor their movements.” He paused, “As for the woman sealed in the remains of the tower, she might know the truth behind the Holy City Taqila and the utter defeat of the Church.”

“I have the same thoughts,” Tilly closed her eyes and pondered about it, “Is there any way to avoid taking a land route, could we perhaps reach it directly from the air? Ashes told me that you have a tool that can be driven by hot air.”

“You want to bring her out of ruins now, in the middle of the Months of Demons?” Roland asked, full of disbelief, “The number of people which can

board the hot air balloon is ten, or if we exchange it for a bigger one, we could perhaps expand the number of people to fifteen. However, no matter how many we are, if we encounter the Devils we are likely to suffer casualties. Furthermore, there is also the risk which comes from encountering roaming demonic beasts… it's too dangerous.

"If you only depend on the Witch Alliance, it will indeed be very dangerous," Tilly agreed, "But Shavi and Ashes are here now. With them the degree of danger will be reduced by a lot. According to your previous statement, the Devil's current attack patterns is throwing spears from a far off distance and using the same amount of strength as an extraordinary. If it is like this, then Shavi's invisible barrier can block several spears, while Ashes could suppress the enemy during close combat. Right now the Months of Demons is still in its early stages, so the power of the demonic beasts is still not that strong, if you want to go to the ruins, now would be the best opportunity."

Roland felt a little hesitant, the last fight with the Devils was also an air battle which had been to their disadvantage so if he wanted to fly over there he felt quite unstable within his heart. But the words Tilly had said also made sense. Sylvie's magic eye could ensure that they would discover the enemy first. Furthermore, as long as they maintained an altitude of 10 to 15 meters, flying only a bit above the tree-top, he had confidence that they could reach the ground before the enemy spotted them. Then with Nightingale's and Ashes' powerful offensive abilities, defeating a group of around ten Devils would easily be accomplished. Even if there were some who managed to slip through the net, the double protection of from Shavi's and Anna's shields should be able to assure the team's safety.

After irresolutely muttering to himself for a short period he asked, "Are you really sure you want to go?"

"I feel that this might be an opportunity to unravel the mystery," Tilly said frankly, "This year's advanced start for the Months of Demons and the Sea Ghost emerging from the Southern Sea Vortex is always giving me a bad feeling."

Roland's heart skipped a beat, this feeling he also knew quite well. The early start of the Months of Demons was unlikely to be abnormal phenomena caused by climate change, he faintly felt that it had something to do with the Devils and the Church.

"In that case, who will fill the ranks?"

"I do not know which witches Border Town will send, but I will be going," Tilly declared without hesitation.

…

As far as the eye could see snowflakes were dancing in the air under the gray sky, after repelling the last attack Mayne and Tayfun unhurriedly boarded Hermes' city wall.

Some of the snowflakes landed in the black and warm blood river flowing at the foot of the wall, diluting the thick blood as it melted. Fortunately, all this blood belonged to the enemy, while hundreds of soldiers from the God's Punishment Army stood straight along the wall and were waiting for the launch of the next wave of demonic beasts.

"Your Excellencies, Sir!" the shoulders of the Army of Judges who assisted the God's Punishment Army shouted while placing their fists on their chest. Most of their faces appeared to be somewhat young and tender, but their eyes also held two distinct emotions, fear and excitement.

"It seems that some of them are still children," Tayfun commented after reaching an open space and overlooking the wilderness, then he sighed and continued, "When I was their age, I was still milling flour for some nobles."

"The priority of the God's Punishment Army is to protect the New Holy City while parts of the Army of Judges that are more experienced are still caught up in Wolfsheart City cleaning up the last remaining evil elements. Those people are only recently promoted believers, they have never been on a real battlefield before," Mayne explained, "The snow has come too early."

Tayfun hesitated before he asked, “There isn’t such a situation mentioned within the Holy Book?”

“The Holy Book is also only written by the Pope, so it’s unavoidable that there would be some parts that are overlooked that will appear,” the bishop said as he leaned against the ice-cold wall while overlooking the pile of corpses at the foot of the steep cliff. Ordinary demonic beasts would never be able to climb up such a steep wall, the only ones that could threaten the Holy City were the mixed species, “It’s fine as long as it can point out the general direction we need to follow. From the demonic beasts which have appeared, it can be inferred that there are still approximately ten years remaining.”

“Using two years to unify the Four Kingdoms and spending the remaining eight years to build up the God’s Punishment Army, by then the Church should have a large contingent of more than ten thousand people.” After stopping for a moment he went on to say, “Using the firm walls and Hermes’ terrain, we will stick to this plateau until the enemy’s strength reverses.”

“I’m old, I’m afraid I won’t be able to see that day come.”

“It’s unrelated to age, Your Excellency Tayfun,” Mayne said in a comforting tone, “There are many people who are unable to see that moment, like Allan, Stone, Liji…”

“And Heather,” Tayfun added.

“Yes, and Heather.” He nodded, “but in any case, there will always be people who will carry on our mission and continue to move forward.”

“Do not say such discouraging words,” the old man shook his head, but then smiled as he asked, “Wait, was Zero able to get a hold on the fierce snow powder formula? Did the Pivotal Secret Area already start their test?”

“Mortal’s toys aren’t of any help to the Church,” Mayne said full of disdain, “It may be possible to use snow powder to clean up a group of demonic beasts, but our real enemies are the Devils from hell. Used in an open area it lethality will be greatly reduced, if you want to create a force strong enough

to break the Devil's heavy armor, you are going to need a very large amount of it. In addition, besides the soldiers from the God's Punishment Army there is no one who could go out and throw half a body-sized bag of snow powder over a great distance.

"It's like that? What a pity."

"If you want to beat the Devils, there is no time to play tricks," Mayne said stressing each word, "Only by confronting them head-on will we be able to survive."

At this moment, from the watchtower to the side of them came the sound of a long horn blow.

One long horn blow stood for an invading wave of demonic beasts.

"Let's go back to the cathedral since there is going to be another fight soon."

"Okay," Tayfun nodded and turned around to go as the horn sounded again.

Woo-woo

Two long sounds meant that the wave of demonic beasts contained a lot of mixed species. Hearing this Mayne's heart quickened, it was undoubted that the God's Punishment Army would have to face a fierce battle.

But… why is it so fast? This is only the first month of the Months of Demons, ah.

However, just as the horn sound ended the third one already rang up. An oppressive and unbroken sound like the sudden clap of thunder, rolling over Hermes for a long time without subsiding.

Woowoo – woo –

Mayne almost couldn't believe his ear, looking at Tayfun, he saw that the other's face looked as shocked as he felt himself. Three horn blows stood for a very urgent situation, a situation at which Hermes' survival stood at stake! Even last time, when the demonic beasts were able to reach the outskirts of

the cathedral, it wasn't a situation where the blows have reached that number.

What did the watchman see?

It wasn't long until Mayne got his answer.

Within the black tide of demonic beasts were two strangely formed enormous beasts. They possessed four thick fangs, four feet, and two hands. Their bodies were covered in pitch-black fur and one foot alone already possessed the size of a mixed wolf species. From afar, those two beasts looked like moving fortresses. With every step they took they left a deep mark in permafrost covered plains. If those demonic beasts which surrounded them were not avoided on time they would be smashed into the ground by their feet and turned into a pool of flesh and blood.

There were several records of them within the Holy Book, The Death's Herald, the Hell's Nightmare, the Devil's fangs… But what Mayne feared the most wasn't their terrible appearance, but what they represented.

Why? His mind was completely occupied by horror. Why are those terror striking monsters, which according to the Holy Book should only appear five years before the disaster already appearing at Hermes right now?

Chapter 330

Chapter 330 Farewell

The next day, Roland bid Lotus and Honey farewell in the castle backyard.

Even though the two women didn't want to leave so soon, but when he heard that the Charming Beauty and its crew were still waiting at the beach he decided not to delay their departure any further. In this way he could show off his magnanimity, and keep from causing Tilly any further embarrassment. Putting himself into her shoes he had to recognize that even though she needed to finish their large scale construction on Sleeping Island first, the fact that they will continue to send the all important witches to Border Town still counted as a sincere gesture on their part. Since their situation was already like this he also couldn't be too demanding.

In order to to avoid a long journey through the snow, Anna and Wendy would be there to send them off using Cloud Gazer, in so doing they could easily reduce the travel time to reach the beach to thirty minutes.

"Thank you for taking care of us these past few months," the two witches said while bowing in front of Roland.

"It should be me thanking you," Roland said laughingly. "You two have made many contributions towards the construction of Border Town, so I have gifts I would like to give to you."

"G-gift?" Lotus said with her cheeks having turned slightly red from embarrassment.

While Honey touched her chest and looked over at Lotus' and then excitedly asking: "Will we also get them?"

Roland took two bags from Nightingale and handed it over to them, "Yes you can have them."

Unable to wait any longer, Honey opened the gift and pulled out a long white cloth, “Hey, what is this? It isn’t a corset.”

“Keke, it’s a scarf,” he stepped forward, took the fabric made of cotton from her before wrapping it around her neck, “This way, you won’t need to be afraid of the wind and snow pouring onto your neck. Wrap it around a bit higher and you can even cover your ears with it.”

“Hmm… nice and warm,” the latter cried out with a contented face.

It was unsure whether this was an illusion, but it seemed that Lotus’ face had became even redder.

“There’s more,” Honey said after having played with the scarf for a moment, she then took out a small box from the bag and asked, “Your Highness, is this also a gift?”

“Yes, open it and take a look.”

“Wow, it is so clear!” She jubilantly exclaimed after lifting up the top of the box, “Lotus, come and take a look, you can clearly see for yourself!”

It was a small mirror embedded in a wooden box, a gift which was also available at the convenience market. In Roland’s life experience, as long as they were women, there was no way they would be able to resist such a sparkling present.

Honey’s voice, which was filled with excitement, immediately attracted the other witches, and so the Sleeping Island’s witches clustered in a group. They used the mirror to look at their own appearance and couldn’t help but show an undisguised love and envy towards it. After all, the image reflected by the mirror made using Soraya’s reflective coating was far better than a silver mirror, which also allowed Roland to discover a new way he could bribe them.

After the gifts were all handed out and the hot air balloon fully inflated. The group boarded the basket and waved their goodbyes to Roland and the other

witches. On seeing this scene, it seemed that now that they were about to leave town they have started to feel a slight bit reluctant to parting ways.

“I can’t help but admit that this is indeed a good place,” Tilly came over to him and whispered, “With a convenient water supply and comfortable rooms. It’s very difficult to believe that in just one year you were able to transform such a desolate place into its current appearance.”

“Do you regret it?”

“You mean that I’ve sent the witches to your town?” She laughed, “How could that be? As long as they can live a better life, how could I ever regret it? Do not forget, I too am a witch.”

In the white garden, Tilly’s smile was pure and beautiful, not a trace of color to be seen. If he had a younger sister like this in his previous life, he would have caused a 100% rate for turning heads if he were to bring her out. But Roland knew, compared to her identity as his sister, his actual relationship with her was more like a partner, a natural ally. From yesterday’s decision he could already see that she wouldn’t hesitate to take on personal risks to deal with any possible threats .

“Do you really intend to go to such a dangerous place?” Roland asked her, “Although you are an exceptional witch, in the end, your ability isn’t suited towards fighting.”

“Do not worry, it isn’t as if I don’t have any self-protection ability,” Tilly said as she stretched out her hands, showing him the ornaments she wore. On the ring finger of her left hand, she carried a blue crystal ring, while on her right hand she wore a white silk glove with a red gem embedded in the back. To be honest Roland had to acknowledge that this collection looked a bit strange clothing looked similar to the asymmetrical mix and match style of dress used by artist of the later generations. He had been very curious about this since yesterday, but out of courtesy had kept from asking.

“It is a magic stone. This one, in particular, is the magic stone we found within the ancient ruins,” she explained, “After putting your magic into it, it

can display all kinds of abilities. For example, this ring allows me to fly like Lightning."

After she spoke, as if to prove her words, her feet lifted from the ground. As if her whole body had turned weightless, she stayed suspended in midair which had given Roland quite a shock.

A witch's ability can actually change through a magic stone?

He soon realized the significance this held.

If it was possible to order custom-made abilities in batches, a witch's work efficiency would increase drastically. For example, Lotus', if the Witch Union could have several magic stones with a copy of her ability the construction of the temporary residential area could be completed within a single day.

When Tilly landed back on the ground, she pointed at an open space with her right hand, and soon after Roland saw a bright light flaring from her fingertips. After hitting the snow it left an ankle deep bowl shaped hole which revealing the dark earth of the ground.

"Does this mean you can use both abilities at the same time?" Roland asked in surprise.

"No," Tilly shook her head, "Within a certain range, the magic stone allows you to use one ability. If I push magic simultaneously into two stones nothing would happen," she smiled, "Originally, I didn't intend to reveal this information to you this early on, but after our conversation from last night, I've come to think that I might have misunderstood you… The fact that you've honestly told me about what had happened in the ancient ruins, made me happy… but also a little apologetic."

"No harm, I can understand where you're come from."

"Oh that's right, there is still something I want to ask you, what is this corset Honey just mentioned?"

Roland almost choked on his own saliva, “Keke, I have no idea… maybe you should go and ask Sylvie or Evelyn about it.”

“Well,” Tilly shrugged, “It seems you still have some reservation towards me.”

For some time, the Prince didn’t know what to say.

With a wink, she said, “Let’s not talk about this for now. Since last night I’ve had a problem I’ve been thinking something, it these sites really did belong to the Church why would they leave these magic stones behind? According to what happened to Ashes, it is most likely that the Church is raising their own group of witches. Thus, these items should also have the a similar importance to them. Even if they wanted to deliberately bury knowledge of the war after being forced to flee from the Devils, it wouldn’t hinder them from continuing to use these stones, it just doesn’t make sense.”

“Does that mean the Church doesn’t care about this loss at all?” Roland thought aloud, only to quickly reject his conjecture, “No, they should not be able to mass produce these magic stones, or it would have been completely impossible for the Witch Cooperation Association to flee. After all, if they had been able to fly, it would have been completely impossible to escape the Church’s witch hunt.”

“Indeed, I recall that I’ve found a very strange point when I looked through all the books in the palace library about the Church and their God… Not only does their historical records stop at around four hundred years ago, even their god’s origin is somewhat vague. He has no name, no epic legend, except for propagating his omnipotence there is nothing more, no more details. Compared with the Three Ancient Gods, he appears to be a vague notion with nothing to it. With those two points together, I can’t help it but feel that something is strange about all of this.”

“What?” Roland’s heart trembled with fear.

“It feels as if the Church just suddenly has appeared from out of nowhere.”

Chapter 331

Chapter 331 The Key to “Art”

‘It feels as if the Church just suddenly has appeared from out of nowhere.’

This sentence continued echoing through Roland’s mind as he was returning to his office.

He closed his eyes and carefully looked through the memories of the 4th Prince, but he still couldn’t find any relevant information about this. His understanding of the Church was the same as that of any other ordinary nobleman. During his time at the palace the 4th Prince never bothered spending that much effort in learning anything useful, so his knowledge concerning the occult was practically a full-on blank space. But, if what Tilly had said was true, then the Church’s propaganda strategy was also rather strange.

Taking his former world of religious myths, for example, since the beginning of the world there have always been gods and the routine everyone agreed on was that the gods were the ones who created the world. Stories such as the creation in seven days, karma, reincarnation, and so on… those were legends used to describe the power of the Gods and were a standard part of every religion.

Compared to them, the Church of this world was quite… lacking.

But Roland didn’t have any more clues to consider, so he shook his head and decided to put such thoughts behind him.

Maybe their questions would be answered when they went to explore the ruins within the Concealing Forest.

He went to the window and looked towards the garden where a huge coating was laid out on the ground – in the middle of the vast expanse of white snow its bluish green appearance seemed particularly eye-catching.

Nowadays Soraya was creating a bigger air sac, the new hot air balloon's volume would become much larger and would thus be able to transport a larger crowd of people. This was preparation in case they were unable to free the trapped woman when going to the ruins in the case that Anna wasn't able to cut-down the whole "ice-coffin" and bring the woman and some of the transparent stones back to Border Town.

They would depart in in two days.

The people that would be going along had already been decided. Tilly, Sylvie, Shavi, Ashes and Andrea would be from the Sleeping Island witches while the Witch Alliance would send Anna, Wendy, Nightingale, Nana, Lightning, and Maggie. This line-up could be said to be unprecedentedly powerful. Its attack, defense, and battlefield awareness were of the highest level, so as long as there was no God's Stone of Retaliation being used, the Devils wouldn't even have a chance of approaching them.

"Your Royal Highness, Chief Alchemist Sir Kyle Sichi wishes to see you," one of his personal guards said from the door.

"Let him in."

Kyle wasn't alone, this time he had come together with his colleague Chavez, "Your Royal Highness, the outline for your requested large-scale production of nitric acid has been completed."

"Really?" Roland stared blankly but soon after a burst of happiness flooded his heart. This was probably the best piece of news he had heard within these past few days. He stood up in excitement and personally poured a cup of tea for the two chemists as he asked, "Tell me, how did you manage it?"

"The credit for this belong to Chavez," he said laughingly, "so I will let him explain it."

"Your honorable Highness," the young Chavez bowed, seeming somewhat reserved as soon as he opened his mouth. "Your alchemical… no, the chemical reaction used in the laboratory to produce nitric acid is produced by distilling saltpeter to obtain diluted nitric acid and then it's purified with

concentrated sulfuric acid. I tried to put the two together by placing the saltpeter directly into the concentrated sulfuric acid for shared heating. By doing so I successfully obtained nitric acid, even more, its purity was very high, so much so that it was possible to observe the phenomenon of fuming which was spoken of within “Elementary Chemistry”.

“Shared heating? But combining those two isn’t the same,” Roland said baffled, “The temperature used for dry distillation is much higher than the temperature that is used for shared heating, the gas produced by the dry distillation should be nitrogen oxide. Only by bubbling it through water it would become diluted nitric acid. Concentrated sulfuric acid is only used for purification because of its high boiling point and its strong water absorption which in turn reduces the moisture content in the nitric acid, this doesn’t involve any sort of chemical reactions.”

“I myself also don’t quite understand why it happened, but Mr. Sichi, thinking that my discovery was merely a coincidence, then went and did a couple of experiments.”

“Coincidence?” Roland stared at the Chief Alchemist.

“Indeed,” Kyle said with certainty, “The two are not the same, but they still produced the same effect. Following the chemical formula, I guess that there is a component within the saltpeter that reacts with the sulfuric acid but evaporates in the heat, leaving only nitric acid behind. According to the formula, it looks like some kind of… well, nitrate.”

It suddenly occurred to Roland that the chemistry textbook did mention that before synthetic ammonia was invented, people had used nitric acid or potassium nitrate to react with concentrated sulfuric acid to produce nitric acid, this was also the oldest manufacture method known. Because the main ingredient of saltpeter were two different kinds of nitrate, it was, easy to obtain. Furthermore, the extraction was also relatively easy. So as long as the temperature could be controlled, they would have a steady stream of evaporated nitric acid to collect.

Of course, because this method consumed a large amount of sulfuric acid, and at the same time easily led to the corrosion of the equipment, it was later

replaced by more advanced technology.

But to Roland, these two points weren't much of a problem. After all, the fertilizer and pesticide industry hasn't been established yet, so the produced sulfuric acid could only be used for the purification of nitric acid. While Soraya's coatings could easily solve the problem brought from the strongly corrosive nitric acid steam.

"Well done," Roland said while happily patting Chavez's shoulder, "You were unexpectedly able to come up with such a method by chance."

"You're unaware of it, but his outstanding luck has already revealed itself within Redwater City's Alchemic Workshop," Kyle Sichi said as he raised an eyebrow. "Before learning chemistry, the exploration of alchemy was something which relied on luck. Within his early twenties, this kid had already discovered the double acid preparation method and had become the youngest alchemist within the workshop, that was enough to turn the eyes of the other thirty to forty years old apprentices red with envy. You can imagine how most of them will be stuck as apprentices for the rest of their lives."

"Anyway, this is good news for the town," Roland praised. "First, you should try to make a batch of equipment to examine it further, I will let a witch cooperate with you. If feasible, we will then expand the scale of production."

"As you will."

"Alright, I still have another task to give you," Roland said, putting away his joyful expression and continuing in a solemn tone, "Now that we will have a reliable source of nitric acid, I will need you to produce something that is very dangerous – nitroglycerin."

"How dangerous is it?" Kyle asked.

"It is actually very simple to use the raw materials, namely, letting concentrated nitric acid react with glycerol, supplemented with concentrated sulfuric acid to act as a catalysator. However, during the reaction process you must strictly control the temperature and the ventilation. Since the

nitrification produces a lot of heat, it would also be best to put the container into iced water for the experiment. Bear in mind that alteration between hot and cold, vibrations, impacts, or friction might lead to it exploding." Roland didn't know how reliable his amateur knowledge would be in the end, but the ingredients were undoubtedly correct, so even if there was likely to be some danger, it was still something he had to try. "During the experiment, it will be alright to merely use a small amount of ingredients, so that in case a mishap occurs Lady Nana should still be able to heal you."

"This…" Chavez opened his mouth to answer, but even before he could say another word, Kyle had already given his promise, "I understand, and its power is something comparable to snow powder?"

"It's entirely different."

"It looks like an interesting experiment." The Chief Alchemist said and laughed.

So it's true that nine out of ten chemists are explosion maniacs… Roland thought.

Nitroglycerin is extremely unstable, Nobel especially added diatomaceous earth to it to make it blunter and this increased its safety. However, while this did, in fact, improve its safety, it also reduced its explosive power. Naturally, Roland wouldn't be using that classical method. instead, he intended to add nitrocellulose or nitrostarch into the nitroglycerin, both of which could stabilize it while further enhance the explosive effect. The former would make an excellent smoke-free explosive, while the latter would produce a stronger explosion. From their names alone it could already be seen that a lot of nitric acids would be key in the evolution of black powder into gunpowder.

And now he was in the possession of that very key.

Chapter 332

Chapter 332 What one has seen and heard

In the days before they would set out to explore the ruins Tilly's greatest interest was slowly strolling along the flat streets of Border Town, observing the remote territory which had already undergone such startling changes in the hands of Lord Roland.

This small town stands out from the masses, she thought, the more carefully she observed everything, the more she became aware of this. It was entirely different from any other place she had been to before… and what left her the most impressed was probably the gorgeous and unparalleled vitality which this small town radiated.

Even the up-and-coming Sleeping Island couldn't compare with it.

"Aren't these people afraid of the cold?" Andrea said, full of amazement at seeing the pedestrian coming and going on the street. "What did your brother do that they'd be willing to work during the winter?"

"It's still autumn," Ashes retorted, "You can't even tell different season apart."

"But there is no difference between the current weather and winter. This is analogous with the argument which frequently appears within 'her dream, his country'," Andrea elegantly raised her long hair and said, "Of course, a barbaric woman such as you would never understand something like this."

"What's 'your dream, my dream'…"

"It is difficult to communicate with a vulgar person who hasn't ever even enjoyed the drama, but Lady Tilly must surely have watched this famous drama from the Kingdom of Dawn."

“There is no need for you to fight,” Sylvie sighed. “I think the reason behind this is quite simple. Usually the common folk do not want to be active during winter because it would increase food consumption greatly, in case they can’t eat their fill it would be very easy for them to catch a cold. However, this issue doesn’t exist in Border Town. The price of grain isn’t high, firewood is also quite abundant, and Miss Lily is easily able to cure a cold. It would therefore be better if they continued to work hard even within the cold and snow, and try to earn one more day’s salary.”

“I am able to understand that there would be enough firewood due to the Concealing Forest West of the town, but the reason for the price of grain not being high… how is that possible?” Andrea asked feeling puzzled, “My family has also been involved in the food business so I know that crop failures caused by natural disasters could lead to everyone raising the price of grain by a lot. With such a bad weather, how could he keep the nobles and merchants from selling food at a higher prices?”

“Nobles, merchants?” Sylvie asked laughingly, “Here in Border Town, there is only one person who is allowed to sell grain, that is His Royal Highness.”

“All those fields along the river belong to him?” Tilly frowned.

“No, that’s the land of the serfs,” she told her what she had seen and heard, as well as the scene occurring during the bumper harvest. “He made two food prices, one was the purchase price and one was the selling price. Those two prices are fixed, with the latter being higher than the former.”

“Isn’t he forcing them to sell low and buy high?” Ashes asked while showing an expression of disbelief, “If he can sell at a high price, why won’t he allow others to sell it at high prices as well?”

“No, it’s not the same,” Tilly said, “After the wheat is taken in, it also needs to be threshed, ground and stored in a warehouse. All this produces further cost, thus it’s normal for the price to rise.”

“What Lady Tilly said is right. I had the same question, so I later asked Teacher Scroll about it,” Sylvie smiled, “She said that the extra expenses were paid off, some were paid to those who deal with the farmers, it is also

used to build new granaries so that the production can be expanded, which in turn will provide Border town with new…" she stopped for a moment, thinking about the right word to use, "Jobs, right, that's what she called them. I heard that His Highness was very concerned about that."

"But he is still buying weak selling strong," Ashes stressed, "Shouldn't trade be free?"

"Perhaps, but His Highness' selling price is at a rate that still allows everyone to buy it. Furthermore, if the price stays constant, people will also become more comfortable."

"Sometimes freedom isn't always for the best," Tilly said, she already had a clear idea of what Roland was doing. The rule prohibiting anyone else from selling grain within the territory might at first seem overbearing and unjust. But in fact, it put an end to hoarding and profiteering, which could effectively prevent any events of food shortage. If it was King's City, which had to face times of snow during autumn, the food prices would inevitably rise up to five or six times more than usual with more than half of the populace starving due to not having enough grain to eat. If the situation went on for long enough, it could easily cause riots, and eventually, the palace might even be forced to release grain from their own reserves or dispatch the guards to suppress them. Either way, it would still be a big burden on the state's treasury.

Although this policy looked good, it also wouldn't work just anywhere. The majority of the grain traders were aristocrats and rich merchants who also owned large amounts of serfs and fields, making it impossible for the royal family to buy out all the grain and prohibit people from hoarding. However, here in Border Town, except for Roland Wimbledon, there was almost no other aristocratic family around, he was indisputably the one who had the final say in such things.

When Tilly expressed her own opinion, Ashes still hold some grievances, "What about the serfs? They normally would get more income when the grain price rise, but now they get exploited by fixed prices."

"Pfft," Andrea laughed, "As if these people could escape the same exploitation if they were in a city with free trade. At times of bumper harvest,

not only wouldn't they be told to hand over more wheat, they'd even be told to sell it at a very low price. Yet when there is a poor harvest, they'd still have to pay their share, while it would still be a question whether the grain leftover would be enough for them to survive the famine. In contrast, fixed prices are actually more reasonable, as long as the harvest is better, the income should also be better."

"Here they can choose whether they want to sell." Sylvie's words slightly shocked the other three, "His Highness said that in case where the harvest reached a fixed amount, the serfs could be promoted to free people. From then on they can either continue farming or go and choose new jobs, completely according to their own will. However, free people would only need to pay 2/10 of their grain. Furthermore, according to this year's bumper harvest's price, their salary was also very impressive."

"Pro…moted?"

"Uh, His Royal Highness said that after two or three years there won't be any serfs left in Border Town."

So, actually it was like this, Tilly's heart was suddenly touched by what she had heard. That's the reason why the town is full of vitality… When he made his policies, he considered the people's way of thinking and added an incentive system to encourage them to work more and better. This way of handling things is completely different from any other noble. Motivation isn't only expressed through words, rather, he let the people achieve some tangible benefits through hard work instead of hiding his wealth in the castle treasury.

At this moment, she finally understood the real meaning of those red slogans at the river side.

However, the Roland Wimbledon in the royal palace was never such a generous person… So, is this also something brought forth by the sudden change in memory? In addition, those evening lessons of "Elementary Nature", and "Mathematics" are very fascinating too.

Tilly had believed that it would be difficult for her to find something new to stimulate her curiosity and interest after she had finished reading all the books in the palace library, but she now had discovered there were still many things left for her to learn.

Within her heart, she suddenly felt that even doing nothing more than just live in Border Town's castle and flip through all those books filled with miraculous knowledge while watching the changes around the Town… it would still be a very enjoyable life.

Suddenly, a long ringing sound of a bell came over from the city wall, announcing a new demon beast attack.

Tilly immediately put her previous thoughts to the back of her mind, after all, nowadays, she was no longer the worry-free 5th Princes, but rather a leader shouldering the destiny of all the witches living on Sleeping Island. Now, some things could no longer be imposed solely according to her own preferences, thus she said, "Let's go to the wall and see if we can help the guards."

"Of course," Andrea smiled, "That's why we came here in the first place, so they can see how we Witches fight!"

Chapter 333

Chapter 333 The Defense Battle at the New City Wall

In that instant, the sound of the bells echoed. It was as if the emotions of the entire camp had been roused.

Van'er rushed out of the tent. Along with the stream of people, he rushed to the top of the wall with hurried steps and took his combat position. This series of maneuvers had already been rehearsed countless times. Even without someone to command them, everyone was aware of what they should do next.

It was the same as the Month of Demons last year. Under a state of alert, only a small patrol team would be assigned to each segment of the wall as two or three soldiers were enough to deal with the scattered demonic beasts. Only when the lookout post detects a large scale attack from the demonic beasts would an alarm be rung.

In the horizon, a shadow was approaching. Van'er did a rough calculation of the enemy's numbers and found that they numbered around a thousand. If this happened a year ago, what followed would absolutely be a bout of arduous fighting. Back then, as a pikeman responsible for buying some time so the Firearms team could reload, it was necessary for him to take turns rotating with a member that was in reserve. Only by doing that, would he be able to persist to the very end.

But now, the strength of this small town had already undergone an earth-shaking change.

Cat's claw removed the cover on the cannon and shook off the snow that had been collecting on it, while Rodney inspected every inch of the artillery's barrel. After confirming there was no foreign matters inside, he began to load it with gunpowder. Although the current city walls were altered and made using a pile of mud bricks, its height and width had been increased to a

certain extent. In addition, a shelling platform was set up every hundred meters, causing its defensive ability, as well as firepower, to improve greatly.

The width of the passageway allowed four people to fit through it side by side. During a battle, the first row would consist of soldiers from the firearms team, while the second row would then be recruits who would load up the guns. The latter group was responsible for putting bullets into the cylinder of a gun, then handing it over to the regular soldiers ahead of them.

“They just never get bored of this, do they?” Rodney yawned. “When the Month of the Demons arrives each year, all of them run towards this place like a bunch of lunatics. Even if they succeeded in attacking such a small town, they wouldn’t get any sort of benefits from it, right?”

“Well, they’re here just in time for us to hone our skills.” Horatio said with a smile. “Compared to immobile wooden targets, it’s more interesting to shoot at demonic beasts.”

“Speaking of target shooting, I recently heard an interesting rumor that had something to do with us, the gunner team.” Jop said with a mysterious expression.

“What sort of rumor is that?”

“From what I heard the people in other gunner groups say, the people that were able to hit their targets accurately would be incorporated into an elite gunner team, where they would undertake new tasks.” He paused for a moment. “Do any of you here have any more insider knowledge about this?”

“An elite gunner team?”

“How could it be possible for us to know more when even you, who proclaims yourself as experienced and knowledgeable about matters is clueless about it?”

“I bet it’s a cock and bull story made up by some bored person.”

Within the gunner group, only Van'er was silent. After listening to Jop's words, he couldn't help but furrow his brows. Someone had actually treated this matter as flaunt-worthy material and blabbered it out?

Sir Iron-axe had previously looked for him a week before and told him that His Royal Highness had intended to develop a new type of artillery. It would be completely different from the field gun they were currently using and would also not be dispatched for use in the First Army. Instead, it would be installed on the bridge, turning it into a warship that was capable of long distance attacks. The operators of the new artillery gun would be undertaken by the most outstanding members of the gunner team. If one wishes to be a member, they could send their application to Iron Axe.

It went without saying that Iron Axe agreed without the slightest hesitation. This was evidently a chance for him to advance a step further in the army. According to what Iron Axe said, His Royal Highness had an extremely high expectation towards this new branch of the army, to the point that it was possible for it to break away from the First Army and become a brand new army. If one is able to perform great feats, the new warships manufactured in the future would be named using that person's name too.

It was such a honor! If there were a warship named Van'er, he would be perfectly contented for the rest of his life. Recalling his origins, he was just an odd-job labourer in the mines, yet had always posed as someone extraordinary. In the end, Van'er was not able to save even his brother's life when he was in the slums of the stronghold. However, the current him no longer required to flaunt about anything. There was no need to worry about food or drinks in the army while the uniforms were thick and warm; Even when he returned to the district, the surrounding neighbours would greet him as well.

All of these changes were brought about by His Royal Highness.

When he recalled his decision to join the militia for an egg at that time, he felt it was simply the smartest choice he had made in his life.

Besides that, Iron-axe had also inquired whether he had any suitable candidates he wished to recommend and that he could apply together with

them when the time comes. In other words, it was possible for all of these youngsters to receive a life-changing opportunity, but since their personalities were still too energetic, it would be better to wait til they settled down first. Moreover, if they happen to lay down a big accomplishment, wouldn't the warships have to be called Jop, and Cat's claw too? Those names were simply horrendous to the ears…If it were the names Rodney or Nelson, then it could still be taken into consideration.

As for the matter of someone leaking out this information to their subordinates out of impulse, he still had to report and explain to Iron Axe. After all, it had been explained very clearly in their regulation class that any news of the First Army shouldn't be spread without permission unless clearly requested to by the higher ups.

"Stop making such a racket. I want all of you to bring your attention back to the battlefield." Van'er coughed twice, breaking off the discussion within the gunner's members. "Do not forget what Sir Iron Axe had repeatedly emphasized in class. Any lapses made could probably bring about an unsalvageable defeat."

"Understood!" Everyone spoke in unison.

As the killing rate of iron balls was extremely low, when dealing with packs of demonic beasts, canister shells were used to fire at them once they approach. At the moment when the sinister-looking wolves took the lead and crossed past the 100 meter line, the bombardment began.

Heatwaves swirled the snow underneath the gun muzzle, the gigantic boom shook Van'er's eardrums to the point that it hurt. In the distance, a black bloody mist suddenly rose and a field of demonic beasts instantly collapsed. No matter if it was a species of a boar or a bear, the pelts on their bodies were not sufficient to withstand the close quarter bombardment of iron pellets.

"There's a huge one over there." Cat's claw pointed to the left ahead of him. "It's a redskin wolf!'

A group of people nimbly moved the gun carriage and adjusted the muzzle, pointing it to the direction of the target. They then reloaded and fired it once more. In theory, it wasn't necessary to aim while using the canister shells. As long as it was fired while facing ahead, it would always mow down a large number of enemies. Furthermore, as the newly constructed clay walls were taller than the stone walls, there was also no way for the wolves to be of threat to the people at the top of the wall. They would only be practicing their target shooting if they preemptively attacked nimble beasts like that, that's all.

Next in line would finally be the firearm team that had been restraining themselves for a long time. In order to ensure a higher hit rate, they would always wait for them to come close to 50 meters before opening fire.

The sound of the revolver rifles weren't as unified as that time with the flintlocks. Rather, it was crowded together and continuous. On the top of the city wall, a wave of white smoke began to float upwards while the overpowering smell of gunsmoke wafted over, causing Van'er to uncontrollably sneeze.

"This bunch of morons. Even though their might is unacceptably weak, when they fire in unison, the smoke coming out from their rifles is much more overpowering than anything else." Jop said while grumbling.

"But ultimately, it is still the artillery which will decide the outcome of the war." Rodney expressed his approval.

"It's the same when we're dealing with knights, and would probably be the same when dealing with demonic beasts as well."

At this moment, a brief and hurried bell toll began to sound from the direction of the lookout post. This was the warning that a hybrid species of demonic beasts had been sighted.

Van'er squinted his eyes and looked ahead, only to see two massive shadows slowly making its way forward within the mist. From the looks of its size, it should be a siege beast that possessed a thick carapace.

“What did you say was coming earlier?” The corners of his mouth rose. “It’s now time for us to show off our worth, switch to solid tipped ammunition.”

In order to deal with enemies that had comparatively high defensive capabilities, the munitions factory had developed a new type of artillery shell that was capable of penetrating the carapace of an enemy at a range of roughly 200 meters. If the attack on the wolf-like demonic beasts was considered a warm-up exercise, the one at present would be considered the real deal.

“I want everyone to do a good job of it.” Van’er clapped his hand and said, “We will show the other gunner teams who the most skilled artillerymen are.”

Chapter 334

Chapter 334: Heart Stopper

After scaling up a corner of the city wall, Andrea was immediately greeted with an astonishing scene.

All she saw was a row of soldiers, dressed up as militia, standing on top of the wall grasping a strange, stick-like weapon in their hands—those are probably the firearms Ashes was talking about. Following the approach from the group of demonic beasts, flames as well as dense smoke erupted out from it, causing the sound of continuous explosions to echo in her ears.

That ought to be a type of weapon similar to the crossbow, but she couldn't see the bolts that were shot out by the other side, probably due to the large cloud of smoke and dust. The demonic beasts that were charging at the very front of the pack acted as if they had been ruthlessly smashed by something. Their bodies coming to a halt as they began to fall onto the ground in quick succession.

Even so, the soldiers didn't observe the aftermath of the battle, nor did they load up a new bolt. Instead they continued to fire at the enemy with a speed that was a bit quicker than her fitting an arrow to the bowstring.

"Is this the frightening weapon you spoke of?" Andrea felt her lips slightly drying out, turning somewhat coarse. "Its rate of fire is definitely fast, but the accuracy is somewhat…"

"Before these people were recruited into the First Army, they were all miners, farmers and hunters." Ashes interrupted her speech. "The time they spent using this weapon is just shy of six months."

One normally required at least 5 years of time to groom a well trained warrior, and even more time was needed to train an archer. Even crossbows, which required the least amount of training, still required one to train for at least half a year. Even with training, it would only prevent situations like

farmers placing a bolt upside down in panic. As for actual combat? Only God knew whether they were capable of hitting anything. In most cases, they were only brought along to increase one's prestige.

Andrea couldn't help but swallow her saliva. She was extremely familiar with these kinds of practices, as her clan had nurtured their fair share of outstanding knights. Because of that, she naturally understood the significance of soldiers being combat ready with roughly 6 months worth of training. With an ample supply of weapons and rations, Roland could potentially assemble a massive army within a short time period. Furthermore, there was no need to worry about the troops being routed at the first contact during close quarter combat. Even an elite group of cavalrymen would have a hard time coming close amidst an onslaught of attacks with no intermission.

This had nothing to do with the courage or willpower of the militia, but rather, tremendous strength bestowed to them by their weapons.

"Do you know something else about the firearm?" Tilly asked Sylvie after contemplating it for a moment.

The latter nodded her head. "I've examined it inside and out countless times. It's definitely similar to a crossbow, but the arrowhead that is shot out is tiny and has neither a shaft nor tail feathers. The difference lies in the arrowhead not relying on the elasticity of a bowstring, but rather the propelling force of a black, fine powder when it explodes—It can raise the velocity of the arrowhead to extreme speeds instantaneously.."

"A black, fine powder?" Tilly asked. "What is that?"

"It's probably a byproduct of alchemy." She shook her head. "I am not clear about its specific composition either."

"It must be very expensive." Andrea said. "The things that alchemists create have never been anything cheap."

Ashes curled her lips. "Really…From how they're firing it, it totally doesn't look like they're using anything costly."

“Hold on, something’s approaching.” Sylvie, who was in the process of sizing up the battlefield, was slightly shocked. “My goodness, that’s also a demonic beast? It’s almost as tall as the city wall! From the looks of it, it’s a huge turtle, and it’s carrying a huge carapace behind its back.”

Andrea immediately came to her senses. “Carapace? I am afraid these guns won’t help much. As long as I am within 10 feet of it, even the city walls would not be able to withstand my magic arrows. Ashes, cover me.”

“Sigh, alright.” Ashes helplessly removed the claymore behind her back. “For the record, you’d better not tarnish the good name of Lady Tilly.”

“There’s no need for you all to go,” Sylvie said, in an attempt to stop them. “They still have—”

Andrea didn’t hear the latter half of what the opposite side was saying. She only heard an earsplitting boom that sounded like lightning exploding right beside her ears. Turning her head back, she saw flames erupting out from the pipe-shaped metal objects erected all around the city wall that happened to coincide with each other. This time, she had faintly caught the trajectory that the arrowheads took as they flew—they were like a series of shadows. Like a thunderbolt that leaves no time for one to cover their ears, they flew into the distance where the recently appeared monster was.

After a number of breaths, snow pillars that were several feet tall began to spring up near the side of the creature. After the snowflakes that were disturbed and flying around had all floated down, the ugly and massive demonic beast continued to advance at a fixed speed—It was evident that this attack had not managed to hit the target.

But even so, it was enough for Andrea to feel extremely shocked… That distance had already surpassed the range of the longbow and the heavy crossbow. “This is…”

“His Royal Highness calls it field artillery. Simply put, it’s an enlarged firearm.” Sylvie relaxed the hands that was covering her ears. “Its might is much stronger than the firearm, and its range had been increased by quite a

lot. This was what he used to easily rout Timothy's militia fleet at the bifurcation point of Redwater river."

The luck of the demonic beast didn't manage to last for long. During the second wave of bombardment, two rounds had accurately struck its carapace. Andrea saw it extremely clearly; along with the muffled sound of the collision, there was a layer of mist that began to riseup from the bumpy carapace. Two holes had directly exploded at the side that was close to its head, causing black blood and viscera to spurt out from it, splattering all over the ground.

Not long after, the battle ended. Pieces of demonic corpses laid in front of the city wall. The warm, flowing blood created a haze of white mist above the snow-covered ground. While the soldiers had began reparations, she was still processing the incident, unable to find an opportunity to show off her skills from beginning to end.

"Looks like my estimation was off." Tilly smiled helplessly. "He didn't need any assistance from the combat witches."

"The last time I came to this small city, this type of weapon wasn't widely accessible, and only the Knight Commander could possess them. But now, he had actually produced many of it…" Ashes sighed. "Perhaps this is exactly the reason why His Royal Highness dares to publicly support the existence of witches, despite being under the heavy pressure of the Church."

Andrea didn't respond. If it was during normal times, she would definitely ridicule Ashes. However, the current her only felt abnormally depressed in her heart. She didn't even have the strength to to muster an argument.

When they returned to the castle, His Royal Highness, Roland still continued to prepare a sumptuous lunch for the witches.

Seeing the dishes laid out before her in brilliant colors, Andrea felt even more stifled in her heart.

The upper class nobles of the Kingdom of Dawn were very particular about the taste authenticity in their food. They were willing to spend gold royals

and energy to buy precious and rare ingredients, and use the most authentic way to cook them. In her eyes, food that was sprinkled with all kinds of spices and sauces—such as the one in Greycastle, was a very raffish means of preparation. Seasoning only existed for the sake of covering up the natural defects of the food; Adding more simply signified how poorly it tasted.

But unfortunately for her…every plate of food on the table was extremely delicious.

Like these plump and juicy charcoal grilled mushroom, where exactly did His Royal Highness find them from? The juices that were flowing out from just the slightest bite were practically capable of filling up one's entire mouth.

And then there was this bowl of green vegetable soup. From its appearance, it seemed like an extremely unremarkable bowl of clear soup, but once one took a sip of it into their mouth, a fragrant and flavorsome taste could be felt. It was almost like an entire chicken, some pork ribs and kelp, were thrown into a pot and left to simmer.

The most unique food was the dessert after the meal—Ice cream bread. It consisted of ice cream, whose milky aroma filled the room, wedged between two pieces of bread. After taking a bite from it, she was lost in its cold and soft texture and was unable to remove herself from it. The fact that it was "winter" didn't prevent her from eating slice after slice of it.

Blast it, I thoroughly lose even in this aspect!

Looking at Ashes, who was flashing a provocative smile towards her, Andrea found herself being unable to come up with a response for the first time in her life.

Chapter 335

Chapter 335: Sudden Changes

The third day. Along with the assembly of the large hot air balloon, the day had also arrived for them to depart and explore the ruins.

The new hot air balloon was named “Hawk Eye”, and its massive basket was capable of accommodating many witches. In addition, it would be enveloped and wrapped around by a canvas, preventing chilly winds and heavy snowfall from affecting it.

Since the operation would be safer if it were done quickly, the witches boarded the hot air balloon in succession after bidding a simple farewell to Roland. From the garden behind the castle, it lifted up into the skies and began making its way towards the stone tower.

In order to be able to rapidly descend to the ground in times of danger to meet enemies in combat, they had flown the “Hawk Eye” at very low altitudes this time around, to the point where it was sweeping past the roofs of the small town. A large number of residents were witnessing the “extraordinary sight” while a sizeable amount of people were standing at their original spot, stupefied. There were also people loudly shouting “Long Live His Highness!”; in their eyes, it was probable that they believed only the lord of Border Town was capable of bringing about such miracles.

When it passed by the western part of the wall, the soldiers of the First Army began to salute in an orderly manner towards the sky. Regardless of whether it was Lightning or Maggie that were flying alongside the hot-air balloon, they were all witches who they were familiar with. It was exceptionally apparent for the young lady Lightning, who had received passionate cheers from the soldiers, as she had regularly given the gunner team directions on where to fire.

Very soon, under the fluttering snowflakes that were scattered about the skies, Hawk Eye casted the small town behind it and entered the area where the Concealing Forest laid.

Tilly stood at the side of the basket, gazing at the boundless sea of forest far away.

The snowy season that had persisted for the entire Month of Demon had turned the place into a sea of dazzling white. The highest branches of the tall trees had all been enveloped by the snow, which at first glance, looked like a sea of dais protruding from the ground, smooth and broad. On the opposite side of the view was a vast range of mountains, which was grey in color under the hazy fog. The foot of the mountain, which was connected to the ground, wasn't visible at this point, making the arrowhead mountain peaks in the distance seem as if they were floating in mid-air.

"What a beautiful scenery." Shiva let off an emotional sigh. "This is still the first time I've seen such thick snow cover the western region."

"But, aren't you a witch from the Western Region?" Wendy curiously asked.

"I originally lived in Fallen Dragon Ridge. That place was closer to the south and it rarely snowed during winter. It wasn't until later when I heard the news of Lady Tilly developing Sleepy Island did I covertly sneak into a ship bound towards Clearwater port and met up with the other witches."

"That explains it." Wendy smiled while shaking her head. "Our Royal Highness has always been grumbling about the absence of witches coming forward even after rumors of the association settling down in Border Town had been disseminated…Turns out he was one-step behind all along."

"Oh, is your side circulating news of a gathering place for witches too?"

"They are. It's a shame that the person in charge of it is pretty inexperienced. He was discovered right away by me when he had just arrived at Fallen Dragon Ridge." Ashes said in a self-complacent manner. "I had even managed to catch him red-handed in Silver City. Apparently, his name was Theo?"

“You’re a witch after all. It’d be natural for you to notice such a weird rumor.” Andrea curled her lips. “If you hadn’t met Lady Tilly, you would have probably gone to Border Town a long time ago.”

“There’s no way I will serve under His Royal Highness—”

“Hoh.” She mimicked her voice and said, “His Royal Highness…sounds to me you had quite the talent in calling him that.”

“Pfft!” Tilly couldn’t refrain herself from laughing loudly. Yesterday, she had saw Andrea wearing a sulky expression on her face, but from the looks of it currently, she had seemingly returned to normal. Within Sleeping Island, the only person that dare to find fault with Ashes would be Andrea, who had an illustrious family background.

“No matter if it’s at Sleeping Island or Border Town, we’re all family here. There’s no need to discriminate here, alright?”

Turning her head, her gaze swept past the large group of witches in succession.

Everyone had already found out what ability the other had before setting off. This was done so that they could find a reasonable role for everyone in the case of an enemy attack. One could say that the number of combat witches in Border Town completely paled in comparison to that of Sleeping Island, who had a large number of them. In fact, it was to the point that a large number of witches were incapable of combat. However, it was exactly because of their relentless efforts that turned the little town into what it was today.

Tilly’s line of sight stopped at Anna. If she had to choose someone within the group that left the most profound impression on her, it would probably be this woman who awoke her powers in the Border region and had the deepest impression of Roland.

As long as she stood near her, she would be able to feel a heavy and gentle feeling that was difficult to describe. It was still the first time Tilly had encountered such a feeling. If she really had to describe it, it would be the soft and firm feeling coming from someone’s back when they were lying on a

vast plain. It was the kind of feeling that allowed someone to truly feel relaxed.

Other than talking to Roland, Anna was a silent person and her expression rarely changed as well. However, as long as she was standing within a group of witches, her presence was something that was very difficult for people to overlook.

Moreover, from what Sylvie said, Anna was also the quickest witch that had undergone an evolution in Border Town. She possessed a huge, stunning amount of magical power and her black flames, which she could freely manipulate the shape of, was abnormally strong. What's more, she was also the first witch to read through and finish the "Theoretical Foundations of Natural Science". This fact made Tilly feel as if she had found a kindred spirit.

If she was able to sit around a fireplace with Anna and properly discuss the miraculous knowledge present in the book during such a winter, it would presumably be an incomparably happy occasion. Tilly was filled with anticipation for that day to come.

The fifth princess then shifted her gaze towards Lightning, who was outside the basket. Being the daughter of Thunder, she was in many ways similar to the No.1 adventurer of the Fjord. She was lively, possessed an inquisitive heart, was filled with energy, and had an innate nature that was suitable for flying. Tilly believed that only the vast and limitless skies was capable of accommodating her free spirited mindset.

Although Thunder had hoped her daughter could live her entire life in a conscientious manner, after seeing the young lady, Tilly knew she was destined to become an adventurer, whose achievement in the future might even surpass her father.

The only thing she could do now was to protect her the best that she can.

"We're almost there." Lightning informed everyone. While Tilly was engrossed in her thoughts, she had since drawn close to the side of the basket.

“Come in and rest a little.” Wendy had a deeply concerned expression on her face. “Your lips have turned white from the cold.”

“No worries, my face is just feeling a bit numb.” She patted her rosy red cheeks. “Fortunately, there’s the scarf His Royal Highness gave me. My ears don’t feel cold at all.”

On the way there, they did not run into any of those ferocious-looking devils. Even though the demonic beasts that were in the forest they were traversing through would raise their head and let off a roar or two from time to time, it was evident they didn’t have the ability to attack the hot air balloon that was above them. As such, the first half of the journey went by without much of a hitch. However, when the “Hawk Eye” was above the destination, everyone was stupefied with the scene in front of them.

The only thing they saw was an aftermath of a large beast sweeping past a chunk of the forest. At every spot, fragments of tree trunks and branches laid scattered about while snow had been flipped over and mixed with the soil. From the looks of it, it was an extremely chaotic sight.

“Where’s the stone tower?” Ashes asked.

“It was originally there.” Lightning’s voice was filled with disbelief as she pointed at the empty patch of land underneath her foot. “It… disappeared.”

Tilly looked towards the direction she was pointing at. On the surface of the ground, which color alternated between brown and white, was a large hole. It was pitch black, bottomless and looked as if someone had excavated a passage at this area towards the abyss. Based on the size of the hole itself, the excavator must certainly be somebody who possessed an astonishingly huge body.

“Sylvie, take a look at what was in that hole.”

Sylvie’s brows very quickly creased while her complexion began to look very terrible. “It’s a—it’s a monster that looked like a maggot. It is currently moving towards the Northwest direction— Hold on a second, the ruins are in its stomach!”

“What, in its stomach?” Ashes said in a shocked manner.

“That’s right, I saw the stone tower…as well as the ice coffin you all were talking about.” She said, while carefully examining it. “My goodness, it had swallowed the whole ruins down into its stomach!”

What should they do next? Everyone began to look at Tilly spontaneously.

“Is there anything else besides the worm?” The fifth princess asked in a deep voice. “The devils in particular.”

“Hmm…There are some demonic beasts, but they’re all in its belly. Seems like they were already dead.” Sylvie observed for a moment before shaking her head.

Tilly contemplated for a moment and spoke in a decisive manner. “We descend now. A team will keep guard outside while the other team will follow me into the caves. We will slay the demonic beasts and take back the ice coffin.”

Chapter 336

Chapter 336: The worm's belly

"Tilly, you can't!" Just when Ashes wanted to stop Tilly, she was cut off by her.

"In order for someone to enter the hole, they needed to rely on witches who can fly to bring them out." Tilly waved the ring that was on her finger. "Although carrying a heavy object will greatly increase the consumption of magical power, I can at least bring another witch along. This is something that will play a big part in this operation—If we can bring another witch with us, we will be that much more adaptable when a situation arises." She paused for a moment and looked at the witches in Border Town. "Anna, Lightning and Maggie, I'll have to ask for your help."

The three did not raise any objection and the little girl, Lightning, even had an eager expression on her face.

Tilly heaved a small sigh of relief. "In that case, we will also include Ashes, Shiva and Sylvie into the list of people heading into the hole. I will entrusting the safety of the surface entrance to you, the remaining home girls."

"Lady Tilly, please allow me to come along with you." Andrea opened her mouth and said.

"If they happen to come across a group of demonic beasts, I am afraid it would be impossible for Nightingale to handle it all alone." Tilly shook her head. "As the two of you happened to be skilled in long and close range combat respectively, you're able to coordinate your attacks with each other.

"Rest assured. I will protect the entrance in your stead." Nightingale appeared to be very confident when she said that. "Whether is it a devil or a demonic beast, they will be unable to take a step close."

Tilly had considered the matter very clearly. The few witches that had been chosen to go down the hole were greatly dependent by the carrying capacity of the flying witches. The first and heaviest object that needed to be taken into consideration of was the “coffin”. If they were unable to awaken the girl on the spot, they would have to break the coffin into pieces and bring it away. In that case, it would roughly be equivalent to the weight of 2-3 witches. Only Shiva’s invisible barrier was capable of moving such a heavy object.

Sylvie’s magic eyes was necessary as well. Without her, it would be impossible for them to locate the precise location of the ruins in the creature’s stomach. The same was true for Anna’s cutting and heating ability, although they were unable to fly. Thankfully, they were relatively light and could be carried by Maggie after she transformed into a demonic bird. Finally, was Ashes, an extraordinaire who could easily fight in any situation. She would be moved and carried by Tilly herself.

According to what Lightning said, even though she was capable of flight, her altitude would decline extremely quickly the moment she took someone along. It was possible she would not be able to fly out of such a deep hole.

Her advantage laid in her excellent flexibility and speed. With her around, their awareness and probing abilities would be effectively increased along with their capability to pull off a pincer attack.

The importance of these few witches was almost irreplaceable and the absence of the one person would make things especially complicated. Because of that, her decision to head down wasn’t done in the spur of the moment, but rather something done after taking all the factors into account.

As for Andrea… While her destructive power was extremely stunning within close range, her power will be greatly reduced under the narrow and pitch dark terrain. Since that was the case, it would be better to have her guard the surface with Nightingale as precautions against the demonic beasts patrolling nearby.

It wasn’t as if Tilly hadn’t considered the idea of giving up the rescue and returning back like that. However, there was always a sort of uneasy premonition in her heart. Of all the undamaged region near it, why did it only

settle on the remnant of the stone tower? Especially the direction where the massive beast was crawling from—she gazed at the northwestern mountains. Following that, was exactly the place where the devils were residing.

Could it be possible that there were some sort of relation between the two parties?

Under the control of Wendy and Anna, the hot air balloon quickly and steadily reached the ground. After Tilly put aside the distracting thoughts in her mind and reviewed the plan once more, she took a deep breath and spoke while emphasising every word, “We shall now depart.”

…..

The hole was much deeper than she had expected and the height of its interior was about two stories high. The passage stretched vertically downwards at the beginning, but started slanting shortly after and eventually formed a horizontal passageway. All around its wall, the soil emitted an unpleasant smell. If one were to come closer, they would be able to see a sticky liquid dripping down from the surface of the soil which resembled the mucus of a slug.

As the group of witches continued to head deeper, the light that was shining into the hole quickly faded away. Other than a few feebly illuminated areas lit up by the few torches, the entire cave were immersed in a sea of darkness. Furthermore, the whistling sounds of the wind had subsequently gone quiet as well. The feeling of coldness was gradually being replaced with heat that was coming from the core of the planet. Tilly felt warm coming into her body again.

Looking at the flames that were sometimes close and sometimes far, she couldn’t help herself from associating it with fireflies.

“The massive beast is just at the front.” It was at that moment that Sylvie softly spoke.

However, there was no need for her reminder; everyone was aware that they getting closer to the objective. A strange noise began to come from the depths

of the cave. It sounded somewhat similar to the rustling sounds made when an autumn wind blew through a forest, but at the same time, it also sounded like "kachi kachi" chewing noises..

"Let's descend." After Tilly had Ashes who was on her back hold two of the torches, she reduced their elevation through the magic stone until her feet were in the flexible and sticky mud.

Soon after, Anna began to illuminate the place with a chilly and bright light.

She had once again turned her black flames into the heart of fire. The chilly and gentle rays of light immediately flooded the vicinity. Under the dark green flame, the witches could clearly see the tail of the massive beast. It was slowly crawling forward while it's grey, wriggling outer skin secreted mucus unceasingly, making its rotting smell become even more pungent.

"A large and disgusting worm." Ashes pulled out her claymore. "What should we do next? Should I slice its belly open?"

"Wait, Anna has to be the one to kill it." Tilly shook her head and said. "I am still unaware about how big of a threat the things in its stomach will pose to us. It will be too risky for you to approach it using a sword."

"Mhm, let me give it a try." While maintaining the green flames and making sure they did went out, Anna summoned a ball of black flames once more. In an instant, the black flames turned into a string the thickness of a finger and flew directly towards the massive beast.

The thin string penetrated the skin of the monster effortlessly and sliced the side of its belly. Perhaps due to the high temperature, the skin that was in contact with the black string immediately began to burn. The liquid inside its body evaporated, causing billows of white mist to spurt out of its body. Shiva, who had long been equipped for this, activated her invisible barrier, blocking the juices that were flying out from all directions, one after the other.

This is the power that comes from evolution. Tilly quietly thought to herself. Even though Anna had introduced her abilities before departing, seeing it

actually happen with her own eyes still shocked her. It was capable of operating outside of her body through her consciousness and it was much sharper than any greatsword in thin string form. What's more, it was extremely difficult to see its trajectory, making it impossible for an enemy to evade them.

The creature let out a sharp and anguished howl, while its body began to squirm around frantically. However, the black flame continued to slice everything ahead of it and speedily shred a greater part of its body. As for the flowing liquid, before it even managed to come near the witches, it had all been evaporated by the lump of the green fire.

Gradually, the massive beast stopped its struggle. Its skin also began to relax.

"It's dead." Sylvie said. "Its heart already stopped beating."

"This thing has a heart too?" Ashes asked while pitching her nose.

"It's at its head and is almost as big as the basket of Hawk Eye. What's more…" She paused for a moment. "Magical power is circulating all around its body."

"In other words, this is a mixed breed of demonic beast?"

"No one knows the answer." Tilly said. "There are very few records regarding demonic beasts and the wilderness in the history books. As there are still a lot of unknowns around here, it's be best if we hurry and dig the coffins out."

After going through another round of burning from Anna, the rotting smell was not as intense as before. Under the guidance of Sylvie, they speedily discovered the ruins that had been swallowed.—Needless to say, the present basement had already been turned into disorderly pieces of rocks to the point that it was virtually impossible to make out its original shape. As for the magic illumination stone that Lightning talked about, they had all became lumps of mush. Fortunately, the transparent crystal column were still as good as before. Despite being rummaged out from the beast's sticky belly, there

was not a strand of corrosion on top, and the girl that was sealed within the crystal still carried an appearance as if she was alive.

“What happen next is up to you now.” Tilly said to Anna.

Chapter 337

Chapter 337: Rescue

Anna nodded her head. She stretched the black flames out into a thin thread, and lightly pressed it against the crystal column.

The crowd of witches involuntarily held their breath; they only saw a continuous stream of green smoke rising from the point of contact. In actuality, that wasn't the true color of the smoke, but instead a different color tone that emerged under the radiance of the green flame.

The black flames dug deeper into the crystal.

"How is it?" Tilly asked.

"It might be a little taxing, but I will be able to slice it open." Anna replied.

Suddenly, the "ice coffin" began to change. Along with a crisp breaking sound, a few cracks appeared at the spot the black flames had dug into and began to extend throughout the coffin. In an instant, it had covered the entire coffin like a spider web. Almost at the same time, Shiva brought up the barrier and enveloped the witches within it.

However, the expected explosion did not happen. The shattered crystal fragments began to fall apart piece by piece, exposing a core that emitted cold air. The interior was a genuine ice crystal. At that instant, everyone felt a chilly wave hit them in their face, and the surrounding temperature rapidly decreased.

Fortunately, Anna quickly prevent the temperature from dropping further and raised it back to its original state.

Under the scorching heat of the black flames, the crystal began to melt even faster while it rapidly lost its transparency. The edges and corners that made up its shape was no longer apparent. Like an ordinary ice cube, it was

shrinking as it melted. However, Tilly noticed that the floor wasn't covered in a large pool of water. Instead, all the parts that had melted turned into smoke and drifted away, making it seem as if the "ice coffin" had never existed in the first place.

When all but a miniscule amount of the ice crystals had melted, the body of the girl who was sealed inside was uncovered.

She had seemingly remained in the midst of a deep sleep. Her long hair, as well as her garment, did not possess any traces of being soaked and were no different than the time she was sealed in ice. Her powerless body began to fall backwards after losing the support of the cylinder and was caught by Ashes' embrace.

"Is she still alive?"

"Although it's very weak, her heart hasn't stopped beating."Ashes pressed one of her hand onto the girl's chest. "This…is just implausible."

It was indeed implausible. Tilly thought. For the duration spanning this short week, she realized the incredible things she witnessed in Border Town were far greater than anything that she had seen within the past year. Tilly let off a small sigh of relief. Her identity was all but confirmed. Since she was someone that was capable of surviving within the extremely cold ice crystals. She was a witch.

The foray this time had, at long last, not been for naught.

As for her name, origin, and the reason she was trapped within these ruins, those questions could slowly be answered once they returned.

****

Andrea was guarding the side of the cave in a seemingly bored manner. Occasionally, she would cast a gaze towards the bottom, hoping that the first thing she saw was Tilly in the midst of returning.

There was no presence of devils near the cave and even demonic beasts were rarely seen. Occasionally, some common wolves and boar species would come out from the forest. But before she could even draw her bow, Nightingale had already stabbed her dagger into their head.

The passing of time had seemingly become slower. Apart from her, the witches that had remained near the cave were all from the witch association. Even if she wanted to, it was incapable for her to talk to someone to pass time. Although the girl named Wendy appeared to be extremely amiable, Andrea couldn't find the resolve to strike a conversation with her.

As an upper class noble from the Kingdom of Dawn, grace and self-restraint were essential qualities a non-married woman should possess.

Forget it. I will chat with Nightingale instead. I heard that she recently fought with Ashes. Surprisingly, they fought to a stalemate. That being the case, if I treat it as gathering information about my rival, it shouldn't be considered as striking the conversation.

Mhm, this is just a necessary job I have to accomplish.

She stretched her hand to pat away the snow that had collected on her head and looked up. Her heart however, abruptly skipped a beat—Nightingale was gone.

The woman who possessed golden curls and an air of elegance similar to that of a noble, was originally leaning against the side of the basket. However, she had now vanished without a trace.

Oh that's right, her ability was invisibility.

Thinking up to this point, Andrea calmed her heart and and began to perceive any sounds of movement around her. When one's sight was unable to be put into good use, their ears and nose would become their best assistant in ascertaining the whereabouts of an enemy.

Soon after, she heard the soft noises of footsteps brushing against something.

Is it Nightingale?

No, that's not right. Andrea felt her hairs standing on end. It was obvious that these footsteps weren't something a single person was capable of producing —There was a group of people that were currently approaching this place. They were in the jungles ahead of them, and were only a hundred steps away from herself! However, when she looked ahead, the place her eye landed on was still undisturbed. There wasn't even a trace of shadow could be found…

The sound of the footsteps very quickly sounded in close proximity to her. My god, the enemy is invisible!

Just when she was about to alarm the others, a sound of explosion suddenly rang in her ears.

A flame suddenly appeared and disappeared in mid-air. Following after was a wave of shimmers in the air and a monster who possessed a peculiar physique appeared. It had a long and narrow head and possessed a pair of sharp sickles. From its appearance, it was like a mutated praying mantis. However, the only thing that made it different from other insects was that it was walking upright.

The bullet shot from the firearm smashed the side of its face into pieces. Black blood began to spurt out from its skull and had almost landed on Andrea's body.

With a loud thud, the creature fell down to the ground. Following which, she saw Nightingale's white cape and hood fluttering in the wind.

Following which, the second gunshot rang!

Damn it, I was careless! Andrea bit her lips tightly. She wished that she could had noticed it earlier.

Although she had summoned her bow, she was not aware of which direction she should have fired her arrows. She could only retreat back to the side of the basket and stand together with the other witches.

Four gunshots rang forth and four monsters toppled over, all of them killed with a shot each.

When Nightingale once again materialized herself beside a monster, Andrea put down her weapon and quickly walked towards Nightingale.

“What is that?”

“If it isn’t a demonic beast, then it should be a devil.” She crouched down and fiddled with its talons and hand sickles. “But judging from its blood color, it’s probably a demonic beast.”

“When did you discover them?”

“Ever since they appeared.” Nightingale smiled. “In the dense fog, the radiance coming from the magic in their bodies were as showy as the sea of stars in a night sky.”

“Can a demonic beast possess such an ability?” Andrea knitted her eyebrows and asked.

The smile that was on the other party disappeared. “Hmm…I guess it’s because mixed breed are somewhat special.”

At that moment, the witches that entered the depths of the cave earlier just so happened to return to the surface as well. Besides the original 7 members, there was also an additional blue-haired girl on Ashes shoulder as well.

“Is she the person that was crying for help in the ruins?” Andrea said while going forward to welcome them.

“That’s right.” Tilly nodded her head. “I will explain the situation in detail once we get back to the Hawk Eye. The longer I stay in this forest, the more uneasy I feel. That reminds me, did any of you encounter any dangerous situation on the surface?”

“Only a few strange and mixed-breed demonic beasts came. However, they’re all dead.” Nightingale lightly shrugged her shoulders.

The hot air balloon quickly inflated and rose up into the air. The basket rose to the very top of a tree and began to make its way towards the small town. At this moment, Sylvie cried out in alarm, “My god, what are those things below? Are they demonic beasts?”

“Demonic beasts?” Andrea extended her head and looked towards the directions of the ruins. However, she was unable to see anything.

That’s not right. There was indeed something moving on the surface. The corpse of the monster which originally laid on the ground had lost half of its body all of a sudden. The bloodstains that was on the ground had been trampled upon and fell apart. Strange worm wriggling movements could be seen between the border of the mud and snow. The scene was almost as if one was looking through a glass cup; if they didn’t examine carefully, it would be very difficult for them to spot the changes.

“It is those strange mixed breed species again.” Nightingale spoke in a careless manner. “There are probably about a hundred of them or so. They were trying to outdo each other in running towards the hole…Could it be that they were attracted by the large worm and wanted to make a hearty meal out of it?” She yawned. “Although, that has nothing to do with us anymore.”

Chapter 338

Chapter 338: Police

Vader got out of his bed with a flip and attempted to do a series of exercises with his body. He didn't feel the least bit of pain from his back. Apparently, what the Knight was saying was right: as long as the wound was left as it was, it would quickly recover.

"How does it feel?" Kukasim asked. "It'll be better if you're able to rest up a little more."

"I won't be a burden. Didn't I do a pretty good job yesterday?" Vader put on his shabby jacket and set his feet into his knee-high boots. "Besides, only by working for them earlier did I get a share of the wheat porridge. After all, I can't eat your portion every time. One bowl is simply insufficient to split between the two of us."

"Truth be told, I think that it's pretty good. Compared to the porridge they offered for the needy, the wheat porridge here is much more substantial. I can still taste a bit of meat in them." The old man shook his head. "Kid, you're a member of the patrol team. It's possible you're not clear about life in the slum district. In that place, the gruel is just like a clear soup, except that the soup has a few more wheat grains. In order to make it appear a bit more nourishing, they normally cook it together with grass and tree leaves. While it's possible the wheat porridge the Lord gave out will not fill our stomachs up completely, it will not starve us too badly either."

"I only want the two of us to eat our fill." Vader said with a smile as he finished tying his shoelaces.

"Alright." Kukasim sighed. "In that case, make sure to take good care of your body and not overexert yourself."

It was a strange feeling. He was originally just a scapegoat chosen by a street rat, but now his behaviour was resembling that of his own elder, Vader

thought to himself. What was even more strange, was that it hadn't actually felt that bad.

"I will." He shook his head, as if he had found something amusing, and put on his hood. "You too."

Right as he pushed the door open, he saw two men who were currently standing outside the door. The shallow blue color that had been embroidered on their shoulders and armbands, along with the white uniform they wore revealed the visitors' identity—clerks under the employment of the city hall.

Vader's brows couldn't help but crease slightly. "May I know who you are looking for?"

One of the men took out a slip of paper and gave it a quick glance. "Are you Vader?"

"Yes."

"Did something happen?" Kukasim had also noticed the situation that was unfolding outside the house.

"Congratulations." The other man revealed a smile. "You passed the paper test to become a public security agent. What follows will be a week of comprehensive training." He passed a small card over to Vader. "This is your temporary identity card. Head with it to the camp of the Second Army, someone will be there to receive you."

His eyes were wide open. "I… have passed the lord's assessment?"

"No, not yet." The clerk replied. "The paper test was just the first round of selection. You will still have to complete the training and receive the approval of the chief knight. Only then can you consider yourself through the assessment and an official public security agent."

The two left promptly after saying their piece. They did not demand any money from him, nor did they try to win him over emotionally. The purpose of their visit was seemingly just to bring the news to him.

“You’ve made it!” The old man patted Vader’s shoulder emotionally and said, “Back then, you were still saying something along the line of how it was impossible for you to be chosen.”

Vader was shocked for a good amount of time before he muttered a reply. “Because those questions were really most odd.”

The old man was slightly startled. “What questions are you talking about?”

He involuntarily thought back to the incident a week ago. Once he came to know that His Royal Highness was recruiting public security agents—the new name for patrol guards, he went to the city hall as the recruitment posting had suggested and expressed his interest. The response had also been relatively quick; just five days had passed before he received a letter about a test.

Vader had been full of confidence. Not only did he fully satisfy the requirements for the post, he also possessed more than five years’ worth of practical experience. Besides, this town was indeed lacking someone to keep an eye on the populace. Because of that, he felt that his chances of being chosen were great. If he could become a member of the patrol team, he would be able to provide aid to Kukasim any time, even if his place of residence was in the inner city.

But he didn’t expect, indeed the test surpassed what everyone on the scene expected.

More than a hundred applicants were sitting in a large hall, while the Knight handed out papers to them one by one. He requested that they answer all of the questions listed on top of the papers and write them down in a neat and orderly fashion. He had even said that the person who would ultimately be looking through their papers would be none other than His Royal Highness himself. This format immediately led to a loud outcry among the crowd. Even though the requirement that one needed to be literate had been clearly stated, no one had expected that it would actually be incorporated into the test.

At that moment, over half the people were dumbfounded. Even though Vader was able to understand the questions on the paper, he sat frozen at his place

after carefully scanning through it one more time—What sort of weird questions are these?

This was one of the question, for instance. “You’re a coachman for a four-wheel carriage and are travelling along a narrow strip of mountainous road. Inside your carriage are two citizens. At this moment, a group of refugees suddenly appears on the road ahead. You cannot avoid them, and can only choose to collide with them head on, or let the carriage fall from the precipice. The former choice will cause the deaths of a large number of refugees while the latter choice will cause the death of the two citizens. No matter the choice you make, you will always be able to rely on your athletic skills to survive. In this case, what would your choice be? Please explain your reasons in a minimum of 300 words.”

This question would putting anyone at a loss. Even though it mentioned which side was the commoner and which was the refugee, the specific number of refugees was completely unclear. Because of that, even if he wanted to weigh his choices, he was clueless as to where to begin. Moreover, he had always believed that running over a bunch of refugees wasn’t anything too serious. However, perhaps that wasn’t the answer His Royal Highness was after.

In that case, should he choose to have the citizens die? Could it be that that was also an accurate answer?

At that point, he had even convinced himself that His Highness was deliberately making things hard. He believed that in reality, the true public security agents had long been decided already.

“It’s nothing. Perhaps it’s just been my imagination.” Vader inhaled a mouthful of air. “Well then, I will be heading to the camp now.”

“Mhm.” Kukasim heartily laughed and said. “I believe you will definitely become an official public security agent.”

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The camp of the Second Army was located on the north side of the small town, outside the stone walls that made up the inner city. When Vader rushed

to that place, he discovered that the Chief Knight was already waiting for him in the camp.

“From today onwards, all of you are police cadets.” After waiting for everyone to arrive, Carter opened his mouth and said, “In the coming week, all of you will be required to stay in this camp and receive special training. The people who pass will stay, while the people who fail will scram back to where they come from! I will teach you all discipline, and what it means to work under His Royal Highness!”

In Vader’s memories, this was exactly how a test should look, except… there were only 15 people remaining out of the 100 applicants. He cast a few quick glances around. From their dress and complexion, with the exception of himself, the rest of the people should be natives here.

As expected, the literacy requirement hadn’t been a joke.

“Permission to speak!” Someone raised their hand and said.

Carter’s lips parted into a grin and said, “Oh? Seems like you’re pretty familiar with customs in the army. Speak.”

“Haha, my big brother is in the First Army.” He stroked the back of his head and said, ‘Sir, may I ask what exactly is a police? Aren’t we supposed to be public security?”

“The police is part of the public security service. Think of them as the crew that is responsible for enforcing law and order within His Highness’s territory. They’re required to arrest criminals, crackdown on illegal acts, maintain order in the territory, carry out policies issued by His Royal Highness and the city hall and help the commoners in need.”

“Help the commoners? But you just said that we will be serving under His Royal Highness…”

“There is no distinction between the two. Serving the people under His Royal Highness means serving His Royal Highness as well. What, do you want to enter the castle and attend to him personally?” Carter shrugged his

shoulders and said, “We can talk about that once you have become an outstanding knight.”

But knights are nobility… Vader thought. Compared to commoners like them, the difference in social status was like heaven and earth. Not something one can bridge just by thinking about it.

“Remember, you’re both executors of the law and guardians of the people. For now, go to your tents and change into your uniforms.” The chief knight clapped his hands. “After that, I just happen to have a mission that I would like to entrust to you all to complete.”

Chapter 339

Chapter 339: Assassins

When Vader took off his patch-covered coat and put on his brand new uniform, he began to feel his entire body warming up nicely.

The top layer of the clothes was a thick leather material, and the inside also had a cotton lining. They possessed both the heat retention of leather, and the softness of the cloth. Just these materials alone were worth several silver royals.

Although in shape it was similar to the uniforms of the city hall, the color was, on the contrary, worlds apart. The predominant color of the outfit was pure black while the shoulders, collar and cuff had a white stripe border, making it very eye-catching. After the fifteen of them had put on their new uniforms and once again stood in a row, they were unable to restrain their emotions and stuck out their chests a little.

“Not bad,” Carter revealed a satisfied smile. “Now, all of you follow me.”

At this point, the snow was still drifting in the sky. For Vader, it was still the first time he had witnessed snow falling unceasingly in autumn. Snow would occasionally fall in Valencia, but it would stop after one or two days at most. When that happened, children would frequently line up snowmen along the street. They would roll the snow up into snowballs and throw them back and forth between each other. As a result, children thought of snowy days as holidays.

These were days of extreme inconvenience to the grown-ups, however. The excess snow made their shoes wet and moldy, which made it extremely difficult for them to traverse the streets. Shops ended up virtually devoid of people… The weight of snow would even cause the roofs of houses to occasionally collapse.

At such a time, the patrol team would be dead set on staying indoors. Even if they had to go out, they would only find a tavern for everyone to sit around the fireplace. Drinking warm ale, they would flirt with the barmaids.

However, none of that was evident in Border Town.

Every day, there would be someone clearing the excess snow from the street, and sweeping it to either side of the road— This was a job that the city hall had long been recruiting for. It was possible for one to work on a daily or monthly basis and people considered it a job with a low but fast return.

There were a large number of residents heading to and fro on the streets. Some were wearing straw hats, while others had cloaks draped over them. All of them were busy minding their own business. If one could get rid of all of the fallen snow in the town, it wouldn't be too far out of the question to call it summer.

If he hadn't witnessed it with his own eyes, Vader would absolutely not believe that a small town at the edge of the kingdom would appear much livelier than Valencia. If it hadn't been for the absence of a tall chapel and bell tower in the town, he would have seriously believed himself to be in some large city.

The party arrived at the wharf very quickly. Ten or more sailboats had been docked on the Redwater River and several hundred people had already gathered near the shore. Seems like I've encountered such a scene before… that's right! An image came to Vader's mind. When he, and other refugees from the Eastern Region, had arrived at this small dock, this was also the scene that had greeted them.

"Permission to speak! Were those people…"

"They were refugees from the South and the North. In order to allow them to get through the winter safely, His Royal Highness specially sent people to bring them to Border Town. Your role is to assist the city hall in maintaining order and to get those people in a line into the inspection checkpoint. Once that is done, you will quarantine them and write each of them into the record," Carter instructed them. "As the police officers are still few in

number, the First Army will be assisting you. However, this job will be assigned to all of you to accomplish on your own in the future."

"Yes, sir!"

From the sound of it, it wasn't a hard task at all and was little more than directing refugees into a queue to collect their porridge. Vader walked towards the front of the checkpoint and began to yell in a loud voice so that everyone could hear his instructions clearly and approach him in an orderly manner.

"What's your name? Where're you from? Do you have any thing you're good at? Can you read?"

Every refugee that passed through the checkpoint would be subjected to a round of inquiries by the clerks in the city hall, following which their responses would be roughly recorded. Vader knew that this was just a rough estimate. Once everyone had settled in, a further investigation would verify everyone's responses. The people who possessed special abilities or knowledge would be prioritized in their transfer into the inner city.—This process was something he had personally experienced once.

Suddenly, a burst of commotion rang out behind him. Vader turned his head only to see a man clad in a furry gown arrive at the wharf under the protection of a group of guards. The long, grey hair blowing in the end made his status clear—He was the feudal lord of the land, HRH Roland Wimbledon. A number of people dressed up in fine clothing, who ought to be the people in charge of city hall, stood beside him.

Never in his mind had he imagined that His Royal Highness would brave the flurry of snow to personally observe this batch of refugees. In a severe winter, it was rare to find a higher noble who was willing to leave a warm bed at the crack of dawn, especially when there were servants present to take care of everything.

"My name is Jockmau, and I am from the Northern Lands. Er… my sp-speciality lies in farming. I can't read."

“Farming?” The city hall official checked the relevant box on his form. “Okay, pass on.”

It was at this exact moment that Vader noticed the individual casting a glance in the direction of His Royal Highness. There was not the least veneration present in his eyes. In its stead was an emotion completely different from that of the other commoners.

“Hold it.” He said unconsciously.

“W-What’s the matter?”

“You’re a farmer, right? Can you tell me which month one should sow their winter wheat?

The city hall official looked at him as well with a somewhat annoyed look on his face. “I am only going through the preliminary registration for now, and I don’t have the time to distinguish whether every single one of them is telling the truth. Didn’t Sir Carter explain clearly how the process should work? All I need you to do is maintain order around these parts.”

After hearing what the official said, the man immediately shut his mouth.

Seriously, what an idiot! Vader pursed his brow and continued speaking, ignoring the official. “The way you speak doesn’t resemble a northerner. Instead, it is similar to the accent commonly used near the middle of the kingdom. Which town in the North did you come from? I’m very familiar with the places there.”

Jockmau hesitated for a moment, but remained silent.

“Your attire is also strange. Even if you were lucky enough not to freeze to death in the North in this outfit, your fingers ought to have developed frostbite by now. The temperature there is below freezing all year round, you know.” Vader grabbed his right hand. “What about your gloves? Don’t tell me you threw them away because you realized when you arrived that it was slightly warmer?”

Even the personnel manning the checkpoint had now noticed the fishy part of his tale. It might be understandable if one lied about being skilled at something, probably trying to obtain better treatment. However, if someone chose to conceal their own origin, that action was much more suspicious. “Where exactly did you come from?”

Jockmau clenched his teeth. Suddenly, he took out a red pellet from his breast. He slapped it into his mouth and yelled, “Out of my way!”

Vader suddenly felt his wrist became scaldingly hot. Although his conditioned reflexes kicked in and made him want to pin the man down to the floor, he found that even with all of his strength, he was not moving at all. Jockmau raised his shoulder and Vader felt his entire body fly into the air.

He fell to the ground heavily and a scorching pain ignited in his back. Dammit, my wound opened! Spitting out a mouthful of saliva, he shook off some of the dizziness in his brain and turned over, getting himself up. Alas, Jockmau was no longer in his original position.

Four or five refugees scuttled out of the crowd, and their actions were as nimble as the demonic beasts outside the town walls. With a few steps, they vaulted over the temporary railing set up by the City Hall and ran toward the prince.

The goal of the group of people was painstakingly obvious. They were here for the high-ranking officials of Border Town, as well as their feudal lord.

Recalling the monstrous strength that had erupted from Jockmau, Vader’s mind could imagine the prince’s royal guard being torn to shreds on the spot. Even the prince himself would be hard-pressed to escape that fate.

However, that did not come to pass.

He quickly heard a string of bangs—the same as when the soldiers stood off against demonic beasts.

In front of the prince, clouds of white smoke floated upwards into the sky.

Within the sea of smoke, Jockmau's head had blossomed into a sea of blood.

Chapter 340

Chapter 340: The reason for the assessment

When all of the freaks rushing out of the crowd had been shot dead, the unexpected change sank in and the refugees suffered a burst of panic. As tens of soldiers that carrying peculiar weapons began to gather around the refugees, fearful cries began to rang out and the situation was becoming harder to control by the second. At this moment, the loud voice of His Highness suddenly echoed above the crowd—

“Settle down, my citizens. I am your Feudal Lord, Roland Wimbledon. Please listen to what I am about to say.”

Although the voice was loud, it was not a hysterical shout. Rather, he spoke as equals, with a clear and calm manner. It was almost as if he was speaking close to his ears, Vader felt. His words carried unquestionable might and calmed the clamor and panic on the scene.

The crowd suddenly got quiet.

“Just as you heard when you arrived, Border Town will provide you with three things: somewhere to say which resists the cold wind and blocks the snow, ample food that will allow you to fill your belly, and even numerous, reasonably paid jobs. I am here to tell you all that these are real.”

“The house is made of thick clay, without the slightest crack for the wind to enter. A charcoal stove lies underneath the bed. When you sleep on it, it is as comfortable as lying on a meadow warmed by the summer sun. As long as the door and windows are closed, you won’t feel even the slightest bit of chill, even if you are wearing the thinnest clothes.”

“The food is wheat porridge, accompanied by meat jerky. When you scoop it up, you will be able to see the grains wheat falling downwards drop by drop. When you put them into your mouth, the rich viscosity will slow their descent into your stomach. Just one bowl alone will fill you to the brim.”

At this point, Vader suddenly began to feel his belly getting hungry. The things that His Royal Highness was speaking about were extremely novel. He was different from the majority of nobles, who repeatedly stressed their power and duty as leaders of the masses and proclaimed that everyone under their jurisdiction should comply with their wishes. Instead, he took the people's point of view and described his promise through basic necessities. It was obvious, looking at the rapt expression on the refugees, that his words had moved their heart.

"My wish is for all the citizens under my rule to live out happy lives, lives where they do not have to worry about basic necessities. However, the enemies hidden in the shadows are not willing to see such a sight. Those beasts rushing out earlier were undoubtedly sent out by them. Their motive is very simple. They do not wish to see me alive; nor do they wish to let my citizens lead comfortable lives."

"If I disappear, would another feudal lord provide you with warm housing and delicious food? I am sure everyone understands this point clearly. The answer is also clear from what you have experienced thus far. There is no one except myself who's willing to do this ."

Vader realized that everyone's panic had dissipated. When the refugees began to treat the supernatural monsters as a common enemy, their unease gradually turned to anger. —The villains trying to harm His Royal Highness are also scumbags trying to harm our beautiful lives! People like them must never be forgiven!

"In order to prevent such a surprise attack from happening again, we will have to conduct the inspection again. This time, my personal guard shall personally take charge of conducting the body check. We shall definitely not give the enemy any chance to destroy what we have here!"

Everyone complied with the order. The people who had already passed the checkpoints were once again taken to the wharf by the personal guards. No one expressed any dissatisfaction and the queue was even more orderly than earlier.

“As expected of His Royal Highness.” Vader couldn’t help but be deeply moved. Just a few sentences were able to eliminate the imminent chaos.

“From what I heard, you were the first person to discover the problem. Am I right?” Carter Lannis approached him and said, “Follow me, His Highness wishes to see you.”

He followed behind the Chief Knight and went before the young prince. Kneeling down on one knee, he said, “I pay my respects to the prince.”

“Tell me, how did you notice something fishy about him back then?” The prince asked.

Vader went over his observations once more.

“An acute sense of perception. Are you sure you were just an ordinary citizen before?”

“No, Your Highness. I used to be part of the patrol team in Valencia.” He replied candidly. “I worked for roughly six years, until a large group of pirates raided Valencia.”

“However, in your CV, it wasn’t clearly stated that you have any personal strength.” The prince said, “I checked with Carter. He said that you’re still staying in the temporary settlements. In other words, you concealed your experience when City Hall was initially trying to keep track of people entering Border Town, when there wasn’t any need for you to do so. Why?”

Even though he didn’t know what a CV was, it didn’t affect his ability to answer this question. He hesitated for a moment and explained about Kukasim to the prince. “I would not have made it to Border Town alive, if it hadn’t been for the convict. For that reason, it’s impossible for me to leave him alone in the western district.”

“And thus you were willing to become a member of the patrol team. Are you thinking of giving him some extra benefits when you’re out on patrol in the future?”

“I…” Vader’s heart suddenly tightened. From the previous sentencing that he had suffered, he knew that His Highness was very particular about how nobody was above the system of laws he had set up. But his words earlier clearly carried a hint of crossing that boundary.

“Don’t worry. You haven’t done it yet. Just thinking about it won’t get you in trouble.” It seemed his mind had been read; the prince smiled and spoke.

However his words also left Vader with a hint of disappointment. It was beyond doubt that His Highness did not endorse his thoughts. Even if he successfully became a police officer, he would be required to settle disputes fairly and follow lead of the city clerks .

“Do you have a family?” The prince suddenly asked.

“…They lost their lives in the raid in Valencia.”

“How about Kukasim?”

“He probably doesn’t have any.” Even though he was unsure why His Royal Highness was asking that, Vader still truthfully replied, “If he had any, the street rats wouldn’t have chosen him as a scapegoat.”

“As long as one possess a special ability, they will all get priority for the right to a small residence. Furthermore, they will receive an identification certificate from the city hall and enjoy all of the rights of citizens. This offer naturally extends to their family members as well.” The prince smiled and said, “I believe you should be able to tell where I am going?”

Vader was startled, and was uncontrollably surprised. He said, “Do you agree to let me have Kukasim…”

“Bring the old man along to the city hall for registration. They will arrange everything for you.”

He endured the emotions stirring within him, got on his knees once again and said, “Thank you for your benevolence, Your Highness!”

“You still mustn’t let your guard down, though. You have to maintain vigilance as you have today.” The prince nodded his head and said. “Even if the two of you officially became relatives, you will still have to stay in the temporary settlements for the time being if you’re unable to pass the coming tests.

“Understood!”

The matter that had weighed down his heart had finally been answered and Vader began to feel a great tension leaving his entire body. Just when he was ready to leave, he suddenly recalled the written test he had taken. Hesitating for a moment, he couldn’t suppress his urge and asked, “Your Highness. During the first test, there were a lot of questions I did not know answers for and my answers were all confused. Why did you still pick me?”

“Because there were no correct answers to begin with.” The corners of the prince’s mouth curled upwards. “The answers themselves are different for every individual. What’s more, the key point of this test wasn’t in the answers. Instead, they were used to assess the candidates’ reading and writing abilities. As long as they understand the topic and articulate their ideas, they will pass the test.”

Chapter 341

Chapter 341: Transport route

Upon Vader's departure, Carter leaned towards the king and asked, "Your Highness, do you have any idea who sent those people here?"

"If we exclude the church, the person who possessed the pills would be Timothy. Garcia already keeps her distance from Greycastle and it is highly unlikely she would still care about me." Roland heaved a sigh. "Comparing them, it is much more likely to be Timothy. While he is more cautious about sending a large army away from the capital, that does not mean that he would not retaliate against me."

It was lucky that the attackers hidden among the crowd had carried pills instead of covering their bodies with gunpowder. Had they blown up in the crowd, two months' effort would have been wasted.

Roland was not worried that any so-called "suicide squad" his brother dispatched would have harmed him. On days the Nightingale was out, he had an escort of at least ten bodyguards with him at all times, and for additional protection wore a God's Punishment stone. When faced with the suppression of ten revolving firearms, even a witch extraordinaire would have difficulty approaching him, let alone a group of people with berserker pills.

In the short time since he had assumed the role of a Feudal Lord, less than a year, he found that his mentality had undergone tremendous changes. When he had begun this role, an incident such as this would have left him very afraid, to the point where his legs would have given way and he would have been at a complete loss. However, now, although he felt somewhat anxious earlier, he was still able to assume a calm expression and a composed demeanor.

The reason for this change was because he had faith that his guards would put themselves in harm's way for him and trusted them to protect him from enemies, regardless of the peril they faced. Furthermore, it was forbidden for

him to lose any self control, as he was the focus of the masses. Contemplating this, it shocked him that he would think so far…

“Round up the people from the missionary mission and ask them the specifics of the recruitment process.” Roland turned towards Barov and said, “I need to know where those people boarded the sailboats.”

“Yes, Your Highness.” said the city hall’s Prime Minister, with a somewhat gloomy expression on his face. He probably hadn’t expected his subordinates, whom he was so proud of, to commit such a large blunder. He felt that his dignity had been completely besmirched by this.

“You shouldn’t criticize them too harshly either. You can decide what to do with them after you straighten everything out.”

After all the refugees made it through the checkpoint, Roland returned to his office in the castle. This time, the news brought back by the missionary group was a particularly nice surprise—On the southern border were a large number of the destitute and homeless. The flames of war ravaged Eagle City and Clearwater Port, while the fields around the city had been abandoned. On top of that, the fluctuating weather this year had caused the temperatures in various areas of Greycastle to plummet. Because of this, the price of grains surged, increasing day by day, and the price of slaves had reduced by half.

As long as he could establish a reliable passageway for transport, he would be able to draw an unending number of people through the western border—In actuality, when the refugees heard how developed Border Town was, and that it was actively trying to recruit them, a sizable number decided to set off towards the town on their own. That was the report given to him by the missionary group.

However, the greatest difficulty would be establishing a passageway for it

During the month of the demon, all land traffic was halted by the sheer volume of snow, leaving the Redwater River as the only method of transport. The only boat that could travel the river was Little Town, which wouldn’t budge without the help of a witch. Just this boat would be vastly incapable of

transporting everyone. If he wanted ships sailing the waterway at all times, he would have to invest in the construction of at least 20 sailboats capable of sailing inland.

An apt example of the situation he faced would be the difficulties the missionary group had encountered. With all of the gold royals they had brought with them, only a small portion went towards roping in the refugees; the rest was used to hire boats and pay for housing arrangements for personnel. At the moment, less than 400 people had arrived in Border Town, while the other 3,000 or more remained waiting in Willow Town, Silver City, and Fallen Dragon Ridge for ships to transport them inland.

Because they were aware of the conditions in the western region, various captains had raised their prices to insanely high levels. The fees for the 3,000 plus people would be already as high as that of the large-scale rescue operation they had previously held in the capital. Roland, after giving the situation a moment's contemplation, decided that it would be wise to send a letter requesting assistance to Margaret's Chamber of Commerce. He hoped that the latter would not go so far as to give him a quote several times higher, on account of Lightning.

However, if he was truly dedicated to cutting down his expenses, he knew that he would have to build his own ship. As of now, the quality of reinforced steel and cement had greatly improved, it was wholly viable to build larger, sturdier inland ships with those materials. With a steam engine for propulsion, the ship would serve as the groundwork of the transportation industry within the Redwater River.

……

After he finished dinner in his office, Barov knocked on the door, opened it, and said, "Your Highness, I have more or less ascertained the situation."

"Speak."

"There's an apprentice of mine called Salem who is in charge of enticing the refugees in the northern lands. As he was faced with a lack of boats in the midst of returning, he contacted some friends he had met in the capital in

hopes that they could help him make some inquires or employ a couple of merchant ships that were willing to head towards the western border." Barov sighed and continued, "The news must have leaked from there… He had arranged some places for the refugees in Silver City, a little less than half a day away from the capital. I imagine it wouldn't be difficult at all if Timothy wished to tamper with it."

"As of this moment, how many people are still being retained in Silver City?"

"Roughly 800 of them." Barov began to speak in a low voice. "It takes about half month for the merchant ships to do a round trip. We will still be unaware on how the situation unfolds when the next batch of refugees arrive. How about… we immediately recall the small group of First Army soldiers in that area and abandon the refugees?"

"No, no. We will just have to get rid of the people Theodore planted within the group, no matter how many of them there are. So long as the audit checkpoints were properly managed by that time, we can simply get them to pass through it individually." Roland shook his head and continued, "What would we do if the refugees, who we abandoned and left to their own devices, went back to the northern lands and proclaimed their fate to others? If that happened, we would not be able to recruit refugees from the Northern Islands any more."

Under the interrogation of Sylvie's x-ray vision, as well as Nightingale's lie detection, any spy or assassin would have no way to conceal themeselves. Thus, he wasn't that worried about it. As long as they didn't hurt the other refugees, he was fine with it.

"Yes, your highness." Barov coughed twice before he opened his mouth and asked, "In that case… for Salem's punishment, what do you…"

"What do you have in mind?"

He hesitated for a moment and said, "As the birth of this incident was a result of his excessive carelessness, I suggest stripping him of his post in the city hall and a fine amounting 2 months his salary. As his mistake wasn't

intended, and didn't cause too much damage either, I believe it'd be excessive if we sent him into the northern mines."

Roland couldn't hold back his loud laughter. Barov's heartache was written all over his face. "Calm down, I have already made my decision. Seeing the reason he committed this mistake was, subjectively, not a dereliction of duty, I can give him a lighter punishment. After all, it can be considered as his first time undertaking such a post… As I recall, he is only in his twenties, right? Since that's the case, it is certain he will mature rapidly after this lesson. Giving him a two months fine will do."

"Understood." Barov immediately bowed and said, "Everything shall be handled as you said."

While shaking his head, the prince smiled. Although Barov had started in an unbelievable harsh manner, when it came time to truly punish Salem, he displayed an obvious reluctance. After all, Salem had always been by his side when he was in the capital and was also from the first batch of disciples who had come to Border Town.

"You may leave."

Roland stretched his back after dealing with this matter. Taking a few sheets of white paper from his drawers, he planned to sketch out the plans of the steam engine powered cement boat when Leaves suddenly ran into his room.

"Your Highness!" She excitedly said, "The Hawk Eye is back!"

"Really?" Roland slowly got up to his feet. Following behind her, they quickly reached the back garden, only to see a massive hot air balloon slowly descending to the ground. The shadow cast by its air sac caused the sunlight in the courtyard to darken somewhat.

The moment the basket touched the ground, Anna jumped out. With both hands outstretched, Roland began to walk towards her while the former mirrored him while wearing a light smile.

"I have returned."

Chapter 342

Chapter 342: Countermeasures

“Don’t forget about me.” Lighting rushed over.

“I want one too,” Nana exclaimed.

“Guu!” Maggie called out soon after.

Roland simply stood in place, letting each member of the Witch Union hug him in turn. When Tilly saw, she couldn’t help laugh, “You really have a harmonious relationship with them.”

“You want to hug your big brother too?”

“No thanks,” she said, smiling as she shook her head. “I can still clearly remember that time you lifted me up and then dropped me on the ground.”

Roland only shrugged his shoulders to express his innocence, then shifted his gaze over to the woman Ashes was holding—she had a head of ocean-blue hair, looked fairly young, with a figure similar to Anna’s. Her eyes were tightly shut and her slender eyebrows were slightly upturned. She had fair skin, and the teardrop mole at the corner of her eye appeared particularly eye-catching.

Based on external appearances, she didn’t look like someone who had been imprisoned in the basement of a stone tower at all. Instead, she gave off a bit of a sleeping beauty vibe.

However, her physical appearance led to Roland paying more attention to her outfit—In this age, clothing with such a diverse and intricate design was scarcely seen. Because there was such a small assortment of dyes, the violet colour of the robe itself was extremely rare. With the addition of those interlacing white stripes and talisman prints, it resembled one of those gorgeous gowns that could only be seen in movies.

This was definitely a piece of orange1 equipment.

“Is she still alive?”

“Yeah,” Nightingale replied, “but the magic in her body has been depleted. It seems similar to Anna’s condition back when she reached adulthood. But unlike Anna, the recovery speed of her magic is unusually slow. At this rate, she might need three to four days before she returns to normal.”

“In that case, we’ll let her sleep properly,” Roland nodded, “I will tidy up a room on the third floor of the castle for her to rest. The others should return to the hall first.” He paused. “I want to hear the tales of your travels.”

. . .

After listening to Tilly and Nightingale’s accounts, Roland couldn’t help but feel nervous for them.

Although Sylvie provided a full picture, going deep underground in pursuit of a huge demonic beast they had never seen before was a very dangerous affair. If it were him, he may have still been hesitant. He never expected that Tilly would be so decisive. She picked out suitable members for the task in a short amount of time and even led the team herself… Her appointment as the leader of so many witches wasn’t just due to her identity as a princess.

“At the time, did you think that this earth-drilling worm had something to do with the devils?”

“I don’t know, but it’s not impossible,” Tilly replied leisurely. “A witch from the Cooperation Association once encountered devils who were riding some kind of hybrid demonic beast in the wild. The beasts’ fleshy wings were cut off and they heeded the devils’ orders, sort of like tamed livestock. And behind the snowy mountains, you can also see creatures that are capable of flight——Those look completely different to devils, perhaps they’re another kind of demonic beast.”

“So isn’t it possible to surmise that devils and demonic beasts have a subordinate relationship, just like that of humans and hounds? They may have

some method of making these monsters obey their orders, and compel them to complete a few fairly problematic tasks."

"I feel… like it really does seem like it." Roland nodded, but his mind was clouded in incomprehensible uncertainty throughout her explanation. Demonic beasts would only take the initiative to attack human dwellings during the Months of Demons, but that did not mean they only lived during the Months of Demons——the moss and weeds growing on the carapaces of the sieging beasts were proof that these creatures had survived for tens of years. Assuming that the reason those devils were unable to rapidly occupy the entire wilderness and completely expel humans from the continent was due to being confined within the red mist, then they are free to constantly send demonic beasts to harass the four great kingdoms instead of waiting until winter to take action again.

Furthermore… It was hard to forget the intelligence of that wolf-lion demonic beast hybrid that once fought Iron Axe during the Months of Demons in the first year——it differed from the "clever" animals that followed their instincts. It was able to learn, analyse, and choose the best target and course of action. This already at a level that the vast majority of living creatures could never hope to reach. If long-lived demonic beast hybrids could possess such intellect, it would be impossible for them to be tamed by another race.

"But compared to the subterranean demonic beasts, I think that the enemy Miss Nightingale encountered outside the stone tower is more concerning." Tilly sighed. "It was able to conceal itself in broad daylight and moved so silently. It's practically impossible to defend against. It's a pity we know too little about demonic beasts, I have no idea how to handle such a terrifying enemy."

"If Nightingale had not witnessed it with her own eyes, I would not believe that such demonic beasts really exist." Roland shrugged as he spoke. "But it seems they have never appeared at the western border… Otherwise, if just a few of them came every winter, Longsong Stronghold would have long turned to ruins."

"But as the Months of Demons grow longer, the demonic beasts grow stronger; this is the conclusion reached by the history books. This time, the

first snowfall began in Autumn, so the enemy we face may be very formidable."

Tilly's use of the word "we" made Roland's heart grow warm. Whether she treated him as a brother or not, she already considered him and this small town as one of her own allies at least——This was probably done for the sake of the witches.

"Then we can only leave the surveillance of the perimeters to Nightingale."

"No, let Sylvie stand guard this winter," Tilly said, "The city walls are divided into two sections, East and West. To do a single circuit of the place would take almost a quarter of an hour, Miss Nightingale's workload would be too great. Sylvie only needs to stay inside the castle and she would be able to observe the entire region of the city walls. She would also be able to inform the other witches immediately upon discovering a demonic beast."

"That's fine too." Roland nodded.

"That witch…" Scroll hesitated for a moment. "I still have the same opinion as before. As long as her identity has yet to be confirmed, she could very well be an enemy."

"I know, which is why I will have her wear a God's Stone of Retaliation for the time being." He exhaled a breath of air. "Hopefully this won't cause her to misunderstand us."

. . .

Roland entered the bedroom of the unconscious witch. Anna was the only one left inside the room, looking after her alone.

"How is she?"

Anna shook her head. "Still no response."

"Is that so," Roland walked over to the bedside, the woman lying still under the blankets. Although her eyes remained tightly shut, the wrinkles between

her brows seemed to have reduced. Nana and Lily had already used their abilities on her, so the only thing they could do now was to wait quietly.

“She was frozen for so long, yet not a single trace of that remains. It’s really incredible.” He lamented.

“It’s similar to how I don’t fear any flames,” Anna chuckled, “Her ability definitely plays a part.”

“I heard that you were the one who opened the ice coffin.” Roland pat her on the head. “You’re amazing, Anna.”

“I can’t take all the credit,” Anna said earnestly. “This witch made use of her ability in a very ingenious way. She first used cold ice at an extremely low temperature to completely stop all circulation in her body, then used ice crystals that were close to room temperature to fully seal the cold ice inside to prevent it from thawing. She has surely reached a very high level of control over her abilities.”

Ice that approached room temperature… This phrase sounded very contradicting, but Roland understood that the abilities of summon-type witches were unique manifestations of magic, similar to the black flames that were capable of casually taking up different forms and temperatures.

Anna paused for a moment before continuing, “I had only just cut through the outer layer of ice crystals when the whole ice coffin immediately fell apart, like it was an opening she deliberately left behind. So, I think she had been anticipating this day for a while now.”

“By that you mean…”

“She is certain to wake up.”

1. Orange represents one of the highest tier of items in many MMOs and RPGs.

Chapter 343

Chapter 343: Reestablishing Order

“Master, the city walls have been breached! I’m afraid the allied armies won’t be able to endure for much longer. Let’s leave quickly!”

She could already hear the sounds of combat coming from outside. When she left the tower, she saw the gloomy clouds in the sky emitting a dim red light, resembling a clump of viscous blood.

“But my younger sister still hasn’t returned yet.”

“She’s a soldier of the garrison, she can’t leave her post on the perimeter without permission.” Kraft’s voice grew more anxious. “If you die here, you’ll be throwing away her good intentions!”

After hesitating for a while, she finally nodded in acquiescence. “I understand.”

The streets were filled with people fleeing while the guards maintained order within this impending doom. Amidst the stream of people, she was forced to follow everyone towards the south gate. Kraft closely followed beside her the whole time, and even used his sturdy body to protect her from being crushed by the frantic crowd.

It was a crushing defeat.

Is this where we fall? She cast her gaze towards the Tower of Babel behind them. It was the highest point in the city, as well as the core of the Federation. Flying Devils had carried Mad Demons over to attack the top of the tower. Lightning would occasionally flash, striking the devils down. Nevertheless, everything was to no avail—there were simply too many enemies.

After several hundred years of construction and development, this city had become the most flourishing of fertile lands, the Holy City. But today, it seemed like it would soon fall to ruin and the efforts of several generations of people would inevitably be lost—like children spending a whole afternoon building a sandcastle, only for it to be instantly reduced to sand once again in the wake of chaos and disorder.

. . .

When they passed through the south gate, the Devils had already rushed over to intercept them. Those who were still able to fight readily stepped up to fight them alongside the guards. But not only did the other side have Mad Demons, there were also Dreadheart Demons and Infernal Lords. The disparity between the strengths of both sides was too extreme.

Dozens of people lay in a pool of blood after the first wave of spears were thrown. Some had iron spears piercing through their abdomen, their warm intestines spilling out onto the ice-cold snowy ground. Some had their limbs cut off and were crying out in anguish while clutching their wounds.

“Master, what are you trying to do?” Kraft grabbed onto her.

“I can fight too,” She took a deep breath of air, “Let me go.”

“No, your importance far outstrips them. You can’t—”

“Let go!” Her magic bubbled forth, filling the surroundings with cold air as she shook off the other’s grip. She then strode forward without looking back. She felt her heart gradually tighten when she saw the enemies a mere hundred paces away, wearing ferocious-looking battle masks and holding weapons that were dripping with blood. But even so, she wasn’t willing to continue hiding behind everyone——as a witch of the Holy City, even if she were to die, she should die on the battlefield!

“Everyone, step aside!”

At this moment, a clear command resounded from one side of the battlefield as a person fell from the sky, just like a god descending.

With her back to everyone, she raised the longsword in her hand up high. Her long auburn hair resembled a flame, igniting hope in everyone in a flash.

“A Holy Warrior of the Federation!”

“She is… a witch extraordinaire!”

Amidst the voices of astonishment, the edge of her sword started glowing with a brilliant radiance, quickly transforming the sword into a dazzling gold—like the dawning sun, each ray of brilliance shining over the earth. Even the dark red clouds that dominated the skies did not dare obstruct the light, reflecting countless golden tassels below the layer of clouds. As the rays of light ascended towards the summit, she leaped forward and brandished her longsword against the Devils that came to attack.

The silence was deafening.

At that moment, time seemed to have stopped as a bright incandescence engulfed the world and the figures of the enemy mirrored the final hints of darkness at daybreak.

Whether it were the Mad Demons or the Infernal Lords, they all crumbled before this ray of light.

When she opened her eyes once again, the snowy ground before her eyes had already turned into scorched earth, and the approaching enemies seemed to never have existed.

The other Devils witnessing this scene all retreated in conjunction as more Holy Warriors arrived, joining the battlefield to pursue those fleeing enemies and breaking the encirclement.

“You guys go quickly.” The sword-wielding witch seemed to have exhausted all of her strength as she kneeled down on the ground with one knee and gasped for breath. “Take advantage of the moment and quickly leave this place.”

“But… Milady, where can we go?” Someone in the crowd asked.

Right, where can we go? She thought bitterly. Even their final stronghold, the Holy City, had fallen to the assault of the Devils, with tens of thousands of lives lost and no more tricks up their sleeve. They could no longer recover from this losing battle.

“Do not give up, we still have hope!” The red-haired witch said resolutely, “We’ll head over the mountain and across the river, to the desolate lands.”

“But… There are only a few backward-village peasants there.”

“We can always reestablish the order. Let’s go. As long as we can survive, there will surely come a day where we triumph!”

. . .

“Master, why didn’t you go with them?”

She had separated from the crowd with a group of people and rushed towards the west. Apart from Kraft and her family bodyguards, the majority of the others did not possess any fighting strength. They were all her retainers and servants from the tower.

“I left some important documents and magic stones inside the experimental lab in the Concealing Forest. Since we need to reestablish order, these things are essential to the witches. I want to bring them over to the other side of the mountains.”

“The Devils have caught up to us!”

“Hammer, Stone, you go obstruct them!” Kraft commanded.

“Yes!”

She gritted her teeth, proceeding forward with her head lowered. These mortals would only be able to slow down the Devils; they were simply unable to defeat these adversaries. Once they went, they would have no further chance to live. However, she had no choice but to abandon them as she needed to reach her destination as soon as possible.

For some reason, overlapping black and white spots appeared in the sky… And then her vision blurred.

. . .

Kraft panted as he followed behind her. Even someone as robust as him would feel very weary after trudging through snowy ground for three days.

She glanced behind her. The procession of thirty or so people had now dwindled to a mere six people. Some people had fled en-route, and some seriously injured people had taken the initiative to break away from the group. If the Devils were to chase up to them again…

“Rest assured, Master, you still have me.” Kraft appeared to have seen through her thoughts as he comforted her, “I will stall them as best I can.”

“Why?”

He was a little stunned.

“Why are you so persistent until the end? If you escaped now, maybe you would be able to survive.” She asked in bewilderment, “We are witches and have always been aloof and distant, while you are just an ordinary person. Under normal circumstances, you wouldn’t be thinking of accompanying me to death.”

“But you have never mistreated us. Although I don’t have any magic, I still have principles—protecting you is my duty.”

As an uproar sounded behind them, everyone understood that their final moments had arrived.

“Master, go quickly. You mustn’t look back.”

The black and white spots were increasing.

. . .

She staggered into the basement, and organised the data and magic stones that were on the table.

Kraft's words gave rise to some confusion for her.

Since a long time ago, one belief was spread throughout the Holy City: witches were people chosen by the gods, and the people unable to condense magic were both uneducated and powerless, only cultivating their soil. But from this captain of the Imperial Bodyguards, she could see valour and tenacity, nothing like the powerlessness people spoke of throughout the population. In fact, they had qualities that witches were unable to achieve. Cooperation between both sides was much better than unilateral command—at least this was the case within her stone tower.

That being the case, how did the people from over 400 years ago suffer such a crushing defeat?

Suddenly, the bellows of the Devils resounded from outside the door.

Damnit, they arrived faster than expected.

Her vision was blurry and countless spots fluttered before her eyes, practically filling her entire field of view… But she couldn't die here, she had to bring her research results out— past the mountain and across the river, over to the desolate lands to rebuild their social order!

She groped around for a magic stone of reverberation and imbued her magic into it, causing it to produce constant cries for help.

There was a loud noise and the wooden door split apart; the Devils had already broken in.

Hoping that someone might hear her cries for help, she circulated all of the magic power in her body and converted it into cold frost which was then discharged. A Mad Demon raised its spear, its arms rapidly swelling up. In the next moment, the spearhead flew at her with a cold ray of light.

She couldn’t help but close her eyes as the black and white spots covered everything and her vision turned pitch-black. All the sounds faded as well. Her body no longer felt cold, as though she was wrapped in soft velvet. It seemed like she wasn’t in a gloomy basement, but instead lying in a warm meadow. Even the feeling of impalement did not come for a long, long time.

Did I die?

After some time, a fine slit appeared within the darkness which subsequently grew brighter and brighter. She attempted to open her eyes slowly, and a hazy grey ceiling projected itself in her eyes little by little.

She heard someone say, “Your Highness, she has awoken.”

Chapter 344

Chapter 344: Past Events (Part 1)

Your Highness?

What a queer form of address… It's something you'd only hear in the tales of old.

Attempting to move her eyes was a struggle. She tried casting her gaze to the side only to see a gray-haired man enter her field of view, several women standing by his side.

"How do you feel?" he asked softly.

"…" she didn't reply, asking a question instead, "Where am I?"

"Border Town, Kingdom of Greycastle's western territory."

Great, she thought. Things currently looked to be developing in the direction she least wanted them to: an unknown location, an unknown time period, and unknown people. She wanted to get up out of bed, but she discovered that she couldn't muster a single iota of strength.

"I am Roland Wimbledon, the fourth prince of the Kingdom of Greycastle as well as the feudal lord of Border Town," he continued after a short pause, "These girls are members of the Witch Union. You… Do you not remember anything?"

Witch Union? she frowned, So they're witches? I don't know what kind of newfangled organisation this is, but at least we're alike. Still… Why do they look like this man's subordinates?

Wait, a prince?

She thought back for a moment and couldn't help feeling stunned. Wasn't this one of the titles used in the secular regime during the First War of God's Will over four hundred years ago? Could it be… Did I return to a time before the start of the great war? Could the gods have possibly given me another chance to start over, to make preparations, to rescue the Holy City and its people?

No, calm down, she told herself, This kind of completely illogical affair would only occur in a fictional tavern story. That's right, she thought while trying to recall the scene at the end. There was a horde of Mad Demons that had charged into the experimental lab's basement and she had discharged all the magic in her body to construct the sturdiest possible ice barrier. A magic stone of reverberation had been set to release distress signals non-stop, awaiting the day they restored their fertile fields and could locate her again.

"Were you the ones who saved me?" There was no mistake, she had already escaped from the ice barrier so the only possibility was that the witch's army had returned! "Have the Devils withdrawn already? Have we won!? The Holy City… What happened to the Holy City of Taqila?"

Having blurted out this series of questions, she saw the faces of the other party change. They looked at one another with expressions of joy and excitement. "We really did find you in the basement of a stone tower," said a witch with a mature looking face and auburn hair. She clearly couldn't stop herself from asking, "Are you truly someone from four hundred and fifty years ago?"

That person reminded her of the miraculous Holy Warrior who had fought against impossible odds. That woman's hair had also been like this, like a flame igniting everyone's spirit. She was more willing to answer the witch's question than the one the grey-haired man asked. She did not usually care much for social hierarchies, but she nevertheless found being interrogated by someone beneath her somewhat offensive.

Had it been her petty master in her place, this man would most likely be severely punished.

"My name is Agatha, a witch of the Taqila Exploration Society," she paused, "What do you mean by four hundred and fifty years ago? Don't tell me…

Have you been fighting with the Devils for over four hundred years? That's impossible."

"You've slept for a very long time, things might be a little different from what you imagine," said the man who called himself Roland, "If you think it won't be a burden to your body, we can fill you in slowly."

"Go ahead."

Agatha closed her eyes and took a deep breath. This prince behaved very rudely, but she did not have the energy to argue about such matters.

As the other party began to detail the history relating to Greycastle and the development of the Four Great Kingdoms of the continent, she felt shivers creep down her spine. She soon discovered a few familiar features in his tale—the Concealing Forest and the Impassable Mountain Range for example… But when she compared these points with her memories, the conclusion was absolutely shocking.

If those places corresponded to the ones in her memories, then those so-called Four Great Kingdoms were part of the desolate lands of the past—a long, narrow area situated between the mountains and the sea that was, in her contemporaries' opinion, a barren place with no development value whatsoever. And the forbidden wastelands he spoke of laid where she remembered the fertile plains to be. Finally, when it came to the Holy City of Taqila, it had long become a region no one knew of, buried in the depths of the fertile plains after many, many years.

How ridiculous was this?

However, there was something to top even that.

The status of witches in society had been lost along with Taqila. According to the prince, witches had unexpectedly become the target of opprobrium in the wider society and the regular people had a firm grip on power in the Four Great Kingdoms. All those obsolete playthings from before the First War of God's Will now called themselves kings and lords.

Yet it was precisely these antediluvian beings who had become the rulers that dominated the witches.

How could this be?

“Preposterous!” She couldn’t stop herself objecting, “To have witches actually be killed by regular people? Who would be courageous enough to dare do such a thing?”

Full of indignation, Agatha extended her arm, intending to teach this drivelling man a lesson, but to her surprise the magic failed to transform into frost and was not discharged.

It was only at this moment that she noticed a metal cuff fastened around her ankle. When she lifted up the quilt she saw there was a stone embedded in the shackle – a God’s Stone of Retaliation.

“Are you guys insane!?” She looked at the group of witches in disbelief, “You would go so far as to help a regular person suppress a high-ranked witch, violating the Federation’s prohibition on unauthorized use of a God’s Stone of Retaliation!?”

Only the Federation’s law enforcement team was allowed to use the God Stones. Anybody apart from them who dared to carry, sell, modify or destroy the God Stones would receive the most severe of punishments, up to the death penalty.

The prince sighed, “This was what I was worried about.”

“Don’t worry, I’ll go and talk to her,” the auburn-haired witch sat at the bedside, covering Agatha’s body with the quilt once again, “My name is Wendy. You see, things aren’t really as you believe them to be. Not only is all he said true… Taqila no longer exists and I have never heard about the federation you spoke of either. I don’t know what the Holy City you lived in four hundred and fifty years ago was like, but nowadays we witches are always spending our days in hiding. As we have been until we met Prince Roland.”

“He gave us a safe place to stay, encouraged us to use our powers, and at the same time researched ways on how to make use of our abilities to transform the world. Here, we can live completely free, just like a normal person, without the need to hide. Neither do we have to worry about suffering persecution from the church or the masses. You must know that nowadays God’s Stones of Retaliation are everywhere. A witch that loses her powers is no stronger than a normal person.”

After listening to Wendy’s story, Agatha was completely silent.

The Federation was a large organisation established jointly by several witch kingdoms. It possessed many high-ranked witches and witch extraordinaires. They concentrated their forces in order to win the War of God’s Will and the Federation formed a colossal army while incorporating every Holy City into the fold at the same time. It was responsible for training and dispatching witches, resolving disputes, and maintaining the stability and public order of the city. Only it had the power to capture and try a witch… Yet somehow an organisation that powerfull had declined so much that no one knew of its reputation nowadays…

Those refugees who wanted to re-establish order, she mused, Where are they now?

Chapter 345

Chapter 345: Bygones (Part II)

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

Elsa was perplexed by the immense changes. She told herself not to believe them, but their stories sounded so real that she thought no witch could have made it up out of blue.

Putting herself in their shoes, she could never imagine she was slaved, hunted or even slaughtered.

Even ordinary people with the lowest status in the Holy City were treated by witches as human beings instead of animals.

She started to feel extremely exhausted. Wendy sensed it and brought her a cup of hot milk and tried to console her, “Oh, dear, drink this milk, and you’ll feel better.”

Though the lady with reddish brown hair didn’t have the godlike power and strength, she affected Elsa with her good temperament and manner…. Elsa drank the milk in one gulp. A warm and sweet current flew into her gut, which helped her recover a little. Elsa rested for a long period before she continued their conversation.

Although she couldn’t understand why these witches were wary of her, she knew that she must win their trust first, or they wouldn’t help take the fetters off.

As for the credibility of what the prince and Wendy said, she had to find out by her own eyes.

She wouldn’t believe the words that the holy Union had vanished before she saw the cramped and underdeveloped Barbarian Land with her own eyes.

“As I said, my name is Elsa, and I was a member of Taquila Quest Society. In the 30th year of the Battle of Divine Will, Taquila, the last Holy City, fell down in the war. Most people went into exile, while I went to the Misty Forest to fetch things we left there. ”

“Wait. Were you fighting against the demons?” asked the Prince.

“Who else could be fighting against them other than us?” Elsa frowned. “Should we rely on vulnerable humans like you?”

“Were you a witch raised by the Church?”

“I never heard of anything about the Church. What’s it?” she said impatiently. “Taquila… no, all the Holy Cities which hosted tens of thousands of people were created by witches. Apart from witches, most of the citizens were ordinary people… like you. They were responsible for reproducing and raising children until their magic power was awakened. And then these young witches would be handed over to another special department to receive education and training. Of course, the witches who were good at fighting would join the Union and participate in battles with demons.”

The prince pondered for a moment, and then took out a book and asked, “Can you read it?”

Elsa skimmed several lines and was attracted by the content at once. “This is a diary from a witch.”

“Did you also write in this way?” a witch with light gray hair asked.

“This writing system was created by the Union and exclusive to witches. In this way, the ordinary human beings would be prevented from participating in important affairs at upper level. But in my opinion, I didn’t think this sort of exclusion was a good idea.”

“How could you prevent ordinary people?” she asked with a great curiosity. “Even if witches created another language system, ordinary people could also grasp it through learning, right?”

“It takes magic power to read it,” explained Elsa. “It isn’t very difficult. I can teach you since you’re a witch.”

“Language is a tool for communication.” The prince commented. “The more popular it is the better. So what the Union did was very stupid. The exclusion of ordinary people would only limit the resources available to you. In fact, after training and education, ordinary people are capable of many jobs. Except that they cannot use magic power, they are as good as witches.”

Although Elsa agreed with him, yet she could hardly accept that an ordinary person criticized the Union. She would collaborate with them when necessary, but she couldn’t tolerate their finger pointing.

She began to miss Kaff, her chief guard.

Even though he was only a subordinate to her family, she thought he was more gentle than the so-called prince.

“My name is Scroll, Miss Elsa,” another witch who looked pretty mature, suddenly asked, “Have you ever heard of the name of Alice?”

“How come you know this name?” Else suffered a jolt. “Wasn’t it said that all the records about 450 years ago had been lost?”

“I found an ancient book in the ruins located in the forest on East Border of King City in Graycastle,” said Scroll. “It’s the one on your hand. Her name is on the last page written in ordinary people’s language.”

Elsa quickly turned to the last page. After reading the illegible diary, she deeply sighed and fell into silence. A female statue started emerging in Elsa’s mind. The lady raised her long sword, with light radiating from her body shinning and dazzling all the people’s eyes. But finally her figure was fading away, step by step, little by little. In the end it totally dissolved in the darkness.

After a long while, she said slowly, “Right, Alice was the Queen of the Meteor City as well as one of the three chiefs in the Union.She was an

Extraordinary, or a Transcendent. Even among amounts of Blessed Ones in the Union, she was also the strongest."

"A Transcendent!" The crowd murmured.

"Since these records have been lost, it's natural for you all knowing nothing about it," Elsa said in a serious voice. "The abilities of withes will be enhanced continuously since they awoke and become stable since the Day of Adulthood. But it isn't the ceiling of their ability growth. Some lucky dogs can step forward and get unbelievable achievements… We often call it the High Awakening. In fact, there's no limit for their awakenings, or growth rate. But obvious changes could be observed on the performance of their magic power."

"Hum, is this ability evolution?" The prince touched the back of his head and muttered. "In total, four witches have evolved in the Witch Union."

"Four?" Elsa was almost choked by that. She asked surprisingly, "How many witches are there in your Witch Union exactly?"

The prince counted with the help of fingers and said, "More than ten."

" Stop talking nonsense!" Elsa obviously seemed to be enraged by his rash words. "Do you mean four out of ten have undergone the High Awakening? You have no idea what evolution means for witches.It's totally different from the consolidation or derivative skills on the Day of Adulthood. Only the luckiest ones can be promoted, which takes both perspiration and inspiration!"

The prince looked rather innocent and gestured to Anna.

"What a pretty and elegant girl!" Elsa said to herself as she watched the girl walk towards her bed. She was extraordinarily good-looking even among all the witches. Her beautiful blue eyes seemed like a lucid lake, where Elsa could see her own reflections. But she was too young and maybe just had her adulthood. It was impossible for her to accumulate enough experience in training, meditation and enlightening. Elsa evolved at 26 years old. At that time, she was treated as the most promising genius in the Union for her

achievement. She knew how difficult the evolution was since she went through that.

“They probably take derivative skills a young witch developed on her Day of Adulthood as a High Awakening,” Elsa said to herself .

A ball of orange fire appeared in Anna’s palm.

“It’s the ability to control the flame, a common type of the summoning capabilities, which can be ranked by the maximum temperature and the heating rate,” she gave her comments quickly. “The one who can eject the flame are regarded as a combat witch.”

Just after Elsa’s words, the blaze dimmed away, and then turned into a tongue of fluorescent green flame. It began to change its color, from dark green to light green. It seemed that the green flame tried to absorb all the lights around so that it could become stronger and stronger.

“This is the consolidated skill she mastered on the Day of Adulthood, and you’ll see her most important skill soon,” the prince explained.

“Is it? No, it can’t be a consolidated skill! If it were, the flame should be hotter and the heart of the flame should be bigger and brighter.” Elsa was astonished with her mouth wide open. “Besides, what’s her most important skill?”

Soon something incredible happened. The green flame suddenly disappeared, and a black solid cube emerged in Anna’s palm, which looked like a piece of rigid metal with smooth facets and angular sides.

Chapter 346

Chapter 346: Bygones (Part III)

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

“Well … does this count as High Awakening?” asked the prince.

Elsa didn’t know what to say for a moment. What was left in her brain was – how could this be?

The Holy City had been forgotten, and the Union had been destroyed. There was nowhere for the witches to receive training and guidance, so it was only logical that the witches’ abilities declined. But what did she just see? A newly matured witch had received two promotions. This couldn’t be explained by luck. After all, even in the Union, the home of geniuses, a witch like this was still very rare.

Furthermore, if she heard correctly (serve her right is only for memory, not for eyes or ears), there were three more of them who were equally talented as Anna?

Elsa stared at the man with gray hair motionlessly. It was some time before she could recover, “This… should count as High Awakening, but I don’t have the Stone of Measuring, so I can’t measure her change in skill.” She paused, her throat feeling dry. “I want to ask, if I may, what did Anna experience during her awakening? She seemed to have come of age not long ago. Could these two awakenings have happened in only the past one or two years?”

It was not until she finished talking that she realized she had used honorifics. The status of a witch couldn’t be inherited. Even if a great number of common people were put together, there was no guarantee a capable witch would come out of them. Thus, a witch’s level was usually decided based on capability instead of origin. According to Anna’s ability, she was already qualified to be a high-level member of the Union. Compared to herself, Elsa felt that Anna was at least her equal, if not her superior.

Any awakened senior was worthy of respect.

“My first awakening happened after I exhausted my magic power while fighting against demonic beasts. As to the second awakening, I think it was caused by my learning of knowledge.”

“Knowledge …” she was startled, “what kind of knowledge?”

“Ahem, this can be discussed later,” the Prince cleared his throat. “Now let’s get back to the topic we were discussing earlier. What do Alice and Experiment of God’s Punishment Army exactly mean?”

“Indeed, if he wasn’t lying to me, this knowledge must contain something extraordinary in itself. That was why Anna could awaken a new ability through epiphany. So it’s understandable that he didn’t want to elaborate on it before he could trust me.” Elsa could not help but feel excited. Enhancing the chance of evolution had extraordinary significance toward witches. If she could figure out its mechanism, reviving the Union wouldn’t be impossible.

Then again, where did he acquire this knowledge from? This place is but a barbarian land. How could a bunch of peasants like him understand the secrets of magic power?” She was full of confusion. What had the world become in these 400 years?

Elsa put those intractable problems aside for the time being. “Alice was very powerful. With the help of God’s Stone of Retaliation, she wouldn’t be defeated even faced with several Lords of Hell. However, there were too few Transcendents. Put differently… the lack of diversity in our ability led to our defeat.”

“Diversity?”

“That’s right. A witch wouldn’t know what kind of ability she would have before awakening. But according to the Union’s calculation, only ten percent of all the witches were fit for combat – the same ratio could be applied to Extraordinary Witches. As to what the ratio was of combat witches that were actually promoted, no one knew. There was a period of time when not a

single witch was promoted within 50 years. Thus, actually the fighting ability of the Union was very unstable."

"So mortals may necessarily awaken, the awakened may not be good at combat, and combat experience doesn't necessarily lead to capability. Is this what you mean?" the prince said with one hand fumbling his chin.

"That's about right," Elsa sighed. "We formed a guard platoon composed of mortals to compensate for the witches' number shortage, but … mortals could not defeat demons." Even equipped with God's Stones of Retaliation, they were still far from being able to fight against the mighty Mad Demon. Under this unfavorable situation, Alice ordered the Quest Society to research warriors that could break through the limits of the human body. Judging from this scrawled note, it seemed that she had succeeded …"

"Seemed?" the prince said in curiosity. "Didn't you say that you were a member of the Quest Society?"

"Indeed. But ever since the order was issued, I left the Taquila Quest Society and began to build my own lab in the Misty Forest." She bit her lips and hesitated for a moment before proceeding. "They quickly found the solution, which was to unite witches and mortals by force with the help of God's Stone of Retaliation, but… this process required them to consume the witches' lives. I couldn't accept this approach. I believed that the Quest Society should focus on exploring the use of God's Stone of Retaliation, rather than using witches as consumable resources. What's written on the note is right. This behavior would only bring destruction to witches."

The prince looked a bit shocked, "Using witches as consumable resources?"

"Alice did this out of helplessness. At that time Taquila was on the verge of destruction," Elsa felt the prince somehow looked a bit pleasing to the eye when she saw that he showed an expression of sympathy. "But now the Union has vanished into thin air, it proves that this approach wasn't able to proceed, and probably won't ever appear again."

After she finished talking, she bowed her head and fumbled the book with her hands, 'climb over the mountains, wade through the waters…' how familiar

the slogans were. “Yet where are you now? How could I possibly revive the order all by myself?”

“But God’s Punishment Army is still there.”

Upon hearing this, Elsa’s fumbling fingers suddenly froze. She looked at the prince with disbelief, “What… did you just say?”

“I am not sure whether this is a mere coincidence,” the other said very slowly, as if he was looking for the appropriate wording. “The Church… the organization you’ve never heard of, established two cities at the grand opening in the middle of the Impassable Mountain Range. Those cities were named Holy Cities. The hunting of witches was also initiated by them. What’s more, they also searched for orphans and street urchins, and brought them back to the monastery of the Holy City. Wendy was one of them who had escaped.”

“The church had its own army and territory. Its most powerful warriors were from the God’s Punishment Army. Those monsters who had lost their sanity had infinite strength and were almost as mighty as Extraordinary Witches. And their numbers were absolutely not few. Apart from that, they might even have owned a number of powerful witches, which is why I temporarily sealed your ability with the God’s Locket of Retribution.” The prince laid out his hands, “Prior to what you told us… we had always thought that it was the church who established the Holy City of Taquila, fought against the demons, and left the ruins.”

Elsa opened her mouth but was unable to utter a word. How could it be that an organization composed of mortals took away the most important secrets of the Union, hunted witches in return, and built God’s Punishment Army to consolidate its rule? She suddenly had a splitting headache. So God’s Punishment Army didn’t vanish, but fell into the hands of an organization that hates witches! What on earth did the members of the Union do?

Wendy must have sensed her exhaustion and discomfort, because she gently pushed Elsa down onto the bed, and said in a low voice, “Let’s call it a day. Have a good night’s sleep. Rest assured that we will find out the reason.”

Then, she felt something loosened from her ankle-the God's Locket of Retribution was taken off by Anna. The crowd left the room one by one, and the gray-haired prince was the last.

As the door being closed behind him, Elsa heard some calm steady words.

Chapter 347

Chapter 347: Confusions

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

…

“How is she?” Roland asked. Roland put down the pen, looking up at Nightingale who had just quietly appeared in his office.

“She’s fallen asleep. Before that, she had a bowl of oatmeal. It seems that she had a good appetite.” Nightingale went to the table and sat back in her old place. “Now it’s Silvio’s turn to guard her.”

“Well, that’s not bad.”

“Do you believe what she said?” Nightingale asked.

“With the God’s Stone of Retaliation being removed, you can easily judge if she is lying when you question her tomorrow, but…” Roland paused for a moment, “I think most of what she said is true.”

“Why do you think so?” she asked curiously.

“Have you noticed that as a person from 400 years ago, she’s using the same diction and language as us?” the prince said with his hands propping up his chin. “Theoretically, such a situation would be almost impossible for two territories separated by the Impassable Mountain Range, unless these two territories were of the same origin and had frequent contact.”

“But she called the Four Kingdoms the Barbarian Land.”

“That’s the point … I don’t know what the scene was like 400 years ago. Perhaps all this used to be was just a few scattered villages and some criminals exiled by the world of witches. The Kingdom’s history book also

records that the age of the major cities was generally between 200 and 300 years, and astrologers also came into existence during that era," he said with great interest. "It had always bewildered me that the astrologers, who generally had no achievements nor research findings, were also called 'sages', the same as alchemists. Now I think I've got my answer—the Union fled to this borderland, and brought with them the survivors, their language and civilization. These people mingled with the locals, and helped the latter build the regime, fortress and city."

"You speak as if you'd seen it happening." Nightingale shook her head, smiling.

"This is the only way we can explain why we're using the same language as her," Roland said earnestly, "because we're of the same origin. And during these 400 years, civilization was constantly in the process of rebuilding without the slightest opportunity of advancing past where it used to be. "Alright," she said with her hands laid out, "anyway, you'll know the answer by tomorrow, and if your guess is wrong… then you'll have to give me a 'luxury lunch'."

The so-called luxury lunch was composed of corn soup, roast chicken drumstick and ice cream bread and was usually only served once a week.

"What if you're wrong?"

"Whatever you want," said Nightingale, tilting her head and squinting. The perfect curve formed by her cheek and smooth neck was exceptionally beautiful. "Regardless of what kind of movement an attractive person makes, it will always look seductive." Roland finally believed this saying.

"I will bear that in mind," he said with two coughs, turning his attention back to his notebook.

Since Elsa had only recently awakened after four decades of sleep, Roland didn't want to press her to give accurate and detailed answers to all his questions. For the most part, his questions followed her train of thought, and the information he gained was quite disordered as a result. What he was

doing at the moment was to rearrange the information he gleaned from Elsa, and to find out the key points he had to know next.

Undoubtedly, the most pressing problem was about the demons.

What was the cause of the war with the demons, and why did the demons cease fighting? This information was essential to Border Town. No war could have been started without a reason, but the demons' behavior didn't seem like an attack motivated by resources or expansion. They didn't occupy the Barbarian Land, nor did they pillage mankind. What they did seemed like an act purely for the joy of slaughter.

Roland also noticed that Elsa mentioned the term Battle of Divine Will. Could it be that the two sides waged the dreadful war under the will of God? But at that time, the Church hadn't come into being, so there wasn't the one and only God that the Church declared. Without this explained, his mind remained unsettled.

Meanwhile, he needed to figure out the basic necessities of life in the Holy City's civilization as soon as possible, or in other words, assess its degree of economic and civil development. He needed this information to measure the level of this civilization and deduce the demons' capabilities.

As for the Union, Roland wasn't too concerned about it. Its witches were scarce and their abilities were unstable. This organization's capability for organized combat wouldn't be very high. Historical experience had repeatedly stressed that before the formation of a generation gap, a comprehensive war was all about attrition. A few sophisticated weapons wouldn't reverse the overall disadvantage.

The second question was about the Magic Stone.

Considering what Tilly said, the magical nature of such stones could greatly compensate for the witches' unstable ability, enabling the witches to exert powers that didn't belong to them. In this way, even auxiliary witches could be sent to war. However, in Roland's point of view, that was like putting the cart before the horse. He'd rather turn all the combat witches into auxiliary witches and put them all to work in production roles.

Oddly enough, the Union, which had large numbers of witches, didn't make use of Magic Stones to fight against the demons. Instead, it chose to produce God's Punishment Army, which in Roland's view was beyond comprehension. Maybe the Magic Stone had some unknown shortcomings, or its production was extremely difficult?

Fortunately, Elsa was a member of the Quest Society, an organization similar to the current Alchemy Workshop, which gathered a group of highly talented witches specializing in the research of Magic Stones and magic power. Roland faintly felt that there must be a wealth of potential information to be exploited.

The last question was about the Church.

He drew a circle on this column. Obviously, he couldn't count on getting details from Elsa about the organization's foundation and development. What he could infer from the scattered information at hand was that the Church was founded after the witches' defeat. After obtaining the Union's secret, the Church concealed everything about the witches and declared them as incarnations of demons. If the people of the Four Kingdoms were seen as descendants of aborigines, the Church would be a veritable outsider. Since the aborigines didn't have their own civilization, they could be easily fooled by fabricated history and prophecies.

"Was it only because the witches used to suppress ordinary people that the refugees took the witches as their enemy and went on to hunt the witches on this continent?" Roland frowned. "All these deductions did sound reasonable, yet… he felt that there was something wrong."

The Union had a great number of Bliss Warriors, Extraordinary Witches, and even Transcendents. Even if the Church managed to get a hold of God's Stones of Retaliation, was it possible for them to defeat an opponent like the Union?

To wipe out a much stronger force, you couldn't purely rely on hatred. Clearly there was some key information missing.

"That witch seems to dislike you," Nightingale suddenly said.

“After all, she used to live in a world where the witches were considered superior to the human being.” Roland laughed. “I’m afraid I’m just no different from the roadside weeds in her eyes.”

“Don’t you hate her?”

“Why would I? She is nothing but a poor woman abandoned by her own time.” He shook his head. “She’d been sleeping in the frozen coffin for 400 years, and woke up to find the world had completely changed. The strangeness brought by the new world would bring her fear, so it was no surprise that she would build a defensive wall in her heart. After she accepts all this, she will probably gradually change her point of view.”

“What a typical response of yours,” said Nightingale with a smile. “But rest assured, I won’t allow her to offend you in any way.”

Chapter 348

Chapter 348: Mortals and Extraordinaries

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

When Elsa woke up again, she was alone in the room. The thick curtains were tightly closed, making the room extremely quiet.

Probably considering the fact that she wasn't familiar with the environment, someone put a candle beside the front of the bed, which was quietly burning with orange flames.

Elsa turned her head and watched it for a long time, only to find that there wasn't a single drop of wax overflowing. The candle seemed to be burning forever without any change in the length.

"It may be caused by magic," she thought.

The quilt was so soft that it was probably made of high-quality cotton and filled with light and warm fluff. The treatment was as good as that in the Holy City of Taquila, which made it hard for Elsa to believe that there could be such comfortable beds and bedrooms in Barbarian Land.

She moved her fingers and found that she had recovered most of her physical strength. Elsa rolled out of bed. She drove her power, and chill overflowed from her fingers immediately— "It seems that the prince didn't play any tricks. He had God's Stone of Retaliation removed to give me a certain degree of freedom." She went to the window and opened a bit of the curtains. It was totally dark outside. Stars couldn't been seen, so did the moon. The whole earth seemed to be swallowed by darkness with only a few hazy flare shaking so far away. She could hear the wind roaring outside next to the window, and could occasionally see some snow falling on the glass.

It seemed to be winter now which was a good season for the awakening of witches. In Taquila, this kind of evening didn't even exist since the whole

city would celebrate every day of winter.Bonfires burned throughout the night on the street. When she overlooked the city on the tower, it seemed to be lit by flares shining like stars, which symbolized hope and a promising future. People prayed around the campfires, eager to gather magic power and surmount the mortal world. Whenever a witch awakened, the fate of her family changed as well. They don't need to worry about food or clothing anymore.

Elsa pulled up the bolt and opened the window. The cold wind suddenly swept into the room and blew the curtains away. The candles in the house were snuffed out as well. The room suddenly was plunged into darkness. When her eyes became adapted to the changes of light, she could see the faint white light reflected by the accumulated snow on the roof of the town. "Judging from the silhouette of the buildings, this place isn't very big indeed, and is identical with the 'Border Town' mentioned by the prince."

Ordinary people would be frozen after a few hours if they stayed outside in such cold weather. But Elsa wasn't afraid of the cold since her body would automatically expel the slightest chill that made her uncomfortable. The last time she felt cold was before her awakening. But now, she had almost forgotten the feeling.

The earlier conversation was lingering in Elsa's mind as long as she closed her eyes.

The Union died and the witch became the devil's minions. Hence mortals were recklessly hunting witches with the help of God's Stones of Retaliation… According to the diary, Alice and Natalia successfully fled from the Fertile Plains. But if they failed to stop everything, the Union was doomed.

What on earth happened at that time? Why were the two Transcendents defeated by mortals?

She was reluctant to think about that anymore.

"Aren't you cold?" someone behind her suddenly asked .

Elsa was shocked. She turned back and saw a girl sitting by the bed in the dark. Her face was completely hidden in the night. She was like a ghost that appeared quietly. The door was closed at that time, but Elsa didn't hear any footsteps before she came in.

"If you can close the window, I don't mind re-lighting the candle," she said again.

There was no doubt that the girl was a witch.

But it's late in the midnight. What's she up to?

Elsa nodded without any word. She closed the window and secretly let the thin yet hard ice cover her skin. The girl didn't do anything dangerous; instead, she opened the first drawer of the night table from which she took out a flint to light the candle. In the candlelight, Elsa saw the her. She had beautiful golden curls and slender eyebrows which made her eyes look very sharp. Elsa hadn't see her before.

"Nice to meet you… Oops. It's the second time that we meet," she raised her lips and said, "My name is Nightingale."

Did she mean that… she also hid in the crowd before? "Is this your ability?" Elsa frowned and asked, "Are you also the High Awakened?"

Even if she was one of the honorable High Awakened, it was still impolite of her to break in without knocking at the door.

"Ah, you are talking about evolution…" Nightingale shook her head. "I'm not that smart like Anna. She finished the book called 'The Theory of Natural Balabala' in a short time. My head is going to explode once I see those formulas and theorems. Maybe I don't have the luck to evolve in this life."

Elsa was absent-minded for a short period because she couldn't understand half of what the girl said. Honestly, she didn't expect that "an Original Witch" could say something like that. Besides, according to her facial expressions, the girl didn't seem to deliberately tease herself. "Is that what the prince called… knowledge?

“As for the book you mentioned, can I read it?”

“Of course. You may read it as long as you join the Witch Union and be loyal to His Highness.” She shrugged her shoulders.

“To serve a mortal?” Elsa stared at her and said in a low voice after a while, “I thought I was weird enough, but you are crazier than me.”

“Weird? Crazy?” Nightingale tilted her head and asked, “Why would you say that?”

“In the Holy City of Taquila, most of the Awakened Witches only treat ordinary people who couldn’t gather magic as humble servants, inferior people, or … fertility tools.” She said slowly, “but I didn’t think so. Even though they were stupid, they weren’t hopeless. Those people were no different from witches in many aspects as long as they were taught to learn and think. Because of that, many people thought that I was so weird that I had allocated part of the business in the tower to mortals. However, I didn’t expect that you are crazier than me since you are loyal to a mortal and take orders from him.”

“His Highness Roland didn’t consider us as servants,” Nightingale twitched her mouth and said, “I don’t know what kind of strange idea you have on the word of loyalty, but the fact is that he took in the witches oppressed by the Church, gave us new power, and let us live together with his subjects in Western Region. We are united to fight against the Church and demonic beasts, as well as against the demons in the future

“But this model was proved to be a failure!” Elsa couldn’t help raising her voice. “400 years ago… for you, it might be 800 or 900 years ago, the world was ruled by both mortals and witches. At that time, human beings lived almost throughout the entire Dawn Region. However, when demons attacked, we suffered such a big defeat that we only managed to keep the Fertile Plains.”

“Oh?” She raised her eyebrows. “Was that true?”

“You said the history had been buried for 400 or 500 years,” Elsa continued, “According to the Union’s records, the third Battle of Divine Will is about to break out very soon, yet you have no idea of demons! The east of Barbarian Land is Swirling Sea. So where else can you retreat? Only by rebuilding the Union, uniting witches and improving the probability of High Awakening with knowledge can we seize the final chance to stop demons’ attack!”

“Why do you have to say that?”

“What do you mean?”

“400 years have passed, right?” A lot of things could be changed in such a long time. But why are you still restrained by those old ideas? ” Nightingale sighed. “His Highness said that mortals could defeat demons when he left. You heard that as well. He is also uniting all the people, including witches. He wants to unite every ordinary person on the continent, because he told me that people across the land are the most powerful group. ”

“Wasteland—” Elsa was about to refute this nonsense when she suddenly paused. “The girl is so certain that she seems to know the result in advance. Could 400 years really change everything? Does that prince with gray hair really have such incredible ability to let mortals have the same power as witches?”

“You seem to have realized that,” Nightingale smiled and said, “We still have a lot of time, so why not open your heart and to see with your own eyes?’

This time, Elsa was silent for a long time. “… I can see that you don’t like me.”

Nightingale didn’t retort.

“The witches of the Quest Association used to see me like that as well—after they knew that I had appointed a group of mortals as experimental assistants in the tower,” she said. “Obviously, you don’t like me, but why do you tell me these?”

“I don’t hate you as long as you stop being so arrogant and treat His Highness normally. As for your question… ” she paused and continued, “because the prince said he didn’t want to see you abandoned by the times.”

Chapter 349

Chapter 349: Passing On (Part I)

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

Standing on the top floor of the Tower of Babel, Mayne peered through the window towards the snow-covered city of Hermes.

Since the last attack by a large group of demonic beasts on New Holy City, peace temporarily returned to the icy plains, and the fall of snow weakened. The citizens of Hermes were able to enjoy an unlikely, but timely respite.

Even though this was supposed to be a time of happiness and celebration, Mayne continued to feel nothing but emptiness in his heart. During the attack, in order to kill the terrifyingly-large, hybrid, demonic beasts, a platoon of warriors from God's Punishment Army dashed out from the side entrance of the city wall and fought them head-on. In total, 19 warriors were wounded and two were killed. As for the two beasts, they laid on the ground, growling for a long time after the warriors hacked off their limbs. Eventually, the city wall's guards killed them with spears. Rather than the loss of the warriors, it was the timing of the demonic beasts' attack that terrified Mayne.

After remaining silent for some time, he let out a long sigh and returned to his seat beside the table. He wanted to flip open the Canon and read through it carefully one more time.

"Even if you flip the book until it breaks, the result isn't going to change." Tayfun said as he walked into the circular room holding two hot drinks, and placed one in front of Mayne. "His Holiness O'Brien hasn't agreed to meet you?"

"I've sent my request to the Pivotal Secret Area three times already, but there's still no reply." Mayne said anxiously. "And I have no idea what His Holiness is up to at such an important time…"

“Don’t worry,” Tayfun interjected, “as you’ve said yourself, the Canon was written by the first Pope, and hence there are bound to be mistakes. After more than four hundred years, who can guarantee that everything in the book is accurate?”

“But this time it’s different.” The Archbishop shook his head. “If the time is miscalculated, it’ll be a serious catastrophe for us! We’re investing a lot of strength and energy in unifying the kingdom to gather all the power of the mainland against the demons. But, if the time is shortened by half, we have no way to build up God’s Punishment Army sufficiently after the war!”

“Quiet, Lord Mayne.” The old bishop laughed and slowly sipped on his hot drink. “What’s done cannot be undone. We can’t change the fact that Fang of Hell appeared before us. But there might be two reasons for this.”

“What reasons?”

“Drink first and I’ll speak,” Tayfun said, stroking his beard.

Mayne picked up his cup. It looked like goat milk at first, but when he brought it closer, a spicy smell rushed into his nose. “What did you put in it?”

“Coltsfoot.” Tayfun tilted his mouth. “Although you aren’t able to directly drink Dreamland Water, drinking a bit of this will be beneficial for you. It’ll help you to release your tensions, soothe your nerves, and sleep easier.”

With one gulp, Mayne emptied the cup and soon felt a fierce burning sensation in his throat. Although the savory taste of the goat milk was supposed to dilute the coltsfoot juice, it was still extremely uncomfortable for someone who did not consume such drinks often. He coughed twice, wiped his mouth, and said, “Even a cup of Dreamland Water wouldn’t make me fall asleep. Can you speak now?”

“One possibility is that the Pope made a mistake in writing. Old men get dizzy spells and moments of amnesia very often, as I know very well.” Tayfun shrugged.

“That’s unlikely.” Mayne frowned. “This concerns the layout and arrangement of the Church, and more importantly, determines the destiny of Man. I’m sure he took great care in writing this down. What’s the second reason?”

“The second possibility is that there are circumstances we don’t know about that have changed everything.”

The Archbishop waited for a moment, and upon realizing that the old bishop had no intention to continue speaking, he questioned, “That’s it?”

“Well, that’s it.” Tayfun repeated.

“Is this… a joke? Everything changed? For this simple reason, all of our efforts will go down the drain! How can you be so cursory…”

“Lord Mayne!” Tayfun raised his voice a few notches. “What exactly do you insist on getting? Is it a sure-fire way to defeat the demons? Or do you think that you’re the only person who wants to defend Hermes and prevent the demons from entering the icy plains?”

“…” Mayne froze.

“In any battle, everyone wants to win. But so far, we can’t even assure victory in every battle against the Four Kingdoms, not to mention the demons from hell.” Speaking in a louder voice, he said, “Have you forgotten the Supreme Pontiff’s teachings? The consequences of over-insistence and fear aren’t too different. What you should do is accept reality and take things step by step till the end – the eventual result isn’t for us to control.

Fear of… the result. Mayne’s heart palpitated. “He’s right, I’m indeed afraid. Afraid that after becoming the Pope, I’ll be unable to fend off the demons, and watch the death of Mankind under my charge.”

“I used to be like you,” Tayfun suddenly lowered his voice, “but Heather’s death made me understand that the result is often unpredictable. The Months of Demons came earlier than usual without warning, yet we were still able to capture Wolfheart City before the big snowfall, as planned… but Heather

died and the nature of the war changed. Even so, we still have to carry on." He stood up and let out a long sigh, then patted Mayne on the shoulder and walked out of the room. "So… whether for five or ten years, you must be unrelenting in your mission, not for the path of certain victory, but to fulfil your duty even if the result turns out to be not what you desired."

After hearing the door closing, Mayne gazed at the empty cup in front of him and remained silent.

He had to admit that Tayfun's words were reasonable, but now that he was about to shoulder this heavy responsibility, how could he not feel afraid?

Suddenly, a Presiding Judge walked into the room. "Lord Mayne, the Supreme Pontiff wishes to see you."

Finally!

He stood up immediately, and said eagerly, "Take me quickly to the Pivotal Secret Area."

…

Hidden deep beneath a plateau, the Pivotal Secret Area was a cold and quiet place.

Walking into the hall of the Pivotal Secret Temple, Mayne seemed slightly dazed. Although there was no incarnation ceremony arranged for the day, all of the candles in the hall were lit up and the resultant candlelight sketched out an orange-yellow silhouette for the hall. The overhead chandelier seemed like a gathering of stars in the Kingdom of God.

His Holiness O'Brien was sat on the throne, silently gazing at Mayne.

Mayne felt something was not right, but suppressed his suspicions, and walked up to the throne. He knelt prostrate with his forehead touching the floor.

"Rise, child." The Pope's voice was very delicate, and without paying attention it would be difficult to hear what he was saying.

Mayne straightened his body, and saw that the Pope's face was ridden with age and fatigue, as if he had not had a rest for a long time. "Your Holiness, please take care of your body."

"No need." He laughed, and deep wrinkle lines covered his face at once. "I'm going to die soon."

"Your Holiness, you aren't…"

"No, listen to me, child." O'Brien labored to interrupt the Bishop. "I understand the condition of my own body, and without question, my time is soon up." He paused for a moment and took a deep breath. "The purpose of calling you here today… is to pass on the Pope's position to you."

Chapter 350

Chapter 350: Passing On (Part II)

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

Mayne froze and stared at the old man in front of him, hoping to see something in his eyes.

But he saw nothing other than lifelessness.

The Pope's eyes were no longer as penetrating and authoritative as they used to be. Perhaps, he still possessed the wisdom passed down from previous Popes, as well as the knowledge obtained from the Canon, but… nothing escaped time.

"His Holiness wasn't kidding," Mayne realized. His journey was reaching its end.

Mayne's eyes started to blur.

He knelt once again, with his forehead touching the floor. This time, His Holiness did not ask him to stand up, but instead waited until he completed the entire action before saying, "Follow me."

The attending guards helped the Pope on to a cart and wheeled him towards the gate of the Pivotal Secret Area. Mayne followed closely behind, and the party left the Pivotal Secret Temple, turning into a long and narrow tunnel. On the smooth stone walls of the tunnel was embedded a luminous crystal at every ten steps' distance. Looking down the tunnel, one couldn't see the end.

After walking for a long time, Mayne finally left the tunnel and entered a well-lit room. Beneath his feet, the floor had turned into flat slabs, and he was able to see the edges and corners of the walls, as well as the chandelier that hung from the ceiling. Apparently, the tunnel had led into an underground chamber.

“We’re underneath the cathedral of the old Holy City.” Perceiving Mayne’s bewilderment, the Pope clarified. “The design of this place is identical to the cathedral, except that it is built upside down. I call it the Reflection Church.”

“Underneath the cathedral?” Mayne exclaimed. “I never expected there to be a basement.”

“It’s not a basement indeed, because the two aren’t mutually accessible.” O’Brien smiled. “This place is only accessible through the underground tunnel of the Pivotal Secret Area. The roof is made of an extremely thick mixture of slab and clay, which is impossible to break through using conventional methods.”

“Why… is such a design necessary?”

“To guard a secret, without completely burying it.” He replied. “Before a Pope ascends the throne, he must come to the Reflection Church to witness the establishment, development and expansion of the Church, and at the same time, learn by heart the goals of the Church.”

“To defeat the demons,” Mayne said solemnly.

O’Brien did not nod in agreement, but instead said softly, “No, child. To win the smile of God.”

The Archbishop was briefly at a loss. “What?”

This time, the Pope did not respond, but instead commanded the guards to continue moving forward. According to the direction of the stairway and the ramp, they were moving upwards. Soon, the party arrived in front of a grand hall. By recognizing the designs in the surroundings that he was familiar with, Mayne identified the place as the Prayer Room of the Reflection Church.

The thick wooden door of the room was pushed open with a creaking sound. Although it seemed that the Pope had not visited this hall for a long time, there wasn’t a smell of dust… Evidently, someone had been keeping this place clean at all times.

“They’re only allowed to send me thus far. From here on, you’ll have to push me into the room.” O’Brien said.

“Yes, Your Holiness.” Mayne took the cart handles and pushed the Pope into the Prayer Room. Closing the wooden door behind him, the room no longer received light from the torches outside. Now, the only light remaining in the room was the soft radiance of the yellow crystals – similar to the arrangement in the tunnel, the crystals were embedded evenly on the walls of two sides of the room. However, a notable difference was that above each crystal hung a large portrait. Mayne vaguely remembered that the positions of the portrait frames were where the windows of the Prayer Room above ground went.

The portraits’ contents were much the same. They were half-body portraits of people wearing magnificent gowns, looking full of energy, with their eyes seemingly fixed upon anyone who entered the Prayer Room. Mayne was astonished when he found His Holiness O’Brien’s portrait among them – the drawing looked exactly like the real person, and stared at Mayne with a smile on his face. A strange feeling caused Mayne to shudder uncontrollably, and goose bumps covered his back.

“Ah, you found me.” The Pope seemed to sense the Bishop’s change of emotion. “This portrait was completed half a year ago. At that time, I didn’t look quite as old as I do now, and hence it’s relatively good-looking. By right, the portrait should only be hung up after my death.” He observed the portrait carefully. “Blame it on my impatience, for I wanted to see how I looked on the portrait earlier than I should.”

“Your Holiness, these are…” Mayne felt his throat turn dry.

“Yes, they’re the noble pioneers, the Supreme Pontiffs of old.” O’Brien said softly. “Let’s continue moving forward, and I’ll introduce them to you.”

The Archbishop listened to His Highness’ descriptions, while at the same time studied the portraits – even though he understood that they were the former leaders of the Church, but an inexplicable strange feeling continued to linger in his mind. The persons in the portraits were simply too lifelike, and Mayne was unable to imagine what techniques and dyes were used by the

artist to produce these half-body portraits. Under the dim yellow light, the top half of the portraits gradually faded into the darkness as Mayne walked further, leaving visible only the lower section of the faces which continued to grin at him.

Halfway through the grand hall, Mayne unexpectedly noticed the portraits of women.

Their looks were dissimilar and they were dressed differently, but each of them could be said to be movingly beautiful – it was rare for mortals to have such remarkable appearances, as the Bishop well knew, and it was for this reason that he felt extremely puzzled and astounded. However, His Highness seemed unconcerned, and continued to calmly introduce their names, terms of service, and contributions.

Each of these people was a former Pope of the Church.

The two men soon reached the end of the Prayer Room.

Facing the central aisle of the grand hall was a full-body portrait which occupied an entire wall on its own. It was hung behind the sanctuary, and its four sides were decorated with shiny crystals, which made the picture look even more vivid.

Mayne swallowed hard and walked up to the portrait.

At the very instant he managed to get a full view of the painting, he felt his heart leap up. “O holy, a woman of peerless beauty!” Aside from these words, there was no other way for him to describe what he saw. From her looks, she possessed both feminine beauty and masculine fortitude, which blended naturally and did not conflict with each other. Her red hair seemed like streaks of burning flame, while she wielded a large sword which looked wanton and capable of extinguishing all fires and evil desires. She stood erect holding the sword, with her eyebrows slightly raised, both eyes glancing forward, her slender lips firmly closed, and looked naturally powerful and imposing. Under the gaze of her sharp and penetrating pupils, Mayne felt an immense and overwhelming pressure which almost coerced him to kneel in front of this magnificent lady.

“Your Holiness, this is…”

He struggled to turn his head, only to find that O’Brien had already knelt down.

“She’s Alice, the First Pope and a Transcendent. She also has a nickname – the Queen of Witches.”

Mayne felt his heart jump violently. His earlier speculations had turned out to be absolutely correct – the first Popes of the Church were witches!

“Why was the founder of the Church a witch?”

“Kneel and pay respect, child. I’ll let you see everything that you wish to know later.”

Chapter 351

Chapter 351: Illusions (Part I)

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

After Mayne paid his respects, he carried the Pope back on to the cart.

“Zero,” O’Brien gasped and called softly.

A Pure Witch dressed in white entered the room through a small side door, taking light footsteps which were barely audible. “I’m here.”

The Archbishop frowned. He did not expect the presence of a Pure Witch in such a secret place. “Even though they were single-handedly raised by the Pope after their awakenings, and served His Holiness for life, these women are, after all, witches.” Furthermore, he felt a little unhappy that this person seemed to know about the Reflection Church earlier than he did.

“Take him to the Illusion Room.”

“Yes.” She walked up to the sanctuary and pressed down the stone carved Canon on the table. A magical light flashed and the giant portrait started to rise upwards slowly, revealing a black metal gate. Then, Zero took the crystal pendant off the Pope’s neck, inserted it into the door lock and twisted. A clicking sound was heard from inside the iron gate, and it started to open outwards.

She pulled out the crystal pendant, but instead of returning it to His Holiness O’Brien, she placed it in Mayne’s hand.

The Archbishop turned his head back to look at the Pope, and the latter nodded his head. “Take it. You’ll keep it from now on. You may use it to open the library of the Pivotal Secret Temple, or the secret door of the Research Office.”

“Let’s go.” Zero smiled and took Mayne by the hand. They walked together into the room behind the giant portrait – it was probably no longer the Church in the same position above ground, and there was nothing in the room except for a floor-to-ceiling window which faced the highlands of Hermes.

The room looked very spacious and was formed in a circular structure. It was approximately half the size of the prayer hall and could accommodate rows of ten people standing side by side, such that it was difficult to associate it with the name “Secret Room”. However, within this space, there was no furniture. The only place to sit down was a stone bench that extended along one of the room’s curved walls.

After the metal door was closed, Mayne threw off the hand of the Pure Witch and asked, “Did His Highness allow you to enter?”

Zero dismissed his question. “If I don’t come with you, who’s going to activate the Stone of Illusion? It’s not like you have Driving Power.”

Her rude response made Mayne’s heart skip a beat. “It seems that she still regards herself as His Holiness O’Brien’s witch. After I receive the scepter and take control of the Church’s domain, I must absolutely let her understand that she shouldn’t only respect the Pope, but also the Archbishop who has heirship.”

“Then let’s start.” He held back the emotions that triggered in his heart and sat down on the stone bench.

“Yes, Your Highness.” Zero lifted open a dark panel on the wall, and pressed the Magic Stone with her hands. “But please be prepared, for this is the first time I’m activating this thing.”

“The first time? Hasn’t she lived for over two hundred years? Didn’t she participate in the previous papal handover ceremonies?” Mayne felt a little puzzled, but before he had any time to dwell on it, a dazzling ray of light flashed by and he found himself covered in darkness.

The darkness was so complete that there was virtually no light at all, causing the walls, floor and the stone bench to disappear from sight. Mayne felt as if

he was swallowed by a giant beast from the abyss and suddenly lost all concept of distance. The sky and the earth seemed to merge into one entity, and all he could see was darkness. Lowering his head, he realized that he could not even see his body.

Holding his breath, he cautiously reached his hand down and touched the stone bench which remained underneath him. Stamping with his feet, he realized that the floor was also in place. These allowed him to feel a little relieved. Hence, it was fair for Mayne to believe that he had not been transferred into a new underground chamber, but simply that the Magic Stone had absorbed all the light in the room. ,

“However, under this darkness, how is it possible to witness the “truth” that His Highness mentioned?”

As if responding to Mayne’s question, the floor started to brighten again, but it was obvious that this no longer the same Secret Room. The slabs on the floor were polished until they were glossy and slick, reflected a dark blue sheen, and on every one of them was carved various elaborate and exquisite patterns. Soon, rays of light streaked down from overhead, and Mayne was astonished to see a transparent skylight appearing on the roof. Peering through the skylight, he was even able to see the clear sky and clouds.

In a short while, more furnishings appeared within the room: a marble round table was surrounded by chairs, with a globe and glass cups placed on top; the four walls were curtained; an ornamental sword and shield were erected in the middle of the room; a Megacerops’ head hung from the top of the doorway.

What followed were shadows of people.

Mayne watched in disbelief as lifelike figures of women appeared one by one in the room. Each of them was wearing a magnificent robe, and they sat around the table. Sat facing the gate of the hall was none other than the leader of all, the red-haired Queen of Witches. Her hands drooped and folded in front of her, with her head raised and her chest out. Her eyes looked directly forward while the other women’s eyes focused on her. To Mayne, all of these seemed like an extremely realistic painting.

“Was this what the ‘illusion’ in ‘Illusion Room’ represented?” Mayne mused. The illusion before his eyes was perfectly identical to a real scene, such that for a moment, the women seemed to come alive.

“Everyone, the Experiment of God’s Punishment Army has been successful,” said a witch sitting beside Alice. “They’re now extremely aggressive, fearless of life and death, and extremely powerful. Even a feeble assistant witch can be transformed into a mighty warrior who isn’t inferior to the Original Extraordinary. In addition, they also have the ability to disrupt the release of magic power, and hence when facing Mad Demons and Lords of Hell, both of whom require the Stone of Driving to fight, they undoubtedly possess a huge advantage.”

“But the incarnation ceremony consumes witches’ lives, and I’ve heard that not everyone can be successfully transformed.” Someone said.

“These are insignificant details.” She unfolded her hands. “I believe that with the continuation of the research, the Quest Society will be able to remedy this.”

“Don’t talk so easily, Elaine. We’re already short on numbers, and therefore every witch is precious!” That other person frowned.

“What’s the difference between dying in the demons’ hands and dying in the ceremony?” Elaine raised her head and said. “At least with the latter, a contribution is made to the Union prior to death.”

“What are you saying…”

“Enough.” Alice said softly. Even though her voice was very soft, the scene was instantly silenced. Everyone kept their mouths closed and awaited the Queen’s forthcoming words.

“Mortals cannot defeat the demons, my sisters,” she said calmly. “We can choose to do nothing but simply enjoy this final moment of peace, and when the next invasion of the demons arrives, we’ll be completely consigned to history. Or, we can choose to put up a final fight, placing our hopes in the God’s Punishment Warriors, and make necessary sacrifices for them. I admit

that this is a difficult choice, but as long as there is a chance to prolong the existence of Mankind, the spirit and determination of witches will never break."

"Although I'm the Queen of Starfall City, I'm willing to allow you to make this important choice. Do you want to give up the resistance and die in peace, or do you want to avenge our dead sisters, chase the demons out of the Dawn Region, and restore the past glory of witches? It's entirely up to you."

"Of course, none of us is able to directly participate in the third Battle of Divine Will, hence no matter which choice we make, we can live out our transient lives peacefully. Remember, the choice which you make now isn't only for yourselves, but for the whole group of witches… for our future sisters to still be able to see God's smile."

"Those who don't agree, please stand up now."

Chapter 352

Chapter 352: Illusion (Part II)

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

§§ Chapter 352 Illusion (Part II)

“So… that’s what happened then!”

Mayne could not take his eyes off the illusionary scene, and his heart leapt like never before.

“The incarnation ceremony of the God’s Punishment Army turned out to be invented by witches in order to defeat the demons, and they willingly sacrificed their own kind… How many of the witches present would stand up and castigate her for her cruelty?”

The final result was beyond his expectation. After a few minutes, not a single person stood up. Even the witch who questioned the ceremony did not openly oppose Alice’s words, albeit gritting her teeth and smacked the table as she thought, “How ironic! Having killed so many witches with her own hands, she can still talk about it being for the continuation of witches! Is there anything more ridiculous than this?”

“But she isn’t wrong,” said an elderly witch. “We’re after all born of mortals, and thus if Mankind was wiped out, witches wouldn’t be able to persist either.”

“Conversely, no matter how many witches are sacrificed in the incarnation ceremony, there’ll always be new witches to replace them. The more mortals there are, the more witches there’ll be.” Elaine shrugged her shoulders.

“Is it certain that the God’s Punishment Army will defeat the demons?” Someone asked.

“I don’t know,” said Alice. “Before we try, nobody really knows. The defeats in the previous two Battles of Divine Will have already shown that the demons are way stronger than us, and the only way for us to restrict their actions is to use the Red Mist. This implies that even if we create a large number of God’s Punishment Warriors, it’s uncertain that we’ll secure the final victory.” She paused. “But you should be familiar with how I do things.”

Elaine smiled and said, “Even if there’s only a small chance, we must try our best.”

“I’m willing to follow you wherever.”

“For the continuation of witches.”

“I, too, don’t want to admit defeat.”

Everyone stood up and saluted the Queen of Witches.

The witch who raised questions was the last to stand up, but she declared, “Hopefully you’re right.”

“So it’s decided.” Alice nodded, seeming unsurprised by the result. “What we’ve to do now is to convince the other members of the Union.”

“They won’t necessarily listen to you,” said the elderly witch. “If we’re to carry out the incarnation without resistance, the witches cannot continue to act in a superior and privileged position. The Union must be disbanded, and the past must be completely buried.”

“I’ll do my best to convince them,” Alice said in a resolute voice. “If they aren’t able to accept it, Starfall City will carry out this plan alone, and a new order will be made.”

Shortly, the scene disappeared… Darkness consumed everything again. When light in the Secret Room was restored, Mayne realized that his back was soaked in cold sweat, and his head spun terribly.

“You look a little tired. Shall I carry you outside?” Zero walked over to him and asked.

“No need. Quickly open the door!” Mayne said, taking huge gasps of breath.

After the metal door was opened, Mayne stumbled out of the Illusion Room, and then covered his mouth as he rushed over to the Sanctuary, and knelt in front of O’Brien.

“After the Magic Stone was activated, the scene was automatically mapped into your mind, hence feeling discomfort is perfectly normal,” the Pope said softly. “The first time I came into contact with these, I had the same reaction as you. You will be fine after a short rest.”

“Why didn’t I have any problems?” Zero asked, embracing the Pope’s arms.

“Because you’re a witch, thus your body has long been used to the operation of magic power.” O’Brien smiled benignly. “Whether in terms of endurance or resistance, witches are universally far superior to mortals.”

It took a long time for Mayne to calm his breath down. “This is the Church’s… origin?”

“Yes. After this, Alice led the witches of Starfall City and two other cities into battle, eventually emerging victorious, and laid down a new set of rules. Witches were no longer the chosen ones, but instead became the evil ones who were lured into degeneration by demons. This war lasted for nearly a hundred years, and is known in the history books as the Battle of Faiths.”

“Did she live for that long?”

The Pope shook his head. “Not long after Alice established the Church, she perished along with another Transcendent. The second Pope inherited her will and continued to lead the Army into battle until they completely subdued two other factions. Unfortunately, this battle badly damaged the three cities, and they virtually lost control over the world. The mortals who were unwilling to participate in the battle began to settle down in this narrow

strait, and led the indigenes to cultivate the land. Gradually, this became what is now the Four Kingdoms."

Somehow, O'Brien became more energetic as he spoke, and even his voice became more coherent and no longer as feeble as it used to be.

"After that, the Church continued to eliminate its remaining enemies on many occasions, including mortals who didn't belong to Starfall City. But the world order had already taken shape, and due to a lack of strength, the Church was never able to complete the unification of the continent. All of this is due to the early death of the Queen of Witches."

"Natalia, whom she considered a friend, not only rejected her plan but also suddenly attacked her during a meeting. This was recorded in the unabridged Canon." The Pope sighed. "If she was still alive, the Battle of Faiths would have ended fifty years earlier, and after the Church accepted all witches into its membership, it would have easily unified the continent. No one expected the Battle would continue until today."

Mayne wiped the sweat on his forehead and said, "Your Highness, there's something I'm unclear about. Why were the earlier Popes all witches, while after that, it became entirely normal people?"

"Zero, you should head back first." O'Brien kept silent for a brief moment before saying.

"Yes."

Only after the Pure Witch had departed, O'Brien slowly said, "Because of weakness and cowardice."

"W… what?" Mayne was shocked, and for a moment, hesuspected that he had heard wrongly.

"No, child, you didn't hear wrongly." O'Brien seemed to have read his thoughts. The Pope's eyes gleamed, and he looked as if he had returned to a younger age. "In order to restore the witches' glory after defeating the demons, Alice had stipulated that the Pope's position must be taken up by an

Extraordinary. But Extraordinary Witches were very rare, and it wasn't always possible to find the ideal candidate. Therefore, a few prominent ordinary witches served as the Pope – but weakness and cowardice were like poisonous snakes in the heart which could never be removed once they appeared. A mortal who served as the Archbishop was afraid of being oppressed by the witches someday and therefore usurped the Pope's position."

Mayne's eyes opened wide. "And therefore, the later Popes were…"

"Yes, all of us are cowardly descendants who profiteered from the witches' sacrifice." The Pope let out a long and deep sigh. "No matter what happens, the Church has to bury this secret forever." He paused. "The truth regarding the Battle of Divine Will is recorded in the Pivotal Secret Temple. It's now for you to bear this responsibility and continue the line. Even giving up… may also be a wise choice."

After saying these words, his whole body abruptly slackened, as if he had put down a heavy load, and he lay down and slumbered on top of the cart.

"Giving up? If he did so, who else was going to take over this position?" But before he had any time to ponder, Mayne realized that something was not right with O'Brien — his physical condition took a dramatic turn for the worse, and the spirited look of only a moment ago disappeared. His eyes' muscles relaxed rapidly and the radiance from his eyes slowly faded.

"Your Highness, Your Highness O'Brien!" Mayne shook the Pope's body anxiously, but O'Brien stared vacantly at the ceiling with his mouth twitching slightly, as if he was murmuring something.

At the last moment, Mayne felt him saying, "Child, I'm sorry."

Chapter 353

Chapter 353: The Quest Society

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

As the night wore on, a soft ray of light peeked through the cracks of the curtains.

It was daybreak.

Elsa had barely slept all night. Her head had been spinning with Nightingale's words.

"The mortals of this continent are the most powerful ones."

"So much can change in 400 years. Why can't you let go of past ideas?"

"You still have much time ahead of you. You can confirm it with your own eyes."

Elsa rolled out of bed and walked over to her clothes-rack, resting her hand on the robe of the Taquila Quest Society. As she reminisced about gaining the unanimous approval of the Three Chief Witches when she earned this robe, her spirits leaped with joy. Exploring the mysteries of magic power had always been her lifelong pursuit, and the Quest Society's most revered motto was "Existence is truth". So, if those mortals really could prove their ability…

Elsa put on her robe, opened the door, and walked towards the grand hall.

"In any case, I am probably the last member of the Quest Society, as well as the sole survivor of Taquila. If I want to rebuild a new Holy City, it will take more than a couple of days. But before that, I might as well have a look at what this mortal prince could possibly be capable of to have witches at his beck and call."

After breakfast, Elsa, accompanied by Wendy, went to the office of the prince with gray hair.

At a glance, the Prince looked no different from people of 400 years ago. However, he gave off an aura unlike a common mercenary, merchant, or farmer, but it was also different from Kaff, her head of family guards. It took only one glance to see right through these kinds of people, whose deepest thoughts were usually very easy to read, as if they were only symbols on a piece of paper. However, she could not perceive the prince in the same way, especially his eyes. Although they were a simple set of gray pupils, they seemed to be filled with indescribable radiance and confidence. More importantly, this confidence was not blind optimism. It exuded a kind of calmness and peacefulness beyond his years. It was as if he had lived for… thousands of years, and knew all that was in this world like the back of his hand.

“Why do I feel this way?”

“He is Roland Wimbledon.” Elsa thought, silently memorizing this name.

“How did you sleep last night?” He smiled. “Did the oatmeal and fried eggs 400 years into the future suit your tastes?”

“It was so-so, but it would have been better if you hadn’t let a witch barge into my room.”

He was stunned for a moment, and shook his head resignedly. “Alright, she will knock next time. Oh, by the way – if you wish to take a stroll outside to explore the town and people’s customs, you can ask Nightingale to show you around. If you wish to read history books, you can ask Scroll; she has kept all the books she read in her mind.”

“People’s customs?” Elsa frowned, “With the dangers of demons looming over us, I would love to see how you have the audacity to claim that mortals can defeat demons. If you can’t fend off their attacks, all the history and customs are completely meaningless!”

The Prince smirked and said, “Compared with heavy industry, light industry and civilian livelihood are just as important… Why are you so interested in cannons?”

“What do you mean by light and heavy?”

“Nothing… Never mind…” The Prince sighed, “You will soon see, and we’re going to test new weapons this afternoon. But before that, I have some questions to ask you – questions about the Holy City of Taquila 450 years ago.”

New weapons mortals operating ? Elsa’s mind immediately went to crossbows and mangonels. If he simply updated these weapons, they would not be nearly enough to defeat the demons. However, she did not let her skepticism show. “Ask away.”

“You mentioned that the Holy City of Taquila was a city ruled by witches and that mortals without magic power could only belong to the lowest class. How many meals did mortals eat in a day? What was their staple food? Did they eat a lot of meat?”

Elsa was stunned. She did not expect him to ask such questions. “There were also ranks within the mortals. The mortals who served Senior Witches by running errands or protecting the city had the same standing as the weakest assistant witches. Below them were farmers and merchants, and lastly came slaves and coolies. As for what you asked, I have no idea – no witch in the Upper City ever paid attention to what mortals ate. As for the guards and servants in my tower, they were all provided with three meals a day. Except for the “Months of the Demons”, they got to eat meat once a week.”

“What was their salary?”

“What is that, money?” She arched her brow. “They became my attendants and vowed to serve me for life, and in return I gave them shelter and food, and I imparted my knowledge onto them. They didn’t need any other compensation.”

“I see.” The Prince scribbled furiously on a piece of paper and asked, “Did the witches participate in farming, livestock breeding, or iron forging?”

“Of course, all of these things were done by assistant witches,” Elsa replied. “Although they were only assistant witches, they were far superior to commoners – if commoners handled the work alone, they could never fulfill the Union’s needs.”

This back-and-forth went on for almost half-an-hour. He seemed to be especially interested in basic necessities of life in major witch cities and asked extremely detailed questions, which confused Elsa to no end. “Compared with these insignificant matters, isn’t he concerned about the demons who have already conquered more than half of the Dawn Region and are about to strike again?”

The Prince paused for a moment and handed his notes to Scroll. “You said that you were a member of the Quest Society and that this society specifically studied Magic Stones and magic power?”

Finally, such a decent question was asked. Elsa nodded, “Yes, the so-called Magic Stone is transformed from God’s Stone of Retaliation, and it can suppress a witch’s ability, but it can also give her unique powers.”

These remarks were a shock to everyone. The witch who called herself Tilly blurted, “How is it done?”

Elsa finally felt a rush of her past importance and was quite pleased, “For the past 400 years or so, the Quest Society made endless sacrifices to pursue the secret of the relationship between magic power and Magic Stones. I can share it with you, but you must also share your knowledge of increasing witches’ awakening rates in return.”

Tilly and Roland exchanged a glance, “No problem, but I am still confused by one thing.” She lifted her left hand, and the blue crystal resting on her finger glinted with a striking light. “This Magic Stone was discovered in the ancient ruins and enabled me to fly – there is no doubt that this type of Magic Stone is immensely powerful. When battling the demons, it will give troops an advantage in both attacks and retreats. Not to mention, it saved quite an

amount of time in my daily commute." She paused, "So why did you still retreat on foot? How was it that even a Senior Awakened Witch like you did not have such a convenient Magic Stone?"

Chapter 354

Chapter 354: The Magic Stone

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

Agatha froze in shock. She never dreamed that Tilly would have a Stone of Flight and even figured out how to use it. After hesitating for quite some time, she finally spoke, “We only understood the relationship between magic power and Magic Stones, but we couldn’t produce the Stones.”

“You couldn’t produce them?” Tilly asked surprisedly, “What does that mean?”

“These Magic Stones were made by demons…” she sighed, “If we had a reliable source of Magic Stones, we would have been able to transform assistant witches into combat witches, and God’s Punishment Army wouldn’t exist.”

“Made by demons?” The witches couldn’t help but look shocked, while Roland’s expression darkened.

“How much do you know about making Magic Stones?” he asked, “and how were these Magic Stones made?”

The tone of these two questions sounded a little too blunt, and Agatha initially didn’t want to answer them. However, considering that demons were witches’ real enemies and that this information would eventually come to light, she stifled her remarks on his rudeness and answered slowly, “There was a strange being among the demons, which we called the Chaos Beast. Its appearance resembled a large flower bud with the height of three or four people, and it crawled slowly on its tentacles. After it swallowed God’s Stones of Retaliation, it could produce a variety of Magic Stones, and the speed of this process depended on the type of Magic Stone being produced.”

“Have you… witnessed this?”

“We caught a live beast once.” She was extremely irritated by the Prince’s skepticism. “The Bliss Army launched a surprise attack on a remote Devil’s Town where there was a Chaos Beast producing Stones of Light. Witches brought it back to Taquila and made it work for the Holy City – this kind of demon was extremely unintelligent, so it automatically transformed the stones it was fed. Unfortunately, we did not know how to make it produce more powerful stones, and we also didn’t know how to raise it. Six months later, it turned yellow and wilted like an uprooted plant.”

“Afterwards, the Quest Society sent a couple of witches to other Devil’s Towns to investigate. All reports led to the same conclusion – Chaos Beasts were the only way of obtaining Magic Stones, and it would take a longer time to produce more powerful stones. Most demons used Magic Stones in battle; for example, the Mad Demon embedded on its arm a Magic Stone that could instantly excite its body’s energy and give it powerful long-range attacking abilities. All the Magic Stones we had were seized from enemies’ bodies or battalions.

“So this Stone of Flight used to belong to a demon?” Tilly asked curiously.

“As far as I know, only a powerful demon leader could have such a Magic Stone.” Agatha sighed, “So it probably belonged to the battle spoils of a Transcendent.”

“What about the types of Magic Stones?” Roland frowned, “Did they always have all types of Magic Stones?”

“Of course not. If that were the case, humans would have been doomed long ago.” She rolled her eyes, “In the First Battle of Divine Will, most demons did not have Magic Stones. Instead, they relied on their immense bodies and impenetrable armor and attacked human cities with metal spears. This is all recorded very thoroughly in history books. After hundreds of years of war, human territories were conquered bit by bit, until everyone was forced to retreat to the Fertile Plains.” At this, she sighed, “That was when we were closest to victory. If we had been led by a witch and had a trained platoon of combat witches, the demons wouldn’t have even been able to set foot in the Dawn Region.”

“And then they gained access to all kinds of Magic Stones?”

“I think so. In the Second Battle of Divine Will, their attacks became much more varied.” Agatha’s voice dropped in defeat. “This time, we were totally crushed in a matter of 35 years. Although the elite Bliss Army was a strong match for the Lords of Avernus, there were many more of the enemy than there were of us. I heard from the elders of the Union that the witches actually had the upper hand for the first ten years, and that one Transcendent could slaughter an entire demon platoon. However, after we began to lose a lot of soldiers, we were forced into the defensive within our city.”

Then, the Prince was silent for a long time and appeared to be considering something very serious.

“He has finally understood the horror of demons,” thought Agatha. “Not only were their numbers immense, but their evolution was frightening. Who knows what kind of army will emerge in the next attack.”

“Are Mad Demon, Fearsome Demon, and Lord of Avernus categories you assigned to the demons?” Tilly asked as Roland was still lost in thought.

“Yes, these names became widespread in the Second Battle of Divine Will – before they had their Magic Stones, there was not much difference between them besides their appearance.”

“How did they reproduce?”

“Uh… that,” Agatha stuttered, “I don’t know. It was never recorded in any books or learned from captives – they couldn’t survive for long without the Red Mist, so we didn’t have enough time to understand their language. And the demons who did not need the Red Mist to survive were all low-level beasts that couldn’t communicate.”

“Beasts?”

“Yes. Demons consisted of many different species, but there were two main categories,” she explained carefully. “One had magic power, and the other didn’t. The latter didn’t need the Red Mist to survive, but their appearance

and intelligence were no different from regular animals. Examples of these beasts were Eight-feet Reptiles that carried supplies for the demons, and winged Devilbeasts that could carry demons into the air."

"Hold on." the Prince suddenly frowned and asked, "Did these Devilbeasts you mentioned look like this?" He took a painting out of a drawer and spread it out in front of Agatha.

"This is indeed a Devilbeast." The painting of the winged demon was incredibly lifelike and was no doubt the work of a witch. "Have you seen one before?"

"Not too far from here." Roland sipped his tea and continued, "I thought it was a demonic beast tamed by the demons. So you're saying that… they aren't the same thing?"

"Of course not. Low-level demonic beasts were nothing but food for demons, while powerful mutant demonic beasts were actual threats to demons. When the 'Months of the Demons' arrived, their attacks usually decreased, giving us some time to recover." Agatha paused and changed the subject to the nearby enemy, "If there are Dinotheres around, that means a Demon's Town can't be far away… Where are they?"

"Just West of the Mist Forest, behind a large snow mountain." Roland roughly told her about his investigation, "It's completely covered in Red Mist."

"No, not completely!" Agatha exclaimed, "Those short stone towers are used to maintain the Red Mist by evaporating a stored liquid, so they need to be refilled periodically. That's why those demons always hide underground to reduce usage. We can try to capture this battalion!"

"Initiate an attack on the demons?" the witches all gasped in fear.

"There are Multi-eyed Demons on watch, which meant that there is probably a Chaos Beast in the battalion. Otherwise, there would not be high-level demons stationed in such a remote and small battalion." She bit her lip, "A Chaos Beast will always preserve its ability to produce its last Magic Stone.

Even if it is not a powerful Magic Stone, we can still use it to further the research of the Quest Society, and even find the principle of transforming God's Stone of Retaliation!"

Chapter 355

Chapter 355: Miracles

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

The group of people stared at her, dumbfounded. After a long silence, the prince cleared his throat and asked, “Isn’t the red fog extremely toxic? There’s no way for us to approach it right?”

“It’s only toxic to witches. According to the Quest Society’s research, normal humans, plants and animals can all survive underneath the red fog. In addition, fire can speed up its rate of dispersion,” Agatha plainly replied.

“Weren’t you the one who said even normal people could fight the Devils? Well, prove it for me to see! The winged hybrids can be lured away by our flying witches,” She said as she pointed to Tilly, “The rest of the people can stand by waiting for us to rouse the devils and lead them into a trap. If what you said is true, taking this stronghold should be a piece of cake.”

Roland chuckled and shook his head, “I forgot to mention this earlier, this investigation trip was done via hot air balloon, not the flying witches you assumed — this kind of flying device can only carry a dozen people, I’m afraid there’s no way we can carry a whole troop of normal soldiers. In addition…” he paused, “This plan you came up with is highly susceptible to risk. We have no idea just how many devils are lurking around. Close quarters combat will result in casualties, not to mention the dangerous job of luring the Devilbeasts. I refuse to put my people in such danger.”

“How could anyone have a foolproof plan for fighting the devils?” Agatha fumed. “Every time the Blessed Army mobilized its people in the past, everyone went in with the expectation of a bitter battle to the death. As I thought, he’s delusional! In order to achieve an end goal, casualties are an eventuality. Only a naive rookie who’s never experienced the cruel reality of war would worry so much about every single individual life.”

Though extremely disappointed, she still controlled her feelings, managing to hide her doubts. In the afternoon, after attending his presentation of this so-called new weapon, everything will become clear.

Only now, Agatha no longer harbored any real expectations.

They were just a prince who's only fought before on paper, a bunch of witches with support abilities, and finally some fragile and useless ordinary mortals. Even with the most powerful of weapons, how strong could they possibly be?

Perhaps from the moment the Union collapsed, humanity had already been destined for destruction.

"You often spoke of the Battle of Divine Will, why do you call it that? Isn't it simply a war to repel the devil invasion," Roland took a new piece of paper, raised his quill and asked.

That's what everyone called it. The history books never recorded the initial reason for the war," Agatha answered in a disheartened tone, "It's not wrong to call it a war to repel the invasion, after all, the devils did only come to the Land of Dawn from the stone gates…"

"What stone gates?" Scroll couldn't help but interrupt.

"The Gates of Hell that rose from the ground." Agatha sighed. "On the eve of the Bloody Moon, the Gates of Hell shall open, engulfing the world we know. That's what was written in the history books — either way, these damned stone gates would appear every few hundred years. The first horde of devils used them to come to the Land of Dawn and rabidly attempted to murder us all."

"So the pattern of their invasions is also related to this?"

"They needed the red fog to survive, in order to leave the fog they had to depend on their own handheld reservoirs — the leather pouches, metal containers and demonic beast hide tanks. This is also the reason we were even able to have the second or third Battles of Divine Will. Only when the

stone gates appeared could the devils build their fog generating Obelisks, which were usually taller than even mountains and had a wide area of diffusion. A single one is enough to cover the entire Fertile Plains," she explained slowly.

"If another Battle of Divine Will erupts, the devils will definitely construct an Obelisk in the middle of the plains to serve as their base. After it's complete, they'll use their fortresses at the boundaries of the fog to initiate their attack. This time, I'm afraid there's nowhere left for humanity to run."

"If that day comes, everyone can at least escape to Fjords to weather the storm." Tilly shrugged her shoulders.

"Are you talking about those few islands in the middle of the Swirling Sea? How many people could a tiny land like that possibly sustain? It's nothing but a place of desperation where one waits for their eventual demise," Agatha snappily retorted.

"Alright, everyone cheer up a little, at least we now have a decent understanding of the devils we're up against," the Prince shrugged and said, "By the time the third Battle of Divine Will begins, we won't be unprepared. Let's call it a day here. Anything else we can discuss after lunch."

…

Agatha finished her sumptuous lunch and followed Wendy back to her room.

Life in the wastelands was a lot more… luxurious than she imagined. Both the variety and taste were far superior to that of any feast in her memory. She thought that perhaps this was because she was born in an era of war; those days, be it in her own stone tower or at the fortress of the Union, food consisted solely of bread, jerky and vegetable soup. Yet here salt, butter, and honey were all plentiful, as well as some delicious spices she didn't recognize. Even though she wanted to maintain her image, she nevertheless couldn't help but devour an entire plate of fried mushrooms as well as two huge pieces of honeyed steak.

However, the more she ate, the angrier she became. She both loathed herself for succumbing to the temptation of delicious food, bringing shame upon Taquila, and loathed the Prince for being so short-sighted as to be wasting time savoring delicacies while the humanity walked towards its doom!

Thinking of this, she couldn't help but harden her tone and say, "I'm already familiar with the castle halls now. You needn't bother with the hassle of escorting me back from now on."

"It's not a hassle at all. I'm delighted to do these things… " Wendy smiled. "Also, if you want to talk about anything, I'm always here. Bottling your feelings up in your heart will only make them fester."

"Didn't he say he was going to show us the new weapons in the afternoon? Why'd he leave all by himself after eating?"

"You mean Roland? This… is probably because he's taking a nap," Wendy covered her mouth and whispered, "That's His Majesty's habit, usually after lunch he'll always sleep for at least an hour. His Majesty often says the body is the foundation of all efforts. Without enough rest, it's impossible to fulfill the duties of a lord."

"An afternoon nap! What kind of habit is this! A whole night isn't enough for him!?" Agatha angrily thought, "This is obviously nothing but a lazy person making excuses, yet you actually wholeheartedly believe him!'

"Be it normal witches or Senior Awakened Witches… why is it that you all have such confidence in him?" she took a deep breath, "Is it just because he gave you a safe haven? Do you really believe that he can win against the devils – no, even against the Church that has been suppressing you all?"

"I can't speak for the other sisters," Wendy gently replied, "but I myself do believe in him. Because His Majesty is capable of making the things that no one else imagined, or even dared to imagine, happen. To me, he's someone who's made countless miracles happen."

"Mira… cles?

“When witches everywhere were being hunted to death, he saved the Association; when everyone saw us as demons, he created a place where we could coexist in harmony; in a single short year, His Majesty has managed to use an army of peasants to fend off the Months of the Demons, and defeated Duke Ryan who had a territory several times of his; even the mad empowered army of Graycastle wasn’t able to take a single step past our border.”

“But these are merely the battles of mortals, compared with the war between God’s Punishment Army and the devils, they’re completely different.” Agatha shook her head.

“Of course it’s not just this,” Wendy continued, “His teachings and theories allowed four sisters to evolve their abilities, and has unceasingly created increasingly powerful weapons, which allow knights and even ordinary people to win against Extraordinaries… these are all miracles that I’ve personally witnessed, not just the wild rumors of a tavern, nor the bombastic descriptions of historical records — they happened right in front of my eyes.”

“One day he’ll become the King of Graycastle, and lead us to defeat any and all of our enemies.” Her eyes were filled with mirth yet her voice was full of confidence.

“That’s what I believe.”

Chapter 356

Chapter 356: 「152！」

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

Weapons that enable civilians to defeat Extraordinaries?

After Wendy left, Agatha kept mulling over this phrase. Did they truly know what an Extraordinary was?

Unfortunately, she did not have a Stone of Measuring with her to clearly determine the powers and types of these witches.

After waiting for an annoyingly long time, Nightingale appeared in her doorway. “His Highness invites you to view his new weaponry tests. If you don’t want to go…”

“I’ll go,” she mumbled. “Please lead the way.”

When she saw Prince Roland still groggy and yawning, Agatha had a sudden impulse to dump ice chips onto him to wake him up. However, this move would probably cause some misunderstandings with the other witches, so she could only think about it to herself.

As they left the castle, she saw the entirety of the town in broad daylight for the first time.

With the snow as a backdrop, the first impression that leaped into her mind was order—all the two-story houses stood in clean rows and had exactly the same appearance, with matching white silhouettes and red tile roofs. The black roads were all straight as an arrow, splitting the town into equal square sections. Looking into the distance, the scenery seemed to be continuous layers of houses, trees and streets and so on.

Even Taquila’s Inner City could never be this orderly!

But she felt there was something about the town that couldn't compare to her city. Except the castle, there were no buildings worth a second glance in this town. Even the castle itself could not compare to Taquila's Quest Tower in grandiosity.

"After all, it's only a small town." Agatha scoffed inwardly and turned to Nightingale. "How many people live here?"

"Um… There used to be only a little over 2,000, but now, with the refugees from the North and South, there're almost 30,000."

"There were only 2,000, and he claimed to defeat demons. What a stupid… hold on, 30… 30,000?" Agatha widened her eyes in shock. Even in its prime, Taquila could only accommodate 50,000 people. Could this tiny place hold 30,000? She wasn't counting the populations of the surrounding villages, right?

Although these square brick houses did seem to have a larger capacity than wooden bungalows, the increase of population wasn't merely a simple addition of numbers. After the population reached a certain point, demands on the city would also increase exponentially. Firstly, the demand for food and water would increase dramatically. Secondly, there would be more public safety issues following an increase in slums. Finally, even waste disposal would become a difficult issue.

Towards the end of the Second Battle of Divine Will, Taquila faced all of these issues—following the collapse of many major cities, more and more people flocked to the Holy City. Overpopulation did not strengthen the city's defense, but instead paralyzed the entire city. The Union had to forcefully remove a group of refugees to settle the crisis.

After experiencing this firsthand, Agatha knew how difficult the growth of population was. As she observed her companion's casual demeanor, she somewhat distrusted her. Perhaps Nightingale had no idea what she was talking about and was simply lying to her.

"I should ask Wendy these kinds of questions in the future, " she thought. "At least she seemed more sincere."

After crossing the crowded city streets, Agatha followed the prince and his group onto a city wall made of mud. This kind of short city wall was far from lofty and sturdy. There were no barbs on the surface of the wall, nor was there a moat surrounding it. Demons wouldn't even need machines to climb this wall as they could do so bare-handedly.

She became more disappointed in her heart.

Every hundred steps or so, there were protrusions of flat platforms on the top of the wall, which seemed to be prepared for ballistas. It didn't take a long walk along the wall for Agatha to see the weapon being tested that day.

Its appearance was so unique that it commanded everyone's attention.

It was a metal tube that looked like an enlarged iron spear, except there was no spear head. It was entirely smooth and had a slight silver tinge to it, so it didn't seem like a metal weapon. The parts at the ends of the tube were slightly complicated. Besides a stabilizing stand, there were also two shorter tubes that were attached to the top and bottom of the large tube. It had no pulleys or slots for arrows, appearing nothing like a larger ballista or mangonel.

But she still could not figure out how this thing could attack enemies.

"This is a newly-invented weapon of Border Town—the 152 mm Stronghold Standard Artillery, symbolizing justice and glory!" The prince exclaimed, waving his hands. "We made many improvements on the basis of the 12 pound field artillery, and it's outstanding in all respects. It's undoubtedly a revolutionary weapon!"

Agatha couldn't help but frown. All this talk of justice, glory and Stronghold Standards sounded extremely superficial. Not to mention that the long string of introductions was a mouthful of made-up words. Was he really the prince, whom, as Wendy introduced, was learned and trusted by all witches?

"Clap, clap, clap," Nightingale was the only person clapping, and the atmosphere seemed a little awkward.

“Ahem,” Roland cleared his throat. “Let’s not waste our breath and start testing. Iron Axe, take it away.”

“Yes, Your Highness.” Three people dressed in the same uniforms immediately stood up and got to work.

Agatha stood on the side and followed every movement of these men, hoping to understand the workings of this weapon.

She watched one man slide off the metal piece at the end of the tube, and another immediately stuff an orange sharp object into the tube and shut the metal piece.

“Report. Preparation is ready. Prepare to launch!”

“Everyone, cover your ears.” The prince demonstrated with his hands, nodded, and said, “Fire.”

“Wait… is it ready this quickly?” Just as Agatha was about to ask, a large boom exploded next to her ears. Her head immediately began buzzing, and her surroundings quieted. The long metal tube spat out a ball of orange flames, blinding yet fleeting. In that moment, she sensed the immense power of the fire, and felt the city wall trembling beneath her feet. A wave of heat rushed towards her, pushing her back a few steps. The cannon itself also suddenly sank back suddenly—but then it steadily returned to its original position.

“…” Nightingale supported her in time from behind and seemed to say something to her, but she could only hear fragments of whispers, as if they were coming from far away… Finally, the buzzing subsided, and her hearing was back to normal. “Are you okay?”

She shook her head, looking towards the fields of snow, but couldn’t see any change.

Were those flames only good for intimidating the enemy?

“Did you see the landing point?” the prince asked a witch with green hair.

“It fell behind a small hill, nearest to the red flag,” the latter said after peering out for some time, “but it was still much farther.”

“Red flag?” Agatha looked at Roland with puzzlement. “What are they talking about?”

Luckily, the prince quickly addressed her confusion. “This weapon can fire shells—or bolts that you’re familiar with—to a long distance, so it’s used to attack enemies far away. In order to observe the range of attack, I had Lightning place colored flags every one kilometer, and the red flag was the last one at five kilometers away.” He explained, “By your measurements, one kilometer is a little over 300 yards.”

Agatha was stunned. “Is he saying that that weapon fired a bolt over a distance of more than 5,000 meters? There were no pulleys or power-storing mechanisms. How did they make it? Even Siege Beasts driven by magic power could only reach a range of 1,500-2,000 meters. If he was not lying, then a tall and sturdy city wall, combined with these kinds of weapons, could really fend off the demons’ attack.”

But… it’s probably not very easy for a weapon with such an astonishing firing range to fire even once.

“It just doesn’t feel right without seeing where the shells landed,” The Prince stroked his chin and said, “Next, let’s test a fast triple-shot flat aim to attack targets in short range.”

Chapter 357

Chapter 357: Unfinished-work

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

The second time it fired, Agatha covered her ears up in advance.

Then she saw an incredible scene.

There was no endless charging work that she expected. Gigantic as the long metal pipe seemed, it was actually not as heavy as it looked like. Every shot seemed to shake the earth up. However, its base remained absolutely still, as if the pipe and the base were not related at all. The long tube was quick and accurate each time in terms of backing and resetting, and this process did not even require human control—only three of the four operators were busy working, while the commander Iron Axe was just standing aside issuing orders.

Withdrew the metal stopper, slid off the copper shell, stuffed the new bolt, and then fired… and repeated the process. Agatha could feel the ground-shaking anger of the earth almost every ten breaths. At the same time, she also witnessed the soil and the snow columns kicked up one after another by the flat fire at a close distance—the prince did not lie that this weapon truly shot the bolt out at a speed that was impossible to capture with naked eyes. Judging from the interval between the firing time and the time when the snow columns were kicked up, it could be concluded that even a Transcendent would absolutely have no way to avoid the attack!

Agatha looked at this silver white long tube weapon and could not help being amazed.

If … if Taquila was guarded by such a powerful weapon at that time, we should have been able to keep all the frightful demons below the city walls, and thereby prevented falling into the dilemma of attrition after the walls were destroyed. The war would perhaps not have gone that bad either.

“Was this weapon created by witches?” After quite a while, she swallowed a mouthful of saliva and asked quietly. From its bright and shiny appearance, this could absolutely not be handcrafted by mortals with iron hammers.

However, the prince’s reply greatly surprised her.

“This is a masterpiece jointly created by witches and mortals,” he smiled and said, “Witches took care of everything from smelting to casting the Longsong Cannon, whereas alchemists were responsible for shells that were used to fire. By the way, the witches who have been engaged in manufacturing are all what you call assistant witches except Anna.”

Agatha felt that her long-standing idea was suddenly shaken. She thought she had been kind and generous enough to mortals, and for this she had been even marginalized by the Quest Society. However, it now appeared that what she had done was far from enough?

Is that true that the Union had been wrong all the way from the beginning? Did it mean that what the prince said, namely “Mortals can defeat demons” was actually right? …

Yet if the cooperation between witches and mortals can generate such powerful strength, then why did the first Battle of Divine Will end up with a disastrous defeat?”

With questions continuously coming to her mind, Agatha started to feel very confused.

…

When the Longsong Cannons jetted out flames in succession, Tilly was greatly shocked as well.

Although she once stood on the top of the city wall and saw shells being fired at demonic beasts, the drawbacks of those firearms were also quite evident —It was hard to target at a long distance, and it could not shoot downwards if enemies drew close. It was only at somewhere in the middle that they were able to exert the optimum power. However, as the loading was sort of slow,

it was very likely that swift hybrid demonic beasts may have already arrived at the foot of the city walls before they had time to ignite them.

Furthermore, in order to quickly load and shoot, five to ten people were required to run a mortar team. The weapon operation would be affected even a single step went wrong. Besides, it required someone to specially keep an eye on the combustion source upon ignition. When there was heavy rain, field artilleries probably would not be useless.

Nevertheless, the Longsong Cannon newly developed by Roland did not have the aforesaid deficiencies.

Charging from the rear of the cannon enabled the muzzle to stay lower than the breech, and thereby largely increased the efficiency of close range shooting. The firing rate was also multiplied several times, yet the staff was reduced to three people. Meanwhile, the cannon did not need to be lit by open fire, which meant that they could operate even in harsh weather. As its attacking scope was far greater than that of mangonels, it totally deserved what Roland referred to as “an epochal weapon”.

Although they currently relied on witches’ abilities to manufacture such weapons, Tilly believed that this was only temporary—Sylvie’s observation could verify this: In the past, only Chief Knight was equipped with automatic weapons, but now each soldier had one in their hand. Anna only needed to create the facilities and equipment for the manufacturing of such weapons. Specific casting and assembling work could be independently completed by laborers.

From Ashes’ and Anderlia’s looks, one could tell that the Longsong Cannon was something that they could not possibly imagine.

It was nice to have such an ally, but as a brother, she felt he was even more distant.

She even had a feeling that Roland had gone far ahead of her.

This made Tilly a little frustrated.

If only he could be more frank.

…

Seeing the shells that were produced with great difficulty exhaust in a blink, Roland felt his heart was aching. In spite of this, he still had to put on an inscrutable look to cover up his unwillingness.

This was not a new cannon testing in a real sense.

In order to achieve a brilliant demo effect, he asked Iron Axe to borrow a group of elite artillery from the artillery battalion and had them start on simulative shooting practice a few days beforehand, during which they also carried out two rounds of ball firing practice. This was nothing but a force demonstration specially prepared for the witches.

The shooting went on well, and the result was also excellent—at least from Agatha's shocked look, one could tell that the performance of the cannons had blown her mind.

Nonetheless, to Roland, the firing performance of this Longsong Cannon was far from ideal.

Except for the sacred caliber of 152 mm, the rest of it was not even close to that of the real 152. With Anna's ability in precision machining, Lucia's in element purification and Sylvie's in crack detection, theoretically, he could manufacture modern cannons in a real sense, rather than a replica that only had a shooting range of seven to eight kilometers.

The key lay in details.

For now, it appeared that the setting of its chamber was too small.

In consideration of the weight of fixed ammunition, Roland decreased the volume of the chamber on purpose, which resulted in insufficiency in powder charge. Although it had a long barrel of 40 caliber, its shooting range was still unsatisfactory.

Another thing was propellant.

Since nitroglycerin was still in the process of testing, all that was loaded to the cannons was nitrocotton. This was also a reason why Roland felt it was a pity that the nitrocotton consumed by a few shells was enough to load thousands of bullets. In addition, these smokeless propellants had not been gelatinized, which further decreased the powder charge.

Finally, the shell itself was after all a larger version of the bullet. If the bullet had not been charged, it all relied on kinetic energy to create lethality. Missing the target meant zero harm. At this stage it could only be used to attack some slow enemies.

Overall, there was still a long way to go before they were able to barrage and cover every inch of the earth with cannon shells.

However, Roland felt he probably did not have as much time as he initially expected.

Ever since he knew that the transformation of the Magic Stone was originated from demons, he felt increasingly alert deep down inside.

“If demons also had their own scientific technologies, would they enjoy an advance by leaps and bounds in these technologies at some point?”

Chapter 358

Chapter 358: Invitation

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

This was not a wild guess, but it could be best proved by the development of human civilization.

It took mankind nearly a million years to enter the Iron Age from the Stone Age, but only 3,200 years from the Iron Age to the Age of Steam. From the Age of Steam to the Electric Age, it merely took 150 years, and the world directly stepped into the information era in another 50 years.

From the information Agatha disclosed, demons were not an invariable race. Over 800 years ago, they combatted in a close range with knives and shields made of bronze and pig iron, fighting in a similar way to mankind. In order to compete against witches, some Senior Demons would also wear God's Stones of Retaliation. Every time they attacked a city, demons generally did not have any effective countermeasures for long-distance weapons such as crossbow bolts and mangonels, and therefore always suffered great loss before conquering a fortified city. If they were not born to possess such immense power, perhaps mankind would have become the ultimate victor of the first Battle of Divine Will.

Nevertheless, demons had already been able to mass produce Magic Stones in the second Battle of Divine Will, and their groups had also experienced differentiation. Demons of various forms took on diverse operation missions, and even Mad Demons who outweighed in number had also developed measures for long-distance attack. According to Agatha, they even created transportation tools and engineering instruments driven by Magic Stones! Now more than 400 years had passed, how far had they evolved?

Roland originally thought Agatha would bring him the Magic Stone technologies from Taquila's Quest Society, and based on them, he would be

able to wedge a new path of industrial development, but he did not expect that such technologies were from the enemies. In that way, the competition against demons would very likely become a war between industrial and Magic Stone technologies.

“Only the one that develops technologies faster will win in the end.”

At this thought, Roland could not help but heave a sigh. It seemed necessary to have a thorough discussion with Tilly.

…

Roland met Tilly Wimbledon at his office after dinner.

He felt pleased when he saw she came alone—at least there had been great progress in terms of trust between them.

“Nightingale told me you want to discuss something with me.” she took a seat and came straight to the point.

“Yes.” Roland poured a cup of tea and handed it over to her himself. “It’s mainly about how to cope with the third Battle of Divine Will and our future.”

Tilly took the tea cup and blinked, seeming to wait for him to continue.

“According to Agatha, the Four Kingdoms was merely a tip of the Land of Dawn and that even the Barbarian Land used to be the most prosperous Fertile Plains. It was after being defeated by demons twice that human beings had to retreat to this place. Based on the time the Stone Gates opened, the third Battle of Divine Will is at the corner.” Roland hesitated for a moment and stated bluntly, “I hope you can stay.”

Tilly smiled faintly after a short pause and said, “I didn’t expect you would say that.”

“The strength of demons is unpredictable, and we must gather all the powers available to win the war. Although Agatha said the first Battle of Divine Will was operated by both mortals and witches, it was very likely that their

cooperation was only on the surface, which essentially had no difference from the second Battle of Divine Will." He addressed in a sincere tone, "As you've already seen, the excess of the memories in my head possesses weapons sufficient to defeat demons. Once these memories are converted to physical entities, mortals can also burst out powers beyond imagination. The right choice is to have witches take care of the operation of war machines, while ordinary people fight in the war. Upon a big war, one more person means one more source of strength."

"…" Tilly took a sip of the tea and did not answer for quite a while. Roland felt his heart was in his throat.

Yet under such circumstances, there was no use feeling vexed. He put on a composed look, waiting silently for Tilly to speak.

After seven minutes or so, Tilly finally heaved a sigh and broke the silence. "If I stay, what about the witches on the Sleeping Island?"

"Does that mean… she agreed?" Roland restrained his excitement. "Ask them to come to the Border Town. They are totally welcome here. I'll mark off a plot of land for your witches, and each of them will be equally paid as those in the Witch Union—ah, I don't mean making them members of the Union. They'll still be led by you. It's like establishing a special autonomous district in the Western Region. This is not only convenient for our cooperation, but also helpful to boost the mutual understanding between us."

"Will they be equally paid?" She could not help but smile, "You don't mind their abilities? You know most of them can't fight for you."

"No, no," Roland waved his hand repeatedly and said, "In the cooperation model I have conceived, assistant witches, on the contrary, can play a more important role than combat ones, because it isn't themselves that are strengthened, but hundreds of thousands of ordinary people—nature doesn't lack power, but lacks people who discover and make use of them. In this regard, the abilities of assistant witches are far greater."

"Is this your real purpose?" she asked slyly.

“Um…”

“It’s indeed a generous offer.” Tilly smiled, shaking her head. “In view of the public concerns, I can’t refuse your request to jointly fight against the intrusion of demons; in view of the personal concerns, I also want to stay here to learn the interesting knowledge. However, I can’t give you my consent now.”

A bit surprised, Roland immediately asked, “Why?”

“Since I am the leader elected by the witches on the Sleeping Island, I can’t decide their future based on my personal preference. Once moved to the Western Region, the organization will inevitably lose its independence. If something happens, they’ll be too vulnerable to resist. If one day there’re conflicts between us, should all the witches have to pack up and return to the the Sleeping Island again?”

“No, I’ll never…”

“I can’t put their future in an oral promise,” Tilly interrupted, “If you were me, would you surrender everything of yours to me simply because we are allies?”

Roland was instantly speechless. He knew the answer even without thinking about it. If he himself was in such a situation, he would never agree with others easily. Most of the time, the closer two people are, the more likely they’ll have conflicts. That’s exactly what the so-called “befriending a distant state while attacking a neighbor” means. The same applies to powers and lovers.

“See? You are worried about the same thing as I am.”

“But… you are my younger sister. I won’t hurt you.” Roland had no choice but to make the last effort.

“Really… but for the reason you just said, I still can’t trust it,” Tilly closed her eyes somewhat melancholy, “this is probably why I can’t promise you right away.” She paused for a little bit, as if she wanted to leave those

thoughts behind, “Let’s just treat each other as an ally for now—I will give my full support to the construction of Border Town. If you need witches, I’ll try to meet your requirements as much as I can… If it’s really hard to resist the attacks from demons, you can still return to Sleeping Island and spend the rest of your life in peace. This is all that I can do so far.”

Chapter 359

Chapter 359: Different Choices

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

The fire in the fireplace shook for a second and fainted. Nightingale revealed herself, and put some firewood inside. Cracking sounds came from the fireplace and the flames suddenly rose up.

Roland looked at the stretched shadow of the cup and took a deep exhalation. Tilly had been away for some time, and he had been recalling their conversation to see if there was any way to change the result, but it ended up in vain – trust is very intriguing, and only by taking a lot of time can he earn someone's trust.

"It seems that you're not capable of everything," said Nightingale. She brushed off the dust on her hand and sat back at her usual place, "What on earth did you say to her that day?"

"A white lie." Roland leaned on the chair. "It's very normal that she doesn't believe it." He paused and said, "You said that you had a younger brother. If he suddenly becomes very different than he used to be, and keeps saying that he's still himself, will you believe him?"

"Do you mean that guy who looked innocent but then betrayed me at the back?" Nightingale twitched her mouth, "As far as I see, he was basically no different than a mutation."

"Well, I shouldn't have mentioned this."

"It doesn't matter. Anyway, I'm not a member of Gelan Family anymore, and they're just strangers to me." She said carelessly.

"She and I were once just like strangers as well," Roland sighed and continued, "or I would rather say that I didn't get along well with anyone in

the palace.”

“If you feel bored, you can share it with me.” Nightingale gave a subtle smile, “I’ve been very curious about the royal life, but I also want to know how bad you were at that time. How could you be so bad that your notorious reputation was even spread to the Silver City?”

“To be honest, back then I was much worse than now.” Roland could not help but raise his lips. He picked some stories from his memories and said briefly, “Probably from the moment she fell onto the glass slag, she began to hate me.”

“It’s indeed… terrible,” she clicked her tongue and continued, “but I think she doesn’t hate you now.”

“Oh?” Roland raised his eyebrows and asked, “How could you know that?”

“Of course I know. Didn’t she say these words—’in view of the personal concerns, I also want to stay here to learn the interesting knowledge.'” Nightingale imitated. “It sounded like a consolation, but the truth is that she didn’t lie about it. If she still hates you as much as she did in the past, she would never feel like staying here.”

“Are you comforting me?” Roland smiled and said.

“I’m just telling the truth,” she shrugged and continued, “and I think it’s fine to maintain the status quo.”

“Why?”

“She promised to give priority to providing witches for the town to support you against demons, so there’s no difference whether she stays here or not. If the witches on the Sleeping Island all come to the town at the same time, with more witches like Ashes, I may be very busy.” Nightingale threw a dried fish into her mouth and muttered,” Not everyone is as obedient as Maggie.”

Roland could not help but laugh, “It sounds like that you had some issues with Ashes before?”

“Oh? Of course not. How could it be,” Nightingale waved her hands and said, “I just keep my eyes on her occasionally to prevent her turning against the Witch Union.”

“Really?”

She turned her head to another side and whistled.

“I’m not sure if it’s an illusion,” Roland stared at her. “Why do you feel so happy when I was rejected?”

“That’s an illusion,” affirmed Nightingale, and then she looked at the door, “well, someone is coming.” With these words,she concealed herself.

“Was it just her excuse to get away?” Just at this moment, someone began to knock on the door outside the office.

Roland was very surprised. It was almost midnight now. Who would come at this time of the night? He changed a new candle for the candlestick and said, “Come in.”

The visitor was Agatha.

The prince was shocked for a moment and asked, “What’s the matter?”

She didn’t reply but came to sit down at the round stool beside the table, “Ms. Wendy said that the flintlock that can fight against Extraordinaries and the cannon with an amazing long shooting range were both your ideas. Is it true? And the theories behind these things and their manufacturing methods are all recorded in the books you wrote? ”

“Do you mean Natural Science Theoretical Foundation and Elementary Chemistry? There’re related theories in them, but as for their manufacturing methods, they’re not written down because of length.” said Roland, “After all, they are just textbooks for elementary theories. ” Do you come to see me just for this?”

“Only members of the Witch Union can learn such knowledge, right?” she didn’t reply but continued to ask.

Roland nodded and had almost figured out what she wanted to say.

“Then I apply to join the Witch Union,” Agatha said without a pause.

“But the Witch Union is an organization belonging to the Border Town. Are you sure you want to work for the town?” he said with curiosity, “Its lord is not a Transcendent but just an ordinary mortal.”

“Any mortal that can create weapons to defend demons is not ordinary at all. Even in the Quest Society, there’ll be a place for you.” Agatha paused for a little bit and said, “As long as it does no harm to the witches and it’s not against the survivors of the Union, I don’t mind… cooperating with a mortal.”

Probably it’s a little hard for her to say “to work for a mortal” at the moment, but Agatha’s capability of accepting new things had impressed Roland a lot. Perhaps someone who was engaged in research was always able to accept new things quickly. He restrained himself from smiling and said, “I thought you would follow Tilly to the Sleeping Island, which is a city built by the witches.”

“It’s just a refuge for hiding from the hunting of the Church,” she shook her head and said, “I’ve learned about everything from them before I made this decision. And I’ve seen so many cities ruled by the witches before I was frozen, yet they were all gone without any traces. It’ll be meaningless if we cannot defeat demons. I wish I could see the hope of victory here.”

“You will,” Rolland nodded, “but as to not be against the Union… I cannot promise that, because it probably hasn’t been gone, but just changed its name and covered itself up.”

“What?” Agatha was shocked.

“I’ve thought about what you said carefully. Even if you ran away from Taquila after it was defeated, there were still Transcendents and many Blessed Warriors in the Union. On this undeveloped land in which many original inhabitants are living, they can’t entirely extinct unless they intend to do so.” Roland said in a deep voice, “The Church is probably a

transformation of the Union. It were not the mortals that took away the power and the methods of creating God's Punishment Army from the witches, but the witches themselves did that and turned the Union into an organization that hunted witches. In this way, it's more convenient for them to create a large number of God's Punishment Armies."

"Are you saying that it's the Union that has led to the tragic situation where witches are oppressed and hunted?" She said in great surprise.

"I'm not sure yet. It's just a guess." Roland stood up and went to the bookcase, took out several thick black books and handed them to her. "You can find their chronology written by the Church itself, and the histories of the Four Kingdoms written by astrologers. You can make reference to them. In any case, the Church is now our enemy that we must eliminate in the future."

"If you decide to stand on the side of witches and fight against demons with me, you're most welcome at the Witch Union."

Chapter 360

Chapter 360: Ice

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

Early in the next morning, Agatha received parchment scroll from Roland.

“What is it?”

“A contract. After you leave your fingerprint on it, you’ll officially become a member of the Witch Union.”

She spread the scroll of paper, carefully read the contents in it and asked in surprise, “That’s all?”

“Yup?” Roland seemed a little confused about what she said, “Why ask?”

“The restrictions on it are useless,” Agatha pointed to the part of “Services” and continued, “it just mentions that witches cannot betray Border Town unless the mutual agreement between both parties is breached, but there isn’t any restricting measures. If a witch does want to break the contract, she might have no pressure at all. Besides, and the wordings are way too loose. Is this a real contract?”

“Well, I just wrote it casually and it’s just a kinda formality.” The prince nodded without any surprise. It seemed that Agatha was not the first one to point out the loopholes of this contract.

“It’s a formality full of loopholes .” Secretly criticizing the contract in her mind, she then touched the ink pad and put her thumbprint on it. There were very few requirements for both parties in the contract of the Witch Union. According to the articles, Agatha could barely see any differences after she joined the Witch Union. Although she thought it was unnecessary to sign the contract, she felt much relieved than before.

She said she would work with the mortals, but she knew it well that the man with gray hair was the real leader of the Union. If she had to work for a mortal like the way she served the Union or the leader of three cities with the utmost deference, she would probably not accept it. But now, she was at least free to a large extent.

Roland put away the contract and asked curiously, “What were the restrictions on the contract of Taquila?”

“It was only used for recruiting the mortals and the penalties included corporal punishment and mental torture.” She twitched her mouth. “As for us witches, we didn’t need such contracts. Once you joined the Union, you should serve it for your lifetime and there was only death for traitors.”

“Okay,” he took a breath and said, “welcome to the Witch Union.” After breakfast, remember to come to the castle garden. I need to test your ability comprehensively.”

…

The ability test was much easier than what Agatha thought. All she needed to do was to show every characteristic of her ability once in front of the prince and answer some questions.

“The form of the magic power is a sky blue pentagonal prism and it’s a medium level. It belongs to the summon category. Your ability has evolved once. The initial performance is creating a low temperature, and it can freeze at a normal temperature after evolution, which is a very convenient ability,” Roland asked after recording the results, “how did you get evolved? ”

“Constant practice and a sudden enlightenment,” she proudly said. As the youngest High Awakened, she was called “the Genius of Taquila” by all the members of the Union. “Every day I kept trying to lower the temperature to freeze the water instantly. One day, I saw a witch who manipulated the flame to melt a piece of lead into liquid, and as the lead was heated by the flame, the lead water began to boil.”

“This scene made me realize that everything may have three states: gaseous, liquid and solid—lead is solid at room temperature, but if the temperature is high enough, it can also turn into gas; water is liquid at room temperature, and when the temperature falls, it can freeze into ice.”

“So for gas at normal temperature, can it freeze as long as the temperature is low enough, just like the case of the lead?”

“With this idea, I quickly felt the magic power in my body changing entirely, and I finally evolved into a Senior Witches. This enlightenment is also recorded in the General Principles.”

In fact, she was the youngest witch whose enlightenment was recorded in that book. Back then, even all the Three Chiefs praised her, for such enlightenment was very significant in enlightening witches to evolve and in practical research. However, when she said those in a serious manner, Roland was quite calm.

“I see.” The prince nodded. “What is the General Principles?”

“Wait… Aren’t you surprised at all?” Agatha asked surprisedly. “The world is full of gas everywhere. It can be anywhere and without any weight. Actually, the gas can turn into flowing water and frozen ice.”

“They are very normal phenomena, and there are many kinds of gases, each of which has different boiling points and melting points.” Roland shrugged. “Why should I be surprised? These’re common sense in Natural Science Theoretical Foundation.”

“…” Agatha was quite shocked and hurt, and she took two deep breaths and said, “Alright, I’ll read it carefully.”

“The General Principles…”

“It records the feelings and experiences of the High Awakened during their evolution,” she said in discontent, “but the abilities of witches are different from each other, which makes it very difficult for them to evolve by imitation

and referencing, so this book is of course uncomparable to your Natural Science Theoretical Foundation!"

"Did I say something wrong?" The prince was quite confused.

"No, I'm too arrogant," Agatha was unhappier now.

"Well." He seemed to figure out the reason, so he changed the topic quickly. "You just said that the abilities of the witches are different from each other… so there's no one sharing the same ability among thousands of witches in the Union?"

"No," she replied bluntly, "The Quest Society believes that the form of magic power decides the ability, but there are no witches sharing the same form of magic power."

"But when you first saw Anna, you could instantly tell that it was the ability of fire control."

"It's just an informal categorization, which is easy to understand. The abilities of generating light and heat can be categorized into fire control, but with the development of magic power, consolidation after growing up, or High Awakening, similar abilities will change greatly. Even at the initial stage of fire control, some witches are good at controlling the temperature, some generating greater fire, and some throwing the fire. Even if there're no obvious differences, it's because of the lack of careful observation," Agatha said, "The Quest Society's categorization method was much more formal and basically the same as yours."

"Also three categories?" Roland asked.

"Four. The main difference is the summoning type—the Quest Society divided it into two categories, Magic Power and Shaping. You can understand the difference from the literal meanings."

"The former means that the summoning of the ability costs magic power all the time, just like Anna's. When the magic power is gone, the summoning of

the ability will stop. And Shaping can exist for a very long time, just like the Coating drawn by Soroya, right?"

"Although I don't know the exact ability of Soroya, it's pretty much like that… That can stay for a long time can be taken as Shaping, such as my ability of freezing at a normal temperature."

"Understood." Roland recorded these contents as well. "That's all for the test today." Usually, if you receive no assignment from me, you can practice your ability as you wish, but I'm thinking that someone might urgently need your help."

"Who?"

"Kyle Sichi, the Chief Alchemist of Border Town."

Chapter 361

Chapter 361: Expansion

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

According to the records of Stall Literature, temperature control was the key in large-scale production of nitrifying glycerol because the excessive heat of exothermic reactions was extremely prone to cause the sensitive dynamites to explode. As long as the temperature of the large reaction vessel could be kept constant, the nitrating glycerin could be safely manufactured in batches.

However, the ice-water mixture had limited performance in heat absorption, especially when a large amount of heat was released. Its cooling rate was slow while the consumption of itself was fast. Besides,it was very troublesome to produce ice cubes. In light of these, ice cubes were suitable for laboratory tests, but not for the mass production. As the Frozen Coffin of Agatha could easily produce low temperatures, such as nearly 100 below zero, it was undoubtedly a great way to cool down the container.

Roland did not know whether the news was reliable or not, but it didn't stop him from trying one by one. Even in the event of an accident, Nana could always save her life.

Back in his office, he wrote a reference letter and gave it to his guard, who brought Agatha to the chemical laboratory and sent the letter to Kyle Sichi.

Besides introducing Agatha's abilities, he also made up an upper-class identity for her in the letter to mellow the alchemist so that he would take good care of the witch who might bring great help to the chemistry experiments. Roland was still worried after the guard left. He knew Keymor was straightforward while Agatha was arrogant and hoped they would not get into a big fight with each other.

Scroll pushed the door open and walked into the room while he was pondering whether he should go to the lab to take a look.

“Your Highness, here are the results for the second batch educational examination.” She smiled with a curve at the corner of her eye and continued, “This time, 762 students have passed the exam and half of them are adults.”

“So many?” Roland was pleased. Compared with the first group of more than 50 kids from Karl College, half of the adults graduated this time proved that night school training did work. At the same time, it verified the feasibility of a series of training programs formulated by the Ministry of Education based on different training schedules and durations.

“Yes, you’ve been implementing universal education for almost six months now, and these students are generally under 25 years old, it’s not too difficult for them to master the basic reading and writing skills.”

It probably has something to do with the characters themselves. It would never be as fast if it was Chinese instead.” Roland thought to himself, although he always felt that these earthworm-like characters were awkward.

During the initial implementation of universal education, he had no idea how far it would go. After all it was utterly new to the Kingdom of Graycastle. In accordance with the principle of encouragement and subsidy, he had been discussing with Scroll for a long time to formulate a set of educational programs for minors and night classes for the workers and make a series of incentives to tempt the workers to study. The result appeared to be really good as of now.

Of course, all of these were attributed to the executor Scroll for she really did a good job in management.

“Thanks for your hard work.” Roland nodded.

“It’s my pleasure to be at your service, Your Highness.” She bowed.

As she was the eldest witch in the Union, it was hard for Roland to compare her with the young girls like Anna and Lightning. Scroll always gave him a feeling of remaining stable and well-organized. When discussing things, she would both silently listen to his thoughts and brutally point out his mistakes. Sometimes, he even felt like a junior in front of Scroll.

Probably… she was born to be a teacher.

Roland smiled and shook his head, putting these thoughts aside.

Anyway, the long-standing factories could finally be put into use with the new productive forces.

“Please invite over Barov,” he said with great excitement.

…

The City Hall Director rushed to the castle quickly. As his workload had been increasing since he started building the city, he seemed older now with balder head and more wrinkles on the forehead. But there was not any fatigue on his face, he seemed increasingly energetic instead.

“Your Highness, are you want to see me for the recruitment matter?”

He probably had also received the news of the new group of graduates in town and took the initiative to ask.

“Exactly,” Roland nodded, “since the Months of Demons this year came earlier, Timothy won’t be able to disturb the Western Region. I’d like to scale up the army of Border Town in order to deal with the war next year and increase the number of factory workers at the same time.”

“And, the City Hall as well.” Barov added. “After the town is expanded into a city, your territory will be five to six times bigger. The City Hall will need more officers to manage such a vast land.”

“No worries,” the prince smiled and said, “you’re not forgotten.” He drew out a piece of paper and said while writing, “For the new group of 700 graduates, the City Hall will provide 20% of the graduates’ jobs, and the acid plant 40%. The rest will be recruited by the steam engine plant and the bicycle plant, with at least 100 allocated to the latter. You may set the salary based on the previous standards, but that for acid factory workers can be a little bit higher. Try to fill all the vacancies quickly.”

As for the soap and perfume plant, the main tasks were completed by the witches, and the ordinary people will only need to repeat a few simple operations. The workers there don't need to be literate, so there is no need to recruit graduates for them.

Roland believed that education could not only improve one's knowledge and vision, but also improve his sense of responsibility and sociality, which were exactly the significance of enlightenment. That was why advanced factories required large numbers of elementary educators, who knew their social attributes and the importance of cooperation, altruism and self-discipline better than the illiterate. This was critical to the fine work featuring many complex procedures.

"Yes, Your Highness." Barov replied. "How many people does the army need?"

"At least 1,000. Start recruiting from the newly promoted civilians and the refugees from the Eastern Region." Roland commanded. "As in the past, the City Hall issues the notices and the First Army is responsible for the reviewing and hiring."

"1,000… headcounts?" Barov startled and said, "This is equivalent to the amount of the current headcount of the first army, Your Highness. If they're equipped with the resources and weapons in accordance with the specifications of the First Army, the cost won't be low. "

"I have taken these into consideration. Just do it."

Knowing the danger of the demon's invasion, he naturally could not be planning as slow as before. Besides ruling the entire Western Region, the first task in the spring of the coming year was to completely defeat Timothy. As long as he wiped out the regime against him, the new town of the Western Region would become the veritable King's City even if the other areas were not seized. By then, both the expansion of population and the promotion of trade would be allowed, rather than be limited as it was currently.

However, the prince did not think Barov had to know the plan since all the latter needed to do was to arrange financial and material distribution.

After the City Hall Director left, the guards brought a new message.

Margaret's caravan had arrived.

Chapter 362

Chapter 362: Predicament

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

At the pier, more than 10 sailships were lined up in a column, with the top of their masts and their interlacing hemp ropes covered in snow, such that they looked like threads of clear silver. Refugees filed out of the cabins and rushed towards the large open space in front of the pier.

This was not the first time Border Town welcomed refugees from the Kingdom of Graycastle, and therefore the entire procedure seemed very orderly. Four lines of iron fence separated the crowd into two columns, which helped to control the crowd movement and prevented a stampede. On both sides of the fences, there were policemen carrying batons on patrol. Anyone who pushed his way through or attempted to climb the fence would be beaten. Although there was punishment, there was also reward—in order to comfort them after an arduous journey, the refugees would each receive a hot bowl of gruel when they passed through the railed passageway. In any case, filling up their stomachs before all else could effectively abate the refugees' fear and discomfort of being in a foreign land.

This time, aside from the policemen, First Army soldiers, and City Hall officials, Nightingale and Sylvie also took part in the inspection to locate the drug users who were planted in the crowd by Timothy. Under the surveillance of the Eye of Magic, pills and snow powder had nowhere to be hidden.

"Thank you for all that you've done for Western Region." Roland looked away from the crowd and said to Margaret beside him. "If it wasn't for your fleet, these people would've to spend the winter in the slums of other cities."

"It was rare for Your Highness to ask me for help in such an urgent tone of voice, and naturally I had to do my best." She laughed. "However, many

sailors were unwilling to set sail in the heavy snow, and hence I was only able to pool together these 13 sailships."

"It's better than not even one." Roland puffed out a white breath. After he learned that there were still large numbers of refugees held up in Silver City, Redwater City and Willow Town, he sent a letter of help to Margeret's Chamber of Commerce, hoping that it could deploy a fleet of sailships to help him transport the refugees.

Although 13 was a smaller number than he expected, all of the refugees could be transported by making the sailships take two extra trips. Assuming that each sailship could accommodate 100 people, and each trip to and fro required an estimated two weeks, the 3,000 stranded refugees would take roughly a month and a half to be transported. Because the gold royals brought along by a small platoon of the First Army were insufficient to last for this entire duration, therefore, on the last return journey, the sailships had to transport food and winter clothing as well. Roland did not wish to see the refugees carry their hopes of a better life on board the ships yet eventually fail to reach the destination.

Thanks to Lightning, Margaret calculated the transportation costs to be two times the normal daily rate. Any other merchant would have considered this to be a foolish transaction, as the transportation costs alone exceeded the value of the goods. On average, it cost one gold royal per two people, which, according to the current market price, would be enough to purchase several strong and high-quality slaves. Margaret had initially expressed her doubts to Roland, but he was insistent on bringing these people over to the Western Region.

From the moment the refugees stepped on board the ships together with the emissary delegation, they were considered subjects of the Western Region, and it was in line with his duty to provide them with asylum. Furthermore, in Roland's eyes, the value of these refugees was far greater than that of slaves. After receiving education and training, and eventually given employment, the wealth they would create through their jobs would be immeasurable.

…

Returning back to the reception room of the castle, Roland ordered the kitchen to prepare a hot pottage for Margaret. “Drink this, it’ll make your limbs feel much warmer.”

“Thank you for your kindness.” The businesswoman scooped up a spoonful of the soup and sniffed. “There seems to be White Liquor in it.”

“Indeed.” He laughed, “In addition, there’s also pepper and honey, and the base is chicken soup. Spirit is always an excellent drink to dispel the cold, and when heated with chicken soup, it becomes even more delicious. The other seasonings are added to cover the pungent taste, as well as add flavor and a little spice to the soup, such that even a person who rarely drinks alcohol will find it palatable.

Margaret slowly drank the pottage and finished it with a loud burp. “That’s great. Every time I’m on the way to your place, I’m filled with anticipation, never knowing what novelty is in store. It’s a pity that next year I’ll probably be unable to visit you.”

“Are you referring to a trading opportunity?” Roland subtly caught the meaning in her words.

The businesswoman nodded, “Timothy has decreed a ban on saltpeter trade, and therefore, sales are prohibited not only to King’s City, but also Silver City and Redwater City. Aside from supplying at a low price to the Alchemist Workshop, the only other customers are the nobility in the city.

Roland frowned.

“Furthermore, according to a piece of news that I heard from a City Hall source, Timothy is planning to blockade the Western Region. It won’t be just saltpeter, but also merchants, which will be stopped at the frontier of Redwater City. When the time comes, not only Border Town, but also Longsong Stronghold and Willow Town will be affected. Although many nobles have expressed opposition, it’s unlikely that Timothy will revoke his order.” She shook her head in resignation, “From next year onwards, I’ll not only be unable to ship saltpeter and ingots over here, but even the steam engine trade will probably be suspended.”

“I must have pushed him too far, or he wouldn’t have issued a decree that’s so damaging to the royalty.” Roland silently thought. “Before completing the centralization of authority, hasty interference in the trading activities of other territories is always likely to evoke the resistance and defiance of the lords and nobles. Even if Timothy sends his own troops to blockade the land and river routes, the troops would easily be eliminated by assassins covertly sent by the local lords—just let him try to enforce this policy for a year and a half.”

However, trade was the lifeblood of Border Town. Let alone a year… even half a year of blockade was a huge no-no. Saltpeter was a material used in large-scale acid production, and before the problem of synthetic ammonia was solved, it remained an irreplaceable component. If supply was cut off, the 152 mm artillery would become useless, and the reloading of the new repeating rifles would also be massively delayed.

However, compared to weapons, the prohibition of the steam engine trade was even more destructive. At present, the amount of gold royals stored in the City Hall’s vaults was not much. A portion of revenue was used in infrastructure projects and increasing the number of jobs, while another portion was distributed as pay to the townspeople and recollected through the sale of food, convenience goods and housing. This economic model necessitated a continuous injection of gold royals into the market, which had to be at least equal in amount to the wealth created by the subjects.

At present, Border Town remained in a state of primitive accumulation and also did not issue credit. If the revenue from the steam engine trade was lost, finances might dry up to the point that pay cannot be issued to the people, and a full economic meltdown would follow.

In any case, the interruption of funds was absolutely unacceptable.

“This situation won’t last long.” Roland spread his arms, “I believe that you’ll soon be able to visit our town again… no, when that time comes, you’ll see a brand new city.”

Margaret was slightly surprised, “Are you planning to build a city here?”

“Indeed, after the Months of the Demons.” He smiled. “Also, I plan to set up a trade shipping route that connects directly to the fjords. Instead of passing through Seawindshire or Port of Clearwater, it’ll set out directly from the Western Region towards the Fjord Islands. Will you be interested to participate in this?”

Chapter 363

Chapter 363: New Trading Route

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

“Setting out from the… Western Region?” Margaret asked curiously. “I didn’t know that there’s a good harbor that leads to the sea here.”

“There isn’t yet, but we can build one.”

Her eyes widened, “Your Highness, are you serious?”

“Of course. By next spring, we should be able to begin the construction.” Roland smiled and said.

In this era, harbors were, without exception, natural. Construction projects which required transforming the natural landscape, such as man-made harbors, were practically impossible.

However, now that he had obtained Tilly’s full support, he simply had to wait until the housing construction in Sleeping Island was completed, after which Lotus would come back to the Western Region, and furthermore, the crisis caused by the demonic beasts should have subsided by then. It would then be a suitable time to start work on the harbor.

He stood up and pointed to a map that was hung behind him. “In the south of Border Town, there’s a shore where the depth of water is ideal and the surface area is highly suitable, sufficient to accommodate all of the facilities required by the harbor. By making only a few modifications, and also flattening the ridges along the coast, I’ll be able to transport goods from the inland of Western Region to the harbor.”

“Modifying the shore… and flattening the ridges? Why is it that when you speak of these astonishing plans, I seem to get the impression that they are not difficult at all?” Margaret said with interest. “However, do you have a

merchant fleet? You should know that sea ships and inland river ships are very different."

"At the moment, no." Roland spread his hands. "This is also one of the reasons why I hope that you'll participate."

"I'll provide the ships?"

"And also be responsible for shipping and selling," he added, "while Western Region will only provide the goods."

This was equivalent to possessing the exclusive dealership in the fjord region, and with her experience, Margaret could smell the potential profits. If he created his own merchant fleet and sold goods to the Fjords himself, the profits would be higher, but Roland did not want to expend too much energy and manpower in this area. He simply wanted to obtain some funds as soon as possible, in order to maintain the rapid development of his territory. After the primitive accumulation was completed, it would only be a matter of time before he introduced credit.

As expected, the businesswoman blinked her eyes and excitedly asked, "You're entrusting it all to me?"

"If the price is reasonable." Roland nodded. "If you're willing to take care of Western Region's overseas trade, we can discuss the details right now. The selling area is limited to the Fjords, and the selling price must not be lower than the price at which we're currently selling to the Crescent-Moon-Bay Caravan."

"That's for sure. The steam-powered boat, which doesn't rely on wind power to sail continuously, has alone made it worth it for maritime trading teams to compete for and buy goods at high prices." She said in a highly assured voice, "If selling directly to the Fjord Islands, I'm confident of doubling the price."

"We can share the excess profits together." Roland laughed. "And, aside from the steam engine, there's also another major product." He clapped his hands, and a guard who was waiting outside the hall immediately walked in with a

plate in hand. On top of the plate was four or five gleaming crystal bottles, and each of them was only about the size of a thumb.

“This is…”

“Open it and smell.”

Feeling curious, Margaret pulled the cork from the top of the bottle and sniffed. Her eyes immediately lit up. “My gosh, you actually created perfume!”

“I wonder, how is it compared with the perfume created by the Alchemist Workshop in King’s City?”

“The fragrance seems to be stronger.” She raised up and scrutinized the bottle, seeming very fond of it. “Was this manufactured by the Alchemist Workshop in Border Town?”

“More or less.” Roland also took a bottle and placed it in his palm. In accordance with his demands, the perfume bottles were made by firing crystals of excellent transparency, and each of them had the same hexagonal prism shape. By spinning the bottle gently under light, the perfume inside the bottle would change into various shades of color, and looked extremely aesthetically pleasing. If the sales concept of later generations was anything to go by, exquisite packaging could greatly increase the quality of the product itself. As the perfume served as the hit product to open up the Fjords’ market, he naturally took great care with every aspect.

Compared to the steam engine, the perfume could be described as real low-cost goods. When Evelyn realized that “the spiciest White Liquor” was also a type of liquor, she started to continually produce liquors with very high concentrations and even skipped the final step of distillation. As for roses and other flowers with unique smells, they were made into various oil products by Leaf. By mashing only two or three stalks of flowers, it produced sufficient fragrance to fill a bottle of liquor.

“If you like, I’ll give these few bottles to you.” He placed the perfume back on the plate.

“Really?” Margaret smiled, “Then I shall not be courteous.”

“I heard that this thing can be sold in the Fjords at a high price?”

“You should know, the Alchemist Workshop in King’s City sells only a very limited stock of perfumes every year. The thousand or so bottles don’t come anywhere close to fulfilling the demand. In fact, of the perfumes sold in other regions, a large portion is bought by maritime merchants and resold in the Fjords.”

Margaret paused after she said this. “I wonder, how many bottles of perfume can your Alchemist Workshop produce a year?”

“If there’s sufficient material, it should be approximately ten times the amount produced by the Alchemist Workshop in King’s City.” Roland deliberately downplayed the actual figure. He did not want to sell this highly profitable good as if it was cabbage, or earn only four or five thousand gold pieces a year. Along with the steam engine, the perfume served as his hit product, and Roland hoped that it would be able to bring back a similar profit.

“…” The businesswoman remained silent for a long while before she heaved, “Your territory is truly full of the unexpected.”

“So, does that mean you’re willing to manage the sales of these goods?”

“Of course, Your Highness.” She stood up and bowed to Roland. “I find this to be a rare opportunity.”

…

After a general agreement was reached, the specific details and contractual terms were handed over to Barov to negotiate. Roland returned to his office and prepared to write a letter to Theo, who was hiding in King’s City.

Whether to initiate an attack and overthrow Timothy, or to open up a new trading route, a fine balancing act was required. Roland did not want to put

all his eggs in one basket. He hoped that even if the attack failed, he could continue to obtain saltpeter.

And the way to do this was self-production.

In the letter, aside from mentioning his intention to attack, he made a point to encourage Theo to contact the nitre plants in the surrounding areas of King's City and purchase a batch of nitre workers to send to Western Region.

This year, life was certainly not rosy for saltpeter merchants. Apart from prohibiting exports, Timothy also forced the merchants to sell at a low price to Alchemist Workshop. As a result, the profits of saltpeter fields naturally sank. Roland believed that as long as the pay was good enough, it would not be a problem to obtain entire factories' worth of workers.

The principle of saltpeter production was not complicated. At present, the population of Border Town was continually increasing, and could already satisfy the large amount of faeces required by the saltpeter fields. All of the conditions for self-production were fully met. Before defeating Timothy, this was undoubtedly one of the most stable guarantees.

Chapter 364

Chapter 364: Double Image

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

…

The snow outside was becoming heavier again. Snowflakes that were the size of a fingernail fell from the sky and covered Border Town. Gray elves danced in the wind and descended towards the land together, where they blended in with the white roofs and tree branches. In all probability, witnessing such a scene made one feel nothing but cold.

Yet, the more it was so, the warmer Tilly felt.

She leant back on her deckchair, with half of her body covered by a soft woolen blanket, and her legs extended towards a fire barrel. This convenient device for warming oneself was invented by Roland. A charcoal brazier was placed inside a square barrel, which was arranged in line with a chair separated by a horizontal wooden plank. It was different to a blazing bonfire, which could cause burns if one got too close, yet did not provide much heat if one was far away. By placing one's feet on the wooden plank, one could safely enjoy the warmth of the charcoal fire from a close distance. And by additionally tucking into a blanket, one's entire body would feel warm.

The swirling snow outside the window accentuated the cosiness of indoors, and the sense of bliss created by this contrast was deeply memorable.

She had to say that the treatment that the witches received in Border Town was completely different from one year ago. Understandably, the witches did not wish to leave as even she herself was immensely enjoying the stay.

Apart from her, Anna and Agatha were also staying in the room. This was originally Anna's bedroom, and whenever there was a rare downtime, Tilly would bring her books to the room and seek advice from Anna for things she

did not understand. At first, there were only the two of them, but now, there was also an ancient witch who had awakened from the ruins. Anna simply moved the fire barrel from beside the table to an empty space in the room and asked Roland to install two more deckchairs. The three of them sat around the fire barrel with their legs resting on each other, and together they learned eye-opening and arcane knowledge.

Of course, most of the time, Tilly and Agatha asked questions while Anna answered.

"It's hard to believe that a book like this could be written by a mortal." Agatha closed the cover of Natural Science Theoretical Foundation, and inhaled deeply. "The more I read, the more I realize that the world is the way it is. Amidst the mass chaos there are hidden rules, and everything operates according to the same rules. If he was born in Taquila, the Union would certainly accept him as a member, and there's a chance that he'll possess the same status as a Senior Witch."

At first, she asked many questions regarding the book's contents, but through Anna's detailed explanations, Agatha's attitude towards Roland changed significantly.

However, Tilly believed that this change was only directed towards Roland, while together, they continued to see other mortals as extremely dull and stupid.

As she thought of this, Tilly sighed uncontrollably. Only she knew that all of this knowledge did not originate from Roland Wimbledon but another person who suddenly appeared in his mind.

Through these few days of contact, as well as Sylvie's supporting evidence, Tilly was able to confirm this explanation. However, it would be impossible for them to prove he was still Roland Wimbledon. What was even more suspicious was that he did not know where this portion of memory came from or who it belonged to. It was hard to believe that memory could be completely separated from his life, or at least, she herself was unable to do so. As long as he recalled in his mind the knowledge of the court mentor and professor, the relevant segments of memory would flash in front of his eyes.

“Where exactly did he acquire all of this knowledge from?” Agatha sighed and said, “I had thought that the mortals’ research has been extensive, but after these few days of observation, it seems that there’s not much difference from 400 years ago—and perhaps even a little behind.”

“I don’t know either.” Tilly shrugged. “In any case, the knowledge couldn’t have been acquired in the palace.”

“How was he like in the past?”

This question made Anna raise her head.

“In the past…” Tilly hesitated for a moment. “He was arrogant, cowardly, bigoted, ignorant, unskilled and terrible… His only merit was probably that he didn’t make use of his status as a prince to commit any atrocious act.”

“Oh… so, he was equal to other mortals?”

“No. Even among mortals, he was considered a terrible fella.” She said, grumbling, “Though he improved after coming here, it’s still never clear what he’s thinking… He would always hold back his words and yet wanted people to trust him. How is that possible?”

The room suddenly quietened.

“What’s the matter?” Tilly sensed something odd in the other two’s eyes.

“No… Nothing.” Anna smiled with her mouth closed. “This is the first time I’ve heard you speak about this.”

“Damn, she only now realized that she had spoken too much. This kind of complaint shouldn’t be coming from an ally. It was probably because in recent days she had been too relaxed.” She tried to explain. “What I mean is…”

“It’s OK, His Highness wouldn’t care.” Anna shook her head and laughed. “He probably has his own reasons.”

“Roland…” Tilly hesitated briefly and asked, “didn’t mention these to you before?”

“No,” Anna said casually, “I haven’t asked him either. If he wanted to talk about it, he would.”

“Indeed,” Tilly sighed in mind. The first time that Anna met the prince, he was already a changed person, and hence it was meaningless to consider this question.

“From what you said, he was a totally different person in the past?” Agatha asked with interest. “There used to be a saying in the Quest Society that the more uncommon a person is, the more distinct quirks he has. Perhaps this kind of change is a normal occurrence. While in the palace, did Roland howl at the moon, or spend a long time staring and gesturing at the wall?”

“What kind of quirks are these?” Tilly could not help but shake her head. “Apart from being a little eccentric in the way he did things, he was no different from ordinary people. However… I heard people mention that once during a court lesson, he publicly exclaimed that he would marry a witch, and probably because of these words, Gerald and Timothy constantly picked on him in the name of purifying the Devil’s minions, while his own father was also unhappy with the behavior. After that, his personality became more and more stubborn and unruly.”

“He was discriminated against because he wanted to marry a witch?” Agatha curled her lips. “This was a noble goal in Taquila. Of course, the number of people who were successful to do this was very small, because most witches were unwilling to spend their lives with only one man.”

“But we’re different from 400 years ago. If he married a witch, it would mean that he wouldn’t have children to succeed him. How could his father feel good about such an idea?” Tilly sighed, “It has already been more than 10 years. He has most probably already forgotten those silly words.”

“Is it?” Anna spoke suddenly, “But now he’s still willing to marry a witch.”

“Oh, he still remembers? Wait…” Tilly’s eyes widened uncontrollably. “You said now?”

“Yes,” Anna laughed gently, “His Highness said so himself.”

Tilly suddenly froze.

Chapter 365

Chapter 365: The Journey to the West

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

Petrov yawned, sat up in his bed, and immediately felt a chill run through his upper body. He would stay in his bed forever if he could, where it was warm and had Shirley's company.

"Don't you want to sleep a little more?" The woman beside him turned over and mumbled groggily, "It's still early, isn't it?"

He bent over and kissed her forehead—Shirley had brown hair that fell in soft ringlets, skin as smooth as a baby's, and a pair of lovely round eyes. When he first met her at the Longsong Theatre, it took no more than a glance for him to be completely drawn by her eyes.

"I think it's almost noon, so I should head downstairs to see if there is any official business to attend to." Petrov whispered. "Go back to bed if you don't want to get up, and I'll have attendants bring lunch to you a while later."

"But I want you to stay here with me." Shirley wrapped her arm around his waist. "It's snowing outside anyways, so what official business could there be?"

She wasn't wrong. Ever since the Months of Demons arrived, the entire city immediately fell silent. Theater performances became weekly, all the merchants left the markets, and even the taverns shut their doors. If someone had walked on the streets during the day, he might have even thought this was a ghost town.

So… should he sleep for a little longer? After pursuing Shirley for nearly a year, Petrov's dream finally came true, and he felt a little reluctant to leave. Yesterday's entire night of joy really wore him out, and now that he had

regained his strength, perhaps there could be a second round of joy with Shirley after lunch.

Right at this moment, a knocking came from outside the bedroom.

“Sir Petrov, there is a blue-envelope letter.”

He was shocked and immediately rolled out of bed, picked up the robe that was carelessly tossed on the ground, and draped it on. “I’ll be there in a second.”

“Sir?” Shirley murmured.

“Give me a minute.” Petrov said as he tied his belt hurriedly and left the bedroom. After a while, he returned to the bedroom and crawled into the quilt holding a letter encased in a blue envelope.

“What’s this? Who wrote this to you?” At this point, the woman was basically wide awake. She yawned and sat up to lean against Petrov.

“It’s from Border Town.” Petrov replied. “It must be a letter written by His Highness.”

He opened the envelope and took out the letter, and as he quickly scanned its contents, he couldn’t help but frown. “His Highness orders me to pay a visit to Border Town.”

“Right now?” Shirley exclaimed. “Even in this weather?”

“Yes, it must be about something urgent.” Petrov sighed, “I’ll pack later and leave in the afternoon. You should go home for now, and I’ll visit you as soon as I get back.” He couldn’t help but think of the time a year ago when he sailed through a blizzard to Border Town, bearing the warning from Longsong Stronghold for Duke Ryan. Yet now, he was summoned back to that god-awful place because of a letter from the town Lord in a cruel twist of fate.

“Can’t you just pretend you didn’t receive it?” She said, annoyed. “Even though he conquered the Longsong Stronghold, you’re the actual ruler here.

Even if it were the King's order, you didn't have to immediately carry it out, right?"

If it were from the Duke, it would have been possible. However, Petrov knew Prince Roland's impatience full well. He could only lovingly stroke her head. "That's not the same. The King might not pay attention to the Western Region, but His Highness Roland can… He isn't only the Lord of Border Town, but the ruler of the entire Western Region."

…

During the Months of Demons, there truly wasn't much official business to attend to in Longsong Stronghold. After delegating a few tasks to his underlings and placing the town under his father Earl Hull's charge, Petrov left the castle. Different from last time when he was only accompanied by one assistant, this time he sailed on the Duke's private ship—the Lionheart, with more than ten attendants and apprentices, as well as two family knights. It was quite a spectacular scene.

Just as they were passing through the outer city and heading towards the Stronghold harbor, sounds of an uproar coming from the street corner caught Petrov's attention.

He saw ten or so men in a circle watching something. Judging from their dress, they were all civilians. They were probably attracted from their homes nearby by the noise. A few cries of "demon" also occasionally erupted from the circle. "Hang her!" Someone screamed sharply.

Petrov felt a twinge of sympathy and told one of his knights, "Go check it out. If it's a regular brawl, tell them to get back into their houses."

"Yes, Sir."

The knight pushed through the people and walked into the middle of the crowd. As he pulled out his swords, the crowd quickly dissipated. He brought back a woman and two children, one of which still had a rope tied around her neck.

“What happened?”

“Sir!” The woman knelt next to Petrov’s feet. “Kill her immediately! She has fallen to temptation and become a witch!”

This word shocked Petrov. “Witch?” He cast his sight onto the other two people. The slightly taller boy immediately stood in front of the girl and looked as if he was ready to attack. His face was badly bruised, revealing that he had been beaten brutally. “She isn’t the demon’s minion! I saw in plays that there were both good and bad witches. Why do you punish her?”

“Are you certain she’s a witch?” Petrov ignored the boy and continued asking the woman.

“Yes, Sir. Don’t be fooled by the plays. If the Church were still here, it would have never allowed them to spread such lies on stage. This thing here is also a little demon, and I was punishing her on behalf of the Church. Sir, hang her right now so that the influence of Hell won’t spread in Longsong!”

“Get to the point!” Petrov snapped.

After the woman had jabbered on for quite some time, Petrov finally understood the whole story. After the church was burned down by Timothy, this woman and some other believers continued preaching of their own accord in the outer city, and at the same time waited for the Holy City of Hermes to send a new priest to rebuild the Western Region’s church. This chaos happened out of pure coincidence. Just as the girl was using her abilities to help her neighbors clear out the snow on their roofs, the woman ran into her, which led to the debacle at hand.

While she was talking, the woman kept complaining about the absurdity of primary education and the demoralization of theater performances, which led to the onlookers only dared to hold onto the boy but not help her kill the damned demon. If it were in the old days, her corpse would have already been hung on a beam… These hateful words made Petrov’s face twitch.

“Take her back and interrogate her thoroughly.” He spoke to his knight. “You’ll stay in the Stronghold this time. When I come back, I expect all the

disciples similar to her to be in prison."

"What… no! Sir, how could you…" The woman had not even finished protesting before she was silenced by a few slaps across the face from the knight.

"Are you really a witch?" Petrov asked the terrified little girl. "Show me your abilities."

The girl could only kneel weakly on the ground and gave no response.

Petrov shook his head, raised his voice, and repeated, "If you can prove that you are really a witch, I'll let you go."

After a long time, the girl stuck her trembling hands in the snow. Soon, a layer of snow that was nearly an inch thick melted into flowing icy water.

"So I see." Petrov nodded. "Come with me."

"Come?" The girl raised her head. "Where to go?"

"A place fit for witches to live." He motioned for his servant to pick up the girl and continued walking to the harbor.

"Put her down, you liar! You promised to let her go! " The boy wanted to rush towards her, but he was blocked by the other attendants, and his voice faded slowly into the distance.

Chapter 366

Chapter 366: Paper

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

After the snowfall during the Months of the Demons, the Redwater River became the only path in the entire Western Region that could still be traveled.

Compared to the small sailboat Petrov used before, the Lionheart was much more spacious. It had room for a simple kitchen, so that even during travels, the passengers could eat piping hot food.

His bedroom naturally was the single bedroom at the stern that the Duke used to live in, which was essentially the poop of the boat. It had windows that allowed Petrov to see the currents and floating ice running under his feet.

“Sir, the egg soup you demanded.” The knight carried a clay jar and a ceramic bowl into his room.

“Thanks for the trouble.” Roland nodded and said. “You should sit down and have a bowl to warm yourself up.”

After His Highness drafted all the knights of the other four noble families to Border Town, the first thing those nobilities did was to send the knights’ families over as well. All the empty lands left behind were used for soliciting new knights, or directly taken up by the nobilities themselves.

Only the Honeysuckle Family didn’t suffer too many losses in this war, and they actually expanded swiftly after they were placed in charge of Longsong Stronghold. Now, they were high above the other four families and still owned a relatively complete platoon of knights. Sise, the knight next to him, was a member of this platoon. Although he was not as well-known as Morning Light, he was still one of the more outstanding young knights.

“Yes, Sir.” He smiled, opened the lid of the jar, and poured a bowl of soup for Petrov. “But… Sir, do you really think this is alright?”

“Are you talking about the witch?”

“Yes. Even though the church was burned down, it’s pretty easy to rebuild it, and the church will surely return to the Western Region someday. If you place all the blame on Prince Roland, there won’t be anything they can do. However, you rescued a witch in public and arrested the believers of the church…” The knight hesitated and continued, “That’s an outright opposition to them.”

“If it’s easy to rebuild it, then why is that place still a pile of rubbles?” Petrov blew on his fragrant egg soup. “The church won’t ever come back to the Western Region again.”

Sise blinked confusedly and didn’t seem convinced.

After the egg soup had slightly cooled, Petrov took a little sip and puffed a cloud of smoke in satisfaction. “As an escrow, my most important duty is to figure out the true intentions of my superior. The real purpose of His Highness’ efforts to normalize education in the Stronghold, utilize the newly trained Border Town soldiers, and act out plays with obvious messages was to weaken the church’s influence. Since I’m the caretaker of the Stronghold under His Highness, I have to follow his intentions in governing this area. If I can’t even figure this out, he’ll probably replace me with someone else.” Petrov shrugged. “Preventing the church from being rebuilt is as easy as lifting a hand—the stonemasons and carpenters should have all gotten their warnings. Even if the believers want to rebuild the church on their own, the Rats won’t let these artisans work for them.”

“But the church…”

“Since His Highness did it, he’s not afraid of the church’s retribution, which is to say that he’s confident that he can fend off the church. If they can still set foot in the Western Region, it’ll mean the prince has failed. If he fails, I won’t be able to sit on the Stronghold throne anymore. I think you can understand this.”

“Do you think Prince Roland can defeat the church’s army?” Sise asked.

“Who knows?” Petrov shook his head, smiling. “A year ago, no one thought that he could fend off Duke Ryan’s knights.” He stood and lifted up the jar. “I’ll go check on the little girl, who may be hungry.”

…

The girl’s name was Paper.

There was no doubt that only an orphan could have such a meaningless name.

Ever since she boarded the boat, she stayed silently in the cabin under the deck. Even when her hands were frozen and red, and her body was trembling in the cold, she didn’t make a sound. For safety reasons, Petrov still placed a God’s Locket of Retribution onto her. Although His Highness kept claiming that witches were just like normal people, he still didn’t fully believe that someone with such extraordinary powers could be like a normal person—even the slightest wrong move could end up in being hurt.

“Why aren’t you lying in the blanket?” Petrov pointed at the hammock hanging in the cabin. Cabin space was limited, so sailors usually slept in suspended hammocks, and used coarse linen blankets. Although it wasn’t the most comfortable thing, it was still warm.

“I’ll get it dirty,” she whispered.

“Sailors can’t be any cleaner than you.” He found a relatively dry spot and sat down. “This journey takes three days. Are you just going to sit like this the entire time? I’m worried that you’ll starve to death before we even reach Border Town.”

“Border Town?” Paper stared in confusion.

“Didn’t I tell you? You’re going to a place fit for witches to live in.” Petrov opened the jar. “Drink some hot soup and go lie on the hammock.”

This time, the girl did not refuse. It was obvious that she was starved as she began drinking directly from the jar without the fear of burning her tongue.

Petrov shook his head. She was as skinny as a monkey, her hair was matted with dirt, and there were holes all over her clothes, which she probably found somewhere. At a glance, she seemed no different from all the other orphans in the Stronghold.

“Who’s he, the boy protecting you?” He asked, “Your orphan friend?”

“Snaketooth. He… often brought us… food to eat,” Paper swallowed the soup, stuck out her tongue, and mumbled. “If I go with you, you won’t… arrest him, right? He’s not… a witch.”

“Of course,” Petrov said expressionlessly. “He isn’t important.” The phrase “often brought us food to eat” slightly surprised him. There were few people like that boy in the slums. Usually, a lack of food pushed people to steal from each other—people who were already struggling to survive rarely had the energy to worry about others. And the name Snaketooth… sounded a bit like a Rat.

At that thought, he couldn’t help but ask, “You said ‘us’ – were there other witches besides you?”

“No.” Paper shook her head. “All of the others were just orphans.”

This relieved Petrov a little. “So what was that old bat talking about when she said you were using your abilities to clear snow? This’s the first time I’ve heard about a witch who used her abilities in public.”

“It was Snaketooth’s idea. He said that I could help the residents clear the snow on their roofs in exchange for food, so no one would go hungry. The theater puts on stories about witches all the time, so no one is afraid of witches now. As long as I’m willing to do it, he can negotiate with the adults.”

“It is that so.” Petrov thought, the corners of his mouth curling into a smirk. “This kid is quite interesting. He knew how to make the most of his resources, but he underestimated the church’s influence.” Then, he asked, “So, did you get food in exchange?”

“Um…” Paper bowed her head. “I cleaned three roofs. One family chased me away, while the other two gave me half a loaf of bread and a pancake. However, when I got to the fourth…”

She met that hateful old woman. Petrov patted her head. “Get some rest when you’re done drinking. I’ll send someone to get you when it’s dinnertime.”

Three days later, the Lionheart arrived in the harbor of Border Town.

Chapter 367

Chapter 367: The First Step to Building the City

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

Petrov stepped out of his cabin and was surprised that he was not greeted with the smell of rotting wood. There was a newly built bridge next to the boat, and the harbor had doubled in size and thudded instead of creaking when stepped on—he could tell that the planks had been laid sturdily and that the material was of great quality.

After leaving the harbor, a few uniformed guards immediately walked over. The leader of the group gave the family crest hanging on the Lionheart's flagpole an once-over and asked, "Are you… Sir Hull of the Honeysuckle Family?"

"Yes." Petrov nodded, feeling quite important. "I am Petrov Hull, and I came here at His Highness' invitation."

"Lord Iron Axe has already told us about you. Please come with me." The guard waved his hand.

"We're walking?" Petrov was shocked.

"Yes. All the stables have been demolished," the guard smiled apologetically and said. "Don't worry. The town roads are in great condition."

Petrov soon understood what the guard meant by "great condition".

The road was smooth and wide, and all the snow had been cleared so that there were barely even any puddles. It seemed to be paved with many little black stones that had tiny spaces between them and glistened with moisture. Furthermore, what surprised Petrov the most was that this wasn't the only road like this. There was an intersection every hundred steps. The roads

were so straight and symmetrical that they seemed to be drawn on paper. During the half-hour walk, he didn't see a single bit of mud.

Petrov was stunned to find that this town looked completely different from the one in his memories.

"Sir, is this really… Border Town?" Sise stared at the scenery around him. "Wasn't it only a temporary living area for miners?"

"It used to be that way," the guard said, smiling, "but ever since His Highness arrived, everything has been changing. Take these roads for example, they were all built six months ago. Back then, there were thousands of people working together every day, so we could practically build a new one every month."

Petrov noticed a strong tone of pride peeking through the guard's voice, as if he felt proud to be a member of the town.

But… this was so unbelievable! Neat rows of trees bordered every road, which he imagined to form a beautiful canopy of leaves to block out the scorching sun in summer. Then there were the houses—all the short mud huts and shabby wooden inns were nowhere to be seen. Instead, there were clean-cut brick buildings with two to three stories that all shared a similar style. They obviously must have all been built by the same group of stonemasons.

How could he possibly transform a poor little town in only one year?

The shocked and confused Petrov followed the guards into the castle grounds. His guide was replaced by an armored knight, while his attendants were left to wait outside the castle walls.

When he stepped into the Lord's castle, Petrov finally felt the same as he did one year ago.

It seemed that not much had changed here. Compared to the Stronghold castle, the prince's was still much smaller.

The knight pushed open the door to the hall and made a motion for him to enter. Petrov immediately saw the prince sitting on the throne.

It was His Highness Roland Wimbledon.

“Welcome to Border Town,” Roland said with a smile, “Mr. ‘Ambassador’.”

It seemed the prince hadn’t changed much. For some reason, Petrov felt relieved. He raised his hand to his chest and bowed solemnly. “The Honeysuckle Family pays you our respects, Your Highness.”

“Have a seat.” The prince nodded. “I call you here because of a very important matter. It concerns the future of the entire Western Region, Longsong Stronghold naturally also included.”

“Please, go ahead.”

“I plan to build a city here, which will extend westward to the Misty Forest, eastward to Longsong Stronghold, and it’ll include half of the Western Region in its bounds. From then on, the Stronghold will be an eastern fortress for the new city and the first line of defense against the church’s army instead of an independent city like it is now,” Roland said in a methodical manner. “In such a vast and expansive region, it’s important to pass the same laws everywhere and centralize their enforcement to the City Hall of the new city. No nobility can meddle in city affairs, which includes the five main noble families of the Western Region.”

Petrov felt a sudden shock! A year ago, he had a similar idea to have Duke Ryan move the defense line against the demonic beasts to Border Town and utilize the space between the two towns. He would never have expected that the prince would use this method a year later with a much heavier hand. Turn Longsong Stronghold into a section of a city? He could only imagine how terrifyingly massive this city would be!

He felt an impulse to question the prince, but stifled his words—if the prince was telling this to him, it meant he had already made up his mind, and no one would be able to stop him from carrying out his plan.

Petrov didn't dare to challenge the prince. Duke Ryan's fiasco was forever burned in his mind and made him believe that this man with gray hair was unbeatable… at least by him. The only thing he could do was to reap as much profit as possible during this immense change.

"You said that the five noble families can't meddle in city affairs, so how can the Honeysuckle Family continue to serve you?"

The prince was silent for such a long time that Petrov began to feel uneasy. Then, he chuckled and said, "You've really surprised me, Mr. Ambassador. Both your asking to ransom the Stronghold and your positive attitude right now are wise and calculated decisions that are rarely seen made by nobles."

After a few words of praise, his smile faded, and he said seriously, "As long as the Honeysuckle Family is willing to accept my rule, you can continue to assist me to govern the Longsong region."

"Both my father and I will always do as you wish—"

"I'm not talking about individuals—I'm talking about the whole area," Roland interrupted. "From now on, the nobilities under my rule will have the ownership of their land, but not the right to govern it—whether it is regarding the law, law enforcement, or other policies, they'll all have to defer to the decrees of the City Hall."

"Um…" Petrov hesitated.

"Land can still be passed on through family lineage, just like titles. Any industries that your family conducts, such as farming or craftsmanship, will also belong to the Honeysuckles along with your land. That's your indisputable right, and I promise you my blessing. Aside from governing rights, nothing will change about the land you own. It might even flourish under new policies." The prince continued. "Of course, you can also choose to return to your land and continue to live as a feudal lord. However, when I finish building my new city and begin expanding, any land I conquer won't belong to its original owner anymore."

Chapter 368

Chapter 368: Filling in the Gaps

Translator: Meh Editor: – –

…

“Do you really think he’ll agree?” asked Nightingale after Petrov left, whispering into Roland’s ear.

“I’m not sure. In addition, even if he does, he’ll still need to persuade Count Hull for it to be of any use,” said Roland as he took a sip of his hot tea, “If his father still insists on his position as a noble, then there’ll be nothing we can do.”

“You can’t bear to see him go, can you?” she teased.

“Of course not.” Roland pursed his lips. “As a noble, he’s both intelligent and humble, as well as having a penchant for managing commerce. As long as he studies in Longsong Stronghold for a year or two, he’ll definitely become an capable government official.”

“If he manages to persuade Count Hull, you’ll really hand the Royal Capital over for him to govern?”

“If I manage to conquer Graycastle, the capital will naturally need to be moved elsewhere… In addition, cities that are far from the Western Region will need to be managed by officials sent from the west. As such, the terms I laid out may have sounded fantastical but were nevertheless legitimate.”

Towards the end of his conversation with Petrov, Roland informed him that from henceforth, he would not appoint any nobles. In fact, after consolidating Graycastle, he planned on establishing a brand new model for society throughout the kingdom based on that of Bordertown. He planned to consolidate and create a central government with a single word of law and

judicial policy. Should Petrov decide to stay, Longsong Stronghold would be far from his final destination. Be it a mayor of a major city or chief bureaucrat of the new central government, neither was impossible for him.

As for how far he'll go in reality, it'll be up to none other than himself.

Roland sincerely hoped that Petrov would understand his implications and anticipations from the conversation just now.

"Alright then, it's not as if I understand these things anyway," Nightingale patted his shoulder and continued, "in any case, the new witch is coming over soon. It's best if you go elsewhere for a while."

"You're going to question her by yourself?"

"I'll call Wendy over." The sound of her laughter rang out beside him. "She's better at these things than I am."

The Witches Union for the sake of safety (a cause mainly championed by Scroll), had established a rule: prior to any further interactions with an unknown Witch, their identity had to first be confirmed by Nightingale. Doing this required her to enter her mist, and therefore also take off the God's Stone of Retaliation. Thus, it was best if Roland was not present, lest the outsider revolted and anything unexpected happened.

Scroll even managed to come up with a series of 10 questions specifically to determine one's identity, such as "Where are you from", "What is your real name", "Do you recognize the prince", "Do you hold any hostile intentions towards the prince", etc. Since Nightingale could only determine the veracity of someone's statements based on the target's own beliefs, this battery of true/false questions aimed to establish the target's true intentions without leaving any loopholes. Even if they could deceive her once or twice, there was no way they could pass every single question.

Roland didn't know whether to laugh or cry when this was brought up, but in consideration of the witches' good intentions, he could only go along with this plan.

…

After leaving the main hall, he returned to his office and immediately sent for City Hall Director Barov.

After reading Petrov's report on the discovery of new witches in Longsong Stronghold, Roland realized his oversight. Though he had sent Anna onto the ceremonial award stage and acknowledged the existence of witches in Border Town, no official decree ever explained their status and how they should be treated. Thus, Border Town might very well have a similar situation as the Stronghold, where a witch would hide herself upon awakening and lie unknown instead of revealing her talents.

The second Barov stepped into the room, Roland immediately ordered, "I'm declaring a long term recruitment drive, and the details are on this paper here."

Barov received the draft and took a cursory glance, "Your Majesty… you mean to recruit witches at a monthly salary of an entire gold royal each?"

"That's right," Roland nodded, "This is also the Witches Union's standard salary." A monthly salary of one gold royal in this era was for only the most prestigious of positions. Border Town's average salary and standard of living were already well beyond those of other cities, with the highest paid being the workers in the acid manufacturing plant at 20 silver royals. Yet, this new decree set the witches' wage at five times the current highest, cementing their position in society.

"Since you want to recruit more witches, why not send people to search for them?" asked Barov, "the same way you had the citizens report spies. After all, their eyes see more truth than anyone else's."

"Even my Director has learned to fight [The Peoples' War]." Roland mused, holding back the delight in his heart, "And should I offer a reward for finding them? What difference will there be between me and the church then?"

"But… you're doing this to recruit them, whereas the church means to hang them."

“Even if we say so, the witches forcibly exposed this way might think we’re actually persecuting them. Though new witches in Border Town may have not experienced the persecution of the populace, the same cannot be said for those who have come from elsewhere,” said Roland, declining Barov’s proposal. “My hope is for them to stand forward of their own volition, for the sake of making their own contribution to Border Town.”

In addition to the witches’ own inhibitions, Roland was also worried about the effect declaring a reward would have on the populace, possibly creating a new wave of “witch hunters”, or making witches out to be valuable “commodities” to be created and found. Giving birth to a witch would become more profitable than hard work, which though in the short term would elevate the witches’ positions, but in the long term could easily hurt Border Town’s “American Dream” that Roland had worked so hard to achieve.

Right after Barov left, Wendy immediately entered, placing the results of the investigation on his desk.

“Your Highness, we’ve confirmed her identity. There are no problems as her answers line up with what the Honeysuckle’s eldest said.”

“See,” smiled Roland, “I told you guys you were being too careful.”

“Nevertheless this level of caution is necessary,” Wendy persevered, “Your Highness’ personal safety will always be our first and foremost priority.”

“Alright,” said Roland, suddenly feeling a little touched, as he took a deep breath and said, “bring her here then.”

The girl seemed around 15 years old, her dirtied hair a muddled brown, eyes brimming with timidity and slight panic. It seemed to be the first time she’d ever stepped foot into a carpeted room, as seen from her restless fidgeting as she tried to determine where to put her feet.

According to the information on the report, she called herself Paper and was born just outside of Longsong Stronghold. She became an orphan during a blizzard three years ago, a background shared by many of the street urchins in

the western region. These orphans' fates were usually to either die scrounging for food, or join the underground street rats, becoming a pickpocket, thug or scapegoat.

"You…" Roland paused, unable to decide what to say. The girl was neither like Agatha, resilient and adaptable, nor like Anna, determined and firm of heart. Even Mystery Moon and Lily, whose situations most resembled hers, had the sisterhood and companionship of the Union. As a young girl in a completely new place, she was probably in a state of constant panic, and most likely required a lengthy period to acclimate to her new environment. From Petrov's report, her ability to melt snow was most likely related to the control of temperature.

"Anyway, there's no rush to test her ability, we can slowly learn about it as she becomes familiarized with this place." With that thought, Roland turned to Wendy and said, "She must be exhausted from the long journey, why don't you take her for a bath first and let her rest awhile. Arrange for her to stay in the witches' building. As for any instructions she requires with respect to magic, I'll leave that to you, alright?"

"Of course," she smiled coyly, "As you wish."

Chapter 369

Chapter 369: Changes

Translator: Meh Editor: – –

Steam billowed out of the bathroom's bathtub.

Wendy lathered the soap and rubbed it everywhere on the little girl's body: behind the ears, under the arms, not even sparing the area between her fingertips. Upon seeing the layers of dirt intermixed with foam slide into the bathtub, revealing the tender skin underneath, Wendy felt an unprecedented amount of satisfaction.

It had been quite some time since Wendy experienced this feeling. Back in the days when the Witch Cooperation Association was still fleeing for its life, every close call or scare and every newly awakened witch that had given up all hope was made well again under her care, recovering a state of peaceful normalcy. Leaf, Lily, even Nightingale all found their hope with her help.

Yet, ever since they had come to Border Town, the witches' lives had undergone a 180 degree change. No one had to worry anymore about any life necessities, as everything was now provided for them—of course, she had no problem with this, and was incredibly grateful for everything Roland had done for the sisters. It was merely the fact that there were no longer any witches that needed her care—even Mystery Moon had become open and carefree that led Wendy to feel a little frustrated.

Now, she finally once again had the opportunity to feel the joy of being a big sister.

"Close your eyes. I'm turning the water on."

"Okay," the little girl's voice quietly slid out, soft and graceful like a droplet of morning dew.

It must be said, His Highness' decision to give her a bath was truly genius.

The water ran past the girl's bangs and trickled down her back, taking with it the now ashy brown foam. Only after rinsing her body three times did the color of the water turn back to normal.

Without any set of clothes to cover it up, the girl's frail and emaciated body was completely revealed to Wendy's eyes. "What a poor, skinny child," Wendy couldn't help but think. Her spine could be seen protruding out of her back, her arm so thin that a single hand could easily grasp it, and her skin not white like her namesake but instead a pallid yellow revealing her years of living in hunger.

Luckily she was a witch, and as long as she was properly taken care of, it wouldn't be long before she could recover.

After rinsing her body clean, it was time for them to enjoy a bath. Wendy first tested the temperature and then carried her into the bathtub, the water quickly submerging and enveloping them. Though the water was near scalding, after enduring the slight discomfort and acclimating, one would soon be able to savor the joy and comfort of being cradled by its warmth.

Paper involuntarily let out a low shout, most likely because it had been a long, long time since she was last able to bathe in hot water. She tightly grasped Wendy's hands, and then gradually loosened her grip. Wendy then spun her around so that the girl faced away from her, letting her sit in her lap as she meticulously began to parse through the little girl's twisted bun of hair, strand by strand.

"When did you find out you were a witch?"

"Two… two years ago," Paper quietly replied, "I think in the winter, just like now."

"That's not surprising." Wendy smiled and continued, "Most witches awaken during the Months of the Demons. According to rumor, it's during this period of time that magic power is most abundant."

“Isn’t it demonic magic power?”

“Of course not,” she patted the little girl’s head and said, “becoming a witch is a very, very normal thing. Asides from having the abilities to do some things other people can’t imagine, we are no different from your everyday normal person. You should know that several hundred years ago, witches were even viewed as those blessed by the gods.

“Really?”

“Absolutely.”

“In reality, the difference between witches and mortals was quite large, such as their superhuman physical abilities and sterility,” thought Wendy as she replied, “but these things could be slowly taught to her at a later time.”

“Then, what’s magic power?” Paper asked shyly.

“Magic power is a type of natural energy, just like the sun’s ever-present light.” Wendy thought for a second. “Well, sort of. The sun has a time when it sets, but magic power is always there. All in all, you can regard it as an extension of yourself, an extension that’s constantly growing.”

“Constantly growing?”

“That’s right, your magic power will grow as you do, becoming increasingly powerful. In order to accommodate its growth you must also increase the limits of your own body. Otherwise there will be a backlash.” Wendy meticulously explained, “The church abused this very fact, claiming that witches were being devoured by the energy of the devil when in reality it couldn’t be further from the truth. As long as you continuously practice your control of your powers, even if your magic power grows, there will be no need to worry about it harming your body. If you awakened two years ago, you must have already experienced a Day of Awakening already. Back then… it must have hurt a lot.”

Paper gently nodded her head.

“Worry not though, now that you’ve arrived in Border Town, everything will be better.” Wendy tenderly consoled her. “As long as you make the most of this time and practice, this year’s Day of Awakening will be quick and painless.”

Just as she was about to continue, the door to the bath was shoved open, revealing Lily running in with a towel in her hand.

“I heard there was a new sister? Where? Where? Mystery Moon’s so anxious to see her!”

“It’s obviously you who’s anxious!” Mystery Moon, dragged all the way here by Lily, shot her a glare. “Why take a shower now? What if we have to use our abilities this afternoon?”

“Don’t worry, there’s no harm in resting for a day. His Highness probably won’t need you for anything, after all, you’re not Miss Anna.”

“… You traitor!!”

Upon seeing the two barge in, Paper quickly shrunk her neck, the bottom half of her head submerging itself into the water.

“Oh, so this is the new witch?” Lily climbed to the edge of the bathtub and looked at Paper, eyes brimming with curiosity. “You look around the same age as me, but you can still call me big sister.”

“Why would she call you big sister if she’s around the same age as you?” Mystery Moon noisily interjected. “And how come you’ve never called me that?”

“They’re both witches of Border Town,” Wendy introduced with a smile. “You may think they are open, but when they first arrived here, they were both just like you… especially Mystery Moon, she wasn’t much braver than you, always speaking with a very quiet and soft little voice.”

“Ahem. I was just worried His Highness would look down on me for having such weak magic power.” Mystery Moon mumbled to herself.

“His Highness has told me several times, your power has incredibly unexplored potential.” Wendy shook her head. “As long as you finish reading and learning Elementary Physics, it might evolve into something surpassing your wildest dreams.”

“Forget the books. She doesn’t even understand all the words yet. She barely even passed the last examination.” Lily interjected, shrugging her shoulders. “She even came to me at night asking me to help her with her studies. By the time she’s done learning all the weird theories and formulas in that book, His Highness Roland will probably have already conquered and unified all of Graycastle and won’t even need the witches’ help anymore.” Ignoring Mystery Moon’s annoyed expression, her gaze turned towards the girl sitting in Wendy’s lap. “Oh, that’s right. What kind of power does Paper have?”

“… Melting snow.” The little girl pondered for a while before replying.

“Anything else?” Lily curiously asked, “Can you freeze the melted snow back into ice?”

“No,” Paper meekly replied, “and also… also I can make hot water cool really fast.”

“Temperature manipulation then?” Wendy mused and said, “But melting snow is adding heat, whereas cooling water is removing it, yet the two processes can’t be reversed, so it’s probably not temperature control. Have you only tried your power with water?”

“With other things, the difference is very small.”

“Try using this.” Lily held up a basin full of soapy water.

The little girl cautiously placed her hand into the basin. Very soon, the steaming hot water began to cool. Then, before everyone’s eyes, a change occurred in the murky soap water. The soap bubbles on the surface began to disappear, the white kernels of soap also vanished into thin air, and the basin was once again filled with pristine, clear water.

Chapter 370

Chapter 370: Rhythm

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

Three days later, Roland received an affirmative answer from the eldest son of the Honeysuckle Family.

“I’m willing to continue serving you, and so is the Honeysuckle Family,” he said, bowing his head. “I’ll convince my father—he’s a little… different from the other families.”

“Is that so.” Roland suddenly felt quite cheerful. “That’s great to hear.”

“In the past few days, I’ve witnessed all the extraordinary changes that have taken place in your town, and I realized that this was the city I wished for all long,” Petrov confessed. “If the Honeysuckle Family can flourish like this, Father won’t mind merging with the new city.”

This struck a chord in the Prince’s heart. He originally only had two reasons for bringing Petrov here: The first was that it was more sincere to share such momentous news with Petrov in person, and the other was to observe his attitude towards the decree. Roland never imagined that Petrov would react this well. Roland nodded and said, “Of course. In time, every inch of land in the Kingdom of Graycastle will be home to the people.”

“Then I must return to Stronghold as quickly as possible and relay this news to my father.”

“Don’t forget the other four noble families and all the nobilites of the Western Region.” Roland added, “Any family who wishes to accept my terms will be welcomed unconditionally into the new city, regardless of past conflicts. You can hold a banquet in the Stronghold to spread the word.”

“You mean you want me to tell them?” Petrov asked, stunned.

“Yes,” the prince said, smiling. “This time… you can act as my ambassador.”

“Yes, Your Highness,” the eldest of the Honeysuckles raised a hand to his chest and said.

Just as he was about to leave, Roland stopped him and said, “By the way, you did a great job with the witch incident. There’ll be no more hiding from now on. After all this universal education, if anyone is still blindly hanging onto the church’s teachings, they should be removed from the Western Region. You can decide how exactly you want to do it.”

“Yes, Your Highness.”

After Petrov Hull left, Roland stretched and yawned, and then continued flipping through the data that the City Hall had compiled on various construction projects.

Due to the heavy snowfall, the construction of the Kingdom Main Street had to be halted, and the construction of houses had been slowed down as well, so there were only a few indoor maintenance projects underway. Fortunately Lotus had constructed a series of cave dwellings to shelter the refugees before she left. Even if more refugees came, they could be distributed among the current caves—this was the advantage of using heated brick beds.

According to the Ministry of Construction, at least more than 60% of the workers were currently employed, so any last-minute recruitments from the City Hall were always snatched up quickly, such as clearing the snow off the streets, transporting goods in the Blast Furnace Zone and so on. If this were in any other city, having this many eager workers during the Months of Demons would be unbelievable. Winter was already the most difficult season for civilians, so most people usually shut themselves in their homes and survived by their fall harvest. However, Roland felt dissatisfied with seeing all this manpower being idle, so he racked his brain trying to think of something that could utilize it all.

After all, Margerie’s Chamber of Commerce had bought the last batch of steam engines manufactured this year, and the City Hall had more than enough money and grains, so that he could carry out many of his plans.

At this thought, Roland had his guard summon Karl Van Bate, the Minister of Construction.

After he explained his ideas, Karl couldn't help but stare. "You want the masons and clay artisans to build ships for you?"

He nodded and said seriously, "Yes, right by the harbor. Build a temporary workshop out of wood and keep a brazier burning inside to maintain the temperature. When the ships are completed, they can go straight into the water."

"But, Your Highness, how can they ever know how to build such a thing?"

"Of course they can. It's just like building the witches' tower," Roland said as he took out a piece of paper and drew a diagram. "Just set up a frame, lay down steel bars, and fill it in with concrete. I'll instruct you in building the first ship, and then you'll be solely in charge of supervision, so all the workers can be utilized as well."

Karl looked at the blueprint skeptically. "Is this… a bowl?"

Roland couldn't help but smile. "Yes, it's a giant concrete bowl."

Karl had not participated in the construction of the Littletown, so it was natural that he did not understand it. In fact, ships were constantly changing their shapes over time, with those of the next era barely inheriting those of the previous one. Roland had no idea how to design an ancient wooden ship with keels, but building a concrete ship was essentially no different from making a clay model—all it had to do was to float. It was the same for steel ships. With the improvements in welding technology, most modern ships abandoned the keeling method and were instead pieced together with steel plates so that the entire floor sustained its weight. There was no need to bother with wooden ships.

He had already considered building a new fleet of concrete ships for a long time. Both the coal mining excavations in the nearby mountains and the transportation of refugees required large riverboats, so a flat-bottom design with a low draught was the best option. Compared to the conservative design

of the Littletown, the new ships should have longer hulls to ensure a larger load, better stability, and higher speed. In order to also reduce construction difficulty, Roland decided to use paddle wheels to propel the ships. This had already been tested on wooden ships and was easier for the masons to achieve.

“Your Highness, how many men do you plan to employ to build these… concrete ships?” Karl asked awkwardly.

“Round up all the idle workers and build multiple ships at a time, just like when you were building houses.”

This way, even if no one bought the newly produced steam engines, there was something for people to do. The Furnace Area could continue producing cement, which would kill two birds with one stone. In the coming years, if he could command a large fleet of cement ships, the First Army would always have reliable logistic fallback wherever it attacked.

After dealing with this matter, Roland decided to check out the castle backyard.

The olive trees and grape vines that Leaf planted provided a shelter against the snow. If they weren’t working, the witches would usually practice in the backyard, including the newcomer Paper.

According to Wendy, her abilities weren’t temperature control, but they weren’t material restoration either, and they had little effect on any substance other than water. This intrigued Roland to no end. After three days, the little girl shouldn’t be as timid as she was when she first arrived, so he wanted to see her for himself.

As soon as he entered the garden, Roland felt that there was something off.

All he could see was lush greenery, as if he was in a different world from the snow outside—the olive trees were evergreen and had vines winding around their branches. Although it wasn’t surprising that the trees blocked out the snow, all the plants here were still a little too vibrant. What made it different

from a forest was that although there was no wind, the grass and trees swayed rhythmically in unison.

He thought it was an illusion, but as he walked deeper into the garden, he saw the olive branches bend over as if they were greeting him, and the grass around his feet fell to the side as if to welcome him.

This made Roland a little uneasy, and goosebumps began to appear on his back. He felt as if he was not walking in a garden, but inside the body of a giant creature.

The whole garden seemed to be breathing.

Chapter 371

Chapter 371: The Heart of the Forest

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

Roland walked into the center of the garden and froze in shock.

At the end of the path, a small house made out of plants suddenly appeared, with tree trunks and reformed crops forming its walls and layers of woven vines hanging up above, with some even carrying bunches of glistening grapes. A bonfire burned in the middle of the room, and there was green furniture placed all around. A closer look would reveal that they were actually shaped by strange plants that grew from the ground. For a moment, Roland felt as if he were in a fairyland. If it weren't for the familiar faces next to the bonfire, he truly would have thought he was dreaming.

"What's this?"

Tilly turned around and exclaimed, "Leaf's ability has evolved, and she's transformed herself into this garden."

"Where's she?" Roland asked surprisedly.

"She has become one with the plants," Tilly said, looking around her. "Everything you see right now is a part of Leaf."

His feeling of walking inside a creature wasn't wrong. It was just that the "creature" was actually Leaf. Roland suddenly felt a tug on his heart, "She can still turn back, right?"

"As soon as I call off my powers, I can return to my normal form." Leaf's voice suddenly echoed.

However, when he listened carefully, he realized that it wasn't Leaf herself who was speaking. The voice came from the rustling of swaying leaves and

the rubbing of branches.

Her answer calmed Roland down a little bit. “Can you hear us talk?”

“Not only can I hear you, I can also see you, smell you and feel you,” Leaf answered happily. “I can feel the slightest changes in the garden, including the birds building their nest on a branch and a bug crawling on a trunk… It’s hard to explain, but Lady Tilly is right. I am the garden itself, and I noticed you as soon as you walked in.”

Suddenly, a giant leaf hanging from the ceiling was lowered down next to Roland and unfurled slowly to reveal a cup containing purple liquid. The intricate cup was made from four overlapping olive leaves with their stems curving into a handle. Roland raised the cup up to his lips and realized that the liquid was freshly-made wine, a perfect combination of sourness and refreshing sweetness. Clearly, both the wine and its container came from this garden.

Roland downed Leaf’s “toast”, walked up to the bonfire, and sat excitedly on a plant chair—its frame was made of rough branches, and its seat and back were covered with a heavy layer of wheat leaves. Sitting in it was like sinking into a soft couch. Next to the bonfire stood a grill, where Andrea was roasting apples and corn for everyone. These foods were undoubtedly also taken directly from the garden.

“How did you manage to do all this?” the prince looked up and asked.

“I don’t really know either,” the voice answered immediately. “I was just taking care of the newly planted crops and your messenger birds as usual, while also practicing my abilities—and they responded to my call. Maybe this is the reconciliation I have been searching for—bringing the forest and the lives inside it together as one.”

“Could you use your abilities in the Misty Forest? Could you also turn it into a part of you?”

“I don’t think so…” She hesitated. “Even if I could, it would take a really long time. Maintaining this state doesn’t require a lot of magic power, and I

can even draw power from the forest, but every time I expand my area of influence, my mind becomes more sluggish."

"Sluggish?" Roland asked confusedly.

"I don't know how to describe this feeling," said Leaf. "If I kept expanding slowly, I might become one with the entire Misty Forest in a couple of years, but I'm scared that I might lose my consciousness. When I first started fusing with the garden, my mind felt so overwhelmed, as if it suddenly became very expansive. It took me a long time to get used to it." She paused and added, "However, re-entering plants that I have already controlled doesn't give me this unfamiliar feeling, and it only takes the slightest thought to accomplish."

"How incredible," Roland thought. "Compared to Anna and Lily's micro-evolution, Leaf's new abilities were a breakthrough in macro-evolution. If she could one day control the entire Misty Forest, not a single move of our enemies would escape her."

"Congratulations," Wendy said, smiling. "Now there's another evolved witch in the Witch Union. According to Elsa, we have about half the amount of evolved witches as the Union."

"If she were here, she must have gone on and on about this for ages." Roland chuckled and glanced over at the little girl who was peeking curiously at him. "What about Paper?"

"Her ability… unfortunately requires further testing," Wendy responded, "but we found a strange phenomenon."

She snapped her fingers, and two piles of packed snow immediately fell off the roof.

Wendy placed one pile next to the bonfire and another in a corner of the room, and then she asked Paper to use her powers. "I'm currently teaching her how to use her magic power evenly so that its effects are consistent—just like how you taught me. Although she can't control her power very precisely, it doesn't differ too greatly in general."

Roland noticed that the snow next to the bonfire had quickly melted into an icy puddle, while the farther pile had only melted halfway.

Wendy scooped up the melted water, carried it to one side of the room, and knocked on the wall. The tightly woven vines shrunk back to reveal a fist-sized hole, letting in the chilly wind.

“Here, now use your power on this,” she said to Paper.

The girl nodded and raised her hands, and Roland was shocked to find that the water had formed a thin layer of ice crystals.

“So her power is to… speed up time and accelerate results?” He doubted his theory as soon as he said. “That can’t be right. Time is but a concept created by humans for convenience, so it doesn’t exist on its own. How can she affect something that doesn’t exist?”

“That’s what I thought as well, but Lady Tilly said it wasn’t the case.” Wendy tied a stone to the end of a vine and swung it back and forth in front of Paper. As much as Paper tried to use her powers, the pendulum continued to swing at the same speed and eventually stopped. “If she could speed up time, the stone would have swung faster.”

Indeed. Roland quickly realized what her power was—she wasn’t affecting time, but molecular movement. Her magic power could lower or raise the energy levels of molecules, which led to freezing and melting. Of course, Paper probably didn’t understand this, so she simply used her intuition to control her power, which was why she had little impact on other objects. Oxidation was a long process and needed time to show visible results.

If he guessed correctly, her power made her a natural catalyst.

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Chapter 372: Leisure

Translator: TransN Editor: – –

A week later, Border Town welcomed its last month of fall with a giant blizzard.

Roland gazed out of his office window at the dark figures on the snowy rooftops—these were the townspeople carrying out their daily task of shoveling away the snow on their rooftops, so their houses wouldn't collapse under the weight.

This day marked a full year of him being in this world, but last year's fall was not nearly this cold, and his view from this window was not nearly this orderly.

At that time, the town was practically a wasteland. Besides a few decent wooden houses around the square, there were only shabby clay huts and straw shacks. Most of the nobilities lived near the square, from which the only stone road led to the castle. Otherwise, there was not a single inch of clean ground in the entire town, and everything reeked of the faeces of human and livestock.

Now, all the roads here were built from cement pavement, and even the uncovered roads were expertly packed solid. Dark lines separated the town into various sections, with the two sides of the main road reserved as a commercial district and the surrounding areas as residential complexes.

In addition, Border Town's manufacturing industry was beginning to take shape, which was to say that it finally replaced workshop manufacturing with a continuous assembly line—although this was only the case for steam engines. The Blast Furnace Zone produced enough iron ingots for processing, while the steam engine factory turned these raw materials into machine parts. The blacksmiths had all become familiar with their various tools and took on many apprentices. Even though Anna was still needed in producing the highly precise tools, the blacksmiths had already achieved great progress on their part. After all, before the appearance of tools, these men only knew how to use a hammer, while others started out as miners and hunters.

He might as well call these engines the fruits of these workers' labor.

There was also the production of ammunition and gunpowder, which was also entirely done by civilians. Anna still needed to produce the firearms herself, not because of a lack of machine tools, but because the town's blast furnace couldn't produce iron with consistent quality. This had already been added to Roland's list of problems to tackle.

The achievements in chemical engineering were even more exciting; because Roland didn't have any high expectation, any result was a pleasant surprise. Now, sulfuric acid and nitric acid were being massively produced, and chemical explosives were beginning to be developed. As long as ammunition production could increase, switching to repeating rifles wouldn't be an issue.

It didn't matter that their production methods were outdated, because producing anything at all was more important, given the town's current state. When Paper's abilities stabilized so that she could precisely control her own magic power, there might even be another peak in chemical engineering.

What mattered the most was that all aspects of Border Town, whether it was production, education, or construction, were all on an upwards developing trend. In time, as more and more people became educated, there would be more frequent breakthroughs in every field.

He felt his heart burst with pride for transforming a run-down land into what it was today within only a year.

Roland felt as if he could stand by the window and watch this town all day long.

At that moment, the sounds of tolling bells came from the north-west direction.

That was the alarm for a demonic beast attack.

After the arrival of the Months of the Demons, the alarm would sound every three to four days. However, the First Army was already very experienced in handling attacks and no longer required Roland's supervision—if he had not

stood alongside the Militia a year ago, they all would have dropped their weapons and run away.

“The demonic beasts are back. Should I go take a look?” Nightingale’s voice emerged next to his ears.

“Sure.” Roland nodded. “Be careful.”

“Don’t worry. They can’t touch me.”

He felt a slight warmth on his cheek, and the voice disappeared.

Roland shook his head helplessly. The witches were probably sick of hiding indoors from the snow, so Nightingale might just want something to do. The combat type witches who came with Tilly were especially eager to rush to the city wall and watch the battle, waiting for demonic hybrids to rush up the wall so they could put their ablilities into play. Nightingale was intrigued after hearing about this and began joining the combat witches every time the alarm sounded. Perhaps she intended to compare herself to others and determine who was the strongest combat witch.

Roland sighed. “If only she could be this eager in her training…”

However, fighting side by side could bring witches and mortals closer together, so he didn’t bother to stop them. The current revolving rifles were enough to fend off regular demonic beasts, but they faltered in the face of demonic wolf-lion hybrids, so having powerful witches present could stabilize the defense line and reduce casualties.

So far, there hadn’t been a single death in the First Army.

Nightingale’s exit reminded him that the combat witches had found a way to entertain themselves, but the assistant witches still didn’t have much to have fun with. It was time to think of some new activities.

At that thought, he summoned Soroya.

“Your Highness, do you have a new task for me?”

This painter who had accomplished so much for Border Town seemed to be in good spirits. The Freckles on her face had lightened, and her eyes shined with a piercing vitality.

Her pleading question stifled Roland a little—why did he suddenly feel so remorseful?

“Um, have you been busy lately?”

“No, why do you ask?” Soroya pushed a lock of hair out of her forehead. “Recently, fewer workers have been going to the factory, so it only took me a few hours to finish my coating everyday, and the weird metal boxes made by the alchemist Sir Kyle kept me busy sometimes.” She paused, tilted her head, and smiled. “However, compared with being in the camp of the Witch Cooperation Association, I prefer this fulfilling life here, and I’m really glad that my abilities are helpful to you.”

Wow… What a blinding smile.

Roland couldn’t help but feel a little guilty. “Ahem, I called you here to draw some new cards for me.”

“More Gwent Cards?”

“No, you all are probably tired of those,” he waved his hand and said. “It’s too simple. As long as you know your opponent’s hand, the game is basically predictable.”

“Yes, you’re right…”

“See, this’s what the new cards look like—very simple.” Roland took out a piece of paper and drew a rough sketch. “There’re four different symbols, each with cards numbered from one to thirteen, as well as two jokers, so it’s 54 cards in total.”

Soroya’s abilities had evolved greatly, so she was able to quickly produce a deck of cards directly from his sketch. “How do we play them?”

“There’re a lot of games you can play with these, but let’s start with an easy one.” Roland tested the cards with his hands and felt as if he were time-traveling again. To celebrate a Spring Festival, his family would always sit around their fire barrels, watch the Spring Festival Gala, and play poker until the next morning, when they would light firecrackers to welcome the spring.

Different from mah jong, poker could be played anywhere and had many variations, so it was probably the most popular game in the world.

“Go fetch Anna,” Roland said, smiling. “I’ll teach you how to play Fight the Landlord.”

Chapter 372

Chapter 372: Leisure

Translator: TransN Editor: – –

A week later, Border Town welcomed its last month of fall with a giant blizzard.

Roland gazed out of his office window at the dark figures on the snowy rooftops—these were the townspeople carrying out their daily task of shoveling away the snow on their rooftops, so their houses wouldn't collapse under the weight.

This day marked a full year of him being in this world, but last year's fall was not nearly this cold, and his view from this window was not nearly this orderly.

At that time, the town was practically a wasteland. Besides a few decent wooden houses around the square, there were only shabby clay huts and straw shacks. Most of the nobilities lived near the square, from which the only stone road led to the castle. Otherwise, there was not a single inch of clean ground in the entire town, and everything reeked of the faeces of human and livestock.

Now, all the roads here were built from cement pavement, and even the uncovered roads were expertly packed solid. Dark lines separated the town into various sections, with the two sides of the main road reserved as a commercial district and the surrounding areas as residential complexes.

In addition, Border Town's manufacturing industry was beginning to take shape, which was to say that it finally replaced workshop manufacturing with a continuous assembly line—although this was only the case for steam engines. The Blast Furnace Zone produced enough iron ingots for processing, while the steam engine factory turned these raw materials into machine parts. The blacksmiths had all become familiar with their various tools and took on

many apprentices. Even though Anna was still needed in producing the highly precise tools, the blacksmiths had already achieved great progress on their part. After all, before the appearance of tools, these men only knew how to use a hammer, while others started out as miners and hunters.

He might as well call these engines the fruits of these workers' labor.

There was also the production of ammunition and gunpowder, which was also entirely done by civilians. Anna still needed to produce the firearms herself, not because of a lack of machine tools, but because the town's blast furnace couldn't produce iron with consistent quality. This had already been added to Roland's list of problems to tackle.

The achievements in chemical engineering were even more exciting; because Roland didn't have any high expectation, any result was a pleasant surprise. Now, sulfuric acid and nitric acid were being massively produced, and chemical explosives were beginning to be developed. As long as ammunition production could increase, switching to repeating rifles wouldn't be an issue.

It didn't matter that their production methods were outdated, because producing anything at all was more important, given the town's current state. When Paper's abilities stabilized so that she could precisely control her own magic power, there might even be another peak in chemical engineering.

What mattered the most was that all aspects of Border Town, whether it was production, education, or construction, were all on an upwards developing trend. In time, as more and more people became educated, there would be more frequent breakthroughs in every field.

He felt his heart burst with pride for transforming a run-down land into what it was today within only a year.

Roland felt as if he could stand by the window and watch this town all day long.

At that moment, the sounds of tolling bells came from the north-west direction.

That was the alarm for a demonic beast attack.

After the arrival of the Months of the Demons, the alarm would sound every three to four days. However, the First Army was already very experienced in handling attacks and no longer required Roland's supervision—if he had not stood alongside the Militia a year ago, they all would have dropped their weapons and run away.

"The demonic beasts are back. Should I go take a look?" Nightingale's voice emerged next to his ears.

"Sure." Roland nodded. "Be careful."

"Don't worry. They can't touch me."

He felt a slight warmth on his cheek, and the voice disappeared.

Roland shook his head helplessly. The witches were probably sick of hiding indoors from the snow, so Nightingale might just want something to do. The combat type witches who came with Tilly were especially eager to rush to the city wall and watch the battle, waiting for demonic hybrids to rush up the wall so they could put their ablilities into play. Nightingale was intrigued after hearing about this and began joining the combat witches every time the alarm sounded. Perhaps she intended to compare herself to others and determine who was the strongest combat witch.

Roland sighed. "If only she could be this eager in her training…"

However, fighting side by side could bring witches and mortals closer together, so he didn't bother to stop them. The current revolving rifles were enough to fend off regular demonic beasts, but they faltered in the face of demonic wolf-lion hybrids, so having powerful witches present could stabilize the defense line and reduce casualties.

So far, there hadn't been a single death in the First Army.

Nightingale's exit reminded him that the combat witches had found a way to entertain themselves, but the assistant witches still didn't have much to have

fun with. It was time to think of some new activities.

At that thought, he summoned Soroya.

“Your Highness, do you have a new task for me?”

This painter who had accomplished so much for Border Town seemed to be in good spirits. The Freckles on her face had lightened, and her eyes shined with a piercing vitality.

Her pleading question stifled Roland a little—why did he suddenly feel so remorseful?

“Um, have you been busy lately?”

“No, why do you ask?” Soroya pushed a lock of hair out of her forehead. “Recently, fewer workers have been going to the factory, so it only took me a few hours to finish my coating everyday, and the weird metal boxes made by the alchemist Sir Kyle kept me busy sometimes.” She paused, tilted her head, and smiled. “However, compared with being in the camp of the Witch Cooperation Association, I prefer this fulfilling life here, and I’m really glad that my abilities are helpful to you.”

Wow… What a blinding smile.

Roland couldn’t help but feel a little guilty. “Ahem, I called you here to draw some new cards for me.”

“More Gwent Cards?”

“No, you all are probably tired of those,” he waved his hand and said. “It’s too simple. As long as you know your opponent’s hand, the game is basically predictable.”

“Yes, you’re right…”

“See, this’s what the new cards look like—very simple.” Roland took out a piece of paper and drew a rough sketch. “There’re four different symbols,

each with cards numbered from one to thirteen, as well as two jokers, so it's 54 cards in total."

Soroya's abilities had evolved greatly, so she was able to quickly produce a deck of cards directly from his sketch. "How do we play them?"

"There're a lot of games you can play with these, but let's start with an easy one." Roland tested the cards with his hands and felt as if he were time-traveling again. To celebrate a Spring Festival, his family would always sit around their fire barrels, watch the Spring Festival Gala, and play poker until the next morning, when they would light firecrackers to welcome the spring.

Different from mah jong, poker could be played anywhere and had many variations, so it was probably the most popular game in the world.

"Go fetch Anna," Roland said, smiling. "I'll teach you how to play Fight the Landlord."

Chapter 373

Chapter 373: A Clue at the Market

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

Ferlin stood behind his wife and smiled gently as he watched her pick out pieces of meat from a stall.

There would always come a certain time when the look in Irene's eyes became extra serious.

"Actually… every piece of meat is priced according to its weight, so you don't have to spend so much time choosing."

"That won't do!" she said in firm rejection. "Although I know that you like lean meat, without the fat, the dish won't have any flavor. A layer of fatty meat for every layer of lean meat will make the best ribs, and is also ideal for slicing and frying. I have to choose carefully."

Ferlin laughed uncontrollably. "Fine, you take your time. I'll go and buy a sack of wheat. The queue is quite long, so when you're done, come and find me.

"Okay," Irene replied without turning her head.

He shook his head helplessly and advanced towards the wheat stall in the Convenience Market.

Ever since snow started falling, Lord Roland had put up wooden sheds, which acted as wind shields, around the market. He also specially posted an announcement that even though it was winter, the sales in the market would not stop.

This implied that during the long Months of the Demons, Border Town would continue to be provided with a stable supply of food.

To the townspeople, this measure effectively granted them peace of mind.

Compared to the meat stall, the wheat stall was much more frequented by customers. A long queue was formed in front of the counter, while surrounding the queue were two patrol members wearing black uniforms whose task was to maintain order. In Border Town, they were given a unique name: “policemen”.

Morning Light had already gotten used to seeing all kinds of amazing initiatives by Lord Roland, and a change in name was nothing interesting. He also knew that the name “patrol members” was commonly associated with rogues and ruffians, and therefore changing the name gave a wholly different impression.

“Good afternoon, Mr. Eltek.” Someone in the queue recognized him. “You’ve also come to buy wheat?”

“Stand here with me.”

“Let me offer you my position.”

“No, that’s unnecessary.” Ferlin waved his hands and stood at the back of the queue. “Thank you.”

“You’re so popular,” A middle-aged man in front of him laughed and said, “the former First Knight of the Western Region indeed.”

Ferlin was slightly stunned. “You know about my past…”

“Haha, of course. This is no secret in Border Town.” The man touched his own chin and grinned. “My sons and daughters are highly fond of you. Ever since my eldest son, Nat, heard about your background, he can’t stop telling us how much he wants to become a knight too.”

“That’s all in the past.” Ferlin shook his head. “And His Highness no longer needs Knights.”

“That’s because we have the First Army.” The man said casually. “In the past, I wouldn’t dare to talk to you like that.”

Indeed, while he was still a knight of the Duke, most common folks did not even dare to look straight at him. The rumors about him were filled with words of not only envy and admiration, but more commonly, fear. The only person who dared to make eye contact with him, and who was able to speak straight to him without scruple about status, was Irene. The first time they met at a theatre, his heart found its home.

After being defeated and brought captive to Border Town, Ferlin originally thought that it simply entailed a change of the lord he worked for. He did not expect that he would become a teacher to many people and receive widespread respect.

The form of respect shown towards him was completely different from the old times when he was a knight. People no longer avoided him and instead came close to him. Compared with the respect shown by keeping a distance, it was the latter which made Ferlin feel more comfortable and satisfied.

Perhaps, I'm not suited to be a Knight.

…

After waiting for more than a quarter of an hour, it was finally Ferlin Eltek's turn.

"Identity card, please." The counterperson said before she got a shock. "Teacher Ferlin?"

"Betty." Ferlin was also a little surprised that the girl standing behind the counter was a student from his first batch of graduates. He soon understood, and said happily, "You're working in the City Hall now?"

"Indeed," she revealed an expression of joy and bowed towards Ferlin as if she was still in school. "I'm now a trainee in the Governing Hall, and I am currently working in the Agriculture Department."

Ferlin did not want to make the people behind him wait, so he hastily presented his identity card together with six silver royals. "I want to buy a medium sack of wheat."

“Sure!” She recorded his name in the daybook and shouted towards the back room. A porter walked out of the warehouse and placed a sack of wheat on the counter. Inspection and selection of goods were prohibited at this stall. Every sack was filled beforehand and classified as large, medium or small according to its weight. A small sack was roughly able to feed two people for a month. The food prices were fixed and fluctuations were very rare. Identity cards had to be presented during purchase, and each customer’s purchase volume was limited. Ferlin understood that the purpose of this measure was to prevent a single person from purchasing a large volume of food, which would cause a shortage of food for other people with actual needs.

“Teacher, when you have time, visit me at my house.” Betty returned his identity card.

“Sure.” Ferlin smiled and replied. He carried the sack and walked off to one side so that the next person could make his purchase. Irene was still nowhere to be seen, and he guessed that it was because she had taken a fancy to other products. He thus thought about finding a prominent and dry spot where he could place the sack and sit down for a rest.

Just then, a faint blue figure flashed across in front of him.

Morning Light flinched and turned his head instinctively, and then felt a full body shiver. It was a beautiful woman with exquisite facial features and a head of blue hair which was rarely seen. She was the type who one would absolutely never forget after the first sight. Ferlin felt the blood throughout his body freeze. This was not because of the person’s outstanding beauty, but because… he had seen her before in the family hall.

When he was young, he asked more than once about the person in the portrait that was hung in the most prominent position on one of the hall’s walls. Yet, his father always kept silent. The person was undoubtedly a woman, but her portrait was ranked higher than the portraits of his other ancestors. It was only once, when drunk, that his father mentioned the person.

If I remember correctly, the person in the portrait is… the founder of the Eltek Family.

How… is this possible?

“Sorry for making you wait.” Irene’s voice snapped him out of his confused thoughts. “I went to choose some eggs, and also bought a small sachet of butter. Have you bought the wheat?”

“Yes…” Ferlin replied with his mind elsewhere.

Back home, he continued to see the woman’s figure linger in front of his eyes. “Why would I see an ancestor of the Eltek Family when I’m in Border Town?”

After deliberating for a long time, he decided that he would make a trip back to Longsong Stronghold.

When he informed Irene about this plan, she frowned. “Haven’t you severed relations with your family? Why do you want to go back?”

“Uh… because,” he said hesitantly, “because of some matters.”

“Succession rights?” Irene tilted her head and said. “That’s not it. Or is it because of… a woman?”

“Ugh,” Ferlin replied. “That’s impossible!”

“But your eyes tell me that you are lying.” She pressed Morning Light against his chair and looked down at him. “You promised me to be my knight, and I believed that you would not break this promise. That’s why I’m now feeling so curious… What could it be that you cannot tell me about? Remember that in the farmhouse on the outskirts of Longsong Stronghold, we promised not to hide anything from each other.”

He looked into her clear and beautiful eyes. At all times, she would want to share everything good or bad with him. Despite experiencing so many hardships together, Irene never changed.

Ferlin took a deep breath and held her in his arms. In a soft voice, he told her about what he saw.

“So that’s what happened.” After listening to his story, Irene nodded. “Go.”

“You… believe me?” Reasonably speaking, even he himself would not believe such an absurd tale that an ancestor was still alive.

“Of course.” She blinked her eyes. “This time, you did not look away.”

Chapter 374

Chapter 374: Returning Home

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

Having separated from the family, it seemed inappropriate for Ferlin to return to the domain of the Elteks. However, he was not doing this to address his own doubts, but instead, for the sake of his father.

During that particular banquet, Sir Eltek not only talked about the person in the portrait, but furthermore, in a very emotional speech, he claimed that the Eltek lineage existed only because of her benevolence, which was betrayed by his ancestors. Ferlin did not understand the meaning of the speech at that time, but his father's expression—which showed remorse for his ancestors' behavior—made it memorable.

Since remorse has been shown, is there a chance to remedy the situation? Perhaps, the woman who I saw is the descendant of my family's founder.

After all, he left his family only because he did not want to separate from Irene. As the eldest son, his family could not accept him marrying a commoner. This was only a difference of choice, and he did not have any other problem with his family.

After his marriage, although his father never visited him once, his mother arranged someone to send some daily supplies together with a letter which said that his father had forgiven him.

It was because of these reasons that Ferlin decided to return home and tell them about what he saw.

Due to the impact of the Months of Demons, the number of ships which travelled between the two lands had significantly reduced. He had to wait three days for a merchant ship that came from the Stronghold, and including

the time required to unload the cargo, he would arrive at Longsong Stronghold only in a week's time.

When he finally arrived and got off the ship, Ferlin immediately felt the emptiness of the city. The ground snow was up to his ankles, yet he saw that apart from a few lanes which left different depths of footprints, most of the snow on the streets was flat and even, implying that no one had passed through for a long time. Compared with the crowded Border Town, it was hard to believe that this was actually the largest city in Western Region.

The Elteks' estate was to the north of the Stronghold, and included a village of nearly two thousand acres. If even the Stronghold was this empty, it was, needless to say, more empty in the village. As his coach travelled along the road towards his family's mansion, he saw bodies of starved people on the way. Every year, if snow started falling early in autumn, most poor people would be caught unprepared without sufficient food and firewood, and approximately half of these people would not be able to hold out till the next spring. Although what he saw was very common during the Months of Demons, Ferlin could never get used to seeing it.

After passing through several more scattered huts, Ferlin finally returned to the doorsteps of his family home for the first time in many years.

The iron gate in the courtyard was firmly locked, and the front yard was covered with snow. However, the slabs of the walkway were cleared of snow, evidently showing that there was someone in the family who took care of the estate.

He knocked on the iron gate forcefully, and after a short while, two guards walked out of the mansion. One of them quickly identified Ferlin and said surprisedly, "You are… Eldest Master."

"I want to see Sir Eltek," Ferlin said placidly.

Although everyone living in the mansion knew that Morning Light had severed ties with the family, this was after all a matter among the noble family, and hence the guards did not dare to make any decision. The two

guards quickly opened the iron gate. One of them led him into the lobby to wait, while the other went to inform the butler.

Ferlin did not expect that the first person to rush over would be his younger brother, Miso Eltek.

“You don’t belong here anymore. Why are you back?” He frowned as he sized up his elder brother. “You walked over here? “Where’s the squire?”

“I’m no longer a knight.” Ferlin laughed. “Naturally, a squire no longer accompanies me.”

“Ah, I almost forgot that you were brutally defeated by the prince of Border Town and became his prisoner. Has he released you or what?” Miso snorted. “Is it because you don’t have money to tide over winter? I can give you a little, but you’ll then have to leave.”

His brother’s attitude made Ferlin sigh. It was understandable that he would behave this way—Miso Eltek was presently the heir apparent in the family, and naturally did not wish to see him return and cause complications.

“I’m not here for money, and have no intention to fight over heirship.” Morning Light said in a low voice. “His Highness appointed me to become a teacher, and I’m very satisfied with my current life.”

“Teacher?” Miso looked astonished. “I don’t remember you possessing so much knowledge that you can teach other members of the nobility.”

“I don’t teach nobles, but rather commoners to read and write.”

“Teach commoners…” Miso sneered. “The lie you’re fabricating is getting more interesting. Did that commoner wife make you lose your mind?”

“Enough!” A low groan was heard from behind, causing Miso to tremble. Ferlin looked towards where the sound came from, only to see his father, Sir Eltek. “Ms. Irene isn’t inferior to the nobility. All that she lacks is status. It’s rude to continue talking about it.”

“Father!” Miso cried.

Sir Eltek did not pay attention to his younger son. “I heard the guard mention that you have information for me.”

“Yes.” Ferlin bowed and said.

“Come into my study.”

…

Ferlin followed his father up to the study on the second floor of the mansion. When he passed through the hall, he took the opportunity to look towards the portrait wall. The blue-haired woman appeared before him once again, looking exactly like she did in the Convenience Market. Compared with the other portraits, her portrait appeared more vivid and elaborately detailed, such that even the mole on the corner of her eye was clearly visible.

When they entered the study, his father was the first to speak. “During a theatre performance in autumn, I had the chance to see your wife. Her complexion was excellent, and her acting skills didn’t pale in comparison to Miss May’s. It seems that the two of you are getting along fine.”

Ferlin suddenly felt his eyes welling up with tears. He did not expect his father to mention this first. After a brief moment of silence, he nodded and said, “Indeed. We have our own house in Border Town and plan to have a child after the Months of Demons.”

“That’s great.” Eltek took a sip from his cup of tea. “It must be difficult to come over from Border Town now. What’s the information?”

Morning Light checked his emotions and said, “I saw a woman while out in the market. She looked exactly like the person in the large portrait in the hall.”

The father’s hands trembled and nearly overturned his cup of tea. He raised his head with his eyes widened. “What did you say?”

“Her blue hair was rarely seen and her beauty was unmistakable. I’m sure that I didn’t see wrongly.” Ferlin replied. “Could she be the descendant of

the person in the portrait?”

“Impossible! That person was…” He paused and shook his head. “It’s impossible for her to have descendants.”

“Is… that right?” Ferlin looked downwards. “Then maybe I’m wrong.”

“You rushed all the way here just because of this matter?”

“Yes, because I remember that you once… expressed your remorse towards her.”

Sir Eltek lowered his head and pondered for a moment. “Did she really look alike?”

“Apart from a slight difference in hair length…” Ferlin recalled. “Everything else was exactly the same.” “You know, since I was born, I have only ever seen this hair color in that portrait, hence I paid extra attention.”

“She couldn’t be a descendant of that person.” Sir Eltek said tentatively. “However, she could be the person in the portrait herself.”

Ferlin almost could not believe what his father was saying. This idea seemed even more inconceivable than his own imagination. “Herself?” You mean… she has lived for more than four hundred years?”

“I didn’t want to tell you about this.” Sir Eltek stood up and said. “She is a witch after all, hence anything is possible. Follow me.”

“To where?”

“The basement. I have a few things to show you.” Sir Eltek said slowly. “Our ancestors’ heritage includes a relic that she left behind.”

Chapter 375

Chapter 375: Last Wish

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

Ferlin was not unfamiliar with the basement in the Eltek mansion.

When he was young, this place used to be his personal playground. He took immense pleasure in finding all kinds of strange artifacts in the dusty boxes. Of course, for this reason, he was often beaten by his father and was eventually forbidden from entering the basement alone, but he somehow always found a way to sneak in.

This time, Sir Eltek led him into the furthest stone room. The four walls of the room were embedded with pale blue crystals which were the size of a fist. Ferlin inhaled a cold breath involuntarily. To his surprise, every block of stone was a high-quality God's Stone of Retaliation. As a young boy, he was unaware of this, but now, he naturally understood the implications. High-quality magic stones were worth a lot of money, and those as big as these were worth at least five or six hundred gold royals each.

Is the Eltek Family actually so wealthy?

He suddenly recalled that the treasure map was also found in the Elteks' house.

A circle of boxes was placed in the stone room, and the arrangement was similar to the impression in his memory. Sir Eltek took out a bunch of keys from his pocket and opened the largest box in the circle. Following a loud creaking sound, a cloud of dust kicked up at once.

Ferlin held his breath and looked inside the box. The interior was divided into numerous layers, similar to the dressing boxes used by young noble ladies, and on every layer was placed gemstones of different colors.

“Which ancestor had passed this down?”

“I’ve not been here for a very long time.” Sir Eltek sighed. “Every time I see these Magic Stones, I would remember the past events which my ancestors told me about.”

“Magic Stones?” Ferlin asked in surprise.

“Yes, they are treasures which only witches are able to use.” He nodded. “This is a long story. Our family was established under the blessings of a witch.”

Ferlin’s father started to recount about the family and its history. Some of the details of his story were different to what Ferlin had heard as a child. The first Eltek ancestor was in fact not from Western Region, but instead, from the remote and unexplored Barbarian Land, which was located past the Impassable Mountain Range.

Ferlin’s eyes gradually widened. He did not imagine that the portrait could have concealed such an amazing secret.

“Our family’s founder, Ancestor Elsa, had once established a huge kingdom together with many other witches. The witches were part of the dominant class, akin to today’s nobility, in the kingdom. It was an offensive by the demons from Hell which brought about the demise of the kingdom. In the final battle, the survivors fled in different directions. Elsa led a group of people towards the stone tower in the Misty Forest to collect experimental materials, while another group of people followed the troops to Graycastle —at that time, the land on which the Kingdom was eventually built was barren and desolate.”

“Were our ancestors part of the other group?” Ferlin asked hoarsely.

“Indeed. He used to be the housekeeper of Elsa. Accordingly, he was supposed to follow her into the forest, but he cowered and suggested that he would stay behind to look after the materials. His request was accepted by his master.” Sir Eltek spoke in a deep voice. “You should know what this means.”

Ferlin nodded. The housekeeper was typically the person the master trusted the most in the household apart from her kin. At most times, the housekeeper ought to have accompanied the master wherever she went, unless she commanded otherwise. In a sense, proposing to leave was equivalent to betraying the master even if she did not refuse.

"When he arrived at Western Region, he began to feel remorse for what he did, and recorded his sentiments in a book." Sir Eltek took out a black-coated book from another box and handed it to his son. "His master never returned, and after that, he broke off from the Union and left the refugee camp. He took many servants with him and settled down on this piece of land, which was yet to be cultivated."

Ferlin grasped the black-coated book without opening it. Instead, he thought of something frightening. "So, does that mean that you knew from the beginning that everything the church did was wrong?"

If the witches had fought against the demons before, why are they now branded as the Devil's minions? There's definitely much more to this than meets the eye.

"I knew, but I couldn't do anything." Sir Eltek said calmly. "If a witch was found in our territory, I would definitely help to hide her. But in the Stronghold, I wasn't able to do so, because of Duke Ryan's disagreement—he hated witches more than the church did. From the records of some of our later ancestors, it's evident that they did the same thing as me… except that they never informed the survivors about what happened in the witches' kingdom."

"Are these survivors still in the household?"

"Of course not, they're all in their graves already." He spread his hands. "It was very rare to live until 60 or 70 years of age, and being humans after all, they aged and passed away."

"But you believe that our first ancestor could still be living."

“This is only a possibility—witches have many different abilities but are unable to breed children, hence I made this supposition.”

Ferlin pondered for a brief moment and then changed the subject. “Did our ancestors never think of entering the Misty Forest to find Ancestor Elsa?”

“Easier said than done.” His father shook his head. “If even witches were unable to return safely, ordinary mortals entering the forest would simply be courting death. Furthermore, four hundred years ago, the Western Region was a wasteland with beasts and jungles everywhere. It was extremely difficult to settle down upon, and hence there wasn’t time to take care of other issues. However, our ancestors did indeed write in their wills that they hoped that someday a descendant would enter the stone tower of the Misty Forest, even if it was just to take a look.”

Morning Light inhaled a deep breath and flipped open the dust-laden book. From the very first page, he already felt a sense of regret written between the lines. Much of the writing had faded over time, but perhaps because of this reason, the heavy feelings of his ancestors became even more pronounced. After reading for a long time, he finally flipped to the last page of the book where the wills, which seemed more like unfulfilled wishes, were written.

This was, in all likelihood, the page which made his father become emotional on that night when he was drunk.

As a former knight himself, he could empathize with this.

“Do you need me to find her?” Ferlin asked after a brief silence. “If she’s indeed Elsa, then she must be staying at the prince’s castle, and as far as I know, many witches are also gathered there.”

“Witches are gathered in the castle?” The knight responded while deep in thought. “Little wonder that Longsong Stronghold made an announcement to recruit witches a few days ago. It seems that His Highness is intent on becoming an enemy of the church.” Then, he shook his head. “No, you don’t have to find her.”

Ferlin felt surprised. “Don’t you want to see her?”

“It’s wrong for an ancestor to visit a descendant.” Sir Eltek laughed. “Of course, we should be the ones to visit her.”

“W…we?”

“Indeed. I’m following you to Border Town.” His father stroked his chin and smiled. “Bring all of these things. If she’s really Elsa, our ancestors’ last wish may finally be fulfilled.”

Chapter 376

Chapter 376: The Castle's new facilities

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

"What are they?" Andrea asked while chewing on the dried fish.

The prince of the Kingdom of Graycastle was tossing about something new again. He spliced sections of brass together, having Anna melt the joint and Soraya wrap a soft layer of magic coating around it. At first sight, they looked like the water pipes installed in the bathroom, but they were much larger in size and each of them was about the size of a human thigh. It was impossible for a man to move it without the help of Hummingbird, who reduced the weight.

Yet, the brass was not installed only in one or two rooms but horizontally throughout the whole castle and the Witches' House. It entered from the corner of the room, connecting with a strange metal louver along the bottom of the wall, crossed the next room and joined with the longitudinal pipe at the very end.

This large project attracted a lot of witches to surround and watch it, in which the witches from both the Sleeping Island and the Witch Union showed great interest.

"Any guesses?" Roland smiled mysteriously and said, "If you get it right, an extra ice cream bread for dinner."

Ice cream bread! This caught Andrea's attention. It was the most amazing food here, a layer of sweet ice cream stuffed in two slices of toasted bread. It had never been heard of before in the Kingdom of Dawn. She instantly fell in love with the delicacy the moment she tried it. Despite being teased by Ashes repeatedly, she would still eat it. Otherwise, watching it being left on the plate would still be nothing short of torture to her.

“Does this supply water to rooms?” Ashes frowned.

“Of course not.” Andrea pouted to herself. Copper was not cheap. Since the small pipes in the bathroom could distribute water, why use such a huge one?

However, considering she was always teased by Ashes’ jeers of “who was the one who said the food from the past was the most delicious”, which she had indeed once said in front of Tilly and could not deny, Andrea could only pretend that she did not hear such superficial words.

“What a shallow opinion. Who needs such a big pipe for water supply?” someone said behind Andrea, “His Highness would never do such a pointless thing.”

Incisive! That was exactly what Andrea was thinking. Her spirit was lifted right away. No one else would dare to use such a tone to talk to an Extraordinary other than herself and Miss Nightingale from the Witch Union. She turned around and saw a woman looking at Ashes in disdain, with her chin being lifted to just the right angle.

This is the expression the nobility should use!

Andrea secretly praised this mysterious woman who was the most cordial witch she had met since she came to Border Town. Nightingale showed her extraordinary skills during the rescue of the witch in the relic. She was also from a noble background, and even her hair color was similar to Andrea’s. In the battles against the demonic hybrids on the city wall, Nightingale had recognized her ability and shared dried fish with her. She was just acting like a noble.

Most importantly, she didn’t like Ashes at all.

Andrea didn’t know how Ashes offended Nightingale when she first came to Border Town, but wasn’t it true that the enemies my enemy was my friend? Not to mention that her character was very compatible with Andrea herself.

“You’re talking as if you know the answer,” Ashes shrugged and said.

“Of course, I know,” Nightingale grinned and said, “I’ve been in the office when His Highness was drafting the design drawings. All of his plans were drafted in front of my very eyes.”

“It’s not fair!” Mystery Moon muttered.

“She doesn’t take part in the examinations though,” said the prince. The prince’s words made Nightingale’s proud expression stupefied right away. “A hint for you all, these pipes are only parts of the system and you may want to look elsewhere in order to better figure out the answer.”

“Goo!” Maggie flew out of the room with Lightning immediately, the other witches were not far behind. Everyone had scattered away, trying to have a look at the pipe. Andrea fell behind everyone else on purpose. When everyone left, she winked at Nightingale and called her out to the door.

“What’s that?” Andrea whispered, “I’ll share half of the dinner bread with you if I got it right.”

“I don’t know either.” Nightingale’s reply shocked her.

“But you just said that you had gone through all the designs, didn’t you?”

“Yeah, just like Natural Science Theoretical Foundation, even if you understand the individual words on it, can you understand them when they’re put together? ”

“Uh…” Andrea opened her mouth but she found that she was quite right. She had tried the book herself and found that it was just like hieroglyphics.

“I’m afraid only Anna has the ability to understand His Highness’ intention by simply looking at his drawings,” Nightingale said, “If you ask her, she’ll definitely tell you the answer.”

After Nightingale left, Andrea hesitated for a while and finally didn’t call for Anna to come out from the room. It was not being reserved or embarrassed, but rather… out of respect. She was not afraid of the heinous criminals nor the cruel Verdict Army, but she was in awe of such a girl less than twenty.

She remembered when she passed by the prince's office once and overheard the conversation of Anna and His Highness. Their conversation still brought her goosebumps now. Those strange terms like the high angle calculation, orbit-trimming with drop-point parameters and the conversion from kinetic energy to potential energy in an ideal state, all made her rooted to the spot immediately. The were both witches, but why Anna could fluently speak such terms that Andrea didn't understand at all? From that moment onwards, Andrea had an extended admiration towards Anna. She thought that Anna was a totally different type of person from herself but at the same level with Lady Tilly instead.

Since she could not ask for the answer, she could only rely on herself. Andrea went around to explore each of the rooms according to His Highness' advice. She found that there was a rectangular metal railing separating the pipes in the room that had completed the installation as if it was to prevent anyone from touching the pipes. Upon seeing this, she thought, if it wasn't for the presence of barbarians like Ashes, even if someone touched them it probably wouldn't be a big deal. Thinking of what Nightingale said—"His Highness will never do such a pointless thing", Andrea thought that these metal railings should have their own functions.

She had a new discovery when she came to the first floor of the Witch House. There was a newly built bungalow between the castle and the Witch House and that was where the copper pipes leading to the two buildings extended.

There was a huge iron box in the house, it was hollow at the bottom half of the box and there was a huge chimney on the top… It looked almost like a cooking stove. And she saw a pipe connected directly to the well in the yard, which looked rather similar to the water supply system in the water tower.

Wait… Was it supposed to be used for boiling water?

If the pipes were used for hot water distribution, there was no need to be such humongous at all.

Andrea still couldn't understand what it was for after a long contemplation.

His Highness gathered all the witches in the hall before dinner. He smiled and said, “The heating system in the castle is officially launched from today.”

“Heating system?” Ashes puzzled.

“Yes. Water will be boiled in the boiler, and the high-temperature steam will enter the rooms through the pipes and increase the temperature there, as long as the doors and windows are closed, the whole room can be warmed up pretty quickly,” Prince explained, “comparing to fire barrels that are too heavy to move and require a good air flow to prevent anthracemia. The new heating system doesn’t have such concerns at all. It’ll make you feel as warm as in spring while sleeping.” When the debug ends, the residential area will be gradually equipped with such heating system.”

“Next, the ice cream bread winners are, in addition to Anna, Soraya and Hummingbird who were participating in the installation of the heating system, there was only one person who guessed it right. And, it was… Tilly!”

Andrea helplessly stared at Lady Tilly who was smiling while eating the delicious dinner, completely losing her reserved manner of a noble.

Chapter 377

Chapter 377: Under Low Temperatures

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

The boiler heating system was not too complicated and essentially just involved boiling the water and distributing the heat through pipes and radiators into the rooms. The heat could be carried by water or steam, and Roland preferred the latter because it had a higher temperature and was more convenient. As long as the boiler kept on running, the steam pressure would fill the pipes with hot water droplets without the help of a pump.

Of course, there were also shortcomings to a steam heating system. The pipes were always under very high pressure, so weak infrastructure could cause leakages or even explosions. The steam would reach temperatures of 200 to 300 degrees Celsius, making it extremely damaging to human flesh and thus raising the safety standards for the steam heating system. Anna's Blackfire welding technique, combined with Soraya's coating, guaranteed system integrity and reduced these risks to a minimum.

Roland also installed an automatic valve on the boiler, which had the same mechanical principles as the centrifugal governor on a steam engine . When the furnace pressure was too high, the high-speed rotation of the flywheel would pull the valve upwards, releasing steam and lowering pressure.

The last safety measure was located between the boiler and the two main heating pipes. Roland asked Anna to carve several grooves around the connecting copper pipe in order to decrease its strength, just like in the design of tin cans. Even if the pressure valve failed to turn on, the explosion would still be contained in the boiler and would not harm anyone in the room.

The castle was completely transformed after the heating system was up and running.

The witches' thick winter clothes were replaced with unlined fall garments. Watching the girls talking and laughing in their colorful attire greatly increased Roland's motivation to work.

Of course, these facilities could only act as a supplement to their lifestyle and help create a better working environment.

His next task was much more important and decided the future of the Western Region.

He had to find a way to produce synthetic ammonia and reduce dependence on nitrate, which would allow chemical explosive production to reach new heights and satisfy the amount required to use automatic firing weapons.

If he could achieve this by the end of the winter, it would undoubtedly serve him well in his planned offensive in the spring.

Roland summoned Kyle Sichi and Agatha to his office.

"How have you two been working together during these past few days?" he asked with a smile on his face. Kyle Sichi was the Chief Alchemist of Border Town, but besides his love for alchemy, he hardly cared about people's feelings or opinions. On the other hand, Agatha came from the Witch Kingdom from four centuries ago and was a proud member of the Quest Society, the kingdom's most prestigious research institution. Both of them were straight talkers and had highly reactionary personalities. Roland was often worried that they might fight, but he needed them to work together to produce nitro-explosives and ammonia. Thus, he had to personally check in with them, because if they argued, only he would be able to work things out.

"Very well." Kyle's words shocked Roland. "Miss Agatha's abilities are of great help to my experiments. I've found the stable synthesis temperature of nitration glycerol, and there have been no problems with laboratory preparation, so we're currently testing the possibility of industrial production. None of this would be possible without the ice cups… Oh, forgive me, I was so busy that I forgot to inform you of this. " He paused and said, "By the way, if you called me here to ask about this, can I return to my laboratory now? I still have many things to do."

“Um… is that so?” Roland looked towards Agatha, and she nodded.

“Sir Kyle has an extraordinary amount of knowledge, especially in regards to the elements, which is somewhat similar to that of the Quest Society. We’re cooperating very nicely, and if he was in Taquila, he would definitely have been accepted by the Union.”

“Was it actually easier for two straight talkers to get along? It seems I was worried for nothing. But why does the chief alchemist more respectful towards the witch than towards me? How sad…” Roland thought to himself and cleared his throat. “Then I’m relieved. I gathered you here to assign you some new research. ”

“Please.” Kyle perked up as soon as he heard the word “research”.

“As I said before, there are many different gases in the air, and it’s time we start using them. According to ‘Elementary Chemistry’, oxygen and nitrogen make up 99% of the air, and I need to separate these two gases for chemical production,” Roland explained.

Kyle contemplated for a moment. “Do you mean we should separate them by using their different characteristics, such as their different boiling points and melting points?”

“That’s right.” Roland nodded. “Condense and then reheat the gases. As the boiling point of nitrogen is lower than oxygen, it can be distilled from the liquid first. Since the temperature needed is far below the freezing point for water, the experiment is difficult to conduct with conventional methods, so Agatha’s abilities are crucial.”

“Turning air into liquid,” Kyle said, stroking his beard. “It sounds very interesting.”

“If the temperature was brought low enough, they could freeze into solids,” Roland smiled and said. The alchemist probably never dreamed that the seemingly elusive gas could be held in a person’s hands – as long as adequate anti-frostbite measures were taken.

Agatha asked confusedly, “I flipped through the same book a little, but I didn’t see anything about air being frozen into a variety of gases.”

“It’s difficult to distinguish them with the naked eye because they are mixed together and show no distinct layers,” Rolland explained. “The first step is to eliminate carbon dioxide, which has the highest freezing point, but it makes up a very small percentage of air, so you wouldn’t even notice its solid form. Next, oxygen and nitrogen would fuse together to give off a light blue hue. If you don’t separate it, it would look like a pure substance, but liquid nitrogen is actually colorless.”

“What should we do?”

“First, prepare the distillation vessel.” The prince grinned. “This is a very important project.”

There was no doubt that depending on Agatha alone would not be enough. Glass could easily break under repeated temperature changes, so the vessels for the liquid air could only be made of steel. This was not difficult for Anna, but the closed shell would make it impossible to see the liquefied air changing during the heating process. Therefore, Sylvie’s Eye of Magic was necessary to observe the situation inside of the vessel. Then, Agatha would record the magic consumption at the boiling point of nitrogen, as well as the stable production temperatures.

Preparation alone took three days.

When the vessel was completed, Roland went to the chemistry laboratory to personally oversee the town’s first oxygen-nitrogen separation experiment.

Chapter 378

Chapter 378: Oxygen and Nitrogen

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

Agatha, Sylvie, Chavez and Kyle Sichi would conduct the experiment. Carter, Iron Axe, Barov and all the other witches of the Witch Union were also required by Roland to come to the lab, as it was an experiment of great practical and educational significance. The fifth laboratory was chosen for this event, given that it was the largest lab and had enough space for the two dozen people.

Considering the experiment was the first of its kind, Roland had built a tower-shaped vessel which was only as tall as a man with a diameter of one meter instead of a giant fractionation vessel. The inside of the vessel was divided into three parts. The air would enter the vessel through the bottom part and come out through the two parts above.

Before separating the air, Roland gave them a simple lecture on chemistry, telling them what was going to happen and putting forward a few questions for them to think about and try to answer. It was a trick frequently used by chemistry teachers to intrigue their students and enhance the effects of the lesson.

"… theoretically, when Agatha cools down the vessel and brings down its internal temperature, the air inside will gradually be condensed into liquid, and drip down into the bottom of the vessel through the holes in the plate. So when you see liquid at the bottom, please let us know."

Roland explained to Sylvie in detail, because no one except her could directly see into the vessel and describe the changes happening inside.

Sylvie nodded somewhat skeptically, "Will I really see liquid appear? Will it not be only the water vapor inside the vessel?"

“No, it’s different. The liquefied air is light blue, completely different from water vapor.” Roland shook his head and explained further, “Plus, at that temperature, the water vapor will be solidified into ice crystals long before the air.” Then he made a gesture toward Agatha and said, “Let’s get started.”

“Wait… Do we not have to plug up the hole in the vessel’s bottom now?” she asked.

“Block it up later. Otherwise, the vessel won’t have enough air inside to bring about significant changes.” As this was only an experiment, he chose the easiest way for air intake—when the air temperature inside the vessel was rapidly lowered, the internal pressure would fall, and thereby draw the air into the vessel. In mass production, cooling down the air cost too much energy and the cool air would run off continuously. Therefore, this cooling method was considered inefficient and rarely applied in practice. However, Agatha’s magic power could bring down the vessel’s temperature more efficiently than any refrigerators, saving Roland the trouble to prepare an air pump.

Agatha took a deep breath and pressed her hands onto the fractionation vessel.

About half a minute later, whistling sounds could be clearly heard as the air was rapidly passing through the air intake pipe. White frost could be seen by the naked eye around the pipe hole, and its area gradually expanded—the water in the air nearby was quickly solidified, and then adhered to the vessel. Anna turned her Blackfire into threads to clean up these continuously thickening ice crystals.

“I see some liquid appearing on the plate, but there’s more white frost inside.” Sylvie said in an amazement a moment later.

“The white frost may be the solidified water vapor or the crystallized carbon dioxide,” explained Roland. “Considering that there’s only a small portion of carbon dioxide in the air, most of it should be solidified water vapor.”

In normal production, air must be dried out first before being sucked into the fractionating vessel. Otherwise, the solidified water vapor would block the

parting plates and the holes, and thus decrease the production efficiency.

Several minutes later, Sylvie reported to Roland that the bottom part of the vessel had been filled with light blue liquid. Roland immediately instructed Soraya to block the holes in the air intake pipe and seal them with coatings.

The next thing to do was heat the vessel, a crucial step in this experiment.

When the liquefied air was heated, the nitrogen would first reach its boiling point, vaporize and run off due to the different boiling points of nitrogen and oxygen. In this way the two could be separated. Due to the fact that Roland forgot the exact temperature at which nitrogen reached its boiling point, and that he had no way to measure it either, it all depended on Agatha to control the temperature. If she managed to heat the fractionation vessel to the right temperature, the nitrogen gas would come out via the exhaust pipe and the liquid in the bottom part would grow bluer and bluer, with an increasing purity of oxygen.

Fortunately, Agatha was familiar with magic power control. She accurately adjusted the cooling range, increasing the temperature slowly. After a while, Sylvie observed that the liquid was boiling. She saw bubbles around the coating pipe which was plunged into the water. At the same time, Keymor quickly collected several bottles of gas, using the drainage gas-gathering method.

“This is nitrogen?” Lily twitched her lips and said, “I can’t see anything at all.”

“That’s exactly the first question I put forward earlier,” Roland said, “How do we prove it’s different from the air?”

“Test it with a piece of burning wood,” Tilly answered first, “it’ll extinguish the fire instantly if it’s nitrogen. According to Elementary Chemistry, everything requires oxygen to burn.”

“Cool it down again and condense it back into liquid,” Agatha said after thinking for a while, “Didn’t you say that liquefied nitrogen is colorless?”

“How about pouring out the remaining liquid in the vessel and proving it’s pure oxygen? By doing so we can verify the diversity of air composition.” Anna suggested.

In the lab, only a few quick learners eagerly proposed different methods and began a heated discussion, while the others remained silent. Roland looked around and found Nightingale, Andrea, Maggie, the City Hall Director and the Chief Knight Carter all seeming confused and at a loss. Iron Axe, the commander of the First Army, on the other hand, always maintained the same facial expression. Roland believed that Iron Axe would probably give him a nod no matter what he said.

Roland sighed silently. “It looks like this chemistry lecture is a little above their level.”

Perhaps the only ones who could really share His Highness’s happiness at this moment would be Kyle Sichi and Chavez.

“Your Highness, it’s really… amazing,” the young alchemist exclaimed, “and you’ve proven what’s written in the Elementary Chemistry is true. I’m afraid it has never occurred to alchemists that even the air around us is so complicated.”

“With pure oxygen, it’s possible to observe more intense oxidation reactions, right? I have a lot more experiments to try out now.” Kyle said in excitement.

Roland nodded and an idea suddenly jumped into his head.

Nitrogen was the most important raw material for synthetic ammonia. It can react with hydrogen at a high temperature and under high pressure to form ammonia that can be used to manufacture nitrogenous fertilizer and synthesize nitrogen oxides, which can be further used to produce nitric acid. However, in order to carry out this plan, much work needed to be done and many pieces of equipment needed to be built, such as air pumps and vacuum gasholders. Even if Paper has the magic power to work as a catalyst, it would require repeated testing.

Now, with pure oxygen and pure nitrogen, why not try to produce nitrogen monoxide?

The reaction of oxygen and nitrogen in nature wasn't an automatic one because it was an exothermic reaction that required external energy, such as an electric discharge in which an electric arc can instantly heat the air up to a temperature of thousands of degrees. That's why places where thunder and lightning frequently occurred had more fertile lands, and why ammonia was often used instead to produce nitric acid in the chemical industry. The electrical method of production was not a common practice as it costed too much energy and required extremely high-quality equipment.

Yet it was the most efficient method in case of an emergency, as it didn't even require any catalyst, simply constant electric discharge… in fact, any other means that produce the extremely high temperatures that electric arcs can achieve will do.

Roland naturally thought of Blackfire.

He was sure that it was easy for Anna to manipulate her Blackfire, which worked as an efficient and powerful electric discharge. Now all they needed to do to produce nitrogen monoxide was mix purified oxygen and purified nitrogen in the proper proportions and pour the mixture into an airtight reactor.

He decided to give it a try.

Chapter 379

Chapter 379: Attack

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

“Move faster!”

“Keep your hands steady. Insert the bullets into the cartridge one at a time!”

“Your teammates at the front need you to act quickly. Otherwise, you’ll give the enemy the chance to approach and kill you!”

“Don’t look at other places. Stay focused on the job in your hands!”

“As long as your teammates are still shooting, you just keep on reloading!”

In the First Army’s military camp, Lord Brian was loudly urging the new recruits to practice, and Nail was one of them.

He was not newly recruited, but instead a veteran in the First Army. After the Militia defeated the demonic beasts under the leadership of His Highness, he joined the army at Iron Head’s strong recommendation. In Iron Head’s words, it was much more promising to carry a flintlock to fight and protect His Highness and Miss Nana than to spend the rest of his life mining in the pit.

Not long after Nail joined the Militia, they were reorganized into the First Army. Guided by Prince Roland and Lord Iron Axe, the army in which he served defeated not only demonic beasts but also great nobles whom he used to regard as unbeatable. They overthrew Duke Ryan and even prevented the troops of Timothy, the new king, from setting foot in Border Town. After those battles, Nail was promoted to a team leader in the Flintlock Squad.

However, according to the First Army’s tradition, whenever a large number of new recruits came, some veterans would be chosen to join the newly formed platoon. They would live and eat together with the new recruits and

accompany them in practices, as their instructors. When knowing he was chosen for this instructor job, Nail was at first not willing to take it. He was just reluctant to leave the front line and his familiar battle companions, but thinking of the veterans who had helped him when he was a new recruit in the Militia, he had no choice but to accept this task.

At that time, the instructor in his squad had been Lord Brian, who now was the commander of the First Battalion in the Flintlock Squad.

Nail hoped that one day, he would be someone like Lord Brian, wearing a medal bestowed by His Highness and giving commands to nearly a thousand soldiers. Iron Head was right. “This job is far more promising than operating a steam engine in front of a mining pit.”

“My lord, how long do we have to continue with this practice?” A young man in his platoon grumbled. “It’s still snowing.”

“Keep practicing until you can finish the reloading in about half a minute with your eyes closed,” Nail stopped in front of him and said. “You’re Haimon, right? Remember to say ‘Report’ before you speak. That’s a rule in the First Army! ”

“Report,” shouted a little man next to Haimon, with his hands filling the loader all the time, “do we have eggs for dinner tonight?”

Hearing this question, many soldiers in the platoon started to lick their lips.

Nail could not help but grin. He understood aside from the two weeks’ strict military training, sufficient food supply was also an important factor to keep these new soldiers from the Northern and the Southern Territory well disciplined even on such a snowy day. They had oatmeal and salty dried meat for every meal, and sometimes a piece of pickled fish or even an egg. Yet eggs were only provided after a battle against demonic beasts or a field training.

“Well, you’d better ask demonic beasts whether or not they’re coming to Border Town today.” Nail shrugged. “What’s your name?”

“Al Bitter, my lord,” answered the little man.

“It takes you almost half a day to insert one bullet. My next-door neighbor, an old lady, is far more nimble than you,” Nail suddenly stopped smiling and said seriously. “If you can’t improve when today’s training is over, I’ll cancel your share of oatmeal and meat, let alone the eggs!”

The new soldiers immediately lowered their heads and focused. No one wanted to be punished like that.

Just at the moment, the bell on the city wall tolled rapidly.

Demonic beasts were coming.

“Stop practicing!” Brian shouted, “Instructors lead your men into the city wall area. Get ready to fight!”

“Have you heard it?” Nail urged. “Carry your ammunition, everyone. Line up and go up to the top of the city wall, as what you did in the training. Our position is the fourth section of the city wall. Move quickly!”

“The new soldiers now do get a chance to have eggs for dinner tonight.” Nail thought in secret.

…

After arriving at their position, Nail saw the Flintlock Squad was ready. Seeing the dark shadows gradually approaching, he calmly did the last fire check and instructed his men to mount the guns upon the wall piers.

Nail somehow felt a little disappointed. He himself could have given those beasts a hard strike with his revolving rifle.

The bullets were filled into the loaders one by one and then put at handy places that the soldiers at the front could easily reach. There were one to two people responsible for loading behind each veteran. If necessary, the veterans could fire five bullets in a shot. The new weapons were much more powerful than previously-used flintlocks.

“Look! Here comes the witches!” Haimon whispered.

“They’re so… pretty.” Al Bitter murmured. “Before I came here, I only heard about them via the church and thought they were ugly and dreadful.”

“That’s the only thing you’ve noticed?” Haimon grunted. “Don’t you remember the witch carrying a big sword? The girl could chop and kill demonic hybrids. Oh! If only I had powers like that.”

“If it’s truly the power of demons…”

“Shut up!” Nailed shouted loudly. “Miss Nana is also a witch. You think she’s a demon?” Then he lowered his voice and said, “Miss Nana is our town’s angel. The power she has is the power of gods, understood? If you dare say anything like that in front of any veteran in the First Army, I promise you’ll be beaten up really badly. Now focus on the reloading. It’s not practice!”

After shouting at the two gabby guys, he cast a glance at the coming demonic beasts, “They look almost the same as the ones that have come before. It appears to be a short battle… Wait, what’s that?”

There seemed to be a giant figure among the dark shadows, something like a tortoiseshell Siege Beast, but it seemed much bigger and faster.

When it came closer, Nail could not help but stare at it. It was a super giant demonic beast that he had never ever seen! Its huge tusks were almost thicker than a human’s body, like sickles sticking straight up. Its four legs looked like pillars of rock, kicking up layers of snow mists. At each step of its running, the earth beneath its feet trembled. The city walls of more than four meters in height was even lower than its jaw. If the beast ran into the wall, this mud wall would probably crack into pieces.

The artillerymen!

There was no doubt that flintclocks had very limited influence on such a giant monster, but only the big equipment of the artillerymen was able to stop it!

The new culverins mounted upon the sixth section of the city walls were the most powerful artillery equipment they had.

At that moment, the new recruits started to scream in fright, “Good God. Look! What’s that?”

“Gods have mercy on us. Is it a demon from the Hell?”

“Close your mouth and focus on what you should do!” Nail swallowed the lump in the throat and looked at the new cannons at the sixth section of the city wall. The barrel, which reflected the silver light, slowly turned around and projected in the direction of the giant monster.

Then bright flames were shot into the air, and the cannons thundered and boomed!

Chapter 380

Chapter 380: Flesh and Blood

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

Nail felt his heart suddenly in his throat.

At that moment, time seemed to slow down. He stared at the giant demonic beast without a blink, while at the same time prayed in secret that the new cannons could hit the target. However, the demonic beast was still safe and sound, rushing forward by the time he started to breathe again.

About half a minute later, a snow column was kicked up far away from the monster.

This is gonna be bad.

Nail's heart suddenly sank. As the monster was not coming toward the sixth section of the city wall, it left an included angle between the cannons. The artillery unit had to constantly adjust the angle of the culverin, while at the same time also estimate how fast the beast was moving and fire in advance. Otherwise, the shell would land somewhere behind the target just like what was happening now.

Based on the firing rate of the field artillery, they only had one last chance before the monster broke into the city wall!

Nail had already been able to see the thick fur that covered the enemy's body, as well as its huge crimson mouth beneath the tusks. Witches were coming in this direction, apparently planning to stop this monster. Yet the four of them altogether was not even as big as the beast's one leg. Were they able to succeed with pure magic?

He was so anxious and worried that he even wanted to run to the sixth section of the city wall and remind the cannon team to aim forward.

However, since there were supervisors standing on both sides at each section of the city wall, he eventually suppressed this impulse—he would be very likely accused of being a coward if he left his post now without permission. Lord Iron Axe had stated repeatedly that behaviors that would break down the line of defense were absolutely forbidden. Once such a person was discovered, the supervising team could directly shoot him down.

The demonic beast running at the very front had already entered the shooting range of the revolving rifles. There was a series of cracking shooting sounds upon the city wall.

Nail had no choice but to continue with his mission, putting the already prepared loaders one by one next to the shooters.

Just at that moment, there was a second ground-shaking roar, which was less than half a minute after the first firing of the culverin.

“That… fast!?” Nail looked at the sixth section of the city wall in great surprise. The smoke above the muzzle had not completely disappeared and some smoke was continuously running out of it, making the cannon look like a litten silver pipe. Nevertheless, what was shocking was yet to come. He had not even had time to notice whether the enemy was shot or not when the dazzling blazes appeared again.

The third firing!

Good Lord. Don’t they need to load the shells?

Nail only saw four or five people busy working at the rear of the barrel, but none approaching the muzzle. It appeared that entirely different from the short thick field artillery, this new cannon could fire in succession like a revolving rifle!

This time the firing was effective.

Nail did not see the shell entering the monster’s body. What he first noticed was a mass of blood mist bursting out from one side of the giant demonic beast. Aside from the black blood that spilled over, there were also furry

skins torn apart, as well as large pieces of flesh. The demonic beast suddenly quivered. Its entire body seemed to be flattened a little bit, and there were streaks of crinkles showing up on its thick furry skins like the ripples on the water surface—but he was not sure whether it was an illusion, because in the next minute, the sunken body restored to normal again, except for the eye balls of the monster, which had been pushed forward when the body was flattened. Meanwhile the eye balls ejected something thick and sluggish in black and white.

With a dull crashing sound, the giant beast fell all its length onto the ground, lying on its side even without an agonal growl. It was until then that Nail found where the shell hit—there was a big hole close to the beast's neck. It was so insignificant compared with its robust body that it was hard to relate the hole with the fatal shot that occurred just now. Strands of smoke was coming out of the hole, and the furry skins around it were blackened.

The monster from the Hell just died like this?

Nail could no longer restrain the excitement in his heart, but vent out all his earlier anxiety with a roar.

"Long live His Highness!"

Even such a terrifying and fierce enemy could not possibly resist the powerful weapon invented by His Highness! Apart from that new cannon, he could not even think of any other ways to kill this huge hybrid demonic beast—even if a witch could manage to do so, it would not be such a clean shot. Thinking further, he could say that His Highness, in a way, had granted them a supreme power comparable to witches'!

His shout, like an introduction, was responded by more people and it soon created an uproar among others. At first only the new recruits responded with loud shouts, but later even the veterans could not help clenching their fists.

There were loud cheers bursting out from the top of the city walls.

"Long live His Highness!"

****

Roland was only informed that the beast was killed by the new cannon after the battle was over.

He put on a woolen coat and hurried to the West Wall. The demonic beast's gigantic body was still lying quietly in the snow, with its black blood melting the snow around it into a pool of black water.

It seemed that no matter how horrible these monsters might look like, they were after all carbon based organism. When faced with ammunition and steels, they were as weak as a piece of thin paper.

This solid pointed shell rolled over due to the loss of its stability after being projected into the beast's body, and thus transmitted its kinetic energy throughout the entire torso, and finally went through the body while swirling —as it could be seen from the scene, the other side of the beast's body was completely torn, with the internal organs and broken bones scattered around. Even its head, which was the hardest part of all, was shattered by the vibrating energy and collapsed in total.

However, he still felt a little concerned. "The bone strength of creatures has a limit. This beast is apparently several times bigger than an elephant. How does it support its body without being crushed by its own weight? This is the exactly why terricolous animals have much smaller body builds than marine lives, as they can't overcome the pull of the gravity."

Would it have anything to do with the magic power? He remembered Nightingale once said she could see there were magic powers flowing inside some of the hybrid demonic beasts' bodies.

"How… could this be possible?" Agatha who arrived later had her eyes wide open, "Isn't this the Fearful Beast of Hell?"

"What's that? Is that the name of the hybrid demonic beast?" Roland asked curiously, "It has also shown up at the Fertile Plains before?"

“Yes, and when they showed up in group, they were difficult enemies to both witches and demons. Many cities and towns were devastated by the Fearful Beasts of Hell,” Agatha’s voice sounded a little dry, “However, they could only be seen when the arrival of the Bloody Moon was drawing near.”

“The arrival of… the Bloody Moon?” Roland suddenly remembered what was written in the ancient book, “When there was a Bloody Moon in the sky, the Gates of Hell would open once again.” He frowned and asked, “What does that mean?”

“This was a record passing down since the first Battle of Divine Will when the magic power was the strongest. The appearance of witches would bring another peak in magic power, but likewise, demons and demonic beasts would also be extremely powerful.” Agatha said nervously, “I’ve perused the history book you gave me. Based on the years, I deduce that there’re still at least 20 to 50 years before the arrival of the Bloody Moon. It’s impossible to see such monsters.”

“But it has still appeared,” said Roland in a deep voice, “What does it mean?”

“It means that we don’t have much time left.”

Chapter 381

Chapter 381: Evelyn's Resolution

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

Roland was frightened by the sentence "we don't have much time left", but he was a bit relieved after hearing the full explanation. "Don't stop in the halfway. It sounds scary."

"You think five years is a long time?" Agatha frowned and said, "The timing was accurate at the first and the second Battles of Divine Will. I don't know why the cycle has now been shorten, and… it may become even shorter."

"I thought you would say the Bloody Moon would come this winter," Roland shrugged and replied. According to the current research and development plan, he would be able to universalize the new firearms throughout the whole army in one year. As long as the enemies were not impervious to blades and spears, they still had a chance to win the war. The only thing he needed to pay attention to was that the construction of the territory should be developed to an extent where it was able to support a long lasting war. This required its land, population and resources to be all at a high level, and that the territory had sufficient strategic depth to allow people to retreat temporarily and recover upon a defeat.

Therefore, the difficulty did not lie in weapons, but in the establishment of two to three industrial cities to constantly provide population, ammunition and food. Logistics guaranteed a victory, while staff guaranteed logistics. In the end, he found what he needed most were still reliable leaders, cadres and clerks. Without these, even he had unified the Kingdom of Graycastle, he still could not integrate it into a war machine, and the nobility would probably drag him down.

It's indeed true that a country capable of waging a war always has a high level of educational popularity.

“What’s this weapon called?” Agatha suddenly changed the topic, “Back then, I remember you called it 152mm Stronghold… ”

“Stronghold Standard Artillery,” Roland added, “There’ll be naval artilleries in the future.”

“If you can fill the city wall with weapons like this prior to the arrival of the Bloody Moon, we probably can resist the attacks from demons. According to Kyle Sichi, what I made in the chemistry lab is also a part of the cannon, right?” Agatha seemed to be determined and said, “I’ll try my best to produce liquid nitrogen and liquid oxygen, as long as you can… ”

“Don’t worry.” He comforted her. “We’ll defeat demons.”

****

“Was this all that I needed to do today?” Evelyn dipped her finger into the wine and touched her tongue. The spicy taste appeared to be more instense. According to His Highness’ requirement, the purer the white liquor was, the better it would taste. The best spirit did not even have any water, and every drop of it was mellow and rich—although she felt the white liquor she made became increasingly close to what His Highness described, it could lesser and lesser be considered as “tasty”.

“Yes, good work.” The manager of the brewery labeled the wine jars and nodded to her. “Remember me to His Highness.”

“Can you… really sell these?” Evelyn asked, confused. From her past experience of running a tavern, she was afraid that only few people could take such a spicy flavor.

“For this, I don’t know either,” the manager smiled and said, “but there would be someone coming to ship liquors every now and then, so I think there’re still some people who like it.”

Evelyn was relieved instantly. If nobody was willing to drink this, not only did His Highness fail, but she herself would become useless as well… It was fortunate that things turned out not to be what she thought was, and it

appeared that His Highness was a true great noble who knew the taste of the nobility very well. She smiled, “I’ll take off then.”

Evelyn left the brewery and went across the streets filled with bitterly cold wind. Upon returning to the castle, she sensed the warm air surrounding her. The world inside the castle was totally different from the one outside. She took a deep breath, taking off her coat to be closer to the warmth.

This kind of comfortable life was unimaginable at all in the past. In winter, she used to either tightly sit with her families by a brazier, or curl up beneath a blanket. “What’s the difference between the life in the castle and the Kingdom of God that the church has alleged to be like spring all the year round? Plus, His Highness had said that he would popularize the central heating system throughout the residential area, and enable all the subjects to stay away from the piercing coldness of the Months of the Demons.” She had no idea how many believers of the church had arrived at the Kingdom of God, but in here, witches who were considered as Devil’s minions and ordinary civilians were the first to enjoy this privilege. If it was known by those believers, they would probably grit their teeth out of envy.

His Royal Highness is truly capable of everything.

Across the hall, Andrea, Ashes and Shavi were playing poker.

“Double eight!”

“Pass.”

“Double two! I win,” Andrea smiled proudly and said, “Ashes has the most cards, six. Hand over the IOU for ice cream!” Then she turned around and waived at Evelyn, “Hey, do you want to play with us?”

Out of curiosity, Evelyn could not help asking, “What’s an IOU for ice cream?”

“That’s a bet,” Ashes waived her hand and continued, “Whoever has the most IOUs will have to give her next ice cream bread to the winner. How does it sound? Do you want to give it a shot?”

Evelyn was very hesitated. “This is a rare chance for her to make conversations with combat witches. If it was on the Sleeping Island, both Andrea and Ashes would be figures only next to Lady Tilly, who were rarely seen, and would certainly not invite her to join their activities voluntarily. Besides, Fighting the Landlord is indeed very interesting, with simple rules but numerous variations, and it also requires teamwork. One can easily spend the whole day just playing it. However…”

“Um, it’ll be the final exam soon. Aren’t you going to review what you’ve learned?”

“Did you mean the exam for that basic course in the evening?” Andrea pouted and said, “It’s very simple. Probably I can pass it without much reviewing.”

The other two seconded with a nod.

Right… Andrea is the nobility, whose insight and knowledge are greater than ordinary people. Both Ashes and Shavi can read and write. It appears now that she’s the one that falls behind.

“I… I might as well not play,” she hesitated for a moment and said, “and I’d better go back to my room and do some reading. You guys please continue.”

Leaving the three people who were a little surprised behind, Evelyn rushed to Witch House. She pushed the wooden door open, and found Candle sitting at the table in the living room practicing the arithmetic exercises at the back of the textbook.

“You’re back?”

“Yes.” Seeing the hard-working Candle, she felt a lot relieved at once. “How did your revision go?”

“Not bad. Nature and arithmetic are a little hard to understand,” Candle smiled and said. “How about you?”

“Me too,” Evelyn nodded and said, “Let’s list all that we don’t understand and ask Miss Anna in the evening.”

“Sounds good.”

According to Miss Scroll, these books were written by His Royal Highness himself, and they were part of his knowledge in his head. If she mastered them, did it mean that she would also possess one part of his almightiness? Evelyn thought in secret that although she couldn’t change the ability she was born with, at least she could achieve progress in this regard by working hard. Even if the nobles no longer liked to drink spicy white liquor, she could still work as a teacher in the territory rather than being useless. To this end, she pretty much read the textbook and studied those difficult phrases and equations whenever she had time, and she had become a frequent visitor of Anna’, Scroll’ and Wendy’s room.

She had the lowest score during the last test, but she firmly believed that it would not be the case this time.

“Let me set an achievable goal first—I want to exceed Maggie! ” she said to herself.

Chapter 382

Chapter 382: Final Exam

Translator: Meh Editor: – –

The day of the final exam soon arrived.

In the hall, the witches sat in neat rows as they waited for Teacher Scroll to distribute the test papers.

Meanwhile, Andrea was elegantly trimming her nails with a clipper. She was already thinking about dinner—according to His Highness Roland, the first semester of school would conclude as soon as the exam was over. To celebrate, every student would receive a roll of ice cream bread for dinner.

This meant that Andrea would receive much more than one roll.

In recent days, she would play "Fight the Landlord" with Ashes and Shavi whenever she was free. This game of tactics and technique was somewhat similar to beasts chess, which used to be popular among the upper-class nobility. In both games, the key was to make use of one's advantages and hide one's weaknesses, and deep planning was required. She would often brag about never having lost a game of "Fight the Landlord" to Lady Tilly and, even more so, Ashes, and she was indeed telling the truth. At the moment, she was owed six rolls of ice cream bread, of which four were from Ashes and two were from Shavi. In other words, whenever His Highness arranged this delicacy as dessert, the two of them would have to give their portions to Andrea.

It was going to be a "bumper harvest" for Andrea. She would be able to enjoy three rolls of ice cream bread for dinner, which would be finally enough to satiate her craving.

Naturally, she was also confident about the exam.

As soon as she heard that there would be an exam, she asked Sylvie about the previous test and even attempted the questions on her own. She realized that the test was very simple and was basically equivalent to the basic education for nobility. The test paper was mainly about recognizing words and phrases, and there were also a few simple arithmetic calculations of profit and loss, which were not as difficult as accounting problems, let alone family finance calculations. She was widely known as her family's prodigy in this area, and at the age of 15, she was already able to check her family's account books.

The true way of the nobility was to do everything to one's best.

The test papers were soon distributed.

Andrea took a quick look through the paper and raised her head. The test consisted of three question sheets, which were each labeled separately as "Kingdom Language", "Basic Arithmetic", and "Elementary Nature".

Great, exactly the same as last time.

She grinned uncontrollably as she opened the "Kingdom Language" question sheet and began writing with her goose quill pen immediately.

Within 15 minutes, she completed the questions on the first sheet. Although the range of vocabulary was greater than that of the previous time, and there were a few unexpected segments such as "reading comprehension" and "filling in the blanks", the test remained easy for her. "Well, it's just answering the questions after comprehending the passage and completing the sentences. It only looks confusing, but it's quite simple."

The next sheet was "Basic Arithmetic".

The front segment comprised of simple calculations of profit and loss, but gradually, Andrea's progress slowed down.

"What does 'Use an equation to describe two intersecting lines with a few dots above them.' mean?"

Her heart suddenly clenched. She began to have the feeling she got when she read Natural Science Theoretical Foundation. “Why is it that I can understand the words separately, but not when they’re connected?”

This was also the case for the subsequent questions.

Andrea started to sweat profusely.

She took a deep breath and held it in her chest. Then, she turned towards Nightingale, who was seated in the back row. “As a fellow noble, can she give me some hints?”

But Nightingale’s facial expression shocked Andrea.

Nightingale was staring dully at her test paper while holding her goose quill pen in her mouth. She did not shift her gaze for a long time.

Are the questions also difficult for her?

Lady Tilly did not attend the exam, while the legendarily gifted Miss Anna was also nowhere to be seen. Andrea saw that most of the witches were still stuck on the first page and unable to answer the questions.

After another 15 minutes, everyone flipped to the second question sheet. Even though they were much slower than Andrea for the first sheet, they did not stop writing even for a brief moment on the second sheet, and even Maggie was writing furiously. “Oh dear, Maggie doesn’t even hold the pen properly and looks as though she’s clawing the pen in her fist, yet she’s able to answer the questions?”

Andrea felt entirely helpless. Pretending that she had completed the “Basic Arithmetic” sheet, she flipped to the final sheet, “Elementary Nature”.

Compared to the previous test’s straightforward question-and-answer format, there were numbers and incomprehensible symbols this time. “Wait… this requires calculation as well?”

She suddenly began to feel that things were not going according to what she had anticipated.

The only relief was that Ashes had stopped writing a long time ago, apparently because she was equally stumped by the questions.

“But… what the heck,” she thought, “what joy is there in beating a meathead?”

Amidst her anxiety, she heard Teacher Scroll announce the end of the exam. Slumping back in her chair, she watched as the teacher took her test paper away, and she felt that her three rolls of ice cream bread for dinner were no longer that sweet.

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“Your Highness, here are all of the test papers.” Scroll placed a stack of paper on Roland’s office table. “Are you sure that you want to mark them yourself?”

“Indeed.” Roland smiled. “Sometimes, reading test papers is a form of pleasure.”

For example, he could read their bizarre answers, or discover the test takers’ anguish and suffering by reading between the lines. These served as spiritual food during his leisure time.

“Shall I collate the scores for you?”

“Yes, sorry to trouble you.” Roland nodded, and then he shouted, “Nightingale, no peeping.”

“You knew.” From the couch, Nightingale revealed her form and smiled. “Why doesn’t Anna have to attend the exam? Isn’t it the end of the semester? All sisters of the Witch Union should have to take the test.”

Roland burst into laughter uncontrollably. “Because this test was formulated by Teacher Scroll and her.”

Nightingale kept silent for a long while before she asked, “How about your younger sister?”

“Lady Tilly? She helped review the test paper and took the exam beforehand in order to check for errors.” The prince spread his arms. “By the way, she got full marks.”

Nightingale’s shadow appeared to grow heavier.

Roland shook his head and started to mark the papers.

…

After all of the scores had been collated, Roland stretched his sluggish body. The Sleeping Island witches showed considerable improvement this time. Candle, Evelyn and Sylvie all passed the exam, and among them, it was Evelyn who improved the most. Although she had the lowest score among the trio in the previous exam, she improved from 5 to 62 marks this time, undoubtedly because she had put in a great amount of effort.

Conversely, the three combat witches who had recently arrived attained low scores, none of which went above 50 marks. This was understandable because they had spent a much shorter time in the classroom and their scores for “Kingdom Language” were assigned a relatively low weight.

However, it was Nightingale who fared the most terribly. Although she had attended class with everyone else, her total score was less than her last test’s. Roland did not know whether to laugh or cry. “It appears that learning ability is indeed a natural gift that can’t be forced.”

The only one who surprised him was Maggie.

Although she was not able to solve more than a handful of calculation problems in the “Basic Arithmetic” and “Elementary Nature” sections, she correctly answered most of the multiple-choice and true-or-false questions and ultimately scored 63 marks, which Roland found rather unbelievable.

“How did she manage it?”

Roland could not think of a reason.

Chapter 383

Chapter 383: The Bite

Translator: Meh Editor: – –

Inside the Tower of Babel at Hermes Cathedral.

The newly-crowned Supreme Pontiff, Mayne, was quietly listening to the reports of the three Bishops in the secret room.

Aside from the elder Bishop Tayfun, the other two were newly-promoted Archbishops, Soli Darl and Ell, who came from the Verdict Army and Tribunal respectively. The former had been a gallant and heroic Presiding Judge who had gained a stellar reputation over the course of more than 25 years of service in the army, and the latter had been Heather's adjutant and was also widely respected.

"The intake of orphans from the Kingdom of Everwinter has been very successful during this year's Months of Demons. The nobles of every major city have fully yielded to the church. At present, the number of orphans sent to the Holy City is already three times more than the planned," Tayfun said with a sigh. "This is the only piece of good news recently."

The nobles were always like this—as soon as they saw that the situation was not advantageous to them, they would change sides faster than they drank water. Mayne nodded and replied, "This is only the first year, and there will be more and more in the future. If we're able to take over the whole continent, our yearly intake could fill up an entirely new city."

"I hope so." Tayfun sighed deeply. "How many times has this place been attacked by demonic beasts since the heavy snow began to fall?"

"Six times," Soli replied.

“Six times… and hundreds of Verdict Warriors have already died on the frontline,” Tayfun said in a heavy tone. “The God’s Punishment Army has also lost ten of its personnel, and the demonic beasts’ offensive will only become fiercer next year.”

“This is easier than fighting the demons,” Ell said and gestured with his hands. “Although I haven’t personally witnessed the might of the demons, the Holy Book describes them as invincible. Is it really necessary to defend this place to the death?”

“What on earth do you mean?!” Soli frowned upon hearing Ell’s words. “God gives us our direction and strength. As his disciples, how can we not stick to our faith and run away instead?”

“Stop quarreling,” Mayne said, thumping his scepter on the ground. “After working with Heather for more than ten years, Ell has been affected by her loose-lipped temperament.” As he watched Soli and Ell bicker, he could not help thinking about the partnership between Tayfun and Heather in the old times. He glanced at the old Bishop, only to discover that the latter was glancing back at him, as if they were thinking about the same thing. “Our ultimate goal is to sustain the human race, and the only way to do so is to defeat our enemies.”

“Understood, Your Holiness.” The two Bishops bowed their heads in respect.

Although, even he himself was not sure if they could defeat the demons by maintaining their position and defending Hermes.

Mayne suddenly thought about O’Brien’s entrustment and felt his shoulders grow heavy.

The Fearful Beasts of Hell had already appeared, and the demons would arrive in five years. Mayne would get to witness the next Battle of Divine Will while he was alive, but unlike O’Brien, he would not be able to entrust his duties to a successor. He could neither sleep nor eat well whenever he thought about this.

In truth, he had also thought about leaving a way out for himself. When Garcia's Blacksail Fleet was captured, Mayne did not order the ships to be burned nor execute all of the rebels, but instead locked them behind bars. Apart from executing a few of the fleet leaders together with a large number of scapegoats who were actually commoners living in the slums, most of the fleet crew were kept alive and were presently locked up in the harbor of the Kingdom of Everwinter by Mayne's most trusted subordinates.

If the defensive line is completely broken, the Fjords will become the final refuge—even though retreating to those islands will mean that Mankind is near extinction and has no chance of redemption, at least I'll be able to live out the rest of my life.

After all, hasn't Mankind already done everything it could and not been able to defeat its enemies in two attempts?"

In the subsequent discussions regarding how the church should expand and how to stabilize the governance of the Kingdom of Wolfheart, Mayne did not pay much attention. He waited until the three bishops finished discussing before saying absent-mindedly, "We'll do as you three have said. That'll be it for today's meeting."

"Yes, Your Holiness." The three bishops hurriedly stood up and bowed.

Mayne left the secret room and made his way towards the Pivotal Secret Area together with his guards.

According to the plan, a new batch of Verdict Army soldiers were to be converted to members of the God's Punishment Army today. This was what he was truly concerned about. Whether it was standing their ground or retreating, these powerful warriors were guaranteed to follow his orders.

However, before this, he had to handle another problem.

He passed through the stone steps and entered the Pivotal Secret Area. Then, he turned into the long prison corridor that was situated in the middle of the area. The last time he was here, it was to secretly execute the King of Graycastle, Wimbledon III.

The long corridor was extremely deserted. The rosin torches that were placed on both sides of the corridor emitted a dim yellow light. The far end of the corridor was covered in darkness as if it was the entrance to a bottomless abyss. Many people who had been imprisoned here never saw sunlight ever again.

Mayne walked towards cell No. 85 and signaled to his guards to open the door.

The thick wooden door gave out a harsh grinding sound. Then, fits of wailing and crying were suddenly heard. When the cell door was closed again, these fits were shut out on the outside.

Through the iron railings, Mayne saw Zero's figure.

The Pure Witch's back was facing the entrance. Her upper body was bare, while she was handcuffed to an iron bar overhead that forced her to tiptoe at all times. A dozen fresh lash marks were visible on her white-skinned back, but the streams of blood that flowed downwards had already solidified.

"How does the tribunal's Sermon Whip feel?" Mayne asked. "I hope that this teaches you the meaning of obedience."

"Uh…" Zero groaned softly as if she had just awakened from a dream and turned her head meekly. "So the Supreme Pontiff has come. Do you mean obedience towards you, or towards other bishops?"

Her frivolous tone made Mayne frown. However, his displeasure diminished when he reminded himself that he was currently the Supreme Pontiff, which was very different from his previous position as a bishop. "After this lesson, she should understand that I can decide whether she lives or dies." "Obedience towards me. And when I ask you to assist another bishop to complete a mission, you have to obey his orders."

"Is that all?" She asked noncommittally. "If this is what you demand, I'll agree to it."

"Release her handcuffs," Mayne ordered a guard.

Having been handcuffed up high for a long time, Zero's hands seemed to be dislocated, and they dropped down as though they did not have an ounce of energy left. The Pope picked up Zero's clothes using his scepter and tossed them on her shoulder. "I have a task for you. Follow me."

Zero allowed her clothes to dangle on her shoulder and nonchalantly followed Mayne out of the long prison corridor.

"This year's Months of Demons could be as long as five months. This is a daunting challenge for the Holy City, and even more so for other places that are affected by the Months of Demons." Mayne walked to the border of the Trap Area, and then passed through a narrow iron-walled passageway and arrived in front of the elevator cage once again. Ever since he was crowned as the Pope, he had been busy with the various matters of the church. This was the first time he stepped foot in this place as the ruler. "I order you to follow the other Pure Witches to the Kingdom of Graycastle and kill the rebels Timothy and Roland Wimbledon by taking advantage of the disorder brought about by the heavy snow. Is that understood?"

As the door of the elevator cage closed, the clicking sound of the capstan rotation was heard overhead and the elevator began to descend slowly. But Mayne didn't hear Zero's reply.

"Damn, the whipping hasn't taught her to obey." With a sullen face, Mayne turned to look at Zero, only to see her smiling with a dangerous glint in her eyes.

Then, he saw a beam of bright light heading straight at him.

Chapter 384

Chapter 384: Sin and Redemption

Translator: Meh Editor: – –

After the darkness disappeared, Mayne found himself standing in an empty square.

Everything in front of him seemed vaguely familiar… short houses, a monastery still in construction, and a new stone church. The dirt floor was dry and firm without a trace of snow, the sun was peeking through the clouds, and a warm breeze kissed his cheek. It didn't feel like the Months of the Demons at all.

"Wait." He suddenly realized. "Was this the old Holy City where I first became a believer? At that moment, His Holiness O'Brien was hosting a cleansing ritual on the square."

"So this is the most prominent place in your memories," said Zero coldly from behind him. "It's a pretty nice place."

The Pure Witch!

His fragmented memories suddenly came together, and he felt a fit of rage come over him. He turned around and glared straight at her. "Zero, are you insane?!"

How dare she use her powers against me!

Also, why doesn't the God's Stone of Retaliation that I wear have any effect?

"I know exactly what I'm doing." Zero smiled. "It's you… who is still confused. It's alright. There's more than enough time in your subconscious world for me to explain this to you."

Mayne was familiar with Zero's power of the Soul Battlefield, which allowed her to battle the possessed victim using only her mind, and the victor would gain everything, while the defeated would lose it all. This was an extremely rare type of summoning power and could only be resisted by God's Stone of Retaliation. "But… damn it! I'm clearly wearing a God's Stone of Retaliation!"

He reached into his pocket and took out the blue crystal, the silhouette of which reflected a cerulean light under the sun, showing no defects.

"Why?" Mayne asked, gnashing his teeth.

"Are you talking about the Stone?" Zero smiled. "Basically, its sphere of influence has been removed. Of course, a mortal won't be able to feel the difference."

"Its influence has been removed?" The Pope couldn't help but stare. "There's only one person in the entire Holy City who can counter the effects of God's Stone of Retaliation, and that's the Pure Witch Isabella.

This is… blatant betrayal!

"These b*tches!" A vein throbbed on Mayne's forehead, and his hands shook with anger. "If I knew how unreliable these tools were, I would have added them to the God's Punishment Army when I was appointed!" He tried to control his temper and said bitterly, "When did this happen?"

"How could I know when she struck, since you put me in a cell to teach me a lesson?" Zero shrugged. "I only asked her to do it and that's all."

"You asked! If you hadn't been planning this for a long time, how could she do such a blasphemous thing so easily?" "No." His heartbeat suddenly stopped. "Even the two of them wouldn't be able to pull this off…" After he became the Pope, he moved into the bedroom that used to belong to His Holiness O'Brien, which had all kinds of booby traps and Verdict Warriors standing guard at all times. Not to mention there were Advanced Magic Stones by his bed, which he carried with him every day, and guards followed him everywhere. How did they manage to find an opportunity to strike?

Mayne was so angry that he actually grew eerily calm. “What do you want? Are you doing this just to get back at me for my punishment? Even if you kill me, the entire cave below your cage is the influence area of God’s Stones, so you have nowhere to run. As soon as the elevator stops, you’ll be spotted and captured by the waiting Verdict Warriors. Don’t even dream of escaping this cell, because when they start interrogating you, you’ll feel like the days of whipping is just tickles to you.”

“I don’t want to escape.” Zero shook her head. “I want to replace you and become the Pope.”

“…” Mayne was stunned. He had predicted all kinds of reasons, but he never expected to hear this answer. “A Pure Witch as the Pope? You have quite an imagination, since I’m the one who was crowned as the Pope in front of all our believers! If you kill me, do you think they would accept you?”

“I don’t need to appear in front of everyone because I can just have a ‘mouthpiece’ to act as the Pope,” said Zero unconcernedly. “See, His Holiness O’Brien also stayed in the Pivotal Secret Temple most of the time and would wear a mask on the rare occasions he came out. Under these circumstances, who could tell that the Pope was actually someone else?”

“You won’t be able to keep up your ruse for long! Didn’t you hear what I just said? As soon as your cage hits the ground, when the Verdict Warriors realize I’m not here, they’ll immediately arrest you!” Mayne roared. “If you let me out right now, I can still forget that you ever did such a reckless thing!”

“As soon as the Battle of Souls begins, it won’t ever end,” said Zero with a smile. “Also, you were wrong from the beginning, because they won’t arrest me.”

“Won’t arrest her… What does that mean?” The Pope stared at the Pure Witch’s eyes with a frown and tried to see what she was thinking, but her eyes only shined with excitement and didn’t reveal a trace of fear or panic. She didn’t avert her eyes and instead stared calmly at him, as if she was saying a completely normal thing.

Mayne suddenly felt a bolt of electricity flash through his mind!

“Even giving up… may also be a wise choice.”

“I’m sorry, child.”

He opened his mouth, but he felt that his throat was choked by a pair of large hands and couldn’t make a sound. He felt his heart sink, as if it fell into a pool of icy water. After a long time, he said with great difficulty: “Is this all O’Brien…”

“So you finally understand.” Zero arched her eyebrows. “The Supreme Pontiff has given orders to all the guards and Verdict Warriors in the Pivotal Secret Temple—they’ll never leave their position below ground and will only listen to the Pope. You accepted the scepter above ground, but you don’t have the control of the Pivotal Secret Temple yet.” She chuckled quietly. “Think about it. We’re currently above the cave and the core organization of the church, as well as the only place free from the guards above ground and from the influence of God’s Stone of Retaliation. Don’t you agree that this is the perfect arena?”

The Pure Witch stopped smiling, and her eyes flashed like dancing flames. “This is the battlefield His Holiness arranged for us, so whoever survives will become the true ruler of the church.”

“How… how could this be?” Mayne felt his throat dry up. “This stupid old man. Is he doing this to repent for his sins of taking the power that belonged originally to witches? How absurd!”

The flames in Zero’s eyes were clearly from ambition, an emotion that was rarely seen in Pure Witches—they were trained as tools since birth and were all supposed to be unwaveringly loyal to church officials. “If we hadn’t conquered those reckless… No, shoot!” Mayne suddenly remembered what His Holiness said to him before invading the Kingdom of Wolfheart.

“I’m sending two Pure Witches to fight alongside you. No one can escape their wrath.”

Why didn’t he ever consider how acquiring the memories of the King of Wolfheart and the Queen of Clearwater would affect Zero?

As he recalled O'Brien's relieved expression in his last hour, he finally understood the meaning behind his dying words. Mayne gritted his teeth furiously. "How did the old man not consider this issue? He had already been preparing for the ambition to return to the Pure Witch's heart."

Is this the ending you hoped to see, Supreme Pontiff?!

Chapter 385

Chapter 385: Cause and Effect

Translator: Meh Editor: – –

“Don’t be so upset, Lord Mayne.” Zero held her hands behind her back and slowly circled the square. “The church was originally founded by the Union anyway, so His Holiness only did this so that the witches could get back what was theirs. If you win, you can also get my memories and experiences—wealth I accumulated over the past 200 years.”

“I see. Letting Zero use the Reflection Church was already strange because even if she were the Pope’s favorite, she was still a Pure Witch and shouldn’t have been given access to the church’s deepest secrets. Unfortunately, I didn’t realize this soon enough.” Mayne was silent for a while before saying, “If you win, where do you plan to lead the church to?”

“To victory,” she said, raising her head, “or destruction… just not towards the Fjord Islands.”

“W… what?”

“You think no one knows about your secret orders?” Zero’s tone contained a trace of mockery. “Right before a great battle, you sent resources to the port of Kingdom of Everwinter to repair ships and support sailors. Plus, you sent a large number of scapegoats to the gallows. These are all costly expenses, practically impossible to hide from the church.”

“Shoot, O’Brien even entrusted her with the Pivotal Secret Area’s intelligence agency.” He thought silently. “That doesn’t prove anything! As the Pope, I need to think in the long-term to ensure that the church survives under any circumstances.”

“Do you even believe your own words?” Zero laughed. “Right after you accepted the scepter in front of all those believers, you started thinking about

your own future, and you lost your will to win the Battle of Divine Will before it even began—do you think a mortal like you can earn the approval of God?"

"What approval of God?" Mayne couldn't help but scream. "If his approval was really protecting us, why were the humans suffering defeat after defeat?" He panted heavily and rasped. "Meanwhile, we need to rely on God's Punishment Army to battle the demons, so time is of the essence, and there's nothing you can do to change that."

"No, not just God's Punishment Army," whispered Zero. "The fate of mankind shouldn't rest in the hands of a few people."

"Are we supposed to count on you witches?" Mayne chuckled coldly. "Don't forget that it was your kind who failed us 400 years ago!"

"The witches are also only a small group." She stopped walking and stared directly at the Pope, her eyes chilling him to the core. "This battle will decide the survival of all of the mankind, so everyone needs to be involved —men, women, the elderly and children will all become honored warriors and join the fight against the demons, or else… they'll all die."

"That's absurd. You plan to send those civilians who are scared senseless by demonic beasts against actual demons? You must be out of your mind…" Mayne suddenly stopped, as he realized she wasn't joking and was seriously sharing her plans with him. "The only way to give civilians the ability to fight was…"

"You want to feed all of them Pills of Madness?" He asked in disbelief.

"One enchanted person is no match for a God's Punishment Warrior, but what about ten?" Zero turned her head and asked. "Not only is there currently a steady supply of demonic beasts running rampant, but the Pivotal Secret Area might also be able to invent a few new formulas. Five years later, the church will have a supply of around three to four million pills. What does this mean?" She paused. "It means that besides God's Punishment Army, the Holy City can also send out an army of millions of maddened men to participate in the battle against demons."

“You’re… insane!”

“Insane? You’re the insane one for not taking the Battle of Doomsday seriously!” The Pure Witch suddenly roared. “Both the Union and the church used small groups to fight against their enemy’s full force, which is why they failed. No one is exempt from this battle, and mortals can’t hide behind God’s Punishment Army or witches forever—as I said, this is a fateful battle that requires everyone’s full efforts, otherwise we won’t be able to contend with the demons in the Barbarian Land!”

A Pure Witch raised by the church would never say such a thing because this was the mentality of a conqueror. Mayne’s face grew pale. “You are… an absolute mutt!”

Your Holiness O’Brien, did you really foresee all of this?

“Accepting knowledge is a part of the process of self-change, and only the exchange of thoughts can bring progress.” Zero inhaled sharply. “Perhaps we should stop chatting and decide who the ruler of the church should be.”

“Don’t bet on winning,” said the Pope through gritted teeth. “I built this world!”

As soon as he finished speaking, Red Mist appeared at his feet and began to spread. Zero seemed slightly taken aback. Suddenly, she grasped her throat and screamed a tortured cry, her face curling up like orange peels, falling off in chunks, and spewing blood everywhere, soon losing its human form.

“This is the demonic mist hidden in the Pivotal Area’s traps and only affects witches with magic power,” said Mayne bitterly through the Red Mist. “If I fill the entire square with it, you’ll be left to suffer endlessly and die a thousand times!”

“Is that so?” A gust of wind suddenly cleared all the Red Mist around the Pure Witch, and the reborn Zero said painfully, “Of course, the new Pope has some tricks up his sleeve. If you headed straight to the library of the Pivotal Secret Temple in the beginning, this battle would be even more difficult—but this is also the fun part of the Battle of Souls.

“Is that… a Stone of Windpower?” Mayne noticed a ring with a green crystal on her finger. “The stone’s area of influence is limited, so as long as I keep my distance, I can break this shield with a God’s Stone of Retaliation bolt. But just to be safe, I should make some preparations.” He racked his brain, created two Pills of Madness, and swallowed them.

“Oh, smart idea,” said Zero with a grin.” Your biggest weakness is in your fighting ability, so the duo-colored pill can increase your strength, agility, and pain tolerance, so it’s much harder for me to attack you from afar with weapons such as crossbow bolts.”

Mayne ignored her, moved to an area unaffected by the Magic Stone, and focused on creating a God’s Stone of Retaliation. The Pills of Madness were kicking in, and he felt his strength increase rapidly and sight become very clear. When he created the God’s Stone of Retaliation, it would make the most effective weapon against the witch, and she would die of erosion by the Red Mist if she tried to attack him.

She’s also making her own weapon—what is it? A pair of long swords?

It makes sense to have bolts, but what does she need swords for?” Also, the structure of the swords is very strange, with a blade as broad as her torso and encrusted with many crystals, seeming strangely familiar.

Zero raised the weapons in her hands. “Do you know? In the Illusion Room of the Reflection Church, there is more than one recorded image.”

What does that mean?

“Did you forget what His Holiness O’Brien said? Alice’s battle with Natalia was completely recorded by the Union,” she said carefully. “Besides absorbing memories, watching and learning are also talents of mine.”

As she said this, the crystals on the swords lit up one by one, as if they were signaling something. And then a bright golden light emerged from the swords and ripped through the Red Mist, shooting straight into the sky. The sky also seemed to respond to this power by shooting down thousands of bolts of light.

“What… kind of ability is this?” Mayne stared in shock.

Before getting the answer, he was surrounded by an engulfing golden light, which seemed to tear the entire world apart.

****

The cage fell slowly to the bottom of the God’s Stone cave.

Zero threw the clothes on her shoulder onto the ground and walked out of the cage. The scars from whippings had all disappeared from her back, as if they had never been there.

The Verdict Warrior standing guard lowered his head respectfully and handed her a prepared golden robe—the clothing signaling the highest authority in the Church.

With the help of many attendants, Zero put on the baggy robe and walked straight to the Pivotal Secret Temple, not sparing even a single glance ba.

Chapter 386

Chapter 386: A Different Story

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

After a busy week, Roland built a new chemical factory next to the Redwater River. Considering the toxicity of nitrogen oxide, this factory was built like the Convenience Market, with a gaping wall and wooden roof, a one-story tall gap in the middle, and awful ventilation. Of course, the temperature inside was pretty much the same with that outside.

The new oxygen and nitrogen synthesizing system was already in use. The heat produced instantaneously by the Blackfire was the same as an electric arc and was much more efficient. After the raw materials were placed into the reactor, Anna only needed 8 minutes to turn them into nitrogen dioxide, which produced nitric acid when combined with water.

The system that synthesized ammonia from nitrogen and hydrogen was also in full swing—the amount of liquid nitrogen resolved from cooling was much larger than the amount of liquid oxygen, so the leftover nitrogen was used to produce ammonia. Roland also did not cease the regular industrial production of nitric acid so that he could cover all his bases. Every new production line for nitric acid was an opportunity for more chemical explosives.

According to the test on Paper's abilities, he found that she truly could speed up a heated nitrogen and hydrogen reaction to the extent that it seemed like the results were instantaneous. The problem remained that she still could not control the release of her magic power, and her young age made her consume the little power she had very quickly.

However, this could be fixed through practice. According to Wendy, the girl was improving quickly, and she would be able to maintain her power at a basically stable level in about a week.

With these two production lines and a stable glycerol nitrification output, achieving modern smokeless powder became possible. The next step was to design a repeating firearm and begin producing it as soon as possible.

Roland was just thinking about his design for the new weapon when a guard walked into his office and reported, “Sir Ferlin Eltek and his father Duke Eltek are here to see you and are waiting in the lobby.”

“Ferlin?” He pondered for a while. “Wasn’t he the first knight of the Western Region, Kingdom of Dawn? All his family should be at Longsong Stronghold. Why is he suddenly in Border Town?” Did they mention why they were here?”

“Sir Ferlin said it had something to do with witches and told me to give this to you.” The guard handed him a piece of delicate parchment depicting the treasure map previously drawn by Morning Light, but compared with the previous rough draft, this map almost seemed to be printed.

Roland suddenly remembered that Ferlin once said this map had been passed down in his family for 400 years, and that Lightning used it to find the stone tower where Agatha was being held.

He was suddenly very interested. “Go summon Agatha; she should still be in the chemical lab right now. I’ll go and see them right away.”

“Yes, Your Highness.”

After the guard left, Roland rolled up the map and went to the lobby.

Ferlin and an old man immediately stood up and bowed in respect.

The prince noticed that both men were wearing thick leather jackets with sweat stains on their shoulders, and the old man’s forehead was already brimming with sweat. He smiled and said, “If it’s too hot, you can take off your coats. There’s heating in the castle, so it’s much warmer in here than it’s outside. Don’t make yourself sick.”

“Heating?” Ferlin was stunned.

“It’s a new type of heating equipment that’s much better than a fireplace.” Roland didn’t waste time on explaining and instead directed the subject to his visitors’ intentions. “I heard you came because of the witches?”

“Yes, Your Highness,” said Morning Light, nodding furiously. “I met a woman with blue hair at the Convenience Market…” He briefly summarized his experience during the past few days. “When I returned home, my father told me about my family’s history, and I thought that she might be a witch.”

“I see.” Roland was shocked to hear his story. He didn’t think that Agatha’s family had any mortals who survived till now. “There’s such a witch at Border Town, and her name is Agatha indeed.”

Duke Eltek bolted out of his chair in excitement. “Then could Your Highness…”

“Let you meet her?” Roland nodded with a smile. “Of course, she should be on her way to the castle right now. Also, considering that she’s a witch, I think you should do her the courtesy of taking off that God’s Stone of Retaliation you’re wearing.”

“Ah, you’re right.” The Duke hastily removed the stone from his shirt and placed it on the table.

“There was no such courtesy in Taquila 400 years ago, and witches weren’t hunted like animals by the church yet,” Nightingale whispered in his ear. “This stone is nothing but research material for Agatha.”

“This way, you can determine whether they’re telling the truth or not,” Roland said, hiding his smile.

He felt Nightingale lightly pinch his neck.

“Liar.”

…

“Why do you summon me back?” Agatha pushed through the lobby door and demanded. “The Battle of Divine Will is looming and I need all the time I

have to produce weapons to fight… in battle." She fought down the word "demons" when she noticed the strangers. "If it isn't important, you can just send someone to tell me."

After working with the Chief Alchemist for a long time, she started to sound a little like Kyle Sichi, and her tireless attitude in serving Border Town's production industries made the town leader Roland feel a little guilty. He cleared his throat, "Ahem, this is a very important matter. Do you remember, when Taquila was on the verge of collapse 400 years ago, that one group of servants was separated from you and followed the masses to the south of the Impassable Mountain Range?"

"I think so." Agatha took off her hat, which was covered in snow, and tossed her blue hair. "What kind of important matter is this? It happened a long time ago."

When she showed her full appearance, Ferlin and the Duke gasped, and the Duke immediately kneeled in front of her. "You really are Lady Agatha!"

"And you are… ?" Agatha frowned.

"I'm a descendant of Kagar. Do you still remember that name?" The Duke asked, looking up expectantly.

"Kagar… of course. I gave him that name." She shrugged her shoulders. "I purchased two mortal servants and named one Kaff, who was the head of my family guards, and the other Kagar, who was my housekeeper." She paused slightly. "So you're the descendants of that housekeeper who snuck away with my Magic Stones and experiment notes?"

"Snuck… away?" The Duke stared in shock. "No, he…"

"Get out." Agatha's face darkened. "I don't ever want to see you again."

Chapter 387

Chapter 387: Inheritance

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

The witch left the hall as soon as she was finished talking and gave the two men no time to explain.

Roland turned his head slightly. “Can you tell what’s going on?”

“Both sides are telling the truth,” Nightingale whispered in his ear.

Roland pondered this for a bit and quickly guessed what had really happened. What was spoken truthfully wasn’t necessarily the truth, but only what one thought was true. It seemed that the issue lay in their family history book.

“Since you came all this way from Longsong Stronghold, don’t go back so soon. Stay in Ferlin’s house for a couple of days and tour the scenery of this town.” Roland turned to the confused Duke. “I’ll try to reason with her, and maybe you will get to talk again.”

“Is that… is that true?” The Duke was shocked, but he bowed his head and said, “Then I must trouble Your Highness.”

“By the way, where are the Magic Stones and ancient books that you brought?”

“There’re more than ten boxes on our boat.”

“Great, let’s bring them all to the castle,” Roland said, nodding. “I think she’ll soften up a little after seeing all of her things that survived for over 400 years.”

…

After dinner, the Prince called Elsa to his office.

“You should give Duke Eltek a chance to explain himself.” He told her the Duke’s entire story. “No matter what your housekeeper did, this man is trying to return your belongings to you, and he may even be trying to right his ancestor’s wrongs.”

“My housekeeper deceived his descendants, so this man doesn’t owe me anything.” Elsa pouted. “Also, witch families mean nothing now. They belong to the nobility of the Western Region, right? If I accept them, it would make things difficult for you, because you want to seize all the ruling authority of the Western Region for yourself, don’t you?”

Roland was shocked that she even considered this issue, and he shook his head with a smile. “Alright, that makes sense. But you don’t seem to blame them.”

“I shouldn’t place my anger towards a mortal from 400 years ago onto his descendants, especially if they don’t know what happened.”

“Spoken like a true enlighted member of the witches’ kingdom!” Roland thought. “Whether it is towards mortals or accepting new things, she always has a positive outlook. To me, this is no doubt an outstanding mindset, but it was probably a rare one in Taquila, so it’s no surprise that she was rejected by other witches in the Quest Society.”

“In that case, I’ll explain it to them,” he said, smiling. “Do you have any interest in going through your belongings?”

Elsa rolled her eyes and scoffed, “They’re not mine. They’re the Quest Society’s belongings.”

…

All the boxes were brought to the castle basement. Beside Elsa, Roland also invited Tilly, Silvio, and Anna.

The boxes were opened one by one under Silvio's watch—ten out of the fifteen boxes contained Magic Stones. Roland picked up a fist-sized crystal and clicked his tongue. "You said that they were all transformed from God's Stone of Retaliation, so a stone this big must be worth 200 or 300 gold royals."

"200 or 300 gold royals?" Elsa said, unimpressed, "Magic Stones can only be produced by Chaos Beasts, so every piece is practically priceless."

"What kind of Magic Stones are these?" Tilly asked. "They don't seem easy to carry."

"Stones of Light." Elsa pressed on the stone in the Prince's hand and channeled her magic power into it, causing a pale yellow light to stream out of it, which quickly exceeded the light of a torch. When the blinding light became too much to bear, she finally lifted her hand. "More than half of these are Stones of Light. Besides the ones produced by the Chaos Beasts, the rest were all battle spoils we gained from attacking Devil's Towns."

"How were the Magic Stones made into different sizes?" Anna asked curiously. "If they were all God's Stones of Retaliation, then they couldn't be cut with magic power, but the block of God's Stone of Retaliation was extremely hard and couldn't possibly be cut with knives either."

"An entire block?" Elsa was stunned. "Are you talking about the God's Stone of Retaliation vein?"

"It's right under Border Town's mines." Roland explained the story of the treasure map. "Its surface is very hard, and even a flintlock can only leave a tiny dent in it."

"I see." She couldn't help but smile. "You used this map to find my laboratory tower. Yes, it really was used by the Quest Society to mark the God's Stone of Retaliation vein and was a chosen location for the next Holy City."

"Holy City?" Everyone asked surprisedly in unison.

“Why else do you think there would be hundreds of cities on the Fertile Plains, but only three Holy Cities?” She lifted the corners of her mouth. “These supposed Holy Cities are all built on top of God’s Stone of Retaliation veins. We needed a lot of God’s Stones of Retaliation to research the relationship between magic power and Magic Stones, and also to prevent large-scale damage in conflicts between witches.

“So you were planning to build a New Holy City on North Slope Mountain?” Roland asked in surprise.

“Yes, if we weren’t defeated so quickly in the Battle of Divine Will.” Elsa sighed. “It was the same case with the Barbarian Ridge in the Impassable Mountain Range—you now refer to it as the Hermes plateau, which is where the church’s Holy City is now.”

“The church also continued using the term ‘Holy City’,” Tilly said with a frown, “so it is even more possible that they are descendants of the Union.”

Thank goodness they didn’t build the church’s Holy City in Western Region. Roland sighed quietly in relief.

“Anyway, the God’s Stone of Retaliation is basically indestructible, so cutting it requires a special solution,” Elsa continued to explain. “It contains the blood of witches with magic power… or the blood of demons.”

“Blood?” Sylvie couldn’t help but gape.

“Yes, and the amount of blood needed depends on the Stone,” she said, spreading her hands. “In the Holy City, all adult witches were required to donate blood. Once it leaves the body, the blood lost magic power very quickly, so it must be used on the spot. Every two or three years, eligible witches would be ordered by the Union to go to the mines and donate blood, and any captured demons would also serve this purpose.”

“Have you done this as well?” Anna asked.

“Of course,” Elsa said, nodding. “Even the Three Chiefs of the Union were no exception.”

“What about demonic beasts?” Sylvie asked. “Some demonic hybrids also seem to have magic power.”

“Yes, but the levels of their magic power are very low, so their blood can only be used to deal with shattered stones, and they have no effect on the actual veins,” Elsa replied. “After the God’s Stone of Retaliation is cut, its hardness will greatly decrease with its size, and its range of impact will shrink as well. For example, the God’s Stone of Retaliation that people carry around with them can be easily smashed with a hammer.”

Chapter 388

Chapter 388: The Sigil of God's Will

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

These words confirmed Roland's guess, which was that the God's Stone of Retaliation did not affect magic power, but witches' abilities.

"Besides the Chaos Beast, did the Quest Society find any other ways to produce Magic Stones?"

Agatha shook her head. "It's easier said than done. The Union once had a witch who could turn God's Stones of Retaliation into regular stones, but all she did was to remove the magic power—it wasn't nearly enough to even produce the simplest Stones of Light." She turned to Sylvie. "You can see the form of magic power, so you should also be able to see the real forms of these crystals."

"It's a ball of faint… fog," Sylvie said with an unsure tone.

"This is one of the ways magic power gathers." Agatha nodded. "The Quest Society examined and recorded almost 10,000 witches and Magic Stones, and they found that most unevolved magic power came in the form of fog, cyclones, blown sand, light balls and flames. They might look similar, but each had an infinite amount of minute differences, which was why we believed there were no two identical magic powers. As for magic powers that were condensed after the High Awakening, their shapes differed even more."

"Its light is dimming," Tilly suddenly pointed to the Stone of Light in Roland's hand and said.

"That's because I only channeled a small amount of magic power," Agatha explained.

“But I once saw a Stone of Light in the Fjord ruins that never dimmed,” she said confusedly. “If those underwater ruins belonged to you, then can you also make a Stone of Light shine for 400 years?”

“Underwater ruins?” Agatha was shocked. “Did some Union members go to the Swirling Sea?” She shook her head and dismissed this thought. “It’s possible to make a Stone of Light shine forever, but it requires more than 10 witches.”

“More than 10… ” Anna mumbled. “Is it transferring magic power?”

“Yes. Some witches can refill others’ magic power or directly exchange the magic power collected from two people. This way, a witch can channel much more power than the amount she has in her own body and cause a Magic Stone to act continuously.” Agatha returned the Stone of Light to its original brightness. “However, this method doesn’t work on every kind of Magic Stone. Usually, only the Stones of Mist with the simplest form of magic power can be used this way, such as Stones of Light or Echo Stones, which aren’t much help in battle.”

“But they would be very useful in the castle,” Roland said excitedly, staring at the box of Stones of Light.

In a time before the Electrical Age, these things would be perfect lighting, and he was sick of weak and flickering candlelight. Candles were alright in the winter, but working in the office in the summer was absolute torture, not to mention it’s horrible for his eyesight. Now, these magic stones could brighten the entire castle, even at night.

“They would?” Agatha asked disapprovingly. “I think they would be more useful in the laboratories, especially if we want to keep producing liquid oxygen at night, because open flames are too dangerous.”

“Um… Is she asking to work overtime in addition to the eight hours during the day?” Roland tilted his head. “Ahem, let’s take a look at the Magic Stones in the other boxes first.”

A quick check showed that besides Stones of Light of various shapes and brightness, there were also some random Stones. According to the Ice Witch, although these were all priceless goods, they were still of the lowest tier of Magic Stones. For example, there were Stones of Vigilance that sent out signals and Stones of Pathfinding that located things. “I wasn’t in charge of everything in the Holy City’s stone tower, and I was basically estranged from the Quest Society at the time, so all the goods I transported were unimportant.”

“What about these books?” Roland pointed to the black books in the other boxes. “Are these all lab records?”

“Some of these are the General Principles.” Agatha blushed. “I wanted to save a copy as a promotion guide to the new witches who had to reclaim wastelands.”

Why was this embarrassing? Roland glanced at her curiously and continued to sift through the remaining boxes.

“This wooden box… is a little strange.” Sylvie’s words caused his hands to tremble and recoil immediately.

“Is there a booby trap?”

“No… there’s an interlayer,” she said, examining the box. “It’s at the very bottom. I didn’t notice it at first because I thought it was only a regular partition.”

Roland took out all the books from the box, exposing the thick bottom. Anna carefully cut open the wooden plank and retrieved a cast iron box.

“What’s it?” Roland curiously opened the lid and saw a thick metal plate encrusted with four colorful crystals. Its design revealed that it was obviously very unique. “Perhaps the Quest Society did leave you with some valuable objects after all.”

Agatha gasped. “This… can’t be possible!”

Her dramatic reaction confused the other four people, and Roland immediately put the metal plate back into the box. “What’s wrong?”

“This is the Sigil of God’s Will!” the Ice Witch said in disbelief. “How did Kagar manage to get his hands on this?” She rechecked the box a couple of times. “Did he steal it from the other witches in the Quest Society?”

“Maybe his fleet was attacked and someone entrusted him with it,” Roland guess randomly. “It’s been 400 years, and it doesn’t matter who the box belonged to… What on earth is the Sigil of God’s Will?”

“Some Magic Stones, when pieced together, can have extra abilities, alter their magic powers’ properties, or increase their effects—this was the most important topic of research for the Quest Society.” Agatha carefully scooped up the silver plate. “Magic Stones that are pieced together are called Sigils, and the Sigil of God’s Will is the most powerful kind. Its Magic Stones all come from Senior Demons, and there are only three or four of its kind in all of Taquila.”

Roland couldn’t help but whistle in awe. “How powerful is it?”

“It can wipe out your entire castle.”

The prince choked in shock.

“Don’t worry, it also requires an alarming amount of magic power—the more Magic Stones are on the Sigil, the harder it is to activate.” Agatha closed her eyes, and two of the Magic Stones on the metal plate began to glow, while the third remained dull. After a while, she seemed to be exhausted and let go of the plate, panting. “The only witches who could use the Sigil of God’s Will were the Union’s two Chiefs.”

“You mean… Transcendents?”

Agatha nodded.

Roland thought for a while and said, “Let Anna have a try.”

“That’s useless,” Agatha said, shaking her head. “Extraordinaries use their magic power differently from ordinary witches, basically practicing all the time. Once they evolve, the amount of magic power in their bodies will greatly surpass… What?!”

Everyone saw that as soon as Anna touched the Sigil, the four Magic Stones immediately began lighting up one by one, and the edges of the metal plate began streaming with a gold light that looked like lightning. The gold light became more and more intense, and the Sigil shone like the rising sun!

“Let go of it right now!” Agatha screamed.

The light immediately vanished as if it had never even appeared. Anna let out a gasp and gently placed the Sigil back into the iron box. “It does use up a lot of magic power, so I can probably only use it twice.”

The basement was dead silent.

Chapter 389

Chapter 389: Entrust

Translator: Meh/TransN Editor: – –

“Duke… Eltek, dinner is ready.”

Irene opened the room door and bowed rigidly. Her voice sounded more restrained than usual. This was the first time Ferlin had seen his wife behaving in such a manner. Even when she met the prince, she was not as nervous as this.

“Father?” He raised his voice and glanced at the knight who had not spoken a word since he returned.

“Ugh…” Duke Eltek blinked his eyes as if he had just woken up from a period of meditation. “Come and eat.”

The dishes placed on the small dining table were especially sumptuous. To Ferlin, it was apparent that his wife had made a trip to the Convenience Market. He looked at her and smiled, as if to praise and encourage her. He started the dinner by slicing the bread as usual and then proceeded to divide the main course into four equal portions—apart from the three of them, there was also Irene’s friend, May.

Earlier, when he came home, he saw May discussing the content of a drama with Irene. After he introduced his father to the two of them, he expected that May would choose to leave, as most people would do. However, she did not, and instead, after making a simple bow towards Duke Eltek while revealing a frown on her face, she remained beside Irene. Even more uncommonly, she proposed that she should stay for dinner.

Ferlin was boggled by all of this. In the past, when he wanted to thank her properly, he invited her several times to attend a banquet, but she never agreed even once.

However, Morning Light had no time to think about all of this. Although on the surface he appeared calm and collected, his heart was in an utter mess. The first reason was that he was worried about what his father thought about his wife, and the second Agatha's attitude. From the look of disappointment on his father's face, it was evident that, as the current head of the Eltek family, he cared a great deal about the matter. However, Ferlin did not know how to console his father, particularly because the many years of separation had created some estrangement between them. All he could do was continue to eat quietly.

Fortunately, Miss May was around.

Her conversation topic regarding the drama aroused the interest of Duke Eltek, and together they had a nice chat about the charm of King's City and the lives of the nobility. Hence, the dinner was not so dreary at last. Moreover, Irene was able to participate in the discussion regarding the new drama, and Duke Eltek even enquired about her recent performances. This allowed Ferlin to feel relieved.

After dinner, May swiftly took her leave.

After helping his wife to wash the cutlery, he was asked by his father to meet in the study.

"Your wife has made a good friend."

"You mean Miss May?" Ferlin was slightly surprised. "She's indeed an outstanding actress, and has assisted Irene tremendously in her dramas. She took care of Irene during the show in the Stronghold…"

"No, I'm not referring to acting," Duke Eltek said. "Didn't you notice? She kept asserting power over me."

"Assert power?" Ferlin's eyes grew bigger. "Weren't the two of them simply having a nice chat?"

"Hahaha…" The old man laughed uncontrollably and shook his head. "You really don't understand how nobles deal. Her story regarding King's City

was taken from a legend about the interaction between a commoner girl and a noble man. It's called Cinderella. When discussing politics, she even referred to His Highness' intention to reclaim feudal land. I believe that she knows that you willingly severed ties with your family to be with Irene, or else, she wouldn't have opposed me in every sentence."

"Is… that right?"

Duke Eltek smiled. "Rather than be in awe of superficial things like status and title, you should know that it's one's practical actions which are more important. After talking to Miss May, I've figured out what to do regarding Miss Agatha. Whether or not our ancestors lied, we've returned the items that she entrusted to us wholly intact. Even if she's unwilling to accept us, we can serve her through other means." As he spoke, he sighed loudly. "Although I personally disagree with your view, yet after seeing your life here with Irene, I suddenly realize that these efforts may not be futile after all."

"Thank you…" The sense of affirmation which was revealed in his father's words made Ferlin's eyes well up with tears. Although he was very firm about severing his family ties back then, he still hoped in his heart that his marriage would be endorsed by his family.

However, what Duke Eltek said next astounded him.

"Have you ever considered returning to the Eltek family?"

"What? No, I… you…" Morning Light was stupefied. He opened his mouth but did not know how to reply. "Return to the family? Why would father suddenly mention this?"

The old knight said slowly, "Since you know that your initial decision was a mistake, it's not too late to turn back."

After a long while, Ferlin said cagily, "I feel that my current work is decent, and also the life in Border Town is…"

"I'm not asking you to go back to become a knight in Longsong Stronghold." Duke Eltek interrupted. "You should understand what I mean." He then

enunciated his words. “I want you to inherit the family.”

Kingdom of Dawn swallowed his own saliva. “But brother…”

“Miso Eltek won’t make a good successor,” Duke Eltek said openly. “At first, he wanted to become a renowned knight in Western Region just like you, but after the Duke’s defeat, he lost his direction. As a family of the losing side, we should pledge our allegiances to the new ruler of the city, but your brother continues to keep in close contact with the other four big families, and I’m unable to change his mind about it. You should be able to guess the reason for this.”

“Because he’s sure of becoming the next head of the family.” Ferlin guessed. After he left the family, his father had no other option except Miso to succeed him. This was also probably why his brother gave him the cold shoulder when he returned to the family mansion after so many years.

“This has nothing to do with ability and knowledge. Ability can be developed and knowledge can be taught. But a suitable successor should know how to observe the current situation,” his father continued saying. “Lord Petrov has announced His Highness Roland’s new policies. By also inferring from Miss May’s drama in the Stronghold, which is titled “New City”, I suspect that he’s going to shape the entire Western Region into one entity soon. It’s uncertain whether the four big families will accept this change, but the situation is definitely not calm. At this time, the most suitable thing for us to do is to observe the changes quietly, rather than be used by these families as pathfinding stones.”

Ferlin had heard this news before. His Highness had never concealed his own intentions and policies, and in fact, he would publicize them to his people before implementing them. This included the plan to build Border Town into a city.

However, he did not wish to participate in a contest over leadership of the family. Despite his father’s words, Miso would definitely not take things lying down. Ferlin understood his younger brother’s personality very well.

Finally, he shook his head. “Sorry, Father. I… ”

“I’m not asking you to make a decision now.” The knight gestured with his hands. “After all, I’m still very healthy, and with me around, our family won’t lose its direction.” His smile appeared to have aged somewhat. “If Miso could understand these, I wouldn’t need to say so much. All I’m hoping for is that, should our family ever fall into some kind of trouble, you’ll do us a favor—on behalf of your mother and me.”

This time, Ferlin was not able to refuse.

Chapter 390

Chapter 390: Winter

Translator: TransN Editor: Meh

After Paper finished washing up, she wrung her towel and hung it on the snow-covered balcony.

By leaving the towel outside for a day, it would freeze completely. Before she used it again, all she needed to do was to knead and pat it a few times, and then remove the remnants of ice. Of course, she could also remain warm indoors and use her magic power to vaporize the moisture on the towel, but that would reduce her number of daily practices.

Paper was aware that her body's capacity for magic power was considered to be one of the worst among the witches, hence every drop of it had to be used wisely.

Just as she completed the cleaning work, someone knocked on the door. Almost every day at this time, big sister Wendy would bring her to the castle hall to enjoy a hearty breakfast.

"Coming!"

Paper opened the door cheerfully. It was indeed Wendy who was standing outside—she proceeded to hug Paper lovingly and sniffed her cheeks. "Excellent, you've cleaned up already."

"Hehe." Paper grinned and held Wendy's hand as they walked towards the castle hall together.

It had been nearly half a month since she came to Border Town, and she had become accustomed to the way of life.

Here, there was no need to leave her shack early in the morning to find food, and no need to worry that the firewood she gathered would be stolen. Aside from the time she spent filling her stomach and keeping warm, she could concentrate on practicing her magic power and acquiring knowledge. In the past, she could only imagine having such a life while chatting with her companions. A life where one had no worries about survival seemed to be reserved only for the masters and mistresses of the great noble families.

Paper had never expected that someday, she could also have this kind of life.

Wendy's palms felt soft and warm—a feeling Paper had never experienced while living in the slums. In her present life, Paper felt that there were people who constantly loved and cared about her. She hoped that she could remain permanently in this warm and loving place.

If it was only a dream, she would rather not wake up.

As they walked into the hall, Paper noticed that the witches were not sitting at the long table and eating their meals as usual. Instead, they crowded around a wall and bawled incessantly.

She blinked her eyes in curiosity, but was too embarrassed to ask Wendy what the witches were doing.

However, the latter seemed to read her thoughts, and said, laughing, "Our sisters are testing out their fighting capacities."

"Fighting capacity?" Paper was intrigued. "What… is that?"

"It's something that was invented by His Highness' eccentric rhetoric. Don't take it too seriously." Wendy bent her waist and lifted the young lady onto her shoulder. "See that silver sheet of metal? It's said to be a relic from the witches' kingdom, which existed more than four hundred years ago, and was used by Extraordinaries as a battle weapon. Only those with strong magic power can summon its might. His Highness has placed it in the hall so that everyone can test the level of their magic power, or should I say… to satisfy the curiosity of our sisters. Those who are able to illumine the four magic

stones placed on the weapon in one breath would be considered to have divinely willed fighting capacity."

"…" Paper felt extremely confused. "Witches' kingdom?" "Extraordinaries?" "Magic Stones?" These foreign words left her scratching her head, but that did not mitigate the shock caused by the incredible sight before her—as the witches took turns to place their hands on the metal sheet, the embedded crystals glowed brightly and resembled a kaleidoscope of colorful stars.

"I can illumine two magic stones!" exclaimed Lightning, who was the same age as Paper. On her shoulder sat a stout-looking dove—Paper recalled that the bird was also a witch who was called Maggie around here.

"Two and a half, coo!" Pigeon cried out proudly.

"Aye, you actually did better than me? That's impossible!"

"Do you want to try?" Wendy laughed. "I guess that you won't do very well now. You haven't learnt how to imbue magic power into a magic stone, let alone summon a sigil. But, His Highness has stipulated this as a required course for witches, and therefore, you'll soon be given a Stone of Light to use for practice."

"Would it be as crystal-clear and shiny as these gems?" Paper was suddenly excited. She looked at Wendy and nodded. "I'll practice really really well!"

"Good girl." Wendy laughed and rubbed the young child's cheeks. "Eat first, then you'll have the energy to practice."

…

After finishing her oatmeal, Paper returned to the Witch Tower and began her daily practice.

Wendy had told her that everything on this Earth was formed of tiny balls which the eyes could not see, and material changes were the result of these

balls separating and bonding. One's abilities could only accelerate these processes, rather than simply, for example, melting ice or cooling hot water.

Although she was not able to understand the meaning of Wendy's words, she conscientiously followed Wendy's request—she would feel the magic power that was contained in her own body and released it as evenly as possible. From her earlier years living in the slums, she understood that the fact that she was now able to live a good life was because His Highness required the power of witches—this was her only worth, and therefore, if she did not want to be abandoned, she had to work hard.

Suddenly, Paper felt a twisting pain in her abdomen. Magic power was vibrating inside her body and seemed like it wanted to burst out, causing her to groan uncontrollably.

"What's the matter?" Wendy, who was by her side, asked.

"No, nothing." She shook her head. "Just now, my magic power felt like it wanted to break free."

"Break free…" Wendy pondered for a moment. "Do you remember when you became a witch?"

"It was probably winter," Paper said softly. "I cannot remember the exact date."

"It's now the end of autumn, and winter will be here in a few days." Wendy's smile disappeared. "As we near the Day of Awakening, our body's magic power will become active as a form of bite. Take a rest first. I'll call Nightingale over. She'll be able to see the changes of your body's magic power." She walked to the door, then turned back and added, "Don't worry. For a witch from Border Town, this is not a life and death issue."

…

Wendy's prediction was confirmed.

After three days, Paper was about to have her second Day of Awakening.

Lying on her large bed, she looked around at the circle of witches that had come to visit her. Listening to their gabble of comforting words, she suddenly felt like crying.

The pain of being burned by magic power, which she remembered from her first awakening, seemed to become much more bearable.

“Because your practice time is relatively short, it’s not guaranteed that the pain of the bite will completely go away.” Wendy sat at Paper’s bedside and stroked her hair. “But remember, don’t ever think about giving up, and don’t lose your sense of awareness.”

Paper nodded.

She did not dare to speak up, afraid that the moment she opened her mouth, she would start to cry loudly.

She did not want to disgrace herself in front of everyone.

While living in the slums, crying was seen as the weakest expression, something which only people who gave up would do.

Paper closed her eyes and quietly waited for that moment to arrive.

…

When she opened her eyes, she saw that outside the window was a sea of white.

The bite was weaker than she had expected, such that the various means of rescue which everyone had helped to prepare turned out to be redundant. When she awakened, she felt that her body’s capacity for magic power had increased considerably. Small changes had taken place all over her body. Her eyes could see further, and her limbs possessed greater strength than before.

After she washed her face, she once again heard Wendy knocking on the door.

“I’m coming.” Paper opened the door cheerfully and held Wendy’s hand. However, this time, Wendy did not bring her to the castle hall, but instead, to the Lord’s office on the third floor.

The gray-haired big shot smiled gently at Paper and held a piece of parchment in front of her.

“From today onwards, you’re officially a member of the Witch Union.”

Chapter 391

Chapter 391: The Sigil's Secret

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

After winter arrived, the snow seemed to subside considerably.

Roland was humming a tune as he read through the three manuscripts on his table.

They were, separately, the plan for the trial and production of the latest type of ammunition, the blueprint for the latest generation of small weapons, and the construction plan for the Spellcaster Tower.

The former two manuscripts were ideas which he had conceived for a long time. Now that he could make use of Agatha's abilities to freeze and control temperature, the town's nitric acid output increased manyfold. The problem regarding the stability of the mass production of nitroglycerin had also been solved, and therefore, all of the conditions for the manufacture of double base propellants were fundamentally provided.

Even though Roland knew that this type of propellant was created by dissolving nitrocotton in nitroglycerin, and eventually obtaining a viscous jelly that could be sliced or granulated, he still required an alchemist to test and find out the mixture ratios involved.

Fortunately, Kyle Sichi was already very experienced in conducting both quantitative and qualitative experiments. If this task was given to him, the results should be obtainable in one or two weeks.

Since Roland was already trying to produce a brand new propellant, naturally, the development of a new type of light weapon was also on the agenda.

Compared with blackfire gunpowder, which required the use of a large-caliber revolving rifle, only a small amount of a double base propellant was necessary to achieve an equivalent lethality. Therefore, based on firepower and cost-to-performance ratio, it was definitely better to switch from rifles to light-caliber automatic weapons.

Of course, the specific parameters were to be further determined according to the results of Anna's processing.

Roland drank a mouthful of hot tea and placed the third manuscript in front of him. This was what excited him the most at present.

Compared to the other plans, the contents of this document looked very discordant. At Agatha's request, he planned to build a Spellcaster Tower beside the Witch House and use it for the research and manufacturing of sigils.

He imagined a lofty Magic Tower standing high among the masses of chimneys and factories. It felt simply… too cool and fancy.

Roland started laughing uncontrollably.

Nightingale, who was at one side busy gnawing on dried fish, looked at Roland contemptuously. "Are sigils really so interesting? The witches' kingdom possessed many sigils, yet still lost to the demons."

"But there're some very interesting things inside." The prince took a thick book out of a drawer. It was a sigil collection that was translated from the experimental notes left behind by the Quest Society. It recorded all of the formulas discovered by the Quest Society over more than 200 years.

To him, this was a completely new territory.

After Agatha had completed the translation, Roland spent most of his nighttimes reading the book. As he read about the uses and composite lists of the magic stones, He felt as if he was assembling runewords. Probably, when the Chief Alchemist first received the book of Elementary Chemistry, he carried similar excitement as he studied the different chemical formulas.

“Knowledge that’s new always seems especially attractive, even if it’s only basics.”

“For example?” Nightingale leant over to Roland.

“Like this.” Roland pointed to a sentence in the book. “The ancient witches called this the Sigil of Listening. It is used for long-distance communication, and, like the Sigil of Tracking, it’ll remain effective even if it’s separated into parts.” He shifted his pointing finger downwards. “The materials are very simple. All you need is a piece of Echo Stone and a piece of Marking Stone.”

According to the book’s description, the effective range of this sigil was dozens of miles. Although it could not compare to the mobile phones of later ages, which were supported by many signal towers and satellites, it could still suffice as a walkie-talkie.

“Is it?” Nightingale glanced at the page and then pulled Roland’s finger towards the page on the right. “However, it’s written here that ‘Echo Stones come from Fearsome Demons, and Marking Stones are commonly seen in Devil’s Town.’ How are you going to obtain these two magic stones?”

“No, we already have the materials,” Roland said zealously. “The piece of red crystal which Lightning found in the ruins was an Echo Stone. As for the Marking Stone, it’s one of the composite materials of the Sigil of Tracking—Tilly has brought along a few of this, and they simply have to be disassembled.”

“Even if Agatha is able to create it, you’ll only be able to obtain one Sigil of Listening.”

“Just let her try. Anyway, when we fight demons in the future, we’ll acquire more and more Magic Stones.” It was too bad that, previously, there weren’t the conditions for research on new applications of magic power. Now that Roland had the technical support of Agatha, he was not about to let go of these resources which cost nearly nothing.

“Alright.” Nightingale shrugged. “As for the Sigil of God’s Will, what magic stones does it require?”

“This… I remember seeing it on the last page.” Roland flipped to the final page of the book. “By the way, how was the result of your fighting capacity test?”

Nightingale flinched for a while and then uttered a single word. “Secret!”

She seemed to have been frustrated by Anna.

“Found it, over here.” Roland pouted his lips. “The four required magic stones are all written as unknown… probably, out of confidentiality considerations, the Quest Society didn’t record them in the written form. However, according to Agatha, these magic stones mostly come from the Senior Demons, and therefore, even if they were written down, no one would be able to obtain them.”

“And yet you display such a precious object openly in the hall.” Nightingale groaned. “If the Transcendents find out, they’ll be so angry at you that they’ll even come back to life.”

“Because it’s nothing precious, probably… as precious as a few dozen kilograms of TNT.” Roland laughed but did not reply.

…

This time, he waited until Agatha had completed her production of acid for the day before he called her into the office.

“Have a look at the Spellcaster Tower that I’ve designed for you.” Roland held up his sketch. “The basement is a warehouse, and there are three storeys above ground. They are, separately, the apprentice lab, the tower master’s lab, and the office.”

“Wait… why is it called the Spellcaster Tower?” Agatha frowned. “All I want is a chemical lab like Sir Kyle’s, except a little more spacious and bright. It’ll be very troublesome to build a tower like this. In Taquila, towers

were built only because the land area of the city was small. You have lots of open space here."

"That's not fashionable already!" Roland shouted in his heart. "Anyway, the problems regarding the construction aren't difficult to solve. Aside from the facilities that I have stated, do you have other demands?"

"No." Agatha raised her hands. "If you insist."

"Great." Roland placed the sketch down and started talking about the idea he thought of in the morning. "Can you complete the sigil production alone?"

"No, I can't." Agatha shook her head. "Although sigils are created by linking magic stones, the materials required to transmit magic power are very complicated. Most importantly, it requires the blood of demons."

The prince was stunned. "What?"

"You didn't hear wrongly. And it has to be fresh blood." She said solemnly. "When the Quest Society was figuring out the nature of magic power, it conducted thousands of experiments and eventually proved that the flesh and blood of witches, demons and demonic beasts are completely different in nature, and their functions are also remarkably different."

"The flesh and blood of…witches?" Roland received a shock when he suddenly realized the meaning behind these words. He asked impulsively, "What are their functions?"

"To create God's Punishment Army," Agatha said stoically.

Chapter 392

Chapter 392: Determination

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

Roland widened his eyes and said, “Using dead…”

“No.” Agatha interrupted him. “Just as with demons’ blood, the flesh should be taken from a living witch.”

He heard Nightingale gasp behind him.

“This was the most important secret of the Quest Society. Not long after the experiment began, I left the stone tower of the Holy City. The only thing I knew about the experiment was that it used the blood of weak and old witches, mixed it with God’s Stone of Retaliation, and injected it into the bodies of mortals to make mortal’s body change.” Agatha’s tone was a bit grave. “Judging from the notebook you found, this research must have succeeded.”

“How much blood was needed?”

“More than half.” Agatha’s answer saddened Roland. “The blood must come from the same person, otherwise the magic powers contained in it would reject each other and their effectiveness would greatly decrease.” She paused. “You guessed correctly. A witch died for every experiment, and mortals could barely survive the erosion of the weakened magic blood. In the beginning, no one could survive. A great number of society members objected to it because they believed that mortals could never gain magic power. If not for the insistence of Chief Alice, this plan might not have been carried out fully.”

“But now the church has a huge God’s Punishment Army… According to Tilly’s information, there may be 500 to 1,000 God’s Punishment Warriors,” Roland said, frowning.

“Suppose the success recorded in the notebook refers to the increase of the transformation rate to 10%, it means that at least half of the witches had been killed. I don’t think those people could gather such a large number of old witches.”

“The church arrested and raised witches so that they could drain their blood and create powerful extraordinary warriors?” Roland felt the hand on his shoulder clench involuntarily. “Damn it. Hundreds of witches with all kinds of magic powers died in the Holy City of Hermes for no reason, and they were branded as the Fallen and were loathed by the public. Such an ignorant organization must be destroyed, even if its original intention was to fight against the demons.”

“Rest assured. I’ll stop them,” Roland said word by word.

After Agatha left, Nightingale shut off her Mist and appeared in front of him. She gritted her teeth and said, “I didn’t expect that was how God’s Punishment Army was produced! If the Church really came from the Union, their chief must be a lunatic! ”

“Indeed.” He sighed. “Now it makes sense why the church has been adopting female orphans and abandoned babies everywhere—they were only collecting materials for creating a huge army. Perhaps slandering the witches as Devil’s minions was also part of their plan, in order to justify their treatment of witches.”

“…” Nightingale did not respond, but her face was full of anger.

Roland slightly worried about her. Holding her hand, he said, “You don’t intend to…”

“Pick a fight with the church by myself?” She shook her head. “I’m not that silly. If they were so fragile that they could be overturned by a witch, someone else would have done it long ago.”

The prince felt a little relieved. “The ultimate goal of creating the God’s Punishment Army is to strengthen the church. If there’re extraordinary ones among the witches the church raised, they won’t have to give blood… Even

escaping into the Mist won't guarantee safety when facing witches loyal to the church. When we wage a war against the church, the safest strategy is to push forward step by step following the firearms of the First Army. Whatever the enemies are, they are no different in front of bullets." He paused. "I've said that in the new world, witches will be able to live a normal life without restrictions, just like ordinary people do."

"Hmm." Nightingale whispered, putting her forehead on Roland's head. "I'm sure you can do it all."

****

Wendy sent Paper back to the witches' building and happily returned to the Lord's castle.

Recently, she felt her days were very fulfilling. Although her previous life was quite comfortable, she'd always felt something missing. Now, with this little girl who was well-behaved and full of admiration for her, she believed there was nothing more pleasing than this.

"Winter has come. This is when the witches' awakenings happen the most. In the following months, there might be more new witches joining the Witch Union, so there'll be more kids for me to take care of." This thought excited Wendy very much.

She gently hummed the song she heard from His Highness. But when she pushed open her bedroom door, what she saw startled her.

God, what do I see? Nightingale sits in front of the book table, reading the Natural Science Theoretical Foundation!

Did she fight with His Highness Roland?"

"Ahem." Wendy coughed twice. "I'm back."

Nightingale nodded, giving no response. From the side, her face seemed very upset and sad.

She must have guessed correctly.

Wendy stepped forward, patted Nightingale's shoulder, and softly comforted her. "This is love. You sometimes quarrel, but when you think about it, it's nothing serious. Sleep on it and you'll feel better afterwards."

"What are you talking about?" Nightingale frowned.

"You and His Highness… Fighting is only temporary, so don't take it seriously."

"Why would I quarrel with him?" She said, touching her forehead.

"Uh… you didn't?" Wendy paused. "Then why are you reading all of a sudden?"

Nightingale sighed and told Wendy about the Experiment of God's Punishment that Agatha had revealed to her. "I just feel I need to become stronger to help more in future battles to overthrow the church."

"I see." Upon hearing what Nightingale said, Wendy solemnly nodded. "I didn't expect that the church built monasteries to obtain witches' blood… If it weren't for Ashes, who had suddenly awakened as an Extraordinary and drew all the guards' attention, I'm afraid I would have been among the other corpses in the church."

"Nightingale is right. Perhaps the environment in the castle is so relaxing that I've let my guard down." Wendy suddenly realized that the enemies were very close. Be it from the church or demons, their threats weren't completely eliminated, yet she hadn't improved for a long time. Although her magic power was slowly increasing, her fighting skills and ability to create wind weren't so different from the time when she was in the Witch Cooperation Association, and evolution was totally out of the question.

Sisters such as Mystery Moon, Hummingbird and Echo were studying very hard. Compared to them, she seemed to be slacking off. As an older predecessor, she couldn't even light two Magic Stones on the Sigil of God's Will. If this continued, she would feel like an unworthy elder to the other witches.

“You’re right. I need to study hard as well.” Wendy took a deep breath. She decided that from that day on, she would spend two hours every night before bed learning the knowledge from His Highness.

She went to the bathroom to have a quick wash, returned to the room, and found Nightingale lying on the desk, asleep.

Chapter 393

Chapter 393: New Boats Entering the Water

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

A crowd of people surrounded the temporary shipyard by the Redwater River.

Everyone knew that in the wooden shed some strange boats were being built with shells resembling a huge bathtub. The boats were made of gray cement —a material which was no different from rock after it set. If they were put into water, there would be no trace of it except a splash.

The craftsmen who worked here gave it a proper name: Bathtub Ship.

Today would be when the first two boats went into the water.

The crowd was composed of two kinds of people. One kind was civilians who had just joined Border Town and were curious about the event or felt it unconceivable, so they came to check it out with great skepticism. A great number of them were fishermen and sailors from the Eastern and Southern Territory. The other kind was locals who were used to His Highness' various "miracles". They had heard of the previous Littletown and gathered here in the drifting snow to see His Highness.

Cacusim was among the first kind.

When Cacusim first saw the notice about the test of new boats and the new recruiting order of His Highness, he said he would come and watch the boats entering water no matter what. Vader had no choice but to ask His Excellency Carter for a leave and accompany Cacusim. Considering Cacusim wasn't familiar with this area, and the ground was covered with thick snow, Vader was worried about his going to a crowded place all by himself. If he fell down in a push-squeeze situation, it could mean incurable injury.

“You’re underestimating me, child.” The old man waved his hand, suggesting Vader not to follow him. “I’ve been through winds and waves. Although I’m getting old, my physical condition isn’t much worse than yours.”

“Sure, sure,” Vader said carelessly. “I’ve already asked for leave, so any rejection is too late. I just don’t quite get it—why do you have to come and see this thing enter water? It’s only a boat.”

“But you said it was made out of gray stone.” Cacusim shook his head. “Have we entered a time when even a bathtub-sized stone could float on water?”

“It’s my own fault.” Vader thought. “I shouldn’t have mentioned the notice at the square.” “Maybe His Highness was only bragging. Probably it’s a wooden boat with a few parts made out of that… cement.”

“That’s even more unlikely.” The old man insisted. “Think about it—when was this wooden shed built?”

“About… over a month ago.”

“That’s right. It’s before when you were recruited as a policeman. When we first moved to the Inner City here, this place was still empty!” His beard shook. “It took a month to build the shed, so it means building the first boat only took half a month.”

“Uh, isn’t that normal?” Vader was bewildered.

“Of course not!” Cacusim exclaimed, “In the name of the Sea God! I’ve never seen a boat that could be built within half a month. It’s not a matter of size—for any type of sailing boat, processing keels alone would take more than a month, because you must wait until the wood is totally dried to then curve it with steam. This is a very complicated process that can’t be completed in a short time.”

Vader was very surprised. “Why are you so familiar with shipbuilding?”

“I was once a captain, child.” The old man sighed. “When I was young, I used to sail with lots of goods through Seawindshire and the Port of Clearwater, and I reached as far as the Kingdom of Dawn and Fjord Islands. Then something happened… and now I’m here. ”

“You’ve never told me any of that.” Vader said with his eyes wide open.

“You’ve never asked, child.” Cacusim shrugged.

“Alright.” Vader shifted his attention to the shipyard. “So what you’re really curious about is the technique His Highness used to build a sailing boat within half a month.”

“Any captain would be curious.” Cacusim touched his beard. “If His Highness isn’t lying, do you know what this means?” One or two years later, his fleet will be sailing through all the rivers in the Kingdom of Graycastle.”

Vader’ heart twitched. “You don’t intend to…”

Cacusim smiled, “I can’t always eat your oatmeal.”

“His Highness never lies.” Someone nearby suddenly said. “Besides, that’s not a sailing boat.”

Vader turned around to find that the speaker was a young man. Judging from his accent, he seemed to be a local Western Region resident. “Not a sailing boat?”

“No. It can travel without wind and at a speed faster than any sailing boat.” “The young man continued proudly, “Have you seen the steam engines in the mines? They can easily drag a basket of ore out of the mine hole. These cement boats are driven by those steam engines, and according to His Highness, they’re actually steam-powered boats!”

“Travelling without sails?” Cacusim said with disbelief, “Kid, that’s nonsense. If a boat has no sails, it can only rely on paddling. Such a boat can never travel faster than a sailing boat. Besides, they’re not in the water yet. If you haven’t seen it, how can you be sure that they can move in water at all?”

“Of course I’ve seen it,” said the young man. “You must be newcomers from other territories, so it’s normal if you don’t understand. In the summertime, I modified a steam-powered boat for a Caravan across the strait. But the boat was still wooden and not as durable as those cement ones.”

Vader intended to argue more, but that young man’s eyes suddenly brightened up. Pointing to the shipyard, that man said, “Look over there. His Highness is here!”

Cheers and applause erupted from the crowd as all the people raised their hands to greet the Lord.

Prince Roland went up to the temporary wooden platform next to the shipyard, conveyed a few congratulatory words, and then announced the entering water of the new boats.

With rhythmic chants, the workers opened the wooden shed towards the Redwater River. A boat with a 40-meter-long gray hull slid down the river levee, collecting snow, and plunged into the icy water.

Vader felt his heart jump into his throat. He thought this thing would sink directly to the river bottom, but to his surprise, after the rear half entered the water, the front lifted up and splashed with foam.

The crowd burst into applause again.

“Gee, it really floats up.” Cacusim froze in shock. “But is it really made of stone?”

Vader had the same question—the surface of the Bathtub Ship looked so smooth, as if it was made of finely polished granite slabs seamlessly connected together. The hull of the boat looked like one whole piece. The boat cabin was shallow and it had no decks, so there were no places for the crew to sleep. Furthermore, the boat bottom was too flat for masts to be fixed on. As its nickname indicated, this thing looked exactly like a bathtub.

Either way, His Highness had indeed managed to produce the boat within half a month.

Vader looked at Cacusim and found his eyes glinting with excitement.

“I want to apply to be captain,” said the old man.

Chapter 394

Chapter 394: The Seed of a Navy

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

…

Roland watched the second cement boat slip into the water with satisfaction His subjects cheered loudly.

The two cement boats looked simple in terms of structure, but they were actually much better than previous models, namely the Littletown. A framework of dense steel reinforcement had been added to the internal structure, and the quality of the cement had improved tremendously. The overall strength of the boat was thus several times greater than the Littletown.

To expedite the shipbuilding process, Roland reserved slots and ports for steam engines, transmission mechanisms and paddle wheels when he designed the hull. This way, laborers only needed to weld bolts into the metal components. They could quickly build the boat putting pieces together like a jigsaw puzzle.

Meanwhile, the mold was now made of iron rather than temporary masonry. This change not only guaranteed a high density of the poured concrete, thereby improving the boat's waterproof performance, but it also ensured that each boat was almost exactly the same. This helped to avoid errors when installing the power system. In order to create a complete design of the mold, Roland had scrapped at least seven or eight testing samples. Fortunately, cement was no longer scarce these days. Steam engines had replaced human labor, from stone grinding all the way to kiln feeding. It was the only large-scale industrial project that did not rely on witches' abilities in Border Town.

With ample materials, reliable molds and skilled laborers, the only factor that limited the production of hulls was the hardening rate of cement.

However, with the help of Paper's reaction acceleration ability, it only took one day (rather than the original one to two months) to launch a cement boat. In other words, the shipyard could launch an unpowered vessel every two or three days if Roland wished to.

If the speed of steam engine manufacturing could catch up with that of crew training, he would most likely develop a huge shipping fleet in a short period of time and fill the Redwater River with his own cement boats. They would look like "dumplings in boiling water".

That was the appeal of industrialization.

Now that the hull had been completed, the next step would be the installation of power units. The mechanical equipment was pretty much the same as those on the modified boats of the Chamber of Commerce at Crescent Moon Bay. The craftsmen already had practical experience, so he didn't need to worry about it.

"I don't understand. Why did you tell these things to subjects?" Nightingale asked.

"To advertise the national power." Roland smiled faintly.

"I'm sorry?"

"I mean to behold the tremendous changes the town has gone through." The prince stroked his chin. "You probably never expected a boat made of stones could float on the water before seeing the Littletown. My subjects think the same way. After realizing what is impossible, they'll have a greater sense of township. It's a comprehensive upgrading in mentality, which can even turn into a belief that there's nothing they can't achieve."

"I don't quite understand." Nightingale sounded a little confused.

"You just see it as a means of propaganda, and that will do," Roland smiled and said. In this era, the nobilities only celebrated with civilians for big events or ceremonies, both of which were almost entirely noble affairs. If it weren't for the free food, many civilians wouldn't attend. Nevertheless, the

cement boats were the combined work of hundreds of laborers, and they were part of the festivities.

After witnessing constant miracles, members of the territory would gradually develop their confidence and sense of identity, collectively referred to as "superpower mentality" in later generations. Once a territory had become powerful and prosperous, the mentality of its subjects would inevitably experience positive changes.

…

A week later, Roland met over twenty townies who had applied for the captain's position in the castle's hall.

He was quite surprised at first when Barov reported the number, as he did not expect there would be so many "top-notch talents" among the refugees taken in by this town. When he read the detailed report that he couldn't help laughing. There were quite a few fishermen who operated rafts and small fishing boats, even some boatmen who made a living providing ferry services. They could indeed be regarded as "captain", in a sense.

Among all the applicants, there were only three people with experience operating sloops on the inland river, one of whom claimed that he used to work as a commander for a merchant fleet, and had earned a living on the sea for a long time.

Roland thought for a while, then decided to recruit all twenty people.

Steam-powered boats belonged to a completely different system from that of sailboats, and were also operated in a distinct way. Even an experienced captain would not necessarily learn the operation of paddle steamers that fast. Besides, he knew nothing about operating a boat himself, so it would be better for them to learn as they went.

Since he was starting from scratch, he needed to be resolute and have the courage to explore.

“I’ve reviewed your applications,” Roland glanced at the group of people kneeling in the hall, “Today I’ve summoned you here to tell you that you’ve passed the preliminary assessment, and have gloriously become the first group of captain interns. Please rise.”

“Yes… Your Highness,” all the people rose gingerly, exchanging looks with one other. They looked rather confused about the term “captain intern”.

The prince took the initiative to explain, “Being an intern means you haven’t been officially hired yet. You’ll only get half of the salary stated in the post until you are officially on board, ten silver royals a month. The first two months will be the learning period, during which you will get yourselves familiarized with the performance, operation method and procedures of the new boat. The third month will be the trial period, during which you’ll be assessed in terms of your learning ability. Only the qualified ones will be promoted to official captains and paid full salary. Those who aren’t willing to accept these terms can leave now.”

Nobody in the group moved. After a while, an old man suddenly spoke, “Your Highness, who’ll teach us and who’ll assess us to see if we’re qualified?”

Roland cast him a glance with great interest. He was the one who claimed to be an experienced fleet commander. His name appeared to be Cacusim. If Roland remembered correctly, he was a relative of the policeman from the assassination case two months ago. Judging from the old man’s tone, Roland could tell that he didn’t think there was anyone qualified to teach him how to operate a ship. Indeed, there was none.

“The ‘teachers’ will be yourselves,” the prince nodded and said.

These words caused a stir among the group.

“Your Highness, what does that mean?” Cacusim asked, confused.

“How much do you know about steam engines?” Roland replied with a question. As he expected, not a single person could answer. “The steam-powered boat is brand new in every aspect. Your past experience will not

actually help much, therefore you need to explore and find a way yourselves. Of course, I'll send the craftsmen from the steam engine plant to assist you in familiarizing yourselves with machines." He paused for a little bit and said, "The assessment approach is very simple. Those who are able to operate the boat with a group of sailors and complete a transportation task will be regarded as qualified."

Although the saying 'It takes ten years to build an army and a hundred years a navy' was exaggerating slightly, it did indicate the difficulty in building a navy. If this group of people could master the operation of the steam-powered boat, they could for sure foster a large group of capable crews for the Western Region. These crews could be directly employed to build steam-powered shallow water gunboats later.

He wondered what kind of navy it would turn out to be.

Chapter 395

Chapter 395: Deep down inside the Winter Forest

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

Leaf passed through the branches and foliage looking for Lightning and Maggie.

In actuality, she was not exactly passing through them, but moving just her vision—her body was integrated into the thick forest.

It was an amazing feeling. She felt like a bird, except a bird would fall to the ground if it wasn't flapping its wings, whereas she wouldn't. As long as she maintained this form, she could cross from one end of the Fusion Forest to the other instantly. Of course, compared to the entire Misty Forest, the range that Leaf could cover now was just a drop in the ocean.

Ever since her ability had evolved, she had longed to experience the Misty Forest to the west of the town. If she could control this vast forest it would be of great help to His Highness, whether it was fighting against demonic beasts or collecting goods and materials. There wasn't much she could do for His Highness in return. Apart from improving crops, this was the only thing she could do, so she wanted to be good at it.

Compared to the castle's back garden, this was a real forest. Its complexity was far greater than the ecosphere of the castle's olive trees and grape vines and beyond comparison. There were numerous creatures hiding beneath every inch of earth. Looking down along the roots of plants she could sense dormant animals, squirming insects, and decaying remains, along with tiny babbling streams.

To prevent losing herself, Leaf expanded her territory with great caution—starting from the city wall on the west, extending little by little each day. Once she completely adapted to an environment, she would then try to control a new plot of forest land.

At this rate, she could cover the entire Misty Forest within two or three years.

Shortly after, Leaf found two people hunting in the forest. If she had been walking in the snow instead of flying above the treetops, she would have noticed them sooner.

“I found some prey,” said Leaf, shaking the branches.

“Ah!” Lightning patted her chest after a shudder. “You scared me!”

“Coo, coo!” Maggie nodded repeatedly.

“Sorry.” Leaf revealed herself through a tree trunk, just like a twig growing out of the branches. “Is this better?”

“Well, at least I’m not talking to a ghost.” Lightning landed quietly. “You can appear anywhere in the forest at will?”

She nodded. “As long as it falls in the territory that’s under my control.”

Maggie landed right on Leaf’s back, walked a few steps back and forth, and even pecked where her body and the trunk joined. “You’ve even grown into a tree, coo!”

Feeling her back tickling, Leaf couldn’t help laughing. “Because this is my ability,” said she.

“It feels a little weird, coo.”

“How can you call someone else weird? You’ve turned yourself into a giant demon bird.” Lightning rolled her eyes and looked at Leaf. “Where’s the prey?”

“Follow me,” she said, turning her head.

Leaf couldn’t sustain a human form while moving, instead she made vines grow up from the ground to lead Lightning and Maggie on the way.

“What kind of prey?” Lightning asked.

“A big boar that ran out of the depths of the forest,” she replied. “Do you really want to catch it yourself? I can just tie it up with grape vines and throw it at the foot of the city wall.”

“Of course. Explorers seek more than just results.” The little girl raised her head. “The process is sometimes more memorable than the outcome.”

“I’m good as long as there’s meat to eat, coo!”

Leaf could not help smiling. The two of them had already become frequent visitors to the Misty Forest before she had integrated into it. They hunted in the forest to practice their magic powers, and Maggie would carry all of the prey they caught back to the castle. Half of the meat on the table these days was provided by them.

“Look, there it is,” said Leaf.

There was a huge boar squatting down by the stream, lapping up the cold water. With large, sharp tusks at the side of its snout, and a raised mane that was almost finger-length, it appeared to be a tough enemy. Hunters would normally stay away when coming across such an animal, but it was just a feast in the witches’ eyes.

“I’m ready,” said Lightning, who pulled out her dagger.

“No gun?” Leaf asked in surprise.

“That would be too boring.” She wiped her nose with great confidence and rushed straight toward the target.

“Good luck, coo!”

The little girl’s figure, like a streak of golden light, sprang onto the head of the boar from behind. As she rose, the boar shook its head fiercely, bursting out a high-pitched scream.

“She missed it?” No… Leaf noticed one of the boar’s eyes had become a bloody gash. It seemed that Lightning was planning to take advantage of her flexibility and first eliminate the threat of counterattacks from the enemy, and then exhaust it through a battle of attrition.

The boar was as clumsy as a stone facing Lightning’s attack from the sky. It soon fell to the snow without the strength to resist.

She whistled, “How was that?”

“Good job,” Leaf said. She tied the boar’s rear legs with vines and hung it up. “First let’s bleed it out. His Highness says meat without any traces of blood is tastier.”

“Purr.” Maggie’s mouth was watery. “It’s gonna be a big meal tonight, coo.”

“Wait… ” Leaf suddenly sensed there were other creatures entering the forest. She looked toward the edge of the controlled area and saw two grey wolves approaching.

She frowned, something was wrong. This type of animal usually lived deep within the forest and wouldn’t normally come so close to Border Town, even in the winter.

She was just debating whether she should tell Lightning when a familiar figure suddenly appeared before her eyes. Leaf felt all her hair stand up as she remembered the tragic battle she had experienced in the Barbarian Land.

“Demons!”

She saw two demons slowly walking in the direction of the city wall. There were no Magic Stones on their arms, nor spears on their back, so they weren’t carrying any weapons. However, Leaf noticed that they both wore a black iron glove, the same weapon that had killed Red Light.

“Why would demons come here?”

With great horror and uneasiness, she turned to Lightning and said, “Get out of here, quick! Demons are coming!”

“What?” Both of them were slightly startled.

Leaf briefly told them what she saw and urged them on, “Hurry up. They don’t have a mount and can’t catch up. I’ll come later.”

To her surprise, Lightning hesitated for a moment and then shook her head, saying, “I’m staying here to fight them.”

“F… Fight?” Leaf was stunned and asked, “Why?”

“If I run away from the enemy now, how can I defeat them in the future?” The little girl took a deep breath, pulled the gun from her waist and said, “My father told me to get up from where you fall. I won’t run away any more.”

Chapter 396

Chapter 396: The Fierce Battle

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

“The explorers will never be afraid of the adventures, but they will definitely not take an adventure recklessly.

Demons are not that horrible because they can also be killed. And they have a huge weakness—they can’t survive without Red Mist.

Leaf once used the crossbow bolts to kill a trapped demon. Nightingale managed to kill the enemy under a very unfavorable circumstance.” Lightning secretly cheered for herself and she believed that she could also make it.

“We should first report this to His Highness,” Leaf said hurriedly. “Comparing with us, both Nightingale and Ashes are much more experienced in fighting the demons!”

“But, the demons may have already left by the time they reach here.” Lightning checked the pistol’s cartridge to ensure that it was filled with bullets and said, “By letting such dangerous enemies wandering around the border, we’ll face much more serious risks.”

“I… can stay and keep an eye on them.”

“What if they walk out of your control area,” the little girl insisted and continued, “and if you try to stop them, you’ll end up exposing yourself. Three of us might as well work together.”

Leaf relapsed into silent. She seemed to be persuaded.

“Coo coo!” Maggie stood on top of Lightning and flutered her wings.

“Alright,” she scratched the pigeon’s neck and said, “we’ll each take care of a demon.”

“What did she just say?” Leaf asked.

Lightning pouted and said, “She said she wants to break the head of the enemy with her claws and pound the flesh into a meat pie with her wings. Finally, she will toast it in the fire to find out how it may taste like.”

“She just said ‘Coo’ twice!” the latter questioned.

“It’s basically what it means.” The little girl nodded earnestly.

“An excellent explorer is not only extraordinarily brave but also has the ability to lead the entire team, helping them to relax when they are nervous and keeping them when they are over relaxed. I’ll try my best to follow your words, father.”

Lightning shook her wrist and the cartridge was closed. Trying not to look nervous, she pretended to look calm and said, “How far are they away from here?”

“About three hundred meters away from our right.” Leaf answered.

“I should have seen the enemies if I was not blocked by the woods.” She was thinking that she definitely had the advantage of taking the first shot, and the pistol obviously outperforms the Magic Stone due to its long range. “You can trap the demons with vines, right? Just like last time at the Barbarian Land.”

“I believe I should be able to trap them for a short period of time.”

“OK. We can attack from the sky.” Lightning said, “It’s the last direction the enemies will notice. They will temporarily focus on the vines only. We can end this fight in seconds.”

“I… understand.” The leaves shook slightly. Perhaps because there were too many related horrible memories when Leaf was in the Witch Cooperation Association. But Lightning had no time to worry about this at this moment. She would probably lose her courage if they kept waiting. After all, she and

Maggie were the ones that fight the demons. But Leaf would hide in the woods. She wouldn't be hurt no matter how the demons attacked the vines.

"Let's get started!" Lightning flew right into the sky.

"Coo!" Pigeon was following right behind her.

The forest instantly looked like green and white patches below her. The little girl put on the goggles given by His Highness and she felt braver right away.

"They're over there." Maggie transformed into a Gray-tailed hawk and found the targets just after seconds of searching—with her hawk eye, she would never even miss a running rabbit in the snow.

Lightning took a deep breath. Thunder and His Highness flashed upon her mind. She shook her head and made her mind clear. With her hands holding the pistol grip, she said, "I'll take care of the left side and you, the right side. When we are half way through then you turn into the giant-winged bird again."

"Leave it to me. Coo!"

"Go!" The little girl shouted and then began to dive in. With the cold wind roaring through her cheeks, her ears were hurting. She moved her head a little bit into the scarf. Thinking of the shooting method she learned from Nightingale, she pointed the flintlock forward. The effective range of the bullet was about 100 meters, but it was clear that she should move as close as possible to make sure the target would be hit. Assuming that Leaf's information was right, the demons' iron gloves must be inlaid with the electrical Magic Stone. Their magic range was around five meters, almost the same as the witches'. It was the best choice to shoot them at a distance of seven to eight meters.

The enemies' figures became clearer. And she could see their horrible headgears and scarlet masks. Suddenly, a demon stopped to look up and roared towards them. "Are we… exposed?" Lightning's heart sank. "Why does the enemy act as if they can perceive her?" At the same time, countless

vines rose around the demons. They twined the enemy's legs and continued to climb upwards. Finally, the enemies were totally twined by the vines.

A white flash shined from Maggie's body and she turned into a huge monster instantly, diving and screaming at the same time to show her strength.

"Whatever." Lightning grit her teeth and decided to speed up again. When she was about fifty meters from the enemies, she took a sudden turn and rushed down to the back of the enemies like a shooting star—she could only hit the heads of the enemies if she shot straight down, while she could expand the shooting area if she shot horizontally. And Nightingale had also repeated many times that she should fire on the widest body part of the enemy.

The demon struggled to lift his right hand twined by the vines. Dazzling light burst out from his iron gloves. Almost at the same time, Lighting pushed down the trigger. A huge boom suddenly went through the sky above of the forest.

As she expected, the attack range of the Magic Stone was really limited. The blue and white arc light just existed for a very short time. With the sounds of gunshots, blood mist burst out from the back of the demon—the bullets not only went through its body but also smashed the gas bottle on its back.

However, Maggie was not as lucky. Another demon hit her body with its lightning. Sparks burst out from her body and her mighty screams turned into terrible ones. She curled up her wings and then heavily fell down on the demon, kicking up large snowflakes. When they hit the ground, Lightning felt the ground shaking. It was probably because of the severe impact, the demon's gas bottle was smashed and Red Mist was overflowing from under the giant bird. The little girl was very anxious and worried, looking at this.

Leaf reacted immediately. Dozens of vines gathered on Maggie's body and moved her away from the demon. The giant bird rolled in the snow twice, and lay still with her face on the ground.

Lightning rushed towards her. She held her giant head, shaking it and said, "Wake up, Maggie! Are you alright? "

“Coo… I feel numb,” Maggie opened her eyes. She transformed back into her human shape with her magic power faded off and said, “what just happened?”

Lightning checked every part of her body, feeling relaxed after confirming her safety and said, “I’m glad that you’re alright.”

It seemed that in the shape of the flying giant monster, Maggie would not be hurt by the blood mist and she could endure more harms with her giant body. The electric arc just knocked her out for a moment, and there was a demon right below her as a cushion when she was falling down. It was a frightening attack but she was barely harmed. This could be the best out of the worst.

“Both of them are dead.” Leaf moved half of her body from the trunk, examining two lifeless demons and said, “What should we do next?”

“Bring the bodies back,” Lightning said, “His Highness should know how to deal with them.”

Chapter 397

Chapter 397: A Close Study

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

Hearing the news, Roland was shocked.

Rushing after Leaf he couldn't even attempt to question her further until they had reached the castle's backyard. As he stepped out of the castle he saw Lightening dragging two dead demons off of Maggie's back.

"Your Highness, look, we won!" Seeing the prince, the little girl jumped up straight into Roland's arms. "We defeated the demons!"

"No one is hurt?" Roland asked.

"No, everyone is fine." Lightning looked up, her eyes sparkling with eagerness and hopes of praise. Her metaphorical tail wagging was with excitement.

Roland sighed. Seeing her look of sheer joy made him reluctant to point fingers. So, instead of asking why no one had reported seeing the demons he decided to say, "I am glad there are no injuries, but what just happened exactly?"

The three witches all replied at once. Roland had to listen for a long while before he was able to piece together what had happened.

The way they told it made the fight seem easy and it was over quickly. However, there were many moments that could have ended in disaster. If Maggie had not been able to withstand the impact of the electric arc, or if the demons had been able to shake off Leaf's restraints, the consequences would have been unthinkable.

“Don’t you ever do anything like that again.” Nightingale couldn’t keep quiet any longer. Stepping from the cloak of her mist as she said, “To fight with demons is to leave us. With Sylvie, there is no escape.”

“But we won,” Lightning said while pouting.

“I call it dumb luck. Before the fight did you know Maggie was going to be hit?” Nightingale countered sternly, “I taught you to use a gun so you could protect your sisters and self. Instead, you drag them into danger!”

“No…” Lightning dropped her head in contrition and said, “I was wrong.”

“And you,” Nightingale said turning to Maggie, “You know you are obligated to fly back and report and yet you chose to stay? If you make a mistake like this again I won’t give you anymore dried fish!”

“Sigh…” Maggie’s head drooped, too.

‘Nightingale is indeed the toughest witch fighter Border Town has to offer,’ Roland thought, giving Nightingale a glance of approval. Then he said, “Well, as long as it was just this once. Go and bring Tilly and Agatha to me. It’s time for us to examine our new trophies.”

…

In the castle’s basement, on the cold stone floor lay two bodies stripped bare, their shabby clothes and meager belongings stacked beside them.

“Are they demons?” Tilly inquired while covering her nose, hoping to block the fetid stench.

“They don’t look stronger than ordinary people,” Ashes said, twitching her mouth.

Agatha looked glum. “Don’t underestimate them. Any demon is a tough opponent, with or without magic powers. A senior demon or even a Transcendent would wear a God’s Stone of Retaliation,” she stated frowning. Looking over at Roland she then said. “They really showed up near the town?”

“Pretty much, Leaf said they were less than two miles from the town’s city walls.” Roland nodded his response while looking at the bodies displayed before him.

The demon bodies were tall, over six feet, they had stong powerful limbs, and their skin was a shade of light blue. One of the bodies appeared to be severly mutilated and the organs could be seen peeking from its collapsed chest. It looked almost as if it had been crushed by a steam roller. This in combination with Lightening’s narrative, Roland could almost see the great impact that had caused the damage.

The other body was in better shape and the only visible damage was two puncture wounds. He could still see the demons blue blood trickling from the perfect holes. Of the four shots Lightening took, only two had hit their mark, fortunately they were fatal.

The blue blood makes sense since demons don’t need oxygen like humans, they have no need for hemoglobin. Technically a demons blood could be any color.

And their massive bone structure was also logical. It was necessary to support their height and powerful frame.

What is confusing is their striking resemblance to humans, minus the reproductive organs.

“How do they… reproduce with their own kind?” Roland asked Agatha curiously, “Don’t they have gender differences?”

“To my knowledge, no, they don’t,” she said shaking her head. “It has been an unsolved mystery for me. No one can get close enough to Red Mist tower to find out. There is speculation that they were born in the tower, formed by the mist. However, the Quest Society rejected the notion claiming that the demons were regenerating and every battle was with the same demons, in different forms. They called it the ‘regeneration upgrade phenomenon’.”

“Regeneration upgrade phenomenon?” Ashes frowned and asked, “what is that?”

“Some of the demons that were severely wounded by our witches would again appear on the battlefield. Based on the pattern of the wounds, we could tell they were the ones that had been beaten previously even though their forms had changed. This implies that Senior Demons were not born but instead likely evolved through battle. Once they reach their full upgrade their forms would change.” Agatha explained.

‘Well… the magic stone technology by itself is worrying enough, and now the enemy seems to have the ability to upgrade from battle. No wonder they defeated the human beings in the last two Battles of the Divine Will.’

Roland squatted down to have a closer look at the demons’ stacked clothing and belongings.

Fortunately, it did not look as if they had anything that could be considered advanced. Their belongings actually looked a little out dated. The clothing was a mix of animal skins and ugly primitive weaves. The ferocious masks were actual skulls from demonic hybrids, clearly not manufactured.

Even the transparent portion embedded into the eyes of the skulls were no more than a polished crystal, tinged and clouded from the Red Mist. While wearing the masks, they would only be able to see a bloody red shadow. How did they learn to fight with something like this?

In addition to the clothes and masks, there were a dozen black slates and a few magic stones.’

“Has the Quest Society ever seen anything like this?” Roland asked Agatha as he laid out the slates, side by side, they made him think of the towering buildings in the red mist. A few of the slates had distorted red marking, while others had nothing you could see with the naked eye.

“That’s the way demons keep records,” she nodded while answering, “and they record with magic too, so we can’t decode their meaning at all.”

“Maybe the way they think is completely different,” Tilly suggested.

“That’s a possibility,” Rolland agreed, “and what about the magic stones?”

“Stones of Perception, Stones of Pathfinding… and Stones of Marking,” Agatha answered while glancing over them, “Nothing precious. They are only basic equipment for Scout Devils.”

‘Scout Devil…’ Roland felt a dull pain in his head as he asked Agatha, “Does it mean that the demons have already noticed this place, and have started to send their scouts to the town?”

Chapter 398

Chapter 398: Puzzle

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

“Don’t bet on it.” Agatha shook her head, “Based on what we experienced during the second Battle of the Divine Will, if they wanted to investigate a human town, they wouldn’t act this carelessly.”

“What does that mean?” asked Prince Roland.

“To make sure information makes it back to Red Mist tower, this type of reconnaissance would be conducted by two or even three platoons. Quite often the soldiers rode demonic beasts and acted as a unit, under the protection of Spear-wielding Demons,” she said slowly. “In order to destroy the investigative platoons, the Union would often send out flying witches to block their rear and they would send out twice as many Blessed Warriors as there were demons for a head on assault. In the last war, the investigative platoons just kept growing in numbers and even Fearsom Demons and Flying Demons joined the recon. It would be odd for them to send out only two ordinary Mad Demons to investigate. Not to mention they were unprotected and really poorly equipped.”

“Maybe they don’t think it is necessary to send large platoons to investigate Border Town and that only two ordinary demons would be enough?” Ashes suggested.

“That doesn’t make sense,” Agatha said after a thought, refuting Ashes’ theory. “During the time of the Union, every town near the border, no matter how small it was, would be protected by witches. Since the demons couldn’t possibly know of the changes that have happened in the human world over the past 400 years, they would have been more cautious and investigated like they had done previously.”

“So you think… they were not here deliberately but found the town by accident?” Roland couldn’t help but relax at the thought.

“Very likely.” she frowned and seemed to be pondering something. “The demons probably had no idea the town was even here, but it’s more likely they were scouting the area surrounding their camps. It’s unlikely they thought they would meet anything more than a few demonic beasts. That would explain why they only carried Stones of Lightning for protection, instead of Stones of Unifying Strength which manifest spears that can not be used continuously.”

“Wait… ” Roland was startled, “You think there are demon camps near by?”

“Of course. What other reason would cause them to be out this way?” Agatha stated simply. “They must have established strongholds on the Fertile Plains and from there spread into the Barbarian Land… Oh, I forgot it is now called the Four Kingdoms.”

‘Awe, Hell, that’s a big problem! If the enemies establish themselves under my nose, how will the town survive?’ The prince worried to himself. He then asked aloud, eyebrows raised, “Are they like the camps behind the snow-capped mountains?”

“Yes, they are pretty much the same. During the war, there were several storage towers to store the Red Mist at each outpost. Each tower was guarded by 100 to 200 demons.” Agatha stated while nodding, “Considering the Bloody Moon hasn’t arrived yet it is not likely that they have built a new Towering Stronghold on the Fertile Plains. Since it isn’t easy to transport Red Mist the camps are probably small.”

“What are you going to do?” Tilly asked, looking at Roland with concern.

“First, we find the camp—see if it really exists,” he paused and said, “then… we wipe it out.”

“A decisive choice,” said Ashes, smiling. “That’s indeed a lord’s decision, and don’t worry, we’ll help too.”

‘If Agatha is right, before the third Battle of the Divine Will officially starts, demons are unable to spread their influences to the whole Fertile Plains. Given that, once the camp near the Western Region is eliminated, there will be at least a few years’ peace during which demons won’t have the ability to strike back even if they wanted to.

However, this plan could be risky due to the fact it would inform the demons that there are humans who live to the east of the Misty Forest and reveal that they have the ability to take the initiative and attack the demons.

If I leave the camp alone, it’ll expand and cause me even bigger trouble. First, they’ll probably send out more demons here after they realize those two Scout Demons are missing, and after that, it is just a matter of time before they find the town. Second, if it is a larger camp, the demons will just increase in number and attack the town whenever they desire. Even after the Months of Demons has passed, which is very dangerous. How can I expect the First Army to complete their spring plan of attack if they are trapped in the town, busy constantly fighting demons?’

When Roland returned to his office, he immediately sent for Lightning and Maggie and quickly gave them a task,

“Please remember that you are never to act without authorization. Once you find the camp, fly back here immediately. Don’t engage the demons in battle, they may have flying beasts on hand. Your first priority is to keep yourselves safe.”

“Yes!”

“Coo!”

He paused before adding, “If you do find the camp, you’ll be rewarded with ice cream bread for dessert after every meal this coming week.”

Maggie stretched her neck and said, “You can count on us, coo!”

…

Three days later, Roland received Lightning's report. Out in the Barbarian Land, there was a place suspected to be a Demon's Town, it was located about 130 kilometers away from Border Town.

After roughly mapping out its position, he noticed that it was right in front of the route that the Witch Cooperation Association used to follow. This was less than ten kilometers away from the place where the Association was attacked by demons.

"What do you mean when you say 'suspected'?" he asked Lightning. "Have you not seen their black stone towers?"

The little girl shook her head, her expression perplexed, "I have only seen what appears to be… wreckage."

"What?"

"What I saw was crushed black stone, broken fences pieces, and… a huge hole in the ground," she continued while rubbing her forehead, "the place looks like the one where Agatha found the relic. I didn't track any demons though. After surveying the destruction, I flew back here immediately."

"'Another hole?' Roland was stunned, 'Are there giant maggot-like beasts inside this hole too? Last time, there were maggot-like beasts with the relic and they devoured the stone towers remains, this time… did they swallow the demon camp as well?

Did I miss some important clue that links those two events?'

He shook his head and pushed aside the puzzling pieces and asked, "Did you find anything else?"

"No… the camp was deserted. There were no demons there." Lightning replied.

"And no sparkling magic stones either, Coo!" Maggie added.

"I see," Roland mulled over the information he had been given and then quickly began to make arrangements. He looked over at the white haired girl

and said, “You take Nightingale and Soraya to the suspected camp site and get pictures of the scene. Then escort Nightingale and Sylvie there so they can check it out further.”

“Why not just let Soraya and Sylvie go there together?” asked Lightning.

“Just in case the demons have flying beasts that Maggie can’t get rid of,” Roland explained briefly. “Nightingale can use her Mist to help you escape. In any dangerous situation, you just get out of there as quickly as possible.”

…

Soraya’s “photo” of the scene was soon placed in front of Roland.

Just as Lightning had described, there was a massive crater in the ground, stretching five to six meters across, with broken debris scattered around its edge. The fringe of the hole looked almost like the earth and been churned from below. The snow and dirt were mixed, along with various pieces of the crushed black stone and that was exactly how it looked, like it had been crushed by a massive creature.

Sylvie’s findings made him even more uneasy—the underground passage there led towards the snow-capped mountains, the same direction as the one relic they found in the Misty Forest.

Both tunnels led to the same place.

Chapter 399

Chapter 399: Contact

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

In the basement of the palace, King's City, Kingdom of Graycastle.

Timothy sat on the throne with his cheek resting on his right hand. He watched impatiently as the candidates performed their assassination stunts.

"How many fools have I watched since winter begin?

I must have been too lenient recently, to have allowed these clowns to perform."

He sneezed and felt the dryness in his eyes.

Ever since the Hall of Sky Dome was destroyed by snow powder, Timothy had moved the venue of the Council Meeting to the basement of the palace. After some renovation, including opening up several storage chambers, the total space was large enough to accommodate all of the Council's ministers and nobles. Most importantly, this place was absolutely safe. There was only one entrance, and the magnificent palace was directly above. No amount of snow powder could disrupt matters in here. The only disadvantage was the lack of sunlight, and thus light had to be supplied using turpentine torches. The torches, which were placed on the surrounding walls, caused the air in the room to become abnormally dry and stuffy. Furthermore, the turpentine gave off a sweet yet foul smell which made Timothy feel drowsy.

Whenever he thought about his Fourth Brother, Timothy would become furious and spiteful. Had it not been for the eyewitnesses who noticed that the attacks came from the sky, Timothy would probably still be building guard towers recklessly. After he realized that this method was completely ineffective, all he could do was to hold his meetings in this place for the time being.

“Roland Wimbledon will surely pay for this!”

“Your Highness.” The voice of a candidate disrupted his thoughts. “Have a look. If that traitor Roland ever dares to appear in front of me, I’ll accomplish the mission that you’ve entrusted to me!”

Timothy took a swift glance at the candidate. In a split second, the candidate landed four flying knives accurately on a barrel that was twenty steps away.

“Is this the stunt that you mentioned?”

“Indeed, Your Highness,” he replied assuredly. “Frankly speaking, I was in this line of business previously. I’ve killed dozens of Rats using this method. If I hide in a crowd, most of my targets won’t even know where the knives are flying out from.”

“How much do you want?” Timothy shifted his stiff body a little.

“Just 25 gold royals,” the candidate counted his fingers and said, “five of which will be used to cover the cost of my journey and my disguise—I’ll dress in a common and unattractive fashion in order to get closer to the traitor.”

“Knight Weimar.” The King beckoned.

“Yes, Your Highness.” Steelheart Knight walked into the hall, brandishing his saber and shield.

“Your Highness, what do you mean by this?” The candidate was startled.

“If you defeat my knight, I’ll give you your reward straight away.” Timothy winked at Knight Weimar.

The latter nodded his head. Then, he took off his head armor and walked towards the candidate.

“Wait, wait… no, Your Highness, this won’t do.” The candidate flipped his body distressedly to dodge the knight’s incoming slashes, and stammered, “I can’t fight head on! Ah!”

The knight swiftly followed up with a vicious kick to his stomach, causing him to swallow the rest of his words.

After rolling on the floor for a while, the candidate flimsily flung a flying knife at the knight, but it was easily deflected by the knight's shield. The knight stomped on the candidate's hand and, using his sword, sliced off half of the candidate's arm. Blood spilled on to the ground in a curved line.

"My hand…!" the candidate cried in pain. He held onto the remainder of his right arm and coiled his body.

"Firstly, the royal family isn't as dumb as your average target. Even that foolish brother of mine won't easily go near crowds. And secondly, if you can't even handle a knight, what makes you think you're able to assassinate a lord who's protected by many knights? I'm afraid that once you receive the 25 gold royals, you'll never be seen again." Timothy gestured with his hands. "Throw him out."

Had it been a month or two ago, he would not even entertain this bunch of ignorant and greedy people. He had given a small sum of money to those whom he deemed to have a slight chance of succeeding—yet until now, Roland was still alive and kicking.

It was probably because of this 'benevolent' attitude that caused more and more people to come forward and declare that they could solve the problems created by the traitor, and the methods they proposed became increasingly absurd. There was even a fella who suggested using a tavern maid as the assassin, claiming that her technique was outstanding and that no man could refuse her service. "Utter ignorance! Don't they know the difference between a normal female and a witch?" It was already well-publicized that Roland had raised and groomed several witches, so there was zero chance that Roland would fall for someone so cheap.

Timothy let out a long sigh. "By teaching these ignorant candidates a lesson, perhaps others will think twice about coming forth.

Maybe it was a mistake to recruit an assassin from the citizenry.

The only things that could defeat Roland are pills and snow powder."

He swept a glance around the hall, and, seeing that there were no outsiders remaining, he asked the Prime Minister, "How's the progress of the development of the snow powder weapon?"

According to successive intelligence gathered from Longsong Stronghold, the reason that Border Town miners were able to defeat the Duke's knights and the mad militia was because they used an unusual snow powder weapon. It was, in all likelihood, a semi-closed iron pipe which made use of the force generated by the explosion of snow powder to propel a lead shot towards the target, similar to how a crossbow worked. Timothy was highly interested in this, and had immediately gathered the experienced blacksmiths of King's City to begin creating an imitation of this unique weapon.

"Not ideal, Your Highness." Marquis Wyke shook his head. "The blacksmiths have created 10 or so prototypes of this weapon in accordance with the intelligence, but none of them have anywhere close to the alleged firepower. Only a few can penetrate a knight's breastplate within 10 steps, while all are inaccurate over 50 steps."

"10 steps?" Timothy frowned. "Might as well aim at the face, no? At this rate, how are we going to stop the charging knights?"

"Indeed, there may be some tricks we have yet to master… Another thing, even if we gather all of the city's blacksmiths and apprentices, we can at most produce 20 of these weapons per month, and there's no guarantee that every one of them will work." The Marquis sighed. "Until today, there have been four cases of iron pipes exploding during training, and the guards are rather reluctant about training with this kind of snow powder weapon."

Damn it. Border Town was several times poorer than King's City, yet Roland was able to produce hundreds of iron pipes in one winter. He must have received the assistance of demons.

Timothy angrily switched the topic. "How about the pills? Hasn't the church replied to us yet?"

“Yes, Your Highness.” The Marquis responded. “The High Priest said that Holy City was busy fighting the invasion of the demonic beasts, and therefore temporarily unable to provide more pills of madness. He hoped that we could wait until after the Months of Demons to discuss things.”

“I don’t want to see the traitor remain peacefully in the castle of Western Region, not even one day longer!”

“Looks like I have to personally write a letter to the Holy City of Hermes,” Timothy thought spitefully. “In the future, if they want to continue recruiting believers in the Kingdom of Graycastle, they’ll have to bring pills for exchange.”

Just as he was about to announce the end of the day’s Council Meeting, the Minister for Diplomacy, Sir Bullet, suddenly walked up to him and said, “Your Highness, messengers from the Kingdom of Dawn have arrived in King’s City, and they wish to see you.”

Chapter 400

Chapter 400: Alliance Agreement

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

“According to the customary practice, the reception of messengers from other kingdoms should be conducted in the Hall of Sky Dome. However, it was only recently cleared of rubble from the collapsed ceiling and is still a long way from restoration.” As Timothy thought about this, his resentment against Roland grew.

“Bring them to my study,” Timothy ordered. After a brief hesitation, he decided to receive them in the palace anyway. No matter what, it would be rude to receive messengers in the basement.

He was clueless as to why the Kingdom of Dawn would send messengers to the Kingdom of Graycastle at this time, especially with no prior notification. Had it been one of the other two kingdoms instead, it would most certainly be a request for aid—either for food or materials to resist the winter cold. There was a saying among the nobility that people who made contact in summer were friends, while those who did in winter were enemies. It held true among all of the kingdoms, except for the Kingdom of Dawn. Although its territory was small, it did not lack in materials, and, in fact, it sold a large amount of food and cloth to the Kingdom of Graycastle every year in exchange for perfumes and crystals.

Timothy shook his head discreetly. He had many things to attend to and therefore intended to dismiss the messengers as early as possible.

When he returned to his study, he saw that the two members of the emissary delegation had been waiting for a long time under the companion of Sir Bullet. Upon seeing His Majesty enter the room, they stood up and bowed. “To the honorable king of the Kingdom of Graycastle, Wimbledon IV, the king of the Kingdom of Dawn sends his regards.”

“Bring him my regards too.” Timothy nodded inattentively. “Have a seat.”

He noticed that the pair of messengers, which comprised of a man and a woman, was very young and looked rather alike. The family insignia on their chests was an antler scepter, and if he did not remember wrongly, this meant that they came from the illustrious Luoxi Family of the Kingdom of Dawn.

“What exactly is Mia IV thinking? Why did he send these young ‘uns?” Timothy felt rather curious. Nobles of this age were typically haughty and arrogant, and were vastly different from older nobles who would fight for every little bit of benefit on the negotiating table.

“Are you both members of the Zulu Family?” Timothy pointed to their chests. “I once briefly met Duke Luoxi.”

“Indeed, Your Highness.” The young man smiled. “I’m Otto Luoxi. This is my younger sister, Belinda Luoxi.”

“They’re even siblings.” Timothy raised his eyebrows. “If that’s the case, I don’t have to beat around the bush with them.”

“It’s currently the massacre period of the Months of Demons. Why did the king of the Kingdom of Dawn send you here?” Timothy took the lead and asked. “I guess you are neither short of cotton and cloth, nor of wheat and bread. And of course, even if you met with a disaster, the aid that I can provide is very limited—you should know that the Royal Decree on the Selection of Crown Prince has left my kingdom in a mess. Many places have come to a standstill, and just helping the refugees has stretched the City Hall thin. It’s very difficult for me to pull out more supplies.”

“With regard to this, I express my deepest regrets,” Otto felt his chest and said. “However, Mia IV did not send us here to request aid, but to respond to an even more dangerous threat.”

His words startled Timothy. “What threat?”

“The church, Your Highness,” Belinda replied. “Currently, the Church’s army has seized the Kingdom of Everwinter and the Kingdom of Wolfheart, and

large numbers of refugees have swamped into the Kingdom of Dawn. According to the information the refugees brought, the church's methods are abominable and in serious violation of the rules of engagement agreed among the nobility. Those who resist are either hanged or exiled, while only the nobles who agree to switch allegiance are allowed to live."

"This method intends to completely eliminate the noble class and bring the territories under the full control of the church," Otto spoke in a rather heavy tone. "Mia IV believes that the Kingdom of Wolfheart won't be their last target. Given the critical situation that both our kingdoms are in, the church is likely to bring the flames of war to our lands in the coming year. Our king hopes that we can work together and fight back against the church."

"Are you sure that Wolfheart City has already been captured?" After hearing from the other party, Timothy began to frown.

"A thousand times sure, Your Highness." The two messengers nodded in unison.

Timothy had caught wind of the church's aggressive war, but he did not expect that it would be able to seize two large kingdoms in such a short period of time. If the messengers were not lying, the strength displayed by the church was a little too frightening.

Certainly, it was best to verify this matter with the Minister of Intelligence first. The early arrival of snow during the Months of the Demons had impeded his caravan's route, and thus he had not received messages from the Kingdom of Wolfheart for a very long time.

After a long silence, Timothy asked, "What's the specific plan?"

Otto moistened his lips and pulled out a map underneath his arm. Spreading the map in front of Timothy, he said, "If the church sets off from Holy City and attacks the Kingdom of Dawn or the Kingdom of Graycastle, then the other kingdom should lead an army towards the north and invade the Holy City of Hermes. Doing so will suppress the church's offensive and divide its troops."

“Is this an offensive-defensive agreement?”

“Indeed, Your Highness,” Otto replied. “No matter the starting point is Coldwind Ridge of the Kingdom of Graycastle, or Northshire of the Kingdom of Dawn, it’ll be possible to reach the Holy City of Hermes in a week’s time. As long as our main forces are stationed in these two places, the church may decide to retreat wisely—it’ll be a blessing to both kingdoms if we can prevent this war from happening.”

“If that’s the case, I might as well forget about buying pills from the church.” Timothy thought silently. “But without them, how am I supposed to drive Roland Wimbledon out of the Western Region?”

Timothy understood that precautions had to be taken against the church. But he felt that it was best to first purchase the pills he needed and unify the entire Kingdom of Graycastle before he reached an agreement with the Kingdom of Dawn.

“This is a matter of great importance. I’ll need to consult with my ministers before I decide. The two of you can stay in the palace while you wait for my decision.”

“Sure, Your Highness.”

“There’s another thing I would like to ask. How much do you know about the situation in the Kingdom of Everwinter and the Kingdom of Wolfheart? Did all of the information come from refugees by word-of-mouth?”

“There are a few reports from spies, but not many… When the church sieged Broken Tooth Castle and Wolfheart City, it also sealed off the surrounding roads. That’s why we don’t know much about the progress of the battle,” Otto replied. “According to the refugees, the church used a terrifying siege weapon which demolished the walls of Wolfheart City in only one day.”

“It was probably a snow powder weapon, which was possibly revealed from Garcia’s side.” Timothy gestured with his hands and asked, “I’m not interested in this. Have you heard of any news about the Blacksail Fleet or Garcia Wimbledon?”

“This…” The two messengers exchanged glances before Belinda said cautiously, “We heard that when Garcia was fleeing from King’s City together with the King of Wolfheart, she was struck by the church’s arrows and perished.”

“Garcia was with the King of Wolfheart?” Timothy’s heart skipped a beat. “Was her body found?”

“Not that we’re aware of. Judging from the church’s publicity after the siege, as well as the lack of news from the Kingdom of Wolfheart, it’s highly unlikely that they managed to escape.”

“Really…” Timothy exhaled and felt a little relieved. Although there was a bit of regret, this was one of the few pieces of good news he had heard since winter arrived, and he hoped that the messengers were right. “Okay then, you two can go and have a rest.”

As the messengers took their leave, a smile began to form on his face. “Hear that, Roland Wimbledon? This is the kind of demise which, as a fellow insurgent, you’ll end up in as well.”

Chapter 401

Chapter 401: Winter in the Fjords

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

In the sea of the Fjords lies Sleeping Island.

The skyline turned a pale yellow as the last of the highrise buildings was finally completed. Although the setting sun was not visible, one could still see a streak of golden light reflected on the sea's surface by the sunset glow that passed through the clouds. Only the harsh cold gusts of wind, which blew directly at one's face, gave away the fact that it was no longer autumn.

"And it's done." Lotus lifted up the scarf around her neck until her ears were also covered by the soft cotton. "This will be our new home once the furniture and beds are moved in."

"Fantastic!" Durat Kimshoe clapped and said. "That's a lot of houses built in half a month. And I thought Lady Tilly was exaggerating."

"Lady Tilly doesn't lie," Breeze added.

"Indeed," Durat stroked his thick double chin and said. "If that's the case, I'm reassured about resettling my citizens over here. Oh, what's this?"

The merchant who came from the Crescent Moon Bay analyzed the groove-shaped parapet that was in the house. Bending his body, he even stuck his head in the hole to take a look inside.

"This is a warming device that I learnt about in the Western Region. It's called a heated brick bed." Lotus explained. "It's connected to the kitchen, and hence when a fire is started in the kitchen, this bed will also turn warm. "Add a wooden plank on top and cover it with linen or straw, and you can use it as a bench or a bed. It'll be more comfortable than your typical furniture, especially in the current season."

“Interesting design,” Durat said and glanced squarely at Lotus. “If I wanted to hire you for the long term, how many gold royals would it cost?”

“What… do you mean?” Lotus was slightly astonished.

“Follow me to work in the Crescent Moon Bay. There remain several wastelands which have yet to be developed in my territory. Your abilities will prove extremely useful.” Durat rubbed his hands and said. “How many gold royals do I have to pay the ‘Sleeping Spell’ in order for Lady Tilly to authorize you to follow me?”

“Sorry, I’ve never thought of leaving…”

“Your life over there will be much better than it is here,” Durat interrupted quickly. “You’ll get to live in the same large compound as me, enjoy fine wine and cuisine from the Four Kingdoms every day, and have attendants accompanying you wherever you go. That’s the ideal life that many people envision, and I’m giving it to you as long as you work for me. Besides, Lady Tilly has said that the requests of the ‘Sleeping Spell’ must be fulfilled, and I’m able to afford your recruitment fees no matter how high it is.”

Lotus frowned. She was not unfamiliar with his kind of attitude. Although verbally, he said that he was hiring her, it felt to her more as though she was being bought. Just as she was about to bawl out a few sentences, Breeze gently tugged on her hand. “Even though the requests must be fulfilled, it doesn’t mean that it’ll be accepted. There are some things that even witches can’t do. Besides, all parties have to approve before an agreement can be made.”

“You mean that money alone isn’t enough? I’ve never seen a deal like this,” Durat spoke with displeasure. “Was what you said when you cast the ‘Sleeping Island’ mere rhetoric to make fun of us? “No one will believe or be interested in you if this goes on.”

“I doubt so,” someone responded from behind. “There’s only one witches’ guild that offers rewards, whether it be in the Fjords or the Four Kingdoms. If you don’t come, there will be others.”

“Who speaks?” The merchant turned his head and received a rude shock. “Y… Your Highness Thunder!”

“I came up with some of the ideas for the regulations of the ‘Sleeping Spell’. Before a contract is signed, the consent of the employee has to take into consideration the possible risks associated with the tasks. They’ll not be forced to venture into grave danger,” Thunder said in a clear voice and laughed. “Do you have an issue with this?”

“No… this is definitely reasonable.” Durat’s facial expression restored to normal. “Then… I’ll still have to trouble you in the future, Miss Lotus.”

“Phew.” Lotus watched the merchant and his entourage make their departure, and sighed in relief. “Thanks.”

“No problem, I was just passing through.” Thunder laughed. “Didn’t you follow Lady Tilly to the Western Region?”

“Yes, but I came back early together with Honey and Breeze, because Sleeping Island needed to prepare supplies and houses for winter.” She gave him a simple account of the matter. “Have you completed your expedition?”

“Hahaha, yes… it was an incredible and unimaginable trip.” Thunder’s eyes lit up as soon as she mentioned his expedition. “This was the first time I saw different sea levels occurring at the same time. Our ship seemed as though it was flying. We didn’t ‘fall’ into the sea when we advanced past the cliffs that were formed by the waves! If I hadn’t seen it myself, I absolutely wouldn’t believe that such a strange sight could be real.”

“Different… sea levels?” Lotus murmured. “How could it be? The sea water ain’t rocks. Wouldn’t it flow downwards?”

“Hmm, I named it the ‘Sealine’, and it’s located to the northeast of the Shadow Islands. When we reached the top of a cliff, it would appear like a long line which we couldn’t see the ends of, and the sea would seem to be divided into two distinct sections.” He patted his chest excitedly. “I can’t wait to venture even further next time!”

It was indeed worthy of the most prominent explorer in the Fjords that the first thing he talked about upon his return was regarding his adventures, and not regarding his daughter who was far away in the Western Region. Lotus shook her head helplessly as she watched him talk on and on.

Before darkness fell and the temperature outdoors plunged, Lotus had already climbed early into the heated brick bed. This was the most relaxing moment of her day. For more than a month, she not only constructed a new batch of houses but also renovated the creaking houses of other witches. Crowding on to the heated brick bed with everyone else and chatting about her experiences in Border Town, the questions from her companions – which were borne out of a mix of curiosity and envy – ensured that she did not get any sleep for half of the night.

The conversation topic shifted to the Bird Beak Mushrooms.

Her companions started to salivate when she mentioned how she prepared them. She would place the mushrooms in some butter and flip them a few times, then fry until both sides of the mushrooms were golden brown in color, and finally sprinkle a bit of salt on top to create a most delicious dish.

“Mmm… I feel like eating this,” Shadow exclaimed. “After eating dried fish onboard for a month, my mouth is full of a salty and fishy smell.”

“Great,” Molly could not help interrupting Lotus. ” If only I was the one whom Lady Tilly’s elder brother invited.”

“Hey, there are even more amazing things you haven’t heard.” Someone giggled. “In the showers of Border Town, the water comes straight out of the wall, and the scented soap makes your whole body smell great after showering.”

“There’s really something like this?” Shadow asked curiosly.

“Of course, and I even brought one back.” Lotus curled her lips upwards. “But it has been used up.”

“Don’t talk about it. At least they got to experience it. I followed Lady Tilly to the Western Region and then immediately brought these girls back here. I didn’t get to enjoy anything!” Breeze bemoaned.

As she listened to the witches’ gabbling discussions, Lotus suddenly had a thought.

If it was instead His Highness Roland Wimbledon who wanted to hire her long term, would she have agreed?

After contemplating for a while, she realized that she would not be able to refuse if it was indeed Roland.

What an embarrassment!

Lotus tucked herself inside her quilt and glanced left and right. Luckily, the lamp was already extinguished, or else someone might have realized what she was thinking about.

However, when would Lady Tilly finally be able to accept His Highness Roland?

It would be great if they could stay together forever. Lotus held the cloth tightly in her arms. If so, it would be good for me and the other witches, as we would all be able to live happily in Border Town.

Chapter 402

Chapter 402: Organizational Structure

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

At the beginning of the second month of winter, Barov walked into Roland's office, carrying a stack of books under his arms.

As he walked up to Roland's table, a huge color painting on the table caught his attention. "Is this… a map of the entire Western Region?"

"Not just the Western Region," Roland said, laughing. "It also includes a portion of the Barbarian Land and the Misty Forest, especially this space over here." He pointed to an area in the northern part of the Impassable Mountain Range—it was the Fertile Plains that Agatha had talked about. "At present, the area that we've already discovered is equivalent to three Western Regions. If we manage to cultivate the land of this large space, we can resettle hundreds of thousands of people."

In order to eliminate the threat that came from Devil's Town, he had sent Lightning and Maggie to comb through the area and draw up a map. Now that Maggie could carry Soraya while she did the drawing, more accurate maps could be drawn. Although the disappearance of the Devil's camp was still a mystery, the good news was that there was no sign of another enemy camp within 200 kilometers of Border Town.

"In the Barbarian Land, there aren't only demonic beasts, but also… scary enemies, like you said." Barov's words came with a hint of hesitation. "Won't it be too dangerous to cultivate the land towards the northwest?"

"By that time, the First Army will most likely be equipped with the power to fight demons." Roland slowly swiveled his finger around the plains on the map. "It won't be safe anywhere if we're unable to defeat these enemies."

Ever since demon scouts were spotted in the Misty Forest, he knew that he could not conceal this information for long. In order to prevent the panic that could be brought about by a sudden revelation, he first disclosed the existence of demons to his top brass. Judging from the current situation, the reaction of the people were fairly normal. Of course, he had slightly downplayed the strength of the demons by asserting that they were of the same ilk as demonic hybrid beasts, while he did not divulge the history of the two Battles of Divine Will.

Roland knew that his kingdom could not remain on the mainland border forever if it wanted to be on par with the Four Kingdoms. Only the Barbarian Land… or should we say, the Fertile Plains, was a land area that was worthy of his governance. In fact, the area that had been explored was only a tiny fraction of the entire plains. One could imagine the vast amount of land that humans occupied during the second Battle of Divine Will.

He retracted his finger, then rolled up the map and placed it to one side. “Do you have any news to report?”

“Yes, Your Highness.” Barov nodded and then spread the books that were under his arms in front of the prince. “I’ve drawn up a plan for the City Hall’s expansion according to your demands.”

“Oh? I’ll have a look.”

In order to cope with the rapid growth of territory after the establishment of the city, Roland utilized a futuristic classification of his government’s functional departments, and thus set a new framework for management organizations of his time. Overall, the upper sector of the government was divided into four main branches, namely the City Hall, the military, the Security Bureau and the Witch Union.

Under the expansion plan, the new City Hall would assume the role of the cabinet or State Department, and would be the core institution of the entire territory. In time, the personnel would increase to approximately 500 people. Its six departments would be finance, foreign affairs, education, agriculture, industry and law, while new departments could be added at any time according to demand. Moreover, if (or when) the Kingdom of Graycastle was

reunified, all of the other cities could follow this template and set up corresponding lower sector institutions, and together they would be managed by the City Hall.

In addition to its battle staff, the military also had independent production and medical departments that served as logistical safeguards. Every military division had a commander-in-chief who was responsible for specific combat matters, but the supreme authority of the military rested with Roland himself.

The Security Bureau was a secret organization which hid in the dark. Its funds were not allocated by the City Hall, while its members were also not recorded in any dossier. Its primary functions were to monitor and ensure the security within the territory and handle issues of official corruption.

Lastly, the Witch Union… Roland had thought hard about this organization but eventually decided that it would be a separate department, instead of sorting the witches into the other departments.

This was because, for some of the witches, their abilities would increase dramatically after evolution, and then they would be able to work across multiple departments. For example, Anna and Soraya could both play important roles in industry, agriculture, military, and education.

Another reason was that there would be times when a witch would not be assigned any work, and therefore, classifying them together could effectively avoid dampening their enthusiasm. This was a point that Scroll and Wendy had brought up to him.

Roland hoped that in the future, the Witch Union would operate on its own, which included handling its membership, inspection and work allocation.

“Are you really able to hire so many literate people?” After he finished reading the City Hall Director’s proposal, Roland raised his head and asked. A 500-person institution was considered enormous in this era. Plus, the requirement that every employee had to be literate would almost certainly be impossible to fulfil in other territories. Although the royal city of each kingdom might have sufficient literate people, these were in large part nobles who were too proud and arrogant to be willing to serve as apprentices.

“Add in the fresh batch of graduates and there shouldn’t be a problem,” Barov replied. “According to the feedback from the recruitment notices, jobs in the City Hall are the most popular.”

“It seems that being a civil servant is popular everywhere… ” Roland arced his lips upwards uncontrollably. “In that case, go ahead and recruit people according to this scheme. The next and final task is to formulate laws.”

“Pass me the principal article that you mentioned the last time, and I’ll have my apprentices complete the rest as fast as possible,” the City Hall Director said in high spirits.

“It’s called Basic Laws,” Roland said and laughed. It appeared that enthusiastic “model workers” were not only confined to witches—this was a good sign for a new regime.

“Another thing, Your Highness,” Barov said. “If the City Hall is expanded according to the plan, the current building may not be able to accommodate so many people. Can… ”

“You want to build a new City Hall?” The prince nodded in agreement. “For sure. I’ll arrange Karl to see to it.” In the eyes of the citizens, this was the face of the lord. While they rarely had the chance to enter the castle, they would often settle matters in the City Hall. Thus, a certain degree of splendor and style was necessary. If it was austere and unembellished, the people’s confidence in him might erode.

After Barov took his leave, Roland called his guards to bring in Prius Dessau, the knight from the Elk Family.

Roland had not seen him for half a year. The knight was visibly fatter and his face fuller than usual, while his cheeks even glowed a bright red. Life had certainly been good.

“Recently, there’s been more eggs and poultry in the Convenience Market. This’s all your credit.” Roland smiled. “Your way of raising chickens and ducks must be great.”

“Hehe…” Prius laughed, somewhat embarrassed. “Without your support from the start, I couldn’t have done any of this.”

Farming was not a smooth journey. When Prius first started, the fowl plague even appeared and caused the death of many chickens. Roland simply thought of it as a good lesson and did not give up on him. Instead, the prince continued to buy baby chicks from the Stronghold and passed them to him for raising. Presently, he had become an indispensable talent of the town’s community.

“I plan to recruit you in the City Hall under the agriculture department. Do you agree?”

“Your Highness, you… don’t want me to continue raising chickens and ducks?” Prius was slightly surprised.

“Of course not. You’ve been doing a great job, and therefore, I hope that you can bring more people into this business.” Roland said encouragingly, “Soon, I plan to expand the scale of farming by more than ten times. Then, you and your family won’t be able to handle it alone. After you’re recruited in the City Hall, you can pass on your experience to more people and teach them how to farm.”

Given Lily’s ability to eliminate bacteria and diseases, the most thorny problems of animal husbandry ceased to exist. Apart from chickens and ducks, large livestock such as cows and lambs were also within the prince’s expansion plans.

“This is undoubtedly a noble job that’s no less honorable than knighthood.” The prince paused for a moment and then continued speaking. “There’ll be a day when eggs and poultry will be served on the dining tables of every household in the Western Region. And when people see these delicious foods, they’ll all remember your name. What do you think?”

“I’m… willing to serve you.” Prius Dessau clenched his fists and bowed respectfully.

Chapter 403

Chapter 403: Student and Teacher

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

…

Nana yawned loudly as she got off the bed.

She glanced at the whiteness outside the window. Still, she could see nothing but snow.

Reluctantly, she moved out of the warm bed and put on her thick winter coat. As she trudged out of the bedroom, she saw Aunt Alda tidying up the living room.

“Good morning,” she muttered.

“Ah, little princess, you’re awake.” Alda smiled at her. “Want breakfast? It’s ready.”

“Yes.” Nana sat beside the dining table and ran her eyes around the room, but she did not see her father. “Where’s Daddy?”

“Lord Pine went out early in the morning,” Alda replied from the kitchen. “He was carrying his silver shotgun.”

“Indeed.” Nana curled her lips upwards. “He’s probably gone to the city wall to practice shooting again—ever since he fended off the demonic beasts with the flintlock, he has become enamored by this loud and booming weapon. Not only does he wipe a gun barrel every day, but also he’ll go to the city wall to practice whenever he has time. Furthermore, he managed to apply for a specially-made flintlock from his Highness using my healing abilities as a bargaining chip.

It's all His Highness' fault for saying that long shotguns are the standard equipment for hunters," Nana thought. "If Mummy's still around, Daddy probably won't go out all day long like this."

"Breakfast's here." Alda placed two steaming plates on the table in front of Nana. "Fried eggs and white bread. Eat while they're hot."

"Thank you."

Breakfast's normally prepared before Daddy leaves home. Only Aunt Alda would specially place it in hot water to keep it warm. If instead, Daddy took care of me, I'd be eating cold and hard eggs.

Nana sighed uncontrollably.

If only Aunt Alda could marry Daddy.

But the young girl knew that this wish had little chance of happening. Alda was the family servant while Daddy was a noble of Border Town—as far as she understood, it was difficult for a commoner and a noble to get married.

She devoured the delicious breakfast, wiped her mouth, and shouted. "I'm going to the medical center."

"Okay." Alda put down the broom she was holding, and led Nana to the door. As she bent down and tied a scarf around Nana's neck, she said, "Be careful on the road, Miss Pine."

"Yes, Aunt!"

White snowflakes greeted Nana as she made her way out of the house.

This was her daily routine: In the morning, she would leave home for the medical center. She would treat the patients if there were any, or else, she would practice her abilities on animals. At noon, she would go to the castle to have lunch with Roland, while in the afternoon until night time, she would remain in the medical center, after which she would return home—she was the only witch who did not live in the castle.

Although time in the medical center was boring, she persisted because she wanted the patients to receive treatment as quickly as possible. The smile and warmth of the townspeople also supported and pushed her on.

“Lady Nana, good morning!”

“Miss Angel, going to the medical center again?”

“Today’s weather ain’t good. Do take care of your body.”

“Miss Pine, have you eaten breakfast? Why not have a bowl of hot oatmeal that I just prepared?”

Greetings like these continued incessantly whenever she walked in public. It was a stark contrast to a year ago. Her sisters claimed that she was currently the most popular witch in Border Town, even more popular than Anna. Nana wasn’t concerned about a popularity contest, albeit she was happy with the current atmosphere. Every person whom she had treated before would greet her affectionately, and this filled her with a sense of achievement.

“Elder sister Anna was right,” Nana thought. “The only way to change people’s prejudices was to face them adamantly.”

When she arrived at the medical center, the First Army soldier who was manning the gate bowed and greeted her. “Hello, Miss Anna.”

“Good morning, are there patients today?”

“Not at the moment,” the soldier replied. “But your friends have come.”

“Friends?” She was surprised. “Could it be Anna?” As she thought of Anna, she excitedly ran up to the second floor and pushed open the door, only to find Mystery Moon, Hummingbird, and Lily idly lying on the table. On noticing her, the three of them immediately got up and surrounded her.

“You three… ”

“Haha, are you pleasantly surprised? We came all the way just to see you!” Mystery Moon raised her arms and exclaimed.

“Mystery Moon suggested that instead of lazing about in the castle, it would be a good idea to come out for a walk,” Hummingbird added.

“You two may be free, but I’m certainly not. I still have many insect samples to observe.” Lily, who was standing at the back, lamented. “Nana must be very busy as well. You think that she’s like you?”

“Is that so? Yesterday, I peeked and saw you dozing off in front of the microscope. You were obviously sick of your job.” Mystery Moon shrugged her shoulders.

“Nothing of that sort!”

Nana was slightly disappointed that it wasn’t Anna who turned up, but she quickly buoyed up. At present, Anna was His Highness’ busiest subordinate, and naturally, could not spend as much time with her as in the past.

“No, I’m in fact very free,” she replied, laughing. “Thank you, you three.”

“Ahem… since you say so, I shall remain behind to accompany you.” Lily turned her head. “It won’t be a problem to observe the samples tomorrow.”

“What are we gonna play?” Hummingbird questioned.

“What else?” Mystery Moon took out a pack of playing cards. “Of course, this!”

“Aye, ‘Fight the Landlord’ may be interesting, but it’s a three-player game.”

“No, not ‘Fight the Landlord’.” She shook her head uncannily. “A new game that’s suitable for four players, where we compete to see who can show her cards the fastest. I learned it from Andrea’s group only yesterday!”

“The three-player group of the Sleeping Island?” Lily said, holding her forehead. “You learn poorly from others, yet still choose to learn from this bunch… had you used your energy to learn new knowledge from His Highness instead, you won’t have made so little progress until now.”

“This was also handed down by His Highness.” Mystery Moon retorted. “Why’s it not considered part of His Highness’ new knowledge?”

“Other than you, there’s probably no one in the Witch Union who thinks this way.” Lily stared at her for a moment.

“I’d like to learn as well… ” Hummingbird mumbled softly.

Nana watched the conversation going on, and laughed uncontrollably. She felt like she was back to the carefree days when she attended Teacher Karl’s academy.

…

Under the company of the three witches, the morning time, which was usually boring, passed quickly. They then went to the castle for lunch together, after which Nana returned to the medical center alone.

As she stepped into the hall, she saw someone unexpected.

Karl Van Bate.

“Mr. Karl!” Nana said in surprise. “What brings you here?”

“To see you.” Karl smiled and gazed at her, and then said happily, “You… have grown up.”

“Is that so?” Nana lowered her head, as if embarrassed. “I’m still a long way from Anna.”

“Everyone’s different. You have your strong points.” He laughed. “Watching you and Anna grow up, as well as observing the town’s changes, it seems that I can no longer see the cracks.”

“What cracks?” Nana was confused.

“Nothing… I’m just spouting nonsense.” Karl shook his head. “I used to believe that the god had forsaken this world, but now, I feel that it continues to watch over us.”

“Not a god,” Nana corrected him. “His Highness says that these are the fruits of human efforts. Weren’t those residential communities built by you?”

“But without an origin, nothing could have happened. At that time, when I thought that Anna was dead, and you somehow awakened as a witch, I was utterly flustered. It might have been a God who heard my prayers and answered my call.” Karl said in a gentle voice. “It brought us His Highness Roland.”

Chapter 404

Chapter 404: The Journey to Magnetoelectricity

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

“Ah… I envy Nana so much.” Mystery Moon wiped her wet hair and drew her face close to Lily who was sitting upright at the desk.

“Hmm,” Lily replied without even turning her head.

“You don’t ask why I envy her?”

“You’ll soon fill me in anyway,” Lily said, twitching her mouth.

“Damn it!” Mystery Moon mumbled, but could not help saying in the end, “Didn’t you see how the soldiers at the hospital and the townsmen nearby treat her?”

“Saw it.”

” ‘Hello, Miss Nana,’ ‘Are you leaving, Miss Angel?’ ‘Miss Pine, this is the wheat cake I made,’ … I want to be treated like that, too!” Mystery Moon pressed her face onto Lily’s cheek, but was pushed away relentlessly.

“That’s a return for her ability,” Lily said without turning a hair. “Didn’t you notice that ever since the Months of the Demons, she’s been staying at the hospital almost every day, waiting to treat the wounded? Half of the locals have received her treatment, and the rest are pretty much their families.”

“You’re exaggerating.”

“Not really,” Lily said with a sigh and put down the book in her hand. “Although not everyone will fight against demonic beasts at the city wall, it’s perfectly normal for townees to get injured—miners can hurt their toes by ores; kiln labors can get burned. The same applies to the apprentices at the

steam engine plants and the chemistry laboratory." She paused for a moment and said, "His Highness once told me that Nana and I are the foundation of medical care in Border Town; one of us for internal medication and the other surgery. This allows the operation to remain at an intense level, while still make sure everyone is healthy without establishing a safety policy. However, in fact, I haven't done anything except epidemic prevention for new refugees."

"So you're feeling sour like me!" Mystery Moon said, leaning over unyieldingly.

"No, I'm not!" Lily fired. "And stay away from me. You're interfering with my reading."

"Aw… " Mystery Moon chickened and said, "but I'm really envious of her."

"Then learn from Nana. Take the initiative to help every townee until they know you and get familiar with you. Then surely everybody will say hello to you wherever you go," said Lily, shrugging her shoulders.

"But I don't have an ability like Nana's," Mystery Moon said, frustrated.

"Then use your physical strength if not your ability," said Lily, mocking. "Regardless, you've been there at the camps of the Witch Cooperation Association."

"You… rascal!"

Mystery Moon still nursed a grudge when she went to bed. She knew that Lily was right, but being inferior to the other witches chafed her pride. This was intolerable. She had gone through so much pain before finally finding an ideal place to settle down and idling about all day was torture.

Mystery Moon slept fitfully all night. She knocked on Roland's office door with dark circles below her eyes the following day.

"What's the matter?" the prince asked in surprise. "Were you bullied?"

“By Lily… No, nevermind.” She leaned dramatically on Roland’s desk and asked, “Your Highness, didn’t you say that I have great potential? Why’s there no change in my ability yet? It really can’t evolve unless I understand Natural Science Theoretical Foundation?”

“I see,” Roland said, trying in vain to suppress his laughter. “Actually, I’ve been thinking about this problem, too.”

“What problem?”

“Didn’t Agatha say that over 400 years ago, the witches at the Union experienced High Awakening even without a comprehensive understanding of the world? Apart from basic practices, the rest will be a sudden enlightenment—this could be achieved by the observation of natural phenomena, or by an accidental flash of inspiration.” Roland continued, “However, the latter is apparently not comparable to the awakening inspired by systematic learning. Look at Agatha’s magic power. She’s not only the weakest one among the evolved witches, but she can’t even compete with some of the ordinary witches such as Sylvie and Andrea.”

“Doesn’t matter, as long as it evolves!” Mystery Moon’s eyes were sparkling. “You’ve got an idea?”

“It may not work,” the prince said, throwing up his hands, “but it’s worth a try. What do you know about magnetic forces?”

“Um… A force produced by the directional movement of electrons, which a magnetic field acts on the magnetic bodies and electric currents in it.”

“That was copied from the book,” he smiled and said. “You memorized it well, but you probably don’t understand it at all.”

Mystery Moon hesitated for a moment and nodded.

“You’ve seen lines of magnetic forces simulated by iron powder. You also know the direction of magnetic forces, and have seen the DC generator, too. So I think… you may not enable closed circuits to quickly cut lines of

magnetic forces, yet you can change the magnetic field you form, thereby personally experiencing the transformation from magnetism to electricity. ”

“I don’t quite follow you.”

“The nature of the transformation from magnetism to electricity is the change in magnetic flux. If you wanna change the magnetic flux in a constant magnetic field, the only way is to change the area, that is, to cut magnetic induction lines.” The prince drew a diagram on the paper and said, “What if the area remains constant? That’ll be changing the magnetic field, which means changing the magnetic flux.”

Mystery Moon groped unsuccessfully for adequate words, failing because she didn’t understand a word.

The prince laughed and said, “It’s OK that you don’t get it. You only need to do this—quickly release and withdraw your magnetic forces rather than continuously use your power.”

“And then?” Mystery Moon waited for Roland to continue.

“Nothing more.” He shook his head. “This is the only step.”

“Huh? Just release and withdraw magnetic forces?”

“Correct. If you can also change the direction of lines of magnetic forces, that would be perfect. For example, switch from the left hand to the right hand.” The prince smiled and said, “While you practice, I’ll prepare a ‘little toy’ for you. You’ll know why when you get the hang of this method.”

…

Two days later, Mystery Moon received what His Highness called a “little toy”. It was a square frame made of copper wires, the top of which was connected to a glass ball no bigger than half of a fist. Taking a closer look, she could see the copper wires were cut open in the ball, and were connected by a much finer metal wire.

An accompanying instruction manual read, “Hold the two ends of the square frame with both hands and practice. Note: be sure to draw the curtains and hide the Stone of Light.”

What the heck is that?

She scratched her head and then did what the instruction manual instructed—“It’s practice no matter how I do it. Just ignore it, and it’ll be fine.”

Mystery Moon learned that it was not hard to quickly release and withdraw her power, but changing the direction of magnetic forces delivered a blinding headache. Magnetic force was an essential power to her and at first, this endeavor was akin to breathing with only one nostril at a time. Although Mystery Moon had restrained herself from playing poker games and been dutifully practicing her new skill for the last two days, the result lasted merely half a minute.

She took a deep breath and summoned the magic power in her body.

At first she felt nothing, but soon she saw a flash of red light.

The metal wire in the glass ball turned orangy red, and the light became increasingly bright and intense. In a few seconds, the light was glaring. Mystery Moon almost could not believe her eyes. The inkily dark room was lit by soft light much purer than the candle light, which she had never seen.

She was still in a daze when the red light faded away accompanied by a feeble popping sound before the darkness enveloped the room again.

Chapter 405

Chapter 405: Accompany

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

The next morning, Mystery Moon ran to the office in a hurry with bigger dark circles under her eyes.

“Why would the glass ball light up? It didn’t work afterwards, no matter how hard I tried to apply my power… ” she could not wait to spit it all out after pushing open the door.

“That… fast?” The prince was a little surprised. He put down the quill, took the small object from Mystery Moon and said, “I thought it would take you two or three days.”

Mystery Moon bent over, propped up her chin on the edge of the desk, and asked with a blink, “What on earth was glowing?”

“That was electric light.” The prince smiled and said, “You released lightning from the sky.”

“Lightning?” She could not help repeating the word in a quiet voice, and then shook her head. “But it didn’t look like it at all. This light was a red-orange color, and kept glowing—lightning is always just a flash. ”

“The lightning lit the filament, making it glow continuously.” The prince twisted the glass ball and took it off, then said, “It’s fine that you don’t understand it. I’ll let you see the real electric light later.”

Mystery Moon’s eyes were wide open. She gazed at Roland’s every single movement, afraid of missing something. The prince drew the two copper wires closer and put the glass ball back again. “There you go. Now continue to practice.”

“That’s it?” She took the wire frame, utterly disappointed.

“That’s right,” the prince covered his mouth and said, “and don’t forget to draw the curtains when practicing.”

…

Lily was sitting at the end of the bed reading Natural Science Theoretical Foundation when Mystery Moon returned to the bedroom.

“Why are you up so early today?” she asked in surprise. “Since you’re up, bring me breakfast. An omelet and bread, please. No porridge.”

“No, I won’t bring breakfast for a traitor,” Mystery Moon said with a grunt. She drew the curtains, and the room turned completely dark in an instant.

“Hey, what’re you doing?” Lily frowned and asked.

“Practicing my ability.” She threw herself on the floor and said, “Draw the curtains and hide the Stone of Light—that’s His Highness’ requirement.”

“Fine, fine,” the little girl rolled her eyes and said, “I’ll do my reading in the hall.”

“No, you can’t!” Mystery Moon hollered.

“Why?” Lily darted her a look, “I can’t read when I’m starving, and I have to stay with you here?”

“Um… ” Mystery Moon paused a moment, “I’ll bring you breakfast. Can you stay here?”

“What?” Lily asked with great interest, “Are you afraid of the dark?”

“Not at all!” She puffed out her cheeks and muttered after a while, “I just need company.”

She wanted somebody to witness her progress and be amazed at her ability. Even if she failed, she hoped someone would still comfort her, but she would

rather carry these words to her grave than confide in Lily.

“Okay then. I’ll stay with you this time, since you sound so pathetic,” Lily said with a yawn. “Breakfast, quick!”

Mystery Moon finally got ready to practice after reluctantly bringing the breakfast over.

Lily swallowed the egg in content and asked, “What’re you going to do? Magnetize the stuff in your hand?”

“No, I’m going to let the magnetic forces in my hand change quickly. His Highness says that’ll produce thunder and lightning.”

Lily was stunned—”Thunder and lightning?”

“Yeah, I’m going to start… ”

“Hold on,” the little girl shouted, drawing closer to the door. “It’s good now. Go ahead.”

Mystery Moon exhaled a long breath and mobilized her magic power as she had earlier. If this happened at the camps of the Witch Cooperation Association, Supervisor Cara would definitely scold her for such behavior. However, His Highness had intentionally replaced all the wares in the bedroom that contained iron, including iron nails with copper-made items, making it easy for her to practice.

She was generously treated in Border Town and would not allow herself to sit idle.

Reminiscences of her experience in the town swarmed back upon her, image by image, as vivid as a merry-go-round. This time Mystery Moon found herself quickly in a ready state. The magic power danced between her hands with increased movement and growing intensity.

Then she saw the electric light. Like a blue ghost revealing itself from layers of clouds, the light was transient, and disappeared instantly. Nevertheless,

she clearly saw a trace of electric light. It was like a tiny arc, spanning from one end of the copper wire to the other, bursting out gentle popping sounds.

It was far from the end.

Then came a second arc, and then a third… She noticed in dismay that every time the magnetic forces transformed, there was dazzling electric light springing up, the traces of which also changed correspondingly with its movements. With the direction of magnetic forces quickly switching back and forth, a bridge of blue and white gradually took shape between the two copper wires.

“What’s that?” Lily who stood far away asked, her eyes wide open.

The electric light was insignificant compared with the red-orange blaze of yesterday, but it made Mystery Moon quiver in excitement—this was her first time witnessing her own ability! In comparison to the invisible lines of magnetic forces she could not understand in the slightest, the rythm at which the electric arc danced and the direction of its movement were completely under her control. This was truly “lightning” created by her.

Electricity generates magnetism, and vice versa. That’s what it is. She sensed the power in her body had become more visible and clear.

Mystery Moon got up on her feet and put the metal frame on the desk. She slowly released her hands to let the magic power die down, but the ends of the copper wires were still glittering, like flickering stars in the darkness from a far distance.

She now had a better understanding of these words.

In other words, electricity is magnetism, and vice versa.

****

Roland kneaded his sore neck with a quill between his teeth.

“Do you need a hand?” Nightingale’s voice popped up by his ears.

“Ah, thank you,” he nodded slightly and said. Nightingale thus laid her two fair hands on Roland’s shoulders and started to massage his neck with just the right amount of strength.

Roland half closed his eyes, enjoying this moment of serenity. In order to draft the first code of the town, which would later serve as the Basic Laws of all the primary laws, he had been up earlier than even the guards for the past three days. It wasn’t until today that he finally finished the draft. As Roland had no knowledge of the laws, he could only jot down some ten articles in plain language based on his understanding of the system, which was no longer than two pages altogether.

Nonetheless, these articles contained ideas and ideology from the new world. He believed this code would enable him to carry out a brand new system which was entirely different from the ancient feudal system across the whole continent while expanding his territory. With this code as its base, his new kingdom would indubitably distinguish itself from the others.

“Your Highness!” The office door was suddenly flung open. Mystery Moon rushed in with the copper wire frame in her hand, shouting, “I finally got it!”

Roland opened his eyes, and saw the girl withdraw her hands and put the “little toy” on the desk.

“Look!” She did not touch the wire frame, but there was still an arc of light where the copper wires were cut open.

Looking at this incredible scene, Roland could not help dropping his jaw. The quill slid off the corner of his mouth and fell on the floor.

Chapter 406

Chapter 406: The Limitation of Magic Power

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

“What did I just see? A self-generating system of electricity that doesn’t need an external energy supply!

Mystery Moon’s ability is an attaching type of magic so the answer is the answer is clear. She’s added a brand new property to the metal frame, and” her magic power acts as the energy supply,” Roland mused to himeself.

“How did you manage to do that?” Roland asked aloud.

“When you said that there’s an intertwining relationship between electricity and magnetism, and that they’re indivisible, I wondered if I could make the objects generate lightning by magnetizing them. I tried to add a constantly changing magnetic forces to the copper wires because you’ve said creating electricity requires changes in magnetic forces. Then it turned out this way,” Mystery Moon answered cautiously, her eyes sparkling with expectation.

“That’s why… Changes in electric currents do produce magnetic fields, but magnetic fields only generate electricity under certain circumstances. It requires both closed circuits and changes in magnetic flux; changes in the magnetic area and magnetic forces both need external energy supply.

Mystery Moon’s new ability has replaced an energy supply with the self-changing magnetic force,” the prince concluded. Roland would have thought it was a perpetual motion machine prototype, if he saw it in modern times. Yet here in this world, he understood that powers of witches could not be judged by common sense of his time. The magnetic property added to the objects might not be produced by magnetic poles, just as the Blackfire was not natural fire.

They were tangible forms of the magic power.

He could only wonder whether Mystery Moon had noticed any magnetic force change in objects to which she attached her magic power.

When Roland asked her about it, she nodded and then shook her head. “When I was in the Witch Cooperation Association, I once wanted to change the magnetism of objects according to my will. To avoid causing my sisters any trouble, I tried to make the objects less magnetic when they were not in use. However, it didn’t work. Their magnetic force remained the same. I thought it was impossible, so I gave up on it,” she said.

“Just as I expected,” Roland thought. He cocked his head towards Nightingale and said, “The form of her magic power… ”

“They have been united.” Nightingale stepped out of her mist and smiled. “The two are now one.”

Mystery Moon gasped, “Did I really… ”

“Yes, you did. Your ability has evolved.” Roland confirmed. “Only a long-term and relentless dedication of practice can lead to enlightenment and evolution that fast. You did a great job. From now on, you’ll be the sixth evolved witch in the Witch Union.”

“Congratulations.” Nightingale went to Mystery Moon and patted her head, smiling.

“Now, am I able to do more for Your Highness?” she asked, her eyes shining with excitement.

“Yes, countless things,” Roland smiled and said. “As I’ve told you before, you’ve got great potential. But first, go rest. You have dark circles as huge as fists around your eyes. I’ll test your ability in the afternoon.”

“Yes!” she nodded vigorously.

After Mystery Moon left the office, Nightingale purposefully shut the door and turned her attention to Roland. Ignoring her regular perche at either Roland’s desk or the French window, she drew close to him. Grasping his

shoulders and leaning in to speak, she stood so close that strands of her fair hair tickled his face. He felt his heart beating violently at the sight of her bright eyes and soft, red lips.

Eh? What's going on? Is she asking for it in broad daylight?"

"Tell me the method." These were not the words that the prince had expected to hear from Nightingale, "Wait… what's this have to do with anything?"

"What method?" he asked.

"The method to evolve without reading Natural Science Theoretical Foundation?" she said excitedly, "I can tell from Mystery Moon's grades that she doesn't understand the contents of the book, but you taught her how to evolve and gain a new ability! What should I do? Practice with 'little toys' as well?"

"Eh, she is asking for the evolvement method. What a pity… no, a relief." Roland thought and cleared his throat, putting himself together. "I'm afraid your ability won't evolve through a sudden flash of enlightenment," he said.

"Why not?"

"According to Agatha, only observing natural phenomena related to your ability can provoke an evolvement. Your Mist is just too incredible for me to understand, let alone guide you to learn about it." Roland explained. "Maybe the only method for you to develop your magic power is a sound understanding of natural science, physics and even advanced mathematics."

Nightingale's face fell. She feebly walked to the couch and sank back into it, feeling as if her body was hollowed out.

After lunch, Roland spent the whole afternoon conducting a comprehensive test on Mystery Moon's new ability.

He named it "Variable Magnetic Force." It could be applied to any object like her magnetizing ability, and it would create periodic variation based on

the magic power she initially conjured. However, as far as insulators, no electricity would be generated.

Roland determined that Mystery Moon's magic power was the weakest of the the evolved witches. She could only light up two Magic Stones embedded in the Sigil of God's Will, half a stone less than even Maggie. Unfortunately, the attaching-type magic ability required a vast amount of magic power. The greater and longer variations in magnetic forces, the greater demand for magic power. After a series of tests, Roland found that Mystery Moon's new ability could serve as a stable battery, but it was far from sufficient to drive a large electric motor or power a steam engine. He tested her ability by transforming an old DC motor, initially used for the electrolysis of water, into an electric motor, and the result was disappointing. The motor, which consumed all of Mystery Moon's magic power to add a magnetic force, could only work half day. That meant her new abilitycould not practically be used as a source power.

Roland didn't tell Mystery Moon the bad results. Instead, he encouraged her to keep studying and practicing her new ability, because she was fragile and he feared bad news would be devestating.

Besides, he knew that ability evolvement was not a sudden transformation, but a metamorphosis through learning.

Roland remembered something he had heard from Agatha, the method to jointly produce Stone of Light. He thought,"If there is a witch who can control or transfer magic power, Mystery Moon's power limitation won't be a problem anymore."

In the evening, he went to talk to Tilly Wimbledon.

"An assistant witch with a controlling type of magic?" she said after hearing the prince's idea. She thought for a while and answered, "No witch of the Sleeping Island has that kind of ability."

"Really?" he asked, heaving a sigh. "It seems that Mystery Moon has to depend on herself to improve."

Yet what Tilly said next cheered him. “However, I know where you can find the witch you want.”

Chapter 407

Chapter 407: Tilly's Questioning

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

"You mean… she didn't follow you to Sleeping Island?" The prince soon got what Tilly meant.

"Exactly." Princess Tilly shook her head helplessly. "Her name is Spear Passi and her ability is magic power channeling. She can channel magic powers of several witches. In other words, a witch at one end of the channel can borrow magic powers from other witches connected, so you may need her help." Tilly paused for a while and continued. "She lives right in Fallen Dragon Ridge."

"Since you know so much about her, you must have contacted her," Roland asked for further explanation, "and what're the reasons for her to stay there? There's a risk that she'll be caught by the church."

After a moment of silence, Tilly answered, "That's because she's a Marquess and Lord of Fallen Dragon Ridge."

"Lord?" He was startled, "A witch?"

"Yes, her father Marquis Passi, the last Lord, gave the title and the territory to her, instead of to his second and third son. Due to her high rank, Spear can conceal her witch identity pretty well, and thus can lead a far better life than ordinary witches," Tilly said slowly, "and she contacted me first and offered her help during the migrations. Because of her, I was able to quickly gather the witches from the towns in the southern and middle parts of the Kingdom."

"'She contacted me first'…", Roland sensed something strange thereinto and asked, "Wait… She didn't intend to give a shelter to her fellow witches?"

“No.” Tilly shook her head. “Not only that, she also wanted those witches to leave her territory as soon as possible and protect themselves from being tortured by the church. Spear apparently values her lord title more.”

Her Lord title would no doubt be in danger if the church found she was protecting witches. Unlike towns in the remote border area, Fallen Dragon Ridge had well-established churches and priests, and their believers greatly outnumbered those in the Western Region. Roland understood her choice but was still astonished. “If a witch in her territory is seized, will she… ”

“I asked her the same question, ” Tilly said with some sadness, “and Spear Passi bluntly told me if a witch was caught by the people, she would try to replace her in the jail with a death-row prisoner and secretly send her out of her territory; but if a witch was caught by the Verdict Army or judged by the church, she would just stand by.”

“…” Roland thought, “It turned out that Spear Passi voluntarily got in touch with Tilly because of the hidden danger of witches in Fallen Dragon Ridge. That was why Tilly chose to leave for the Fjords, which was a new place for her despite the risk of crossing the channel, instead of settling down in Fallen Dragon Ridge.” At this thought, he frowned and asked Tilly, “If I invite her to Border Town, will she come?”

“I won’t bank on that, but you may have a try,” Tilly threw up her hands and said, “I’m just telling you where you can find her but I’m not promising anything.”

Roland made a long sigh and said, “I’ll send a messenger to talk to her first.”

Without doubt, he would choose Nightingale as the messenger, given that she was able to avoid eyes and ears of the people when she got into the castle, and that she could also discern lies. As long as she made Spear believe she held no hostility, Spear would probably not overreact, either.

It generally took five or six days to travel from Border Town to Fallen Dragon Ridge by boat, but that trip would only cost Maggie half a day. They could bring Lightning, who acted faster as a helper. The three witches formed

a team of the highest mobility in the Witch Union, and now equipped with guns, they could both attack enemies and defend themselves.

Thinking about the plan for quite a while, Roland made up his mind.

Assuming that the Marquise did not agree to come, it was still a matter of time for him to investigate the situation of her territory. As an important passage on the way to the Southernmost Region, Fallen Dragon Ridge was included in his spring attack plan.

“I heard there’s a newly evolved witch in the castle?” Tilly suddenly switched the topic.

“Ah, you mean Mystery Moon. Yes, she did cohere her magic power,” Roland nodded and told Tilly about her evolvement process. “But using the ancient witches’ method to evolve is not very effective in increasing her magic power. To become someone like Anna, it still requires the thorough understanding of solid knowledge.”

“But the ancient way is still a method,” Tilly said with interest, “and there’s a point I find very interesting in what you said just now. What did you mean by ‘They’re not natural phenomena but only concrete forms of magic powers’?”

“That was my personal speculation.” He picked up his cup and had some tea. “Neither Anna’s Heart Fire nor her Blackfire is something you can find in nature, so it’s not hard to view them as concrete forms of magic powers, but what about the normal fires before the evolvement? So I assume the normal fires were also created by magic powers, and that it reflected what Anna perceived as ‘heat’. As her perception became more thorough and profound, the images of ‘heat” also changed. This explains exactly what Agatha has experienced. Many witches have similar abilities before their evolvement because they’ve observed the same natural phenomenon. After High Awakening, their abilities vary because their understandings of the phenomenon have huge differences.”

“Sounds quite reasonable,” Tilly replied without saying yes or no, “but according to your speculation, the witches of the same kind will evolve

almost the same new abilities if they've same understandings of the phenomenon, right?"

"Yes, pretty much like that, but under the condition that they've got exactly the same understanding abilities."

Roland did not tell her another idea of his, which was to what extent magic powers could evolve. "Since magic power forms the foundation of all kinds of abilities, it is elementary and universal. Provided that there is a witch who understands everything in the nature, will she be able to display all kinds of abilities?"

"Are you… coming from a world without magic power?" Tilly suddenly questioned.

"Poof…" The tea nearly gushed out of the prince's mouth. He wiped his mouth and asked, "What, what did you say?"

"I've gone through all the books written by you during this month and always felt something was wrong." Princess Tilly looked at him in the eye. "I finally see what the problem is after hearing what you said just now. You separate magic power from the nature… Neither Natural Science Theoretical Foundation nor Elementary Physics mentions anything about magic power and you said concrete expressions of magic power were not something existing in the nature, but… magic power itself is a part of the nature."

Roland was stunned.

He suddenly realized that he completely forgot Tilly lived in a world where magic power naturally existed. So did the previous Prince Roland, but he just placed magic power in a position opposite to natural phenomena and seemed to get used to it.

Blame the excess memories coming all of a sudden for this careless mistake? It probably won't work this time. It is acceptable to say that Prince Roland wrote these books based entirely on his memories, but how to explain that he firmly believes in them and subconsciously separate magic power from the

nature? Is it possible for him to pledge that this is still the memory of the previous Prince Roland's?

Roland swallowed hard.

Chapter 408

Chapter 408: The Conundrum

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

He couldn't believe that she was digging holes for him using the books that he wrote himself.

When faced with such complicated information, most people struggled to even understand it, let alone to notice its flaws—it was pretty unbelievable that there was no mention of magic power at all in a science book studying the nature of everything in the world.

Roland had also completely wiped the Fourth Prince's memories from his mind, and besides trying to mimic the Prince during his first month after traversing the space and time, he never considered it ever again. His ministers were afraid to question him, and he didn't have to hide who he was from the witches, so he became more and more careless.

However, Tilly was no ordinary witch.

Besides being Prince Roland's sister, she was also an Extraordinary.

Not only was she able to quickly finish all of his books, but she also shrewdly noticed this inconsistency. Her logic was just as clear as that of any modern person who had undergone universal education. In addition, she used leading questions to prove her point so that he had no chance of arguing his way out.

This was a disaster.

Roland's brain was spinning with frantic thoughts, but he had no idea how to respond to her. Any forced explanation to someone who could notice this inconsistency would only arouse more suspicion, and lying to cover a lie would only create even more issues.

Tilly broke the awkward silence and said gently, “You don’t have to answer me right now. It’s late, and I’m going back to the Witch House. You should get some rest too, Your Highness.”

“Um… Okay.” Roland stared into the eyes of this grey-haired woman, trying to understand her thoughts, and forgot to send her off.

Tilly stopped at his office door, turned around and asked, “I can trust you, right?”

Usually, Roland would have confidently agreed, but in that moment, he found himself struggling to respond and could only manage a slow nod.

After the door closed, Nightingale said, confused, “How could she just leave like that?”

“Why do you look so upset?” Roland scoffed at her.

“I was so close to hearing about your true life story!” Nightingale stuck out her tongue. “Why didn’t she press on you harder?

“Because she didn’t want to risk our friendship.” The Prince heavily sighed.

“What?”

“No… nothing.” Roland leaned back in his chair and felt a chill on his back. Tilly’s behavior was absolutely perfect because she didn’t push him too far. Border Town was definitely the biggest ally to the Sleeping Island, and allies were more important than identities in the face of their enemies. If she strained their relationship by asking too much, it would only mean bad news for the witches of the Sleeping Island.

That was why Tilly left him some time to recover after posing her question. However, this didn’t mean that she didn’t need an answer, and if he kept dragging his feet, he could also lose her trust right after they defeated their enemies together. She had made her move, and it was time for him to respond.

However, Roland couldn't tell Tilly the truth, at least not at the moment—Anna and Nightingale were different because they knew only him from the very beginning, but Tilly was Prince Roland's little sister. Until he figured out what her real thoughts on her brother were, he would have to keep this secret to himself.

He shook his head and dismissed these annoying thoughts. Roland turned to Nightingale and said, "You heard our conversation earlier, too. What do you think about checking out the situation with Maggie and Lightning?"

"No problem, Your Highness."

"It's not just going to be a simple chat… To be honest, I'm a little worried about you," he slowly said.

"Wha… what's there to be worried about?" Nightingale stuttered. "I… I'm fine, even if I have to drag her back… "

"That's exactly what I'm worried about!" Roland slammed on the table. "What do you mean drag her back? Are you trying to have her tear us to shreds? Listen, you have to be careful this time and check out the situation before you confront Spear Passi. It's alright if she refuses; just don't threaten her—as a fellow witch, she'll be no stranger to you."

"Uh… is that all?" she asked disappointedly.

"That's all in regards to witches." Roland frowned. "Additionally, you need to help Lightning record the layout of Fallen Dragon Ridge's surroundings, fortifications, sentries, and armies, and then return as quickly as possible."

Nightingale murmured in acknowledgment.

"And finally," Roland said, pausing, "be safe. This's the most important thing."

****

"Can we get another pint of ale over here?"

“Hey, is my oatmeal ready?”

“Coming, coming! Sorry for the wait!”

Otto Luoxi entered the pub, Covert Trumpeter, and was instantly surrounded by chaotic chatter. A crackling fire warmed him, and a smell of sour and musty body odor made him cringe. As a nobility, Otto rarely set foot into commoners’ areas and was not used to being in close quarters with them. If not for his appointment with the Rats, he wouldn’t be caught dead in this backalley pub in the outer city.

Following local rules, he quickly found his target—a skinny man wearing a hood sitting in an unlit corner of the pub, enveloped in the shadows. A small piece of bone lay next to his hand.

Otto sat across the man and said, “Cheers to Skeleton Fingers.”

“You don’t have liquor to give cheers.”

“But I have the thing measuring all things on earth.” He spoke the code word.

The man shrugged. “Call me Hood. I heard you’re here to get some information?”

Otto nodded. While Timothy was stalling on giving him a response, he hadn’t been able to rest and was busy asking around about the rebel king—someone who could hold the Western Territory for half a year after the king’s ascension and completely stump Timothy was surely with a force to be reckoned with.

The fastest way to gain as much information as possible was through the Rats.

This was the sixth Rat Otto had spoken to, and the information he had gained startled him. The legendary rebel king, Roland Wimbledon, fourth son of King Wimbledon III, was not showing any signs of weakening and was even challenging the new king with the threat of an attack to dethrone Timothy.

This man was also true to his word—although Timothy went to great lengths to hide the news, Otto was still able to find out about the strange collapse in King's City. If this news was true, an alliance with Timothy was questionable at best. He needed to get to the bottom of all this to protect the Kingdom of Dawn.

"That's right," Otto Luoxi whispered. "I want to know about the giant crash and collapse in the King's City palace three months ago."

Chapter 409

Chapter 409: A Reliable Ally

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

“You’ve come to the right man,” Hood smiled and said in a raspy voice that made it hard to tell his age. “Even though I live in the outer city, I happened to be near the palace on the day of the incident, and as soon as I heard the crash, I ran to the palace gate. You have no idea how terrifying the crash was, because it sounded like lightning hitting the earth. All the surrounding windows, whether paper or glass, were shattered by an invisible force, and some people were even scared to death by the sudden sound… ”

Every Rat claimed to be nearby and to have witnessed everything, but each person’s story was different from the other. “Okay, no need to ramble on about unimportant things. How did it happen?” Otto Luoxi interrupted and asked. “Was this incident really related to the Fourth Prince… Roland Wimbledon?”

Hood cleared his throat and stretched out his right hand. “I can answer that, but… ”

“You need the thing measuring all things on earth, right?” Otto opened his wallet. “How much?”

The so-called “thing measuring all things on earth” was nothing more than a gold royal. Only uncultured people like Rats would use such an obvious code word or phrase to appear mysterious.

The Rat stuck up two fingers.

Otto took out two gold royals and placed them in Hood’s hand. “This is not a small fee, so I hope your information lives up to it.”

“Of course. The reputation of Skeleton Fingers rests upon this.” The Rat smiled greedily and pocketed the gold royals.

“A Rat’s reputation is as ridiculous as a ruler’s mercy.” Otto sniffed. “Go ahead.”

“I’ll start by answering your first question.” After his payment, Hood’s posture was much more relaxed. He sipped his ale, leaned back in his chair, and pointed towards the ceiling. “Thunder comes from the sky.”

“What do you mean?” Otto frowned.

“Didn’t you want to know what caused the crash?” the Rat whispered. “All thunder comes from the sky, and this was no exception. I saw it with my own eyes. Before the crash, a white rock floated into the palace, and then the incident happened.”

“Nonsense! You mean to tell me that a huge rock fell from the sky and smashed the palace into pieces?”

“Hehe, everything I said is true, or else Skeleton Fingers wouldn’t assign me this task. If you think I’m lying, you can leave right now.” Hood shrugged. “But you won’t get your fee back.”

“… Keep going.” Otto tried to repress his annoyance.

“The rock entered the palace only seconds after it appeared, but I could clearly tell that it wasn’t that big or fast and didn’t like something that could destroy the Hall of Sky Dome, which is why I said it ‘floated’. Also, when the crash and smoke appeared, I saw a menacing flash of fire that definitely wasn’t caused by the collision,” Hood said, smacking his lips. “I mean, His Highness Timothy’s search afterwards proved this very point—he closed off and cleared the Inner City multiple times without arresting any suspects, and the palace is heavily guarded, so where else could the attack be from if not the sky?”

He took another sip of ale. “As for the fire and smoke, they resemble the phenomenon caused when an alchemy solution called snow powder burns,

which is why I'm certain that this was an attack. By the way, I also have some information about snow powder, but you'd have to pay only a little more… "

"No need, I don't want to know." Otto interrupted. He had already heard through other channels about snow powder, which was originally used in celebrations but could be modified into a weapon. Rats probably didn't know anything about its specific content, so he didn't feel like wasting his money.

"Alright, now I'll answer your second question," Hood said, splaying his hands indifferently. "This incident was certainly related to Prince Roland."

"Why?"

"When did you arrive in King's City? Of course, I'm not trying to ask about your background or… identity, since that's a rule of Black Street, so you don't have to answer me." The Rat smiled. "What I mean is, if you arrived in King's City in early autumn, you'd know this: His Highness sent thousands of soldiers to attack Western Region, but only very few returned, all bearing letters from Prince Roland to His Highness."

All six Rats had mentioned this, which meant that it was probably true, but he continued to ask, "Are you talking about the warning of revenge? It sounds quite scary. Are you sure it's not pure folklore?"

"Most letters were brought by the soldiers into the palace, and the few that were leaked were mostly seized by the City Hall, but Skeleton Fingers always surprises its clients. I actually have a preserved 'warning' with me." Hood stuck up five fingers. "Considering it's a very rare letter from Prince Roland himself, the price is slightly higher. What do you think?"

…

Otto Luoxi returned to the palace, and Belinda immediately stood up to greet him. "Any news?"

“Not much, but I did get my hands on a letter from Prince Roland.” He handed the wrinkly piece of paper to her, took off his coat, sat next to the fireplace, and told her all about what he had learned. “All six Rats gave similar answers to the second question, and this paper proves them right—Roland Wimbledon is not as weak as the King says he is, but the complete opposite. If the Kingdom of Dawn allies with Timothy, we may benefit very little and gain a tricky enemy.”

“But all the Rats’ answers to the first question were different,” Belinda said with a frown.

“This proves that the attack was very mysterious and difficult to understand, and I kind of believe what the last Rat said.” Otto sipped his hot tea and sighed. Spending too much time in the cheap pub made him very uncomfortable.

“From the sky?” Belinda gaped at him. “Are you crazy?”

“Of course not. If I hadn’t seen this letter, I wouldn’t dream of it either. Roland was very confident about the time and location of the attack, and only an attack from the sky would be able to pass the high city wall and strong fortifications, confusing even the shrewdest Rats.” He frowned. “However, what’s more important is what we do next.”

“With the imminent threat from the Church, they should stop fighting each other and join forces against their common enemy.”

“That’s not for us to decide.” Otto shook his head. “The only thing we can do is to find a reliable ally for the Kingdom of Dawn. His Highness Timothy Wimbledon seems a little… unreliable.”

“Are you really going to go to Western Region?” Belinda was shocked. “Isn’t that a place currently facing the dangers of the Months of the Demons?”

“It’s nothing compared to the danger of our kingdom collapsing,” he said after some silence. “You can stay here and wait for the new king’s response, while I travel alone to Western Region.”

Chapter 410

Chapter 410: Expectations

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

The water vapor formed an even layer of white mist resembling thin gauze on the window pane. Chilly wind blew on the windows with a popping sound, which contrasted with the tranquil fireplace burning in the room.

Scroll sat in front of a long desk in the City Hall Office, reading rolls of thick documents.

Those documents were not about education but were statistics reported by various departments. She used her free time to memorize such information in case someone needed it. This was recently the main part of her work since there was not much to deal with in the Ministry of Education. After all, the second round of assessment ended not long ago, and another round wouldn't be carried out before next summer.

Having worked for His Highness Roland for half a year, she found out His Highness was particularly interested in statistics—he liked it when his subordinates described things with a long series of precise numbers; he frequently used terms such as horizontal ratio, year-on-year ratio, and chain relative ratio. Subsequently, all the staff in the City Hall had picked up this habit from him.

As the township population grew, the related statistical work increased correspondingly. Therefore, His Highness entrusted this work to Scroll and jokingly called her the "database" of Border Town. Although the nickname made her sound like a warehouse, His Highness described it as something extremely important. With the help of a database, he said he could estimate the development of next year and make economic and military plans. He even said all his future decisions concerning the territory would be based on the data analysis.

“Lady Scroll.” A woman dressed as an apprentice pushed open the office door and entered the room. After bowing to Scroll, she handed her an application form. “Hello, my name is Freya. His Excellency Carter from the Department of Justice wishes to acquire the information on refugees who passed the resident verification within the last week.”

Due to her limited ability to derivative skills, His Highness ordered that anyone who wanted to inquire complex data must get consent from Barov first. As for individual data, one could ask Scroll at any time.

“Wait a minute!” Scroll glanced at the signature on the application form, summoned the Book of Magic, and showed the corresponding contents on its pages. “Alright. Give this to Mr. Carter.”

“Thank… thank you.” Freya carefully held the book that came out of thin air as if it was a demonic beast.

“Don’t worry. It won’t hurt you.” Scroll could not help but laugh. Most people had such an expression when they saw the Book of Magic. “You do not need to return the book to me because it will vanish four hours later. However, according to the Constitution of Confidentiality, you aren’t allowed to give it to anybody other than Carter.”

“Yes …My Lady.”

Freya bowed and retreated. While she pushed open the door, Scroll saw a sea of people in the hall, and a chattering sound instantly rushed into her room, quieting down again when the door was closed.

This was a weekend, which was supposed to be a rest day, but the City Hall was still as busy as on workdays. Everybody was excited about the upcoming construction of Border Town, so they worked particularly hard. With the salary reward for overtime offered by His Highness, no one was willing to stay at home.

Scroll didn’t understand His Highness’s decisions. To her, there wasn’t that much work to be done in the City Hall, and compared to the labors of miners and furnace workers, writing official documents, collecting data and making

reports took much less effort – yet these were the main jobs of the City Hall. His Highness only had to give orders, and everyone would easily comply. There was really no need to raise the salary in this regard. Compared to most of the nobilities, His Highness appeared to be too benevolent.

Truthfully, Scroll didn't think His Highness Roland seemed like a real Lord. Yet, it was exactly such a person who led everybody to this stage, which was nearly a miracle.

She didn't come to this conclusion due to her respect and trust for Roland, but due to clear data; compared with one year ago, when only miners had a stable income in Border Town; the wages of miners, furnace workers and handymen had doubled now, although they used to earn the least; some emerging occupations such as assemblers in the steam plant and operators in the acid plant had had their wages raised eightfold, and the number of workers was still on the rise.

The changes within the town itself were so obvious that if a person hadn't lived here one year ago, he might find it very hard to believe that such changes were possible.

Scroll touched the words on the document. She couldn't imagine how the territory would continue to transform under His Highness' leadership, but she firmly believed it would have a future full of hope and surprises.

"Miss Scroll." The wooden door was pushed open, and His Highness Roland's guard stepped in. "His Highness wants to see you."

…

When she returned to the third floor of the castle, Scroll saw that His Highness was organizing pieces of the manuscript.

"Would you like me to record these things?" Tying her black hair up, which was messed up by the cold wind, she stepped up and asked the prince.

"That's right. It took at least half of my brain cells to finish this book." The prince massaged his neck, murmuring words that were difficult for Scroll to

comprehend. “Even for the knowledge that was commonly used at the time, I could only remember them generally, and I even had to deduce several formulas myself.”

Scroll had gotten used to this behavior. She ignored his weird terms, picked up the manuscript, realizing the letters on its cover were in an unprecedented orange color that formed the word “calculus”.

She flipped through a couple pages, and found it impossible to understand what the book title meant. She then focused on memorizing its contents—compared to the equations she had learned previously, she found these new formulas didn’t even have numbers, but a series of bizarre symbols, like a whole set of new characters. They looked like things only Anna and Tilly would be interested in.

“Right,” Roland asked, “what’s the average income of the residents here?”

“The minimum was 10 silver royals per month, and the maximum was 40,” Scroll answered without stopping her memorizing of calculus, “but to calculate the average income I would need the Book of Magic, which has been used once today.”

“That’s alright. You can give me the statistical result the day after tomorrow.” Roland waved his hand. “I need this number to determine the fee for water and heating supply. The collective heating supply project is about to begin in a week. On its completion, this place would be as warm as spring, even through the longest winter.”

A city without fear for the cold. This is one of the miracles that could only happen in His Highness’s territory. “If I don’t get extra work, I’ll give you the result tomorrow.”

“Tomorrow …It would be nice if you could turn the Book of Magic into a storybook.” Roland shook his head with a smile. “Or any book that Anna hasn’t read.”

“Storybook?” Scroll was slightly startled before quickly understanding his reasoning. “Tomorrow is Miss Anna’s …”

“Day of Awakening,” the Prince nodded and said.

Chapter 411

Chapter 411: The Vow

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

…

With no swaying candlelight or crackling burning fire, the room was made so warm and pleasant by the heater that one wouldn't feel cold even when only wearing thin clothes. The Stone of Light at the bed stand brightened the room —the stable and gentle yellow light shone on the bedsheet and carpet, producing a wonderful nostalgic scene.

Sitting at the bedside and listening to the occasional slight chirps from the caliducts, Roland felt as if he was in a dream. It was like he wasn't in a backward monarchy nor a modern society full of electronic products, rather somewhere in between… his childhood.

His childhood memories very much resembled the scene in front of him— everything was covered in a faint shade of yellow, whether it was a light bulb, a movie, or a developed photo.

The only difference was that Anna wasn't in his childhood memory.

At this thought, he turned and looked at the girl sitting at the edge of the bed.

She was reading a storybook. Her blonde hair on her forehead glimmering under light and her long eyelashes occasionally trembling, made her look extremely moving. Yet, the most extraordinary part was her sapphire eyes, which were still as blue as a clear lake even under the reflection of the Magic Stone. The only difference from one year ago was that this pair of eyes weren't such a peaceful lake anymore.

Her existence alone made the whole picture vivid. Anna is not only a different color from the rest of this whole setting, but also a marker that

separates my reality from memory. Seeing her assumes me that everything is real.

“What are you looking at?” Anna had already put down the Book of Magic and was staring at Roland. “Me?”

“Ahem… ” Roland shifted his eyesight eyes subconsciously, but quickly shifted them back again. “Uh-huh…That’s right.”

After spending about a year together, the two of them had been quite familiar with each other. Roland wasn’t as passive as he had been, and since they were alone in the room, he was more open about the emotions he had been holding back all this time.

They looked at each other and burst into laughter at the same time.

“Do you think my demand is a little too stubborn?” Anna shook her head and smiled. “Clearly everybody cares about me, but I pushed all of them away.”

“Don’t worry about it.” Roland said with his hands laid out, “They were only surprised by your reaction at that time.”

“If it weren’t for the ‘ancient methods’ suggested by Miss Agatha, I wouldn’t have made this request,” Anna said, sticking out her tongue – a cute move that she rarely made. “But I assume other sisters would do the same. You’ll be busy then.”

Roland smiled resignedly and said, “I think they would only ask for a few more pieces of ice cream bread.”

After learning that Anna was going to have her Day of Awakening, Agatha instantly contributed her experience gained in the Holy City of Taquila—according to the research of the Union, on the Day of Awakening or the Day of Adulthood, a witch needed to drain her magic power to decrease the influence of bite. Additionally, the witch’s emotions were also very important – positive emotions as happiness and contentment would greatly increase her resistance. For some outstanding witches, the Union even dispatched personnel to fulfill their wishes on their Day of Adulthood.

After knowing this, Anna requested that Roland accompany her on her Day of Awakening.

“Thanks to Miss Agatha, I’m having a good time.” She confessed. “I couldn’t spend my Day of Adulthood with you, but I can make up for it on my Day of Awakening.”

Watching Anna’s sincere expression, Roland almost blushed. He cleared his throat, took out a thin book tied with a colorful ribbon from his back, and handed it to her. “A gift for your Day of Awakening.”

The reason why he rushed to write down the advanced calculus knowledge that he remembered was to finish it before this day. To a witch, the Day of Awakening was more important than a birthday and could almost be seen as a rebirth. Roland had always had difficulty choosing presents for holidays, and this time was no different. After racking his brains, he decided to give Anna new knowledge as a present—Anna had a talent for learning and an appetite for new knowledge, so he chose her gift accordingly.

However, after receiving the book with orange cover, she didn’t open it instantly as she used to. Instead, she put it down together with the Book of Magic. “Thank you.”

“The storybook… Have you finished reading it?”

“Not yet.” Anna slightly shook her head. “But I want to hear something special.”

“Special?” Roland was slightly astonished.

“Yes.” She said with a smile, “Your story—last time I fell asleep too soon while listening to it and today I hope to continue hearing about it.”

“Does she mean the day when we lay in bed together?” Roland pursed his lips. He suddenly had an impulse to tell her about his true identity, and to not hide it anymore. “Do you still remember that I once told you I used to live in a big city? By a big city, I didn’t mean Kingdom of Graycastle.”

“I know.”

“Huh?” Anna’s reply was shocking to him.

“When I thought about it, I found those stories you told me couldn’t have happened in the palace of King’s City,” she said with a smile. “Don’t forget, I have repeatedly read through Chronicles of Graycastle.”

“Is that so?” Roland hesitated for a moment. “I actually …”

“You don’t have to say anything.” Anna stopped him. “You are hesitating, which means it’s not easy to tell, right? Then don’t. Besides, it’s not hard to guess. I believe I’m not the only one who has this feeling. The closer we get to you, the easier to feel this way—you are different from everybody else.” She paused. “What if… we take a bet.”

“Bet… on what?”

“Let’s bet how much I can guess about your life story.”

Roland suddenly recalled a game he used to play when he was little: time capsule. “The game works like this: write down your words to the future on a note, put it into a can, and take the can out a certain number of years later… Although most of the cans would be missing, a few of them would be retrieved, and looking at the note you wrote years ago would give you an unspeakable sensation.”

He didn’t ask about the wager. “It doesn’t matter who wins and who loses, since she probably proposed it to comfort me, rather than to figure out my true identity.” He must admit, among all the witches, Anna was the one who understood him the best.

“Deal.” He nodded.

“Where did we stop last time?”

“I finished my study under the guidance of my mentor …” Roland laughed. “Let’s start from here.”

When the light of dawn lit up the skyline, Anna peacefully passed through the first Day of Awakening since her adulthood.

Chapter 412

Chapter 412: Sneaking into the Fallen Dragon Ridge

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

The entire world was gloomy, from the sky to the land and sea.

Although the south central area of the Kingdom of Graycastle wasn't covered by endless snow, the impact of the Months of Demons was inevitable—the sun was hidden by an expanse of gray clouds which filled the whole sky. A pale fog rose from the earth, shrouding the land, rocks, and jungles. All that was revealed was the black and gray mountain peaks above the clouds, which stretched towards the southern end of the continent, and acted as the visual guide for Nightingale and her companions.

While flying in the sky on Maggie's back, Nightingale intensely experienced just how terrible the cold wind was in the open air. Even with a set of customized windproof clothes on, which were given to her by His Highness before they left, she could still feel the cold penetrating her body from her scarf and cuffs. In particular, her ears and fingers would soon get numb due to hypothermia. They often had to stop and rest for a while, making the normally half-day journey eventually extend to the next day—even flying at full speed.

"Here we are." Lightning approached her.

Nightingale peered out and realized the ridge had become much lower, as if it was sinking into the ground. A city built on the hillside emerged faintly from the fog, which should be their exact target—Fallen Dragon Ridge.

"Let's land." She patted Maggie's back. "Be careful and don't let anyone see us."

"Awh!" Maggie nodded, folding her wings as she glided down. The Mist soon enveloped the three of them as they landed. Nightingale found that the

visibility around them was so low that she couldn't see clearly what was only 50 steps in front of them, let alone over a great distance.

This was a good sign for the witches—at least they wouldn't be easily noticed.

After entering into the Mist, the true colors of the world would be revealed, but she wasn't worried about running into the church's Judgement Army due to the thick white fog.

"You just wait here, this shouldn't take long," said Nightingale.

"His Highness asked me to keep a lookout from the air." Lightning shook her head.

"And he asked me to be the emergency contact in case you kidnapped the target. Coo!" Maggie transformed into a fat pigeon, crouching on the top of the little girl's head.

"His Highness gave some meaningless commands," Nightingale thought. "In that case, let's go."

Suddenly, the world became black and white—the fog disappeared, or transformed into something else, which no longer hindered her vision. All of a sudden, the view became clear. The dark city wall was 200 meters away, extending out of the mountain side, and linked the city and the mountain like a dome. The stone wall was much shorter compared to the outer wall of Longsong Stronghold, and there were no sentry guards on it.

Nightingale went to the side of the wall and found the entrance through the curved lines. She stepped forward and realized that she was already on the other side of the city wall.

The city was half the size of Stronghold, and it was more like a small town in this area just outside of the mountain cliffs. But Fallen Dragon Ridge was located within the rocky mountains, and the Lord's castle built on the hillside could be seen from far away.

Nightingale assured that Lightning and Maggie were following her into the city, and then she went straight towards the castle.

This mission wasn't new to her and she was very proficient at it.

When she served old Gilen, it was a common assignment to infiltrate into other nobles' mansions and castles. Most of the buildings were similar in structure, and the owners always liked to live in the most spacious house right in the center. Back then, she was unable to go in through walls freely and could only conceal herself—while carefully avoiding any possible traps and the God's Stones of Retaliation—before stealing the letters and documents hidden in the cabinet.

Now with the help of the Mist, she could easily do these things, since the lightless black hole presented by the God's Stone of Retaliation, embedded at the corner of castle's aisle, seemed as attractive as the moon hanging in the dark sky. The hidden traps could be seen clearly, as their twisted contours were like creeping earthworms, and she could easily destroy them after passing through the walls. While under the influence of her ability, Nightingale was perfectly free to move—the walls, doors, and roofs were just inconsequential to her.

Walking into the largest house at the top, she found her target.

Although they had never met before, Nightingale identified Marquess Spear Passi, the Lord of Fallen Dragon Ridge, at first sight because a magic blue light was rotating in her body, which was the only color visible in the world of the Mist.

Sitting in front of a desk with a quill in her hand waving back and forth, the Marquess seemed to be writing something. She was about 30 years old with wrinkles at the corners of her eyes, and the silver curls of hair and plain robes she wore made her look older. Nightingale examined the room carefully and found that there was no God's Stone of Retaliation or trap, and that Parcy's only weapon was a delicate and luxurious short crossbow hidden inside her sleeve.

After leaving a mark on the side of the window, she dissolved the Mist and revealed herself.

“Greetings, Marquess Spear Passi.”

Shocked by the unexpected voice, Spear Passi raised her head swiftly and saw Nightingale. She quickly calmed down and asked, “Who are you?”

Nightingale remembered the scenario of her first meeting with Prince Rolandhis first reaction was to try to escape and she had to stop him by using a dagger, which in hindsight was really funny.

“I’m Nightingale and I’m from Border Town of the Western Region. As you can see, I’m a witch.”

“I thought so, as no one can come here without an invitation, except a witch.” Spear Passi pretended to be calm, as she moved one of her hand slowly into her sleeve. “You should knock on the door before coming in.”

“Then I’d be welcomed by your guard, not you.” Nightingale laughed softly. “Don’t worry. I don’t intend to hurt you. I just want to have a talk—so you won’t need that crossbow inside your sleeve.”

This surprised Spear Passi and her face got more serious. “You know quite a lot.” She took her hands out and crossed them in front of her chest. “Well, why are you here?”

“I bring you a message from Lord of Border town, Guardian of the Western Region, the fourth prince of the Kingdom of Graycastle, His Highness Roland Wimbledon.” Nightingale bowed slightly. “He’s creating a new order of the world that allows witches to live together with average people peacefully, and he hopes you can assist him.”

“Prince… Roland?” Marquess frowned. “The incompetent nobility who was always laughed at by everyone?” With an absurd look on her face, she said, “This is ridiculous, Lord of Border Town? He’s just a rebel banished to a waste land!”

“Timothy was the real usurper,” Nightingale said, “and Prince Roland will soon dethrone him. But that’s beside the point… His Highness needs your magic power to strengthen the ability of a witch. Would you mind making a trip to Border Town?”

Chapter 413

Chapter 413: The Incident

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

Spear Passi was silent for a while before saying, “Are you threatening or inviting me?”

“I’m inviting you, of course,” Nightingale said. “His Highness doesn’t believe in coercing witches. In fact, I don’t either.”

“In this case, I refuse,” Spear answered without hesitation. “If he really needs my help, he can bring the witches to the Fallen Dragon Ridge to visit me for the ritual of the nobility. No need to send someone sneaking in my castle. Of course, if a witch attracts the church’s attention I can’t ensure her safety.”

The answer was just as Nightingale had expected. It was difficult to get a stranger to agree to such a difficult request. Generally, there were two means of handling the situation—coercion and inducement, but she didn’t want to perform either option. Marquess Passi was the Lord of the city and would be the guardian of the realm once promoted. However, His Highness did not plan to flatter her in any way. Instead, he would withdraw power from the nobles. According to His highness, this was called the centralization of authority. In this instance, she would be degrading herself in the eyes of nobility if she was at His Highness’ service.

In regards to following Roland, to create a brand new world and defend in the Battle of Divine Will, she would not believe it from word alone.

“I understand.” Nightingale pouted. “In this case, I shall leave.”

“Hold on…” Spear looked surprised. “That’s all?”

“I’m responsible for bringing His Highness’ messages to you. Now that the message has been delivered and you’ve given me your answer, my task is complete.” She grinned. “Were you expecting me to tie you up and bring you back with me?”

“How did you know about my ability to channel magic?” Marquess hesitated. “Did you talk to the witches who planned to go to the Fjord Islands?”

“Yes. The leader of the witches is Lady Tilly Wimbledon. She’s currently in Border Town, fighting the Demons with her brother.” Nightingale shrugged. “His Highness heard about you from her.”

“They didn’t go to the Fjords?”

“No, they didn’t know His Highness had gained such a firm foothold in the Western Region. They only got in touch after settling down on Sleeping Island.” She gave a brief outline of the alliances on both sides. “Just like you, Lady Tilly was invited to the Western Region by His Highness.”

“Prince Roland really established a system of coexistence for witches and ordinary people in his territory?” Spear frowned and asked. She was having a hard time believing it.

“Not only that, he also evicted the church from his territory.” Nightingale smiled. “Currently there are more than 10 witches living in Border Town. The locals are accustomed to their existence. I’m not lying about this.”

Marquis stood up and poured her a cup of tea. “Can you tell me more about it? How did he do it?”

“If you want to know.” Nightingale turned and sat at the table. It might not change her decision but it was never a bad thing to deepen her understanding. Nightingale decided to tell her about the Witch Union His Highness had built, the war with Duke Ryan and the political run after the recovery of Longsong Stronghold. If Spear could understand the witches’ situation, hopefully she would not resist too much when His Highness eventually unified the Kingdom of Graycastle.

A sudden rush of percussion was heard.

“This is…” Spear looked at Nightingale in shock.

Nightingale opened the window. It was Maggie squatting outside. “Danger, coo! Lightning discovered an accident, coo!”

“What happened?”

“A troop of Judgement Army soldiers is rushing towards the castle, coo!” The pigeon patted its wings and said, “There are at least 20 people, coo!”

“The Judgement Army from the church?” Nightingale turned around and frowned. “Did you summon them?”

“No… I didn’t have an appointment with the church Priest today,” Marquis looked particularly puzzled, “could it be your whereabouts have been exposed?”

“That’s impossible.” She shook her head. “Unless the church has the ability to monitor every bird in the sky.”

“That’s weird…” Spear murmured, “if they were coming for me, they wouldn’t need so many Judgement Warriors. It’s almost the entire force!”

“What are you waiting for? They’re almost at the entrance!” A golden figure darted through the window and landed lightly beside Nightingale. It was Lightning.

“I’m not sure about the situation, I suggest that you avoid it,” Nightingale said, “or get the guards to stop them outside the castle and find out why they’re here before proceeding.”

“This is my castle. Where would I hide? Don’t worry, these people can’t enter without my permission. Otherwise, I would not have been able to protect the witches.” Spear sighed. “However, this meeting may have to end here… If you’re not in a rush, I think…”

Before she could finish her sentence, a series of chaotic footsteps were heard just below the castle. The sound of swords fighting could be heard clearly in the castle, echoing in the mountains. Marquis expression changed. “Who let them in?! Guards!”

Spear called a few names but no one responded from outside. The footsteps were approaching closer and closer.

“It looks like they’re here for you.” Nightingale made a gesture towards Lightning, indicating she should leave first, “You still have time to leave, we can protect you.”

“No, I’m not going anywhere! This is my territory; how could they be so presumptuous… ”

She hardly finished speaking when the door was broken down by a group of heavily armed Judgement Warriors. The Lord was fully surrounded by warriors holding up their swords and shields.

Nightingale hid in the Mist, taking a step back into the corner where it was both convenient to escape and suitable for observation. She noticed that neither Lightning nor Maggie left. The former was peeking her head out from the top of a window, the latter was simply squatting on a beam, arranging her wings.

“These two brats are totally reckless. I’ll get His Highness to discipline them well when we’re back…” She shook her head helplessly and shifted her eyes to the Judgement Warriors. Every one of them was wearing the God’s Stone of Retaliation. The dark holes were intertwined and totally obscured Spear. She could only hear the Marquess’ angry rebuke. “Redwyne, are you crazy? You let them into my castle without permission?”

“Of course not, wise sister.” A man’s voice raised within the crowd. “Father was wrong to give the title to one of the Devil’s minions. I’m simply correcting his mistake.”

Chapter 414

Chapter 414: The Conspiracy

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

“What… What are you talking about?” Spear asked in disbelief. “The devil’s minion? This is a complete fabrication!”

“Fabrication or not, His Reverence will draw his own conclusion,” Redwyne raised his voice and said. “Just because you managed to deceive Father, it doesn’t mean that you can deceive everyone else! Soon, people will know who you really are. You belong in hell!”

“Did you make all these up?” Spear’s tone suddenly became icy cold. “Or someone else put you up to it? I think the latter is true. After all, father chose me because you and our third brother were completely useless.”

“Shut up!”

Nightingale heard a rattle and the Marquess groaned in pain.

“Enough, bring her to the church for questioning,” someone said, “but she’s still a member of the nobility before her verdict, so maintain your etiquette.”

As Spear Passi was carted away, the Judgement Warriors followed right behind her, and soon there were only two people left in the room. Nightingale couldn’t see their faces clearly because of the effects of God’s Stone of Retaliation, but she could tell that one of the voices belonged to Redwyne, the man who spoke to the Lord. If she was not mistaken, this person seemed to be Spear’s younger brother.

“You’re doing really well, Mr. Redwyne; perhaps, I shall address you as Earl going forward.”

“So that’s it, Mr. Rosad?” Redwyne could not hide his excitement. “I really can inherit the title of Earl and become the Lord of the Fallen Dragon Ridge?”

“Of course. As long as you abide by our agreement, you may even go further,” came the reply.

“So, what should I do next?” he asked eagerly. “Can I move into my sister’s room? She won’t leave her cell, right?”

“Spear Passi will soon be hanged to death as a witch in the square as per the terms of our cooperation.” The other man hesitated for a moment, and continued, “As for what to do next, I suggest you relay this incident to all her ministers, knights and men and divide the rights of the Marquess.”

“Do… do I really have to do that?”

“If everyone can benefit from the incident, your position will be much more secure, which will help our future plans to proceed smoothly,” Rosad said. “If you’re still confused, I can always assign a priest to you. He’s very good at handling government affairs and can always advise you on any questions you may have.”

“Yes, please,” Redwyne replied quickly.

“It’ll be very helpful for us if you can hold the Lord’s position, so the church is happy to help with these issues.” His peals of laughter filled the room.

After the men left, Nightingale emerged from the Mist, followed by Lightning and Maggie.

“We’re in trouble.” She stared at both of them and said, “How could the church show up at precisely the right time and place?”

“I thought they said her brother found her true identity and revealed it to the church,” Lightning said, her eyes flashing with excitement. “Now we have something to do.”

“Why didn’t they find it out earlier? Why right now? I feel like something’s wrong.” Nightingale frowned.

“No matter what, we are not going to watch them execute Spear.” Lightning held her head up high and said, “We must save her and annihilate the church!”

“Annihilate it, coo!”

“The confidence of this blonde girl has inflated since defeating the demons. This is not a good sign.” Nightingale shook her head and responded, “We can’t defeat the church for the time being. They must have participated in this conspiracy, so if we removed these people, Spear would naturally return to her position as Lord. This might be an opportunity for us. If we sneak her out, she’ll probably agree to go back to Border Town with us under these circumstances.”

“Awww, we’re not fighting the church?” Lightning asked, disappointment in her voice.

“Battling will be the very last resort since they outnumber us and have a large amount of the God’s Stones of Retaliation. It’s pretty risky to try routing them all at once.” Nightingale contemplated for a moment and said, “I’ll go to the church first and find out what’s going on.”

There was one concern that she didn’t mention. Spear Passi might be thinking that His Highness was the one framing her if the situation wasn’t explained clearly. That, Nightingale knew, should be avoided at all costs.

“What about us?” the little girl asked.

“Just be ready to meet me outside.”

…

The church of the Fallen Dragon Ridge was located on the outskirts of the city. It was small and had a prayer hall, a residential area for the believers, and a three-story tower surrounded by a wall with only one exit. None of these obstacles posed a problem for Nightingale.

She had familiarized herself with the entire area by the time all of the faithful had departed in the evening. Although there were many more God's Stones of Retaliation here than in the castle, Nightingale still managed to find her way. There was a huge God's Stone placed right in the middle of the hall to stifle any magic in the room, and the same was true for some corridors. However, she could always take a detour or even hop over the floor.

Nightingale found the place where Spear Passi was imprisoned in the basement of the tower. She didn't seem too hurt, just a little frustrated. She intended to rescue the Marquess during the middle of the night.

Nightingale snuck back into the tower after sharing her plan with Lightning and Maggie. She ascended to the top floor and hid in a magnificent room.

"This," she thought, "would be the Priest's room. He would probably spill the beans if he found me here with a dagger."

When the bell of the Fallen Dragon Ridge struck nine, swung open.

She drew out her dagger stealthily but didn't attack. She judged from the footsteps that there were two people.

"What an unexpected joy!" said a woman's voice. "Little did we know that Marquess Spear is actually a witch. It seems that we need to tweak our plan."

"Uh… Lady Saint," Rosad answered with a very respectful tone, "isn't it more convincing if she's a witch?"

"It's different from before, because according to the will of the Supreme Pontiff, any new witch who comes to realization shall be handed over to be executed in the Holy City as soon as possible," The woman said. "As for the execution, let's not hang her, but burn a masked death-row criminal with a similar build."

"Yes," Rosad answered. "But why did His Holiness set such a troublesome rule of delivering a witch to Hermes?"

“I’ve no idea, but according to my superiors, it’s simply returning to tradition,” she replied.

“Returning to… tradition?”

“You don’t need to know too much. Just fix the matter at hand hand.” The Saint said brusquely. “I’ll have to head towards the Redwater City once everything is done here.”

“Understood,” Rosad answered crisply.

“Who is she exactly? How come even the Priest is so respectful towards her? It seems they didn’t know that Spear Passi was a witch before they captured her. Could it just be all a conspiracy to seize the throne of the Fallen Dragon Ridge?”

Nightingale couldn’t help but come out from her hiding place and looked at the lady while hidden in the Mist, only to find that she was not wearing a God’s Stone of Retaliation. The magic power inside of the Saint was as bright as a fluorescent light in her world of black and white.

“She’s a witch!”

“Who’s there?” She responded in an instant, and a dazzling silver light shot towards Nightingale!

Chapter 415

Chapter 415: The Fight

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

Nightingale's years of fighting experience kicked into gear, and her body immediately responded before she could even think.

She leaned back instinctively, and the silver light grazed her cheek. Even in the Mist, she could feel the immense power of the light—extraordinarily scorching and intense. After dodging the sudden attack, Nightingale tucked into a roll and distanced herself from her opponent.

"What… what's happening, Lady Saint?" Rosad asked frantically.

"It seems like a rat has snuck in." The witch licked her lips. "Find somewhere to hide and protect yourself."

"You mean… there's a witch here?!" The priest's expression suddenly changed. "I'll summon the Judgement Warriors!"

"No need. I haven't hunted a witch for a long time. How could I let someone else have this priceless opportunity? Just stand by and watch me."

Nightingale was observing the so-called Saint during the conversation. Although she knew that the church was probably secretly raising their own witches, it still broke her heart to see the proof of this theory. This witch had entirely owned by the church, she may even have a high rank, and it sounded like she enjoyed hunting witches and did not see herself as one of them.

Nightingale could not help but remember the determined eyes of the witch who attacked them at the harbor outside the King's City and stabbed Wendy.

These people were no longer witches since they had chosen a completely different path.

With this thought in her mind, Nightingale did not hesitate to pull out her revolver—although she hated this kind of battle, she had no choice but to kill to stop the killing.

“Where do you come from?” The Saint tilted her head and stared towards where Nightingale was standing. “If the priest can’t see you, you have the power to conceal yourself; if you can dodge my attacks, you have been trained for battle or you have fought in many wars. Either way, it’s quite rare for wild witches like you.”

“Wherever I come from is none of your business,” Nightingale said coldly. She noticed the ribbon that blindfolded the opponent, and it was what a blind person would do. The “silver whip” in the Saint’s hand was still curled by her side with its tip raised like a snake, waving at her.

Only magic power displayed color in the Mist. Was she using this strange whip to locate her?

“Maybe you are not aware, but the church has crowned a new Pope who is compassionate, forgiving, and believes that even wild witches deserve to be saved. As long as you are willing to serve the Lord, the church can cleanse your sins off and accept you as a Pure Witch,” the Saint said with her hand on her chest. “This is a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity for you. If you didn’t come alone and are accompanied by other fallen witches, you can all go to the Holy City of Hermes together to seek your rebirth.”

“Wow, that sounds great.” Nightingale chuckled. “But if awakening as a witch is a sin, and you had a way of cleansing it, why would you establish this law now instead of helping all my lost sisters from the beginning? Do you think I’m a toddler who has never heard a blatant lie before?”

She inhaled deeply and narrated. “I have not sinned!”

As she said this, Nightingale broke out of the Mist and pulled the trigger, and the barrel erupted in flames with a thunderous roar.

The “silver whip” immediately flicked upwards and blocked it off the Saint, spewing sparks everywhere. Then, the tip of the whip relaxed and tossed a

twisted metal nugget onto the ground which was the bullet that Nightingale just shot.

This thing could block a flintlock!

“Oh?” Her opponent raised her eyebrow. “What kind of weapon is this?” Her voice cooled down suddenly. “I’ve changed my mind. It looks like you’ll be dying here tonight.”

The silver light lunged towards Nightingale once again, this time it was divided into dozens of whips that completely surrounded her.

Nightingale used her Mist to swiftly back away. Unlike common objects, the whips containing magic power were immune to the Mist, so she couldn’t pass through them and could only try to avoid them. However, her enemy’s range of attack was far too big, and the silver light struck by her side. She felt a slight numbness on her shin and she lost her balance, crashing onto the ground. The magic whips pierced into the ground behind her and pulverized the stone floor into dust. If she had been hit directly, she would have immediately lost her fighting power.

Nightingale ignored the wound on her shin and shot all the bullets in her gun at once from the ground.

The silver whips recoiled and turned into a spinning band of light, blocking all the bullets.

She knew she had no time to reload her bullets in the Mist and that once she wasn’t able to hold off her enemy with her flintlock, she would be in huge trouble—it was too cramped to distance herself from her enemy, and not being able to dodge any attacks would only shrink her range of movement. She pulled out another gun in a panic, shot all the bullets randomly and ducked into the Mist, and fell two stories down through the floor.

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“She escaped!” The Saint screamed. “Summon the Judgement Army to lock down the church, and send guards to the Marquess’ cell as well since the

witch might be here to see her!”

“Escaped?” Rosad glanced around him, not seeing any damage in the doors nor secret exits. “Through what?”

“The walls, the ceiling, or the floorboards—her powers go way beyond invisibility. There isn’t any magic power left in the room!” The Pure Witch gnashed her teeth and said, “Do exactly what I told you to, She’s injured and won’t make it too far. Tell all your men to put on the God’s Stone of Retaliation bolts!”

“Yes!”

After the priest left hurriedly, the Pure Witch immediately collapsed helplessly to the floor, her hands trembling powerlessly.

Damn, what kind of weapon is this?

Her abilities were all-powerful, and her defense power, the magic light that could block any attack, was seen as the strongest among Pure Witches—no sword or bolt could ever penetrate it.

In order to strengthen her powers, she was constantly using her magic light. After more than ten years, she was able to carry such an immense amount of magic power that hundreds of arrows were futile, and she had never exhausted her magic power due to blocking anything.

However, her opponent’s attack drained her magic power instantly, and she was no longer able to even maintain her abilities. She felt an extreme fatigue that she hadn’t experienced in years.

“I must get my hands on this Fallen Witch, dead or alive,” she thought vengefully.

Chapter 416

Chapter 416: Retreat

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

Nightingale followed the path she had scouted out before, passed through three rooves, and landed straight in the dungeon that the Marquess was held.

Spear Passi heard the sound and stared up with wide eyes. “How… did you get in?”

Nightingale raised a finger to her lips as a sign for silence and limped out of the steel door. Judging from their clothing, the two guards in the pathway were probably followers of the church. She used the Mist to instantly move behind the two men and slit their throats with a dagger—they would never have expected an attack from within the dungeon, so they didn’t even turn their heads as they lay dying.

After returning to the dungeon, Nightingale finally had a chance to examine her wound.

The wind-resistant pants that Soraya made for her were cut open, and blood was gushing from a wound on her shin that was half an inch deep. Her enemy’s magic whip must have scraped through the pants and cut through her flesh, but thankfully it had not damaged any bones. If not for the sturdy coating on her pants, she would have been injured even more seriously.

“You’re hurt,” Spear said with a frown.

“It’s not too bad. We have to leave before you turn into a corpse.” Nightingale did not tell the Marquess about the Saint’s plans of taking her to Hermes, for it seemed just as bad as dying, or even worse. “They had no idea that you were a witch before they captured you, so it must be the church’s conspiracy to gain control of Fallen Dragon Ridge.”

“How about my brother…”

“He’s probably already become the church’s puppet. There’s no time to waste, so I’ll explain to you on the road.” Nightingale tightly tied a sash right above the wound. “Where is the God’s Locket of Retribution?”

The Marquess pointed at her neck. “At first, they only tied my legs with a chain, but then they replaced it with this.”

Nightingale’s heart immediately sunk upon seeing the metal ring as thick as her thumb—this kind of God’s Locket of Retribution was made by stuffing magic stones into a metal tube and sealing it with a special technique, making it practically impossible for someone to undo it.

“Do you remember where the locking device is?”

“It’s inside the dungeon near the entrance, where they brought me to be locked.”

It was obvious that after discovering the Marquess’ real identity, the Saint decided to use the strongest restrictions that could almost trap any witch except an Extraordinary.

She would have to remove this contraption in order to take Spear into her Mist and escape.

“Let’s go to the first dungeon,” Nightingale said decidedly. “Come with me.”

She fought against the stabbing pain in her shin, returned to the fallen guards, took their keys, and opened the cell door.

Suddenly, the tolls of ringing bells broke the silence and echoed throughout the tower, which made her heart race.

“That’s the church’s alarm,” Spear said with a panicked expression.

“I knew they would come eventually,” Nightingale whispered. “Our only chance of surviving is to move faster than our enemy.”

The alarm might have actually helped her because all the men in the basement would swarm towards the only entrance at once, making it easy for her to eliminate them together.

She descended on them with her Mist and aimed her gun at these men. After her bullets pierced her first target, they immediately struck her second, splattering blood everywhere. The God's Stones of Retaliation that they wore served as clear targets in her black-and-white vision, while her invisibility rendered the men clueless about where to attack. After two rounds of shooting, there was not a single living guard left in the dungeon.

However, she knew that these were the lowest-rank followers and that an armed Judgement Army was headed their way soon. If she couldn't take off the God's Stone of Retaliation before their arrival, it would be very difficult to escape.

"Come here!" She quickly spotted the locking device—a metal instrument resting against the wall with two rusty clamps stretching outwards, resembling a terrifying torture device.

Spear pressed her neck against the clamps, and Nightingale fastened the device onto her and furiously turned its handle. With the help of the pulleys, the clamps pulled in opposite directions and created an opening in the God's Locket of Retribution.

At the same time, the sound of the Judgement Army's armor rattled near the cell door.

"That's them right there!" Someone yelled.

"Take aim—shoot!"

"Let's go!" Nightingale brought Spear into the Mist, but small black holes shot towards her and tore her Mist apart.

There were God's Stones of Retaliation on the bolts! Nightingale felt a cold sweat break on her forehead as she and the Marquess became completely visible to the Judgement Warriors—it was clear to see that these men were

trained very differently from regular followers. They shot their first round of bolts all throughout the passageway to close off their exit, and only half of the men participated in the first attack.

Meanwhile, the other half waited for the witches to expose themselves.

After spotting their target, the second wave of arrows flew towards them.

Nightingale heard the buzzing of arrows behind her and pulled the Marquess in front of her body, yelling. “Duck!”

A searing pain spread like fire through her back as she was hit by countless arrows, but she didn’t stop running.

As they rounded a corner, Nightingale tasted blood in her mouth, probably from biting her lip in pain before. “Are you OK?”

“I’m… I’m fine,” the Marquess said blankly. “Did, did you just block the bolts for me?”

“If you were shot, you would be gone for, but I might make it.” Nightingale reached behind her and found that none of the arrows had pierced through Soraya’s windbreaker—although her back hurt like it was on fire, there were only bruises, and no stone powder had entered her body.

The Judgement Warriors hurried towards them. They probably did not expect the two witches to survive the second wave of bolts without a shield, so they were a considerable distance away.

After escaping the binds of the God’s Stone of Retaliation, Nightingale grabbed Spear and entered her Mist. She rushed upwards through the floorboards and soil to the outside of the tower, took a bamboo tube from her bag, and pulled the string on its end.

A blinding red light shot out of the tube into the sky and exploded into a shower of sparks that looked like stars dotting the sky.

When His Highness gave this to her, he kept boasting about how one flare would summon a thousand troops to her aid. Right now, she didn’t need a

thousand troops and only prayed that Maggie could see her signal.

Soon, a giant shadow descended from the sky as Maggie landed next to the tower, her large body crushing its walls and her wings fanning away the fog around them.

“What… what is that?” Spear Passi stared in awe.

“That’s my friend.” Nightingale had Lightning fastened the Marquess onto Maggie, used the last of her strength to crawl onto her back, patted her body, and said, “Let’s fly.”

“Aooooo… aoooo… ” Maggie roared at the incoming Judgement Warriors, flapped her wings, took off, and disappeared into the night with the two witches.

Chapter 417

Chapter 417: Strike back

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

On the Fallen Dragon Ridge, Lightning expertly set up a tent big enough for four beyond the wind's reach.

Nightingale sat by the fire to warm herself. She rolled up the cuffs of her pants and found her calves stained with blood. The places hit by the Saint were swollen. She had not felt it at the time with adrenaline coursing through her, but now, as she relaxed, she struggled to lift her legs. If Maggie had not come to her rescue, she probably would not have been able to run any further with carrying the Marquess.

It was extremely dangerous to move in the Mist in her current condition. The changing lines inside of it were staircases lined with sharp blades waiting to cut her to pieces if given the opportunity.

"Let me help you, coo."

Maggie took first aid supplies from a big backpack. Besides cotton and a small bottle of rubbing alcohol, she found an herbal remedy prepared by Leaf, the medicinal mainstay of the Witch Cooperation Association.

Try as she might, Nightingale could not stifle her gasp with accompanying grimace when the pungent alcohol was poured over her wounds. If His Highness hadn't mentioned that it could kill the bacteria that caused the demonic plague, she would think this was some type of torture.

To Nightingale's great relief, the scorching burn was relieved quickly by the herbal preparation. As soon as her wounds were bandaged, she felt much more comfortable.

"Your back… " the Marquess said in a low voice, "Is it alright?"

“What’s about her back?” Lightning crawled into the tent with a bundle of firewood.

“To save me… she was shot by their bolts,” Spear said forlornly.

“No big deal. It’s like taking a couple of punches.” Nightingale twitched her mouth. “It’s not a problem as long as I don’t sleep on my back tonight.”

“It’s better to apply some herbal medicine on it,” Lightning said while fiddling the branches in the fire pit with the sparks flying. “Leaf’s medicine, not only can stop the bleeding, but also is very effective for bruises.”

“Lay down on me, coo.” Maggie sat down and patted her lap. “Let me apply the medicine to your back, coo.”

Seeing the serious look in the white-haired girl’s eyes, Nightingale could not disobey and acquiesced without argument. “Alright.”

She took off her clothes with her hands covering her chest and reclined in Maggie’s lap. The Marquess let out a muffled gasp.

She knew without looking that her smooth back was now mottled with darkening red bruises. “But it just looks scary. Since witches have strong self-healing capacity, these wounds will heal after two or three days,” she thought, shrugging it off the best she could.

During this tender evaluation and treatment, Nightingale coughed twice and said, “Marquess, do you have any plans for the future? Your brother Redwyne, deluded by the church, has betrayed you. Actually, before that military coup, neither he nor the church knew you’re a witch.” Then she briefly repeated what she had heard in the tower to the Marquess. “They worked in collusion to deprive you of your title. Even if you aren’t a witch, you’ll be put to death as a devil’s minion. It’ll be easy work for the church.”

“If they dare to murder a marquess,” Spear said, gnashing her teeth, “I’ll make Redwyne and the church pay the price!”

“The church’s deeds are far beyond your imagination.” Nightingale shook her head. “They kill even kings without blinking. Think of the Kingdom of Everwinter and the Kingdom of Wolfheart.”

Spear was stunned for a moment and then opened her mouth to ask, “Does the church really dare to swallow all four kingdoms? I’ve only heard about it from merchants of neighboring countries, but most of the nobility in the King’s City thought it ridiculous.”

“The nobility in King’s City also said Roland Wimbledon was a rebel king.” Nightingale shrugged. “If His Highness guesses right, conquering the four kingdoms is only the first step in the church’s plan, but unless you join the Witch Union, I can’t tell you the conspiracy behind it. Besides, the church must spend some time plotting this military coup and most of your men should have already swung to Redwyne who has promised them more profits. If you want to take back Fallen Dragon Ridge, you can turn to His Highness for help.”

“Will he really help me?”

“Of course, it’s our solemn duty to wipe out the church,” Nightingale said with a trace of a smile touching her lips.

Marquess was silent, and she looked like she was hesitating to say something.

“Believe me,” Nightingale said, recognizing the Marquess’ hesitation. “You’re free to leave the Western Region anytime you want. His Highness never compels anyone to stay.”

“Is he really establishing a place where witches and ordinary human beings live together?”

This was the second time she had asked Nightingale this question, and again Nightingale answered proudly, “Yes, His Highness’ territory is a place like that. It’s the witches’ Holy Mountain.”

In the firelight, the expression seemed uncertain on Spear Passi's face. After quite a long while, she nodded slightly and asked, "Are we going to set off tomorrow?"

"Not yet," Nightingale and Lightning spoke with one voice. Then they gazed into each other's eyes and burst into laughter.

"The local church will try to report to Holy City what happened here, so in the following two days, we must catch all the pigeons sent out by our enemy," Nightingale explained to the Marquess. "After that, Maggie will carry you to Border Town. I have some other pressing demands here."

She remembered what the Saint had said in that room atop the tower: she would leave for Redwater City soon after the military coup.

Apparently, wherever the Saint went, an undercurrent of tension soon followed. Troubles big or small were sure to find His Highness. If she could impede the Saint, she would not only sabotage church's plan but also collect a bounty of information from the Saint.

Nightingale took a deep breath and made a plan to kill every member of that church platoon, but she was not sure whether Prince Roland would agree to her plan. If he insisted on her giving up the plan and going back, she would do as he wished.

…

Three days later Maggie, who had already sent the Marquess on to Border Town, returned to Fallen Dragon Ridge bearing two witches from the Sleeping Island on her back.

"Why are you here?" Nightingale asked, the surprise evident on her face.

"Prince Roland sent us to help you," Andrea said, gracefully hopping off the big bird's back, doffing her hood and giving her blonde hair a nice shake. "We'll get two pieces of ice cream bread in return."

“Wiping out a church platoon, you can never do that without me!” Ashes said with a smile.

“His Highness said you can do what you’ve planned, but take safety into account first, coo.” Maggie changed back to a girl and continued, “He said he was waiting for you to return to the castle.”

“Really… ” Nightingale mused, suddenly aware of warmth in her heart. “I get it.”

“So how many are there?” Ashes raised her eyebrows slightly. “I heard there’s a witch among them?”

“I don’t know the exact number yet, but there are at most 20 Judgement Warriors along with their servants and some believers,” she said in a measured voice. “You take care of the others and leave the witch to me.”

Chapter 418

Chapter 418: Finish the Fighting

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

They had been on the ridge for a week when Lightning detected the platoon at the north gate of Fallen Dragon Ridge.

As Nightingale had expected, the church's emissary delegation was composed of 25 fully armored Judgement Warriors, who were riding stallions at the head of the platoon. There was a transport corps of around 100 mercenary fighters and believers walking behind the Judgement Army.

Among them, there were two coaches. She assumed the Saint was in one of them.

The five witches secretly followed the platoon, as it headed toward Redwater City.

According to the plan, they would initiate the attack when the platoon was out of the monitoring area and thus would be unable to call for backup quickly.

Nightingale quietly watched a coach in the platoon from her mist and vaguely saw a silver light of magic power coming out through the distorted silhouette of the carriage.

If Nightingale acted alone, she could probably kill the Saint of the church, but it was not guaranteed that she could kill all of the enemies here. But now, with the help of the witches from Sleeping Island, it was highly possible that they would be able to block the news in the Southern Territory.

Once this platoon was eliminated, Hermes would not know anything, at least until next spring. And by then it would be very difficult for them to investigate what had happened to the emissary delegation.

Nightingale did not like killing, but this time it was an intentional decision.

It would lighten the burden on His Highness and help to defend the witches' Holy Mountain.

She would not regret it.

When the emissary delegation entered the forest, Nightingale saw a dark shadow coming close.

It was Maggie. She folded her wings and swooped down, roaring. Horses suddenly neighed in fright and went off uncontrollably. All the people were shocked, dumbfounded and only stared goggle-eyed at the scene.

But the giant beast did not burst into the crowd to bite and stomp on them as they had expected. Instead, it spread its wings just over their heads and flew away close to the ground, leaving a storm behind it. The strong wind made it hard for them to open their eyes. Suddenly, a person jumped off the beast's back and landed on the ground.

"Enemy attack!" the Judgement Warriors shouted among the emissary delegation.

Hearing this, the believers began to recover themselves, drew out their weapons and struck at the unknown enemy at the center of the platoon.

Nightingale's vision filled with black and white lines. They were fully covered with lightless black holes which could protect them from ordinary witches, but not from Ashes the Extraordinary.

She cut all the believers within her range in two, at their waists, like reaping wheat. All the people around her fell swiftly. She used an ordinary iron sword instead of her symbolic heavy sword, in order for Maggie to carry one more witch besides herself. The iron sword quickly cracked and broke during the fight. She seized the weapons dropped by the enemy, a halberd, a stick, sometimes an iron hammer or a cutlass. Anything in her hand became a lethal weapon.

Blood splashed and bodies were torn apart. In the middle of the platoon, Ashes cut them in two all by herself.

In the rear part of the platoon, the mercenary fighters could hardly offer the middle section any help because they had their own difficulties.

Andrea kept skipping through the forest like a fairy. She used the branches and trunks of the trees to cover herself and shoot arrows every time she changed position. Every one of her arrows would hit someone between his eyebrows and every one of her shots was to kill.

In less than ten minutes, the whole platoon was a mess. Screams, cries and fighting noises resounded in the forest.

Nightingale joined the fight immediately. She dashed through her mist, closely following her target, whowas her only target in this fight, the Saint of the church and the witch hunter. The coaches were drawn by the frightened horses. They ran wildly for a long way before the horses finally calmed down, but then they did not return to the platoon. Instead, they left the main road and burrowed into the forest in two different directions.

It seemed that the Saint had already noticed that among her enemies there was a tough opponent, an Extraordinary. For most witches, an Extraordinary with God's Stone of Retaliation was unbeatable.

Unfortunately, she could not escape from Nightingale's control.

Nightingale had already spotted her position earlier on. The one in the other coach was likely a high-ranking priestess or priest.

Nightingale left it to Lightning and Maggie.

Despite the fact that the Saint's coach tossed heavily on the bumpy road in the forest, the coachman kept whipping the horses, looking like he was urged by someone to speed up.

Nightingale approached. In order to shoot fatally every time, she only fired when she was less than ten meters behind the target and in line with it. She

aimed at the four Judgement Warriors following the coach and pressed the trigger to kill them one by one. The Judgement Army immediately split off at the sound of the gun, but the distance now was still only several steps for Nightingale in her mist. Further, their full armors were doing more harm than good in a fight against large caliber bullets. The bullets became more harmful to the human body after going through these deformed, cracked armors.

After getting rid of the four Judgement Warriors, she pointed her gun at the horses.

As the two horses fell down, the fragile wooden carriage promptly flew off from the force. It then hit a tree trunk and immediately fell apart.

Through the flying pieces, a person wrapped in silver light rolled out. Nightingale aimed and shot without hesitation, but the light formed by magic power seemed to have consciousness and blocked the bullets one by one.

She moved away to reload a new cartridge.

“Traitor!” the Saint shouted angrily, charging towards where Nightingale hid.

This time, the situation was different.

They did not fight in a small room anymore. Now every step Nightingale took would cost the Saint more than ten steps to catch up and the effective range of a revolver which was around 50 meters was much bigger than the area a witch could affect with her ability. The Saint’s “silver whip” could hardly reach Nightingale while a bullet could put the Saint to death anytime.

At this distance, merely one or two out of five shots could hit the target, but luckily Nightingale had enough time to reload new cartridges and keep aiming and firing.

After five catridges, the silver light dimmed out. One shot hit the Saint’s left shoulder and another went through her stomach. She could no longer stand. She staggered a few steps, and then fell to the ground.

Nightingale was not in a hurry to approach her. She went back to the place where the carriage had fallen apart to pick up a God's Stone of Retaliation before she walked to the Saint. During the fight, she had kept moving around the carriage so it would be easier to search the site afterwards.

The moment Nightingale appeared beside the blood-covered witch, she suddenly stretched out her right hand, the only part she could move now, only to find that her silver light could not pierce her enemy as she wanted.

"You damned demon, the gods will put you on trial!" she said, gritting her teeth, blood was spewing out of her mouth.

Nightingale pointed the gun at her chest expressionlessly and replied, "Really? I'll wait for that day."

Then she pressed down the trigger.

Chapter 419

Chapter 419: Faith

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

After the smoke caused by the battle dissipated, the forest returned to silence.

The witch's long braids had unraveled, and her hair spread like white petals over her body.

Blood streamed down her back and quickly formed a dark red puddle, slowly immersing into the ground and melting the cold, hard soil. After that, the air was filled with a smell of iron.

Nightingale squatted and untied the blindfold on the witch's face. She found the face looked unexpectedly young, probably similar to her own age. However, the scars by her eyes destroyed her overall beauty—her eyes looked like they had been repeatedly burned by red-hot iron, and her skin was red and wrinkled, so she had lost the contours of her eyes.

This was undoubtedly caused by men. Nightingale gently touched the wrinkled scars; as for whether she suffered these wounds before becoming a witch or after serving the church, no one would ever know. However, this was no longer important because from now on, she couldn't hurt any more witches and wouldn't suffer any more torments.

After searching the Saint's body, Nightingale found a letter, a seal and an emblem in the pocket of her robe lining. The emblem was a circle split by a cross with a clenched fist in the center.

She carried nothing else—no gold royals or jewelry.

"Perhaps she never enjoyed anything in her life," Nightingale couldn't help but think.

“Hey, look at what I caught.” Lightning’s voice sounded from the air. She looked up and saw the little girl carrying a struggling man, whom she threw onto the ground.

The man groaned in pain and rolled around, trying to get up, but he was hog-tied, so all he could do was to twist around helplessly.

The man’s outfit revealed that he was probably the Priest who was sitting in the other carriage.

“Where’s Maggie?”

“She’s guiding Ashes to chase the runaway Judgement Army.” Lightning walked over to the Saint. “This is the witch trained by the church?”

“Uh-huh,” Nightingale said softly. “She won’t ever hunt us again.”

“From her appearance, it’s difficult to believe that she saw us as enemies who must be killed… ” The little girl sighed.

“If not for the church, none of this would have happened.” Nightingale turned to glare at the captive man. When he saw the witch lying in a pool of blood, his eyes immediately widened, and he tried to say something but couldn’t because of the cloth gag in his mouth.

She took out the cloth. “Do you have anything to say for yourself?”

“Ahem… you, you’ve killed the Pure Witch of Bishop Tayfun, reckless devil! You’ll sooner or later be hung by the church at the city gate and left to the crows!”

“Even if we didn’t kill her, being caught by the church is no better,” said Nightingale, “and compared with this, you’d better worry about yourself first.”

“Even if I die, I’ll have the salvation of God, and you guys will only sink into Hell and be tortured forever!” He yelled.

“That’s why I have to block his mouth,” Lightning said.

Nightingale stuffed the cloth back into his mouth. “Let His Highness deal with him. He said that the Iron Axe is very good at interrogating such kinds of people.”

…

By the time Maggie brought over the two witches from Sleeping Island, it was already afternoon. Ashes jumped down from the back of the beast and landed steadily next to Nightingale. ” You’re not hurt, are you?”

“Everything went well,” she said. “How about you?”

“Obviously, not a single man escaped.” Ashes laughed proudly.

“Is she dead?” Andrea landed and looked at the Saint. “I thought you’d keep her alive.”

“The enemy was a witch, so hesitating would have been extremely dangerous,” Ashes twitched her mouth and said. “If I were you, I wouldn’t keep her alive either.”

“Gee, you have no mercy for your own kind.”

“She isn’t our kin, but a puppet controlled by the church,” the Extraordinary said casually. “Besides, sometimes our own kind can be even crueler than others. I’ve never seen demonic beasts or demons imprison and torture people for several years.”

After saying that, she took off her blood-stained gloves and offered her hand to Nightingale. “Your actions and performance were amazing, and you did the right thing in this situation.”

“… ” The latter stared at her for a moment before holding her hand. “Thank you.”

“Who would have thought that someone like her would comfort me,” Nightingale thought. “She probably didn’t want me to feel guilty for killing a witch.”

“I think this victory is worth celebrating,” Lightning said.

Maggie agreed with a “Coo!”

Andrea rolled her eyes, reached out her hands, and placed them on top of the others’. “I have to clarify that if it were only your hand, I wouldn’t touch it, so this’s for Nightingale’s sake.”

“OK, I get it,” Ashes said, raising her eyebrow.

Then, the five witches raised their hands to the sky, looking like an unwavering tower in the cold wind.

…

Next, they needed to collect the information carried by the emissary delegation and hide the traces of their battle. After properly dealing with these issues in the forest for two days, they arrived back in Border Town three days later.

After landing in the castle backyard, Nightingale was immediately surrounded by her sisters.

“I heard you were hurt. Where is the wound?” Nana asked.

“She has been waiting for you for a long time. Why did you come back so late?” Lily asked, annoyed.

“Does it… still hurt?” Lucia asked urgently.

“This batch of herbs was made especially by me. They can’t only stop bleeding, but also calm swelling, so their effect should be pretty great,” Leaf said with a smile.

“How could you be so careless to scurry into the church alone! You might not be this lucky next time!” This was Wendy’s voice.

“It’s alright as long as she can return safely.” Scroll chimed in.

Seeing their concerned faces warmed Nightingale's heart, and she didn't understand how the Church's witches lived, but she knew what it was like to belong to the Witch Union. There was no doubt that this was worth devoting everything to.

Then, she saw His Highness Roland.

Lightning jumped into his arms and stuck to him like a gecko.

Maggie also flew onto Roland's shoulder, rubbing his cheek.

Although Nightingale wanted to do this too, she knew that she wasn't a child, so she held back the impulse to embrace Roland, walked up to him, and said with a smile, "I'm back."

"Uh-huh, I've waited for you for a long time." The prince smiled his familiar smile. "Take a hot bath and get some rest. I put a few bags of honey grilled dried fish in the office drawer."

"OK, then I'll go help myself."

Nightingale smiled.

She reassured herself that she had done the right thing.

Chapter 420

Chapter 420: The Lord's Response

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

That night, Roland held a magnificent banquet at the Lord's castle.

Since they not only rescued Spear Passi but also captured a Priest from Hermes, it was technically the Witch Union's first unprovoked attack on the church.

As the five witches who had participated in the battle walked on to the stage, the hall erupted into applause, and even Roland, who rarely drank, drained two glasses of Evelyn's chilled white liquor.

Although it was only a small triumph, the Months of the Demons were long and stressful, and he wanted to take this opportunity to help everyone relax.

When Roland stumbled into his office the next morning with a raging headache, Nightingale was already waiting for him, sitting cross-legged on his table.

"Don't you need more rest?" he asked with a smile.

Ever since he agreed to let her attack the emissary delegation, he had been worrying about her—even if he knew she was in a spacious area and could use the Mist to remain invincible, he still fretted about accidents. Afterall, this wasn't daily practice, but a true battle of life and death. Now seeing her energetic and vital, he felt much better.

Nightingale swallowed her dried fish and said, "Of course I don't. I'm in a great shape right now."

As soon as Roland returned to his seat, she jumped off the table, walked to the back of the chair, and hugged him. "One more day of rest is one more day

without seeing you."

The prince was slightly startled.

"I actually wanted to do this yesterday in the castle garden… but now isn't such a bad timing either," Nightingale whispered into his ear.

…

She did not let him go and disappeared into the Mist until she heard the footsteps outside the door.

"Your Highness." A guard shouted. "The Lord of Fallen Dragon Ridge, Marquess Passi, is here to see you."

"Send her in." Roland cleared his throat and adjusted his posture.

Spear Passi walked into the office, bowed, and sat in front of his desk. "I've thoroughly considered your proposal."

"What do you think?" He poured a cup of tea for her.

While Nightingale, Ashes, and others were battling against the church, he had also been busy with showing the Marquess around the town and negotiating with her. Roland briefly told her the crisis that the kingdom faced, the origins of the church, and the threats of the demons, as well as his future plans.

When Spear heard about the church's origins and their reasons for hunting witches, she was so shocked that her eyes widened to the utmost. If not for the testimonies of Tilly and Agatha, she would have never believed that witches once had ruled the entire Barbarian Land, but her attitude changed greatly afterwards.

"Repealing feudal power, universalizing laws and administration institution, prohibiting the inheritance and sale of titles… I can accept these requests, but…" She paused. "I'm just curious. Do you really plan to spread this to all the territories?"

“Yes. If we don’t do this, Kingdom of Graycastle will be nothing but loose sand,” Roland said, nodding. “Before our final enemies arrive, we must gather as much power as possible.”

“Your plan will offend all of the nobilities,” said Spear slowly, “especially the part prohibiting the inheritance of titles—if I’m not mistaken, the Lord of a territory is also a title. Doing so will confirm your reputation of the ‘rebel king’.”

“That’s why I don’t expect them to back down voluntarily,” he said, knocking on his desk. “Before the fateful Battle of Divine Will, the nobility’s discontent is not my priority. I don’t have to kill them all, either. As long as these people accept my new terms, they may even be able to keep their territories, just not their feudal power—I believe they’ll make the right decision.”

Centralization of authority was only effective when all the power was held by a few people, so if local authorities had too much power, they would threaten this centralization and even his position as a ruler. Unlike one year ago, the town now had the ability to undergo a revolution. After this step was completed, he would be the only ruler of Kingdom of Graycastle in a real sense.

“You seem to have made up your mind.” Spear sighed. “If I don’t accept them, your army will probably overturn my ruling anyways.”

“I desperately need manpower for my plan,” Roland said earnestly, “especially someone with experience in governing a city. Like I said, you won’t lose your territory, and you can proudly reveal your identity as a witch to your people without fear of the church.”

The Marquess was silent for a while. “I also have a request.”

“Please, go ahead.”

“After you take back Fallen Dragon Ridge for me, I don’t want anything to change,” she said bluntly. “I can only fully support you when Timothy is no longer the king.”

“What a clever answer…” Roland thought. “She avoided giving a strict refusal and gave herself some room for changing her mind. Basically what she meant is that in order to earn her support, he needs to prove that his plan of unifying Kingdom of Graycastle isn’t just empty talk and that he’s truly capable of doing it.”

“It’s a deal then.” He didn’t think much of the Marquess’ secret calculations. If his attack in the spring went well, it might be easier to overturn Timothy than retrieving Fallen Dragon Ridge.

“Oh, by the way, Your Highness.” Spear hesitated. “The witches are attending class tonight, and I’m wondering if I could join them…”

Roland was a bit surprised. “Those are all very basic beginner courses. You probably won’t learn anything new.”

“I’m intrigued by their calculating methods,” she said, shaking her head. “I’ve never seen anything like them before.”

“Is she talking about the Multiplication Table or algebraic equations?” He mused. “Of course, as long as you’re willing to join the Witch Union.”

…

After lunch, Iron Axe brought him some good news.

“He’s willing to talk?” Roland was slightly surprised. “That soon?”

According to Nightingale, the captive Priest was quite stubborn.

“Not everyone has a will of steel, Your Highness,” answered Iron Axe seriously. “The Sand Nation has some unique interrogation methods that barely damage the body but destroy the mind, even making some people view death as a relief. He has already lingered longer than most people.”

“That’s right,” he thought. “Professional spies not only have extraordinary willpower, but are also trained not to crack under any interrogation, but no one in this era has received this kind of training.”

“Take me to see him,” said Roland. “I have quite a few questions for him.”

Chapter 421

Chapter 421: The Interrogation

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

The prison of the town hadn't changed much since he arrived one year ago.

His mass infrastructure development did not extend to this place, and although the houses and roads above the ground had been renovated, the prison below still reeked of decay. Moss grew on the stone walls, and muddy water dripped down the stairs.

The only difference was that the cells held very few prisoners.

Due to the the expansion and development of the territory, anyone who was willing to work was able to find a job. The scoundrels who were unwilling to change were sent by Roland to the mines, where they were whipped into shape.

Since Anna had wrecked the cells at the bottom of the prison, and there was no need to repair them, the entire lower floor was sealed off and abandoned. Roland followed Iron Axe to the middle of the third floor and saw the captive Priest—the only criminal on this floor.

The man was not hanging on a torture rack nor beaten to a bloody pulp, which completely defied Roland's idea of an interrogation. He was huddled in the icy corner of his cell, and although his clothes were all intact, he seemed completely lifeless and pale with hollow eyes without focus.

"Is he alright?" Roland asked quietly.

"It's not an issue, Your Highness," Iron Axe answered with a bow. "If you have any questions, you can ask him directly."

The prince nodded. The Sand Nation's interrogation methods were indeed unique, but he was not interested in the specifics or the humanity of Iron Axe's process, as long as it got the job done. He cleared his throat, sat down on the long wooden bench near the cell, and asked the Priest through the bars, "What's your name?"

"Are you the Fourth Prince of Kingdom of Graycastle… Roland Wimbledon?" The man's expression changed. "Look… look at what you've done. You've unleashed the demons' powers."

"His Highness is asking your name," said Iron Axe coldly. "If you don't want to undergo last night's punishment again, then cut the crap."

The Priest's face froze, and after a short pause, he lowered his head and said, "My… my name is Campus."

"I heard you're from the Holy City of Hermes?" Roland glanced at the man. "Who was the witch traveling with you? Was she also from the Holy City? What was her role in the church?"

"Her…" Campus seemed hesitant and was silent for a long time before answering, "Her name was Aurora, and she was one of Master Tayfun's Pure Witches. She didn't take any positions in the church."

"Tayfun?" The prince pondered for a while upon this familiar name.

"He's one of the three Archbishops of the Holy City, in charge of the church's external affairs. His position is second only to the Supreme Pontiff." The Priest explained.

Roland suddenly remembered that he had met this person before—at a ceremony in King's City. That day, King Wimbledon III organized a big coming-of-age celebration for Tilly Wimbledon, and Tayfun was the Bishop sent by the church to the ceremony. In his memory, Tayfun seemed like a benevolent old man with a caring and forgiving smile, as if he had nothing to do with anything evil in the world.

"What's a Pure Witch?"

Campus hesitated once more, but after Iron Axe threatened him again, he grudgingly responded. “Pure Witches are witches who are raised by the church and directly managed by Bishops and the Supreme Pontiff, so I don’t know too much about them.”

Roland scratched his ear to signal for Nightingale’s confirmation and learned that the man was not lying.

“How many people know about the church’s hidden witches?”

The Priest shook his head. “Master Tayfun only told me about this two years ago and ordered me not to tell other believers, so… I’m not sure how many people know.”

“The church is obviously very secretive about raising Pure Witches, which at least means they aren’t publicly holding a double standard,” thought Roland. “This is definitely good news.” This finally confirmed his suspicion and gave him another piece of evidence to hold against the church—if the believers found out that the sermons they received were all false and that the church was secretly raising the very enemies they were taught to fight under their noses, how would they react?

“What was your motive in sabotaging the Lord of Fallen Dragon Ridge? Why did you want to take her back to Hermes?”

“I don’t know. My only mission was to monitor Aurora, so only she knows the exact motive. There was a change of plans because Aurora discovered that the lord was actually a witch, and the new Pope thus ordered us to send all captured witches back to the Holy City to be purified.”

“Purified,” Roland snorted. “Do you actually believe that? If purified witches… no, Pure Witches are sinless, why would the church keep their existence as a secret?”

“Because… because some believers aren’t devoted enough, so this’s the only way for now…” His voice trailed off, and he eventually closed his mouth.

The prince sneered. “Where did you plan to go after leaving Fallen Dragon Ridge?”

“Redwater City.”

“After that?”

“Impassable Castle.”

“Anywhere else?”

“Just these three cities.” The Priest responded numbly, having given up resisting after disclosing the information about Pure Witches. “Master Tayfun didn’t tell us when to return, so we were going to stay at Impassable Castle awaiting new orders.”

His answer matched the letter found on the witch’s body. “Why these three cities?”

Campus shook his head.

It seemed that he didn’t know much since for the church, he was probably just a monitor for the Pure Witch. Roland stroked his chin and thought, “Fallen Dragon Ridge is in the Southern Territory, Redwater city in the center of the kingdom, and Impassable Castle between the Northern and Western Territories, so they have nothing in common, and they aren’t important passes or intersections. Even if the church wanted to overturn the Kingdom of Graycastle, they wouldn’t start with these cities.”

If he had to name a similarity between them, it would be that they all lay on the border of the Western Territory—a thought suddenly sprang into his mind: Was he actually the person the emissary delegation was targeting at?

…

The interrogation didn’t stop until evening. Roland collected his information and stood up. When he was about to leave, he noticed that the Priest was sitting motionless against the wall, as still as a corpse, neither begging for

mercy nor cursing in fury. This surprised him greatly. “Aren’t you asking what I intend to do with you?”

“You tortured me into confessing all this… and God will bear witness,” Campus said with his eyes closed. “God is my final judge, not you. It doesn’t matter what you’ll do to me.”

“Your Highness, give me another night with him,” said Iron Axe. “I’ll turn his attitude around.”

“Not necessary. This is enough.” Since the Priest had already confessed everything, Roland had no interest in continuing to torture him. “He’ll be judged, not by God… but by the people.”

Chapter 422

Chapter 422: Public Trial

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

Shortly after winter began, a wooden stage was built in the center of the square. It was the first of its kind for the people of Border Town. It wasn't for a theatrical performance but rather to conduct the first public trial.

A notice had been issued two days prior. On the day of the trial the stage was surrounded by a large crowd. The square area was much larger after the extension but it still wasn't large enough to accommodate the entire community. There were scattered snowflakes falling from the sky, but everyone was too excited and completely ignored the wind and snow.

The atmosphere suddenly reached extremity as Roland appeared on the stage.

Watching the audience at the bottom waving their arms at him, he was emotionally touched. Once he had been almost a laughing stock in the eyes of the nobility and he'd had little influence on his subjects. Now, after just one year, the situation was reversed.

With shouts from the crowd, the Priest Campus was pushed onto the stage. His facial expressions changed a little while facing the crowd. Perhaps this parade was common for the top management from the church. They were accustomed to worship from the believers, and could easily influence the lives of these people with a single word or action, Roland thought. Except that this time, he probably wouldn't go through the brilliance of the past.

With excitement in their eyes, the witches from the union walked up to the wooden stage. They had always been slandered, hunted, unjustly treated and tried. But this time the roles were reversed. Witches were the victims, accusers, and jurors, and the trial object was the church. They had always imagined such a scene, but never expected that such a day would come so quickly.

Roland waved his hands and the people quieted immediately.

“Greetings, my people.”

“The purpose of today’s gathering is to reveal a shameful crime. The church has hidden the truth from the very beginning. I wouldn’t have discovered this shocking news if the Priest of the Holy City had not been captured in a rebellion case.”

Roland had been thinking about how to reveal the church’s crime effectively for the past two days. The rebellion case of Fallen Dragon Ridge shouldn’t be the key point, because the story from a small town far away from them wouldn’t gain their attention; the Battle of Divine Will and the Kingdom of Witches shouldn’t be mentioned, for the story of a few hundred years ago was irrelevant for them and it might cause panic if it revealed the existence of demons. He needed to share something that they cared about in order to arouse the indignation of the masses.

In other words, it had to touch their hearts.

With no doubt, the witches who lived here shared the same daily lives with the people.

“The church has claimed that witches are the devil’s minions, persons that are neither clean nor fortunate, but in fact, both the Pope and the Archbishop have been sheltering witches in a surprisingly large scale! This was said by the Priest himself.” Roland faced the Priest and said, “Am I correct?”

After a long silence, Campus replied, “Yes.”

Discussions broke out in the crowd.

“Your Highness, is he really a priest from the Holy City?” someone asked.

“Of course,” said Roland, showing an expression of praise in the direction of Echo. “He was sent to the Kingdom of Graycastle in the name of the church as a Saint, and all the documents he’s brought reveal his identity!” Roland

pointed to a small table beside the wooden stage. “Priest’s robe, badge, circular letter, all can be used as evidence.”

The crowd was liable to doubts about these, so he would let Echo ask first and then answer them accordingly. Furthermore, these items were real, he didn’t need to fake it.

“My people, come back to what I said before,” continued the prince. “Take note of the term I used—sheltering! Yes, they gather female infants and orphans from all over the country to the monastery of the Holy City and these women are treated as animals. Only a few turn into witches, and proceed to further their training. The rest simply become trinkets for Church believers.”

“No, these …” Campus raised his head and opened his mouth, but he could hardly make a sound.

“In order to get more witches, they shelter female wanderers in the name of relief, and even collude with Black Street Rats to steal infants! Please think, my people, if there were a church in this town, you wouldn’t only lose Miss Nana, but also a family member of yours could be missing too. They claim that the witches are evil spirits, seduced by demons, and drive believers to persecute these innocent women. Could you tolerate if Miss Nana was framed by them?”

“Never, Your Highness, never!”

The atmosphere of the square was hot, and people shook their fists, expressing their anger at the Priest.

“Miss Nana can’t be evil, and she is the one who cured my injury!”

“I’ve know her since she was little. She was my daughter’s classmate in Karl’s college.”

“I would have been killed by demonic beasts if not for her healing. She is an angel to the First Army.”

Roland paused for a moment so the crowd could voice their dissatisfaction, then he continued. “So, why did they do that?”

The question caused a commotion among the subjects.

“Because the church needed witches to maintain their rule!” Before they could make more speculation, the prince said, “As you know, the witches’ abilities are varied and incredible! Besides Miss Nana’s healing and Miss Lily’s elimination of demonic plague, they have many other abilities that can improve our lives. The water supply equipment in our town was made by Miss Anna and Miss Soraya. The flintlocks used by the First Army and the steam engine that pulls the miner’s truck, all these are gifts given by the witches. Our town wouldn’t have achieved any of this without their contributions.”

“But everything has two sides. Like a sword, it can be used to fight the demonic beasts or used to kill the innocent. The church is using the witches’ abilities to hurt good people. And those who don’t obey them are regarded as God’s outcast. In fact, the top management of the church is committing a heinous crime which is recorded in the doctrine, and they completely disregard that their God is watching them.”

“My dear people, if your children were to be kidnapped by the church and used to hurt you after being trained. If they became the church’s whip and razor, how sad that would be!”

Roland turned around, walked to the front of Campus, expanded the long roll of paper, and asked loudly, “Do you have anything else to say about the accusations recorded on this paper?”

“These… are all true.” Popping his eyes, the Priest looked as if he couldn’t believe he had uttered these words. “I… admit guilt.”

The masses became very angry.

“I hand over the right of judgment to you all!” Roland said loudly while the crowd was agitated, “For this evil, your choice is…”

“Kill him!”

“Kill him!”

“Kill him!”

Everybody was shouting the same words, soon there was only one voice left in the square.

In Border Town, with scattered snowflakes floating above, the people made their choice.

Chapter 423

Chapter 423: The “Connection”

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

…

Spear Passi solemnly signed her name at the end after she read both contracts several times.

One was the Memorandum of Unification and the other Memorandum of the Witch Union.

The first contract agreed that Spear would lead Fallen Dragon Ridge to give allegiance to Roland Wimbledon after Timothy Wimbledon’s rule was overthrown, and in response to the request of the new king, she would surrender her power, and Roland would guarantee her position as the Lord of Fallen Dragon Ridge and other rights. The memorandum categorized those to three categories which were human affairs, administrative and finance. Although such a categorization was new but easy for her to understand of which her daily routine was also included too.

Spear thought about the second contract for a long time before she made up her mind, as this time the union was to serve Prince Roland without any doubt. She didn’t want to join Prince Roland so fast, he just occupied the corner region of the Kingdom of Graycastle. But the content of the evening lecture was attractive, and she vaguely sensed that the unique method of calculation would be helpful in managing her territory.

Fortunately, the constitutions of the Memorandum of the Witch Union were very loose, more like a formal consensus, and didn’t even limit the whereabouts of its members. She consulted with the prince regarding this, and his reply was that the members could leave any time they wanted.

“I’ve signed it.”

Spear placed two elegant parchments on the table, but Roland didn't respond. He looked at the empty side as if thinking about something.

"Your Highness?"

"Ah…" He blinked eyes as if he had come back. "Let me have a look at it."

He had seldom been so absent minded before the negotiation, and it seemed like after the trial yesterday, His Highness felt confused. This made it difficult for her to understand. The trial was an absolute success, and people were on his side and cheered him. Before that, Spear had never thought the ordinary people would support a nobility. She thought that she and they were in two different worlds, and the nobility needed neither the understanding nor supporting of the people. But she changed her mind one day ago. After seeing people surrounding the square waving their fists, shouting with a strong voice that shook the sky and land, she realized that they might contain a power that she had never felt and it was more powerful than the noble.

Besides, the decisive judgment displayed by His Highness was also one of the reasons why she signed these two contracts.

Regardless of whether he's trying to protect the witches, it's some kind of good faith to punish rebels who are against his royal power. Considering this, she should respond accordingly.

However, His Highness doesn't seem satisfied… Is he regretting being against the church publicly?

Spear was clear that it was not an enemy they could easily deal with.

It's better to figure it out since it's related to the direction of the future co-operation. She hesitated, and then mentioned it diplomatically.

The prince was astonished for a while after he heard this, and then he shook his head and smiled. "I never regret fighting against the church, after all, they're enemies that must be defeated from all aspects of the view."

"So why…"

“I just have some mixed feelings now.”

“Mixed feelings?”

“I feel a little embarrassed, although what I said was true and what I disclosed were the crimes committed by the church.” He shrugged, “It seems as I’m not a qualified politician.”

Politician? What’s that? Like an astrologer devoting himself to studying stars, is a politician someone devoting himself to studying politics?

His Highness stopped the topic before she could ask. “I’ll keep these parchments. I heard that your ability is related to controlling magic power?”

“Yes.” Spear stopped questioning. “To be more precise, it’s to extract the magic power of one witch for other witches to use. Of course, I can also retrieve and recover my own magic power for the purpose of consumption. As this process doesn’t have a big impact on the outside world, I can repeat the process anytime in the castle.”

“How did you find out you have such an ability?” the prince asked curiously.

“After my awakening.” The Marquess answered, “I’ve no idea how other witches got to know their abilities, but I could feel it, and the feeling was like… you suddenly owned an extra organ.”

“Interesting description.” He nodded thoughtfully. “You should know that the reason I sent Nightingale to Fallen Dragon Ridge is to pass you an invitation.”

“You need my ability.” Spear paused a moment and bowed. “It’s my honor to serve you.”

Anyway, since there was no way for her to return to Fallen Dragon Ridge at the moment, it was better for her to see what the prince usually do, despite the fact that she had just being in the town for a week. She realized that the town was different from others, a secluded land that was far away from the

center of the Kingdom, but as energetic as the capital. As a Lord, she was curious.

What made Spear more surprised was that the life of the witches here was completely different from what she had imagined. The prince didn't over control them, but rather allowed them to live freely, and this could be seen from his waiting for the return of Nightingale—he obviously hoped that she could return early, but still agreed with her requisition.

His Royal Highness didn't treat them as servants.

Some nobles sheltered witches because of their beauty. She thought it would have been done more unscrupulously because His Highness openly recruited witches, but he was surprisingly self-disciplined.

Was the rumor true? Was the prince both prurient and incompetent?

She had more faith and felt ridiculous at the same time. When she thought it back, she felt what Nightingale had told her was totally true.

…

She left the castle with the prince and they came to a yard at the back of the town, where Spear saw two other witches.

"This's Anna and this's Mystery Moon." Roland introduced. "The Magic Power of Mystery Moon is considered at a relatively low level, but the consumption of her magic power is astonishing."

"I'm obviously at a middle level!" Mystery Moon protested.

"Among the awakened witches," the prince added.

Mystery Moon kept quiet immediately.

"Do you want me to connect their magic powers?" Spear looked at Anna. "Does she have the strongest magic power in the union? I suggest that you invite a few more witches to come over. The stock magic power is related to their age, even if there's a difference, it wouldn't be big."

“It’s just an experiment,” His Highness said, touching his chin, “and if it works, I’ll ask them to come over.”

The Marquess nodded and summoned the passage of magic power—it was a sphere shining with blue light, quietly floating in the air. Under her control, two thin tentacle-shaped threads stretched out from the sphere to Anna and Mystery Moon.

“You’ll feel weird in the beginning, so just relax and it’ll be fine,” Spear explained. “It’ll fail to transfer the magic power if you resist it.”

Anna was shocked when the tentacle touched her chest.

What’s… happening here? It seems the tentacle is connected to a solid metal cube instead of the rotating magic power. It’s so huge that I feel like an ant standing at the bottom of it, and I can only see its top while raising my head.

Chapter 424

Chapter 424: The Dawn I

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

How is magic power with such a form possible?

Spear "touched" the edge of the metal in disbelief, which was her unique way of sensing magic power. As soon as the passage was connected, she could see, touch, and even smell the magic powers of witches, as if she were entering their bodies.

Hard and cold, the surface was as smooth as a mirror, reflecting every detail of the tentacle-shaped thread. When the antenna-like cord of energy reached the cube, it swiftly bounced back.

"Relax." Marquess comforted her. "They're harmless." She wasn't sure whether her ability could affect this metallic cube since Anna's magic power seemed unable to flow.

After trying a few times, the antenna finally stuck to the cube.

But there was no transmission of magic power.

"What's going on?" Nightingale noticed something was wrong.

"I've never… transported magic power of this kind. It's too massive and doesn't look like the air that can be transferred." Spear felt her throat dry. "As soon as the channel is connected, the magic power should have been absorbed by the 'pivot'."

"I'll try to charge it with magic power." Anna suddenly spoke. "The same way as using the Sigil of God's Will."

"Be careful not to expend too much each time." His Highness nodded.

What was the Sigil of God's Will? Spear found that she'd heard several new terms since she came to this little town.

As she was pondering, the magic power in Anna's body suddenly transformed.

The perfect mirror was broken, and the surface of the metal rippled. The liquid without light rushed into the pipe and then became a floating ball as if pushed by something.

She then felt some weight.

Different from the cyclone of magic power, the liquid was very heavy. As it flew into the pivot, it was like putting in chunks of iron ingot. Spear found that she was consuming an increasing amount of magic power.

It was rather unbelievable. Prior to this, she could easily exhibit her abilities for half a day. Now at this rate, she might not be able to last a few hours.

Out of desperation, she drew out another cord from the pivot, connected it with her own body, and sustained the channel using Anna's magic power.

When the light ball was full, the metal cube in Anna's body was still in its original form, as if the magic power it lost was only a very insignificant portion.

Spear really wanted to take back what she had just said. She coughed twice. "Hem… now the channel can supply enough magic power for Miss Mystery Moon. What do we do next?"

"Stick to it." His Highness Roland handed Mystery Moon a copper cylinder. "Now show us what you can do."

"Ok." Mystery Moon took a deep breath, held the copper object in her hands, and closed her eyes.

All of a sudden, the Magic Power began to flow furiously.

Spear saw that the metal cube in Anna's body gleamed, the fluid in the pivot came out, and filled again; the entire channel kept on trembling. It looked as if it would be torn apart by the turbulent magic power. The Marquess had sweat on her forehead. She felt as if she was standing in front of a tsunami.

On the other side, Mystery Moon had a frowned forehead and red cheeks. Obviously, she was also under the impact of the fierce waves. But considering Spear was the one transferring the power, Mystery Moon must be under tremendous impact. Even so, she didn't stop using her abilities, and the rapidly consumed magic power was the proof.

These girls were monsters!

Spear didn't know how she managed to last to the end. When the magic power in Anna's body was drained, Spear felt she could barely stand on her own feet.

"Fi… finished." Mystery Moon opened her eyes and excitingly held up the copper cylinder. "I made it!"

"Well done." Roland carefully clamped the copper object with a pair of wooden tongs, as if it was a red-hot iron.

"What's this?" the Marquess asked. "It looks exactly the same as before."

"A strong magnet with ever changing magnetic force," the prince replied. "I don't know whether it'll form an access with the earth while being held in a person's hand. If so, it would discharge. So we'd better be cautious."

Spear blinked her eyes. "What?"

Nightingale smiled. "Don't mind them. This is such a topic that only Anna can participate in."

"Then… what can it be used for?"

"Let's try it out." Roland put the copper cylinder into a black iron machine standing in the middle of the yard. Judging from the silhouette of the machine, it looked like a giant iron tube. It had a wooden pedestal at the bottom. An

iron pole as thick as an arm stuck out from the middle. The prince looked at Mystery Moon. “Turn on the switch. If it works, it’ll bring a whole new source of power to the town.”

Mystery Moon nodded. She held the wooden handle on the machine and pulled it downward with effort.

Sparks burst out from the downside of her hands, making a crackling sound. To Spear’s surprise, the iron pole in the middle began to rotate rapidly. The pole must have been as heavy as one or two people. How could it rotate so fast?

“Have we… succeeded?”

“Not yet.” The prince found a chair and sat on it. “It depends on how long it can work.”

Spear noticed there was something glittering in Roland’s eyes as he looked at the plain rough iron machine. It was as if he was looking at a piece of shining jewelry.

****

Three days later, Roland pushed open the door to the backyard of the North Slope Mountain. Upon hearing the sound, Anna stopped her work and rushed to greet Roland. She couldn’t conceal her excitement. “It’s still working.”

There was no need for her remark though. The prince also heard the noise made by the operating electric motor. To him, this noise was almost as euphonious as the sounds of nature. Because it meant that the variable magnetic core cylinder, being filled with Mystery Moon’s magic power, was still operating properly. As a whole new power source, it had shown its practical use.

Roland came to the center of the yard and saw that Mystery Moon was sitting beside the electric motor. With her hands on her chin, she looked at the black machine, feeling bored. “Your Highness, when you said my abilities are full

of potential, did you mean this thing ? It doesn't look any different from a steam engine."

"This is only the first step to change the world," Roland said beaming. "You'll be able to see what changes it can bring to our little town soon enough."

Every step forward in the history of the human race was related to the utilization of energy. To some extent it could be used to measure the level of a civilization's advancement. From steam to electricity, from electricity to nuclear, the breakthrough in energy would usually boost the industrial production. The variable magnetic core cylinder filled with Mystery Moon's magic power was such a kind of new energy. It resembled a super large battery and transformed magic power into electric energy. Its small manufacture scale limited its application, which meant it couldn't lead to an energy reform. But as a supplement to the steam engine and internal combustion engine, it was still a perfect power source.

Besides, with the growth of Anna's magic power, it still had the potential to be used in other areas. And when Leaf gained control of the Impassable Forest and obtained the massive magic power supply, the potential was unimaginable.

"The name 'variable magnetic core cylinder' is too long," Roland said, smiling. "Let's call it Dawn I."

Chapter 425

Chapter 425: The Utilization of Energy

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

On the afternoon of the fifth day, the electric motor stopped working.

In other words, a single Dawn I could provide energy for a large-scale electric motor to work for five consecutive days. If an electric motor didn't run continuously, then its work time could be extended. When the magnetic effect of the copper column was lost, it could be recharged with magic power, which was purely low-consumption, recyclable, and pollution-free energy.

Its flaw was also very obvious—recharging it would exhaust all of Anna, Mystery Moon, and Spear's magic powers. So if the three of them produced a Dawn I per day, it could only sustain five electric motors (non-stop). At the moment, Anna was irreplaceable for the fine machining and steel smelting in the little town. Roland had tried his best to distribute most of the manufacturing work to ordinary townsmen, but without the machine tools produced and maintained by Anna and her supply of materials, the production of revolving firearms and bullets would instantly bog down in stagnancy.

Furthermore, Anna was also essential for the production of the 152 mm Longsong Cannons, new-style light weapons, and Roland's other new ideas. So he wouldn't want Anna to strain her magic power on charging the batteries.

Roland leaned back on the wing chair and deeply sighed.

There were two solutions for this problem. First, increasing the duration of Dawn I. To this end, they needed greater resources or more witches to supply magic powers. Unfortunately, the Marquess' passage was just strong enough to transfer Anna's magic power and the process almost exhausted her, so she couldn't manage to transfer any more witches' magic powers to Mystery

Moon. Hopefully, Spear could get used to it gradually—after all, she might not have the time to study how to improve her abilities while she was a lord.

Second, substituting other witches for Anna. Compared with Anna, Soraya, and Agatha (who were usually busy with work), most of the other witches didn't have to exhaust their magic powers during the day. So if the rest of their magic powers could be used to produce variable magnetic core columns, it seemed plausible.

As long as the total volume of the magic powers didn't exceed that of Anna's, Spear would be able to handle it. She had once said that the passage for magic powers could be connected with more than two people at a time.

Thinking of this, Roland wrote it down. Questions like who had more magic powers or how much of the magic powers should be used per day were left for the Witch Union to calculate.

Undoubtedly, Wendy would be a perfect candidate since everybody trusted her.

After finding solutions for this problem, the next question was how to make use of this whole new energy.

Different from the steam engines, of which four to five pieces could be produced per month and would operate as long as boiling water was supplied, the number of terminal conversion machines was dependent on the number of Dawn Is. Considering the magic powers that could be used, he estimated that only three to four terminal conversion machines could be sustained in the little town. Whether to use them as source power, for boiling water, or supplying energy for light bulbs, the correct choice was imperative if the system was to operate steadily.

Roland thought for a long time and finally drew a circle on the light bulbs.

As for source power, electric motors exceeded steam engines in such aspects as stable rotating rates, easy maneuverability, and automatization. But the power supplied by steam engines was enough for the time being. He had also visualized some high-end electric equipment, such as electric cars that

commuted between Longsong Stronghold and the little town, or electric airships that were accessible to ordinary people. But such equipment wasn't so cost effective—to make it work, Anna or other witches had to stop their work for a day.

The same was true with boiling water, which could simply be solved by a boiler and firewood could. Even though several workers needed to be hired to attend to and maintain the steam engines, it was still more economical than using magic powers. After all, the magic powers weren't that abundant.

Furthermore, lighting is more significant—a stable and clean source of light could greatly increase the residents' happiness and render them better study conditions at night. After all, not everybody wants to read a book under the dim candle light after a day's stressful work.

Besides, doing something like seizing the legendary thunder power and using it for daily life would help eliminate suspicion and enhance scientific spirit. This was probably the civilians' most intuitive understanding of electricity's applications. As astonishing as airships and electric cars may sound, they were too far away from people's daily life.

More importantly, the weak candle light simply couldn't meet the needs for night production. With light bulbs, the factories would be able to sustain production even at night, and the workers could even work on three shifts if necessary, which meant the work efficiency in the little town would be further improved.

After setting the direction of development, there were still a series of problems to be solved to achieve his goals, such as light bulb manufacturing, line construction, power supply schemes, and the promotion of electricity utilization, etc.

But these problems could be considered later.

With this thought, Roland called Wendy.

"Do you intend to calculate the daily consumption and the surplus of my sisters' magic powers, and transfer them to Mystery Moon according to the

plan?" Wendy asked, after hearing Roland's statement.

"Yes. Those combat witches who have fixed missions can be excluded from your calculation though." The prince nodded. "What do you think?"

Essentially, they were to gather the magic powers left after the witches' ability practice, mission consumption, and emergency preparation, and use them to produce the Dawn I. Such an arrangement could not only put the magic powers of witches into full play, but could also enhance the effects of their practice, which was helpful to the promotion of their magic powers on the annual Days of Awakening.

"I think Hummingbird and Echo would be happy," Wendy said with a smile, "because they can then be as useful as Anna. But how will the magic power surplus be measured?"

"By using the Stone of Measurement, which was a universal method used by the Union."

"Yes, Your Highness." She bowed slightly. "Right, today is the Day of Adulthood for Lucia. Should we gather all the members of the union to accompany her?"

Roland was shocked a bit. "Oh… I've almost forgotten it."

"There are so many things for you to remember," Wendy said softly. "I've written down every sister's growth history on this notebook so that nothing will be missed."

After Anna's Day of Awakening, Lightning, Nana, and Echo had also passed their "second birthday" in succession. But the Day of Adulthood was actually more meaningful and it could be taken as a special Day of Awakening. Although they happened on the same day, the bite of magic power that one suffered on the Day of Adulthood was several times stronger than usual. Unless the witches could master how to eliminate the pain caused by biting, the Day of Adulthood could be a matter of life and death.

After adulthood, the witches' abilities would be stabilized while getting considerable improvements at the same time, and some witches could even develop derivative skills, which was as significant as evolution.

"OK. I'll prepare a rich dinner tonight." Roland said softly, "Besides the Witch Union, I'll be there to accompany her as well."

Chapter 426

Chapter 426: The Shining Starlight

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

After dinner, the witches gathered in Lucia White's room.

Touched by their encouragement and comfort, she could feel her tear-filled eyes. She inhaled deeply with her eyes shut, willing herself not to cry.

"No crying. It's embarrassing enough to cry out loud in front of Nightingale, not to mention in front of my little sister. I must set a good example for her," Lucia chided herself.

She had only heard about a witch organization situated here before she boarded the boat towards the town. She was not hoping to live a good life here but simply to find a cure for her sister's demonic plague and a shelter.

What they found was not only a comfortable life, but a group of people with so much in common that they soon became like family. She felt at home again for the first time since her parents' death in the pirate attack.

"Is my sister really in danger?" Bell asked while resting in Lucia's arms, "How painful is a magic power bite?"

"Unbearable pain, it feels just like thousands of knives stabbing you from the inside of your body." Nightingale grinned. "Only a few witches can survive this. There are probably only one or two out of ten witches who can survive their Day of Adulthood."

The little girl shivered.

"You don't scare her." Wendy stared at Nightingale. "That was all the way back to the time of Witch Cooperation Association."

“All you need to do now is to keep on practicing every day and release all your magic power before the Day of Awakening, then you’ll be fine,” Scroll said, smiling. “I heard that even Anna was asleep when she was growing into her adulthood.”

“And her first High Awakening appeared at the same time,” Agatha yawned. “It’d definitely cause a stir if it happened 400 years ago back in Taquila, as there’s never any witch who could come to enlightenment in their sleep.”

“Are you alright?” His Highness looked at her and asked, “Even though work’s important, you should not push yourself too hard.”

“The Battle of Divine Will is approaching. If I’m not busy with it now…” Agatha said with her hands covering her mouth, “it would not be an issue to sleep forever if we fail this time.”

“We won’t fail for sure this time.” Prince Roland assured.

“I decided to do a little bit more as I was feeling optimistic about your invention.” Ice Witch rolled her eyes at him, “Otherwise, do you really think that I like to stay in the lab every day?” With these words, she turned around and muttered to herself softly, “I wouldn’t be able to do anything to you even if you don’t fulfill your promise…”

“Well, you shouldn’t discuss such a heavy story at this time.” Wendy interrupted and said, “Oh yeah, didn’t Miss Agatha mention before that each of the witches shall be granted a wish on the Day of Awakening? It’s Lucia’s turn this time; what would you like to wish for?”

“Uh… me?” Lucia was shocked to find that she was the center of attention in the knot of witches.

“Get the ice cream bread in exchange, sister!” Bell said with her eyes sparkling, “10 of them will do, and we’ll have a half each!”

“This one… all you can think of is food,” she thought and gave her sister a good knock on her forehead. Then she looked towards Roland. “May I keep this wish for now?”

“If you wish.” He could not help but smile and say, “However it would not increase even if you keep it.”

“Only one will do,” Lucia answered with gratitude. She had nothing more to ask for herself as long as she could live in this town. All she could hope for was for Bell to live a happy life. Her younger sister was not a witch, so she would have to leave her and build her own family with someone someday. This wish might be able to help her if there were any changes by then.

It was then that Lucia felt her empty body tremble suddenly and the magic power was regenerated as if it was appearing in the void and pouring into her body continuously.

“It’s started.” Nightingale reminded.

Even though the sisters told her not to worry, she grasped the blanket tightly, as a chill washed over her palms and the soles of her feet. This she ascribed to an overwhelming sensation of tension.

“Relax,” Wendy said, reaching for her hands. “The magic power is part of our body.”

“Should we talk about something else to distract her?” Lucia heard someone, perhaps Lily, ask.

“What should we talk about?” Mystery Moon asked.

“What about the result of the second test?” Lily’s voice seemed to come from far away. “Normally once the topic’s brought up, she immediately changes the subject and diverts attention, like what about Mystery Moon’s results…”

“Don’t say!”

“Look, it works.”

Lucia wanted to laugh but she realized that the expression on her face was very stiff and it was scorching hot inside her body. At the same time, there was an undefinable sense of contraction and increasingly more magic power as if she was sucking everything around her into her body.

Will every witch experience this feeling in her Day of Adulthood?

“What was Lucia’s result?” She could only hear Mystery Moon intermittently.

“Her average was 86,” Prince Roland replied.

“Wh… what?”

“That’s very high!”

“You see, she didn’t even try to stop us.”

“You’ve failed, so it’s time for punishment!”

“Go away!”

“Hold on… Stop fighting, Lucia doesn’t seem to look right.”

She could hear the conversation between Mystery Moon, Lily and finally Nightingale’s voice, but she realized the voices of the witches had become distant to her. Lucia was clenching her teeth and she held her head up to look at the sisters around her. She was shocked to see the completely changed scene. Everyone’s appearance became hazy and pixilated like a composition of innumerable squares—some big, some small and each of them had a different color.

She wanted to scream in terror but all she could hear was the hissing sound in her breath.

The contraction in her body was getting stronger and it started to cause a vague but growing sense of pain. Lucia could only hold her breath and see people around her starting to get busy.

It was exactly like Nightingale said, the pain in the Day of Adulthood was far beyond the pain of the awakening. The more persistent she was, the stronger the pain became; it felt as if she was being cut into pieces.

Suddenly, a strange magic power probed her body. Lucia could clearly feel the magic power did not belong to herself. It was just like a tube ridden in the magic whirlpool.

She could not bear it any longer, subconsciously yielding to the overwhelming power and allowing the current to carry her. As if she had finally found her savior, Lucia kept injecting the magic power into it to suppress the pain in her body.

The strange contraction eased after a period of time. The magic power no longer twirled around but it felt substantial and solid; it was a completely different experience.

She blinked and was relieved to find that her vision had fully returned.

Looking at a fearful Bell, Lucia patted her head and reassured her in a hoarse voice, “It’s alright now.”

This was when she realized that she was soaked in sweat. She could feel the chill on her back when the cold wind blew.

“Wait, how could there be any wind in a room with the heater on?”

When she turned her head, she was shocked to see the huge gaps in the wall facing the garden and the two missing windows that allowed the cold air to swarm in. She could see the dark night and the tiny little lights of the small town through the gap. Standing in front of the wall was Anna, looking at her with concern. The Sigil of God’s Will in her hand glimmered.

“Her ability has crystallized,” Nightingale said.

Chapter 427

Chapter 427: The Aftermath

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

Roland walked into the office yawning as the sky turned bright.

He had not expected so many accidents on the Day of Adulthood. It was supposed to be an easy day.

The magic in Lucia's body became extremely turbulent. Nightingale realized something was wrong with her expression. It was exactly the sign of the magic power bite. It was incredible that this was happening to a witch who practiced frequently, especially since she had released all her magic power prior to her Day of Adulthood.

Agatha came out with a solution.

As an ex-member of the Union she had witnessed countless witches awaken. She quickly thought of a remedy.

Ice Witch made Spear Passi summon the magic power channel and release the bite from Lucia's body. Then it was transferred to Anna who had the greatest capacity. Finally, the restless magic power was absorbed by the Sigil of God's Will.

Surprisingly, the released magic power had lit up four God's Stones and activated the Sigil of God's Will. Anna released it into the open space without further hesitation.

Suddenly, the town was brightened by the golden sun. The dazzling light shone through the castle wall and pierced through the dark, starless sky. The thick clouds could be seen in the dark sky and there were thousands of tassels flowing in the sky. It was incredibly beautiful. Although it only lasted for a few moments, the scene was undoubtedly miraculous.

Lucia was finally safe and she had developed a new ability during this adulthood transformation, just like Anna had a year ago.

However, it was not without trouble. The accident had happened around eight o'clock at night, when most people were still awake. Quite a number of people must have witnessed this spectacular event. Roland would have to come up with an explanation to the public when he returned to his room.

"Your Highness, Director Barov asked to see you," the door guard informed after knocking on the door.

"Let him in."

Barov with a head full of white hair walked into the office. Before he paying his respect, he blatantly asked, "Your Highness, what happened last night? How come there was daylight appearing in the night?"

He was indeed here about the light. Roland took a glance at his face and saw dark circles. He probably had not slept either. If outsiders were not strictly prohibited from entering the castle at night, he would have come to the door last night.

"No hurry. Have a seat." Roland pointed at the chair in front of the table and said, "Have a cup of black tea first."

Roland mentioned the incident of Lucia's adulthood after pouring a glass of hot tea. "It was just an accident, don't worry too much."

"So… this was caused by a witch?" The City Hall Director frowned.

"Don't be silly. It was not the demonic side." Roland quickly guessed the other party's thought. "No one was hurt aside from the missing wall of this old, broken castle."

"But the villagers will think this," Barov shook his head. "Most of them accepted the harmless healing power of Miss Nana but not the ability to destroy the castle like this, causing astonishing changes in the sky."

“That’s why I came up with a solution,” said Roland while sipping his tea. “You’ll arrange for your men to spread this news: the golden light that appeared last night was from when His Highness captured lightning, in order to bring light to his people.”

“What?” Barov was stunned.

“I’ll soon be building the power supply equipment in Border Town. It has a similar essence to the lightning in the sky.” Prince Roland explained briefly. He knew he was speaking technically and the other party could hardly understand. “This equipment can light up the town brightly even during the night. It coincides with the news.”

“Is that… Is that true?” The director asked in surprise, “Can you really make lightning?”

“It’s everywhere by itself,” Roland shrugged and said, “however, please remember that it’s just hearsay, so it shall be spread according to ‘the Art of Rumor’. Do you understand?”

In order to prevent any impact on the universal education in the future, these statements should not be too democratic. It would be fine as long as an ambiguous explanation could temporarily be given to the public to redirect the discussion towards himself.

Not too long after Barov left, Karl Van Bate, the Minister of Construction came to the castle.

“Your Highness, regarding last night…”

“I know what you want to ask,” Roland put his hand on his forehead. “Sit down first and we’ll talk.”

He sighed silently to himself. Perhaps he would have to explain this incident for the entire day.

Fortunately, Karl was not a deep thinker like Barov, and he simply sighed after listening and said, “It turns out Anna has already become so strong.”

“It was indeed a decisive disposition at the time.” Roland agreed. “If there was any further delay, I’m afraid it would have been not only the wall that disappeared but the whole bedroom instead.”

“The gap in the wall…”

“Just fill it in with bricks. You can go ahead to arrange an exact plan as long as it’s done before the nightfall. I’ll get Lightning and Hummingbird to help you with this.” Prince Roland said. The appearance of the castle would need to be restored after mending the wall. He would get Soraya to paint a simulation coating on it.

“Yes, Your Highness.”

As expected, Carter Lannis, the Chief Knight; Iron Axe, the instructor of the First Army and Kyle Sichi, the alchemist, were taking turns to ask about yesterday’s incident and each of them had a different concern.

Carter was concerned about whether she was hurt.

Iron Axe was concerned that the light had been caused by the demons’ attack.

However, what concerned Kyle was… which was more powerful, the Sigil of God’s Will or the nitric acid glycerine?

The men were finally dismissed after a series of non-stop talking and explanations by Roland. He leaned back in his chair, getting ready to take a nap but someone was knocking on the door again.

The last to enter was Tilly Wimbledon.

“No worries. Yesterday was…”

“I already know about it.” Lady Tilly interrupted. “I asked Miss Anna before I came here and she told me what happened.”

“Oh, I see.” Roland cleared his throat and sat up straight. “Anything else?”

“I’m just a little concerned with the cause.” Tilly said slowly, “According to Miss Agatha, be it awakening or adulthood, as long as a certain amount of practice is carried out normally, it shouldn’t cause any sign of magic power bite. It’s basically in line with what we’ve learned from past experience. It’s never happened to any of the witches on the Sleeping Island, so how could Lucia be the one who fell into the bite of the magic power?” She paused here for a little, shook her head and said with a smile, “As for the High Awakening, I’m not surprised… I’ve seen a few of them each day since I arrived in Border Town.”

A few of them each day, that’s an extreme exaggeration… Roland thought, he poured her a cup of tea. Contemplating for a moment, he said, “I do have a preliminary guess regarding Lucia’s misfortune.” He pulled out a transcript from the drawer and handed it to Tilly. “This’s probably the reason.”

Chapter 428

Chapter 428: An Exploration of Magic Power

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

"… Grades?" Tilly took the transcript, glanced at it doubtfully, and said, "She did improve a lot."

"Yes," Roland nodded. "As a businessman's daughter in Valencia, Lucia White already had basic writing and arithmetic skills, and she also performed well in the natural theory course. That's why her grades are so good."

"I'm not questioning your theory that 'a better understanding and cognition of the world can help develop abilities,' " replied Tilly, twitching her mouth, "but what does it have to do with the bite of magic power?"

"Judging from the evolution of Lily, Leaf, and Mystery Moon, as well as other witches, we can tell that evolution also increases witches' magic power limits. I think such limits have a lot to do with how well witches perceive the world." Combining what Agatha referred to as "ancient High Awakening" and the evolution of the town witches' abilities, Roland explained his theory in details. "They're essentially the same thing. However, witches who evolved by partial or random enlightenment are far less powerful than those who evolved by a full, comprehensive understanding of the world—Mystery Moon is a typical example. Although she's a member of the Witch Union, her evolution was achieved through enlightenment, so her magic power isn't in the same league as Anna's and Soraya's."

Tilly soon learned what Roland meant after a moment of reflection, "You mean the reason Miss Lucia's magic power was low both on normal days and her Day of Awakening is that her body has adjusted to a certain level of magic power? Yet her ability evolved when she entered adulthood, which

resulted in an instant surge in her magic power, and so much power was far more than she could take, right?"

"Pretty much like that, but I prefer to think there are two different types of power increases." Roland continued, counting on his fingers, "Magic power increases on the Day of Awakening, on the Day of Adulthood, and during evolution. The effects seem the same, but I believe the first two are passive, while the last is voluntary."

"Why do you think so?"

"Because evolution won't cause magic power bites," the prince replied slowly. "If this wasn't the case, Anna would have been killed by the surge of magic power during her evolution. I assume there's a magic power redline for witches. Once they go beyond it, they'll suffer from bites. Daily practice can gradually increase their limits, and that's also why witches need to empty all their magic power before awakening."

"Redline? It sounds interesting…" Tilly murmured, sinking into her thoughts. "Do you think the outpouring of magic power that was generated by Miss Lucia's evolution resulted in insufficient space for magic power on the Day of Awakening, which led her to exceed the power limit and thus caused the accident?"

"Correct. Like Lucia, Anna experienced her first evolution when she reached adulthood, but her magic power capacity was incredible, so she had a much higher limit for bites than ordinary witches." Roland paused for a moment. "This also explains why Lucia went back to normal after Spear extracted the agitated magic power—that power didn't belong to her anyway."

"Your theory… does clarify a lot of problems." Tilly pushed her hair behind her ear and propped up her chin on her hand, apparently absorbed in thoughts. "Why witches present different forms of magic power despite their power sharing the same origin? Why free magic power can only be seen upon witches' awakenings? Because witches can't integrate it unless they accept it."

Roland said with a smile, “We can view awakening as drawing magic power in, but only a small part of it can be retained. Evolution expands and develops this small part, and the greater cognitive breadth a witch possesses, the better strengthening effects she’ll obtain. It’s also reasonable to assume that there’s no limit on the number of times a witch can evolve, since the exploration of the world is endless.”

“I’m suddenly curious.”

“What?”

“If you were a witch, how extensive would your power be after evolution?” asked Tilly, covering her smile.

Roland nearly choked himself. Although he really wanted to personally experience these extraordinary powers, he would rather turn them down knowing the sacrifices he had to make.

“Can I bring a copy of the textbooks you wrote back to Sleeping Island?” Tilly asked, while raising her eyebrow.

She sounded pretty casual, but Roland noticed her right hand gently grasping her skirt’s hemline.

“Absolutely.” He would not miss a single chance to leave his sister a good impression, and generally speaking, it was better to respond as quickly as possible. “It’ll also be helpful to Border Town if the witches on Sleeping Island evolve. Besides, you’re my sister.”

Nightingale immediately pinched his left shoulder with immense strength.

“…” Tilly did not respond back, but simply showed her gratitude with a slight nod. “Thank you, I’ll be excused then.”

“Sure.”

It looks like my performance was overdone. She probably won’t be interested in this kind of approach before hearing a convincing explanation.

Yet to Roland's surprise, Tilly stopped at the door, turned her head and answered quietly, "Sometimes, I'd rather hope that you aren't my brother."

…

After Tilly's departure, Roland sat at his desk in a daze, with her last sentence reverberating all around his head.

Would rather hope I'm not her brother. What does that mean?

"Hey, are you OK?" Nightingale revealed herself, waving her finger in front of the prince.

"What do you think her last sentence meant?"

"How do I know?" Nightingale commented with a shrug. "Perhaps she thinks you're better as an ally than a sibling."

Roland would certainly not assume anything inappropriate, since he had already known this royal princess pretty well after cooperating with her for half a winter.

Could she mean that she doesn't want Prince Roland to come back? Or was it just the backlash of his lame approach?

"You aren't her brother anyway. Why do you even care?" Nightingale turned over to sit on the desk, crossing her slender legs. She thrust a piece of dried fish into her mouth and added, "Plus, I could tell you were lying without even using my ability when you said 'you're my sister'."

"Um, is that so…" Roland stroked his nose. "So the answer is the latter then?"

"Also, since Tilly isn't your real sister, is it alright to give her that Natural 'Something' Theory?"

"That's Natural Science Theoretical Foundation," the prince corrected her with a sigh. "There are several months of winter. Don't you think she can produce a copy? I bet she already knows everything by heart, but she still

requested my formal permission. This definitely says something about her attitude."

At least from the standpoint of political alliance, there's no question in Tilly's sincerity.

He waited for a moment before continuing, "The residents on Sleeping Island are primarily witches. Even if all of them have evolved, they still rely on witches' power. However, I'm different. The knowledge not only enables witches to progress, but ordinary people as well… It's the power of all the people that I'm relying on."

Chapter 429

Chapter 429: Element Separation

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

Accompanied by howling wind and raging snow, Lucia entered the backyard of North Slope Mountain and closed the door, shutting the chill out of the room.

A circle of wooden sheds was pitched in the yard after winter kicked in. Although the lighting was somewhat affected, the houses here would at least not be buried in piles of snow.

There was a bonfire in the yard, and Lucia could even feel the heat of its flickering flames by the door. She took off her gloves and put her freezing hands above the blazes to warm herself up.

“Are you cold?” Anna, who stood at the workstation, turned her head and beckoned. “Come here, I’ll warm you up.”

“Ah… thank you.” Lucia trotted to her. Soon bathed in warm green flames that gave her a languid and relaxing sensation from head to toe, she felt like she was soaking in the bathtub of the castle.

“Such a convenient ability…” Lucia thought enviously. “She’s never afraid of the bitter cold.”

“Are you warm now?”

“Yes!” she affirmed, nodding vigorously. “What are you making?”

“Some parts for new guns.” Anna grabbed a long slim steel tube with a piston in the middle and pulled it back and forth. “His Highness says he’s not sure if it’ll work with the first shot, so it needs to be tested repeatedly.”

These parts, bright and shiny from the outside, were apparently made from the best rolled steel and were carefully carved by the Blackfire. Before coming to the town, Lucia would have never thought that the surface of iron objects could be as smooth as glass, like artwork.

She had also made a contribution to their creation. Lucia could not suppress a smile at this thought. Both Roland and Anna had said that without high-quality materials, the finished products would still be damaged goods, even with precise and refined processing methods.

“His Highness didn’t come with you?” asked Anna, who withdrew her green fire.

“He said that he still needed to take care of something and would come a little later. He asked me to first get familiar with my new ability,” Lucia answered, twitching her mouth.

“What does your ability look like after the evolution?” Anna inquired with great interest. “There’s probably no one in the Witch Union who created a bigger stir than you did upon entering adulthood.”

Lucia scratched her head, looking a bit embarrassed. “I probably couldn’t have made it without you and milord Spear.”

“You already thanked me, no need to worry about it.” Anna dismissed it with a wave. “Let’s see your new ability.”

Lucia agreed. She summoned the magic power in her body and again sensed the same odd feeling enveloping her heart—everything became strange and obscure, dividing into numerous tiny squares that grouped together by color, forming different color speckles. However, this time she did not suffer any pain from magic power bites, so she could calm herself down and carefully observe each single square.

She took one of the parts processed by Anna. There were lumps and bumps on its surface, which had been smooth and shiny earlier. With the help of the magic power, she could clearly see the color speckles on it—there were around seven or eight color blocks, the largest of which was cyan. As if an

artist carelessly spilled various pigments on the floor, there were no patterns whatsoever in their arrangement. The only difference, however, was that each color speckle had visible boundaries that prevented them from mixing with each other.

It occurred to Lucia that these were not the tiny particles His Highness had referred to. These “squares” and “color speckles” were just too big to be considered as the fundamental elements of everything.

There’s a larger classification than the particle, which is the element.

Small particles form larger ones in accordance with different patterns and rules, and these larger particles will exhibit entirely different properties due to their various structures.

Lucia used to have no idea about her own ability or its specific functions back in Valencia, but now she thoroughly understood the concept of elements. According to His Highness’ description and classification, she believed it was elements that she had just observed.

After hearing what Lucia saw and thought, Anna pondered for a while and said, “It may be a type of derivative skill.”

“Derivative… skill?”

“That’s a rare talent,” Anna explained, smiling. “There are only a few adult witches in the Witch Union who possess such a talent—according to Agatha, it only occurs on the Day of Adulthood. Once you miss it, you miss it forever. I believe it has a lot to do with the witch’s primary ability, or we can say, it supplements and strengthens the primary power. For example, Soraya needs to first mix pigments into paint if she doesn’t have the magic brush. The same applies to Miss Scroll’s Book of Magic. She once told me that although she could quickly memorize most of the books prior to adulthood, she couldn’t share the contents with others because she didn’t have any money to purchase pens and paper.”

Anna paused for a moment before continuing. “Your main ability is separation and restoration, so I reckon these color speckles may be assisting

you in accurately separating a specific type of element—you can give it a shot to see whether you can separate a particular color block or not."

Lucia nodded. She started to once again apply her power to the pig iron ingot by the workstation. Unlike the separation earlier, this time she cautiously transformed her magic power into a filament to pull the cyan squares.

The whole process was much harder than she expected. Lucia had never manipulated her magic power in such a laborious manner, but she was delighted to see her progress. Compared with her confusion prior to adulthood, she was now able to truly feel the magic power, as if it had become her own fingers—even an extension of her consciousness.

As more filaments clung to the color speckle, the squares finally started to loosen up and wriggle out of the iron ingot. Meanwhile, the rest of the color speckles also changed—their distinct boundaries began to wobble, and the whole iron ingot collapsed and crumbled into a yellow green crystal as small as half of a nail, next to which appeared a box-like iron block.

Lucia withdrew her power and wiped the perspiration from her forehead. She noticed the crystal and the block displayed different colors under the magic power than with normal vision—the previous cyan speckle had turned silver white, which was a color usually seen among pure iron. Nevertheless, the crystal still remained colorful, but if she did not look at it using her magic power, it just looked like a polished gemstone.

"What's this?" Lucia gently took the tiny crystal. Its size was not even close to that of the iron ingot, but it looked much more beautiful.

"It's probably a compound formed by the other elements in the pig iron," Anna suggested, her eyes glistening. "I'm not sure, but I can do a small experiment to verify it. If I've guessed right, do you know what that means? It means that you can separate some elements from an object and reorganize the rest of the elements, instead of breaking them up… Any useless, poor-quality materials can be reborn with the help of your power."

Chapter 430

Chapter 430: “The Star of Steel”

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

It was the last month of winter in Border Town after Lucia’s day of adulthood.

As for the Months of Demons, the end of winter did not mean the end of the snow. The snow would often continue to fall until the spring of the second year, and it was totally in God’s hands as to when it would cease.

Based on past experiences, the Months of Demons would end within the first half of the first month of spring, and it would be a very difficult period. It would be an extremely tough time if it ended within the second half of the first month. The days could become hard to survive if it delayed until the second month.

However, it was a situation that only the local people ever encountered.

The situation this year had been greatly improved. The wheat being stored in the granary would be enough to make sure everyone was adequately fed, even if the Months of Demons continued to the end of the second month of spring.

Roland naturally would not be satisfied merely by no one being starved or frozen to death. Over the last few days, he had been sprawling across his desk, exitedly working on many drawings and the ideas for the next stage of his big plan, The entire plan was divided into both military and civilian aspects. The former included the construction of the weapon factory, the bicycle plant, and the dock as well as the shallow water gunboats and other locations. The latter mainly involved the connections for the water, heat, and electricity of the residential area in addition to the promotion of the universal use of the iron farming tools.

It was Lucia White who motivated him. After he realized what her ability was, Roland clearly recognized that the final limitation of the mass production was resolved, and the productivity of the town could usher into a new peak of the growth in the population.

The limitation was the supply of materials.

The modern way of smelting was very complicated, and the output of steel iron was one of the most important parameters to measure an industrial country. However, Roland did not know much about it, and this was the main reason that the iron making capacity of the town was still outdated. Not only were the techniques not as advanced, the scale was not nearly comparable with the private smeltery owned by some mining businessmen. When the iron ore in the brick blast furnace was smelt into pig iron, quality pieces would be sent away to become parts of steam engines, while the poorer quality ones would be passed to Anna for further processing into steel. However, this process was totally out of control, and the carbon content was not stable. Sometimes, the useful materials could only fill up one to two carriages after an entire workday, which greatly limited the production of the steam engine manufacturing plant.

Although the low-quality pig iron could be processed into the quality-controlled rolled steel with Anna's special smelter, the production quantity was only enough for military plant use. It would basically meet the need of the small town in the fall, but with the two expansions of the army and the development of new firearms and cannons, the limited quantity of rolled steel could potentially be overstretched come winter.

Lucia's evolutioncould be described as a cardiac stimulant; her targeted separation ability would allow easy removal of undesirable components in the material and regulate the elements proportions in the smelting phase, allowing each furnace of molten steel to be maintained at the same performance.

The smelting standard of Border Town would instantly increase exponentially with the help of both Anna and Lucia.

Roland had already got Anna to put down all the other projects on hand in order to concentrate on the creation of the enormous, latest generation smelter for this reason.

The new smelter was 10 times bigger in size compared with the old special smelter designed by her previously, extending to 50 meters in length, 10 meters in width and four meters in height. It looked like a slender swimming pool at the first glance. It was essentially similar to the last generation special furnace; it was still a metal box without any heating equipment and fully independent on Anna's Blackfire. However, it was buried in the ground, relying on the soil to support the pressure of the molten iron on the walls. There was also an aisle built in the center for Anna to heat up the iron ingots on both sides at the same time.

The huge volume was its only advantage. Based on the previous smelting method, it would contain too much of product for only the limestones used for removal purposes; it also required a lot of effort to clean the impurities generated and would be very painstaking to reinforce and stir them. Thus, it should not be mass produced or used with the old method. However, there was no such concern now. As long as the pig iron was melted, Lucia could eliminate the harmful components, such as phosphorus and sulfur.

Roland intended to build a batch of kilns along with the old blast and shaft furnaces. He was only responsible for the initial smelting, and he did not care about the quality of the finished product as long as the ore could be melted into the rectangular iron ingots, all of which were then put into the new smelter for secondary refining. The molten steel formed would flow through the strobe into the mold at the lower terrain and directly form the materials to be processed. After that, the steam engine plant would be converted into rolled steel production, and it would bring a powerful new source of motivation to the town.

Roland was going to name the latest smelter "Star of Steel".

As soon as Anna completed the manufacturing, the steel production of the town would be more than 10 times higher with the Star of Steel officially in use.

It could be said that the latest large-scale production plan was built on this basis.

Furthermore, the development of the state-of-the-art light-weight weapon had come to a conclusion.

Roland discovered that his initial idea was not appropriate. He had designed a few prototype weapons himself based on the principle of the latest pneumatic automatic rifle, which simply used some of the high pressure gas generated while the bullet was fired to finish the process of ejecting, chambering and re-filling.

This project took about half a month. It was not difficult but it needed to test each of the components repeatedly to make sure it operated normally. He did not bother to memorize the specific structure of the rifle. As long as he knew the operation of the weapon, he thought he would definitely be able to piece together a useful weapon after a few tries.

That was exactly where the problem lay.

The completed prototype machine was not only humongous, it also consisted of almost one hundred different components which were all custom-made by Anna. These included small little gadgets like springs, the firing pins, and the induction pistons. It was really hard to mass produce such a weapon with the current machine tool. If all the revolving rifles in the soldiers' hands were to be replaced by automatic weapons, it would not only increase Anna's burden, but the current firearms processing equipment units that had been put into production would be wasted as well.

Additionally, the ammunition consumption was undoubtedly going to increase significantly if all the soldiers were equipped with the automatic weapons. Roland did not care too much about this in the beginning as he felt that it could be resolved by increasing manpower. However, he soon discovered that as soon as the new weapon was put into production, it could easily overtake the entire production of the acid plant.

The frequent cartridge jamming during the shooting test, failure to fire, and the other small issues had become less important as he reaized that the

weapon production was not feasible.

He finally dispelled the idea of mass replacement of the automatic weapons after repeated contemplation. However, increasing the firepower of the military had become an urgent need. He began to shift his focus on continuous firing weapons.

He was considering the heavy machine gun.

A heavy machine gun could be assigned to 20 to 50 people in order to significantly reduce the number of weapons. In this case, both of the most critical problems would be solved easily. It could also be self-loaded with the use of a ventilation method; the structure was similar to the trial manufacture of the prototype weapons. It could be put into the principal test after a few alterations, and it could be built in a bigger size with bigger components. The difficulty to himself, Anna, and Lucia would be greaty reduced.

Chapter 431

Chapter 431: From the Kingdom of Dawn

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

Apart from the upgraded heavy machine gun, Roland also planned to develop a bolt rifle which would have a mid to long shooting range. He did not need many, a mere hundred or so would suffice. The rifle would have the same caliber as the heavy machine gun, and could be easily transformed into a sniper rifle by simply installing a gun sight.

In this way, he could continue to manufacture revolving firearms and black powder bullets without a huge waste of the products.

During a battle, soldiers could use field artilleries to suppress enemy forces within 800 to 1,000 meters and heavy machines guns 500 to 800 meters. Snipers could take care of enemies in less than 500 meters, and revolving rifles could be used to clear out enemies within the last 200 meters. Therefore he could, in theory, make sure every inch of the battle field was covered.

Of course, it would probably take three or four months to fully equip his army with the whole set of weapons he planned to make. He might not be able to complete it before the spring attack. Therefore, he needed another weapon, an inland river gunboat equipped with a culverin with a 152mm caliber. One would be enough to pressure on enemies when he launched the attack.

Roland felt he held more responsibilities upon his shoulders than before. He thought of the founding ceremony subsequent to the Months of Demons, the unification of the entire Western Region and the new population that would swarm in after he kicked Timothy off the throne. He even wished time could have slowed down its pace, and that the Months of Demons hadn’t ended so soon.

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Upon entering the Western Region, the landscape started to change.

Otto Luoxi lifted up the blinds and peeped through the window. Heaven and earth were washed out altogether. The sky was covered with dense snowflakes which swirled in the harsh wind, drifted down to the ground and blended into the vast canvas of whiteness.

It seemed that the heavy snow would never cease. He could see nothing other than piles of snow cloaking the soil, rocks and woods in the past two days. If the boat was not wobbly, he would even think it remained on the river.

“Shut the blinds.” The captain grunted. “Go out on the deck if you really want to see it. Nobody will care.”

He did not take the captain’s words personally, but shut the blinds and asked, “Does it always look like this here?”

“Of course, do you think I was bluffing?” The captain sipped wine from his decanter and said, “Every year when the Months of the Demons arrives, the Western Region is cut off because of the snow. There’s no way to get here except through the Redwater River. I can use my fingers to count how many people in the entire King’s City are willing to ferry you over here in this bloody weather. Well, they also gotta have a boat.” He grumbled, letting out a burp. “So five gold royals is an awfully good deal. You got it?”

“It’s a bit expensive, but I didn’t bargain with you when I paid,” said Otto, smiling.

“That sounds better.” The Captain tossed the decanter to him and said, “It’s warm. Drink some. It’ll warm you up.” He wiped his mouth and continued, “There was once this tradesman who wanted to purchase goods from the Western Region faster than anyone else, but he didn’t want to pay a little more for the fare, so he asked the rats on the black street to ferry him. You know what? That fellow was killed halfway. Those few mercenaries he brought with him were craps. They all ended up feeding the fishes.”

“That was… really unfortunate.” Otto took the decanter, but did not pull out the cork to drink the wine. Instead, he took off his gloves and held the decanter in his hands. He really did not feel comfortable sharing drinks with others.

“You get what you pay for. It’s a universal rule. There’re always people who think they can get away with it. Did it never occur to him that if rats agree to provide him with the service at such a low price, how are we going to run our business?” The captain added, twitching his mouth, “By the way, what’s your trade in the Western Region? Don’t you blame me for not reminding you. There used to be jewelry and furs in this damn place, but you can’t get anything from here now.”

“Really?” Otto marveled, pretending to be interested. “As far as I know, don’t they make a living on these trades? Have people in the Western Region all become bandits now?”

“They’re stale news now.” The captain lit his pipe with the charcoal fire and inhaled deeply. “Ever since Prince Roland ruled Border Town, the Western Region has become weird. You know the town is well known for its furs and jewelry, but nobody knows what the hell the prince is messing around with in his territory. Now there’re only imports but no exports. Some jewelry still gets sold in the Longsong Stronghold, but the noble has their specific ways to get a hold of it. You can’t butt in.”

“Only imports but no exports?” He echoed, stunned.

“Yes. Although you can’t purchase local products, sales are pretty good. You can pretty much sell out everything from food and garments all the way to fabrics and general goods. No one knows where Prince Roland got so many gold royals from.” The captain breathed out some smoke and concluded, “So you’re very likely to return empty-handed this time.”

Otto put on a worried look without giving any response. In fact, he did not really care whether this would be a fruitless journey, as his sole purpose was to meet the lord of Border Town. However, due to the hostile relationship between Roland and Timothy, he had to be disguised as a tradesman and come to the border in secret.

Before taking off, he had already conducted a thorough investigation of his destination.

As its name suggested, Border Town was insignificant to neighbors. It was initially built for the purpose of monitoring the intrusion of demonic beasts, and was later transformed into a town for permanent residence. From the prince's widespread notoriety and the wasteland he was entitled, it was widely believed that Prince Roland was the least favorite of the king, and had been abandoned to his fate on the border.

However, the truth was, not only did he settle down in the Western Region, but he had also become a big threat to the new king. This was what confused Otto the most. If Prince Roland was indeed a capable man, what was his infamy based on and how had he put himself in such a desperate position in the first place?

According to his information, the rise of Roland Wimbledon was just incredible.

As a matter of fact, it was more like the prince had been banished to Border Town a year ago, accompanied by no ministers or guards. Even the knights with him were dispatched by the king. It was almost impossible for him to force the local noble to submit to his rules with such inadequate resources, not to mention the implementation of his policies. Therefore, a lot of people treated his arrival as a joke.

Nevertheless, Prince Roland defeated Duke Ryan and conquered the Longsong Stronghold, becoming the true ruler of the Western Region in merely six months. There were various rumors about the battle among the mass. Some believed the duke was killed during an internal rebellion, while others thought he'd been thrown from horseback, which was why the knightage failed to compete against a group of miners.

Roland thus secured his position as ruler of the Western Region. The wars induced by the Royal Decree on the Selection of Crown Prince had become increasingly intense. With Prince Gerald and Princess Garcia being killed in succession and Princess Tilly missing, cities in the Southern Territory and the

Eastern Region were devastated by the constant chaos. Only the Western Region remained tranquil and peaceful.

This was certainly not due to the benevolence of the new king, but that the armies sent by Timothy had never come back. Otto was very curious about what on earth Roland had done to foster such fierce soldiers.

“Captain, Border Town is right at the front.” The sailor pushed the cabin door open and reported, “We’re almost there.”

“Ah, finally!” The captain tapped the pipe and yelled, “Lower the sail, raise the flag and tell the dockmen that we’re here! I’m going to a tavern to have a good sip.” He looked at Otto and reminded him, “Hey, don’t you forget your luggage. See you in a week. I’m not waiting for you if you run late.”

Otto shrugged his shoulders, showing no objections.

Out of all the rumors about Prince Roland, the one he cared about most was that the prince had given himself up to demons and was hiring witches in secret. This was believed to be the real reason he was able to quickly crush the duke and occupy the whole Western Region, the evidence of which was the burned church in the Stronghold, the murder of the Priest and the expulsion of believers.

He came here actually because of this rumor.

Otto did not care about whether the prince was trading with demons or hiring witches, as long as the prince was on the opposite side of the church.

In this regard, Roland was more beneficial to the Kingdom of Dawn than Timothy.

The cabin suddenly shook violently when the boat was ashore.

Chapter 432

Chapter 432: An Encounter

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

Since his trip was kept confidential, obviously there would be nobody greeting him.

Therefore, Otto did not plan to go straight to the castle, but to first spend one or two days looking at the prince's territory before turning to local rats for information, as a picture was worth a thousand words.

He walked out of the cabin and onto the trestle, and was immediately astonished at what he saw.

This is… really a borderland wharf?

The dock areas were built with russet colored bricks within several hundred paces from the river bank. Trestles were built at certain intervals, with a sign where the trestle and the dock connected, on which there was a number. Otto counted them roughly. There were 26 in total, all of which were neatly displayed like tentacles extending from the bank. Some were covered with snow while others revealed the tawny planks beneath. This indicated the town's wharf was well taken care of even during the Months of the Demons.

In comparison, the trestles at the dock of King's City were less than half the ones here in terms of both length and number!

However, what stunned him more was the boats at the wharf.

A line of colossal gray boats he had never seen were at berth not far away. There were seven or eight in total, each of which had a shallow waterline with no sail or mast. Nonetheless, they were definitely too big to be operated by poles. One unique feature of these strange boats was the giant wooden tire

on either side and the bulky iron pipe in the middle. They looked different from any inland river boats.

Otto stood there and watched them for quite a while. He was still trying to figure out how these weird “tire boats” were operated when it began to snow.

He brushed the snow off his head, put these thoughts behind him, and decided to follow the crew to the town.

Apparently, Otto was not the only passenger on the “Downwind” from King’s City. He watched the crew unloading cargo and piling it up at the wharf. Several guards wearing black uniforms were jotting something down on the paper. They seemed to be examining the goods, as they picked out a couple of bags every now and then.

“Who are those people? The mercenaries hired by buyers?” Otto went to ask the captain.

“Huh? Mercenaries?” The captain beamed, “Those guys are patrollers in Border Town.”

“Patrollers?” He was puzzled. Weren’t they the same as bandits? He remembered the first time he left King’s City, the patrollers there blackmailed him for two silver royals, which he later learned was actually a common practice everywhere. These patrollers were sort of the rivals of underground rats, but they basically did the same thing. The difference was they charged more and often charged for nothing. However, to Otto’s surprise, the captain seemed pretty relaxed, still smoking his pipe leisurely without any intention to stop them, nor did he thrust them silver royals or ask the patrollers to leave.

“I thought the same thing when I came here for the first time.” The captain explained, seeming to have read his mind, “The patrollers here are different. As long as you follow their rules, you don’t need to pay anything before entering the market.”

“Patrollers’ rules?” Otto doubted, frowning. “Even the bandits here talk about rules, and they also note things down. They probably write nothing but wriggly symbols, but this is already more than enough to blow my mind.”

“What are they recording?” he questioned.

“The types and numbers of goods… especially wheat,” the captain answered, throwing up his hands. “Goods will be checked after being delivered to the market. This is to prevent you from selling them to others halfway. The food here can only be sold by the lord. Of course, I don’t have wheat in my cargo, so it’s going to be fast.”

All the bags were loaded to the carriages and everybody departed from the wharf, ready to set out for the market. Otto was suddenly dazzled by the scene.

Is this really the most deserted territory in the Kingdom of Graycastle?

Looking at the smooth, hard-surfaced road, the handsome houses along the street and people going to and fro, Otto felt the town was as thriving as City of Glow, the capital of the Kingdom of Dawn.

As a noble, he had seen many magnificent buildings. Compared with the Spire of Dawn and the Great Hall of Sun, these two or three-story buildings were definitely not in the same league.

Yet there was only one Spire of Dawn, which was surrounded by tumble-down houses, swampy paths, and muddy water.

However, he could not find a single house here that looked even slightly worn, as if all the residences had come about at the same time.

“You look quite surprised,” the captain said, laughing. “Nothing to be embarrassed about. Everybody was as stunned as you when they first came here. I ought to say Border Town is an amazing place. See the three-story building over there? It wasn’t there when I was here last time.”

“I heard… that it used to be a mining base here.”

“That’s what I’ve heard too, but who knows the truth,” he commented, picking the nose. “You know a lot of times rumors fly and truth walks. Perhaps there’s tons of gold hidden in the North Slope Mine, and that was why His Majesty sent his son down here… After all, they’re blood-related.”

“Hang on. What’s that?!” Across the square, Otto suddenly caught a glimpse of two big colorful balloons floating in the air. Below hung a banner, which read “Welcome to Border Town” on one side, and “Join Now to Obtain the Citizen Welfare” on the other.

“The stuff above or below?” The captain replied, pouting, “I don’t know much about the floating balls up there, but as to the one below… You can go to the east of the square where the Lord’s notices are usually posted. The banner says they’re recruiting tourists, tradesmen, and refugees from all over the world.”

“Even refugees?” Otto asked in dismay, “What’s the citizen welfare?”

“Allowance for work, food for the first two months and a shelter. Sounds pretty awesome, eh?” The captain explained airily, “It isn’t that easy to get approved. Many of my crews have tried, but none of them passed. The Lord wants someone who’s loyal, not a believer of the church and has no criminal records. But holy cricket, theft is also a crime. All sailors stole at some point in their lives, don’t you think? Plus, it looks very bustling here, but in fact, there’re also lots of downsides as far as I can tell.”

“Such as?”

“Barely any entertainment. No casinos or whorehouses, not even a hooker on the street.” He coughed out a spit and continued to complain, “Wouldn’t you be bored to death living in a place like this?”

The marketplace was to the north of the square. Otto decided to first take a look by himself while the captain and his crews were delivering the goods. According to the captain, there were plenty of rare finds in the convenience market on this side and the high-end market on the other. Indeed there were. Otto saw lines of racks filled with various goods. Once he lingered a little longer at a booth, there would be someone coming up to greet him. No matter

what the result of the negotiation with Prince Roland would be, Otto knew this town had already drawn his attention.

Just then, there was a stir among the multitude.

Otto turned around and saw two ladies heading toward this side.

One of them was wearing a black gown with a long dark ponytail. She had fine eyes, a cute nose and plump lips. But the coldness on her face made her look unapproachable. The other one, was completely different, looking soft and gentle. The traits of her every character were elegant and graceful like a warm spring breeze. Her gorgeous blonde hair reflected a shimmer of golden rays of the dawn.

Otto felt all his blood rushed to his head at the sight of the blonde lady.

He rubbed his eyes over and over again, hands slightly trembling, and was sure it was her…

“Andrea Quinn!” Unable to restrain his excitement, Otto shouted aloud in the crowd.

Chapter 433

Chapter 433: Unrequited Love

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

…

“Enjoy.” The maid placed some wine on the table and gave the three people a strange glance. “If you need a refill, just pull the rope near the door.”

“Got it. You’re excused.” Otto waved his hand, and the maid bowed and left. When the door closed, the ruckus in the lobby was blocked out, and the room immediately fell silent.

Even now, his heart was still racing, and he stared intensely at Andrea, as if he was afraid she would suddenly disappear. “I thought this was a dream. Belinda and Oro both think you’re dead, and I never thought I’d see you again…”

Otto’s loud outburst in the market caused Andrea to stare at him; since she responded to this name, this meant that she wasn’t just a lookalike.

In fact, she couldn’t be anyone else, since Andrea’s outstanding beauty and air of elegance were unparalleled among other girls.

However, she wasn’t as excited to see him as he had expected, and instead, she frowned, walked up to him, and sternly ordered him to follow her as she exited the market.

“She probably didn’t want to cause a scene. Yes, that’s right, the noble shouldn’t draw attention to themselves when among commoners. I was being rude.”

He followed the two people into a private room in a pub and finally got a chance to take a closer look at Andrea. Even after five years, she still looked

the same as he remembered. If this was a dream, he hoped that it would last a little longer.

“This is your ex-lover?” The dark-haired girl whistled in awe.

“Since you insisted on coming, you should know when to keep your mouth shut,” Andrea said with a glare. “Even if you stay quiet, no one will think you’re mute.”

“I came to protect you,” said the other girl with a grin. “Besides, you dragged me here to buy Tilly a birthday present, so kicking me out now would be an improper behavior for a noblewoman.”

“That depends on who the behavior is directed to.” Andrea scoffed. “I don’t have to be proper towards you.”

“This is …” Otto didn’t get a response from Andrea and felt a little awkward, so he turned to the equally stunning dark-haired girl. “… your friend?”

“Ashes,” she said quickly before Andrea could respond. “Who are you, and why do you know her?”

“I’m Otto Luoxi, and I come from the Kingdom of Dawn.” He was slightly taken aback by her interrogating tone—this Ashes girl spoke too bluntly and incisively to be an educated noblewoman, so why was Andrea in her company? “I’ve known Andrea since we were children, along with my sister Belinda, Oro Tokat, and the eldest son of the King of Dawn, His Highness Appen. We were all extremely close.”

“Sounds like a bunch of rich brats.” Ashes shrugged. “You said she died?”

“That’s because…”

“That’s enough.” Andrea interrupted. “Belinda and Oro are right—the lady of the Quinn Family whom you knew is dead.”

“But you’re right here.” Otto shook his head. “What happened?”

Besides the royal family, the most powerful families in the City of Glow, the capital of the Kingdom of Dawn, were the Tokat, Quinn and Luoxi families, because their heads were the King's trusted friends and held high positions. This tradition had been passed down since the founding of the Kingdom of Dawn and remained the same for Otto's generation.

Andrea was the eldest daughter of the Quinn family and was outstanding in her appearance and background, so she naturally had many suitors, including Otto and Oro.

However, no one expected that during a spring outing, Andrea's carriage would go out of control and fall into a canyon, an accident that even startled the king. The three families combined their efforts to search for her, and ages later, they found her battered body at the foot of the mountains.

After hearing about this, Otto was depressed for a long time, because while Oro had already begun pursuing Andrea, he had not yet expressed his feelings to her. He never thought he would get the chance to do it, and he would never have expected to see her again in this foreign land.

After a long pause, Andrea sighed. "It wasn't an accident.

"W… what?"

"The carriage accident five years ago was all planned by my family," she whispered. "Father found out that I was a witch."

Otto was startled. "A witch?"

"Seems like you did a pretty good job of hiding your powers," Ashes said, covering her mouth, "since you were even able to fool your childhood friends."

Andrea ignored her. "Yes. After father learned this, he immediately arranged for the accident to be staged—I wasn't even in the carriage, and a driver and maid lost their lives for me. Then, I was sent away from the Kingdom of Dawn and settled secretly in Palisade City of the Kingdom of Graycastle." She paused. "He never actually asked for my opinion on the matter and didn't

care what I thought because he was only focused on getting rid of me as quickly as possible."

"So that's what happened…" Otto fell silent. "The beloved 'Flower of Glow' is actually a witch. If word of this gets out, it'll greatly damage the Quinn Family name." However, the staged accident also protected Andrea from harm—as a member of the upper noble, he had heard many tragic stories about the sufferings of witches who fell into the hands of the church.

After some hesitation, he shared his thoughts with Andrea, but she interrupted him with a cold chuckle.

"Protect? As long as father didn't give me up, what could the church have done? Sent the Judgement Army straight into the inner city to arrest me?" She raised her voice. "He was Prime Minister to the King of Dawn and controlled the outer city's surveillance teams, but he didn't do anything to help me. Nana's father was only a Baron, but for the sake of his daughter, he went straight to the Lord's castle and demanded mercy from His Highness Roland, while my father simply banished me from my home. Do you call that protecting me?"

Otto was at a loss for words, and after a long and awkward silence, he finally said hesitantly, "Are… are you going back?"

"Never." Andrea stood up. "I already said that the lady of the Quinn family died five years ago, which was exactly what father wanted."

"Oro still leaves flowers at your grave every year. He can't forget you."

She walked up to the door and whispered, "His love is one-sided, so he'll forget me one day."

As Otto watched the two people disappear from view, he lay helplessly on his chair.

He was beginning to hate his cowardice.

Even at that moment, he still only mentioned Oro instead of expressing his own feelings.

I can’t forget you either.

He closed his eyes.

Chapter 434

Chapter 434: The Birthday Gift

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

Roland learned from Anna that Tilly got her twentieth birthday coming.

He hadn't thought about such a thing until now.

It wasn't because he was careless, but because Prince Roland's memories were like a database that he would only delve into when necessary. However, his memories rarely contained anything related to politics or occultism and mostly consisted of mischievous wrongdoings and ideas for pranks, so he revisited them less and less.

Moreover, Tilly was a sore spot for Prince Roland, so everything related to her had little significance and had been buried away, as if he didn't want to recall them.

Tilly's birthday didn't mean her Day of Awakening, but her actual day of birth—as an Extraordinary, she didn't even know the time when she awoke as a witch, and she wouldn't experience the feeling of biting by magic power when the Months of Demons came around. Therefore, her birthday was her only important milestone.

Roland scrolled through his memories and realized that since Tilly was the Queen's youngest child, King Wimbledon III used to throw her a birthday celebration in the Inner City every winter when he was still alive, which was a luxury that even his favorite child, Timothy, never received. However, besides this, he usually ignored Tilly and showed no interest in her life. Otherwise, Prince Roland wouldn't have dared to bully his little sister so much.

As he continued scrolling back, he found another interesting piece of memory.

Tilly's celebration on her eighteenth birthday was her most extravagant one, even surpassing the rite of passage ceremony that followed. Not only did the four border guardians come to the King's City for this celebration, but there were also gifts from the Kingdom of Dawn, the Kingdom of Wolfheart, and the Kingdom of Everwinter, and even the Fjord Islands sent an emissary delegation.

Timothy and Garcia were extremely jealous and wanted to teach Tilly a lesson that she wasn't father's favorite child—the only one reason why King Wimbledon III threw her these celebrations was to make up for the loss of his queen and to console the spirit of Tilly's deceased mother.

No matter how Roland felt about this theory, they both believed it at the time, so they tried to convince Prince Roland to carry out their plan on his sister. However, after Tilly taught him a lesson eight years ago, he was too scared to mess with this girl who seemed meek at first glance but had the spirit of resistance in the depth of her heart , so he refused. The two siblings were forced to act on their own.

Prince Roland didn't know how they did it, but Tilly's favorite gift, the bear cubs from the Kingdom of Wolfheart, was somehow poisoned—as he watched his little sister dully cradling the dead bears, Roland realized the prince had actually felt entertained.

No wonder he was the scum of the royal family. Besides murder and arson, Prince Roland had done every awful thing under the sun.

Either way, this was definitely an awful memory for Tilly Wimbledon.

After he finished scrolling through his memories, Roland suddenly came up with an idea for a gift.

He took out a sheet of paper and began drawing the picture of his gift.

"What's this?" Nightingale peeked him from behind. "A bear?"

"Yes, a stuffed bear, the one you can sleep with at night." Roland smiled.

Judging from his limited gift-giving experience, he knew that most girls loved cute and furry gifts, and a life-sized stuffed aminal was the perfect combination of these two features. Of course, a simple stuffed animal was too easy and common. As a prince with a group of witches to assist him, he could do much better.

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On Tilly's birthday, Roland carried her gift to her room.

She was alone when she opened the door and was slightly surprised to see him. "Why do you come over?"

"Today is your birthday, so I'll host a celebratory feast in the castle tonight," Roland said with a smile, "but before that, I have a gift for you."

"A gift?" Tilly said, taken aback. "Is it what you're carrying?" She turned around and said, "Come in."

"Um… It's a little bit big, but I promise it's very special." The prince mopped the sweat on his forehead and placed the gift on the floor. The noble during this time usually gave small and delicate gifts, such as flowers and rings, so that they could hide them in their robes and take them out as a surprise. Roland carrying a large wrapped paper box was definitely a rare sight—and this thing was much heavier than he imagined.

"You've never given me anything before," Tilly said in a mysterious tone.

"I gave you a goose feather quill when you were born." Roland corrected it. "But it wasn't anything valuable."

"Alright, it's a Graycastle royal tradition." She shrugged. "What about this? Can I open it?"

"Of course."

Roland smiled as he watched her untie the ribbons, and when the box fell open, he heard her gasp quietly.

“What… what’s this?” Tilly blinked.

“It’s a bear!” Roland said with a grin.

“What kind of bear looks like this.” She circled the stuffed animal curiously and patted it. “It’s so soft…”

Its fur cover was specially made by Soraya according to the fur of Northern wolf cubs and added a silky soft touch. As for the design… Roland completely based it off of the future’s pandas. As an animal that had survived millenniums by simply acting cute and had even been used as diplomatic gifts, it was exceptionally cute.

“I’ve never seen this kind of bear… Its color is so strange…”

“You don’t like it?”

“No, I mean…” Tilly seemed to be at a loss for words, but her eyes, which were flashing with excitement, revealed her true thoughts.

“It’s called ‘panda’, and it’s a… widely-loved animal.”

She quickly understood what he meant. “This belongs to your other world…”

Roland nodded. “And it’s not just a stuffed animal you can hold. Try pinching its neck.”

Tilly did as he adviced, and the panda suddenly started to move, wave its legs and try to climb on top of Tilly. She covered her mouth in shock and backed away, while the stuffed animal continued to move its legs and walk slowly towards her.

This was why it was so heavy—Roland had installed connecting rods and gears in its body with small generators in each leg, and the generators’ power came from miniature Dawn I engines. As he lowered the magnetic flux, its shelf life was greatly extended, lasting up to three or four months without use or four fifths of the time if used frequently. Even if Tilly returned to the Sleeping Island, the panda would still accompany her for a long time.

“Pinch its neck again, and it’ll stop.” Roland smiled. “I hope you’ll like this gift.”

This time, even though Tilly didn’t respond, her expression told Roland everything he needed to know.

Chapter 435

Chapter 435: Arrested

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

“Why do you… want to give me this?” After a while, Tilly put down the muppet.

“Do you remember what happened on your 18th birthday?” Roland asked slowly.

“…” She pursed her lips and asked, “You did that?”

“No, it was Timothy and Garcia.” The prince told the story again. “But I should also take some responsibility. If I had told father, it wouldn’t have happened.”

“And they also would have beaten you up,” Tilly said, “so it was reasonable for you not to tell.”

“This sort of thing will never happen again.”

“I thought that the extra space in your head was used to store knowledge.” She didn’t respond and changed the topic. “Now it seems that’s not the case. Besides this ‘panda’, is there anything else new? ”

When he heard her get tongue-tied trying to pronounce this strange word, Roland couldn’t help but smile. “Of course… countless things. When I get a chance, I’ll tell you more.”

There was no doubt that Tilly was smart. He believed that she would understand him even if he didn’t tell the whole story.

Sure enough, after pausing for a moment, she stared at Roland with thoughtful eyes.

Suddenly, Andrea's voice sounded through the door. "Lady Tilly, I want to give you a gift… You, go away!"

"I came first, OK?" Ashes' voice immediately followed.

"I was the first one!"

Roland laughed and stood up. "Indeed, a lot of unpleasant things had happened before, but the past is the past. No matter what, you and me, or Border Town and Sleeping Island shouldn't be bound by bad memories. If you have any trouble in the future, you can come to me anytime… I'll be your elder brother forever." He paused for a while and said, "Happy birthday, Tilly."

He opened the door. The two witches were immediately stupefied and stared at each other with confusion.

The prince smiled and said, "Stop quarreling, I was the first."

****

Otto wandered the streets dejectedly with Andrea's words still lingering in his mind.

"…the lady of the Quinn family died five years ago, which was exactly what father wanted."

He didn't agree with her, but he couldn't find any excuses to contradict her with. These days, besides observing Border Town, he spent the rest of his time wandering near the market. He hoped to see her again, but was ultimately disappointed.

Otto went to the stone bench next to the square, flicked away the snow on top, and sat down slowly.

Although thoughts were surging in his heart, he still didn't forget the reason why he came here. Except for the corps and battalions, he had gone through every corner of this village and had a comprehensive understanding of this area. For example, the villagers' lives weren't so affluent at the very

beginning and had been no different from those of regular slums. All these changes were due to the Lord, His Highness Roland Wimbledon. He led the people against those bloodcurdling demonic beasts and invented various magical machines and tools to improve people's lives.

Otto had witnessed the black machines operating in the mine area. Just two or three iron lumps could easily finish the work of tens of people.

Also, it was said that the high tower alongside the Redwater River could send water to each resident's home.

There were the quickly built city walls, residential communities, and docks as well.

In addition, it seemed that the ditches that were being dug would make the installation of heating equipment easier, and the inhabitants would no longer fear the cold—news like this could be seen on the bulletin board in the center of the square every day. More astonishingly, most of the villagers could understand the official documents on the board.

The more he observed, the more astonished he felt. Changes were happening everywhere in Border Town and were totally beyond his imagination.

Opening his notebook, Otto intended to take down today's new discoveries, but someone suddenly grabbed the hand holding his pen.

Looking up, he saw two patrol officers with black uniforms in front of him. "Are you Silver Eye?"

That was a false name he used when disguised as a businessman. Otto answered calmly and when he looked around, he found out that there were also people with black uniforms appearing on the other two sides of the square. However, they just stared at him and didn't come closer.

They came here for me.

Otto's heart sank. Before, he thought that the patrols here weren't like what he saw elsewhere and behaved appropriately, so he didn't expect to get into

trouble.

“What’s up?” he asked with a cold voice. Faced with these bullying and greedy people, there was no benefit in flattering them. Even if they wanted to blackmail him, he wouldn’t let them run their mouths. In the worst case, he would have to use his identity as a nobleman.

However, the uniformed officers’ answer surprised him. “According to the report we received, we suspect that you are conducting espionage. Now, keep your hands behind you and follow our instructions. If there is any resistance, we can’t guarantee your safety.”

“Espionage? What a strange reason… Could it be that they want to find a fall guy?” Otto thought silently. “I don’t understand what you are saying.” He shook off their arms. “I’m from the Luoxi Family in the City of Glow, a noble of the Kingdom of Dawn. I’m not a…”

As soon as he shook off their hands, his belly was suddenly punched severely, and more than half of his strength disappeared immediately with an acidic taste filling his mouth and his body curling up involuntarily. Then, the two men knocked him down into the cold snow, and his hands were tied together with ropes.

“A noble? You said you were a businessman several days ago.” One of them sneered.

“I told you not to resist.” The other man gave him another hard kick. “You asked for it.”

“Several days ago? Does this mean they have targeted me for a while? This is impossible… At least no patrol guards noticed me in the first two days.”

“Ahem… I’m indeed a nobleman, and the writ… is in my bag.” Otto struggled for a while, but the men ignored him.

“Save your excuses for His Excellency Carter.” Two men lifted him up. “If you’re honest, you may get to survive.”

…

After staying in jail for a day, Otto felt hungry and thirsty and finally saw the one whom people called His Excellency Carter.

Before the knight could say a word, he gripped the iron bars and blurted, “I’m really the Otto Luoxi from the City of Glow in the Kingdom of Dawn. Entrusted by the King of Dawn, I came to this Kingdom of Graycastle for allies to confront the church. I’m not the spy you accused me to be! I want to meet with your Lord, His Highness Roland Wimbledon!”

He had long heard about the shady dealings in jail. Patrols always colluded with Rats and imprisoned foreigners to be scapegoats. If they thought that he was an unimportant stranger, he probably wouldn’t live to see another day.

Carter was shocked. “I haven’t asked you anything yet.” He turned his head. “What do you think my answer will be?”

Then, in a scene that shocked Otto, a girl came out from the shadow, her body covered by a white robe and her face concealed by a hood. However, judging from her figure, she seemed no different from the “Flower of Glow”.

“What he said is true,” she shrugged and said.

“Really? Does this mean he’s indeed an envoy from the Kingdom of Dawn?” Carter put his hand on his forehead. “It seems that we caused some trouble for His Highness.”

Chapter 436

Chapter 436: The Indeterminable Appointment

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

Finally, Otto met the legendary Prince Roland of the Kingdom of Graycastle.

After confirming he was a nobleman of the Kingdom of Dawn, Carter brought him into the castle. Then, as the attendants served him with toiletries, new clothes, and some hot food, Carter frisked him.

This might be the most offensive reception that Otto had ever seen.

Prince Roland was in a north-facing room on the castle's third floor. The French windows, which occupied half of the wall, first came into sight as the door was opened. The snow-covered landscape brightened up the room, which was particularly warm, despite there being no lit fireplace.

The prince was sitting at a mahogany table, reading a black-covered book in his hand, which Otto realized was his own notebook. In addition, the diplomatic documents and the family seal were set on the side. It seemed that the hotel that he was staying in had been searched thoroughly.

Although Prince Roland had the same gray hair as Timothy, and there was some resemblance in their features, they gave people an entirely different impression. Both his sitting position and expression seemed to be very casual which conformed to the rumors that Prince Roland liked to persist in his old ways.

Noticing Otto, he closed the book, smiled and said, "Are you the envoy from the Kingdom of Dawn? Have a seat."

Otto bowed in accordance with noble etiquette. No matter how awful the prince behaved, he had to do this—after all, although Prince Roland might

not care if he was treated as a joke, he represented the royal dignity of the Kingdom of Dawn.

“I have read some of your notes,” the prince laughed and said. “Some were recorded in great detail, so it’s not surprising for them to mistake you for a spy. Also, my people didn’t know where you were from, and they enthusiastically reported you to me because of my orders. I’d like to apologize to you here.”

“The people… reported me?” Otto frowned and thought. However, no explanation could excuse rudely offending a noble, not to mention that the offender was just a man without any title of nobility. If it wasn’t for his mission, he would definitely ask the prince to bring the man who assaulted him to justice. Otto restrained his innermost negative emotion and said, “No, you don’t have to. Your Highness, you just do this for the peace of the people. It’s just… that it may hurt innocent strangers, and I’m afraid most people couldn’t provide documents to prove their identities like me.”

“You don’t need to worry about that. The collection of evidence by the judicial department is irrelevant to the identification documents, and we have all kinds of measures to protect the innocent people.” Prince Roland waved his hand and continued, “What’s the saying? We would never wrong a good man or let a single bad one go.” At this, he smiled and said, “I heard about your arrest—if you did as they commanded, then you wouldn’t have been harmed. The process was a little brutal but it’s also done with reluctance. You know, some of the most vicious people may take out a weapon and fight back at any time. Since the winter, two police officers have been injured while making arrests. ”

“Police officers… It might refer to those patrols. What’s a judicial department? The administration to supervise patrols?” Otto wondered and asked, “Does this kind of thing happen often?”

“Once or twice a month,” said the prince, “and it’s probably because Timothy is so bored in this endless winter.”

The prince openly showed his hostility toward the new king. Otto realized that the contradictions between the two sides couldn’t be reconciled. Then he

hesitated for a while and said, “When I went to the King’s City, I heard a rumor… Your Highness, are you really going to overthrow Timothy’s authority?”

“Did the rumor say that the new king’s throne is hung by a thread?” The prince said bluntly, “Timothy shouldn’t be the new king—in order to usurp the throne, he murdered his father, blamed it on his elder brother, and expelled Garcia out of the Kingdom of Graycastle. The entire Southern Territory was destroyed in the war, and the people became destitute and homeless—these are all the crimes he had committed. The only way to restore the past prosperity of the Kingdom of Graycastle is to overthrow him.”

Otto held his breath for a second and thought, “Roland Wimbledon is more active than Timothy; at least Timothy’s fighting resolve isn’t so strong… It seems to be a reversal of both status and momentum.”

He cleared his throat and said, “So, as a friendly neighbor, the Kingdom of Dawn hopes that the Kingdom of Graycastle could soon regain peace. I came here at this time to bring the alliance agreement of Deegan Moya, the King of Dawn.”

“Oh?” said the prince with interest, “Where is it?”

“In order to avoid the message being leaked, I didn’t carry the document with me. However, His Majesty has granted me the right to sign the agreement.” Otto repeated the alliance agreement again. “If the two countries can help each other, we can effectively hold the church in play and avoid going down the same road as the Kingdoms of Everwinter and Wolfheart.”

“That’s it?”

The response of the prince perplexed Otto. “What does ‘that’s it’ mean? I’ve made myself quite clear,” he thought. As he was about to repeat his words, the prince shook his head and said, “The project might not work. The determination of the church to annex the Four Kingdoms is much stronger than you think, let alone the combative God’s Punishment Army and witches—

your troops stationed along the border might be surrounded and destroyed by the enemy before they've even departed."

"God's Punishment Army and… witches?" asked Otto in surprise.

"It seems that you know nothing about the ambition of the church," said Prince Roland. He took a sip of tea and continued, "I'll tell you all the information we know, and I hope you can bring these messages back to the Kingdom of Dawn so that your king can re-examine the alliance agreement. If we want to defeat the church, we need not only a deterrent, but one big attack. "

The meeting didn't come to an end until the evening when the Prince put his cup down, and the wilderness and forest behind him were all in the dark. A strange light lit up in the room, which was brighter and purer than a candle, but Otto had no mind to notice this. He felt his clothes soaked with cold sweat on his back, his hands inadvertently held into a fist, his palms were creamy, and the words of the prince were echoing in his mind.

"The extraordinary warriors created by utilizing wild witches, secret combat witches, and pure witches… And the purpose of the church to eliminate the Four Kingdoms at all costs is to usher in the coming Battle of Doomsday! The news was just too incredible!"

However, many details coincided with the information that he had collected, such as the Pill of Madness, which the church used to weaken the resistance of the kingdom; the carriages transporting female orphans to the Holy City; and their attitude towards the defeated nobles—if it was to completely erase the influence of the nobility to achieve a completely united kingdom of the church, all these things would make sense.

"I… I can't make a decision," Otto stammered. "These matters are too important. I have to report to His… His Majesty first."

"Of course, this is a matter of life and death for the two countries," the prince calmly said, "and you can't be too careful. But don't forget, our time is running out."

…

Ready to leave, Otto went to the door, hesitantly turned around and said, “Your Highness, I heard that a group of witches was recruited to Border Town… I wonder if you’ve heard of the name Andrea.”

“Ah, she used to be a noblewoman of the Kingdom of Dawn, but unfortunately she became homeless and came into the Kingdom of Graycastle afterward.” The prince lifted his eyebrows and asked, “Why? Do you know her?”

“Yes!” answered Otto with his heart beating strongly. “Could you… allow me to see her?”

The prince nodded and said, “I can help to arrange it, but whether or not she’ll meet you will be up to her.”

“Isn’t Andrea your…”

He shook his head with a smile and said, “The witches are just the citizens who live here, not my servants—I can ‘t manipulate their minds.”

Chapter 437

Chapter 437: A Silent Farewell

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

After Otto Luoxi left the office, Nightingale stood by Roland. “What he’s said isn’t completely true, especially the part about his experience before he came to Border Town.”

“No surprise. He must have negotiated with Timothy in King’s City before coming to the Western Region.” Roland smiled. “It would be very strange if he came directly to me first. A diplomat always hedges his bets. If I were him, I wouldn’t put all my eggs in one basket either.”

“You mean… they might not stand on our side?”

“At least, they won’t hurry to make a decision.” He picked up the kettle to refill his tea cup. “When the King of Dawn receives this news, how much of it do you think he will believe?”

Nightingale searched for an answer for quite a while until she finally said, “I… don’t know.”

“Me neither.” At these words, Nightingale pinched Roland’s shoulder. He was not telling the truth. “One thing is obvious though. The King of Dawn is probably not going to swing to us because of this news. It sounds terrifying but it’s something that will only happen several years from now. Besides, we can’t even give him an exact date. The threat of the church, however, is right under his nose. Given that the church may launch the attack in the coming spring, he’s most likely to stand by watching battles between Timothy and me until either of us wins. If he’s clever enough, he’ll probably be on good terms with both of us for future returns.”

Politicians often handled these kinds of issues this way. They preferred smooth gains to risky investments, especially in the case of wars which were

normally highly profitable. If there had been no threat from demons, Roland would have been happy to join this game, setting a trap for his opponent and then reaping some profits. But he was not in the mood for this diplomatic game now. In the following year, Border Town would have to launch an attack and stabilize the situation. A storm was brewing, and the ones who had a narrow vision and concentrated on immediate interests would have no future.

"Is it… good for us to tell them the news?" Nightingale asked in doubt.

"The Kingdom of Dawn isn't our real enemy, after all. I'm not sure how much the nobles there will believe the story about demons, but they'll definitely spread the word about the church's ambition. It'll weaken the ruling of the church," Roland explained. "Without people's support, the church won't be able to use the kingdom's resources that easily."

When he broke the news to Otto, he only mentioned the part about demons, but not the part about the witches' empire and the two Battles of Divine Will.

The former was even more unbelievable than the existence of demons and might cause unwanted effects. It could be purposely distorted into a "witches' scheme" because of people's general hostility towards them.

The latter might shake people's confidence in fighting against the demons. They had failed twice before. What were their chances of winning this time?

Anyhow, he had already hinted that the two kingdoms should fight the demons together. As to the result, it would depend on the reply from the Kingdom of Dawn.

…

Three days later, Roland met Otto Luoxi again,

He could guess the answer from the disappointment in Otto's eyes.

"Personally, I'm more inclined to the alliance, but the priority now is to send the news to the Kingdom of Dawn as soon as possible instead of talking

about the agreement details." Otto bowed and said, "so I'm here to bid you farewell."

"Hope to hear good news from you then." Roland nodded.

"Besides… Your Highness," Otto hesitated for a moment and said, "I would like to ask you a personal favor."

"What is it?"

"Please take good care of Andrea Quinn for me."

"Andrea was a witch from Sleeping Island. You should actually ask Tilly Wimbledon to do that, not me," Roland thought with a sigh, but still he gave his promise.

****

At the top of the castle, Andrea stood, facing the howling wind and looking south toward the Redwater River.

"Aren't you… going to the dock?" Shavi shivered in coldness, hiding behind her invisible barrier. "I hear he's going to lea-leave by boat. As a childhood playmate, you shou-should go to wish him a good trip."

"I can wish him one here, too." She heaved a sigh.

"A-Ashes said he never stops thinking about you."

"Don't listen to anything she's said," Andrea grunted. "She even praised that guy in front of Lady Tilly. A filthy mouth will never utter decent language."

"Eh, is, is that so?" Shavi said, her teeth chattering.

"Yes." She snorted. She noticed Shavi shivering. "If you feel that cold, go down now. You can come back to fetch me later."

"It's, it's OK, I'll wait for you here." Shavi shook her head. "If, if I catch a cold, Miss Lily will cure me and I can take two, two days off. Then I'll have

more time to play cards."

"That sounds reasonable." Andrea gave her a thumbs up and turned her gaze to the Redwater River. Through the falling snow, she could vaguely see some rising sails and something red fluttering at the top of a mast.

It was the sailing signal.

This was good. Time would dilute all the attention and forgetting would be better for everyone, she thought.

Andrea somehow knew Otto's love for her, but she still chose to avoid him. Both he and Oro Tokat should marry someone more suited to their status. They were the most famous noble families in the City of Glow. A relationship with either of them was doomed from the start. Besides, she was not willing to return to the land which had abandoned her.

Avoiding him was the best choice.

"Farewell, my friend," Andrea thought.

The looming sails soon disappeared on the horizon.

****

After sending off the messenger, Roland threw himself into the construction of Border Town.

The Tee Project which included a water supply, a power supply, and a heating system had officially launched. The three pipes were embedded in underground tunnels, reaching every residential community. It was easy to adapt each household because every residential house had been designed with reserve openings for the pipes. The key lay in the location of boilers and water towers.

In order to save materials and reduce loss during transportation as much as they could, Roland changed the plan. Instead of drawing water from the Redwater River, they would draw from underground springs. Given that Border Town was rich in underground water and the it was not deep, it was

easy to dig wells. Besides, in this era, there was no need to take water pollution into consideration. With the help of Sylvie, Roland quickly picked out four spots as water access points for the town. They could purvey water not only for daily uses such as drinking and cleansing, but also for the heating system and boilers.

Chapter 438

Chapter 438: Electricity and Light

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

Based on the construction plan, Roland set up a workroom with all the equipment to build an efficient Tee Project system.

The complete set of equipment included a steam engine, an electric motor, a power supply unit, a boiler, and two water tanks. Together with the water tower outside the room, they formed the workings of the Tee Project system.

The steam engine pumped the water up into the water tower and the water tanks. The former was to provide the residential communities with water for domestic needs. The latter was the water supply for the boiler and the heating system. The first-level water tank was higher. Limestones and washing stones which were used to soften the water by precipitating magnesium and calcium ions in it were put inside the tank. The water in it would then flow into the lower second-level tank through a filter screen specially made by Soraya, which would stop the floating objects in the water from entering the second-level tank.

The boiler's water supply was controlled by an electric motor. When the water level inside the boiler was too low, the ballcock inside would start the electric motor to bring water in until the water level got back to normal. This process was more stable than both the manual control and the steam engine system, saving the trouble to arrange someone to observe the site all the time.

The water supply and heating systems had already been successfully tested. Roland was confident that their construction would go smoothly. His current focus was on the power supply. It was a brand new thing for the town. Neither Karl nor other members of the Mason Guild had any idea of electricity. Given that Roland did not know much about electricity himself either, and that all his knowledge of electronic circuits remained at the high-

school level, he decided to build a model in his courtyard first. If he succeeded, he would explain it to the Ministry of Construction.

Once he had a stable power supply, the first step then was to create that traditional emblem of electrical power: a light bulb.

With that in mind, Roland put on a thick coat and set out for his courtyard on the North Slope Mountain.

It normally would take a quarter of an hour to walk to the courtyard, but with the help of Nightingale's mist, they arrived in scarcely four minutes.

When the wooden door was pushed open, Anna and Lucia immediately noticed Roland. Anna, busy with her work, just nodded to him. Lucia happily ran to him and said, "Your Highness, good morning."

"Good morning," Roland nodded with a smile and then walked to Anna. "What're you busy with?"

"The new gun barrels and locking mechanism." She pointed to several long steel pipes on the desk with a serious look on her face, "Some aspects of your drawings don't make sense. I think it'll be better this way."

"My amazing Anna," Roland thought and could not help stretching out his hand, trying to touch her head but she refused it by rocking back and forth. "Well… this scene seems familiar." He coughed, banished his thoughts of Anna and said, "Good, do whatever you want."

Roland did not mind her questioning his designs. He knew and would naturally have mistakes and shortcomings based on his minimal design experience. He felt like Anna was not only more talented but also had a keener eye for fine detail and he was convinced that one day she would surpass him in skills.

After a while, Anna finished her work and put down her tools . She walked to Roland and lowered her head a little.

"Eh? Is it to make up for the touch just now?" Roland thought in surprise.

He ruffled her soft hair. Anna looked up in satisfaction, “What are we making next?”

“Ah… yes.” The prince turned to Lucia. “How did your separation work of ores from the mines go?”

“Almost done and here are the results,” Lucia gave him a stack of books and said, “but I’m afraid it’ll take a long time to test on the mixtures of them and rolled steel. There are just too many individual elements.”

“It’s already pretty good,” Roland encouraged her.

This was part of his material improvement plan. He had already improved the rolled steel quality by reducing carbon content and eliminating impurities, and now all the elements in the North Slope Mine area could be utilized. They had to try one by one. There was no shortcut.

Roland glanced over the books, looking at the features of the elements separated from ores in the mines. He soon found the element with the highest melting point. He poked his finger at the testing sample marked with No. 12 and asked, “Where are they?”

Lucia quickly found them. They were a crude stone and a bag of elementary particles, both sealed in plastic bags.

Roland thought he recognized this crude, black stone from somewhere else.

“Wait, isn’t it the same as the black stone sent to my office earlier? I gave it to alchemists and then totally forgot about it. I’ve never thought twice about it since then.

Could it turn out to be the mineral that has the highest melting point on the North Slope Mountain?”

Anna could not measure the exact temperatures at which the materials melted, so she described them roughly by words such as “normal”, “high” and “relatively high”. Only the melting point of No.12 testing sample was described as “extremely high.”

The elementary particles in the bag were silvery white, similar to most of the other metallic elements.

He thought, “Is it wolfram?

Whatever, as long as it is difficult to melt.”

Roland let Anna make the particles into very fine wire, twisted the wire into a spiral and fix it onto a glass shelf which was then put into a glass bulb. The main part of an electric lamp was completed.

To make it a stable light, there were two more steps which were also considered to be the most difficult part in making electric bulbs. The first one was to evacuate the bulb, preventing the filament wire from reacting with oxygen. The second was sealing it to ensure that the air could not enter the bulb.

Without a doubt, only witches could realize those two steps.

Roland soon thought of Agatha.

The filament would become extremely reactive at high temperatures. It would easily oxidize, produce new oxides, and eventually melt down. That was why the bulb needed vacuum inside, but filling the bulb with inert gases could achieve the same or an even better effect.

Pure nitrogen was an excellent choice for this.

As nitrogen was lighter than the air, using a simple downward exhaust method, the bulb could be easily filled with nitrogen. It was much simpler than the vacuuming process. When the other end of the exhaust was also pure nitrogen, Soraya quickly sealed the bulb. A simple incandescent lamp was made successfully.

Looking at the electric bulb as small as his palm, Roland felt all sorts of emotions welling up in his mind. It was something outdated but now represented the most advanced manufacturing skills of the town.

The following night, he summoned all the members of City Hall to gather in front of the castle and ordered his guards to put out all the torches in the courtyard.

In this dark, snowy night, Roland switched on the circuit.

All of a sudden, at the center of the courtyard, an orange light lit up. It would not sway and extinguish in the wind like the light of a candle and it never flickered like fire. Though it could merely light up within a radius of a few meters, a stable light in the wind was something that the people had never seen before.

At this moment, everything was self-explanatory.

The fixed look on everyone's face and the silence of the scene told everything.

He had brought electricity to this world.

Chapter 439

Chapter 439: The Crime Scene

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

“Brother Vader, is… this really Okay?” Firehead said while fiddling with her own clothing. “Chief Knight said that our uniforms are the symbol of our status, and thus we must wear it neatly when we’re on duty.”

“What’s more, there’s a punishment for dirtying the uniform, let alone for not wearing it.” Whistle kept looking left and right as if he was afraid of being spotted by a colleague.

“Stop nagging. It’s symbolic enough to wear it. Standing in the midwinter snow in the black uniform will alert everyone in the vicinity that policemen are around. How are we supposed to catch any criminal?” Vader spat on the ground and then continued, “You’re both from Border Town, right?”

The two policewomen became more spirited the moment Vader mentioned this. “Yes, I am. My father was a hunter who used to live on Old Street, and his skill was remarkable. He was able to strike the neck of a fox scampering about in the woods with only one arrow.”

“Me too. But my father often told me that hunting was an unstable career, and he preferred I became a miner. He’d even prepared a hoe for me. Had His Highness Roland not become the new Lord, I would have spent my days in the mines.”

“I can tell.” Vader shrugged his shoulders. “Only the children of hunters would have such uncommon nicknames,” he silently thought. “Since you’re both locals, surely you’re more concerned about the public order in the town than I am, right? If even I’m not afraid of being punished, why are you afraid? Is wearing the uniform more important than enforcing the rules and laws laid down by His Highness?”

“Hmm…” The duo hesitated briefly, before they replied with conviction, “You’re right.”

“But, Brother Vader, you’re not an outsider. Haven’t you already received your identity card? His Highness once said that anyone who possess the identity card are considered to be his subjects,” Whistle muttered.

Vader laughed and did not say a word. Instead, he fixed his gaze on a row of cave dwellings on the eastern side of the temporary housing area.

After serving as a policeman for nearly three months, he had grown fully accustomed to life in the Western Region. Before he became a policeman, he thought that a “patrol team” would have nothing to do apart from extorting and cheating the people. Little did he know that there would be more work than could possibly be completed every day.

The police were required to accept refugees and handle disputes among the citizenry. It was also the police’s duty to catch criminals and spies. Whereas, apart from fighting against the demonic beasts, the First Army did not help or intervene in the internal peacekeeping of Border Town.

This was completely different from what he had initially expected.

In Valencia, the patrol team was more like the city guards’ backup. They handled menial tasks and were not of much use. This was the reason why many patrollers would seek money from illicit sources. However, in Border Town, the police and the First Army belonged to different systems. The former handled internal affairs while the latter handled external ones.

What surprised Vader more was that the majority of the patrol team’s targets came from public reports instead of direct orders from their superiors. Indeed, the citizens of Border Town had changed his perception of commoners. This bunch of lazy and stupid people would actively watch out for suspicious characters and report them to the City Hall. Whenever a foreign merchant ship arrived in the town, the Ministry of Justice would receive a handful of such reports.

Vader soon realized the tremendous power that lied within the town—no foreign spy could shut himself off from the public or integrate into society quickly unless he grew up here. With everyone serving as a vigilant watchdog, what enemy could hide among the populace?

But of course, not every arrest operation would be successful. For example, the sneaky characters whom they arrested during the previous operation turned out to be a noble from the Kingdom of Dawn. Vader was prepared to be punished, but his superiors showed no reaction and seemed unperturbed that he had beaten up a noble. This served to consolidate his current mentality towards his job.

“Gold’s here!” Firehead exclaimed softly.

“Ignore him and just pretend that you’re sweeping the snow,” Vader said calmly. “He didn’t bring any goods, which means he’s only here to check on the situation.”

“Gold” was the code name of their current target. The Ministry of Justice received a report two days ago that a serf was trafficking grains. His Excellency Carter attached great importance to this issue and immediately assigned the task to Vader. He demanded that the serf was arrested alive together with the goods, and called this the “Gold Hunting Mission”.

However, the mission did not start out smoothly. After making some inquiries, they began to uncover the identity of the target. Subsequently, a team of six people took turns to monitor the temporary housing area, but not a single trace of the target was found.

To Vader, it was clear that the reason for the lack of development was because the policemen’s uniforms were too conspicuous. He had lived in the Western Zone for some time, and naturally knew that whenever a City Hall official was in the area, news of it would spread rapidly among the residents. It was no different in the Eastern Zone. The people who lived here were serfs, and thus the black uniforms of the policemen were as striking as fireflies in the night sky.

That explained why he was adamant that Firehead and Whistle should take off their uniforms and put on a tattered coat. In this way, they could disguise as snow sweepers and stand on the thoroughfares of the Eastern Zone and Border Town. The suspect would not be able to escape their sights as soon as he appeared.

They saw Gold walking around the Eastern Zone briefly before returning to a cave dwelling. When he reappeared, he was carrying a large sack on his back.

“He’s indeed trafficking wheat…” Whistle clenched her fists tightly.

“Damn it! He simply doesn’t respect what His Highness has said.” Firehead cursed angrily. “We shall arrest him right now!”

“Don’t be rash,” Vader said and beckoned with his hands. “His Excellency Carter said that he wanted the target arrested alive together with the goods. We shall split three ways and act.” His instructions were in accordance with the previous operation to surround Rat. “Firehead, you’ll mobilize immediately and go to the old city wall area first. There’s only one route for him to enter the inner city.”

“Yes.”

“I’ll follow the target. This requires a lot of skills, and thus I’m the most suitable for this role.” He licked his lips in anticipation. “Lastly, Whistle, you shall stalk me from about a 100 steps back. Remember not to make eye contact with Gold.”

“Understood.”

“Then, let’s begin!”

Although the three policemen were similar in rank, they acted in full compliance with Vader’s plan.

Vader carried a broom and calmly walked a couple of steps in front of Gold. According to his experience, following the target from behind would easily

arouse the target's suspicions. Instead, by "leading the way", the target would be much less cautious. If he was fairly certain of where the target was heading, this would be the safest method of tracking. He fully concentrated on Gold—he was confident that the instant that he heard a slight change in the target's footsteps, he could trip the target and prevent him from fleeing.

After passing through the old city wall, Gold stopped walking and rested by the corner of a street. He was ostensibly aware that if he headed towards the center of the town, there would be a high chance of encountering policemen. Vader took a dozen more steps forward and turned into a side path, where he waited for the buyer to show up.

A short while later, a local who was pushing a handcart appeared. He looked around the vicinity before he slowly walked up to the serf. After inspecting the contents of the sack, he took out a handful of coins to close the deal. At that very moment, Vader gestured for the two policewomen to act.

The three of them dashed towards the target from different directions. The dealer was so dumbstruck that he did not move at all.

Vader pressed the serf down on the ground, accompanied by the clinking sound of coins scattering all over. He yelled, "You're arrested!"

Chapter 440

Chapter 440: The Court Trial

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

Roland was studying the power grid layout of a residential district when he heard the news. After Carter had concluded his report, Roland put down his quill pen and sighed lightly. Although he knew that something like this was inevitable, he felt helpless and sad that it truly happened. He had repeatedly publicized the strict ban on private sales of food, yet there were people who still took the risk for the sake of a small profit. As this was the first case of its kind, it was clear to him that a heavy sentence should be issued to deter others.

In addition, he felt the urge to finalize the laws, and then to recruit specialized legal officers to conduct interrogations and handle cases. After all, when the city was fully constructed, criminal cases would only increase, and he would not have time to play judge to all of them.

It was decided that the trial would be conducted in the castle hall.

Roland had requested for Barov to come to the castle, and together, they would hear the case of this food smuggling crime.

In the hall, the two suspects knelt on the floor. Their ghost pale faces and vacant eyes suggested that they were new to this sort of occasion.

Roland took his seat on the throne, cleared his throat, and said, “Explain everything that you did. You’ll be doubly guilty if you hold back or lie about anything.”

“Yes, yes, Your Highness.” The two suspects seemed as if they had just awoken from a dream. They scrambled between themselves to tell their personal accounts of what happened, particularly the serf, who shouted at the top of his voice, “Your Highness, Lord! I know that what I did was wrong,

but if I didn't sell the wheat… I wouldn't be able to live on! Those officials didn't buy wheat according to your demand. I'd no choice but to do this!"

The case turned out to be very simple, and Roland cleared his emotions halfway through listening.

In order to reassure the citizens, the City Hall had set the individual quota for purchasing grains to be slightly higher than the actual consumption. Therefore, there would be a small excess of wheat every month. Parker, who resided in the Sixth Residential Area, smelled a business opportunity. He would grind the excess wheat into flour and add in a few of his self-grown herbs to make savory pancakes. It sold well—fortunately, the sale restrictions in the Convenience Market only applied to staples, while poultry and eggs could be freely sold in the stalls.

The business brought in some silver royals for him every month. However, there was only so much excess wheat, and hence, he had to reduce his own consumption in order to expand the scale of the business. Parker thus set his sights on serfs who did not sell all of their food to the City Hall, and soon got in touch with "Gold" to establish this trafficking deal.

However, the serf's final words puzzled Roland. "Why didn't the officials purchase wheat according to the rules? Does this affair involve the City Hall?"

Roland looked at Barov. The latter faced him back and said softly, "The Ministry of Agriculture is in charge of purchasing. The minister is Sirius Daly, whom I believe is unlikely to have made such a grave mistake. You can call him in for questioning."

Roland nodded and had his guards summon the Minister of Agriculture to the castle.

Sirius Daly rushed to the castle hall, and after making a very impressive Knight's bow towards Roland, he enquired if His Highness had any decree for him. His mannerisms retained the style of the Wolf Family's knights.

The prince delineated the parts of the case which he did not understand. “Did you ever refuse to purchase the serf’s grains?”

“Your Highness, this was what happened,” Sirius answered without hesitation. “As per your demands, we didn’t stop the purchases after the bumper harvest. However, we lowered the purchase price according to the diminishing quality of the wheat. In the first two months, there was little difference between our purchase price and the original price.”

Sirius paused before he continued, “After winter arrived, because the majority of serfs didn’t have proper storage places for the wheat and they were relocated from the shacks to the temporary housing areas, the quality of the wheat deteriorated substantially. When we do the purchases, we would often find wet, discolored and moldy food, and therefore our purchase prices reduced by 20 to 30 percent. The food of this particular serf was largely wet, moldy, and couldn’t be stored any longer. Therefore, the price that I offered was five times less than during the bumper harvest.”

“Your Highness, that’s as good as not buying!” The serf shouted. “I spent my entire year working on the farm. This price was even lower than what I would get on Black Street! Didn’t you say that the prices wouldn’t change?!”

“But you have to sell it on time, idiot!” Barov snapped angrily. “Do you think that nobody knows why you hoarded wheat? Had there been a food supply problem in town, you would have sold your stock at three to four times the usual price!”

Everything about the case became clear. However, the result slightly surprised Roland. He had thought of it as a simple issue of food trafficking, but instead discovered a case of black-hearted food selling. Parker was obviously aware that this batch of grains was of extremely poor quality, and yet he was fine with buying it at half the price on multiple occasions. He probably did not care whether the moldy wheat was actually edible.

While there was no doubt that the serf had committed a grave crime and should be punished heavily, Roland was uncertain about how to punish Parker. He had heard Scroll’s stories about the life of the poor. When they had no food to eat, they would satiate their hunger with branches, grass and

leaves, let alone moldy bread. This was precisely why Scroll had repeatedly emphasized what a noble and great thing it was for all citizens to be able to eat wheat. Parker used to be poor too, and he was probably not aware that it was a severe crime to use low-quality ingredients to make pancakes.

After discussing the issue with Barov for a while, Roland finally passed his judgment.

He stood up, looked over the entire audience, and then said solemnly, “I pronounce… the two men guilty! The serf disobeyed the ban and trafficked grain. He knowingly violated the law and hence is doubly guilty. I shall sentence him to ten years of labor in the mines. If his performance and behavior are good, the number of years may be reduced.”

“Resident Parker also violated the ban, and furthermore used low-quality wheat to make pancakes which he sold to other citizens. For these two crimes, I shall sentence him to ten years of labor, and a fine equivalent to three times of his earnings from the sale of pancakes. My judgments shall be enforced immediately!”

The two convicts turned feeble and fell on the ground as if paralyzed. The guards standing on one side walked up to them and dragged them out of the hall.

The prince then instructed Sirius. “Write this matter into a bulletin and then hand it to Barov for review and publication. I want to let all citizens know the entire sequence of events, and make sure that this never happens again.”

“Yes, Your Highness!”

After the trial ended, Roland summoned Chief Knight to his office. “Did you hear that the person who arrested the criminal was Vader again?”

Carter nodded. “However, they overdid it this time. They took off their uniforms while arresting the criminal, and in the process, they were also reported for getting into a fight with commoners. I’ll warn him about this.”

“Don’t do that. In fact, you should commend him,” Roland said, stroking his chin. “Isn’t it expected of a plainclothes policeman to adapt to the situation and to understand how to apprehend a criminal? Vader was formerly a patrol team member, and also understands the Black Street Forces well—he’s, quite simply, a natural born talent for inspection work.

When the time’s right, I shall recruit him into the Security Bureau.” Roland quietly thought. “Nightingale’s lacking some manpower after all.”

Chapter 441

Chapter 441: Storm Clouds

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

It was a secret room of the Tower of Babel in the Hermes Cathedral.

Tayfun stared at the witch across him and couldn't help but sigh.

"Is His Holiness Mayne really so busy?"

"Of course he is." The witch stroked her golden curls. "Otherwise, he wouldn't have sent me to meet you. Let me introduce myself. My name is Isabella, and I'm a Pure Witch of the Supreme Pontiff."

"Your Excellency Tayfun, this…" The other two newly appointed Bishops, Soli Daal of the Judgement Army and El of the Tribunal stared at each other. Although they knew about the church's secret witches, they never expected them to be allowed to participate in such important meetings.

"She's a direct subordinate of the Pope with the same rank as a Bishop—she just doesn't have an official position in the church," explained Tayfun with a sigh. "Bishops can also have their own Pure Witches, so when the Months of the Demons are over, you two can choose a few witches to raise."

"I… I see." Soli widened his eyes. "So… so what kind of powers do they have?"

"This is highly confidential, and only the Supreme Pontiff knows about it."

"Why would we want to raise witches?" El seemed quite annoyed. "If the believers find out, the church's reputation will be terribly damaged!"

"Of course, they can help you take care of shady business." Isabella raised her eyebrows. "Also, they can sleep with you, let you vent your anger, or do

many other things… you should know that witches are completely different from regular women."

"Absurd!"

"Ahem, that's enough." Tayfun coughed. "Your Excellency El, I already said that the Pope's Pure Witches are of equal rank as bishops and should be seen as his representatives, so you should show them some respect. And Lady Isabella, please refrain from making these jokes. They aren't as old and near death as me, and might get very angry at what you said."

"As you wish, Your Excellency," Isabella said with a smile.

"Hmph." El uttered a nasal sound and ignored the witch.

"Then let's get to business," Tayfun said, stroking his beard. "Do you have anything to report?"

"I don't understand why His Holiness Mayne is suddenly asking all of the local church groups to send their captured witches to the Holy City. Even if it's to create God's Punishment Army, it's still a high price to pay." El took the lead and said. Her tone sounded harsh probably because of her anger towards the Pure Witch. "Ever since the order was passed, we've captured three witches. While they were being sent over, one broke out of her cage and killed the accompanying guards, and we have yet to find her."

"Wasn't she restrained by a 'metal leash'?" asked Soli.

"Not all churches are equipped with the most advanced God's Locket of Retribution," said El annoyedly. "We lost 16 believers to this witch, including four who were supposed to become Judgement Warriors. If something like this happens again, people might be too afraid to capture witches."

"But we all know that combat witches are a minority, and most of the Fallen aren't capable of fighting back, so this kind of issue is very rare," said Isabella nonchalantly. "Also, every time you bring back a wild witch, the

church can gain two new God's Punishment Warriors, so I shouldn't have to explain to you which is more important."

"I agree with Lady Isabella," Soli said, nodding his head. "With the stress on Hermes' line of defense increasing every day, we desperately need more God's Punishment Warriors to fight the demonic beasts. One God's Punishment Warrior has the fighting ability of three or four Judgement Warriors, and even more Warriors-in-training."

"Since the Supreme Pontiff has made his decision, we should just carry it out to the best of our ability." Tayfun turned to Soli Daal and asked, "What's the situation at our line of defense?"

"Very difficult. Regular demonic hybrids are easy to deal with, but every time a Fearful Beast of Hell appears, a God's Punishment Warrior gets injured or killed." Soli shook his head. "Burying snow powder and detonating it is a good idea, but we can't guarantee that they walk over the snow powder every time."

"His Holiness has also considered this," said Isabella frankly, "and he plans to use the 'Siege Beast' ahead of time."

"What's that?"

"A siege weapon controlled by Pure Witches with a range, accuracy, and power that far exceed those of the mangonel, and the key to conquering the Kingdom of Wolfheart," explained the Pure Witch. "The 'Siege Beast' was originally used to fight demons and giant demonic beasts, so since the Fearful Beasts of Hell showed up early, we should start using it."

"Why didn't we use it from the beginning?" Soli asked confusedly.

"Because of the potential damage." Isabella shrugged. "We can't build new ones and can only repair parts of it."

"So where did it come from?" El asked with a frown.

"This is top secret, so you don't have the clearance to know."

“You…”

As the secret room fell quiet, Tayfun broke the silence by clapping his hands and saying, “Alright, since you all brought bad news, I shall share a piece of good news. Besides a few cities in the Kingdom of Wolfheart that are still resisting, all the other nobles have pledged their allegiance to us, just like the weaklings in the Kingdom of Everwinter did. There’ll be more believers joining the church, and by next summer, the Holy City’s resources and Judgement Army will double in size. Also, the Kingdom of Dawn caused an uprising because of its hostility against believers, and our people are secretly helping them fight the noble, which might last until the end of the Months of the Demons.”

“Finally, some good news.” El sighed. “I thought the church was done for.”

“What kind of nonsense are you talking about?” Soli glared at her. “Aren’t we progressing exactly according to our plan?”

“Good job.” Isabella nodded approvingly and glanced at the three bishops. “Since you’re all done talking, I’ll share the Supreme Pontiff’s new order.”

The three archbishops all immediately looked at the Pure Witch.

“His Holiness orders that we adjust next year’s attacks by targeting the Kingdom of Graycastle first and the Kingdom of Dawn last.”

“What?” Soli Daal was stunned. “But all of our strategies were made in accordance with the Kingdom of Dawn, including our resources and reinforcements, so if we change our plan now, we’ll have to delay our date of the attack.”

“Wasn’t this plan already in place when Pope O’Brien was in power? Why are we changing it now?” El asked curiously. “Both kingdoms will fall eventually, so why does the order of attacks matter?”

Tayfun was silent. When His Holiness Mayne ordered him to send Pure Witches to the Kingdom of Graycastle to plot the Western Region, he had

already predicted this change. “His Holiness wasn’t interested in King’s City, but in the border area of the Kingdom of Graycastle.”

After the two men stopped bickering, Tayfun said quietly, “I’ve nothing against the order itself, but there’s a lot at stake, and I want to see His Holiness Mayne before we carry it out. Can you pass the message for me?”

“No need for such trouble.” Isabella smiled. “It just so happens that His Holiness wants to see you too.”

Chapter 442

Chapter 442: The Approval of God

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

As he walked down the stairs to the bottom of the church, Tayfun felt an inexplicable chill.

In the eerily quiet church basement was the core secret of the church—the Hermes' underground castle.

It was the first time for him to come to this place.

"His Holiness Mayne really wanted to meet me here?" According to the convention, only the archbishop who was in line as the Pope was allowed into the Secret Area, but he was too old to be Mayne's successor.

"You've served the church for so many years and have worked together with His Holiness, so he trusts you deeply," Isabella said with a smile. "Also, past rules don't apply to war-times like these, and God's will shouldn't be hidden underground but used to guide the lost believers and lead us to face our final challenge."

"Is this… His Holiness's idea?"

"That's right," she said gently.

When they entered the Secret Area, they were greeted by two Judgement Warriors. "Milord Bishop, His Holiness is currently testing Magic Stones, so if you are carrying a God's Stone of Retaliation, please give it to me for now—it might affect the stones' magic power."

Tayfun nodded and handed a string of stones to the Judgement Warrior.

"His Holiness is right here, please follow me."

Isabella turned into a long passageway and pushed open the metal door at the end. Following the screech of the hinges, Tayfun saw another masked Pure Witch. She blocked the doorway like a ghost, her white skin peeking through the black silk covering her body, and she wore nothing else besides this chiffon. The most striking thing about the witch was her dull gray eyes that were different from those of ordinary people. They seemed to have whirlpools inside them that sucked him in if he looked for too long.

Tayfun subconsciously lowered his head.

It was only then that he noticed that she was barefoot and her toes were covered with flecks of red.

The archbishop recalled Isabella's sentence that "witches are completely different from regular women."

Damn it; are all these witches demon spirits?

Those delicate feet soon moved out of the way, and Tayfun heard Isabella's voice. "Milord?"

"Ahem." Tayfun broke out of his thoughts and walked into the room.

The room was not big, and even though the rosin torches on the walls were burning brightly, they didn't give off their usual sweet smell.

Four Pure Witches sat around a stone table and were fiddling with a clear stone, while the incumbent Pope, His Holiness Mayne, stood by the table.

Tayfun was about to kneel in respect, when Mayne grasped his arm and stopped him.

"There aren't any outsiders here, so there's no use for all this red tape." He smiled. "We go way back, Milord Tayfun."

In two months, Mayne's forehead had become much more wrinkled, and he had grown a few more strands of silver hair, but his humble tone was still the same.

“You can’t do this…” Tayfun’s heart suddenly felt warm. “Even if there aren’t other believers here, I still have to follow the church’s rules.”

“And I make the rules.” The Pope smiled nonchalantly. “Anyway… are things alright above ground? I originally wanted Isabella to bring me the news, but since you’re here, you can report directly to me.”

“Yes, Your Holiness.” Tayfun nodded. After he shared the recent state of the church, he mentioned the order that Isabella had brought up earlier. “All of the resources we prepared up until now are specific to the Kingdom of Dawn, so adjusting our target will take a lot of effort. Why do you suddenly want to attack the Kingdom of Graycastle first?”

“That’s also why I called you here.” Mayne sighed. “The Kingdom of Graycastle is starting to show signs of decline because the Royal Decree on the Selection of Crown Prince and Pill of Madness are achieving their expected results. Meanwhile, the Kingdom of Dawn is in even more chaos, so both of them will eventually fall, and it doesn’t really matter whom we attack first.”

“I agree, but… Graycastle is still a formidable enemy.”

“I have two reasons for changing our plan of attack,” said the Pope slowly, clasping his hands behind his back. “The first is basically the reason why you’re worried: The Kingdom of Graycastle is vast and rich in resources, which means it’s a high-risk, high-return opponent. If we can make it a territory of the church earlier, our benefits will be much greater than if we conquer the Kingdom of Dawn. If I had ten more years, I would definitely act according to Lord O’Brien’s plan, but we don’t have enough time. The appearance of the Fearful Beast of Hell means that the Bloody Moon may appear even earlier than predicted in the Holy Book. In times like these, a little risk and more sacrifices will be worth it.”

Tayfun nodded slightly, thinking, “This is a good reason, but the problem is… it doesn’t seem Mayne will do it in this way.”He continued, “And the second reason is…”

“Roland Wimbledon of the Western Region,” the Pope said decisively.

“You mean… Prince Roland of the Kingdom of Graycastle?” Tayfun was shocked.

“By combining the past year’s reports, I’ve discovered something incredible.” Mayne patted the bishop’s shoulder. “Both the church and the Kingdom of Graycastle failed in all their attacks against him. The first failure can be traced back to the one when Duke of the Western Region attacked him, and what did Roland have at the time? Nothing but a run-down small town. Outsiders think that he defeated the Duke’s knightage by succumbing to the demons, but we all know that besides Extraordinaries, a few witches have nothing against knights equipped with God’s Stones of Retaliation.”

“Also, the reports have only become more and more confusing, such as the secret letter sent to the Holy City two months ago, which stated that King Timothy once sent 2,000 crazed soldiers to attack the Western Region and was immediately defeated. What does this mean?”

Tayfun couldn’t help but gasp. “2,000 crazed soldiers! Even in Hermes, this is a considerable force.”

“If these messages are read separately, they might seem normal, but when combined, they’re very shocking—Roland Wimbledon has never lost a single battle!” the Pope said quietly. “Also, our reports show that his power is growing at a concerning pace, and he seems to be preparing for expansion. If we delay for another year, the entire Kingdom of Graycastle may fall into his hands, so it’ll be even more costly to try to defeat him.” He paused and turned to Tayfun. “There are a lot of matters to be dealt with in the Secret Area, and I have no time for the operation and expansion of the upper levels of the church, so I can only entrust them to you.”

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After the Archbishop left, the appearance of the room suddenly changed.

The torches on the wall, the Pure Witch who was studying the magic stones, and the stone table disappeared. The figure of the Pope also gradually faded, leaving only Isabella, Zero, and the woman in black.

“If you hadn’t mentioned it, I wouldn’t have known that Prince Roland of Kingdom of Graycastle was so interesting,” said Isabella. “Why do I get the feeling that he, rather than the church, is more likely to defeat the demons?”

“What does that mean?” asked the woman in black, frowning. “Do you want to betray the church?”

“Betray? Don’t phrase it like that.” Isabella shrugged. “Isn’t the purpose of the church to ensure that human beings survive the Battle of Divine Will? If someone else can do this, I don’t care who I serve.”

“You…!”

“Stop fighting,” said Zero. “Isabella isn’t wrong. In the so-called Battle of Divine Will, only the final winner can be protected by God.” She looked expressionlessly at the two witches. “As for who will receive the approval of God—the Union or a prince of the Kingdom of Graycastle, I think this war will give us the answer.”

Chapter 443

Chapter 443: The Conspiracy

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

Somewhere to the north of Longsong Stronghold, the Western Region of Kingdom of Graycastle

Sir Eltek was sitting by the fireplace contemplating.

They had not heard anything from Miso Eltek since he had left the night before. It was morning now, and he had yet to return.

Sir Eltek felt a deep sense of unease.

Recently, Miso had been very close with the majorfamilies in the Western Region. As the prince's agent in Stronghold, the Honeysuckle Familyhad announced His Highness' intention to integrate the Western Region. All territories would adopt one law and the enfeoffment rights of the nobles would be taken back, which meant they could not expand their subordinate nobles or recruit knights to fight for them.

As for lower nobles like the Elteks, they felt little influence and enjoyed many benefits. As the rumor went, anyone who was loyal to His Highness would be rewarded his favor. Right now, the less influential nobles were the safest people because they would determine the success or failure of His Highness' reform plan.

Consequently, the smartest thing to do was wait and see.

However, Miso Eltek hadn't shared that philosophy.

"My lord, the attendants looking for the second master have returned." said the steward, pushing open the door to the knight's study.

“Have they found him?”

“No,” the steward shook his head. “They’ve searched the taverns, casinos, theaters and brothels and still can’t find him.”

Eltek was increasingly anxious. He had dispatched two companies of scouts to search for Miso. The first one went to the homes of lower nobility nearby. Most of these nobles were vassals in the employ of Duke Ryan and retained a status comparable to the Duke’s family. Miso often went to these places for parties or dinners.

The second group went to the entertainment venues, popular spots for young nobles.

Seeing both parties return empty-handed, the knight’s sense of dread intensified.

He stepped to the window, looking toward the eastern territory. The territory of the Elk Family lay in that direction. It was the largest earl domain in the Western Region. Since the collapse of Duke Ryan, Petrov from the Honeysuckle Family had completely swung to Prince Roland and the Elk Family had edged ahead to become the leading power against the prince.

Hell, had Miso gone there…

“My lord, the second master has returned!” Suddenly an attendant ran into the study, breathless. “He’s changing clothes in the hall, and it seems he is getting ready to go out.”

“What!” The knight immediately grasped his crutch and rushed downstairs, disregarding the steward’s pleas for restraint.

The moment Eltek stepped into the hall, he felt his anger rise to a new level. He saw Miso replace his thick coat with a thin and soft leather. The shiny armor of a knight was in front of him and two squires were doing their final preparation work.

“Where did you go yesterday?!” The old knight couldn’t help shouting. “What are you up to now?”

“Father, our chance is coming,” Miso said excitedly, “A chance to be baron. Maybe even viscount!”

Eltek felt his blood pressure increasing. “Who told you this?”

“Jacques Medde, he brought the king’s confidential order!”

Eltek took two steps back, his heart sinking. Jacques Medde was the eldest son of the Elk Family. Never mind the involvement with Timothy. Everyone knew that Timothy wanted to eradicate Roland Wimbledon.

His worst nightmare had occurred and now it was even more serious than he had anticipated.

“What did you hear?”

“Lord Medde summoned the nobility of the Western Region into his castle and opened his Majesty’s holograph. It said that if someone conquers Longsong Stronghold, the king will promote his title and expand his domain!” It seemed that Miso was still immersed in the grand scene. “Lady Miller from the Wild Rose Family, Lord Cavan from the Maple Family and Lord Remy Noah from the Wolf Family all pressed their fingerprints and pledged an oath of allegiance, without hesitation. The rest of the nobles and knights are determined to follow the four families and remove the Honeysuckle Family.”

It was ridiculous. How could the four families make such a decision based on a piece of paper? The knight lamented inwardly. Had you forgotten how they had treated King Wimbledon III when Duke Ryan was guarding the Western Region? When had they become so loyal?

The only answer was that this was a complete fraud to convince the lower nobles to become pioneers in the movement. The plan would commence in a few months and the four families might agree on the benefits after finding success.

Eltek opened his mouth but didn't share his thoughts. This was Miso Eltek, not his eldest son Ferlin, and such dissuasion wouldn't convince him.

"Where are you going in this armor?" the old knight asked after short silence.

"To win honor and status." Miso wore a cuirass made of stainless steel. "Morning Light, the top knight in the Western Region, only won honor for himself. While I fight for my whole family. Father, when this is finished, you'll know that I'm as worthy of respect as my brother."

"If Timothy vanquishes Prince Roland, your words may come to pass. However, the army of the new king is still far away while Prince Roland's army is very near," the old knight thought.

"Don't you remember how Duke Ryan collapsed?" Eltek said in a low voice.

"Things are different this time. The king has shipped a number of snow powder weapons, the same ones used by Prince Roland. He'll provide better ones to Medde. Without the possession of superior weapons, can Roland seize Longsong Stronghold again?" Miso clipped his sword to his waist and nodded to his father. "The battle is coming soon. Please wait here for good news."

Looking at his back, Eltek threw his crutch to the ground.

"My lord, why didn't you stop him?" the steward came up to hold the trembling Knight.

"It would be easy to stop him, but the family would suffer a great calamity," he nodded slowly. A noble attending the 'rebellion' meeting hadn't shown up at the agreed place. What did this mean for the four families? The crime of escape or defection could lead the whole Eltek Family to death.

"Look on the bright side, if the four families win," the steward comforted. "After all, the months of the demons are long and it'll take two or even three months for the snow to melt. When the army of Prince Roland arrives, the king's army may have already besieged the Western Region."

If it were the past, he would view it in the same way. However, after having visited Border Town once, the knight had a totally different view of Prince Roland. Not to mention his eldest son Ferlin Eltek and his family's benefactor Lady Agatha were all living in Border Town.

He turned to his steward and told him in a stern voice, "Go to Border Town immediately and deliver this news to His Highness. If the city gate has closed, go to the docks in the outskirts and find some ferrymen or fishermen. It doesn't matter how you do it, just do it quickly!"

Chapter 444

Chapter 444: The Intelligence

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

Before the housekeeper left the Eltek territory, Roland received a letter from the Second Army of Stronghold delivered by a bird.

An hour later, Petrov's call for help also reached the town's castle.

Since the carrier pigeon could only carry limited information, Roland had to combine the two messages and discovered a piece of astonishing news.

The four families of the Western Region had rebelled!

"Who on earth gave them the confidence to plot treason under my nose?"

Roland immediately summoned Carter and Iron Axe and showed them the notes.

"Your Highness, is this…"

"A message from Stronghold," Roland said angrily. The winter was drawing to an end, and the new year was in three days. Not only were there various matters concerning the city construction, but also the installation of the equipment for the Three Supplies Project required his instruction. "Those nobles chose to trouble me at the wrong time; they must be looking forward to dying!"

According to the secret letter, the inner city nobles led a bunch of squires to attack the city guards. By the time the sentries on the city wall realized something was wrong, the switch for the northern drawbridge had fallen into the control of the enemies. The sentries could do nothing but light the beacon fire and rely on the city wall to hold their positions.

When the other members of the Second Army saw the beacon signal, they followed the emergency response protocol by dividing the camp's ten teams of about 50 soldiers in total into two platoons. One platoon charged toward the north gate, while the other went to the Stronghold castle. Petrov's secret letter was sent after the second platoon confronted the enemies at the castle and realized they were fighting the local nobilities.

"Petrov Hull mentioned that the attackers sieging the castle were carrying the four families' banners, which means this rebellion was planned," Carter frowned after reading the notes. "Since the four families are acting together, there must be a leader among them."

Indeed, the four families, or five families including those under Duke Ryan, were great nobles on equal footing. If they were to set aside their prejudices and cooperate, it was most likely because a bigger force was behind them. Otherwise, with the Earls looking down upon each other, it would take over a decade for them to decide on a leader.

At the moment, there were only one or two people who would be interested in meddling with the Western Region.

"Do you mean… Timothy in the King's City?" Iron Axe looked at the Chief Knight. As a member of the Ironsand people of the Mojin Clan, he was far less sensitive to the political situation of the Kingdom of Graycastle than Carter was.

"I wouldn't be surprised if it's the church," Roland twitched his mouth and said. "Judging from their actions at Fallen Dragon Ridge, it's only a matter of time before they attack the Western Region."

"The problem is, in the second letter, Petrov mentioned the enemies might have firearms." Carter frowned. "Does it mean they have learned the formula for gunpowder?"

"Snow powder isn't unknown to the church and Timothy, but they have a long way to go before they can use it smoothly." The prince knocked on the table lightly. "What puzzles me is that with Border Town as the nearest town to Stronghold, the help they get must be from somewhere further. So even with

the support of an unknown force, how did they gain enough confidence to confront the First Army?"

"Probably because we're in the Months of the Demons," Iron Axe replied after contemplating for a while. "Although last time Your Highness defeated the Duke's knights using thunder power, our troops didn't show extraordinary skills in battle. Now with the snow blocking the roads and demonic beasts attacking the borders, it seems like perfect timing for a successful rebellion, and it'll be at least two months before you have the resources to attack Longsong Stronghold."

"And I'll be hindered by the lofty city walls and powerful flintlocks?"

"Yes," Iron Axe couldn't help but grin. "They have all the weapons that you have, plus the insurmountable city wall and reinforcement of an unknown force, so they have a very good chance of beating you at the foot of the city wall. That's probably what they thought."

"Yet they're fully unaware of the power of Border Town." Roland stood up. "Iron Axe!"

"At your command, Your Highness!" Iron Axe instantly stood at attention.

"The First Army must immediately prepare for an expedition. We'll set off tomorrow morning," Roland said decisively. "Choose 500 soldiers. Carry six field artilleries. You are in charge of making the specific arrangements."

"Yes, Sir!" Iron Axe saluted.

The scale of the First Army had quadrupled its original 500 soldiers to 2,200. Revolving rifles were upgraded, and their firepower was drastically increased. Besides, the efficiency of the First Army's executing instructions was greatly enhanced due to the improvement of the soldiers' educational level. Upon command, personnel would deploy ammunition and rations based on the number of soldiers on the operation and the number of days. The logistics work for 500 people could be done in almost one day. Compared with the knights or the mercenaries, who needed weeks to prepare, Roland's army was functioning at an incredible speed.

The army headed towards the inner city of Stronghold on 11 paddle steamers. After entering mass production, the production of a boat with a reinforced concrete hull took only five days, which was even a deliberately lowered speed, because its number was limited by the available crew and steam engines.

“Carter!”

“At your command, Your Highness,” the Chief Knight said and raised his head high.

“You stay in Border Town.”

The corners of the knight’s mouth instantly fell down. “Wha-what? No. Your Highness. How could you leave me behind again?”

“We’re still in the Months of the Demons. Demonic beasts pose a greater threat than the nobility,” Roland said unwaveringly. “Guard the town well.”

After the two of them retreated, Roland sighed. “This time the witches need to go with me.”

“I’ll follow you, no matter where you go,” Nightingale said with a smile.

Considering their opponent could be the church, Roland knew that only the witches could effectively counter the Pure Witches’ attacks without God’s Stones of Retaliation. After debating his options, Roland decided on the witches who would accompany him: Lightning, Maggie, Sylvie, Nana, Lily, and Nightingale. “If I add the three combat witches from Sleeping Island to the list, it’ll be very hard for the Pure Witches to defeat us.”

Roland stood at the window and looked at the snowy mountains and plains.

“If I view the Impassable Mountain Range as the city wall of Stronghold, then the Barbarian Land in the north is also the domain of the four families, a territory beyond the reach of my power. Elk, Wild Rose, Maple Leaf, and Wolf families… have operated separately on their own lands for over a decade, forming their unique laws and customs, so even Ryan, the overlord

of the Western Region, seldom interfered with their businesses," mused Roland. The prince had intended to slowly divide and annex these aristocratic territories after building the new city, but the rebellion gave him an early opportunity—one to swallow the vast land and population of Stronghold in one gulp.

He didn't intend to let go of the nobles this time.

Chapter 445

Chapter 445: Attacks

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

Cacusim arrived at the dock as the first rays of sunlight started to peep through the clouds.

Unlike the usual, the dock was packed with silent soldiers. They stood erect, with their sacks and long-barrelled guns on their backs, looking like a thick forest in a storm. Although the dock was crowded, everyone was moving in an organized manner. Watching the soldiers board the paddle steamer one by one, Cacusim was filled with an indescribable sense of power and strength.

He swallowed hard while thinking,

These are the soldiers trained by His Highness.

“How incredible!” The old man had traveled from Seawindshire to the Port of Clearwater as a youth. This distance was over half the Kingdom of Graycastle, and he had also led the commercial fleet to the Fjords and nearby islands. So, he had personally witnessed the arrogant demeanor of the armored knights, as well as the fierce demeanor of the barbarians who killed beasts bare-handed. To him, these soldiers were undeniable fighters that could exercise extreme power. However, he had not expected to feel that power once again, but while standing with the group of ordinary people he could feel it and it was stronger than ever.

“No doubt these are just ordinary people…” He thought. It had been about four months since Cacusim arrived at Border Town, and each day he understood the town a little better. He knew that the First Army consisted mostly of locals and that many of them were miners, hunters, furnace labors, and masons before they joined the army. Because of this, they had never received any professional combat training.

Nevertheless, in just a few months, these people had become as brave and disciplined as any knight. “What magic did his Highness use on them?”

“Are you… really going?” Cacusim heard Wade whisper from behind him. He could tell from his lowered voice, that he too was silenced by the presence of the army.

“Why did I apply for the captain position if I wasn’t going?” Cacusim answered while taking a deep breath.

“But they are off to fight.” Wade continued.

“They all offer their services to His Highness.” The old man corrected. Without turning his head he added, “And so do I.”

Following the momentary silence, Wade then implored, “Stay alive.”

Cacusim waved in response.

…

Cacusim boarded the sixth paddle steamer as it arrived with the swirling snow. According to the tradition, a captain can name their own ship, and even though this boat belonged to His Highness, he was still allowed to decide its name.

Yet, he still had not made up his mind.

This was the second time he had assumed the position of captain since his retirement ten years ago. So, he wished to come up with a name dedicated to his memory.

“Captain, there you are!” As soon as Cacusim stepped into the cabin at the helm, the first mate came up to greet him. “We are now preheating the boiler, and I promise it will soon be ready to go”

The young man was called Pike and he was from the Southern Territory. He had a few years experience fishing on the sea. If he was a part of another

fleet, he wouldn't even pass as a sailor but on this boat, everyone was a newbie.

"Everyone's here?"

"All are on board. You were the last one," Pike replied with a wink.

"If you don't know how to respect your captain, I'll be happy to teach you through a full day of deck cleaning."

"Yes, captain." The young man shouted, erecting himself immediately, "Of course I do!"

"That's better," Cacusim commented. While stroking his beard he gave Pike orders. "Tell the boiler house to stoke up the fire, but not to shut the damn steam valve. I don't want to rear-end the boat in front of us!"

"Yes, gotcha." Without finishing the sentence, Pike had slipped back into his previous playful manner. He quickly winked at the old man and dashed out of the cabin.

"That rascal," Cacusim mumbled while shaking his head smiling. He was more at ease after the interaction, as if he had slipped back to the good days of when he roamed the sea. The old man went back to the wheel, where he gently stroked its wooden handle. Slowly he began to remember the operating procedures for a paddle steamer.

The stone boat invented by His Highness was very different from the sailboat. It didn't have a mast or a cabin below deck, instead, it had two chambers. The first chamber is located at the helm and is called the wheelhouse. This room has two large windows from which the captain can see the route and navigate clearly. The second chamber is found in the middle and it contains the boiler that powers the boat.

Behind the wheelhouse, there was a bare deck and this space was often filled by miners during training. During this time of training, they would often travel west along the Redwater River to drop the miners off at the edge of the Misty Forest, where they could find coal. Coal lasted longer than wood and

was the preferred fuel for Seawindshire. Now, there was a makeshift shed constructed from cloth, apparently set up in preparation for the boarded soldiers.

Although Cacusim was not familiar with the stone boat, he soon realized it was not hard to operate and even simpler than a sailboat in many ways. First of all, this boat didn't require wind and sails for direction and power. Overall it took less man power to run. Furthermore, It would not be hard to teach a villager how to run a stove, whereas it would take at least six months for them to master sailing. The stone boat could run by itself for a long time as long as the engine was on and the steam valve was shut.

Just then, the tranquility of Border Town's early morning was broken by a dull steam whistle from the front of the line.

The first boat was sailing off.

"Captain, the water in the boiler is ready!" reported Pike who scurried back to the wheel house.

"Ring the bell to tell Bigpad and Grizzly that it is time to shut the valve and speed up. It's time to move." Cacusim solemnly gave the instructions.

"Yes, sir. Advance!" Pike pulled on the long iron string attached to the wall, which would ring the bell in the boiler house and deliver the captain's command.

In response, the boat shook violently, and the wooden tires on either side started to move slowly.

Cacusim held tight to the wheel at the helm and looked straight ahead. When Vader asked him why he wanted to fight, he actually did not tell him the truth. Saying it was to serve His Highness was only a small part of the reason.

The truth was he simply enjoyed being a "captain".

It didn't matter if it was a sailboat or a paddle steamer, Cacusim truly loved the feel of the wheel in his hands as he navigated the bow through the

thrusting waves.

This is the life he really wants.

“Full sail… No, continue to shovel coal!” The old man turned to face starboard while hollering. “Hold on guys! We’re setting out!”

****

“If you ferry me to Border Town the Eltkes will pay you well. How about five… no, ten gold royals?” The steward asked while blocking the troubled boatman’s cabin door. The steward had placed his left foot in the crack of the door to prevent the boatman from closing it in his face and effectively shutting him out.

“Y… Your Excellency, I’m happy to be at your service, but I just can’t.” The boatman stammered, “L… Look, there isn’t even a shed above my boat to protect you from the snow. It wouldn’t be a problem to ferry you across the river, but to Border Town… that would take several days! “Just consider this freezing weather. Where would we sleep?” the boatman implored. “We would become frozen like popsicles in just one night on the boat, wouldn’t we?”

“Are there any other boatmen nearby who can ferry me to Border Town?” the steward persisted.

“No, not a one.” the boatman denied while waving his hand. “We only have small boats. Y… You should go to Stronghold to find a boat you can spend the night on.”

If I could have entered Longsong Stronghold, why did I come here looking for a boatman that fished and ferried for a living? the steward thought to himself as the boatman shut the door.

The steward kicked at the snow. Ever since the four families started to attack Stronghold, all the city gates had been closed. He spent a long time taking this detour and now found that all of his efforts were in vain.

It will be getting dark soon. How am I going to complete my Lord's task?

The steward sullenly looked at the Redwater River, but he was soon stunned.

Good Heavens, what's that?

He rubbed his eyes in disbelief, making sure what he was seeing was not an illusion. A huge fleet was coming down the river and the boats were unlike any he had seen before. Through the dense misty snow, the vessels roared and whistled towards him at full speed. There was not any sail on the gray boats and yet they were still proceeding against the wind, their bows cutting the water and cleaving through the waves.

On the first boat, he could see a flag flapping in the wind with the embroidered emblem of a tower and a gun. The steward held his breath in realization, "This is the fleet of Prince Roland Wimbledon!"

Chapter 446

Chapter 446: Here Comes the Giant Beast

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

Longsong Stronghold was bisected by a branch of the Redwater River; to the West laid the residential area and to the East laid vast farming lands.

Unlike the other big cities that were set in the suburbs of farmlands, the towering city wall of the Stronghold encircled both the residential area and a portion of the farmlands. It was built to defend against human beings, and not demonic beasts. However, even if the city was under siege, Stronghold would still flourish and be able to supply its people.

As such, the outer wall of Longsong Stronghold was split where the river divided the two sections of the city. Between the divide in the walls hung several massive chains which were the width of a man's arm. If an enemy decided to attack from the river, the hemp cords holding the heavy chains would be cut and send them crashing into the water to stop the enemy below.

Fortunately, the inner land of the Western Region had rarely been attacked by any fleets. So, these cables had almost never come into use, and would not this time either. Out on the water, Roland's fleet pushed through the storm. Around twilight, they were able to see the silhouette of the fortress in the distance. Strands of the beacon's fire could be seen flashing above the city, slashing through the inkiness of the ever gradually darkening sky.

"The enemies have already reached the lord's castle and there are some militias fighting with the guards at the north gate of the city wall. It looks like they can't hold up any longer." Lightning, who had carefully investigated the situation in the city, continued giving her detailed report to the prince, "There are around 200 people attacking the castle. The first round of attacks failed. The enemies have weapons similar to our flintlocks, but they look completely different."

“Is Petrov alright?” Roland inquired, showing concern. Roland currently cared most about the safety of his agent.

“He’s fine, other than being a little frightened. But… ”

“But what?”

“His family was killed,” Lightning answered, her mouth twitching. “His Excellency Petrov warned his father and asked him to get to the castle. However, his other family members were taken as hostages, including the Countess. They were being held by the four families in exchange for surrender and subsequently they were executed one by one.” The little girl paused for a moment before continuing, “I took an opportunity to fly into the castle to tell him that you would be coming soon and he had only one request.”

Roland nodded and asked, “What is it?”

“Blood for blood.”

There was an unwritten rule among nobles where people with bestowed titles were exempt from being murdered in times of battle. In the case of the family of Earl Honeysuckle, most of his loved ones had been honored with a knighthood. However, the four families had betrayed that rule. Not only did they hate the Honeysuckle Family because of the benefits of Roldan’s support but they were also being driven by a new political power.

In light of this, Roland was almost certain the power behind them was the new king, Timothy Wimbledon. He now realized there was no room for mercy and that he needed to crush them. Supporting the king and executing rebels was very different from helping the church slaughter nobles. The prince looked towards Stronghold and coldly gave the order, “Go straight into the city and take the dock!”

****

Ayt heard the sound of footsteps below the city wall.

He raised the flintlock numbly, aiming it at the dark hole below. This was the only path to climb up the city wall from within. There had been several rounds of attacks since the enemies captured the city gate, but they were still not able to seize the northern part of the city wall.

The battle started yesterday at noon and had yet to cease. He hadn't expected to be standing in the cold, brisk wind for so long. After watching his supporting comrades fall one by one into pools of blood, all he could focus on was fighting.

"Are they coming again?" Seeing a long-barrelled gun pop up next to him, Ayt tilted his head to the side and found that it was his unit leader, Bronzehill.

"I could hear them," Ayt replied feebly, "but I have no idea how many there are in the darkness."

"They don't know how many of us are left either," Bronzehill comforted him.

"So… how many are left?"

Bronzehill answered after a moment's hesitation, "Only five. Raven just took his last breath."

"And we probably won't see the sun tomorrow," Ayt said bitterly. After the initial feelings of fear and panic, he then became numb. It was this experience that helped him finally understand what his instructor had meant when he said, "Only a real battle will quickly make you a man." However, this did not make the current situation any better. Out of the three units, there were only five people left. Even if the enemies didn't make it up the wall, they would likely die from starvation or exposure to cold. "Can we still surrender?"

"Surrender?" Bronzehill snorted. "Didn't you hear what they were yelling? 'Kill the rebels!' There's nothing but death ahead. We'd better take down as many as possible while we can."

Ayt knew the unit leader was right. Many captured soldiers from the Second Army were beheaded. They were not nobles, and nobody would pay a

ransom. But… he just hated the idea of dying up here.

The instructor had told them about how happy life in Border Town was and promised that once the Months of the Demons had passed, soldiers who did well in the Second Army would be transferred to the First Army and receive free housing there. There was plenty of food in Border Town, as well as running water and a heating system that could warm up a whole room without ignition…

He wanted to survive and see the amazing things that his instructor had described.

“Here they come!” Bronzehill suddenly shouted while pulling the trigger. In the muzzle flash, Ayt could see the figure of the enemy revealed in the darkness. Six or seven people were creeping slowly up along the wall, holding up their shields. He even caught a glimpse of the terror in their eyes.

The unit leader missed his target, fortunately, he was already pointing the gun in the right direction.

He aimed at the fleeting figure and fired again.

There was the muffled sound of a bullet hitting a wooden shield, and then a shriek, followed by the sound of a heavy object rolling down the stairs. Realizing that they had been exposed, the rest of the enemies rushed to the opening recklessly.

Bronzehill was struggling to reload his gun, but his frozen hands hindered the process, slowing him greatly. Ayt jumped back from the open pit and groped frantically for his gunpowder sack. His heart sank when he found it empty and he realized that he had already used it all.

According to his training, now was the time to use the bayonets.

He pulled out the bayonet and struggled to attach the knife to the front of his gun. Clenching his teeth in frustration, he finally got it to attach and lifted it just in time as the enemy breached the hole and rushed at him.

Instantly firing, Bronzehill took the first man down, but there was a second close on his heels and this one managed to slide a sword into Bronzehill's chest.

Ayt was stunned and his training took over. He mechanically thrust his bayonet in futility, only striking the enemy's shield. The enemy easily kicked him to the ground, disarming him completely.

Am I really going to die here?

Looking up at the night sky in despair, he noticed a dark figure above him.

He normally wouldn't notice something so dark against the inky sky that night, but the shadow was close and rapidly getting closer still. It plummeted towards him like a collapsed curtain made of night.

Ayt's eyes bulged as the shadow became more defined and he realized it was a giant beast!

This was a beast only found in nightmares. Its huge crimson mouth was gaping, head larger than a bull's, and giant wings that almost covered the entire length of the city wall.

The giant beast descended right in front of Ayt, crushing the enemies who just surfaced from the opening.

"Ow… Ow…!"

It released a thunderous growl that was loud enough to wake the dead!

Chapter 447

Chapter 447: The Reaper

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

Ayt was paralyzed with fright. He helplessly stared at the beast, who now also turned to look at him. He could clearly see mucus dripping from its beige fangs.

“Relax. I’m not going to eat you.” The beast suddenly spoke in human language with a muddy voice, which almost horrified him enough to shriek.

He was astounded again when seeing a girl jump off the beast’s back. She walked towards Bronzehill, turned him over and checked him out. She said to the beast, “He’s alive. Maggie, send him to Nana.”

“Ow!” The beast seemed to understand what she said. It grabbed Bronzehill with its claws and flew up again. The flapping of its wings stirred up the air, producing strong winds, which made Ayt unable to open his eyes. When the wind and snow finally stopped, he squinted at the city wall but saw nothing at all—as if everything that had happened was just a dream.

“No, it’s not a dream… That girl is still here!” he thought.

He vaguely saw the girl’s figure in the darkness. There was apparently no light around, but her pupils were emitting weird golden lights, like stars in the night.

“You… you’re…”

“I came to help you.” The girl’s reply left him dumbfounded.

“Wh-what?” Ayt felt this was more implausible than a dream. “You’re here to help me?”

“Yes. His Highness Roland sent me here.” She squatted down, dug out a long sword from the flattened corpses and swung it, completely disregarding the fact that the sword was covered with flesh and blood.

Ayt was overcome by a feeling of sickness. He retched twice but vomited nothing except bile. Just then, outside the city wall, a battle cry resounded again. The beast had just terrified the enemiesbut now that they saw it had left, and they had no idea what had happened up there on top of the city wall, they began to stir again.

“By ‘His Highness’… you mean the prince of Border Town?” He wiped his mouth and gasped.

“Is there another Roland besides him?” the black-haired girl asked, as she started to dig another weapon from a corpse. Ayt immediately turned his head away from her.

“But it takes at least three days to get here from Border Town… How did His Highness know about the noble’s rebellion so quickly?” Ayt swallowed hard and continued, “and the beast just now…”

“It’s not a beast, but a witch that came here to save you.” Her voice turned cold. “I don’t have time to answer all your questions. Just keep quiet.”

As there was no flintlock blocking them this time, the enemies easily came up on top of the city wall. When torches lit the place up again, they were surprised to find only a girl standing in front of them.

Malicious laughter soon broke the silence.

Ayt immediately knew what they meant by the laughter.

“Stay alert. Don’t give them any chance to play any dirty tricks on us.”

“Don’t worry, my lord. We’ll take care of it, but later…”

“When I’m done, I’ll leave her to you.”

“Hey… fine with me.”

“Qui-quickly come back here to me!” Ayt struggled to stand up, but what happened next made him stare in amazement.

A silver light chopped down and the laughter died abruptly.

The leader of the enemies was chopped into two pieces by the long sword. His shield and armor could not stop it at all. In fact, he didn’t even see the girl strike.

When the two pieces of his body fell down with blood spurting out from the wounds, everyone’s smile froze on their face.

However, this was just the beginning.

The black-haired girl took one step forward and swept her sword. Before Ayt could clearly see her movements, he heard the sound of flesh scraping and bones breakings.

The three men had no time to react as they were ripped open in their stomachs.

Their intestines fell out mixed with blood and spilled all over the ground.

“You…” Ayt opened his mouth a little but didn’t know what to say.

The girl looked back at him and said, “Go find your surviving battle companions and gather on top of the wall. Someone will come to fetch you later.” With these words, she jumped directly off the city wall.

“The city wall here was thirty feet tall!” He endured all the pains in his body, fumbled to climb close to the edge of the wall and looked down. He saw the crowd down there turning into a meat grinder. The girl killed wherever she went. She freely dashed among the crowd, with her weapon moving around smoothly in her hand. She easily cut down the entire enemy who dared to stand in front of her, like the reaping of wheat.

In less than a quarter of an hour, the enemy collapsed.

They'd never seen such a fierce opponent, who was faster than a snow wolf and stronger than a grizzly bear. Facing her sword, nobody could react, dodge, or fight. The noblemen hurriedly retreated and the siege was extinguished, merely by one person.

She followed the escaping crowd all the way, leaving a trail of blood behind her. At this sight, Ayt dropped to the ground and cold sweat soaked his spine.

That's a witch?

Well. whatever… I survived!

****

The Stronghold castle was tightly besieged by the four families' armies. A dozen bonfires around the castle brightly lit the place up.

After a day and night of fighting, the second floor of the castle had already been conquered. The Honeysuckles now shrunk back to the very top of it and must be suffering from both hunger and fear up there.

Jacques Medde looked at this towering lord's castle and began to feel excited.

After his father died, he traveled all the way back to the territory from the King's City just to inherit the Earl's title, but now he had an even better chance.

Timothy mentioned in the secret letter that if he could take hold of Longsong Stronghold for the King's City, the king's army would come here when the snow melted to conquer the rebel king, Roland Wimbledon. Once the rebel king was eliminated, Timothy would probably let him govern the Western Region.

Together with the territory of Earl Honeysuckle, Jacques would have both the land and title of a duke.

Duke Medde. What a wonderful name!

This castle would also become my residence.

“My lord, the sixth platoon has come back down,” a knight came and reported, “and they said they heard a lot less flintlock sounds from the enemy. Is it time to send iron armor platoons up there?”

Jacques Medde nodded and said, “Go and arrange it.”

Iron armor platoons were specially developed to fight against flintlocks. During the fighting, three or four soldiers formed a team—two of them held shields made of wood with several layers of iron coating, which could cover them all up, and had holes for aiming and firing. In order to make more shields like this, he made the tough decision to tear down a dozen knight’s armors. Of course, those thick iron-coated shields had a weakness, too. As it was hard to carry and the whole team had to move slowly, they would easily become targets for their enemies.

“Luckily, the Honeysuckles can’t hold out any longer.” Jacques sneered silently. “They reacted unexpectedly quickly and withdrew part of their soldiers and knights back into the castle before the four families’ armies arrived, and they had just only nearly a hundred men. It’s impossible for them to fight a long, hard battle.

It’ll probably take several days before Prince Roland receives the news.

If I send Petrov’s head as a gift to Roland Wimbledon, how will he look like?

Chapter 448

Chapter 448: A Hail of Bullets

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

“My lord, the dock area in the west city seems strange,” reported a guard who was in charge of sealing off the street. “I’ve heard strange noises coming from there and sent two platoons to investigate but none of them came back.”

“What?” Jacques Medde said with a frown, “You must have misheard it.”

“No, it’s clear, like the sounds of heavy, rapid breathing. Wheeze, wheeze…” the guard said, imitating the sounds.

“Maybe it’s the snoring sounds of a tramp?”

“My lord, in this weather, anyone sleeping outside will be frozen to death,” the guard insisted, “and nobody can snore that loudly. It must be a giant almost as tall as the city wall if they’re really snoring sounds.”

The Earl stared at him for a good long while and then turned away, shouting, “Knight Dowcan!”

“My lord, what can I do for you?” a knight wearing the badge of the Maple Family on his chest responded, striding toward the Earl.

“Summon your platoon and follow my guard to investigate the dock in the city.” Jacques patted the knight’s shoulder and added, “Inform me at once if you’ve any news.”

“Eh… Could you send someone else there?” the young knight said, hesitating. “My father urged me to enter the castle together with you.”

“It won’t take you long to go to the dock, but I can assure you here it’ll take a lot longer,” the Earl said with a smile, “and if the Honeysuckle Family surrenders, I’ll wait for you here.”

“Ah… fine.”

After the knight left with his guard, Jacques’ facial expression turned stone-cold. “Keep dreaming! You think you can receive the same credit by sending a son here to enter the castle with me? His Majesty mentioned only me in the secret letter!”

Before long, he heard the distant sound of gunfire coming from the west.

Jacques was instantly on the alert. “What’s that? The eldest son of the Maple Family has no flintlock.”

When he was planning to send some of his knights there to check the situation, the guard who had reported to him earlier stumbled back into the battalion. “My, my lord… things have gone wrong!”

“What went wrong?”

“The rebel king… he came here!” The guard said with his eyes widely opened, “Thousands of enemies are heading for the castle!”

“You meant Roland Wimbledon’s army?” Jacques raised his hand and slapped the guard on the face. “Thousands of them? If you dare to talk nonsense, I’ll hang you up on the city gate!”

“My lord, they carry the flags of the Kingdom of Graycastle.” The guard did not dare to dodge. He got down on one knee and continued, “I wanted the squire of Knight Dowcan to catch one or two enemies to get further information, but the moment they charged towards them, they were, were…”

“What happened to them?” the Earl pressed.

“They were shot down by intense gunfire.” The Earl could tell from the guard’s face that he seemed to have witnessed very terrifying scenes. “At that time, it looked like numerous fires popped out all of a sudden in the darkness

and the cracking sounds never stopped. Twenty people only charged forward for less than 100 steps before they were all shot down and so did the horses!" The guard swallowed and went on, "My lord, I've never seen such an intense gunfire. If there weren't more than a thousand enemies, how could they eliminate the knight's platoon in just a blink?"

"Where is the eldest son of the Maple Family?"

"He's… run away."

The Earl sank, weak-kneed, into his chair and was completely confused. "How is it possible? The four families started to act from yesterday at noon and Prince Roland came to support Longsong Stronghold tonight. If we count the messaging time, does this mean he needs only one day to come here from his town? Even when sailing smoothly with the wind the entire time, they can't reach here that fast, let alone while carrying a thousand people. To transport that many people, he needs at least a huge fleet, but according to the intelligence, Border Town has no ship in the winter!"

How could things turn out like this?

"No, I have to be calm in such an emergency." Jacques Medde wiped the sweat from his forehead and thought that maybe the guard did talk nonsense. Without torches, he could not see clearly how many enemies were there on the dock in the darkness when he was obviously shocked by their firing flintlocks. "Flintlocks may seem powerful. However, their shooting range was merely about 40 steps and their reloading speed and hit rate were extremely low. Assuming that every enemy is equipped with this kind of weapon, they won't be unbeatable for at most two dozen soldiers who can march abreast in the street leading to the castle. If I inform the Wild Rose and the Wolf Family now and gather all the knights, mercenary fighters and guards to attack them after their first round of firing, maybe we could defeat them.

Unlike battles in fields, the poor efficiency in flintlock reloading is a fatal shortcoming in street fights.

“Damn it.” Jacques slapped on an arm of his chair and said to the head of his guards. “Go to invite Earl Wild Rose and the Viscount of the Wolf Family to come here and order all the men with flintlocks to block the entrance of the castle. Go!”

Compared with crossbowmen, it’s much faster to train flintlock soldiers. Let them block the enemies first. Their lives aren’t worth much. If necessary, knights can tread on them.

To his great surprise, the head of his guards came back and reported, “They’ve already left the battalion with their men.”

To besiege Petrov, the four families respectively held the four sides of the castle. Jacques did not expect that the other families received the news earlier than him.

Now, the sounds of gunfire were nearing the castle. As the guard had described, they were the deep rumble of dense drums, loud and clear across the growing mounds of snow.

“These bastards!” Jacques’ heart froze. He looked at the castle for the last time. He had no choice but to order a retreat. This time, only he and his guards had the chance to flee. His men in the castle were left behind.

Outside the castle, the Earl was shocked by the scene.

The enemies were everywhere, and any knight who tried to break through the blockade would be shot down remorselessly. Their weapons were nothing like the flintlocks sent by Timothy. They could fire continuously and seemed to require no reloading. It was chaotic. Members of the other three families were trapped, with the exception of Knight Dowcan, who had been the first to flee.

“My lord, what should we do?”

“Send for the iron armor platoons!” he cried out. “We’ll forge behind them and we’ll be covered by their iron shields.”

After all the troubles, three iron armor platoons finally gathered and slowly moved forward holding their shields. The other knights found it and followed them, too. They knew that this might be their last chance to break through.

Unfortunately, Jacques Medde made a mistake. When they were only 100 steps from their enemies, the latter's weapons exploded with dazzling bursts of fire. The iron shields made to block lead balls were instantly riddled with bullets. The men in the front holding the shields were killed. Splashing metal debris shot through bodies, stirring up a thick fog of blood behind the shields.

Before the Earl could call out the order of charge, he was cut down in a volley of fire.

Chapter 449

Chapter 449: The Course of War

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

…

When Roland walked into the messy castle, Petrov and Earl Hull were kneeling down on one knee in the center of the hall, awaiting his arrival.

All the bodies on the floor had been removed, but the smell of the blood lingered. The pieces of broken furnishings and weapons could be seen everywhere; he could almost imagine the killing-scenes between the two parties in the battle for the castle.

“Rise.” Roland walked towards Petrov, bending over to hold his shoulders.

“Yes,” Petrov said in a choked voice, “Your Highness, you are finally here.”

“You did a good job,” Roland said with a heavy voice, “the four big families will pay a heavy price for this, and the murderers shall be brought to justice.”

“I didn’t guard Longsong Stronghold well…”

“You did your best. It’s not your fault.” Roland sighed. Petrov was not a ruler of war. This was evident from the seizure of the previous city by the light cavalry and the rebellion of the nobilities this time. He was good at managing the territory, proficient in trading, and skilled in capturing opportunities, but he was not a Machiavellian. He was definitely not an expert at fighting and plotting. If it wasn’t for the Second Army that was stationed in the castle in accordance with the emergency measure, he wouldn’t have been able to hold more than two days.

However, that did not mean Petrov Hull was not a good manager. If he was not good at war, he should be assigned to a territory without any war. Roland preferred operators with a business mind to those with fighting talents.

“I believe there must have been an inducement for this riot,” Roland looked at everyone around him. “This is a downright conspiracy. The enemy seeks to subvert the order of Western Region in order to obtain benefits that don’t belong to them.”

The scene quieted down. Everyone, including both the armed soldiers of the First Army and the wounded knights behind Petrov, had their gazes on His Highness.

“They have committed a felony for this, murdering the nobility and killing the civilians. After the war, we’ll see that many people have lost their families, and many houses will have been looted. But their conspiracy didn’t succeed in the end. It was your unyielding resistance that prevented Stronghold from falling into a greater tragedy. Your performance was heroic and your willpower was laudable!”

The knights slightly lifted their chests without realizing it.

“However, the war isn’t over yet. These rebels are fleeing in panic, and it’s time for us to seek our revenge! I swear no matter where the enemies are hiding, they won’t escape the coming trial, be it in the territories of the four families… or King’s City!” Roland paused and said categorically, “The culprits who caused the rebellion are bound to be punished too! The blood you shed… will not be in vain!”

“Long live, Your Highness!” Petrov and Earl Hull knelt down once again.

“Long live, Your Highness!” The surviving knights and soldiers of the Second Army also began to kneel.

Soon, everyone was kneeling on one knee with their upper body upright, right hand on the chest, shouting the slogan in unison.

“Long live, Your Highness!”

…

After comforting the people at the scene, Roland summoned Petrov, Van'er, Brian, and Iron Axe into the study on the third floor of the castle, which was the only place that had not been invaded. All the furnishings were basically intact. Roland knew that he would probably have to spend the next few days there.

The first thing he had to do was to understand the situation regarding the battlefield within the city. He looked at Iron Axe, and the latter reported immediately, "The witches have seized back the northern gate and the eastern gate which was once occupied by the four families. The First Army is eliminating the rebels within the city under Miss Sylvie's guidance. The order of the city should be restored by tomorrow morning."

"What about the casualties?"

"A total of six people were injured so far, and all of them are from the rifle battalion, but they've been treated and cured by Miss Nana."

"What about the Second Army? Has it been counted?"

"Not yet… But according to the latest news, there are more casualties." Brian hesitated. "Both of the platoons sent to support the city wall have been defeated, and they haven't been gathered so far. Out of the 50 soldiers who were sent to defend the castle, 11 were killed, and almost none of the soldiers patrolling on the city wall survived."

Roland nodded. The militancy of this era was not as high, enabling the 100 people to persist for two days. The defensive party tended to have the bigger advantages, especially when the enemy lacked effective assault weapons. If the other party wasn't using firearms, the Lord's castle could not be broken through with only the flesh and blood of the mercenary and guards. This was fully taken into account during the design of this building to prevent enemy attack.

At this thought, he instructed Iron Axe, "Show me some of the rebels' firearms."

Roland was really concerned about the new hot weapons of this era. Although this day was expected to come sooner or later since the birth of the snow powder, the development speed of Timothy really surprised him.

Iron Axe carried out the order quickly. Only several minutes later, a few tube-like weapons of different lengths and shapes were carried into the study by soldiers.

After seeing the actual objects, Roland quickly understood why the enemies could build the weapons in a fairly short time.

These long tubes could not be called flintlock in the sense that they had no trigger and percussion device, and they were nothing more than metal tubes with a hole at each end. It was deeper at one end for loading gunpowder and bullets and had a needle-like hole at the end for ignition. The other end was shallower and could be used as the handle after inserting a bamboo stick or a wooden pole.

It was very similar to the prototype of the firearm, structure-wise.

The loading process of this primitive firearm was the same as that of the flintlock, but the launch was more troublesome. It required a gunman to hold the wooden pole under his armpit and ignite the gunpowder with the hand on the other side. Due to the limitation caused by the holding position, it was impossible to aim accurately and could only be roughly pointed straight ahead while shooting.

But it was still undoubtedly a hot weapon. Putting aside all the inconveniences, its launch principle was completely consistent with the flintlock. Its barrel and projectile were almost the same as those of the latter's, so the power was far greater than crossbow bolts. If shot, the armor of knights would not hold the attack.

Timothy's efforts on the customization could obviously be seen from the unique look of each firearm. Some were made of rolled-steel with clear thumping traces left on the body of the pipe, while some were molded by wrought copper and looked smooth. Considering they were simply testing

products to assist the four families, the firearm used by Timothy himself should be better.

However… even the best firearm was merely a firearm.

The King's City had no chance of winning as soon as the launch of the spring attack began. They would be unable to face the Western Region army armed with revolving rifles, bolt rifles, and HMGs (heavy machine gun).

Roland shifted his gaze back to the four of them and said, "The First Army will be recovering the suburban territories of Longsong Stronghold one by one from tomorrow onwards. Any nobility who resists can be put to death on the spot. I hope the entire Western Region will be unified after this week."

"Yes, Your Highness!" The four of them answered in unison.

Chapter 450

Chapter 450: Old Friends

Translator: TransN Editor: TransN

…

Rene Medde had been trapped in the basement of the Elk's mansion for half a month.

He thought he could've stopped Jacques, but he hadn't expected his elder brother to make the first move.

"Here is your lunch. Hope you enjoy it." Sean, the long-faced steward, brought a plate of sticky food to the cell. What was on the plate looked like a mixture of oatmeal and vegetables, and the portion was only palm-sized.

"Set me free, you dumbass!" Rene threw the food on the floor. Holding the cell bars, he shouted, "Jacques is a dumbass too. He has no idea what he's doing. It's not too late to let me out!"

The steward shook his head regretfully, took out a handkerchief and cleaned up his dirty shoes. "If I were you, I would've eaten that food instead of spoiling it. The Earl told me to bring you food once a day all this week, to let you save some strength."

"Damn it. Haven't you heard what I said?" Rene burst out with strong language. "This isn't about a meal. If Jacques doesn't stop, he'll destroy the Elk Family. For my father's sake, open this cage!"

Seemingly, the steward was moved by what Rene said in the end. As he was just about to leave, he stopped. "Your father? I think if he were still alive, he would've expelled you from this house." He then turned around and looked at Rene, expressionless. "Master, you seem to have forgotten that it was Roland Wimbledon who killed the Earl of the Elk Family. On the other hand, the

Honeysuckle Family has not only gone over to Prince Roland's side, but also assisted him in suppressing the other four families. At this moment, your elder brother is trying to correct this mistake, yet you're scared to death. How can you be a qualified knight this way?"

"It's not for you to judge whether I'm a qualified knight," Rene said angrily. "In the past three years, while I was defeating the demonic beasts in Hermes' defensive line, Jacques was busy enjoying wine and women in the King's City. Do you think it's out of bravery that he decided to attack the Honeysuckle Family? Don't be ridiculous. He's only blinded by profit!"

Sean sighed. "Even if you're the younger brother of Milord Jacques, you should show him some basic respect. After all, he is both an Earl and the head of the Elk Family."

After this, the steward ignored Rene and left the basement along the stairs. When the door was closed, the basement returned to silence.

"Damn it!"

The second son of the Elk Family smashed his fist down onto the floor forcefully.

Since the beginning of winter, Jacques had begun to visit the other families more often. Rene didn't pay much attention to it at first—after all, he wasn't interested in managing his family. Besides, when he was taken captive by His Royal Highness the first time, Jacques refused to pay the ransom, and it was Petrov who offered him a helping hand and got him released from prison. Since then, the relationship between the two brothers had fallen to the freezing point. Even so, Rene didn't plan to fight with his brother about who would be head of the household. When he heard the news about the construction of Border Town, he even considered going to the town and serving Prince Roland by becoming an official guarding knight. But afterwards, there were some changes in the situation. During a private feast held in the Elk mansion, Rene heard that the four families were planning to unite and fight together against Longsong Stronghold.

That night, Rene rushed into Jacques' study and confronted him, but Jacques wasn't happy about it and threw him out. Thinking about it overnight, Rene decided to tell Petrov the news and lead his patrolmen to stop Jacques. Unexpectedly, his breakfast was poisoned by Jacques. When Rene woke up, he found himself in prison.

Since then, despite his yelling and threatening, he hadn't yet earned himself a chance to meet with Jacques. Every day, he could only judge time by looking at the brightness of a louver in the basement corner, and the only person he had seen was Jacques's personal steward.

"Grrr…"

With this lengthy growl coming from his stomach, he realized that he was hungry.

Taking a glimpse at the scattered food on the floor, Rene turned his head and lay back onto the pile of straw on the floor. "I'd better go to sleep… I won't feel hungry once I fall asleep."

The moment Rene closed his eyes, a series of footsteps resounded in the basement.

"Could it be… Jacques coming?" He instantly hopped off the pile of straw and rushed to the bars. With the help of the dim light from the louver, he saw a small and slim figure. Obviously, that couldn't be the arrogant Earl.

"Brother, are you OK?" When the person arrived at the cell, he found it was Aurelia, the third daughter of the Elk Family.

"How did you get in?"

"Jacques wasn't around, and those servants couldn't stop me." Aurelia saw the oatmeal on the floor and said incredulously, "Is this what they are serving you? This is outrageous! Wait a moment. I'll tell the kitchen to cook something else for you."

“Jacques isn’t home?” What his sister said suddenly saddened Rene, and he almost forgot about his hunger. “Where did he go?”

“I’ve no idea… He left two days ago,” Aurelia shook her head and said, “along with most of the house guards. Otherwise, I couldn’t have come here.”

“Damn it.” Rene was disappointed. “Jacques left two days ago, and today is the third day—even if I can get out now, I’m afraid it’s already too late.

“Brother, I heard that Jacques was trying to hurt the Honeysuckle Family. Is this true?” Aurelia looked worried. “Will Milord Petrov be alright?”

“Right… Aurelia has always had a crush on Petrov Hull. Although I’ve tried to set them up as a couple, it seems my friend Petrov has somebody else in mind. But now nothing can be done.” Rene leaned against the bars and sat down, feeling feeble. He knew Jacques fully well. “Jacques won’t show mercy on the Hull Family, which would definitely cause Prince Roland to take his rage out on the whole Western Region.”

“Jacques has spent too much time in the King’s City, so he’s no idea what he’s got himself into… ” Rene closed his eyes. He couldn’t stop thinking about the day when he and his army attacked Border Town—fires continued blazing in front of his eyes; thunder boomed all around his ears unceasingly; knights in the front rows seemed to be hitting an invisible wall; and their skills, gained through years of training and the courage of fighting for honor, had all lost their effectiveness in the face of the enemies’ powerful weapons.

From that moment on, Rene had totally lost the intention of fighting against His Highness ever again.

Nobody could defeat His Highness’ troops—at least no human beings could.

“But when Prince Roland gets to know what’s happening in Stronghold and decides to sweep through this area, what’s the use then if the Elk Family gains a lot of profit? This time… Prince Roland may not let go of the four families.”

“What’s the matter, brother?” Aurelia shook him, but he remained motionless.

“The Elk Family is screwed.”

Just then, some indistinct roars spread through the thick ceiling, and then the floor slightly trembled. It felt as if the mansion was hit by something.

“Is that what I think it is?” Rene turned around, and saw his sister with the same surprised expression.

Then came another dull, yet much clearer, thundering and a series of noises. Rene could hear panicked shouts from his family’s servants coming from somewhere over his head.

“Could it be… Prince Roland’s army coming?” Rene was stunned. “How’s that even possible?”

“What’s happening out there?” Aurelia stood up. “I’ll check.”

“Don’t.” Rene grabbed her hand. “Don’t go anywhere. Just wait here.”

“Huh?”

“Listen to me…” Rene swallowed, and said in a tiresome voice, “It might be dangerous outside.”

The roars quieted down before long. Only a few minutes later, a platoon invaded the basement—they wore brown uniforms and held strange, long-handled weapons. At a glance, Rene realized they were Prince Roland’s troops.

He felt totally hopeless. He had expected retaliation from His Highness, but not so quickly!

“Or maybe this is a drama directed and played by Prince Roland himself?”

“Who are you?! How dare you break into the Earl’s mansion!” Aurelia stood up and questioned them.

A tall, strong man stepped out of the platoon. With an angular face and a chilling aura around his eyes, he looked as if he was from an alien race.

“Are you the second son of the Elk Family, Knight Rene Medde?” the guy asked.

“Since you know who he is, you… should retreat. What are you up to?” Aurelia said, voice trembling, but still she stood in front of the bars.

“I’m Rene! Don’t hurt her… She’s innocent!”

Rene thought he was about to see something unbearable, yet the guy totally ignored Aurelia, and what he said next simply shocked Rene.

“I’m Iron Axe, Commander of the First Army. His Highness Roland asked me to find you specifically,” the guy said in a low voice, “and he asked me to tell you that Mr. Petrov wants to see you.”